You Should See Me In A Crown

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/25670200.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow & Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Horde Prime (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Season 4 alternate ending, Hordak is dead, Prime doesn't show up immediately, Catra Has A Mental Breakdown, Healing, Catra is suicial, at least at first, Angst, Hurt/Comfort, Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, POV Alternating, Slow Burn, They're emotionally aware in this one lads, (Once they get past the denial and repression), Mutual Pining, Character Study, friends to enemies to idiots to lovers, (The show essentially), Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, I mean a really slow burn, Minor Perfuma/Scorpia (She-Ra), Cuddling, Fluff, Past Unrequited Scorpia/Catra, Alternate Season/Series 05, Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra) - Freeform, Battle, Non-Graphic Violence, Angst with a Happy Ending, Love Confessions

Language:
English

Series:
Part 1 of Broken Thrones

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Banco Fic, She ra and the princess of power :>

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You Should See Me In A Crown

by JazzKat1213

Summary

Hordak is dead, crushed under falling metal. Glimmer is gone, saved by Bow. And for one stupid, weak minute Catra thinks about joining them. She doesn't, she stays. Sits upon a throne that she's won but means nothing. The war is over isn't it? Her forces are crushed and there's nothing else for her to climb for power. All that's left to do is fall.

What if Hordak died and Horde Prime had waited a little longer before showing up? Or my flimsy excuse for Adora to see Catra at her worst as she has a breakdown on a throne and the subsequent fallout and falling back in. (Tags will update as we go)

Isn't This What You Wanted?

Chapter Notes

Had a thought and it spiraled into this. It's gonna get a lot worse before it gets better but it *will* get better so.
Beta: toffii

TW: suicidal thoughts, referenced murder (of a guy who had it coming and it's more manslaughter/self-defense anyway), there's a war so y'know things to do with that, blood

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

He's dead. It doesn't feel real, even though the pool of his blood has crawled far enough along the ground to stain her bare feet. Hordak is dead and she killed him.

And she has nothing left. Not even the Princess that was laid at her feet - that she asked to just end it all - she's gone. Saved by Arrow Boy and whisked away and Catra, she just...watched and let it happen.

She feels like a fake. It's exactly what she is.

For one weak, falsely hopeful moment she thinks about following the two of them, asking to know just how the Princess could try to fix instead of destroy what was already half-broken. But she doesn't. She stays rooted to the metal floor she's walked a million times, Black Garnet mocking her with everyone she's lost; Shadow Weaver, Adora, Entrapta, even Scorpia all have become intertwined with her memories of this room and the magic it houses.

She turns from the people who took Adora away, they're already long gone, and the crystal that's caused so much pain. Maybe she'll regret letting her go eventually but what was the point of

capturing her when the Rebellion has already destroyed the Horde's forces? Her forces. *Hers*.

It's both heart-crushing and mind-numbing. She did it. She's free of everyone who's ever tried to hurt her, she can rule the Horde just like she always said she would. But it's not what she wants, it never was. And she really should've admitted it sooner.

"Is that what you really want? To rule the world?"

"Shut. Up. Adora." She hadn't meant to say it aloud, the taste of her name in her mouth hurts like an old wound, but it's not like there's anyone left to hear her. There's no one here.

She carries on walking the ruined halls, leaving ghostly footprints made of drying blood. She's alone. It makes her laugh - quietly, bitterly, miserably - into the silence. And it is *silence*, the machinery broken and melted all around her.

"I mean, yeah, obviously. Isn't that what you want too?"

Even in a perfect world she still lied, still couldn't admit it. She doesn't want to rule the Horde. But it's what she has, it's the *only* thing she has anymore. There's no one left.

If that gnawing hole inside her wasn't so big she might cry. Her throat fills up but she's too tired for anything more than ragged breaths to leave, too burned and hurt and empty. Every step she takes rattles her whole body. The blasted-through walls still glow red and she wouldn't care if it scorched the skin off her body and turned her to ash.

Her feet know where they're taking her before she does. She's going towards the one and only thing she has left.

The rising platform holding the throne she's won sneers at her. Metal clangs in her head like gunfire as it gets closer, red light sprayed across it like bloodshed. She sits upon the throne she's

clawed for years to get. It feels like every heartbreak she's ever known. It's empty and meaningless and it's...not what she wants.

Adora was right, Double Trouble was right. Of course they were, when was she *ever* right? She's just...wrong. About everything. Shadow Weaver knew that, for all the things she'd ever spat at her (*unlovable, worthless, useless, pest*) she'd never believed that she'd been wrong.

She finally gets what she wants only for it to not be what she wants at all. She laughs again, broken and pained, into the heaviest silence she's ever experienced. There's no one here to hear her. She's alone. She's alone. *She's alone*.

"You push them away Wildcat."

Her troops are most likely dead, maimed or deserting on battlefields she can't see. The thought hurts more than it ought to. They're fighting a war, people die. But it's over isn't it? The Rebellion's won and she has nothing but this throne. This meaningless metal that offers no hope of salvation as she once thought. There are people dying for her, for Hordak: the leader she's known her whole life. The leader she's taken from them. And it's all her fault.

Some black rebuttal forms: *'They wouldn't be dying if Double Trouble hadn't betrayed you. You'd be winning.'*

It should be comforting, it's anything but. What's one more betrayal? They should be blurring together by now, with how often she experiences them. But they don't - they always hurt, opening new wounds bound to scar. How is there even room for them on her body anymore?

She takes the seat she always thought she wanted, slumps into its hard, unforgiving surface without the pride she ought to feel. She doesn't leave. She's never known how to.

Chapter End Notes

Sorry for using a Billie Eilish lyric as a title.
It's gonna get a lot angstier from here on out. And the suicidal tendencies stay for a while sorry.

My Tumblr
Playlist for this fic

I've Known For A While Now

Chapter Notes

TW: suicidal thoughts (kinda), implied murder

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The sword is broken, shattered like her destiny. She-Ra is gone. The war? She doesn't even know. All she knows is the stars she's never seen stretched out before her. She feels so small. And so alone. Wherever she is, it's barren and cloudless and far away from anything else.

It's peaceful atop this hill. Maybe she doesn't ever want to come down.

But it can't last. And she's thankful the voices of her friends behind her elicits relief instead of dread. She runs down the hill and into their open arms; "You guys are okay!"

The joy can't stay, not after everything that's happened, and yet she keeps the fantasy alive for as long as she can, head on her friends shoulders and sheltered in their hold. It's remarkably still for a minute - a welcome reprieve from the day's events. When it breaks there's the telltale shine of tears in Glimmer's eyes.

"I'm so sorry, the Heart, I shouldn't have-"

Something hardens in Bow's face as they all remember the last time they talked and the emotions none of them are ready to face again, "- Stop. Not right now okay."

The hurt is as obvious as any wound, they all feel it. A group divided that they need to sew back together. So many things to fix. She can't even begin to unpick the messy thread and find the start.

Bow takes a breath, she understands, there's just *so much*. She feels like with enough air maybe she'll be able to make sense of it all, be able to forgive and move on and do what needs to be done. She holds out on that hope, even though it's never really worked before.

He starts, "So...what happened, are you okay? The Heart didn't go off did it?"

"No. I stopped it." There's a void in her voice she can't fill, she feels hollow...but lighter. Free of the destiny she never wanted. She can't look at them; she feels weak. How can she save everyone and still feel like she's failed?

"I thought you said nothing could stop it once it went off?"

She doesn't give him an answer. She knows she should. There's an uneasy pause where no one looks at anyone else.

"Adora where's the sword?" There's too much concern in Bow's voice.

She doesn't regret what she did; Etheria doesn't deserve to be a weapon, the world doesn't deserve to burn for the First Ones. No amount of power would be worth losing every life she's ever tried to save. "The sword's gone, and so is She-Ra."

Both Bow and Glimmer hesitate, seeming to forget their animosity for a moment as they share matching worried looks. Bow is the first one to speak again, "What do we do now?"

The only thing she feels she knows how to do anymore. "We win this war. Once and for all."

Glimmer looks worried - maybe she doesn't think they can. Wasn't that the point of setting off the Heart? The power? Or was her breaking the sword all for nothing?

"Adora...Catra killed Hordak. She controls the Horde now."

Oh.

She thinks her heart stops as her head flows over with realisations and for a moment the nothing lets up enough for ice to fill her veins. She feels cold. But then it's gone. It sinks in.

She did it. After everything they - she - said, she finally did it. She's the one calling the shots, who took over like they - she - always said she would. Should she feel proud of her? Is that what this is? Some twisted pride? Or disappointment or fear or longing or *'I miss who you used to be'*… She just doesn't know anymore. That void is crushing down on her chest, on her heart. She doesn't want to know what it means. But she does. She's known for a while now.

"We need to stop her before she figures out what to do next. We'll go back to Brightmoon, get everyone together and...figure it out." Her voice doesn't sound like hers, she barely even feels it.

She looks over at Glimmer, she's taking charge again, one of the very things that drove them apart. But there's only worry and regret there, something like pleading for forgiveness when she says, "Let's go home."

Adora gives one last look back towards the endless expanse of speckled sky. It feels like a last *something*, she just doesn't know what. The hill she stood on both pushes and pulls at her, enough for her not to do anything. She wants to stay in that simple nothingness, feeling small but free. Where she can pretend that she doesn't know how this is all going to end. And she will continue to pretend, she realises, till the very last moment. She will lie over and over that this won't end with blood on her hands and a body cradled in her arms.

Because Catra will not go down without a fight, she's a survivor, always has been. She'll make Adora take her out with a blade she doesn't have anymore. But she'll try anyway, she'll reach out to her and offer one last chance if only because if she doesn't, and

Catra dies by her hand, she'll drown in 'what ifs' for the rest of her life. She knows that she might choke on her own sorrow before that ever happens.

That is if Catra doesn't take her with her when she goes. It doesn't sound so bad. And maybe that's the worst part. She's never thought she would live through this war, always knowing that she'll die to end it. But if anyone takes her down she'll be glad it's her. She'll be glad if Catra's face is the last thing she ever sees.

Glimmer offers her hand and it feels like so much more - an apology maybe? Everything is too much and not enough, like she's caught in the stillness of a storm's eye. She doesn't even have time to slow her heart before Brightmoon appears back before her in a shower of sparkles.

Chapter End Notes

> Short chapters feel so wrong to me but here we are. Also Adora is mildly suicidal as well I realised which oops I guess, but like it's just her self-sacrificing nature saying hi.

Last Time Like This

Chapter Summary

> Adora is once again facing the fact that she may have to kill Catra. She tells everyone they better be prepared for the storm on the Fright Zone. She's a fucking hypocrite.

Chapter Notes

> TW: yeah again someone is facing the possibility of having to murder someone

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

She watches Glimmer's homecoming with a smile she doesn't feel. In the whirlwind of the aftermath she hadn't even thought to tell her that her dad is alive and with them. The teary disbelieving smile on the Princess' face isn't enough to fix anything, but for a few minutes at least they can all pretend.

They get word out to the other Princesses and anyone else that might be able to help in dismantling the Horde for good. The results of which consist of an entirely united Alliance and Castaspella arriving with a small group of sorcerers within two days. Another reunion later, and the beginnings of a plan to storm the Fright Zone are already underway.

Since the activation of the Heart, it's taken them all of three days to figure out the plan. It's rushed and sloppy and running on impulse and assumptions for the most part but they don't have time. They need to move, and quickly.

Catra's so many things; she's a puzzle Adora has spent her whole life trying to piece together only for it to shatter before her eyes. There's many aspects which Adora tells herself are long gone,

simply because any other option hurts too much. She can't look into those eyes that have haunted her every moment since Thaymore and believe there's still the woman she fell in love with buried in there. She's not strong enough.

But she thought she had collected every single part in their eighteen years together, she knew - knows - every piece Catra let her see in excruciating detail. And then she left, and the shards she loved so dearly mutated, turning to sharp, jagged weapons; her determination, her resilience and stubbornness becoming familiar enemies. Adora had seen new bladed pieces emerge from within her as well, and in her own heartbreak hoped selfishly that they hadn't been there the whole time.

It means that even with wrecked forces and soldiers deserting she'll pick herself back up, she'll keep on trying. She's never given up before, why would she start now? Hordak is dead, there's no one left to stop her but Adora herself.

"She'll be pulling all her forces back to the Fright Zone, she knows she needs the protection," Shadow Weaver seems to seethe from across the table. Even without her magic, the darkness clings to her. Every time she speaks of Catra, Adora flares with rage she doesn't understand.

She tastes ash in her mouth when she says, "It'll be heavily fortified with whatever artillery they have left so we'll need a large - magical - offensive group and a smaller number to infiltrate and take her on individually."

The many sorcerers and Princesses all nod. Glimmer being the only one who doesn't - she knows she's on that infiltration team. In spite of all the chaos, Glimmer had found the time to apologise, and honestly, it's one of the only things keeping her going. It wasn't perfect, but it was better than nothing. It's allowed her to move on, enough that she's glad to have her by her side again, happy to work with her to stop this war once more.

Bow asks, “What about once you’re inside?” from the other side of the room. Adora tries not to let any shock at him speaking show; he doesn’t talk much when Glimmer’s in the room anymore. Adora just hopes that’ll change after this mission. They’ll have time when the war is over.

When the war is over. She can’t even begin to comprehend it.

“If she’s not too proud for it she’ll have a personal guard set up near her as protection. Shadow Weaver and myself will lead the infiltration team. I’ll get to Catra. Everyone else who is with me will take down her guards.” Even saying her name makes her heart beat faster.

“And what if she’s left the Fright Zone?”

She forces herself not to laugh bitterly at Juliet, she forgets sometimes that no one knows her better than she does. Not even Scorpia, who sits silently next to Perfuma. She gains some weird sort of consolation in knowing that Scorpia looks about as miserable as she feels.

“She’ll be there. She’s spent her whole life vying for that throne, she’s not going to let it go now. We leave tomorrow, be prepared.”

She continues staring rigidly at the pink holographic Fright Zone on the map as everyone else leaves. She can feel her foot tapping and her hands clutching at the table but she doesn’t (can’t) stop either.

“Adora?”

She forces herself to relax, it’s harder than expected. “What is it Glimmer?”

“I didn’t tell you something before, because I honestly forgot about it in the chaos. But I - I just think you should be prepared to see Catra.”

That too, almost gets a bitter laugh. When has she ever been *prepared* to see Catra on a battlefield? When has she ever been *prepared* to see the flames of hate in the eyes of her bestest and oldest friend?

"I'm fine Glimmer. I've fought her before, I'll do it again, I'll -" kill her if I have to. She can't even say it, how the fuck is she meant to actually do it? She'll figure it out. She has to, for everyone's sake, she'll do it and end this war.

"I just don't think -" Glimmer sighs, "Adora I found her, before, by Hordak's body. She was broken. She… she looked me in the eyes and told me to 'do it'."

It takes her far too long to answer, her hands find their place back on the table ledge in some desperate attempt at grounding herself. She hears a crunch and something splinters under her hands, she doesn't look away from the map to see what. Her voice shakes when she finally manages it, "Do what?"
She knows she doesn't want the answer.

"Kill her."

She forces herself to breath past the *'No, no, no'* screaming in her head. The words come falling out anyway, "No that - she - she wouldn't. Catra *doesn't give up*. You *know* that."

"I do. But I saw what I saw, Adora. I saw a woman unmoving by a body asking me to kill her. She had plenty of time to attack me, capture me, but she let me go."

She only meets Glimmer's eyes for a second but it's enough. She's serious. Catra was willing to lay down and die at the hands of a Princess. She doesn't know what that means for her - for them. A fight is expected, she can handle it, it's horridly familiar. But Catra without her anger or her drive or her cruel smiles that tear her apart? That - that terrifies her in a way she's entirely unfamiliar with. And Catra *asking* her to end her life? She can't even begin to think about it.

“Are you going to be okay?”

That finally lets out the pained, bitter laugh she’s been holding down, her throat feels raw when it tears out of her. She drags a hand down her face and finds deep intents in her palms from the material she’d shattered.

“I’ll be fine. I’m always fine.”

When she lies down at night she sees cats eyes in the shadows, burning and dangerous and broken. It’s not even the first night she’s had like this; where she’s shouted to thoughts of Catra and the inevitable demise they seem to face over and over.

And it *hurts*, it hurts every fucking time.

She hears Catra’s laughter in the wind as it whispers through thick curtains. She keeps the lights on to chase away the memories of black nights spent together talking under covers. She cries when she falls into thoughts of her touch, how warm she always was, how alive, like a wildfire. Absolutely untamable.

She lets herself think about it, something deep inside her saying that this ought to be the last time she ever thinks of her like this. She’s heard it before. She succumbs to it every time anyway.

But tonight might be the last time thoughts of Catra aren’t poisoned by the sight of her lifeless body in her hands. It’s a realisation that has her rushing outside and hunching over on cold stone to stop herself throwing up.

Tomorrow sits heavy on her chest as she stares at the ceiling, she’s long since stopped trying to wipe away tears. The aching hasn’t disappeared, it never does, but it’s bearable. She’s built that wall between her heart and her head back up. She wills herself into numbness with the knowledge of what she *has* to do.

She tells herself she can do it if she feels she has no choice. It’s what allowed her to leave (and stay gone) in the first place.

‘There’s always a choice. You chose to do this to us.’ It sounds like *her* and it rips another sob from her ribs.

Not for the first time she falls asleep wishing she had never found the sword in the first place.

Chapter End Notes

> Me (chanting): angst! angst! angst!
>
> This thing keeps getting longer, we're up to 9 chapters now oops.

Battle Calm (Never Stays Long)

Chapter Summary

> The Alliance storms a ruined Fright Zone, and Adora still thinks she needs to do everything alone.

Chapter Notes

> TW: again the whole might have to murder thing, stuff alluding to an anxiety attack

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

There's an inexplicable amount of relief that washes over Adora when she wakes at the first moonrise, finding that within minutes a heavy battle calm has claimed a tight hold of her. It keeps her hyper aware of everything and everyone despite her body and her head feeling disconnected, despite the exhaustion she ought not to feel hanging over her consciousness like a ghost. Given the circumstances and the looming shadow of what she has to do within the next few hours, she doesn't think she could feel better. And besides, she doesn't mind it so much; it means she keeps moving.

It means that she's washed and dressed and fed with far too much time to spare. The pike she finds herself holding instead of her sword doesn't seem to matter, something tickles at the back of her mind, scratching at the wall the focused-haze has built. Something like how much easier this would be if she were She-Ra, if she could just give herself over to the magic, or how much simpler today might be if she never found that damn sword in the first place.

She checks over the plan three more times before she feels even remotely comfortable leaving the war room for what might be the last time.

It's a bad idea but she trains - she just needs to move, keep the numbness flowing in her veins. Or maybe it’s adrenaline, she doesn’t really care so long as it works. There’s a messy array of strands that fall around her face, she pays them no mind, focus solely on empty air as she cuts through it, trying to reaffirm her comfort with a weapon she hasn’t used properly in years. The movements are familiar, they feel right; easy and practiced and she’s grateful. Even still, she feels weaker than she’s ever felt.

“Adora?” She lowers her staff and looks at the doorway, a simple nod from Glimmer is all it takes for her to know it’s time.

Identical hallways pass in a haze until she’s back in the throne room where she had pledged allegiance to a now-dead Queen. She pushes down the grief that rises in her throat.

Their army gathers beneath the moonstone, bathed in its pale light just like everything else. The waters glow a soft blue-grey-white like liquid pearl, the endless woods carved from lapis and sapphire. She tries to memorize the sky, the positions of the moons, the patterns in the stars that drip like diamonds and is reminded of that lonely hilltop. She wishes she were still there, she wishes she never moved, she wishes she could know for certain that she will see the stars again. Idly she wonders if this is what Mara saw before she died.

‘You might never see this place, these people again.’

And still she feels nothing. She doesn’t let herself.

Bow tugs on her arm and she goes willingly, easily finding Shadow Weaver and her sea of wine-red robes in the crowd. She hates having to trust her, hates having to be *near* her but it’s been too long for her to rely on her own knowledge of the Fright Zone. She pretends the fact doesn’t sting with some parody of home-sickness. The four of them stand and wait together in strained silence.

Micah makes sure the army stands within the perimeters of the spells as they ignite underfoot. The magic burns differently than she's used to - all soft and welcoming pastels instead of She-Ra's blinding white-gold. As with so much else in that moment, she doesn't let herself miss it. Brightmoon melts away before her eyes.

Whatever haze she's riding stays even as the Fright Zone paints itself around her. It stays as they're spotted - it wasn't a stealth mission anyway. It stays as tanks are armed and batons blaze to life with all-too-familiar lightning.

All she needs to do is get through the initial wave, find the closest entrance and get in before reinforcements bar their progress. She sticks close to Bow, Glimmer and Shadow Weaver, as is the plan. Her mind is thankful for the fight, of the way it brings that battle calm back down like a blanket. She knows how to fight. She can do that.

She doesn't think a day went by in her youth where she didn't have to fight for *something*. It's natural, instinctual in a way nothing else is. Even without She-Ra thrumming in her skin, she still throws herself into it, taking down as many soldiers as she can. Because it's all she *can* do now - she can't tear through tanks without breaking a sweat anymore, can't heal her friends if they're wounded. She hopes with everything she has that they don't forget that.

It takes only a few minutes for the almost suspiciously small force to be destroyed, Adora doesn't waste time waiting for the next group, calling Glimmer, Bow and Shadow Weaver nearer the door they are to enter through. She's proud of herself for even making it this far, for leaving their friends behind to fight a battle her body is screaming at her to be a part of.

Glimmer teleports them to the other side of the door, and they leave the smog-stained sky of the Fright Zone behind them in a

shower of amethyst sparkles.

Adora swallows thickly against the black air lingering in her lungs as she stares down the first of the infinite hallways that make up the intestines of the Fright Zone. She thought she was prepared to come back here, but in all her worrying and heartache she didn't even consider *where* she was going. She's *here* in this roiling mass of metal she used to call home.

She learned to fight here, to dress herself, and walk and talk and plan battles and navigate barren landscapes and survive. She'd played in these halls as a toddler, chasing Catra - always chasing Catra - through their endless maze. She learned how to *love* here, with *her*, against all the odds.

Gods coming here might be the biggest mistake of her life. It's like a switch and that battle calm she'd been clinging onto is flooded with her own breath-taking dread. It just makes her walk faster, alongside Shadow Weaver and all the memories the witch carries like a disease.

They don't see any other soldiers - it makes the fear skyrocket in her veins. There should be guards rushing to defend against the Princesses. It's deserted. Something whispers in the back of her head. Glimmer had told her about the deal she'd made with Double Trouble, how the Princesses had crushed the Horde's forces that were coming to destroy them with the power of the Heart. But here and now the consequences are so painfully obvious it makes her stomach churn.

She turns a corner and comes unexpectedly face to face with a three-person squadron. She hears one of them whisper, "Shadow Weaver?" under their breath and she uses the momentary pause to tackle one of them into a wall. She's glad she doesn't recognise any of them, it makes it easier to press her staff to their throat.

"Where is she?" There's clear desperation corrupting her shout she can't bring herself to care about.

"Who?" It just makes her angrier.

"Your leader."

"We don't know where Hordak is."

She presses the weapon in a little harder, she doesn't recognize her own voice when it grates against her teeth on the way out, "Wrong answer. Hordak's dead. Try again."

There's a stillness that implies genuine shock. She loosens her hold just a little and waits for an answer while the soldier figures out their next words.

"We stopped receiving orders four days ago. We haven't heard anything."

If Catra isn't giving orders there's a reason. She's power hungry the way Shadow Weaver crafted her to be (the way she tried to make Adora) and after finally seizing it she's not using it? Something is wrong. So undoubtedly wrong.

'Maybe she can't *give orders.'*

She doesn't want to listen. She doesn't, she doesn't, she -

'You might not get to give her that one last chance after all.'

She lets the soldier still in her hold go, and the group hesitates before running, she doesn't care where they're going; none of them had any major grade weapons, they don't even seem to be heading towards the battle.

She turns on Glimmer, words bitter and strained, "You said she let you go."

"She did, she was alive. I saw her walking away."

For a second she's paralyzed between *'Gods I hope you're right,'* and *'Gods I hope you're wrong.'* Finding Catra dead makes her

heart shatter but having to *kill* Catra? That tears her soul to pieces.

And gods it all feels so real suddenly. She's here, in the Fright Zone, with barely a weapon, talking about killing the woman she's loved since before she knew what love was. It's only when her vision starts going black at the edges that she realises how desperately she's sucking in air. For barely a few seconds she's floating above everything, then Bow's hands on her arms drag her back to the ground, all that dread following like a tidal wave.

She wants that numbness back, she wants to be able to breathe, she wants to not have to do this. But she does. And she will. Because she's She-Ra.

'But you're not. Not anymore.'

She wishes that was enough to stop her own undying obligation. She stands up straight again, shrugging off worried hands and turning towards the sorceress that in so many ways had doomed her from the beginning. She doesn't know where the shadows end and she begins.

She holds a hand out, willing it not to shake, unsure if she's successful, "Take me to the throne room."

It's only because she anticipates Glimmer and Bow's pleading objections that she can ignore them. "Adora what -"

"I'm doing this alone, don't even try and stop me." She's glad the apathy is back in her tone.

"Adora it's too dangerous, don't -"

It feels like those shadows crawl into her veins, poison she lets win, when black magic takes hold of her body.

"Just across this bridge and through another set of doors," Shadow Weaver says, a hand on her shoulder.

It’s some caricature of gentle, and it’s a reminder of every time she failed Catra when they were younger. The memories make her head dizzy because she *should have known*, she *should have done more*. Maybe then she wouldn’t have to do this. Maybe she wouldn’t have lost her in the first place.

“Leave.” She rips her body out from the grip the witch had on it; she feels sick, she feels free, she feels chained. There’s too much, she searches desperately for the numbness.

“Adora that’s a foolish idea Catra -”

“*I’m doing this alone.* It has to be me.” Rage she’s never truly let herself feel takes over, it’s desperate and fuelled by her own fear. Her eyes burn with tears when she shouts, it sounds like shattering glass; “You did this to us, you made us this way! You’ve tried to tear us apart our whole lives and guess what? You succeeded. So why -”

Her tongue gets tied with a million questions that ricochet in her head she’ll never ask:
Why did you want us miserable?
Was I anything other than a tool to you?
Was *anything* real?
Did any part of you care about either of us even a little bit?
Can you even care about another person?

She settles for, “Why did you hate her?” And ignores the way her voice breaks.

“She was nothing but a distraction, she was always beneath you, she still is. I never understood why you cared. But I kept her around for you, against my better judgement.”

There’s no remorse, no regret, not even a whisper of it. If the anger set her alight then the ice of realisation dowses it.

“You knew I’d never forgive you if you got rid of her,” she mutters it into the gentle howl of the wind.

She hates how long it's taken her to figure it out. Shadow Weaver needed her loyal, needed her to think she was right, Catra was just another manipulation, another weapon. But a risk to her plans for her; she was never meant to care about Catra as much as she did. As much as she still does. But in so many ways she still succeeded in molding, building, breaking her, into what she wanted. She probably never guessed that weapon she created would be wielded by the opposite side. It's barely reassuring.

"Well you are kind of disrespectful."

Gods how could she have even said that? Catra never deserved anything that Shadow Weaver put her through. Why was she so blind? Why did it take that stupid sword for her to figure things out? Why couldn't she just have been *better* for her? Why has she failed everyone she's ever cared about?

If the storm in her head is reflected on her face Shadow Weaver doesn't show it. She's blank, almost bored, not even acknowledging what she said. She's seen that look so many times, but now the little voice in her head telling her she's disappointed Shadow Weaver means nothing, she ignores it easily. And she just wants her gone, she never wants to see her again. Every second she morphs further into a living reminder of all her failures.

"I understood that you were to grow up to be a hero. I could feel your power Adora and I risked everything trying to prepare you for the day you found it."

The rage is back; she truly believes that she was right to do what she did. To ruin them. She can't even stand to look at her.

She turns away, crossing the bridge, walking away from the woman - no, creature - she tried to make proud her whole life. She doesn't have the energy to even try and convince herself that she lived up to expectations. Shadow Weaver won't care what she says, she speaks the words anyway, tongue sour,

"Yeah, well, hope it was worth it."

Chapter End Notes

They meet next chapter lads :) (And it's longer so it's gonna take a while to get posted.)
Also Adora telling Shadow Weaver to piss off part 1 of 2.

I See Me In You (And I Hate It)

Chapter Summary

So what if they're broken? They're broken together.

Chapter Notes

Heavily inspired by Save the Cat and Don't Go (which is canon fight me)
TW: blood, minor self-harm via claws, absolutely no mental stability whatsoever, implied/referenced starvation and dehydration

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

There’s no guards, there’s no one at all, not that Adora can see. The pressing silence has the hallway echoing like a battlefield even with her quiet footsteps. It makes the blood rush in her ears, she can feel her rapid-fire pulse on her tongue. There’s broken machinery and melted walls and alcoves filled with liquid shadow; she sees the cracked remnants of her childhood before her eyes. She never lets her gaze stay long. So many things feel wrong in this moment, of course they do, but even with the dizzying riptide of her feelings and thoughts, she can pick apart the fact that the ever-present buzz of the Fright Zone is dead here.

She stares at the black-green of the door for minutes on end, frozen in her own dread and hesitation. Knowing she can’t dwell in the storm of her thoughts, that she can’t afford to, she rams her pike into the control board. It opens easily after that, part of her wishes it didn’t, wishes she had an excuse to break and tear and shout. But it welcomes her in silently. She feels the blood drain from her face when she crosses the threshold.

Distantly she hopes that Catra’s not here. It would only prolong the inevitable, but isn’t that what they’ve always done? Delay their

own end?

It’s pitch black for a moment before the sensors catch her movement, red and white lights humming to life and flickering on with deep resounding thuds one by one. Even in the darkness she can find her, can know without a doubt that she’s there even if she can’t see her through the inky blade of shadows - her heart just knows. But another light blinks into illumination and that intuition isn’t needed.

Her entire being sinks seeing Catra upon the throne they once promised would be theirs. The throne she never wanted, not really. It was always just a cover, a safe haven to fall back on; ruling the world *together*. She was allowed to want power, she wasn’t allowed to want *her*. She’s still not allowed to want anything. She’s long since made peace with the fact, not that it ridded her of the burning regret deep in her throat that leaks like acid when she thinks about it. She can taste it now.

She can only just make out her shape from where she is, black and red and still. She waits for Catra to look at her, say something, even move at all but she doesn’t. For a few sickening seconds she thinks she’s dead. Catra sits slumped in her chair, head leaning on her hand, eyes unmoving even as they thin to slits with the sudden light. Adora’s feet take her closer, to the base of the stairs, before fear renders her useless again.

Her fur and hair are burned, messy and bloody. Her clothes hang off her body and her eyes are all but black from exhaustion. The last light sounds like thunder in the quiet room when it wakes and Adora’s whole body goes cold from the fully illuminated sight.

“Catra?” She hates how her voice breaks with concern.

She shouldn’t - she *can’t* - feel like this. She's *never* been allowed to feel like this for her; not when they were cadets, and not as enemies. She wants it to stop, this claw-grip Catra has on her.

Once again she asks her heart why, why her? And as always it responds with memories of her smile and her laugh and her ferocity and her wit and just *Catra*. The one who fights and hisses and scratches at anyone and everyone who means her harm, and who always let Adora and Adora alone see the wounds. The one that turned soft amongst childish whisperings and thin bed covers.

But she's not here anymore. And Adora's been trying to convince herself of that for over two years, slowly replacing it with the person Catra has become. It's never worked. The ruthless, driven creature full of words meant to attack and scar - the one everyone else knows - will never feel fully real so long as the rasp of her laugh lives within her.

At least she can fight that Catra; the second-in-command plotting the Rebellion's demise. Knows how to defend against the blades she wields. And as hard as it is, she can hurt that Catra. She'll gladly die defeating that Catra if it means the war ends for good.

But Glimmer's warning was correct; the Catra in front of her is a ghost of the person she used to be, far from the child she knew, and miles from the woman who had cities burning down in her eyes. And just so, so cut off from the girl Adora fell in love with. But she's still *Catra* and her heart's never known how to let her go.

Catra blinks; the first movement she's made. She sighs shakily and her body moves like a corpse beginning to reanimate. She sits up as much as it seems she's able to, her body relying on the unforgiving metal of the throne to keep her upright.

Adora thinks she might throw up when she hears her speak.

"Hey Adora."

It's a dry whisper she has to strain to hear, those familiar words that send her heart racing, so far beyond hopeless. She's given up, she's broken just like Glimmer said. She never thought Catra

would give up on anything. But here she is, all the power she's ever wanted and the weakest Adora's ever seen her.

Catra

Her throat hurts when she speaks, her bones crack and ache when she tries to move. Everything protests her not staying still and dying in this chair.

She would accuse Adora of coming to take her victory, just as she did her malicious double (she considers that this might be another trick from them but realises right now she doesn't care either way,) if she felt there was anything she'd actually won. Adora doesn't want this throne, she never did. She didn't want her either, she'd made that clear. She just wanted the freedom the throne would've brought them. And what good did it do her? She's still following orders. Catra isn't. She's free. And regrets ever wanting to be.

She sits up a little straighter, bites back a whimper at the pain that shoots through her spine. She finally meets those eyes that have haunted her her whole life. Blue like the tears she hasn't let herself cry. Her claws screech quietly as they rake over the throne's arms, black grooves appearing there: a claim. It's hers. It's all she has.

"Should I be surprised you're here?"

It's quiet like the secrets they shared under bed covers at night. She's surprised Adora even hears, but she does and her mouth opens to answer before she thinks better of it. And it's that little not-action that kills her wondering over whether this is the real Adora or not. Catra's seen that look too many times, each and every instance of it had red-black shadows looming over the two of them.

Gods, Catra will never be rid of her, will she? (And deep down she knows she never truly wanted to be.)

"The war needs to be over Catra."

It doesn't matter how right she is, Catra will never admit to agreeing with her. She's just *so fucking tired*. It needs to end. Everything preferably.

"Where's She-Ra?" She says instead, unable to force disdain into her voice.

"I'm not She-Ra anymore, the sword's gone. Isn't that what you wanted?" There's an edge of pleading in her voice that throws her.

'All I ever wanted was you, just you.'

She doesn't grace her with an answer.

"You have everything you ever wanted. Are you happy now?"

She can see the tear that slips down Adora's cheek and hates how badly it breaks her heart. Adora never let her see her cry when they were kids, only ever seeing her this truly vulnerable on opposite sides of the war. It doesn't stop her from wanting to wipe it away and tell her that, no, she hasn't got everything - she doesn't have her.

'Why doesn't she get it?'

It's much better this way, it's what she's always said: Thank the gods Adora never knew how much she loved her.

'Love. You still do. You always will.'

"Does it look like I'm happy Adora?" Anger she's too tired to feel covers up how tears fill her throat.

There's too long a silence, too much eye-contact. She can't breathe but can't do anything else but try. Adora takes a step

forward and something in Catra snaps. Her ears go back and she knows her face is just teeth in a gaunt frame.

"Do you want to know what it's like living our dream without you?"

She doesn't know what prompted her to spit those words but it's too late to take them back. It makes Adora freeze again, like the poison in her words has a physical effect, like their dreams still mean something to her.

"No. I don't."

She sinks back into unwelcoming metal, "At least you're honest."

'At least you're not lying to me anymore.'

"Is that the only reason you did it?"

It's the unhidden tremble in her voice that makes Catra actually consider an actual answer. Did she do it just to achieve the dream? *Their* dream. Yes, she thinks, because it was - is - the only thing she knew how to do when Adora left. Power is the only thing she ever let herself strive for. She blames Shadow Weaver.

'You always do, don't you?'

But no, some blacker part of her says, she didn't do it just for the dream. She did it to prove everyone wrong, to make them regret ever seeing her as weak, to break out from Adora's shadow. A lot of good it did her. And somewhere deep down she knows that even that wasn't all of it; she did it *for her* as some sick, twisted way of keeping her in her life. Of keeping the version of Adora in her memories alive.

"No."

She can hear the tears in Adora's voice. "Why else?"

When she laughs it tastes like smoke and shadow, her eyes stinging with despair. The burns all over her body are as numb as the rest of her. She screws her eyes against the way Adora looks at her, like there's still something worth saving. She made it clear she doesn't think that way anymore. If she could cry she knows her fur would be matted down with the water, but she doesn't know how long she's been here. All she knows is she's not dead yet. It makes her laughs turn pained, morphing into soft cries. There's only ever been one person she's let see her like this, let see her break at all. And she's here, walking closer, footsteps unsure.

'I don't need you. I don't need you. I don't need you...'

Her ears prick forwards to catch the hitch in Adora's breath (she's standing in front of her now and the space between feels electric in the most painful way possible.) She said it out loud. It doesn't matter. She curls her torso in on itself, claws slicing into her arms, she barely feels the slow drip of blood. It's not deep enough to scar and she wonders why she held back. She has no reason to.

"Catra, please, come home with me."

She can't look at her, she'll break. "This *is* my home Adora."

"Do you really believe that?"

'No. Not anymore. There's really nothing left for me, not here, not anywhere.'

'Not without you.'

"It's the only home I've ever known. You used to feel the same way."

She's still running in a way, weak excuses and deflection. All because she can't admit that home seems to follow Adora like a disease.

"If you don't come willingly…"

“I’m going to Brightmoon in chains either way, aren’t I?”

Adora doesn’t move but she assumes that means yes, it’s better than she deserves, she knows that. She doesn’t think there’s any fight left in her. That flame’s been distinguished by the wind at the top of the mountain she’s been climbing her whole life.

“I’m done making excuses for you Catra. But I’m not done with you. You can still get forgiveness if you’re willing to work for it.”

She feels the movement in the air and she thinks (hopes) that Adora was trying to reach for her, but the contact never comes. She doesn’t know how to feel about it. She misses her so badly but the thought of being close to her again only to lose it, for good this time, is just so much worse.

Catra still isn’t looking at her face but that doesn’t seem to matter, she still sees the tears that drip onto the floor. “Please Catra, please say you’ll try and fix this because I can’t do what I have to if you don’t.”

Oh. Adora’s meant to kill her, that’s why she didn’t say anything. She probably ought to feel more. She can die here, quickly, and have the last thing she ever sees be Adora’s tear stained face. Not She-Ra and her blazing electric blue eyes full of disdain - no, *Adora*. Just Adora, one last time. Her next breath shakes as she pictures it. It sounds like more than she deserves.

She’s hurt Adora so much, and Adora’s always had the power to stop her from doing it again. But she hasn’t. Even when they’re fighting there’s something there that *lets* Catra do those awful things. She’s never really considered why. She doesn’t even consider it now. Too much of her own longing and false hope will stain whatever answer she finds.

Adora falls to her knees before the Horde throne, gripping at her legs and hiding her face in Catra’s knees, soaking the fabric. It’s possibly the last thing Catra ever expected her to do. If she didn’t know what the world ending feels like she’d think that this is it.

It’s like Adora’s hands carve her heart out of her chest and any anger she still had left freezes over. She was right; this is so much worse. It’s the first time she’s touched her like this in she doesn’t know how long. She’s forgotten how it feels to have Adora touch her like she needs her; like she *wants* her to be close to her.

“Please, Catra, please say you’ll try I can’t - I can’t do this without you, I can’t *kill* you, I’m not strong enough I - I told everyone I would do what needs to be done. I always do what *has* to be done but I just - I can’t do *that*, not to you. I -”

There’s nothing left to break inside her and yet the words and the pleading and the cracked cries are devastating in a way she’s never felt. Whatever shards are left inside her disintegrate under Adora’s voice and she sobs again, eyes begging for the release of tears she can’t give.

She’s never seen Adora like this. And she supposes Adora’s never seen *her* like this. Catra knows she’s as selfish as they come, so much in fact that she never even considered that Adora was hurting as well, beyond the pain that she inflicted. But here she is, Etheria’s saviour, Shadow Weaver’s golden child, broken and crying just like she is. Weak and unable to do what she’s been told she should do, just like her. She doesn’t think she’s ever understood her more.

She can’t speak, but her thoughts are loud enough she might as well have said them: *‘I’ll try. I’ll be better for you. I can’t kill you either. I know I ought to. You’re all I ever truly wanted. I’ve spent so long denying that. Can you ever forgive me?’*

“Adora?” A head of blonde hair raises and even with her chin still on her chest, Catra can see the overwhelming amount of pure hope there. Sees it in the way her lips fall open, in the shine of her eyes and her hands that hold tight enough to crush.

Catra doesn’t say anything else, stares down at her own tear-darkened knees as she thrusts out her wrists. Her arms shake with the effort to keep them aloft, she hates it. She’s so fucking

weak. And it's not an answer but it is surrender. It's an *'I'll try,'* and it's more than she ever thought she would admit.

She hears Adora swallow before she stands and Catra can see her legs shaking with the effort. She closes her eyes again, blocking out the source that just makes her want to hold Adora and never let her go. She's never been able to do that. And she supposes she never will.

"Y'know I don't actually have anything to tie you up with."

It gets her to look up, her arms shake even more and she lets them fall. Adora's entire face is red and blotchy and glistening with salt water and she's the most beautiful thing Catra's ever seen. Adora wipes off her face before breaking into a small pained smile, she looks embarrassed and Catra doesn't know who's more shocked by the watery laugh it gets out of her.

"You're such an idiot."

"Yeah, I know."

How can she still be the same? But she's not but she is and... And there's no point in trying to figure out where *her* Adora is. (Even if her heart's telling her she's there in that damn smile.)

'Adora was never yours and she never will be.'

It doesn't matter how many times the thought has occurred to her in the dead of night, it always cuts deep as a blade. Now is no exception. She knows Adora winces at the cracks she hears when she tries to stand, she hisses in a breath through her teeth.

"Catra...how long have you been in that chair?"

"How long has it been since I killed Hordak?" She feels nothing when she says it. She's a murderer. Maybe she always thought she would be.

"I don't -"

"- How long since I let Sparkles go?"

She can see Adora working it through - she always was easy to read. The reminder is like a slap to the face.

"Catra... it's been four days."

She ought to be more shocked by that. It falls into the void of her emotions along with the rest. The only light left is Adora, Adora and gentle hands that are holding her arms. When did that happen? She doesn't have the strength to remove them even though they burn white-hot. (She pretends Adora's holding her this softly because she wants to and not because she's afraid of breaking her or digging into the fresh slices on her arms.)

"Doesn't matter. I'll - I'll go willingly."

She realises she never wants to see this place again. Her whole body wracks with tremors when she tries to take a step, her legs give out under her but Adora's there to catch her.

'Where were you when I needed you most?'

'She's here now.'

Why is nothing ever as simple as she wants it to be?

"Can you walk?" It sounds faded and distorted, like Adora's far away, but she's not, she's right there. Four days - just a little longer and dehydration would've let her go. But Adora won't, not now. She hates how sure of it she is.

"What do you think, genius?"

Adora ignores the growl, bends down to get an arm under her legs and lifts her up. It's so unexpected it shocks her silent. Adora's meant to be predictable, she's not meant to do things like that. (She tries so very desperately to ignore the part of her that says *no one* should have this if it isn't her. Turns out she's too tired to fight that too.)

Adora is so close and they're not fighting. They should be fighting. Catra should be tearing into her throat and drowning on her blood or scratching deep enough to maim. But she doesn't, because just like every other time, she can't bring herself to. Except now it wouldn't even win the war, she's lost either way.

She wraps her arms around Adora's neck, hiding her face in her jacket just so their faces aren't so unbearably close, she breathes her in like they did as children, she smells the same under Brightmoon soaps. She'd lived with, clung to, the ghost of her scent for so long. She'd searched for it in their old room, anywhere she could think of until it was lost entirely. But this isn't that decaying wisp of her she'll soon lose, this is powerful and overwhelming and she wants to cry against it.

"You're a lot lighter than the last time I did this." It's trying to be teasing, some vain attempt to get her to feel better maybe? She doesn't know why Adora would bother to do that. It doesn't work anyway; Adora's never held her like this.

"We've never done this."

'I wish we had.'

"Portal."

Makes sense, she supposes, Adora had to carry her to that skiff. That stupid fucking skiff in that stupid fucking portal. Gods she really fucked up didn't she? How can Adora even bear to touch her? It's because she's always been the better one. Everyone always said so, and Catra's always known it to be true. Her claws catch in Adora's jacket, that same damn jacket. If this is the last time she'll be able to touch her she's going to make the most of it.

(In a lot of ways she's already waiting for the fall of it afterwards, for when she'll have to go maybe the rest of her life without her touch or her smile. She should be used to it by now - the not having her - but she's never been good at letting her go. Not

when she left, not after the portal, and certainly not now that she's in her arms.)

After the first few steps Adora almost trips over her tail where it hangs limp like the rest of her body, Adora winds it around her wrist and any other time she would've hissed or snapped at her for it. She's just too tired and Adora's arms feel too nice around her.

She tells herself a lot of lies as Adora carries her through grunge-green hallways; that Adora is purposefully not trying to rock her too much, that Adora would still offer to do this even if she could walk, that the miniscule back and forth motion of her thumb on her tail is intentional. There's nothing left in her that's able to fight her delusions. And, more importantly, she doesn't want to. Not right now. Not when she can so easily memorize the way her breathing makes their chests move together.

Time means nothing here as she floats on the high of Adora and the *'home'* her scent croons for her. She thinks this might be the most content she's been since Adora left all those years ago, and she's glad her exhaustion prevents her self-loathing from making an appearance at the thought.

When Adora stops and looks around for the third time, Catra realises she should probably be helping her navigate. But she's selfish and the longer it takes them to escape, the longer she can remain here with her, safer than she's ever felt. She doubts she would help anyway, the few times she is able to blink her eyes back open all she sees are swimming colours and shapes.

"Just got to find the others and we'll be home okay?" (she thinks) Adora whispers.

The arm around her back squeezes tighter and she chokes out a purr because of it. She thinks Adora freezes again but her eyes don't open to check. She manages to kill the rumble after a few

seconds and Adora starts up moving again. Catra is sure she imagines the wetness that drips onto her shoulder and the light huff above her. She doesn't think she could unlatch her claws if she tried.

Her ears flick back to the sound of a door opening. It's too far away for it to be Adora, and any other time she would be instantly on edge. Four feet get closer and she relies entirely on hearing and smell (both delayed and distorted enough to disorient) to figure out who it is.

"Is she dead?" Probably Arrow Boy. She doesn't care. He's not Adora.

"No. She's coming willingly as a prisoner." Catra knows she imagines the fondness in the words - it wouldn't make sense otherwise.

Having the words said aloud almost makes her laugh. But she's just too tired to do anything, even dig her claws deeper into the jacket she's holding like a vice. Sparkles and Arrow Boy probably ought to ask why Adora is holding her this way - or maybe she just wants them to ask. She doesn't deserve this softness, not after everything. *She* wants to know why.

"Do you want us to-"

"- No. I'll take her." There's a bite in her voice: conviction. It makes her heart shift in her chest, like it's trying to believe Adora still cares.

Even with her senses fading and her head screaming for sleep, she recognises the sharp crackling smell of Shadow Weaver instantly. Her heart thuds faster, and her entire body protests the involuntary way it wants to tense or run or claw - she's almost thankful she's too tired to do any of it.

With the way Adora's holding her she can't see the sorceress, still, she screws her eyes shut. But it doesn't stop the choking power of her presence or the piercing lilt of her voice when she speaks.

"Adora, there's no point in taking her with us. She's too -"

Adora all but growls, "*She's coming back to Brightmoon.* And if you don't like that you can leave."

'She's standing up to Shadow Weaver for you.'

It makes the world stop.

"You never protected me. Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side."

She doesn't know what she might do in response if she weren't practically comatose. All she knows is that she wants to replace every pain-soaked memory from her childhood with this moment; Adora defending her again, Adora growling at Shadow Weaver full of righteous fury *for her*.

Instead of a thank you her brain sings: *'I love you, I love you, I love you.'*

She can't seem to think anything else. And it hurts, it stings like blades and tears her apart like fire, but for once she thinks it's okay. Just for this moment Adora is holding her like she loves her back and she can feel Adora's racing heartbeat against her chest, and she can admit to herself that she loves her. That she always has and she always will.

Chapter End Notes

****I'll Pretend That You Do****

Did I write dehydration and starvation accurately? No. Is Catra a different species and I can use that to justify a lot of my shit? Yes.

Going forward I've got everything planned out (yes that's why the chapter count has jumped up from 9 to 15 oops.) But this will be finished eventually.

Walls: Part I

Chapter Summary

> Adora doesn't know how to feel about everything, and Catra...well she doesn't really seem to be feeling anything at all.

Chapter Notes

> I struggled with this so much. Anyway it's another longer one so forgive me.
>
> Unnecessary context: I personally think Adora realised she's in love with Catra somewhere between season 1 and 2 and then repressed that shit down. She saw healthy, loving couples and it kinda clicked for her and so she knows but ignores because she also knows she can never have it. (And doesn't think she deserves it anyway.)
>
> TW: referenced past self harm (it's the claw thing)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

She doesn’t want to let Catra go (when has she ever) but she has to.

Glimmer teleports them back to Brightmoon. She looks as tired as Adora feels. Bow spins around, looking for Shadow Weaver, only to realise she was left behind. Adora’s grateful of it. But that semblance of a good feeling dies the moment Catra goes completely limp in her arms. (She never thought she'd miss the feeling of claws at her back quite this much.) She doesn’t bother hiding the sheer amount of panic she feels.

“Catra... it’s been four days.”

Catra's lucky to have even lasted this long. But she's a survivour, always has been, and she's not going to die to fucking dehydration. She barely gets out the, "Where are we putting her?" before Glimmer teleports the two of them into Shadow Weaver's old cell.

It feels wrong. So unbelievably wrong to leave her here. But even Catra knew she was going to be locked up, she knew she deserved it. Adora crushes the storm of thoughts and feelings down even further. It's not so easy to do with Catra dying in her arms.

Adora demands food and water, just shouting it to the air for anyone to hear. She knows Glimmer is there watching her - or maybe she's run off, Adora doesn't know - but she feels utterly alone. Fear and loneliness are the only things she lets live in her head right now, she wishes she could be as numb as this morning, but these feelings, they're her weakness. She's never been all that good at suppressing either of them. It has her gripping Catra to her chest, burying her face in her shoulder and counting her heartbeats.

She whispers, "Catra just hold on," like it'll make any fucking difference at this point.

Every second that passes makes her shake harder. She doesn't even have to think about whether She-Ra's magic could bring Catra back from this; she could, no question. And She-Ra's not here.

'If Catra dies it'll be your fault.'

She wonders how many times she can cry within the same twenty-four hours.

Glimmer brings her what she not-so-kindly asked for, Adora can't even look at her. She's not sure why. She forces some water into Catra's unconscious system while Micah sets up what will be her prison. (She hadn't realised the others had returned and it

somehow makes her feel worse.) Catra's definitely not aware, but her body is at least awake enough to gulp the water down.

She wants to stay more than anything, she never wants to leave Catra alone again. She wants to be here when she wakes up, wants to comfort her when she undoubtedly panics at the unfamiliar, incredibly open and bright surroundings. She'll hate it. But she'll *be here*, in Brightmoon. Not miles away in the Fright Zone plotting against them.

Except Adora's exhausted from the burn out of adrenaline, fear and tears and Glimmer teleports her to her own room before she can say anything. As soon as she hits the mattress she's asleep. Exhaustion taking her out, but not preventing the plague of nightmares that rally in her head.

She doesn't know what she expected, maybe she foolishly hoped having Catra even *near* her again would make her sleep better. But she wakes suddenly three times in the night, tangled in suffocating sheets, and *still* reaching for Catra at the end of her bed. There's that loneliness leaking like ice in her veins, pure cold that takes hold in those early morning hours. She goes outside anyway, staring out at the stars and shivering.

She gives up on sleep altogether as soon as the first moonrise trips over the horizon.

She ignores the guards that tell her the prisoner - her whole body wants to reject the idea - isn't supposed to have visitors, demanding they let her in. They put up less of a fight than she's expecting, maybe she looks as crazed as she feels. (Or maybe Glimmer told them she's allowed.)

She's scared again, apparently always scared now, when she opens the door. It doesn't really leave when she sees Catra asleep, curled into a ball like she used to - and she's not going to let herself fall like that. It's far too early to get lost in memories.

But she's tired, she knows she'll give in eventually. Already knows she's going to wait for Catra to wake up.

She's not leaving this room until she sees her eyes again unless she has to. She needs to know that she's going to live through this. She worried about Catra when they were separated, the question of whether she was okay always playing in the back of her mind. She shouldn't be surprised it's not going away even as she looks at her. Adora sits, paces and lies drowning in her own worry and guilt. She can't stop.

Catra looks like a corpse; cheeks sallow from her body eating away at her muscle mass to survive. Her fur is scarily thin and dull, still matted with dirt and ash and blood and burn. With the moonrises the world gets a little warmer and yet Catra starts shaking in her sleep. It scares her more than it should, like a poison trickling down her throat.

She runs from the room only to return quickly with a mountain of blankets. She doesn't want to hesitate before crossing the magic barrier, but she's terrified of how much this hurts. There's *so much* - like a floodgate's been opened, one she's been barricading since the Battle of Brightmoon. And it's worked up until now - she was able to bury most things regarding Catra after that. Even as she realised she's in love with her, that she always has been, still she didn't let that wall break. In fact she just made it stronger.

She's just got to do it again now. She's not going to think about it. She's going to walk through this magic wall and give Catra a blanket because she looks cold and for absolutely no other reason. As soon as she can force her body to move again that is. Because the sight of Catra this close and this fragile makes her feel sick. But a particularly violent shudder from the sleeping form and Adora's body makes the movement for her.

She's far too gentle in the way she tucks layers around the enemy. (*'The enemy who let your friends go. The enemy who asked Glimmer to kill her. The enemy who surrendered to you, went with you willingly.'* She ignores the burn in her eyes.) She doesn't let

herself touch Catra's skin, almost afraid that she'll shatter given the state she's in. But gods does she want to. She doesn't know if she's ever *wanted* like the way Catra's made her want the past few days. It's just another reason to be scared. Just another reason for her to be holding onto those barriers she's built.

She steps away from her, the magic of the spell prickling at her neck, but stays within its exposing walls. She wonders, not for the first time, why she could never hate Catra. She should. She tried to destroy everything both her and her friends love. But Adora loves her, more than maybe anything else (even if she'll never know that) and so this - her destroying herself - makes some painful sort of sense.

She should do a lot of things. She should leave this room and let Catra and her crimes and her own roiling feelings rot here. She should let her go and never think about her again.

She *can't* do any of it.

Even before she'd seen Catra fall - tear - apart at the seams. She couldn't do it, so how the *fuck* is she meant to now? She knew Catra was hurting, figured that much out from the words that have been spat at her since she left, from the memories they'd been forced to relive. She just never realised how much, and she hates herself for it. Maybe they wouldn't be here if she'd just *figured it out*. As long as Catra's hurting, Adora will be trying to fix it. She knows that.

But Catra hadn't let her, had pushed her away even further and they broke. And Adora had finally accepted Catra's choice to stay with the Horde. And now she's here. Dying. Because Adora still needs to try and fix it.

One action - not even a word - *indicating* that Catra's going to even *attempt* to do better and she's running back to her, every promise they ever made chiming in her head. There's eighteen years of wanting to protect Catra, keep her safe, make her happy that she'll never be able to get rid of. And for it she might get her

heart broken all over again, but even a *chance* to try and fix them is worth it.

And just as there is resolve, there's doubt;

'Maybe Catra was just lying to save her skin.'

The thought disintegrates upon its birth; Catra wanted to die. This time it's not just words she's hearing as if through water, she's seen it. She can't stop her body from recoiling at the memory, and it's not just the sting of the magic as she passes through it that makes her feel empty.

She forces down every thought she has before it's even formed with perfected precision. She starts towards the door; if she can't see Catra then every image of her decayed, shaking body won't scream at the edges of her mind. (Even if the way her heart races says otherwise.) Her hand freezes on the door handle when she gets there. She's paralyzed again. She wants to *break it*. It's not fair.

She's trying to leave, like she should've done long ago, so why -

She hears the weak rattle of Catra's breath behind her and crumbles. The floor is cold when she finds it, she can feel the metal on the door like a blade on her spine as it presses into the ghostly scars on her back that have yet to leave her completely. She stares at the ground, unable to bring herself to look at the woman who right now just seems immune to the defenses she's spent so long building. She can ignore her own thoughts as if they're said by some stranger on the other side of a wall, can pretend her wants are merely dreams she has to let go in the daylight. So why can't she stop thinking about *her*?

About how yesterday was the first time in months that she's even seen Catra. How it had to be a reunion upon death's door and they'd walked away alive and *together* again. Catra who hadn't judged her for breaking because they were the same - both fighters not really knowing how to fight anymore. Not only had

Catra let Glimmer go, asked her to kill her, she surrendered to *her*. And it feels like a balm on her heart for all the times Catra said she'd never go with her, how she'd watch the whole world burn so she wouldn't win.

She let Adora talk, touch, *hold* her again. She laughed and cried in front of her, *with her*. She *purred* in her arms, Catra was happy, or at the very least didn't want her to go, and she swore it had her heart wanting to burst out of her chest. Gods why does Catra have to give her so much hope? And so much pain.

She said she wouldn't think about it. Guess she's a liar now too. It's *all* she can think about. The buzz of those last walls as they come crashing down sound like symphonies. She looks at Catra again, she's too weak not to; she's not shaking anymore, she's not even moving.

This time she welcomes the fear, if only because she knows she has no other choice. It's suffocating. Has her breath scraping against her throat as she tries to get it to her lungs. Catra looks dead from here, still as stone. Minutes pass and she doesn't hear anything past the roar in her head. She thinks she wants to throw up but all that she tastes is bile.

Catra's alive, she knows she is. She saw the rise and fall of her chest not ten minutes ago and yet she wants to rush to her side and check her pulse. Her whole life she's wanted to be close to Catra, but this feels different. This is drenched in cold, unknown terror and 'what ifs'. She hadn't realized how much those walls were hiding.

'You want to be there in case she dies and you never get another chance to.'

Everything feels like lead and the bitterness coats her tongue, her teeth ache from how hard she's clenching her jaw, and yet she moves. Everything trembles but the next time she hits the floor she's close enough to hear Catra's breathing. And even though it

rattles in her hollow chest, it's enough for Adora to just fucking *breathe*.

She just - she just can't lose her again. Not like this. There's a quiet click against stone and she realises the tears flowing from her eyes.

She wants to hit something; she wants to stay here forever and never have to face the outside world again. She wants to scream and she - she wants to hold Catra in her arms again, lay her head on her chest until she wakes up like she's never done before. She wants to see her eyes and her smile, hear her laugh and the rare rumble of her purr that's always been something of a drug to her. She wants all of it again. She bites down on her tongue to hold in the sob that's begging to escape.

"Why do you have to be everything I've ever wanted?"

She doesn't know why she says it out loud, even less so why she expects an answer.

The moment Catra's eyes flutter open Adora is on her feet. The coughs that are drawn from cracked lips make her panic for no good reason.

('*There is a very good fucking reason, she's on the verge of dying.*')

Adora doesn't know whether saying her name will help - she's honestly not sure if Catra's even fully conscious yet - so she stays silent, practically bouncing out of her skin because she can see them again. *Catra's eyes*. There's something so undeniably soft in them and something inside her just *melts*.

She's not even upset when that look dissolves; she's just happy she had it at all. It's replaced with something akin to fear, Catra's whole body tenses and she tears the blankets off. She winces with the sudden movement, biting at her lip in a way Adora knows

means she's trying to hide how badly she's hurting. Adora watches, frozen, as something triggers one of Catra's senses. Her ears, already back, flatten against her head, her tail lashing while she hisses at...Adora's not really sure. It's just *something* and she wants to know so she can make it better.

Once more, she's through that barrier, endlessly grateful it's only meant to keep Catra *in* rather than her *out*.

"It's okay Catra, it's just me." She doesn't know if those words will bring the comfort they once did, but it's the only thing she knows how to do. "You're safe, you're in Brightmoon."

Unsurprisingly that doesn't make Catra's bristling fur go flat again, her teeth are bared as much as possible. It makes Adora halt her path. Catra looks *feral*; thin-slitted eyes set heavy in the shadows on her face, claws tangled in the blankets that are strewn around her on the chair. And she doesn't know what to do.

It's painful how quickly it brings her back to the reality of the situation. This isn't a Catra she really knows how to comfort anymore. Catra won't want it (she never acted like she wanted it even before the fallout, it never stopped her from giving it.) She doesn't know what applies now, but Catra likes her space, that she's sure hasn't changed. She crosses the spell-line again, telling herself it's not a retreat borne of fear or cowardice.

It takes a minute of Catra carefully cataloguing her surroundings before her lips come back over her teeth, ears returning to normal as she sinks into the chair reluctantly. The silence still stretches and Adora's determined not to be the first one to break it. Turns out she doesn't have to wait that long.

"Didn't think you would be here."

Adora can't read her tone at all past the cracked mutter that it is. She can't figure out if Catra's upset by it or not is what bothers her the most. She definitely should've considered Catra not wanting her here after everything (she knows she should feel that

way too.) She doesn't want to go but if that's what Catra wants then...then she'll do it.

"Of course I'm here."

'Where else would I possibly be?'

Maybe she said too much with that because Catra seems to scrutinise it, eyes narrowing when she doesn't say anything else. Adora crosses her arms over her chest, feeling all too exposed under Catra's gaze. (She hates that she's missed it.)

Catra opens her mouth but all that escapes is a cough that rips through her fragile form. It hurts Adora to watch.

"You need to drink something."

The first time Catra tries to retaliate nothing comes out, proving her point, but the next go she manages to whisper, "I don't *need* to do anything," devoid of any and all emotion.

How is this lifelessness worse than her hating snarl?

"Catra -"

There's a growl loud enough for Adora to stop talking. (Even that isn't what she expects, it's flat, doesn't show on her face.) She really should know by now that telling Catra what she 'has' to do practically guarantees she won't. Even when it'll save her life apparently.

She's horribly reminded of everything Catra *didn't* say yesterday. Not a *'sorry'* - though she expected that much, Catra's never apologised for anything in her life - not even a *'I'll do better'* said aloud.

"I'm such an idiot."

Catra wasn't expecting that, it's obvious. And in fairness, Adora wasn't expecting herself to say it out loud. But she has. And the

anger she's been ignoring demands she say anything at all to make Catra understand how she's feeling. (Even if she's not really sure herself.)

"Y'know I thought yesterday might have actually meant something to you."

'It meant so much to me.'

Adora doesn't know what fuels the way Catra curls into herself, why her ears drop, why she turns away. Her claws tug at the fabric on her legs and Adora hates how it makes that fear come ricocheting through her once more. She doesn't trust Catra not to hurt herself again, maybe it's just worse because of the blood that stains the fraying edges of torn black sleeve covering her arm.

After far too long, Catra whispers, "It did..." into her knees.

"Then act like it." It's not what she expected to come out of her mouth, but she's half glad that it did. It's laced with the venom Catra's been giving her these past few years. She can't bring herself to care.

Until she does. Because Catra *shakes*, and she looks just like she did when she was young; vulnerable and scared. And that undying voice calls from within Adora's heart again. She's wondered so many times where the Catra she used to know is. She's right here. And there's heartbreak in this silence.

She knows what'll happen if she reaches out now, has the memory of long-gone scars to prove it. It doesn't stop her wanting to. It never has.

She's not going to apologise, but she shouldn't want to in the first place. She makes herself a promise then: she's not going to apologise until Catra does. She doesn't care for what, anything is all she's asking for. (Except she's not asking, she knows better than that.) It might very well never happen. But she meant what she said yesterday; she's not making excuses for Catra anymore.

It glues some of her shattered resolve back together. Allows her to uncross her arms and say, "I'll go. I know you don't want me here. Please just...eat, at least drink something."

'Please don't let yourself die.'

Catra doesn't emerge when she says, quietly, "Why do you care?"

"You're an idiot if you ever thought I stopped caring." For words that should be almost sweet they come out with that same latent anger.

She knows she's said too much, curses herself and remains frozen for what feels like hours as she waits for Catra to respond in any way she can read. Catra seems to stop breathing and it *shouldn't* make her panic this much. She just wants Catra to look at her again. But she doesn't, and Adora doesn't know what else she expected. Her whole body sags with the sigh she lets loose.

She forces down the reflexive *'I'm sorry'* that almost comes out. "Fine. I'll just - I'll go."

As much as the *'I'll go'* was for Catra's sake, she needs it too. She can't be here, not when Catra can't seem to bring herself to look at her while everything inside of her just wants to sink into her arms like they did as kids. Not when she's like this; cold, distant, absent of fight. That sickness is churning in her stomach again when she walks to the door on surprisingly unsteady legs.

She stops, staring at the handle again, trying to force herself to open it when there's a sound behind her. Except this time it's not the rattle of Catra's breath as she stays suspended in death-sleep that halts her. There's a shuffling and the clink of claws on the floor and she just can't stop herself from looking back. She doesn't turn, not fully, just enough to look over her shoulder as her fingers grip the handle all too tightly.

Catra only meets her eyes for a second but as soon as she turns away she drinks from the bottle that's been sitting on the floor of her cell. It's the biggest relief Adora's ever felt. She wants to

collapse against the door as the feeling threatens to knock her legs out from under her.

Because it's not just that Catra's choosing to live, it means that she's going to have to live with the consequences of what she's done. She's going to *try* and yesterday wasn't meaningless and full of empty unsaid promises.

She hates this *love* that comes crashing through. She needs her walls back, maybe more than ever. But even as she exits the room and closes the door behind her, sees the guards pretending not to have heard anything (she doesn't actually know if they did,) she feels it through her whole body.

That stupid hope she's never been able to get rid of sitting like a light in her chest, whispering that she'll find home again eventually.

She knows if things weren't so weird between the three of them, Glimmer (and Bow as the mediator) would've cornered her and asked about yesterday. She can picture the conversation clearly in her head:

"Why were you like that with her?"

And she'd scramble for a minute trying not to expose (or hurt) herself too badly, before saying, *"She was my best friend for a lot longer than she was my enemy Glimmer."*

And Glimmer would say something like, *"She's still our enemy, Adora."*

And she'd be able to tell them that no, Catra's going to try and be better. And she'd probably smile like the lovesick fool that she is. And maybe they'd figure it out and maybe they wouldn't - she wouldn't say anything either way.

But it won't happen. Because there's still an uncountable amount of fractures between them they have yet to sew back together.

But oddly it’s just another thing that adds to the hope; for the first time she has everyone she loves around her, and through some unexplained miracle, they all seem to be willing to try and fix things.

Chapter End Notes

> Does this technically count as the third time I write Catra temporarily dying? Like she didn't *die* but it's close enough.
>
> Yeah school started again so uploads are gonna be a mess. I'll try and do a chapter once a week but we'll see how that goes. (But if I finish chapters do y'all want them as soon as possible or not?)

Trying

Chapter Notes

> The show never addresses things like bathrooms for prisoners in the little circle prisons so neither will I.
>
> Also there's more runestones that we don't see in the show - there's 12, one for each moon - and it's never addressed past the first season? Which makes the whole Heart activating with the runestone connections a bit weird because Light Hope only shows the ones for the Princesses we see? Idk was gonna bring it up but didn't want to get into that whole thing.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

One of the first things she had realised about her frankly obscene prison is the smell. Old soot and electricity like a stain in the air; Shadow Weaver and something subtle (but much fresher) she's come to know as Double Trouble. If she were anymore dramatic she would think it smells like betrayal.

So they'd been captured and held here. She doesn't know if that makes her feel better. She doesn't care; it doesn't matter now. With the war over they're long gone either way. She tries to figure out if the thought of never seeing them again hurts, it takes her a while to figure it out, but yes. Because she's weak, and she misses everyone who leaves her, even if - *especially* if - she shouldn't.

She thinks a day has passed since Adora came to see her, but she's not really sure. She's been brought three other meals, all by a faceless guard, and she thinks she's rightfully wary of it. Even if they are Princesses, the good guys, she wouldn't exactly blame them for wanting to poison her. But they won't and she knows

that. It’s just that nothing in her mind can justify a prisoner eating three meals a day.

The momentary visits are the only things keeping her aware of time passing at all. Other than that, it’s hazy. There’s hours of gaps in her memory where she must’ve just been sitting here, bored out of her mind while she waited for something.

‘Someone.’

‘Shut up.’

She can ignore her thoughts all she wants, a day later and she’s still bundled in the blankets Adora must’ve gotten her, drowning out the smell in the air with that of *her* that is slowly fading from the fabric. But even Adora's scent isn't enough to rid her of the knowledge that she's alone in a prison that was once Shadow Weaver’s.

In a lot of ways it’s similar to that of her old Fright Zone cell. There’s still the dilute magic hanging in the air that keeps her on edge, sets old memories tiptoeing along the edges of her mind. That horribly familiar unrest in her bones reminding her she should be dead is back again, once more reminding her that it’s only because of people who are so much better than her that she’s not.

This is worse though, it hadn’t taken her that long to come to that conclusion. Because while the green humming metal cage she’d been thrown in was awful, the Fright Zone was still home at that point. She’d found some corrupt version of solace there while she waited for her end. Brightmoon is not home. It’s too quiet, too open, too fucking bright. There’s a painful sort of exposure here that drags out her regrets with nothing to hold them back, no noise to focus on, no distractions at all.

She’s relied on shadowed corners for a lot of things in her life; they can hide her, she can blame them. She was never safe in shadows - the witch made sure of that - but she felt at least safer,

could keep her guard up easier. There's not even walls in this cell, nowhere to turn that will mean no one sees her.

But, of course, there's one other, much starker difference to last time: Adora. Because it ultimately always comes back to her. It simultaneously feels like everything and nothing has changed. She's still angry at her, still hurts, still hasn't forgiven her entirely but everything feels more distant than usual. She blames her fragile state above everything else. There's nothing else that would allow her to admit, even to herself, that this prison is simply better because she has Adora nearby. She didn't have Adora in that metal coffin they'd tied her up in - she doesn't have her now either, not really - but even the memory of her presence is able to make her feel better.

She hates it. It's pathetic really.

But it's *Adora* and she...she is - was - a lot of things to Catra, for Catra. A friend, the closest thing to family she's ever known, a rival, an enemy. But for the longest time she was her safety, her haven in the raging sea of misery and black magic. And she's always been too weak (too stubborn, too self-destructive) to forget the lightness Adora brought her completely. Smother it, she definitely did that, tried to choke it out with her own anger like blood. And just like seemingly everything else, she failed to do even that. *Adora* and everything she used to mean cling to her soul like an ink stain. She can feel it, warmth like a candle inside her even now, as she rots in this room, alive because Adora asked it of her.

It makes her want to laugh to an empty room, that bitter, pain-filled one she's gotten so good at. She can only hope that with time it'll get better. Without sharing every moment of every day with her, and without the war keeping her obsession and pain excruciatingly present, maybe it'll get better. She's got nothing but time to find out.

She’s still too weak and deathly to move, only doing so to eat when food is brought. Or what counts for food in Brightmoon apparently, because it’s all liquid (which she’s secretly thankful for, she’s not sure her withered stomach could really handle anything else right now.)

Funnily enough, it’s still better than anything she ever managed to scavenge in the Fright Zone, even as Hordak’s second-in-command. Hordak. She hasn’t thought about him that much, simply because she doesn’t want to. In the scheme of things it feels almost small. She wonders how differently this would be playing out if she’d delivered the final blow herself instead of that rubble. She doesn’t dwell on it too much.

His blood has long since been gouged out from under her claws, but the stain of it still lives on her fur along with the ash and smoke. She’s just too tired to get rid of it completely, even with the origin of it crawling around in the back of her head, it’s helping keep her grounded. It would be so easy to believe none of this is real otherwise.

Her eyes start burning and she realises she’s been staring at the same spot on the floor for...well she’s not really sure how long. It’s been a day (she’s pretty sure it’s been a day now, the shadows, what little of them there are, keep getting shorter) and she already hates this room. Beyond the uncomfortable exposure, the sheer intensity of light hurts her eyes, whenever she turns it changes and she has to adjust all over again.

After the fifth time she just gives up, screwing them completely shut but still feeling the whiteness even behind her own skin. It’s better than before at least. She curls in tighter, claws catching in the blankets as she bundles into them further, too tired to bother lying to herself about why.

She hears a dull echo of footsteps in the corridor that come to a halt. She doesn’t exactly trust her own senses, so there could very

well be an exchange of hushed words, but she hears none, just more steps and then the click of the door. She doesn't even have to look up to know who it is; there's no one else who would come to see her anyway. (And besides, Adora was never good at stealth exercises.)

Catra tries to casually drop the blankets, opening her eyes (hissing as she does) to look back at that same spot on the floor. But as soon as she does, the diluted smell of shadows crawls back into her senses and seems to trip every response she has. She hates it. She hates it. She hates -

The wind that curls through the room from the balcony (a ridiculous thing for a 'prison' to have really) blows Adora's scent towards her. She's glad she's had the past day to get used to her again, even this much is overwhelming. She valiantly ignores how her head tells her it's home, just trying once more to fill her senses with anything other than lingering black magic.

It's not that being around Adora doesn't hurt - it does, tears her heart from her chest before sewing it back in again - it's just that of two options, she'd pick her over and over again. (She can't believe there was a time when she would've had to consider those options, but she's not *that* good of a liar to convince herself otherwise.)

"Morning."

A *"Hey Adora,"* trips on her tongue. She swallows it down. She just...she can't say her name. She's had all of one day to adjust to *thinking* about her again, and even that causes a storm of thoughts and feelings and memories so powerful it makes her want to break and shatter and tear. But her name holds a power she's never understood; she shouts it sometimes when she's torn from sleep, it plays over and over in her nicer dreams, as rare as they are, makes things boil over inside of her that she's never wanted.

And *gods* she wants to cry just looking at her. She knows there've been an uncountable amount of moments where she's cursed the hold Adora has on her, this is no exception.

It shouldn't be this fucking hard just to look at her, just to *talk* to her, to say anything at all. But it is. Because she's weak and a slave to her own emotions just like Shadow Weaver had always said. Fucking Shadow Weaver.

"Where is she?"

Adora blinks at the unexpected (and unexplained) bluntness of the question, Catra doesn't care. It's a distraction full of thorns, but a distraction all the same from Adora and her sky-steel eyes Catra's missed so dearly.

"Who?"

"Who do you think?" She spits with enough venom for even Adora to get it.

There's hesitation then, "She left."

"She's coming back to Brightmoon. And if you don't like that you can leave."

She's surprised, thankful and angry at the fact she can remember everything that happened that day. (Even her own deluded, exhaustion fuelled admissions she's not ready to relive.) But those words struck a chord, tattooed themselves into her head and her heart without permission. After all, it's what's allowing her to even try this at all - trying to be okay with this tempest that Adora conjures inside her. But there's a consequence, of course there is, she knew she'd have to face them if she were to come here. Might as well start now.

"The witch really hates me that much…"

Adora's almost frantic in her response, "No! No, Glimmer told her to leave. We don't need her power with the war over and she's

hurt most of the people here in one way or another so we got rid of her."

The reassurance leaves her cold. Shadow Weaver's gone. She's locked up in her old prison while the 'good guys' let that monster go free. Her claws snap out and tear into the cushion she's sitting on. Adora, to her credit, doesn't look all that shocked. Just confused.

"Thought you'd want her gone..."

'What I want is for her not to hate me, for her to apologise for everything she's done.'

She knows better than to hope. She just hopes that the stench of her will leave this room in its entirety eventually, and soon.

She pries her claws from the burst cushion and the flurry of feathers that spill out from it, (*'Wait, they put feathers in pillows here?'*) and sighs. She uncurls as best she can but stiff limbs render it harder than she's expecting.

The way Adora's looking at her catches her off guard; expecting, open, attentive and listening for anything she has to say. She has no idea how to respond to it all. She feels like she's falling for a few seconds with just how alien it is. Sure, she's seen it before, Adora always one for a good story. But it's been years, and she'd honestly forgotten that that look even existed.

She bites down the, *"Stop looking at me like that,"* she wants to snarl out in response to her discomfort. Her heart's not in it, and it's not worth the fallout afterwards. (And besides, it really has been so, so long since she's felt like Adora's properly *seen* her. She knows it would feel nice if she could push past her defenses enough to let it in.)

Still reeling, and grasping for anything to say, she figures she might as well ask about the other one as well. It'll at least give her something to think about when she's alone again. Anything other than Adora and her own mistakes.

“How much did you pay them?” The look shatters and she’s thankful.

“What?”

Gods is Adora going to be shocked by every question she asks her? “Double Trouble, how much did you pay them?”

Another long pause before Adora sighs and shrugs weakly, “More than you.”

She doesn’t bother responding, it’ll only make her feel worse.

Adora doesn’t stay long, mumbling something about reparation planning and seeming unable to bear the silted silence. Catra pretends that as soon as she’s gone loneliness doesn’t come creeping back like an old friend. She pretends she’s not hanging onto the smell of ‘home’ in the air before it fades with the wind.

Adora

“Why are you here again?”

‘Because I’m weak, because I miss you, because…’

“What, didn’t think I’d come back?” She tries for something like teasing but it falls flat. It always seems to do that now.

“With your track record, can you blame me?”

It hits her like a kick to the stomach. She’s expecting it to be said with anger (the only emotion Catra’s actually shown since getting to Brightmoon aside from her morose numbness) but there’s none

there, just that resigned sigh that she's becoming more and more acquainted with. Though she doesn't want to be.

It's already been a week since that day and she's managed to keep herself away from Catra for most of it, this only being her third visit since she woke up that second day. She's not proud of herself for her near minimal self-control. It's been awful, sometimes the distance feeling larger than the divide of a war. The only time she remembers feeling this lonely is those first few weeks after she defected. But she hasn't seen Catra in two days, every time she finds herself back in 'her' hallway she grapples onto her pain to drive herself away.

It's exhausting. At least with the war she was usually so busy she didn't have time to think about anything else. But now...well, it's been a week of forcing Catra from her head. And it's not seeming to be getting any easier, she's not sure if she's surprised by that or not.

She's not comforted by her old pattern so much anymore, where she'd be wrestling thoughts from her mind under the cover of night. Mostly because it isn't working so well right now, she can't think about anything without it somehow circling back to her. But she's adapting slowly, out of necessity and nothing else, keeping her mind as blank as possible when usually it would be full of battle plans and training regimes.

And yet even that blankness cracks eventually, leading her right back to her door and the jewel-glow of eyes she'll find behind it. She didn't have an excuse ready when she opened the door, and she's regretting it now. Why does she never think things through? Now she's just standing here, answerless, and depending far too much on her own walls - walls which have been failing her more often than not recently.

"I -"

There's nothing she can say without breaking something. Her own heart being the most likely victim. (Or that promise not to say

sorry.) She ought to say no, she doesn't really blame Catra for thinking like that. She doesn't actually say anything.

Catra's...disappointed (she can't really tell anymore) sigh just adds to her growing heartache, "If you don't want anything you might as well leave." Adora's sure she imagines the sadness that tinges the words. "I don't want to talk to you."

Adora squashes down the anger she feels as Catra curls up once more. It's just an excuse really, the anger, something she's forcing herself to feel instead of the painful grip Catra's always had on her heart.

"Well then I guess it's a good thing I'm not talking."

Catra huffs and gets up - she thinks it might be the first time she's done that with the way her legs shake - she stalks around the back of the tall chair only to stop. Adora sees her tail fall still and limp and she hates the way she worries. She follows the walls of the spell around, slow enough that Catra won't be startled, to see what's happened.

Catra's just standing there, staring out at the night sky, looking more relaxed than Adora can ever remember her looking.

"Adora, what are those?"

Something stops, she's not sure what. It's the first time Catra's said her name since she's gotten here. She doesn't mean for the audible hitch in her breath to happen, but it does, and it's too late to take it back now. She can't remember the last time she felt this...light. She wants to hear her say it like that; free of anger and betrayal, everyday for the rest of her life.

But this is a fleeting thing, and she knows it. She'll take whatever she can get.

She doesn't stop looking at her when she answers, "They're stars. When Scor- when all the main runestones activated, portal

capabilities came back online and we got sucked back into the rest of the Universe."

She's glad she stopped the name before it slipped out fully, it would've broken the wonder on Catra's face. Her ears are soft, her eyes wide and there's almost a smile on her face and even with the Universe glittering and stretching out beyond them, she thinks none of it can compare to Catra beside her. The realisation rips the air out of her.

'How? How can I still love you this much after everything?'

She wants to scream it. She can't, she can't do anything but stare through a wall and choke on the want making a home in her throat.

Catra

She hates that she expects Adora every hour of every day. It's not quite a hope that she'll see her, but it's close enough that that self-loathing litters her head. But Adora doesn't show everyday. She'll wait and wait, and think and think and Adora doesn't come. And it hurts, despite this being her expectation.

Stupid Adora making her hope for the first time in so long. She's not sure if she's missed the feeling. But the tugging in her chest is as incessant as her thoughts are loud. Which is to say, very. Brightmoon is so quiet compared to what she's used to, it took her far too long to realise it as another source of her undying discomfort.

She's sure it's been something like two, nearly three weeks but somehow she hasn't ran out of food for her thoughts. It's

exhausting. Yet she can't sleep, not well anyway. It's too cold, too quiet, too lonely.

What with so much time to herself, she's come to realise things she misses, it (surprisingly) being one of the less painful topics she's managed to come up with. One of those things just happens to be the barracks she grew up in, just sleeping with people close by. She realised on something like day four how much she despised her Force Captain's quarters, the emptiness of it. Sure, she liked the privacy, but looking back, the shitty sleep she's had for the past two or so years just wasn't worth it. (Not that she exactly slept *well* in the barracks, just better.)

She misses people she never thought she would; Lonnie, Rogelio, even Kyle. About five days ago she'd given up on barring back her feelings about Scorpia and Entrapta, finally letting herself just miss them. She'd spent the next two days just sifting through memories for something to do.

Because thinking (and star gazing now that she can walk around again) really is the *only* thing to do in this circle that's maybe, what, four meters in diameter? It's fucking tiny - it's a cage after all. And she has to fight down feeling like an exhibit when Adora comes to see her every couple of days.

And then there's Adora. Because there always is. Adora and the things she's done, the things Catra's done, the feelings she has.

And like with everything else she's trying to be okay with it. She's fucking *trying*. But she's spent so fucking long digging into and relying on her hurt and denial and self-loathing and every other bad thing that comes with...with *loving* Adora, and then laying in her own self-destruction, that she doesn't even know how to start *not* feeling like that.

Gods *loving her*. It - it...she can't even begin to untangle the thorn-filled mess of her own feelings. Every time she dared to even think the words before left her bleeding and her surroundings torn and broken, a distraction from herself that

would last long enough for the denial to come back. But now it - she hasn’t really got anything to break, no escape from herself. And the strangest, most confusing thing? She doesn’t really want to. Sure she *wants to*. But it doesn’t feel like she’ll die without it anymore. Still, there’s tears in the corners of her eyes whenever the words appear.

But days pass and she pulls apart that knot a little more, finding ends of threads and laying them out. There’s not much good to have come out of her pensive musings, it reiterates her heartbreak a hundred times a day. But it’s okay. She’s growing used to the pain in a way she never let herself get used to before. And whatever jagged edges are left get smoothed down a little more every time Adora comes to see her.

There's never going to be a day where the fact that Adora doesn't love her back is going to be okay, but maybe, eventually, it won't hurt. Maybe one day Adora will care about her again. Because she's lying when she says that now, she has to be. There's no way Adora can care after everything she's done. At one point, when she really wanted to hurt, she tried to imagine their situations reversed; how would she feel if Adora had done the things she had. The answer was painfully easy; she'd still love her the exact same. It took hours for the screaming urge to shred everything she can lay her hands on to die down.

But in spite of all that (or maybe because of all that) she’s getting better. Somehow, she, *Catra* is getting better. Frankly, she finds it unbelievable. But she hasn’t felt anything even close to this melancholy peace before in her life. Everything bad is still there, ready and waiting. But she ignores it, listens to it without acting on it.

If Adora could somehow see inside of her head, she hopes she’d be proud. And just like that another thread appears.

Chapter End Notes

The yearning is strong in this one lads. Think this is the most introspection-heavy chapter I've ever written, I really tried to make the timeline believable. A few weeks alone with the only contact you have being the woman you're in love with while you're trying to work through your feelings? Imagine that would be a little difficult tbh.

(Feat. Adora making sure they give Catra soft foods so she can actually eat because love.)

Now the next chapter can either be one longer one that will take a while to do or three shorter ones, up to you guys.

Bow

Chapter Notes

> The next 3 are all gonna be Catra POV cos it was gonna be one chapter just so y'all know. Also Catra has the self-worth of a fucking rock which will not be changing for a good while
>
> Very important side note: Bow is best boy :)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Hey Catra."

If she'd actually been able to sleep here since that first night, she would have jumped awake at the unfamiliar voice. But any amount of good sleep still annoyingly evades her. Which she would be fine with - she can survive it easily - but as a consequence her senses aren't as sharp as she's used to. Every noise that happens within her prison is painfully loud, while everything outside it seems unbearably soft. It's disorientating to say the least.

She doesn't do anything but squint at the boy as he walks deeper into her prison. She's not going to let him see just how unexpected his visit is, but it has her head whirring just the same.

He has absolutely no reason to be here. The only times they've ever even interacted were when she was trying to kidnap, escape or kill him. Coming to see her would make at least some sense if there was a malicious bone in Bow's body; a person she's hurt coming to shout or even laugh at what she's been reduced to she could understand. Who wouldn't be glad to see how far she's let herself fall? But she already knows from experience that he's incapable of even *thinking* like that.

And even if she didn't know that, he's fucking smiling. At her. (It's small and wary but it's still a smile which makes zero fucking sense.)

"What are you doing here, Arrow Boy?" She really does try to keep the accusation out of her voice but that numbness she's been hanging onto has all but left her in the past weeks.

He hesitates then shrugs, "Thought you'd be lonely."

There's more honesty in that than she's expecting. He's so open, acting like it's easy. She remembers how nicely he treated her the few times they've actually interacted (and subsequently how awfully she returned his favours) - maybe she was a fool for expecting anything else other than dangerous earnesty. Not that she was really expecting *anything*, he shouldn't be here.

But it's not all of it, she can tell as much, can read in his face how unused to lying he is. She manages to keep the venom out when she says, "I know when people are hiding things from me okay, there's something else."

"Maybe I'm hoping I'll get through to you."

She chokes the laugh she wants to let loose down to a short huff, "Don't think there's much to get through to anymore."

It's maybe a bit more than she was ready to reveal but it's too late now. And it's accurate, more so by the day. All the regrets that swarm in her head during those endless hours alone consume her more and more everyday. It feels like they're waiting for something. She's terrified to find out what.

"I don't believe that."

Gods he - he really, actually believes that. It's *so obvious*, and he doesn't care. She blames her exhaustion for the way her brain short-circuits trying to comprehend it. It doesn't sink in. She accepts that it simply *won't* pretty quickly. Instead focusing her

attention and apparently limited mental capacity on wrangling her tongue back into moving.

"Yeah well, you Princess types are a bunch of bleeding hearts aren't you."

He's entirely unswayed by her bite, persistently present when a strained silence falls. She keeps her head perched on her knees, arms around them, trying and failing not to look at the eyes she feels on her like a bruise. (She reasons that at least she's managing to keep her growl suppressed in her chest.) The determination hasn't left him (she's pretty sure it's just a part of the Princess package at this point) but it morphs with the quiet - softens.

"Not saying I forgive you for everything you've done, but...I want to believe that you'll make good on what you said."

Her ear flicks. "And what was that?"

"That you'll try and make up for it."

She almost forgot that that was kind of part of the agreement. *Almost*. It's been a distinctly unforgettable (but still ignorable) little whisper in the back of her head, getting a little louder whenever she stares at the crystalline magic of her cell walls too long. She's thought about it, not much in the scheme of things, but only because the conclusion was so easy to come to. There's one glaringly clear course of action for her and she's already doing it.

"And you know what? I can do that by never leaving this room ever again."

'At least that way I can't hurt anyone else.'

She knows her ears drop, knows too much is written across her face. She's too tired to stop it, instead turning into the chair more so he can't see her. (Gods does she miss walls.) Bow seems to

deliberate what to say after that, she takes some minor satisfaction in shocking him.

Doesn't last long though.

"Adora was worried about you."

There it is. The full truth, or as close to it as she's going to get. He looks like he expects her to hiss or something similar, she doesn't blame him (it's what she did the one and only time he dared bring her up during their limited time together.) But she doesn't even want to now, she just curls inwards at the way her name makes it feel like he's picking at a hole in her chest.

Somehow she knows she's going to be playing those words on repeat for *at least* the next two weeks.

"She's on a mission to Salineas, did she tell you? I know she comes in here every couple of days, she acts like we don't know but..."

(She doesn't really know how to react to the information that Adora is hiding things, albeit badly, from her friends. Something like, *'She's ashamed of you,'* and *'Maybe she's breaking the rules by coming to see you,'* are the only conclusions she's able to come to in such a short time. The second of which is dismissed rather quickly given what little else she knows. Unfortunately that really only leaves her with the first option. Just another thing she'll be thinking about later.)

"She...might've mentioned it."

"I'm going away for a week, but I'll be back okay?"

She hates that she can remember her only thought being, *'I'll miss you.'* Because apparently this time spent alone and bored out of her mind has destroyed her ability to lie to herself.

Instead she'd said, *"You promise?"*

She'd meant it as a joke, slightly bitter but there was really nothing she could do about that. But Adora picked up on it, because of course *that* was when she decided not to be dense. She responded with unexpected intensity, just so typically *Adora* that it had her heart jumping in her chest.

"I promise."

Even thinking about it makes her feel better, like a salve on a wound. She wishes it didn't but...

Bow brings her out of her momentary revery, "She didn't ask me to come, but I could tell she didn't want you to feel lonely in here. And neither do I."

She...has absolutely nothing to say to that. It *should* be a lie. She can handle lies - hates them, has heard far too many - but she knows what to do, whether to bite her tongue or not. This though, maybe she needs to make a list of incomprehensible, violently Princess-y things she just might never understand. But not right now. She's too tired. Gods she thought talking to *Adora* was exhausting. (It is, just for different reasons.)

It's a strange turn of events that she willingly turns her thoughts back towards Adora. She reasons that it's because she doesn't know what to say in response to Bow and his...everything. But she knows Adora, even after all this time. At least that much has been evident in their short time together again.

(There's a lot of reasons why that is both a good *and* a bad thing, she's spent hours tugging on those strings already and now is decidedly not the time to work on the knot that still exists in her head.)

"Adora's too selfless for her own good." There's equal amounts joy and sorrow inside her when she says that, love and pain mixing in equal measure. "And I'm guessing you're the same."

He ignores her deflection which is...irritating. She can think about Adora now but actually voicing any of her own thoughts, or gods

forbid feelings, regarding her sounds near impossible. She really doesn't want to talk about -

"Adora just cares about things - that's not bad, Catra. And it doesn't make you weak like the Horde told you."

'Oh that's fucking rich.' She barely manages not laughing in his face at the sheer absurdity of that. But manage it she does.

"Caring about things is what got me in this mess in the first place," comes out instead.

She's struck then by a memory; a year or so earlier, rotting in that Fright Zone cell, Scorpia saying something so very similar, if not the exact same thing. (She stomps down the ache in her chest that still comes with thoughts of Scorpia.) It's painful knowing the rise and fall that follow it.

"Trust me Arrow, this isn't the first time I've had this particular conversation."

She would declare it a too revealing statement if he knew absolutely anything about her, but he doesn't, and it feels oddly safe to say. Maybe it's the barrier between them she keeps forgetting other people can actually pass through simply because no one has, not even Adora. (She doesn't blame her for that, she's not even sure how *she* would react to Adora crossing that boundary. Honestly, probably not well.)

It's quiet again for a good while. Half of her relaxes a little into it for some reason, the other half just becomes more on edge.

"Hey can you pass me one of those?"

She looks around warily because honestly there's nothing here for her to give him, unless she's missed something, which would be more annoying than anything else. It takes her probably too long to realise he's referring to the mountain of cushions she has - most of which are scattered and slightly shredded on the floor by

now. She reaches down and throws one through the barrier without a second thought.

She watches as he drops it onto the floor, his body following, all the while a smile on his face.

She knows she's glaring when she says, "What?"

"You didn't have to do that."

Huh. Guess she didn't but...she has. (And it's only then that she remembers that he can in fact just cross the walls that barr her freedom. The simple fact that he didn't is - well she wouldn't expect it from anyone else but Adora. Unless he's too scared to cross into a space where she could hurt him which is...fair, everything considered.)

"Now what?"

Bow's resulting shrug should infuriate her, she waits a moment for irritation to make an appearance but she remains cold; absent of pretty much everything. Guess that numbness hasn't left in its entirety after all.

"You really didn't come in here with a plan?" Actually that makes sense, she scoffs, "Y'know what I've seen you guys fight, don't know what I expected."

"We're good at fighting!"

"You keep telling yourself that."

It's not enough to get her to smile, but there's at least a twitch in her cheek that lets her know that she wants to. That in itself is surprising. So much of today has been surprising actually; the word seems weak.

She flops back into her carefully constructed pile of cushions and other bedding that she knows were just kind of thrown in here. (And yet it's still the softest thing she's ever felt because

Princesses or whatever.) It smells like her, more than her Force Captain's quarters ever did. It's strangely disappointing how her prison of nearly four weeks is more of a home to her than that room ever was. Not that she'll ever tell anyone that. Especially not the boy who's sitting quietly five feet away from her, messing with something on his trackerpad.

(Clearly Entrapta's design and oh doesn't that make her feel worse. She knows the Princess isn't dead, that Adora and Bow saved her - a conversation that happened early on that left her sinking deep into her own self-loathing. Just another one of her mistakes Adora had to fix.)

She listens to the little clicks and beeps, ears flicking towards them everytime. She didn't think she would miss noise, but anything even a little new is welcome at this point. The sounds, calmingly repetitive in nature, blur after she's not sure how long, and she manages to relax further into the ridiculous armchair.

It's not quite *comfortable* but considering the company and the circumstances and strained history, she thinks this might be the best they're able to obtain. She likes it. She hates that she likes it. But as she's found out, she's not as good at lying to herself as she once was.

It's so much easier to admit things to a white ceiling than anything else. She's learnt that in excruciating detail. She blames her solitary for the next thing that breaks the silence aside from the occasional beep or static hiss.

"I know it's kind of you guys' whole thing but...why are you being nice to me?"

She doesn't know what soft, vulnerable part of her makes her say it, but she knows when she finds it she'll be shoving it as far down as it'll go. (Forgetting entirely that that is exactly what she is meant to *stop* doing. Four weeks isn't going to change *that* much.)

She’s still not looking at him when, “Adora -”

“- Asked you to come here, didn’t ask you to be nice.”

‘Even she knows I don’t deserve it.’

“No. I *decided* to be nice to you. Because you’re a person and you deserve a second chance.”

There’s no lie in his eyes but it doesn’t matter, just because he thinks it's the truth doesn't mean that it is.

“I don’t.”

This long alone and trapped with her mistakes has proved that sentiment’s truth over and over again. She’s already had chances and she’d spat in the face of every single one. And sure, she knew why at the time, but now, without the rage there to justify? If she lets herself feel all the regret she wants to, she'll drown.

Bow’s mouth opens like he’s about to argue, which is honestly quite laughable, but she cuts him off, voice all too weak, “But thanks, for giving one to me anyway.”

He smiles almost as much as Scorpia. (It’s not a reassuring realisation.) “Thanks for taking it.”

“You don’t know that I have yet.”

“You just said ‘thanks’, can’t imagine the Catra we captured a over a year ago saying that.”

He’s got a point about that annoyingly. Stupid pride. Somehow she’s managed to keep it alive in her prison, but it’s quieter. That much is obvious from the fact that she’s even talking to the people that come and see her. (She didn’t exactly offer Scorpia that same courtesy.)

That twitch is back in her cheek when she mutters, “I would’ve rather thrown myself off a cliff than do that.”

“You *did* throw me off a cliff, but - I was gonna say ‘who hasn’t’ but you’re the only one actually.” And yet he’s smiling when he says it. Gods is he confusing.

She shrugs, “You kidnapped me. And I would say it was nothing personal but we’d both know that’s a lie.”

She’s not sure what he would’ve said in response if there wasn’t a horrendous (but familiar) set of beeps from the electronic pad, it has her ears flat against her head. Bow stands, throwing the cushion back through the barrier. She doesn’t have time to be shocked by that before -

“Sorry, I gotta go, Entrapta needs me in her lab - issue with reprogramming the bots. I’ll be back tomorrow okay?”

He’s smiling and waving one second, gone the next. She doesn’t have time to get anymore words out before she’s left alone again in her own mildly stunned silence.

Chapter End Notes

Bow is just the bestest boy and I stan ok?

I know it's canon that Bow is a good liar considering he lied to his dads about his whole life for years but shhhhh Catra's used to being lied to. (And yet she can't tell that Adora's not lying when she says she cares about her smh)
Also started bringing in the whole thing about Bow and Glimmer kinda unintentionally enabling Adora's selflessness because oo boy that's a whole thing.

Hopefully next one won't take too long cos it's *meant* to be short. (But I kinda have this habit of making thing way longer than planned so be prepared for that I guess.)

Here's To Getting Used To It

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

She's not sure when she started expecting Adora to come and eat breakfast with her, it's only been a month for fucks sake, but here she is, staring out at the slowly dimming stars in the growing moonrise and waiting for her just like she's done everyday for the past week.

It took her a while to realise just why this waiting leaves her stomach churning. She knows it's fear now (she hates that it's there, but she hates a lot of the things that live and crawl around inside her head so what's one more?) She's scared of Adora not coming; of feeling like she's left her all over again. Because it's happened, only once, but it happened. And it wasn't until the next morning that she could finally convince herself that Adora doesn't hate her entirely.

That hurts in it's own way she supposes. Because Adora should and she should be able to just accept that. (She more than deserves it.) But Adora doesn't, because she's just *like that* apparently. She always was better than everyone else, it's just one of things that hasn't changed about her. Maybe it was why she fell for her initially, but it certainly wasn't what kept the feeling going. Unless you can love someone for the very same reason they hurt you, which all things considered, wouldn't be unbelievable.

Of course there *are* changes. There's a new hardness in Adora's eyes she knows she mirrors - a war will do that to you. ('*One that you waged, one you kept going…*') Things that weighed her down before have been replaced with new burdens, ones Catra doesn't

know, ones she can't fix for a while by dragging her to somewhere high above the Fright Zone.

But Adora looks healthier, which she figures is probably due to the food if the effect on her own body is to be explained. The lights - so painfully different to the dull grey of the Fright Zone - means that her longer hair shines more, sometimes looking molten in the moonrises. She gets enraptured by it occasionally, transfixed by the steel in her eyes and the gold in her hair. Because she's pathetic and can't listen to her own head when it tells her to stop.

She thinks Adora's gotten taller as well, not that she has anything concrete to compare her to in this room. She's definitely filled out more - which she hates that she's noticed but… Her gangly teenage limbs have gone, meaning that she doesn't look so uncomfortable in her own body anymore. That at least is nice.

But enough is the same that she doesn't feel like she's talking to a stranger. The shades in her eyes, the shape of her smile those rare times she lets it show, the way she bounces her leg when she stays in the same place too long; Catra knows those things better than she knows herself. (Although considering all this time alone, that might change soon, which is a slightly horrifying sentiment.)

Her skin remains free of any lasting bruises and scars just like it always did - she realises she probably has She-Ra to thank for that. If Adora scarred every time she hurt her, well, she probably wouldn't be able to look at her without crying.

Of course this nostalgia she finds herself nursing daily isn't exactly comforting. She's *trying* to distance her own feelings. Not ignore, not deny, not smother; distance. She fully accepts that they're there, that as long as she lives Adora will have her heart. But she keeps them away, won't let them show. Nothing good will come of that. She'll lose Adora all over again, driven away by *Catra* instead of her own morals this time.

And as with fucking everything, it's hard, and painful and tiring. She wakes from terrors in her dreams shouting Adora's name and

can't calm until she manages to find something with her scent. It feels like she's failing herself. She hates that she still *needs* her after everything. Adora doesn't *need* her anymore (*'As if she ever did.'*) And that's fine, Adora's always had the power in their relationship anyway, always been the one making decisions; she's used to it. Despises it. But used to it.

Adora comes just as the fourth day-moon appears on the horizon, it's later than usual.

"Hey."

"Hey."

She still can't say her name, not when she's looking at her anyway, that night with the stars had been her first and only slip up. It's just another way to make herself hurt, and she's already got plenty of those. Not even the disappointment in Adora's eyes is enough to get her to do it. (Why Adora's disappointed, she's not sure, but she's seen the look enough times in her life to know exactly what it is.)

Adora crouches and slides the tray through without a word, and she responds by throwing her a cushion to sit on through the barrier, same as always. (Gods now there's an *'always'*, she really is fucked.)

"You're late you know," she says after Adora's sat down.

She thinks she succeeds in the nochulance, covering up that fear that's quickly dissipating from her chest with a casual bite of...she's not really sure what it is, but it's really fucking good.

Adora hums around the food in her mouth before swallowing and saying, "You miss me or something?"

"I was just hungry, don't let it go to your head."

She's not sure how, but her voice gives her away. *'Not because I like you,'* coming through, it's lying nature with it. She wonders if Adora knows just how false the statement always was - still is.

She pretends she's not addicted to the small smile Adora has balanced on her lips during these moments. It's easy enough to do - to ignore the spike in her pulse when she sees it, tamp it out like a flame deprived of air.

She takes another bite. "Bow came to talk to me, multiple times actually."

She hasn't brought it up before now, she's not sure why. Maybe she was trying to get used to the idea herself. But it's a pretty safe thing for them to talk about, and there's not exactly many of those.

She doesn't miss the way Adora's eyes flit to her and back down again. "He said. How, um, how was it?"

It takes her a few seconds to gauge why Adora seems nervous (the way she stops eating for the moment tells her as much.) There's a brightness in her eyes as she waits for her answer, somehow she knows that Adora is trying to stop herself shifting around. She really shouldn't find it this cute that Adora wants her to get along with her friend.

'Why would she want her friends to be around you? All you do is hurt people, you'll ruin them as well.' It makes her tail snap against the armchair.

"Surprisingly bearable."

She really does try not to stare at the way Adora momentarily chews on her lips before she says, "Would you...be okay with him coming to see you again?"

She tears her eyes back to the food in her lap, taking another bite before, "Not like I have anything better to do."

That was the wrong thing to say. Gods she can see the way Adora deflates a little, that energy that was starting to leak out of her suddenly gone. She wants it back. Because of course she does, she *cares* about things now (she always did, she's just letting herself admit it.) Honestly realising she wants Adora *happy* after everything was probably *the* most shocking moment of her life.

And she's been making an even bigger fool of herself ever since, retracting words far too often when she sees the damage they do. It's not apologising but it's the next best thing (and more than she's ever done before.)

She sighs at herself, audibly and long, "Alright, *maybe* I wouldn't mind talking to him again."

She almost regrets it just for the fact that she can't breathe when Adora looks at her like that. If there weren't a barrier between them she knows she'd be digging her claws into her thighs to stop herself from hugging her (or something worse) - she'd probably fail, only last minute turning it into a tackle to save herself.

She misses that - how easy it was to touch her before everything. And sure, there were things she's never - will never - be able to do, but whatever she got, she took gladly. She misses rough-housing with her, the way they'd both be laughing like maniacs the whole time. Now she has nothing but a wall and it's opalescent blue that disrupts her features.

'That's still more than you deserve.'

She ought to be more surprised that it sounds like Shadow Weaver, but the witch is always somewhere in her head. A little whisper that gets louder the more attention she feeds it. (She *really* needs to stop feeding it. But she knows that's a weak hope at best.)

She shakes herself out of whatever smokey haze she was in, rubbing at her eyes as they readjust to the still-increasing light.

"Hey, you okay?"

'Why do you care?'

"Just tired, can't sleep. Not used to -" she just kind of waves around her head, "Y'know, smells, sounds, even the light is just…"

'Why are you telling her this? It's not like it matters.'

Adora gets up then, leaving her food on the floor. She's never seen Adora leave food, ever. She stops herself reacting in any way other than a worried flick of her ear, following every movement Adora makes till she's at the wall. Catra's not sure what she does but one by one the lights fade until all they're left with is the illumination of daylight through the solitary window.

It takes her a second to realise that Adora's talking, all too mesmerized with that little bit of kindness, wholly unnecessary. Those feelings bubble up in her chest and she forces them away. She can't even get a *"Thanks,"* out past it.

Adora comes back and Catra manages to tune back into what she's saying, "...I get it. I'm still not really used to it, still don't sleep well without -" Adora's eyes widen and she freezes, a small flush appearing on her cheeks, distracting Catra from what she's saying entirely, "Without the, um, noise. 'S too quiet here…"

It's not a big thing for her to admit, not really. But it feels like it. It sounds like, *'I haven't forgotten where I came from,'* which is stupid, but she can't stop it from meaning that in her head. It's just another one of those little things that remind her that the Adora she knew - knows - is in there.

She's not sure how long it'll take, but eventually she'll consider this version of Adora her best friend again. She's already tripping over that line - it's not even a line at this point, more a blurry, muddy mess where her memories begin and end. The loving and the missing and the hating and the anger get more and more confused every day. Because yes, Adora hurt her - they hurt each other, she's always known that - but she's still the best thing in her life. Back then and now (even in the middle most of the time.)

No one's ever come close to replacing her, even if she wished it so. Gods she'd tried (not as hard as she should've) to see Scorpia like that; trust her and care about her the way Scorpia wanted her to. The way she had begged her own rage-ensnared heart to. Scorpia; loyal above all else, unending blind faith in those she loves. She thought that was what she wanted, of course she was fucking wrong about that.

Adora, Adora, Adora. Bloodstain on her heart.

Gods she's pathetic.

The glow is still present on Adora's cheeks, though it's fading. Catra's almost upset that her head is tilted down so she can't see it properly. It's then that she realises she is definitely staring and should probably (absolutely) should stop that. She counts; it takes her seven seconds to do so.

'Why is it so hard to stop looking at you?'

She can hear it in her teenage memories clear as a bell. She kind of wishes that *had* changed. She swallows before trying to actually respond to the last thing that was said. (The words of which are quickly slipping from her memory.)

"Well if *you* can't then there's really no hope for me is there?"

"You've always been better at adapting than me, you'll get the hang of it."

There's no way she can read the small frown on Adora's face. She's not sure if she wants to know why it's there. She just wants it gone.

Apparently she thinks picking up her glass of water and raising it in a mocking toast is the best way to do that. Adora flicks between her eyes but a smile tugs on her lips and that's all she needs to be able to say:

“Here’s to...getting used to it.”

And just like that Adora’s grinning like an idiot and the almost-gone fading red on her cheeks is just making her eyes bluer and just...fuck. Catra thinks she’s almost smiling as well, which again, fuck. Of course this is the first time she’s come close to a normal smile and it’s because of Adora, of fucking course. Really she shouldn’t have expected anything else.

Adora follows suit though, raising her little cylinder glass full of water, “To getting used to it.”

She can’t look at her when she brings the glass to her lips.

When the daytime moons fall that night it’s something akin to dark for Catra for the first time in a month. Her eyes don’t burn white behind her eyelids. She feels safer in the almost-darkness, like she can finally uncurl from the tight ball she’s made of herself every night.

It’s the easiest sleep she’s had in months (even before Brightmoon she was so terrorized by her own conscience that it wouldn’t let her go even for a night.) She doesn’t lie there for hours, tossing and turning, she drifts, able to hide behind the blackness of her own eyes. It’s not good sleep, but it’s better. She doesn’t dream at all.

She mumbles, “Thanks Adora,” into her blankets when she wakes, ignoring the way it makes the splinters of her heart tremble.

Chapter End Notes

> Yeah Catra's inner monologue is gonna show up more, there is a plot reason for this I promise, it's not just for the angst.
>
> Also Adora just wants to fall asleep with her again and it's very sweet. (They will snuggle eventually just wait.)

Glimmer

Chapter Notes

Context: It’s been a day or two since the last chapter. Bow has been to see Catra again. (He was very sweet about it because he knows Catra basically asked to see him again and he 100% did hearteyes and she spent the whole visit trying to keep her aloofness.)

You get to project! And you get to project! Everybody gets to project!
Yeah so Catra and Glimmer be narrative mirrors in season 4 and season 1 Catra was queen of projection and I’m using that to validate this chapter okay.

I feel like I should put a trigger warning since I would count this as a form of self-harm because guess what? Catra’s really hurting herself here just not physically. Also Catra's still suicidal but not actively if that makes sense.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

It’s only been an hour (she thinks) since Adora was here for their morning...whatever it is that they do. It was uneventful and easy, had her basking in a silence not consumed by her own head for once. She’s still floating in it, mind mercifully empty.

She’s relaxed, or at least she is until she hears magic, unsure of where she recognises it for all of one second before the Princess - Queen - of Brightmoon appears before her. She manages to keep herself still, not jumping away from her like her body demands due to sheer shock. Aside from that she can’t keep her reactions in check; tail lashing, claws out, fur bristling, hiss on her tongue. She kills most of it within a couple of seconds.

She waits for the Queen to say something, feeling increasingly exposed under her soundless gaze but determined not to snap. She's deluded herself into thinking she's better than that now. She counts silently to twenty-three before;

"What no comment?"

She almost sighs in relief that it wasn't her who said it.

"Is that what you want from me?" It's carefully blank.

There's a scoff, arms crossing over her chest, "I don't want anything from you."

Oh she's heard that *many* times throughout her life. This seems to be the first time it's a lie.

"Oh Sparkles, you wouldn't be here if that were true."

"Wanna put that to the test Horde Scum? I can leave right now, and you're not really in a position to turn down visitors."

She doesn't have the energy to spare on her obvious snark. "You wanna leave? Then leave. I'm not going to stop you."

'Not like I've ever been able to stop people leaving before.'

She can see Glimmer turning over the idea to go in her head, clear as day. She's looking at the floor, hands on her hips when Catra asks, "Does Adora know?"

The name doesn't make her feel like she's chewing on glass anymore - she's not sure how she feels about that.

"That I'm here?" She nods, not bothering to look the Glimmer in the eye. "No. My Dad does, but he's the only one. I'm just - I messed up with her and Bow a while back, maybe I figured you'd understand."

‘Messed up’ didn’t even begin to cover the things she’s done. She hums some sort of agreement, she doesn’t care if the Queen hears it or not. It takes a while (she thinks minutes but this time she’s not counting) but Glimmer sits on the ground in her peripherals, the same cushion her other visitors take - all two, now three, of them.

It’s silent for a painfully long time. It’s not comfortable like it was this morning with Adora, not even that almost-relaxed setting she’s managed to obtain with Bow now. It’s tense in a way that has her body just wanting to *move*, but her own wariness prevents it. She hates that her body is preparing for a fight but the unexpectedness of her arrival means that there’s adrenaline buzzing in her veins for the first time in a month and it doesn’t seem to want to shut off. (She’s missed how awake she feels.)

As the pressing quiet extends, a growl rises deep in her throat, slipping through her teeth for a second before she reigns it in. Glimmer looks up sharply and she almost panics - she didn’t mean to do that. Instead she covers it with;

“Gods Sparkles, are you going to just sit there or are you gonna talk?”

She doesn’t miss the way Glimmer’s hands ball into fists in her lap. “Are you going to listen?”

She shrugs, “Don’t exactly have a choice.”

It takes a long time, not that she was exactly expecting anything else. There’s an annoyed sigh then, “I set off the Heart.”

‘Yeah I know Sparkles, I was kinda there.’

“Hmm.” Not as confrontational as she could be.

“You know it was meant to destroy the planet?"

She...didn’t actually know that.

“No.”

"There wasn’t really a chance that it *wouldn’t* but I - I did it anyway.”

So that’s why she’s here, well that makes a little sense she supposes.

“If Adora hadn’t broken the sword, we would probably all be dead now.”

Maybe it’s the name but, “So what? You here to have a heart-to-heart with the *other* person who almost destroyed the world? Yeah sure, let’s just bond over the biggest mistakes we’ve ever made, that’ll be fun.”

Sometimes she forgets that non-hybrids don’t growl because she’s waiting for it with the way Glimmer looks at her.

“Gods you’re the worst.”

“It’s been said.”

So many times. (Usually by herself.)

“Fine. I just, I guess I wanted to know how to forgive yourself after something like that.”

She almost laughs. The Princesses are even bigger fools than she assumed if they think she’s *forgiven herself*. How can she? It’s not even a possibility at this point. She just curls in tighter, just like those first few (many) times Adora came to see her.

“I can’t help you with that.”

There’s another sigh, one loud enough to make her ear flick. “This was a mistake, should’ve known better than to think you’d help.”

Glimmer gets up, staring a moment before stepping away. It's only the shower of glitter from her hands that reminds Catra that that is abnormal, that if she's not teleporting then there's a reason. It's almost funny how easy she is to read. It's almost painful how much of herself she can see in her. Can see the way she needs someone to push back - she probably doesn't get a lot of that here.

At least that she *can* help with. It's a strange half-kindness, to pick at wounds till they bleed. It's an outlet; a way to feel when you're surrounded by your own walls. One she knows all too well, and one she can offer. Maybe the only thing she can offer.

She uncurls slightly, voice lilting in the way that always made the other cadets turn and *threaten*, "Thought you Princesses were better than that, you all spew that 'feel your feelings' crap and then run away from me when I'm powerless and trapped? You have nothing to lose here, and you're still a coward."

It works as intended, Glimmer turns sharply, as close to the barrier as she dares. There's still magic seeping out of her fingers and a flare in her eyes that Catra knows; the kind that's wordlessly begging for a fight. And she's all too happy to give it to her.

"I'm not a coward, and I'm not *running away.* Not like you, you ran away from the only good thing in your life to chase a fucking power trip!"

'How much did Adora tell them?'

It doesn't matter, because as much as it stings, makes the blood of her own rage well in her wounds, there's too much in her voice for it to just be about her. There's that edge of self-loathing, something unnamable in her eyes, something that demands to be met. And Catra's kidding herself if she thinks she's going to back down now.

She stands, walks swiftly to the barrier (only dimly realising this is the closest she's been to anyone in a month.) Tail lashing again matched with a venomous grin, she can't help it, whatever it is Glimmer's feeding, she feels it to. Black and aching and familiar in her chest. There's more magic, it spills onto the floor as Glimmer glares down at her claws where they twitch at her sides.

"What, like you did?"

Glimmer doesn't know how to hide the emotion in her eyes evidently.

"You don't know anything about me Horde Scum, you're weak, you've lost everything, and it's your own fucking fault!"

She growls, "*There we go*. Get angry, shout at me, I fucking deserve it!"

"I don't -"

Even when she's offering a vein and a blade to them, they're still *too nice*.

"- I can take it."

There's a moment's hesitation. Magic sputtering out in Glimmer's hands before it's thrown at the floor in a blast. She doesn't even flinch.

"You ruined everything! The only reason the war went on as long as it did was because of you. People are dead, homes and lives are gone, destroyed because of you and your plans and your weapons and your fucking pride! And look where it got you, a cell in *my* castle, with nothing left because you already *fucking took it all*."

Her head screams like a brewing storm. She needs to hear this. Hear how terrible, unforgivable, destructive and hopeless she is. Adora lies, Bow's too kind - she doesn't believe a lot of the things they say. Glimmer though? She can believe this. This rage and

hurt and blame that washes over her like acid, feels right as it tears her apart.

"My mother's not here because of you! My dad's been gone my whole life, he fought everyday just to survive long enough to get home and when he finally returns he's lost her. I have a whole kingdom to run - an alliance to lead - and a planet to start healing and I have no fucking idea what I'm doing! My friends don't trust me anymore, I let myself get consumed by my own fucking need for power, my own need to prove myself and it's all your fault!"

And just as she sees herself, she sees a red mask and shadows, because she's heard so much of this before.

'You're worthless.'

'It's your fault.'

'You've wasted everything you've ever been given.'

'If it weren't for Adora…'

'You're lucky to be alive.'

She closes her hands over her own ears to try and block out her voice but, as always, it doesn't work. She doesn't even know if Glimmer's still speaking, couldn't pick apart the things in her head if she tried. It takes ahold of her tongue before she stop it.

"I know, okay! I fucking know! I've been trapped in here with everything I've ever done wrong for a fucking month. There's so much I can't even fucking sleep! You think I don't hate myself? You think I don't wish Adora had killed me when she was meant to?"

Whatever Glimmer had bubbling under the surface dies, magic stuttering out. The burn in her eyes stays though, she knows it's not from the lights, or even the magic so close to her. Her breath is raw in her throat, she doesn't want the air in her lungs. She doesn't want Glimmer looking at her like that.

“Wait you still feel like that?”

There’s shock, there’s concern, there’s softness. *She doesn’t understand*. She turns, only because she can’t fucking run. They’ve taken that from her.

‘They didn’t take anything - but you did. You did this to yourself. This is a paradise compared to what you deserve.’

There’s rage throbbing in her chest, a reaction to the hurt; a defense. But she can’t get a grip on it. It’s that numbness again, she doesn’t know whether she’s missed it or if that heavy iron weight taking hold of her is dread.

She swallows round the panic coating the back of her throat. “I’ll tell you what I told Bow; Adora’s too selfless for her own good.”

‘She doesn’t want to be here with me. She just feels like she has to.’

“If I knew the guilt wouldn’t destroy her, I would’ve made her do it.”

‘Thought you wanted to destroy her?’ She wants for Glimmer to say it. She doesn’t.

She’s not sure why she’s telling her this; maybe it’s just because she’ll listen. Maybe it’s because Glimmer saw her, blood-soaked and beaten but alive enough to still put up a fight and she just didn’t. Maybe it’s because she sees herself in a Princess - in a friend Adora left her for - and it’s simultaneously a comfort and a horror.

But it’s too late to retract what she’s said. Too late for her to pretend that she doesn’t hate herself, to pretend what she’s said is at all a lie.

She doesn’t know where to go from here (if there even is anywhere *to* go) and neither does Glimmer. She doesn't need to be looking at her to know that.

Her legs start shaking - she's not ready to find out exactly why yet - and she lets it be the excuse for why she drops down to the floor on top of three or so pillows. She lies down fully, still safe from mauve eyes and the emotions she doesn't understand that live within them. At least like this she doesn't feel so much like a coward - she's not hiding completely this way - the blankness of the towering ceiling once more providing a haven.

Glimmer doesn't join her back on the floor, there's discomfort rolling off her in waves, Catra can practically smell it. She's honestly surprised she hasn't just teleported away yet. She would if she were able. But then, for all the similarities she can see on the surface, there's one stark difference; Glimmer is good. And she's...not.

She stays like that until her breathing levels out again, ignoring everything swirling in her head, forcing a blanket down on all that she's feeling. It's remarkably easy to employ the old technique, but there's cracks, fissures her self-destruction will exploit as soon as she's alone.

She's still staring at the ceiling, flat on her back when she says, "Feel better?"

Glimmer's shocked by that - what part of it, she's not sure. But she can hear in the way the Queen exclaims, "What?" that it's at least somewhat genuine.

She traces cracks in the ceiling with her eyes.

"You're easy to read you know. You needed that, I could tell."

'I think we both did.'

"I...How?"

There's shame laced in within the few words, a small admittance feeling all the more larger because she wasn't expecting it in the slightest. She doesn't grace her with an answer. She won't want it anyway. Who would want to be told they remind her of herself?

There’s a frustrated huff tinged with exhaustion rather than anger though. She takes that to be a good sign - maybe she was able to help someone after all. Maybe she can be some caricature of selfless if she tries. It makes her think of Adora. It makes her want her here, proud of her for trying. She can still dream at least it seems.

“Should I say thank you?”

There’s uncertainty there, and something genuine. *Too nice.*

“No.”

“Should I leave?”

“That’s probably for the best Sparkles.”

She’s cracked enough to admit there’s no venom in the name at all. For anyone else but them it would almost be soft, kind even. Friends with a Princess - the notion doesn’t sound as impossible and repulsive as it once did. She doesn’t know who she blames for that yet, but she’ll find out.

Her ears flick towards the swallow she hears.

“For what it’s worth, sleep well Catra.”

It’s not until the tell-tale shimmer of magic as Glimmer leaves that she realises how significant that is. It has her huffing a disbelieving laugh to the empty room she's been returned to, idly wondering if she’ll ever see the Queen again. Wholly unsure what she wants the answer to be.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter has been haunting me throughout all the planning but when it came down to writing it, it was actually fine. Now for the actually hard part; the aftermath. I mean the next chapter, all the planning I had for it was one line and now it's two chapters.

Aftermath: Part I

Chapter Notes

> Oh look at that another big chapter that started as a single bullet point and then I had to split it oops. (This is the short part)
>
> Self improvement is not linear people okay!
> (In the memory Catra's about 15/16 years old and she already knows she's in love, there's a link to my fic that shows Catra's whole 'falling in love' journey in the end notes)
>
> TW: Catra has a panic attack, past self-harm (no actual description of it happening), thinking about self-harm, one line of dehumanizing language

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Her conversation with Glimmer won't leave her head.

Instead of dissipating like it should, the feelings grow; she doesn't know what is feeding it, but it's black and full of smoke and shadow. It doesn't take her all that long to realise it's the memory of Shadow Weaver. Her hate and the way she made her feel; worthless, never good enough, a pet on a leash she loved to throw around for fun. It makes her want to scream.

It's only been a couple of hours, she just needs to wait out the storm but for now...she's trapped in it.

'Why did I do that?'

'Why did I help her?'

'Why did I hurt myself to make her feel better?'

'Why did it make me *feel better?'*

'Why? Why? Why?'

There's so much *noise*. She can't suck air in quickly enough. Her eyes burn; whether through the tears she knows are falling or the lights overhead. It makes her hiss and she can taste the metal in her mouth where her fangs cut something.

She needs to break, to tear, to destroy. She wants to scream her throat raw and bury her claws in whatever will give. But she can't. She knows she can't. It always got her in more trouble than it was worth.

"If you're going to act like a rabid animal then you'll be put down like one."

The only thing she's allowed to destroy anymore is herself. Funny how that's always been the case - she just never listened before. She almost does it, her claws beg her to. But it remains as just that; an almost.

Because despite the panic-ridden fog and venomous words and remembered black magic making her limbs shake, there's *her*. The heartbroken fear on Adora's face when she saw her bleeding the only time she turned her claws on herself rather than the world around her. She can't see it again. Can't hear the shake, equal parts fear and fury, in her voice when she asked what happened.

"Who did this? Catra who hurt you?"

And gods the horror when she told her.

"I did."

"Catra I don't understand. Why -"

"Can you get me some bandages from med? You know they won't give them to me."

The witch made sure of that. She always just knew.

"Yeah, yeah of course I'll…"

Adora was so *scared* to leave. Fuck, she was almost crying by the time she got back. Her hands shook the whole time as she wrapped the bandages, hands infuriatingly gentle and eyes so heartbreakingly intense. If she wasn't in love with her before, the way Adora cradled her hands afterwards would've made her fall. Claws stained with her own blood, and Adora had brought them up to her face, rested her forehead on them. She wanted to cry, Catra knows that. From the water in her voice and the broken hitching in her breathing.

But even then, Adora had to be strong for everyone. Not even she was the exception to that. No matter how much she wished it so.

"Catra please*, never - never do this again. You can't - I can't - I don't know how to protect you from this."*

The memory makes her sob, hunched over and claws digging grooves into the floor. She just can't do it again, she didn't even make a promise but that pure and utter pain may as well have done. It just hurts. Memories, words, thoughts, questions; there's *so much* and she -

Her claws slice through her hair. Enough tension in the still-burnt strands to ease the wanting. She doesn't stop. Over and over again. This pent up energy is allowed to dispel a little more with every hack. There's no blood, no pain, no metal torn apart, but there's a release and a distraction.

There's no one hurt by this. Just a weight shed from her head and shoulders.

It's not neat, it's not even, smooth or anything even close. Once the airless fog lifts from her head, she takes off her mask, throws it through the spell walls so she can get at the rest of it. She's able to feel out the lingering fire damage and watch as it falls to

the floor. When she’s done, the hair that gets stuck to her fur itches but she pays it no attention.

She’s not sure why her last act is to tear off the black sleeve still covering her arm. She does it anyway, slices along the seam and peels it off. She hasn’t seen these scars in a long time, the small scattering of them born from a lifetime as a fighter not so dissimilar to the stars outside her window. It’s balanced again - *she’s* balanced again.

Wiping the water from her face, she rises to her feet, it doesn’t remove the dark stain of their tracks in her fur. It doesn’t matter; no one’s here to see. She kicks the fabric and brushes the hair through the walls. Her limbs are shaking once more, it aches when she takes another step, arms protesting as she tugs on the chair, turning it around.

She sinks back into it, bundling into blankets that have long since lost Adora’s scent, and watches the moons in the sky, revelling silently in the breeze that washes over her fur. She almost shivers from the alien feeling of wind on the back of her neck. But it’s okay. She’ll get used to it. She’ll have to.

She doesn't hear Shadow Weaver right now. Doesn't hear a young, worried Adora. Not even Glimmer. Just quiet echoing originating from various places around the castle that she can't pinpoint, almost like a lullaby. Not that she's ever heard one before.

It’s sad for her to think that this might be the most carefree she’s ever been. Her mind is blissfully blank of anything as she gazes at the world beyond her prison, blue and purple and white on the horizon. She doesn’t know the world outside anymore, she finds she doesn’t really miss it. For what is there to miss? Adora is here, Scorpia, Entrapta, even Bow now are the only things that might draw her out.

Past kingdom walls lives Shadow Weaver, whatever decaying remains of the Horde are left, a world she vowed to break. Here

she’s safe. Here she can grow without other people cutting her down again. She wonders how it took her this long to realise.

Chapter End Notes

Watch me jump on the Shadow Weaver hates Catra’s animal traits train.

Adora POV back next chapter lads.

(Here's a link to my pre-canon fic because I apply it to all my canon-verse stories and it might provide some context: Gorgeous)

Aftermath: Part II

Chapter Summary

Adora sees the aftermath.

Chapter Notes

I basically re-wrote half of this just as I was about to upload it because I just...didn't like it anymore. So this is coming out later than planned.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

"Adora?"

She startles when a voice and shower of glitter erupts behind her, effectively snapping her from the silence she was stewing in.

(Supply routes to Salineas are even more difficult than she first thought, what with it's only access being by treacherous sea. The Horde's resources are proving useful but there's a delay on that as well, since all the insignias need to be removed to avoid hysterical civilians. Needless to say she forgot about that the first time they tried to use them.)

She takes a breath, "Hi Glimmer."

"Can we talk?"

Glimmer looks nervous, hands holding each other. There's no magic spilling from them though - her most obvious sign of severe distress - which is really the only reason she doesn't panic.

"Why, uh, I mean sure, what's wrong?"

She steps away from the table, encouraging Glimmer closer. She seems grateful of it.

"Adora I - I talked to Catra."

'Oh.'

She doesn't know what she was expecting but it wasn't *that*. She's not sure who she's more worried for, but it's definitely worry that she's feeling. Catra is...Catra but Glimmer is...well she's Glimmer and as much as neither of them will want to know it, they're pretty similar. She always thought that if they ever met without the promise of a fight it would be like adding tinder to a fire. Or flame to gasoline.

"What happened?"

"She...helped me with something. But I hurt her in the process. She asked me to and I - I don't know, the things she said kind of...scared me I guess. I just think you should go see her."

Her inner monologue kind of gets stuck on *'Okay, okay, okay,'* for a while.

Catra *helped* Glimmer. First thing, one that doesn't make sense. The Catra she knows would rather rip off her own tail than willingly help a Princess. (It doesn't count with her - she's not a Princess anymore. Plus, Catra doesn't know that she's helping just by being here.)

But...Catra's changed, and pretty drastically at that, from the woman she used to know. That much is obvious. She's even changed from the woman she saw on that throne, and the one she'd seen the day following.

Isolation must be getting to her. She ought to go see her more.

Second thing: Glimmer had hurt Catra. Not all that surprising, again tinder and flame, but Catra had *asked her to*. Why would Catra *ask*? For as long as she's known, Catra's run from or fought

against everything that's ever tried to hurt her (and there have been a *lot* of things.) Except...except she's forgotten something; the thin set of slashes on her arms, hidden under fur.

It's been *years* since she's thought about that day and the new type of fear it had brought. She's tried every moment of her life to save the people she loves from...well from everything. But back then it was just Catra. And she hadn't been prepared, hadn't known in any capacity how to save her from herself.

'That hasn't changed.'

It really hasn't. She thought, hoped, Catra was getting better. Away from the Horde, away from Shadow Weaver. And she is, she has to be. She's *seen* the changes, all of them good.

'What would you know about how she's doing, it's not like she would tell you. She doesn't trust you.'

She needs to move onto the next thing before the possibility that she was wrong breaks her heart. Or sends her spiralling, whichever comes first.

Third, possibly fourth, thing; Glimmer being scared *for* Catra. Which isn't nearly as surprising as it was initially, if only due to the memories of the day before the siege on the Fright Zone. The concern and worry for someone she's meant to hate, the anxious way Glimmer spoke when she told her; it's the same.

Maybe Glimmer knows how she feels about Catra. And as much as she doesn't want people knowing, people worrying about her, it would make sense. Or maybe she's just a good person who doesn't want to see other people in pain. Either way it's eerily similar to that day. It sends that latent panic skyrocketing.

She swallows around the growing heartbeat in her throat, "How bad was it?"

"She - It was bad Adora. It was *really* bad. But then she came down I guess, I don't know, she seemed...bitter? Kind of distant,

sad. I'm just worried what she might do I guess. She wasn't...what I expected."

'She never is.'

She wants to ask if she was angry but if Glimmer hadn't mentioned it then it probably wasn't there at all. And if Catra's not angry then...

"If she's hurting she won't want anyone around, I'll - I'll go talk to her later okay?" She's not sure who she's trying to reassure at this point. "She always needs space after something like that."

There's not sure how to read the look on Glimmer's face; something like realistion, something like *'this has happened before?'* But she knows Catra won't want her to say anything else (she's probably already said too much.)

"If you're sure…"

"I'm sure. Thanks for telling me."

She's out the room before Glimmer has another chance to respond.

She focuses on breathing - something Perfuma's been showing her after she stumbled upon her and Scorpia meditating in the gardens - as she walks directly back to her room. She doesn't even look at the guards, or the other Princesses she passes in the hallways.

She counts in. Hold. She counts out. Hold.

The door sounds so much louder than usual when it clicks shut.

The breathing brings her heart rate down and she's grateful (she'll have to tell Perfuma later.) She sits on her bed and closes her

eyes, tries to focus on counting. *Tries.* The forced blankness in her head keeps getting cut away by the blade of her memories.

Images of Catra's scars, fresh and bloody, flash behind her eyes. She hears every time she's ever asked Catra who hurt her in her head like a siren. Because whenever Catra grew dark, spat *"Who do you think?"* at her, could've been a lie. She'd always thought it had meant Shadow Weaver, hadn't pushed it further because of it.

'You should've known.'

She sees Catra in that stimulated Fright Zone. Sees her grow from that scared child into a woman shaped by a type of pain Adora's never known, wounds from time long past fresh in her eyes.

"You never protected me."

It makes her breath shudder in her lungs.

She doesn't let herself cry. Seems to forget that she even can. Maybe it's because of the memory of Shadow Weaver;

"You have to be better than that Adora."

She lost track of how many times she's heard that a long time ago. It's too deeply ingrained for her to unlearn it now so...she'll be better. For her friends, and more importantly, right now for Catra. Just an hour and she'll go.

She doesn't know what she's going to do - what she's going to be *able* to do. Catra hasn't wanted her past the barrier in all the time she's been here, there's no reason for that to have changed now. She can't take her somewhere high up to clear her head, can't let her win at a training exercise to make her feel better (she only did that a few times though, she was a fool for thinking she could get anything by Shadow Weaver.)

If Catra *has* hurt herself then she probably won't even let her bandage the wounds. Being allowed to do that last time was the only thing that kept her from outright sobbing from fear and

failure. She - She doesn't even know what she's going to do now. She might very well just...break.

But there's a good chance Catra *hasn't* done anything. Given what Glimmer said she won't be *fine* but she may at least be safe and *whole*. She clings to the flicking newfound hope like a lifeline.

Catra *might* be fine, but she will definitely *be here*. She'll always be able to find her here, she can't go missing without a word, leaving her to tread the waters of the Horde by herself.

It might be that fact that keeps her in her room, away from Catra and the series of terrifying unknowns that now surround her. She's practically paralyzed with it. Alone with her memories and worries, all they seem to do is magnify the more time that passes.

In actuality she waits till Catra's due her midday meal before she goes. (She knows the schedule off by heart anyway and figures having an excuse ready might be good.) She spent so long in her room using her own fear to keep her there that it almost makes her hands shake as she carries the tray to Catra's cell.

She can't tell if the guards are surprised to see her or not, what with their helmets. Them being here just makes it worse. She knows she has every right to do this, to check on her...friend when she's worried (terrified) about her. But she feels judged anyway. She's biting down on the inside of her cheek when she knocks on the door.

She waits for a minute with no answer before the fear and worry takes a hold strong enough for her to turn the handle. (Still valiantly ignoring the guards on either side of her.) It's still dark in the room when she enters, lights not having been turned back on.

"Catra?"

Gods it feels like the day she found Catra on that - her - throne. She felt this particular kind of fear then too. She's not ready to unpick that, and she's not sure she ever will be.

There’s no answer again. She takes in the state of the room; the hair, fur and black fabric littering the floor. (She’s proud of herself for not dropping the food in her unsteady hands. She’s not proud of the shaky breath that rushes out of her when she doesn’t see blood on the floor.)

Catra’s turned the chair around, she’s not sure what that means. (It means she can’t see her and it has her heart rate pounding in her ears again.)

She’s careful when she comes closer, footsteps loud enough not to startle - the last thing she wants right now is for Catra to panic. She follows the lining of the spell round, leaving the food on the floor after she slides it through.

Catra’s asleep when she comes to the other side of the barrier, body hidden by the blankets - Adora’s blankets - wrapped around her. Her heart melts a little at the sight, and suddenly it’s not that day in the throne room, it’s the one following. Catra curled up and asleep near her again, only this time there’s actually some semblance of peace on her face. (What of it she can see anyway.)

But the fear hasn’t abated. It flares when Catra screws her eyes against consciousness and she can’t help but wonder what happened to make her sleep that deeply. (She always did bolt awake at any sign of movement.) Adora’s not sure what woke her but it doesn’t really matter. There’s a rustle of fabric before electric eyes appear.

It seems they’re both speechless as Catra studies her (at least she is, Catra never was one for talking right after she woke up.) She thinks there’s confusion but it fizzles away in a few moments, Catra sighing and looking away.

“Catra, please, say something?”

She doesn’t mean for it to be a broken whisper, but it is.

There’s pause, then only an indication that Catra wants to be smiling - a twitch in her lip she could recognise anywhere.

"Hey Adora."

'Oh.'

Her whole chest *aches*, sharp like she's been run through. Catra hasn't said her name since that night with the stars. And her voice is so *soft*; none of their past poisoning it. If she really wanted she could pretend Catra's just jumped down from her bunk, glowing eyes finding hers in the dark.

Catra looks...she can't even describe it. It's not happy, it's not even resigned like she's come to expect, it's...calm, maybe? There's equal amounts exhaustion and gentleness; openness in those split eyes. Eyes that, for once, don't feel like they're ripping her feelings right out of her chest. Rather luring them with quiet, childish whispers.

She comes to the crashing realisation that Catra's not wearing her mask, she wants to look for it but she *can't look away*. She never *wants* to look away from Catra and the markings on her face that look like inkstains, but it's impossible in this moment.

Catra unfurls more, blankets falling around her hips, eyes never straying even as hers do; Catra's sleeve is gone and so is her *hair*. It's messy and clearly been hacked away at with her claws, the shortest parts of it coming midway down her face. She's never wondered what Catra might look like with short hair, free of her wild mane, she's never really wanted to - her hair just as much a part of her as her claws or stripes. But maybe she should've because she...words won't come. She'd describe herself as speechless again if it weren't for her thoughts also being swallowed by silence.

She's beautiful. She'll never tell her that.

Catra realises where she's looking and breaks her stare, eyes down as she runs her hand through the shorn mane.

"Don't have to look so surprised y'know." It gets Adora to close her own mouth at least. "How bad is it?"

“It’s- It’s not bad, I like it.”

Understatement, but what else is she going to say?

Catra’s ears lower and she looks down like she’s embarrassed. And her brain just shouts *‘cute’* at her so loudly she doesn’t even bother to wonder why.

“Did I sleep the whole day?”

It takes her a minute to catch up, “No, I brought lunch.”

Catra looks back at her again, doing that thing with her eyes where it feels like she’s picking her apart. She’s always been good at finding an opponent’s weakness and exploiting it. A lot of the time she needed to be, Adora’s just not sure why she’s using it now.

Catra sighs when her gaze lets up and Adora can feel it leave like a hand letting her face drop. It’s mildly disorientating. Catra brings one of her knees up, the other falling to the floor.

“Sparkles huh?”

Catra really needs to stop doing *things* right now, she can’t keep up. Sparkles is Glimmer, Catra’s asking about Glimmer because...because she’s wondering why she’s here. Okay that makes sense.

“She was worried about you, and...and so was I.”

There’s a shadow that falls on Catra’s face, a grimace that appears on her lips but she doesn’t say anything else. Adora can see the agitated wave of her tail under the blankets and as the silence stretches, the fear comes back. Slow at first, dripping like a faucet while she just waits; she doesn’t know what else to do. But it builds until there’s a question sitting desperately on her tongue.

She manages to stutter out, “Do you - Do you need bandages?”

There’s a flicker of something else in Catra’s eyes, “No.”

She looks down at Catra's wrists anyway - bloodless. And yet she’s still not eased. Maybe it’s the guilt doing it. She knows she looks like a mess, knows there’s stands of her ponytail flying around her face. And she figures that’s why Catra softens.

“You don’t have to worry okay? I only did that once.”

The fear - terror - won’t let her believe that.

“Really?”

Catra’s leg drops to the ground and she leans forward on her hands, blue-gold eyes capturing hers far too easily.

“Adora, *I promise* I didn’t hurt myself okay?”

She sighs, “Okay. Okay, I believe you.”

Even now they don’t make promises lightly. The worry doesn’t leave, it never really does, but it fades into white noise. She sees that almost smile again. She knows she’s giving a proper one back.

“I know whatever happened was bad but, you’re okay though now right?”

Just because she needs to know about as much as she needs air.

She can see Catra sigh rather than hear it. “Yeah. I think so. Not great but…”

She looks...fragile, ears still down as she stares at something out the window and resolutely not at her. Whenever she saw this before she’d hug her, or touch her shoulder, or just brush along her hand. They both knew what it really meant; *‘I’m here for you.’* It was about as much as the Horde allowed, but it was *comfort* and she can’t even do that anymore. She can’t imagine anything she might say would help; Catra’s always had an issue with words.

It was only in the Rebellion, after figuring out the sheer amount of *lies* she's heard (and believed) over the course of her short life exactly why Catra's always felt like that.

But action? That's something Catra's always known. What both of them relied on - still rely on.

It's a risk but she asks, gesturing at the wall that separates them, "Can I…?"

One of her ears pricks forward. "Adora, really, I'm okay. You don't have to do this."

She's really not prepared for Catra to be saying her name again because she's stunned back into silence.

No, she doesn't *have* to do this. But she wants to, she wants to be there for her again. Wants to make up for all the times she *wasn't*. Honestly she just wants to be *close* to her again. She doesn't feel like she has a right to miss her when she's right here, but she *does*. She misses her with every fibre of her being. Is it really so bad that she just wants Catra to let her in?

Catra's looking at the floor again when she exhales, shaking her head slightly before she pushes up. Adora's transfixed by her, the way she moves, when she comes closer. Close enough that without the rippling texture of the barrier she might be able to count the streaks in her eyes. She flicks between them, trying to do just that and finding herself unable.

And maybe it's the gentle way Catra's looking at her, or just how easy it would be, but she mindlessly lifts a hand up to reach through the barrier and touch her. Touch what, she's not sure. Maybe her hand, maybe her shoulder, maybe even her hair. It doesn't matter though, because Catra flinches away from it.

Her hand feels like lead when it drops back to her side.

"Adora," she's scared Catra can hear her heartbeat with the proximity, even with the barrier, "Thanks, for checking on me. I

know you probably didn't - you didn't have to do that."

She...wasn't expecting that. It's probably the reason *'of course I did'* or *'you don't have to thank me'* or something even more telling doesn't come spilling out. Catra won't want to hear it anyway.

Gods she wants to touch her so badly; hug her, hold her, breathe her in, feel the heat of her when she's alive and fighting again. But Catra doesn't want that, doesn't want *her* to want that. Not anymore. But...Catra makes her selfish. And wishes don't just die.

Knowing she's not allowed never stopped her before. She has every day of her life to attest to that fact. Maybe she's addicted to the brand of pain Catra provides. Or maybe she's just in love. Either way, no matter what she does, she will always have this pulsing undercurrent in her veins whispering for her to press kisses into Catra's hair, to tell her that she means everything to her, to apologise for everything she's ever done to hurt her.

"You can go you know."

She blinks a couple times, the sharp drag from her own head disorientating. The crash back to reality (one where Catra is scared of her touch) is a painful one.

"Oh, um, right. Yeah I should…"

She looks towards the door out the corner of her eye. There are things to do (Salineas supply routes won't just draw themselves) but she...well she doesn't *want* to do any of them. She wants to be here. With Catra. And the kind (if a little uncomfortable and tired) way she's looking at her.

It's not even so much hesitance, rather than full on procrastinating the inevitable fuelled by selfish desires. She must be pouting or something similar because Catra laughs, a small, barely there thing that has her heart lurching. Catra's holding her elbows, she looks small, it's strange even after all this time. (Catra

knows how to make herself look big and threatening and it fucking *works*.)

"Go, dummy, I'll be fine."

Okay if Catra starts bringing their old nicknames into this she's really not going to survive. She ought to leave before her heart takes ahold of her limbs and makes her do something she'll regret.

"I'll see you tomorrow?"

She doesn't mean for it to be a question.

"Don't be late."

'As if I could.'

It would be a threat if Catra weren't smiling lightly. She returns it and walks away, ignoring *everything* telling her to turn back.

She gets all of six steps before something red distracts her; Catra's mask on the white Brightmoon floor. She doesn't know whether or not Catra's watching as she goes over and picks it up. It feels lighter than she expected as she runs her fingers over its dented surface. Gods there's so many memories attached to this thing. Catra probably spent just as long wearing it while she was her best friend as she did as her enemy. She remembers the day she got given it (or stole it, she's never really been sure.)

Catra is in fact watching her when she looks up, arms crossed properly as she raises an eyebrow. She's not angry, the gentle sway of her tail tells her that much, but she is questioning. She forces her hand to still.

"Hey, do you want this back?"

Catra hesitates then shakes her head, "No."

She nods, unsure of what else to do. With one last wave she leaves the room entirely, walking past the silent guards, hand holding the mask of the Horde's second-in-command like it's precious.

She leaves it on her dresser for the rest of the day, sighing with a smile when she sees it after she returns to her room that night.

She leaves her lights on when she gets into the bed - a habit from years of automatic lighting that she's been unable to successfully break. Catra's mask looks out of place amongst the pastels, just like she does, just like Adora does.

(Her wardrobe is still filled only with Horde-styled uniform pieces, the harsh red and dull grey so *different* to everything else here. But she just can't let it go. She can't seem to let a lot of things go. Not for the first time, she thinks of Light Hope and her warnings, still as unsure in her feelings regarding them as she's always been.)

She likes seeing the mask in her room, makes her feel less...lonely. (It's stupid and she knows that.)

But that warm feeling fades as always, thoughts of Glimmer and Bow appearing; what they might say, what they might *ask*. She stares at the red until she thinks she might have it's rusty colour imprinted on her eyelids for the rest of her life. She can only admit how she feels to herself *sometimes*. She can't admit it to anyone else. She'll crumble if anyone tries to address it, she's not sure what'll be left of her afterwards.

So she throws off her covers, shivering at the sudden cold on her bare skin (she forgot to close the curtains as well.) She buries the mask under a mountain of practically identical shirts - where Glimmer will never look. Bow might, but if she says no he won't press.

She remembers to turn off her lights now. Closes thick violet fabric afterwards, her curtains and then the fabric of the drapes around her bed, shielding herself from her own worries. It works. Never as well as she wishes, but despite everything, it's still safer in the dark.

Chapter End Notes

Glimmer didn't want Adora having another breakdown if she told her Catra is suicidal again so she kept quiet about it. Which y'know, fair to her because Adora would've totally stormed in and Catra needed that time alone to work through shit.

In between this and the next chapter Bow gets Catra a mirror so she can fix her hair (and she kinda hates her reflection but it was necessary.)
Also I believe that the tent thing around Adora's bed is there as extra insulation in the winter seeing as they don't have any glass in their windows??? Or doors???? You'd think they would, especially after Shadow Weaver broke in but...

Also if any of y'all want chapters from the other ones POV I'd probably be willing to do that, just like let me know specifics :)

Should've Said It Sooner

Chapter Summary

> Catra's feeling more comfortable in Brightmoon. She never thought comfort could be dangerous. And it isn't - it just means she's able to say things she never would've before.

Chapter Notes

> As I said at the end of the last chapter, Bow got Catra a mirror and some scissors and she cut her hair a bit neater. Not exactly relevant but...
>
> Y'all motherfuckers ready for some hurt/comfort????
> (It's come to my attention that I've once again fallen into my long chapter habits but this time it was kind of necessary)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"It's almost flattering, you still being on the other side of this wall."

"Why?"

The trays they'd been holding in their laps sit barren and away, flung into a corner without a care. She's not sure why Adora hasn't left yet, the easy excuse of breakfast long gone. She hates that she's waiting for it so avidly. Why can't she just enjoy it while she has it? Lose herself in it like she wants to?

"Means you think I'm a threat."

She idly drags her claws along the floor. Does she even want Adora to see her as dangerous anymore? It's not a question she's considered before now.

Adora stutters, “That’s not - that’s not why I…”

Catra watches her when they both fall silent, Adora seeming unable to finish what she started. She forces her ears not to go back. It’s fine. It’s Adora.

“Then why…”

‘Why aren’t you here with me?’

Why is she doing this to herself? She doesn’t want Adora with her on this side of the wall - that’s a lie, but one she can believe. She doesn’t think she could bear being close to her again when she can’t touch her. And she *can’t* touch her. It’d be like a fucking floodgate pried open; she imagines that even the brush of her fingertips against her hand would make her feelings come pouring forth from her lips. It might very well ruin everything. Gods, her whole body aches with how much she misses her sometimes. (Right now just happens to be one of those times.)

But her stupid mouth seems to be running itself anyway. Because she needs *something*. She wants answers for things that’ll only tear her apart, she just doesn’t want lies anymore. It’s almost like she wants to hurt, but it’s not the same as it was a few days ago with Glimmer. This is just her being intoxicated by her own obsession; by Adora.

“Why do you stay over there then?”

Adora shuffles slightly; she’s nervous, uncomfortable perhaps. She doesn’t want that.

“Those first few times you - you didn’t want me in there with you so I stopped trying. Do you - do you *want* me to...?”

She probably should’ve been prepared for Adora to ask her that outright. But she’s not. And all she can do is stare at the floor and hope Adora can figure out how much she *does not know*. And she must, given how Adora for her part only looks slightly disappointed with her lack of an answer.

It takes a while, most of it spent trying to look anywhere but blonde hair but another question rises from the ashes of remembered fights.

“Do you...see me as a threat, did you ever?”

Adora is quick to look at her again and it makes her heart pound louder in her chest. (She tells herself it’s the danger the question brings, tiptoeing the line they have yet to fully cross back over; the past.)

“Of course I did. Even before She-Ra you were the only competition I ever really had, I’ve always been amazed by the things you can do, how strong you are when you try.”

She should be happy with that. She should be proud of herself. She's not. Because she doesn't think about them in the Before, she thinks about how they've been *since* then. She hears her tail lash against the floor where she sits, she thinks her claws might be digging grooves into the floor.

“What, when I try to kill you?”

“Catra -”

There’s a small screech when she draws her hands into herself; there’s definitely claw marks in the floor now.

“Adora, please, we - we need to be able to talk about it, okay. I don’t want to but...we should.”

She can’t believe the words left her mouth, Adora seems to be in the same boat if the way she’s openly staring at her, wide-eyed, is any indication.

Whatever sad mockery of a smile she’s able to muster gets strapped to her face. “Trying, remember? Part of the deal.”

Adora softens instantly, eyebrows drawn together with a smile. It’s a look she hasn’t seen in years, one she tried to forget she’d ever

seen at all. She never let herself look too long back then, her lovesick mind never coming up with a *safe* reason for why it was there.

'Stop looking at me like that.'

She can't seem to make herself say it. She never wants Adora to stop looking at her like that; like she cares, like nothing bad ever happened between them, like they're not irreparable.

She wants to kiss her. It makes her breathless and want to cry the same way it always does.

She tilts her head back, eyes closed as a way of giving herself distance from that damn look. It doesn't really work, she can still feel the ache that comes with denying in her chest.

"Trying…" she mutters, mostly to herself. She just needs to get *something* out, she can figure the next step afterwards.

'Come on you've had a whole month to try and work this out, are you going to be a fucking coward and run now *of all times?'*

No. No, she's not.

It's probably the situation, the simple fact that here she *can't* run, that has stopped that instinct in it's tracks. The urge is there. But rarely does she listen anymore. Mostly because she knows the only thing that'll come of it is a premature return to isolation.

'Just look at the ceiling.'

She does, a sigh escaping with it.

"I hurt a lot of people. I hurt the whole fucking planet. I hurt myself. I knew the whole time that I was making mistake after mistake and I just...didn't care. I wanted to win for once, I wanted to prove myself, I wanted to finally feel *safe*, I wanted…"

'I wanted to have never met you.'

'I wanted you to have never left.'

'I wanted you to come back.'

"...a lot of things."

"I know -"

Her eyes snap open again. That look Adora was wearing is gone, she hasn't hardened, she just looks...sad. Guilty.

"- No. You don't. You never have. And it's okay Adora, I can't keep blaming you for not seeing things when I hid them from you."

She really should stop blaming Adora, period. But it's going to take more than a month to do that. Because as much as it's being chipped away at each day, her bitter resentment still resides in her chest. It's strange how it can coincide with her own self-loathing.

'It's the world's fault' and *'It's my fault'* live at equal strengths now. More often than not the latter permeates her head. When she's alone she wonders if this is how Adora's felt her whole life - she thinks so, but has never brought herself to ask. She can't even do it now.

"I wish you hadn't. I wish you'd told me." Adora almost whispers it, picks at the top of her boot.

"Yeah well, too late to change that now." It takes everything she has to keep that bitterness out of it but she does. Somehow.

Needless to say neither of them are exactly comfortable with this amount of vulnerability, even now. It's a strange thing to find comfort in, but right now she'll latch onto anything familiar.

And gods Adora's trying so hard. Her brow is furrowed as she tries to figure out the next words to say and Catra just...loves her. In whatever twisted version of love she's able to have. Because if she were able to love properly she wouldn't have done any of the things she's done - she wouldn't be sitting here waiting for Adora

to say something. Adora's giving and giving and giving and she's barely even meeting her.

'Still taking. Still selfish.'

She doesn't know how to stop.

She doesn't think Adora realises how she shuffles a little closer, the flyaway hair around her head tiptoeing the wall of the barrier. But Catra notices, because right now she feels trapped in her pull, the slightest change threatening to make the world shake.

"You could tell me. I would - I'd listen."

"I know."

She doesn't believe it. Which isn't exactly fair to her but when has anything between them ever been *fair*? But...that's not Adora's fault. She knows that now. The divide they were always fighting to bridge didn't stem from them, in fact they were together in spite of it. It came from Shadow Weaver, as all bad things seem to.

'Adora let it happen.'

'You let it happen.'

'Adora didn't know.'

'You did.'

She's not sure which one's louder.

The inside of her head is insufferable. Gods how can Adora even stand to be around her? She can't even have one fucking conversation without feeling like she's drowning. And the worst part? The one thing that would make it better is Adora herself. But she can't have her, so she settles for the same thing she always does; memories. The feel of her arms around her, her scent, the

sound of her muffled laughter under bed covers late at night. It's drowning in a way she can bear, at least she's used to this.

She takes a deep breath. She can do this. She can speak at the very least. Adora deserves that much.

'Stop breaking promises.'

Adora's voice when she speaks is both air and water - relief from her head and aggravation for her feelings.

"We don't have to talk about this if you don't -"

"- I knew how much damage I was doing."

Whatever else Adora was going to say doesn't come. Her hands fall to her lap, back perfectly straight; the picture of an attentive soldier.

She doesn't close her eyes, though she wants to. Tells herself she has to look at her, it's for her after all, just as much as it is for herself.

"But since I've been here I've *accepted* it. I promised you that I would try and make things better and I will. I'll never leave this room to keep people safe from me."

Adoras position melts, "Catra -"

She ignores the bile on her tongue, "- I know how badly I hurt Glimmer, she made no secret of that. I hurt so many people that most of it kind of blurs into one. But you…it's different I - I didn't know any of them, not the way I know you."

'I didn't love them the way I love you.'

"Made it easier I guess..."

It didn't. Not the way she says it (the way that Adora will interpret it.) It was easier to hurt Adora because she knew her weaknesses,

she knew *how*. But it wasn't *easier*. With every blade she made herself bleed too. Really that's the only kind of love she's ever known. The Horde - Shadow Weaver - made sure of that.

"Probably helped that I hurt you first. And - And I don't just mean me leaving."

It makes her feel weak; that Adora knows that she hurt her. That she's always had that power over her. She can't stop that feeling, but she can ease it with the knowledge that Adora doesn't know how *much* she hurt her, and she probably never will.

But that's not an answer she can give, so she thinks. Did Adora leaving allow her to do all those things? Maybe. Revenge always was a good excuse, fuel, reason. Whatever she needed it to be really. But whatever she tapped into to be able to hurt Adora (and the world,) that was there long before she left. She should tell her that, she *deserves* that. She -

"It wasn't your fault you know. You blame yourself for everything - and I blamed you too. For so long I couldn't bear the *thought* of you. But things - *I've* - changed. You didn't *make* me do anything, you never did. So please Adora just...stop."

She hates the way Adora curls in on herself. "I can't do that Catra. You know that."

She sighs, "Yeah I know."

She hears Adora swallow in the silence. "You want me to stop blaming myself?" Catra nods. "Then can I ask you something?"

That is a dangerous question. Enough so that her teeth dig into her lip and her ears go back, but she nods again. Too wary of herself to do anything else and too afraid of Adora leaving, of being alone again, right now if she says no.

"Catra, when I left...was there *any* way I could've got you to come with me?"

"With the way things happened? No."

It might be what Adora needs to hear right now, but it's also true. She can't tell her how seriously she considered leaving before she got that Force Captain badge. It'll just make her guilt that much worse. If she can save her *any* amount of pain, she feels she has a duty to do so.

If Adora did find out, she thinks she might forgive her (at least for not telling her). Duty is something she understands better than anything.

"Can I ask *you* a question?"

Adora hesitates just as she did. Nods just like she did.

"Were you scared of me?"

Adora's shocked by the question, that much is obvious. Which is fair, she's not even sure why she said it. Sure, it sprouted off the question from earlier but...but nothing. Fear is such a big part in both their lives, maybe it's appropriate.

Adora thinks for a while. And she lets her, since Adora gave her the same. Might be the only nice thing she's done for her all day. (Maybe even all week.)

"I - I was never scared of *you* Catra. I mean I was but... I was - I don't know - scared of things about you? Of what you became. Of what you might do. Of the power you had over me."

Adora stops but she's not done. And she's glad; has no idea what to say in response. She doesn't even know what that means. When has she ever had any power over Adora? Hasn't it always been the other way round? Her trailing after Adora in her shadow.

But her own thoughts don't matter right now - she pushes them aside because Adora's *shaking*. Her hands holding each other in a white-knuckle grip to try and stop it. But just like earlier; Catra notices. Gods she wants to hold her so bad. Wants to ease that

anguish any way she can. But she also wants Adora to explain. She wants everything and nothing and to forget that this is happening and -

"I was *scared* of failing the Rebellion because…because I still see my best friend when I look at you. Deep down I knew if it was a choice between us winning and letting you live, I wouldn't be able to choose. Because I see someone I care about hurting and I wanted - want - to help you more than anything, even if I know you won't let me."

She can see the way Adora goes rigid as she realises how much she's said. Or maybe even just the *weight* of what she's said. It doesn't matter. Her mind grinds to a halt as it processes what it's heard. It doesn't start up again.

It...it doesn't make sense. Nothing does. She - Adora can't - why - *how* could she be telling any sort of truth? After everything? It's not fucking possible. She has to swallow around the bile that's managed to coat her throat with it's bitterness.

She stands and hisses, "Go tell your lies to someone else."

She can't look at Adora and her stupid, shining, *lying* face. How *dare* she? She deserves so many things, but this is not one of them. She's taken enough lies in her life, enough to fill the seas a hundred times over. And Adora *knows* that.

"I'm not lying." It sounds wounded. It doesn't even register.

"Yes you are! You don't have to lie and spare my feelings anymore, we're not fucking kids. I don't matter A-" She can't even say her fucking name it just hurts too much. Fuck, she thought she'd gotten past this. "We both know I don't matter. I ruin things, it's all I'm good for."

Adora gets to her feet as well, distress written into her features. "You matter to me!"

"Stop lying!" She doesn't mean to scream.

“I’m not *fucking lying* Catra!”

She opens her mouth to retort - to scream - again but her tongue won’t let her. If Adora saying *that* with that much fury wasn’t enough to stop her thoughts in their tracks, then Adora’s crossing the barrier certainly would. *Adora’s crossing the barrier*. Her heart rate spikes with panic. She fights the urge to hide behind the chair so she won’t have the steel on her, boring into her, full of sadness she doesn’t understand. Can’t let herself even admit that it’s there.

“Do you really think that little of yourself?”

‘Why are you asking?’

She doesn’t think anyone’s even *thought* to ask her that before. She can’t fucking move, whole body static in her own shock. But shock doesn’t last, it never does. It melts away leaving her heart free to crack under everything she’s feeling.

"Do you really think that little of *me*?"

It’s Adora’s tear-stained eyes, it’s her closeness, it’s her *caring* that apparently never died. It should’ve fucking died. Just like her. But they didn’t, they’re still both here. There’s disbelief and there’s heartbreak so deep she can’t breathe. Tears flood her throat, blur her eyes and maybe she’s choking on them.

She doesn’t know what it is that makes them spill over. It’s probably Adora and the fact she’s so close she can feel the heat coming off her, she can hear her heartbeat and her breath. And she’s drowning again; in her eyes, in her own feelings, in the dread that’s awoken with the very real possibility that Adora might touch her.

And Adora does try, hands raising like she’s going to hold her. And just like last time she flinches, her own hands gripping at her arms like it’ll protect her from what she’s feeling. It’s fear mostly; of herself, of what Adora might do, that makes more tears come.

She can’t fight them anymore. Or maybe she just doesn’t care whether Adora sees them this time.

Adora draws her hands back like she’s been burnt. Catra wants her so badly it almost makes her sob. She wants to wrap her arms around her and sink into the one place that always felt like home. But she’s a coward when it comes to Adora, she always has been. And she runs.

Except she *can’t*, not here. All she can do now is walk a couple steps and slide down the back of the armchair. She can curl as small as she’s able and hide her face in her knees, but that’s all. And it’s not enough.

Adora doesn’t move at first, but Catra can hear the roughness of her breath. Then the slow click of her boots on the floor when she comes beside her. Adora’s probably staring at the door, deciding whether or not to leave her like this.

“Catra I’m…”

It falls away. Adora starts forwards - towards the door, away from her - with a shaky sigh. She doesn’t let her. *She can’t let her leave again*. She can see the way Adora’s whole body tenses when she grabs her hand.

“Adora wait!”

Adora listens, turns, and there’s so much fear in her eyes. She drops her hand despite the way her whole body lights up, demands she never let her go and stands. It's so unbearably hard to do, but she owes it to her.

“I’m sorry, for everything.”

She doesn’t blame Adora for the practically awe-struck look on her face. She doesn’t think *‘sorry’* has ever passed her lips before wherein she actually meant it, it tastes strange on her tongue. Different to the ones forced out of her by shadows.

There’s more screaming static in her head as Adora comes back to her, she couldn’t move if she tried. She thinks her legs might be shaking. It doesn’t matter. Nothing matters but the eyes that she can’t see anymore, because Adora’s wrapped her arms around her shoulders, buried her face in her neck. *She can’t breathe.*

It takes all of three seconds before she cries, uninhibited and pathetic and weak and messy and it *doesn’t matter*.

Her claws latch onto the back of her jacket - that same fucking jacket - and she feels the wetness of Adora’s own tears as they begin to lightly soak her fur. There’s not much else in her head but - but nothing actually. It’s entirely blank, thoughts, reactions all stripped away with the overwhelming scent of *‘home’*.

She starts purring through the water in her throat. Unexpectedly and *loud*. Adora gasps into her neck, a hand gripping at her shoulder. She’s always loved her purrs, Catra’s never asked her why. They never even really spoke about it since it always made her feel weak; exposed. But this? This is okay, if it has Adora’s smiling through her silent tears, then it has to be. It’s her body’s way of begging her to stay even if her tongue can’t do the same. She doesn’t know if Adora remembers what it means, she half-hopes she doesn’t.

“I should have - should have said it sooner. But I’m saying it now and I’m so fucking sorry Adora.”

She sobs her name, she doesn’t care. Adora just shakes a little, holds her tighter.

“I’m sorry too. I'm *sorry*," she says it like it's a relief, "I hurt you and I swear, I never wanted to do that, I never wanted to leave you.”

At least she’s not the only one whose voice seems to be breaking on every other word. The feeling of Adora’s lips brushing lightly against her skin as she speaks makes her shudder in her arms.

‘I love you so much.’

She turns her head outwards just so she can breathe. Adora stills like she's thinking of letting her go, so she wraps her arms around her waist, clinging onto her own wrists. Silently saying, *'Never let me go again,'* even though she knows Adora won't realise that.

Maybe it's the warmth - strength - with which she holds her. Maybe it's Adora's love, even if it is just friendship, that floods through her. So much more than she deserves. But she feels safe enough to say things she's never let the walls outside of her own head hear.

"You broke my fucking heart."

Her next breaths are just hidden cries, muffled in red fabric, drowning out her purrs. She tries not to dig her claws too deep into her own skin when Adora lifts her head. But Adora's not pulling away, just hooking her chin over her shoulder.

"You broke mine too."

And she cries again. Because Adora doesn't mean it the way she does. But it feels *so good* to hear her say it anyway. One of Adora's hands comes to the nape of her neck. And she lets her. For some reason she lets her.

"Catra?"

"Hmm?"

"We can fix this, right? Us?"

Fuck, she sounds so scared. Scared for what she's going to say, like she could even manage to say no when they've come this far.

"Yeah...I think - I think we can."

For the first time in years she actually believes that it's possible. There's so much more that needs to be said but...but they have time. Maybe they can work on it a little everyday. She knows it's her fault that they haven't been doing that the whole time. She's

never really believed in 'better late than never' but she probably ought to start.

"I forgive you. Not for everything…"

"Adora, you don't have to. I know, I know there are things I've done that are...unforgivable in the least."

"I want to though. I want to be able to forgive you for all of it eventually."

She wants to ask how; how can Adora be so *good* all the time. Just apologising (and crying and *feeling*) is exhausting. Not lying or misleading or hiding is draining in a way she's never really experienced before.

"You shouldn't. You shouldn't even want to."

"Yeah I know. But it's you."

She buries her face back in Adora's jacket. She understands what she means; can't decide if she loves it or hates it. It's not the first time she's felt like that about something. Honesty right? That's what she's doing now.

"I hated you, I hated you so much because I still cared about you despite everything I did. I missed you every fucking day."

And maybe 'cared' is replacing what she really means, but Adora doesn't know that. Otherwise she wouldn't be crushing her into her chest the way she is, breathing shakily against her ear like she is. It might still be misleading - hiding - but it's not lying.

"I missed you too, every single day. But I - I never hated you. Don't even think I tried that hard to. You know, I uh, I used to wonder what the others would say, if they knew. I never told them how much you meant to me. And they never asked."

She wants to ask, *'And how much did I mean to you?'* But she doesn't. This is already fragile enough as it is. There's only so

much weight one conversation can bear before it breaks. (And there's really no answer she can see that won't wound her heart as a consequence.)

She thinks it's a good thing she's angry *for* Adora. She knows she can't really say anything, but the Princesses are meant to be better than her, they should've known Adora was suffering. They should've asked if she was alright. (She's still trying to grasp that Adora was hurting over losing her but she doubts she's going to absorb that fully any time soon.)

"...It's probably a good thing though. It was already hard enough fighting you. Don't think I could've handled how they would've looked at me if they knew what we had."

She doesn't cry again, but she wants to. Gods she's pathetic.

"What we had."

Maybe it's the past tense, and the possibility they might never get it back that's fucking her up so badly. Her legs are about to start shaking again and she doesn't really think she can live with herself if she collapses in Adora's arms right now. So, as much as she really doesn't want to, she moves.

She reasons with herself that they were going to have to break this eventually anyway. It doesn't help ease the disappointment all that much. The joints in her fingers crack as she slides her claws in and loosens her hold. She pushes at Adora's hips to signal for her to let go (and ignores how reluctant the simple act of pulling away seems.)

Adora's fingertips graze along the top of her spine when she leaves her arms, and she has to suppress another shudder. If Adora's going to be touching her again, and there's not really any doubt after all of this that she *won't*, she's really going to have to get this under control. And quick.

At least with the distance she can breathe easier, her thoughts less foggy. And her tongue less loose.

Adora rids her face of the water there before crossing her arms in a move that *she* usually employs to stop herself from reaching out again. It makes her chest ache seeing Adora wearing it.

But she's reminded of her own state, and scrubs at the thin fur on her face like it'll do anything other than make it stick up. "You make me a fucking mess, you know that?"

"You think I'm any better off?"

Adora isn't really; her eyes are puffy and her hair's kind of a mess and there's a water stain on her shoulder. But the evidence sticking to her is much more easily disposed of.

"Now what?" It's cute how hesitant Adora is.

"Sit with me?" Adora lets out a relieved sigh. "What, did you think I was gonna ask you to leave?"

"Kind of."

"You're an idiot," she tells her as she pulls them around.

The chair is long enough that she can lay on it lengthways with only her feet hanging off, which means Adora could sit next to her without them touching. But she doesn't want that. She wants Adora here, she wants to feel her again; memorize her scent and the few freckles on her skin she thought she'd forgotten about.

She sits down first, back against the armrest, and pulls a nervous Adora with her. Catra's glad she doesn't have to go through the embarrassing ordeal of tugging her closer, Adora gets as close as she can, within reason. But reason doesn't matter to her so much right now. She lifts her legs and Adora smiles when she realises (remembers) what it means. She shuffles underneath, brings Catra's legs down over her tucked up knees as she settles, the same way they would sit with each other when one of them got hurt.

She’s probably smiling far too softly but she doesn’t care. It takes her all of four seconds for her to decide to doom herself, already trying to figure out a way to curl back into the shape of Adora’s arms, fit her nose into her neck. But Adora’s jacket won’t really let her do that, so it has to go.

“Jacket off dummy.”

“Oh, right.”

Adora drops it on the ground and leaves an arm out for her to tuck under, and it makes her smile; Adora remembered. Remembered how much her scent calmed her, and she not-so-quietly purrs her gratitude into her neck. Adora laughs a little and it’s like the whole fucking room lights up.

“What? Think I’d forget about that?”

“A little. More like I didn’t think you’d offer... I was gonna do it anyway.”

Adora hums quietly, rests her head on hers. And it’s okay (it’s better than okay.)

Eventually she’s able to ease out from the hold and lean back against the armrest without feeling like the moment’s going to crumble into fantasy. She laughs a little when Adora doesn’t seem to know what to do with her hands. (She ends up with them resting on Catra’s legs, looking guilty when she really shouldn’t.)

Her continuous purr fades to practically nothing when she asks, “How long can you stay?”

Because apparently she’s back to thinking about when Adora’s going to leave again.

“Don’t know. Glimmer’s not gonna like it if I stay here that much longer, probably some meeting she’ll want me to go to. Which is

dumb because I'm not even technically a Princess anymore, but..."

"But Sparkles already isn't exactly my biggest fan, and I'm beginning to think I should invest in not pissing off the Queen. I get it. She's vicious."

"Can be. Just like someone else I know."

It's probably not something anyone who grew up outside of the Horde would preen at, but they did, and she does.

"Don't you forget it."

Adora squeezes her leg and her ears prick forward in surprise. She can see Adora trying to suppress a laugh.

"Thanks Catra."

"For what?"

"For...talking, I guess."

"It was a bit late."

It was very, very late. But Adora doesn't seem to care. In fact she smiles before sighing heavily and lifting Catra's legs to escape the comfort of the chair. Is she revelling in how clear it is that Adora doesn't want to go? Yes, entirely, unashamedly yes. A near-silent purr starting up in her chest again.

"Can it really be late if I never expected it to happen in the first place?"

Adora's still smiling, looking over her shoulder as she pulls her jacket back on when she says it. It soothes the desolate nature of the words.

"Not sure." She lets it be playful, not only because it'll mean the smile stays on Adora's face.

"Try and find me an answer by tomorrow?"

“Okay dork.”

Her eyes follow Adora all the way out the door.

Chapter End Notes

Said it before, I'll say it again. I hate last lines.
Another chapter that started off so much shorter and then spiralled because I just do that apparently. Also I wrote a whole one shot based on that hugging position because of this and yes it is another of my one-shots I count as in this universe. (Anyway here: I've Got You)

Pretty much all on the up from here on. And was that...fluff I kind of wrote??? I know, I’m shocked too. Next chapter is kind of a set up/exposition/fluff thing which'll be a nice change of pace. (Also gonna be gay as hell eeeee)

(Also Viscous by Halestorm is a Catra song. I do in fact make the rules.)

Inbetween

Chapter Notes

> This has more world building than I was intending. (Timeline wise, Catra's been in Brightmoon around 40 days by now.)
>
> I know I know Catradora fluff is next chapter I promise - like lots of unnecessary touching

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"Wasn't expecting you Sparkles."

"Heard you apologised."

"I did. Guessing you want one too? I've been practising."

"Kind of already had ours but the actual words would be a nice addition."

"Well then... I'm sorry. You know what for."

"Hm. I guess I'm sorry too... Wow. You just apologised to a Princess."

"You just apologised to the ex-leader of the Horde. It's weird all round."

"I've got duties around the castle. I'll come see you when I'm done."

She's been thinking about it ever since it happened. She apologised to the leader of the Rebellion. And maybe she bit her tongue hard enough to bleed doing it, but she meant it. And Adora knows, came to see her the day after and she was *proud* of her. Looked at her with that face that puts moonshine in her eyes

and gives her false hopes and childish butterflies. And it felt like everything she's always wanted.

Brightmoon really has gotten to her.

“Hi Bow.”

“Morning Catra.”

It’s still strange seeing people aside from Adora wearing a smile when they say her name. And yes, Bow is the only person who does that, but it means a lot. Makes her feel better. Even if there’s no way she’ll ever admit that to anyone.

Maybe one day he’ll figure it out - know her well enough to spot the signs. There’s advantages and consequences to both options.

He’s been trying to make more of an effort to come see her since she let Adora know that she doesn’t *mind* the company (however long ago the conversation was.) This isn’t even his first visit this week. (And maybe it has something to do with what happened between her and Adora a couple of days ago, but if it is, she’s not going to ask.)

“What’s been happening this week?”

“It’s been slow actually, you’re pretty much caught up.”

There’s something there she doesn’t like. But she’s not going to outright accuse him of anything (yet), friendship and all.

“I find that hard to believe.”

Bow makes a half-soured face that gives her all the confirmation she needs. There’s guilt there that she believes to be a result of the act of lying itself, rather than being caught. She’s able to distinguish them now.

“Okay there’s definitely something.” She’s trying so hard to keep the hard edge out of the words.

‘He doesn’t lie to hurt you.’

‘Then why is he lying at all?’

She sighs, mostly at herself, “I get it if you don’t want to tell me. Just don’t lie...please.”

That’s a new word she’s been using. Infrequently, but she can safely say it is in her vocabulary now. And Bow softens because of it. There’s relief in her lungs that she tries her hardest not to feel too uncomfortable with.

“Right, you’re - you’re right. It’s just...y’know...Horde stuff.”

“Oh.”

Either he’s been carefully avoiding the subject (Adora too), or the Alliance has been too preoccupied with rebuilding Salineas and neighbouring kingdoms to address the (inevitable) mess that is the Fright Zone. Which is fair, most of the map has suffered at the Horde’s hands - her hands - at least somewhat during the war after all. Why wouldn't they try and fix their own homes first?

She chokes back whatever feeling is in her throat, “What’s happening over there?”

It’s not quite homesickness (not that she’s ever experienced it before), but maybe it’s some brand of missing. Maybe it’s just general uneasiness - which she thinks is understandable.

“Over there? Not much, no one’s living there - that we know of. We, um, we’re bringing the rest of the bots here so Entrapta can dismantle them. Or experiment on them - we’re not really sure.”

“You trust her not to blow up the castle?”

He gives her a look. It's one she's unsure whether or not he's made for her. It reads like a reprimand; a *'think about what you just said.'* And more often than not she listens, goes back over what she's done and picks through it to find what he might see fault in. Sometimes it takes a while and he'll just tell her, but this one's pretty easy.

"Right, trusting people is a good thing. Forgot."

There was only one time where he got mad at her for it (and even then it was more like aggressive disappointment she really hadn't known how to handle), and it was because she didn't correct herself. Remained stubborn and bitter. Adora had later come to the conclusion that it was because it reminded him of Glimmer. She'd been reluctant to share that insight but Catra was surprisingly okay with it. (Yes, she had come to the same conclusion herself but having Adora say it made it feel different.)

But now is not then and Bow's just smiling a little. "We're keeping an eye on her. Bomb detection is our first priority."

That's good. There are *definitely* some bombs hidden in the cores.

"Looks like you're learning Arrow… If there are bombs, they'll be fused to the metal framework around the core. Which Entrapta will know about but just, full warning."

He leans back on his hands, legs crossed; a position she would describe as easily vulnerable. "Any tips on dismantling them?"

"You're working with Entrapta so have a will ready, but other than that just don't cut the green wire."

She's glad he seems to recognise the distinct lack of maliciousness in the words.

"Good to know."

"Anything else happening?"

"Well, people have stopped panicking when we send the refurbished Horde-tech to help with reconstruction. Soldiers are finding homes finally. It's been, uh, difficult."

"The Horde never really taught us to adapt. Well, adapt beyond a battle setting. Resilience got you extra points."

'Unless you're me.' She doesn't say it aloud.

"Figured. Which, uh, reminds me I had...I had a question for you. I guess I could ask Adora, but missions and meetings mean we keep missing each other."

'Yeah, I know a thing or two about missing her.'

'Wow, dramatic much?'

She blames the shift in their relationship; closer to how it was before, that's making her think like this.

It's been five days and they've had three mornings. That's it. The past two of which she hasn't even seen Adora, or heard from her at all. Diplomatic trip to flower girl's kingdom. (She figures she should probably learn her name, given all the not-so-subtle hints Bow gives regarding her relationship with Scorpia.)

But those three mornings they did have? Interesting to say the least. At first Adora had been so adorably skittish about everything - she actually needed her to hold out a hand before she even crossed.

"You sure it's okay?"

"Adora, I wouldn't be offering if it wasn't."

In some ways she's glad Adora didn't let anything beyond the momentary hand-holding happen the first day. Just that alone made her heart leap into her throat, the pulse strong enough she

was worried Adora would feel it in their palms. But it was okay; Adora let go quick enough. And yet the rush of blood in her body didn’t leave, prolonged and fed by Adora's closeness. Adora never dared to touch her, but it wasn't even needed. (She doesn’t know what reason Adora decided upon for why she kept staring at her, but Catra getting caught up in the vision of her, unruptured by blue magic is probably not it.)

And she was content with it, could swear she was glowing just from having the *option* of feeling her again. But she’s greedy and lovesick. And the next day had her sitting right next to her, the two of them looking out the ever-open window. Not that Adora seemed in any way unhappy about that, in fact she was grinning the whole time. Gods she had felt like a kid again. It was...surprisingly easy.

So she took a risk; highly calculated and incredibly foolish. When Adora set the few remains of her food aside the next day, she’d lain on the floor, feet in Adora’s lap. Adora was (rightly) surprised by the sudden action but was laughing quietly soon after, easing Catra’s worries away.

As with a lot of things now, it seems she has to make the first move, and Adora will follow suit. It’s a strange reversal to what she’s used to - Adora always one to keep pushing. Either Adora’s finally grown wary of how often pushing her will end with claws, or she’s just unsure how to navigate whatever they have now. (It’s definitely the latter.)

But all that means is that as soon as a barrier is broken Adora is adamant to keep it that way. Hands on her shoulders, forearms, shoving at her, even kicking her lightly once. And fuck has she missed it.

Misses it. Because Adora’s not here right now, but she’ll be back soon, said as much from the hug she gave her before she left. (Which she was wholly unprepared for. She blames the resulting purr she couldn't quash down fast enough on that factor alone.)

She'll just have to hope neither of them backslide into the awkward space they had before when she returns.

Dammit she got caught up in her own head again. Right. Bow had a question.

"What is it?"

The amusement he was holding fades a little, "The soldiers I was helping, they - well they didn't really seem to know each other? Most of the soldiers didn't know anyone aside from the people in their squadrons and their Force Captains. Is that normal?"

"Yeah."

If he's asked her that about three weeks ago she'd have asked if that *wasn't* normal. She's now spent enough time with him and Adora to know that it is, in fact, not. Even Glimmer made that clear enough during her visit. (She had indeed kept her word, returning much later in the day.) Queen of thousands of subjects and she knows pretty much all her guards by name.

She hadn't even bothered to look at Hordak's guard when he had them. It'd left her rolling in a new kind of guilt for a few hours afterwards.

If anything, Bow deflates more with the confirmation. "Oh. I thought - I don't know what I thought. No one's exactly big on opening up about what it was like there. Scorpia is of course but she seemed kind of...outcast from the rest of the Horde. Until she met you and Entrapta. But you and Adora…"

She ignores the lilt in his voice that makes it sound like a question fights down the undeserved panic.

It comes out a little shaky and prays he doesn't notice. "Me and Adora aren't exactly a typical example of relations within the Horde, okay? We were told off enough for...well for everything. But Shadow Weaver she - she didn't even want Adora near me most of the time. Bad influence on her prodigy or whatever."

It’s painfully bitter even in her own ears. Shadow Weaver has that affect.

He looks stricken, but curious, “You were punished for being friends?”

Maybe she’s feeling petty, but, “I was punished for everything. But yeah, amongst other things. It wasn’t meant to be anything more than allyship. Not that people really listened to that. They just learned to hide it and I - I guess I didn’t... Shadow Weaver always knew."

She blames what she is for that - body giving so much away. Too much most of the time. She could be read so she had to learn to close the book. Not that she ever truly succeeded at that, and not that Adora ever wanted her to. But she tampered it down enough to get by. And it was one of the few things that became easier with Adora's abrupt absence, a river cut off from it's source.

"But yeah, people had friends, just not many and hardly ever outside their own barracks.”

Bow looks about as desolate as she’s ever seen him. “That sounds...lonely. And awful. But you had Adora, and Scorpia, and Entrapta.”

She scoffs, “Yeah and look how well I did with them.”

He hums thinking for a minute. “Scorpia misses you. She smiles when I tell her about you, asks me how you’re doing.”

It doesn’t matter how curious she is to know what he’s said, it doesn’t change her mild shock. And the subsequent wave of regret.

“She shouldn’t.”

Bow seems to ignore her, a new move for him that almost has her impressed. “Think if you asked her to come see you, she would.”

“I’ll think about it.” She sighs, eyes turning to the ceiling as they always do. “I do- I do want to apologise to her, okay.”

He’s still smiling when she looks back down. “Okay, I have another question, but you really don’t have to answer it, you didn’t exactly respond *well* the last time.”

She resolves to keep the growl in her chest down to simply gritting her teeth. But she does let her tail lash behind her, a warning but not an outright threat. Because for all the trouble her own fucking body has gotten her into, it's easier to be read than it is to say something out loud. Sure, she hates it after so long of trying to get it under control, of never letting anyone but Adora see. But Adora suggested it would help and she really can't be turning away anything that might help at this point.

“Ask me anyway.”

“This isn’t it, but do you know that you do...things?”

Oh so he’s noticed then. She’s kind of surprised he’s calling her out on it. “Of course I do, I’m doing it for your benefit.”

“What do you mean?”

“Been told I’m easier to read when I don’t try and hide absolutely everything. *Don’t* make a big deal out of it.”

He’s going to make *such* a big deal out of it, he’s got his ‘big eyes’ on. She doesn’t like them. He knows that. Doesn’t stop him. He’s even had the audacity to call her cute. (Which he probably only did because she can’t tackle him through the barrier.) Which made her fur puff up, which made him reiterate his claim. It was a vicious cycle.

“You had a question,” she says, still glaring.

“Right, uh, what was Adora like as a kid?”

He was right to be nervous.

There's a possessiveness in her chest she'd thought she'd outgrown. That growl she's been pushing down comes out and she has to force her claws in lest they carve the floor. Those memories are *hers*. He doesn't deserve them. He wasn't there. She was. She held her through the bad times, stole food for them, lied for her, cleaned her wounds, soothed her nightmares.

It's unfair of her to think like this. She knows that. Her memories aren't the only things she has left of Adora anymore. It should be a comfort. Should ease the fear of losing something - because she's not *losing* anything. If anything she's giving.

'He just wants to know what his friend was like when she was younger.'

'Selfish. Selfish. Selfish'

"You don't have to answer, I'm sorry, I shouldn't have pushed."

She doesn't know when she closed her eyes but she must've given all she sees is black.

"No it's -" Deep breath. "It's okay. She's your friend too, just...give me a minute."

He doesn't need to know specifics. Things like Adora chasing after her through endless hallways, shrieking and hiding in boxes full of weapon parts whenever they heard footsteps; that can still be hers. Their records, their jokes, their hiding spots, their bed. No one can take those from her.

She waits until her fur stops bristling.

"She - She was funny I guess, the only person who could make me laugh."

There. That's safe enough. He doesn't need to know that she used to laugh whenever someone failed a training exercise. Or fell over. But properly laugh, not at the expense of anyone else? That was just Adora. It's enough to have her smiling, at least a little.

“And so bloody determined, if she didn’t get something she *would not* give up until she got it.”

‘Even if she got hurt in the process.’

And she usually did. And she’d heal, faster than anyone else. Maybe that was She-Ra. She doesn’t know how she feels about that. But there were other wounds left; ones Adora didn't let her see, ones she's getting to know only now, the ones Shadow Weaver carved into her head and heart. She's learning them slowly, so painfully slowly. Only seeing the first of them when she had Adora sobbing on her knees before a throne.

“So not much has changed then?”

She’s seen the black under Adora’s eyes and the sag in her shoulders. Things one might expect to be gone with a war over. But then again she knows she’s far from free of the ghosts so who is she to say anything.

“Guess not.”

Bow turns back to her on his way out. “Hey, I should’ve asked you sooner, but do you want some new clothes?”

She looks down. There’s still a hole in the side from Hordak’s blaster, even though her fur’s been rejuvenated. There’s also somehow still ash in the fabric and even a little blood. She can’t even remember whose it is. Fuck she’s even still got the Horde insignia on her back.

“...Sure. But no fucking dresses. And no pink.”

He rolls his eyes - he’s never done that before. “Don’t worry, I won’t.”

He says it like he knows what she likes. Maybe she can get used to that.

Chapter End Notes

Apparently I will take any chance for me to enforce my headcanon that She-Ra's healing was active when they were kids and therefore Catra has fewer scars and Adora doesn't really have any.

Again, fluff next chapter I promise.

Reprise

Chapter Summary

Adora comes back from Plumeria.
Someone else gets through the barrier.

Chapter Notes

The internet was scaring me this week therefore...this is late.

For my own sake, Catra's new outfit is just what she wears in season 5. (But her hair is a little longer.)

Also reminder that Adora figured out her feelings somewhere between seasons 1 and 2 after seeing relationships and just kinda going: OH *that's* what I want. (This applies to all my canon-verse stories unless I say otherwise.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The image of Brightmoon; it's bridge and towering jewel melt into her vision once the glitter fades. Neither her nor Glimmer waste any time in homecoming, striding quickly into the castle, both desperately wanting their own beds.

They walk in comfortable silence, encountering only a few guards on the way to their bedrooms. Once they're ascending the stairs, however, she remembers there's more than just an empty room for her to return to. (Not that she's *not* been thinking about Catra for the past few days; always residing on the back burner of her thoughts.)

She's already turning on the stairs, not even wanting to drop her rucksack off; Catra's more important anyway. She's missed her. More than she really ought to for how long it's been. Now she's

aware of it, that want to see her is demanding, howling in her chest and head, despite the fact she's practically dead on her feet.

Glimmer grabs her though, "And where do you think you're going?"

Sometimes she sounds so much like Angella it's scary.

"Uh…" It's not like she won't be able to figure it out. (She has happened to worriedly ask Glimmer how she thinks Catra's doing once or twice, purposely keeping her questions to the times when she'd normally be going to see her.)

Glimmer sighs, somehow managing to sound suspicious, "She'll be there in the morning."

'But I want to see her now.' Her thoughts sound like a petulant child. She's glad she's not too tired that she can't help but voice them.

She should expect the sudden shift in her stomach when Glimmer teleports her to her room, but she doesn't. It has her dizzy and stumbling back onto her bed, exhaustion preventing her from easily righting herself.

"Adora, you need to get some fucking sleep."

She listens, but only because she can't find it in herself to move right now, sinking far too fast into the blankets.

She fully intends to sneak away in the night to go see Catra, she really does. But she gets dragged under a wave of deep sleep within seconds, rendering her plans and intentions useless.

She sleeps well, leaving her head free for clarity when she wakes. There's guilt at first for succumbing to sleep, but she's able to push it away quick enough - Catra wasn't expecting her to go see her as soon as she got back anyway. It allows for the pure, childish excitement to worm its way into her head. It means she's

grinning while she's rushing to dress, walking swiftly to the kitchens, practically bouncing on her toes by the time she reaches Catra's door.

She's glad she doesn't hesitate at her door anymore (even if the fluttery crawling in her stomach has remained a persistent constant), propping the stacked trays and their unstable cargo between her hip and arm as she opens and closes the door.

She rambles, "I'm back, sorry I didn't come see you last night, I wanted to but Glimmer forced me to 'get some fucking sleep' or whatever -"

Catra doesn't wait for her to turn around before; "Hey Adora."

She spins to look at her, whole body wanting to melt into the floor at the smile she sees. It's relief; more powerful than coming home, that's making her own smile grow. Catra's waiting for her as close to the barrier as she can get, but Adora only gets a few steps before her brain catches up with what her eyes are seeing. Her whole body jerks to a halt.

"You, uh, got new clothes."

She did. And she looks great. Catra always looks great. She wonders whether Catra knows how good she looks. She figures she must. Wasn't that a major part of her plan at Princess Prom? Or maybe that was just an added disadvantage on Adora's part. It's not as if her clothes are so different, almost identical to her old outfit. But all that means is that she's still got her thigh-highs (the slither of skin they show) and chest window, both of which make her lose her mind and have her itching to touch. Which she definitely *cannot do.*

"Courtesy of Bow."

She recovers quicker than she did her hair (since it's less shock and more just admiration.)

'Dammit I should've thought of that.'

Catra rolls her eyes and props her hip to the side. “Don’t feel guilty you didn’t think of it, I didn’t either.”

She breathes a small disbelieving laugh, starting to walk again. “How did you…?”

“Oh please,” Catra hooks an arm around her shoulders once she’s close enough, and it takes most of Adora’s effort not to startle at it.

She’s not expecting this amount of contact (or Catra’s face so close to hers.) She takes a second to re-adjust the tray on her hip and, after a few moments, slings a responding arm around Catra’s waist. It’s odd; they’ve done this so many times before. But it didn’t feel like this when they were kids (or even teenagers.) She didn’t feel this awe at being allowed to do it, she didn’t marvel at the way Catra fits into her hand back then. But in fairness she didn’t understand what she was feeling back then either.

Catra grins down at the way her fingers are flexing on her side and it has her holding her breath. But the arm around her drags her forward, Catra saying, “It’s fine, okay?”

At least she can breathe again.

Catra sets her free as they settle against the chair - on the floor but leaning back on it. She’s not sure why they do this - the chair is big enough for the both of them - but the view of the sky out the window isn’t something she’d ever complain about. It’s almost nice not being able to see the woods from here; makes her feel isolated from Etheria and all she has to do out there. (Without She-Ra.)

She unstacks the trays, handing food over. “Well you look good.”

She’s expecting an awkward thanks or even an ‘I know’, not, “You really think so?”

She blames that for the, “Uh, yeah,” she so eloquently responds with.

She thinks Catra's biting at the inside of her cheek to stop herself smiling when she hums and looks down at the food now in her lap.

They don't talk all too much while they eat. Because while the Horde hadn't banned talking during meal times, it wasn't like there was all that much time for it. Twenty to thirty minutes maximum depending on how quickly you showered after training. Adora realises they keep seeming to fall into old habits. (In more ways than one.) And despite Catra's prison, she thinks they've never been more free; finally free to be them at least.

She just doesn't know exactly what that means anymore.

"You done?"

She nods and Catra takes the tray onto hers, dropping it on the floor before literally kicking them away.

She snorts quietly at her antics, "Any reason?"

Catra shrugs, "Nope."

She's smiling, eyes closed, as her back slides further down the chair, deeper into the cushion she's sitting on. She turns her head to speak, getting distracted by Catra looking better than she has in a long time only momentarily.

"You know it's kind of funny…"

"What?"

"It's easier to be around you than Bow or Glimmer right now, even with all our shit."

Maybe she uses the swear because of how Catra always used to smile whenever she just *happened* to say one. And while the

smile isn't as wide as it once was, it's still there. It's more than enough for her right now.

Catra bites at her lip, tail curling on the ground before, "Care to tell me why?"

From the way Catra flusters and looks away, Adora knows her joy is plastered obvious as anything on her face. She can't bring herself to care. Catra's asking about her friends - that is pure progress. She's allowed to be happy about it.

"Stop smiling like that, you look like an idiot."

She doesn't even bother attempting to school her features into a less embarrassing expression.

"Bow and Glimmer - well all of us actually - had a falling out a while back. I don't know what they told you but the, um, the Heart and everything - we told her it would...y'know...blow up the planet. She wanted the power I guess, thought we were betraying her by not backing her up, and did it anyway. She's apologised and I've forgiven her, we're all talking again and everything's pretty much normal but…"

She trails off - despite Catra asking, she thinks she won't want to hear about it. But Catra just looks at her, ears attentive. She even turns her body in slightly, tail draping over her legs, and nudges Adora's shoulder. That bright glowy feeling is back in her chest and all she wants to do is wrap Catra up in her arms. But there's not even a way to touch her right now that she can justify.

She turns her body in too, tucks her knees and rests an arm on the chair. "They're just exhausting right now - you're not allowed to tell them I said that -"

"- I won't don't worry." Catra's starting to smile - she did always like things just to be between the two of them.

"They just won't shut up about each other, always asking me if the other one's said anything. And the worst part is that they

always *have*, but they told me not to tell the other so I can't say anything. And you know I'm a bad liar."

Catra kicks her leg lightly and it's stupid that it makes her smile. "You're not so bad. Lied for me enough times to know that."

She tilts her head, thinking, "Guess I did, I didn't have to think about that though, I just did it."

Catra hums. She wishes she could see her thoughts, or have them written down on paper for her to read over and over. She's gotten into reading more since she's been in Brightmoon - the castle actually having books other than instruction manuals - but she imagines none of them could grab her attention quite like Catra can.

"Think of it this way; you're protecting the other one by keeping quiet."

It shocks her for a moment, leaves her wondering simply *how* Catra can just pick her apart like that and *then* word it in a way that'll make sense for her. No one else would do that. No one else would *know* to do that. (Figures Catra is telling her how to *lie* better of all things.)

"Guess I am…"

Catra hits her lightly on the shoulder. "There you go then."

The following silence would be uncomfortable if it weren't them. Maybe she's just caught up in Catra; the way she looks, the way she *acts* nowadays, finally starting to relax around her again. Normally she'd feel guilty (or confused) about doing it, but it's not like her blatant gazing is going unnoticed. Actually, Catra's doing the exact same thing, so she can't see any reason why she *shouldn't* be looking at her. Catra and her really-pretty-short hair.

She doesn't know who cleaned it up, but she hopes it's Catra herself. She's unsure as to why. At first she thinks it's because that means Catra got to control what she did with it. Which is clearly a

good thing; it's not like she's got much control over anything else here. Not what she wears, not what she eats, not who she sees. Catra's always wanted more control than she's had, and really Adora's willing to give her everything she can. It's the least she can do for her now. (Since she finally understands that Catra *has* always felt like that.)

But it's not *just* that. It's also something she doesn't really recognise. Like she doesn't want anyone else to have touched her. Which is stupid because that's not her fucking choice to make. If Catra's comfortable enough to have other people touching her that's a *good* thing. That's *progress*.

Whatever it is she's feeling, she just has to get a grip on it and lock it away with everything else she doesn't understand or want to think about. It's enough to get her to break her gaze at least, moving her focus to the chair's fabric fibers. But that harsh stare only lasts until she feels the wary brush of Catra's tail against her leg, her eyes locking onto that instead.

She probably ought not to gasp at such a small thing but...it's Catra. And things like the instinctive actions of her tail and her ears aren't something she's ever taken lightly. (Even if Catra's insisted over and over again that she really shouldn't; that they're meaningless.) But she forces her eyes back to Catra's face rather than the pinprick point of contact that's making her head fuzzy. (It's not like Catra's ever responded *well* to her pointing out the little things she does, always making her feel too exposed or inhuman.)

Catra's watching her intently still. Looking something like nervous from the alertness present in her ears, and something like amused from the curve of her lip. And she really should not be looking *there* of all places because all it's going to do is make her want things she shouldn't even want in the first place. She needs Catra to do something other than whatever it is she's doing with her tail (which she resolutely will not look at again.)

There is a *reason* why she is letting Catra set the boundaries, but it is so much more difficult than she thought to not push them. That's all she's ever known how to do with Catra; to push and pull, always riding the blurry, uncertain line of what she can and can't do. It's just that in the Before she wasn't so scared of losing her.

Maybe Catra just doesn't know what to say either. Or maybe Adora's just overthinking this… She's definitely overthinking whatever *this* is because Catra just turns her eyes down, sighing quietly.

"Well I guess I hope Arrow and Sparkles get back together."

Despite the names (still with the names) she can tell Catra's not joking. And she may be wrong but it's almost reassuring that Catra's come to that conclusion. Gives her some confidence in herself at least.

She debates for a moment what she's going to tell her - is it breaking her friend's trust if they didn't actually *tell* her anything? But it is just for a moment before she's armed with the justification that they are Catra's friends too now (even if neither she nor Glimmer will admit it, they are.)

"Actually I think that's part of the problem; they're not together like that. They both want to be but they're too scared to admit it. Or talk about it. Or even tell me."

She's half torn between loving and hating Catra's slow smile and the quirk in her brow. "Wow. You figure that out all on your own?"

"I did, actually, so shut up."

Catra fake gasps. "I'm so proud of you."

She can't help preening (inwardly) at the words. They might be laced with mirthful mocking, but they mean everything coming from Catra of all people.

“Bow’s dads came to visit last week.”

Catra picks at her claws. “Yeah he said. You like them?”

Other people might read it as disinterest. She knows her better than that.

“Yeah they’re great. Without the war they finally feel safe enough to leave the library. I gave them the location of a First Ones ruin, so they’ve gone to do field work there.”

“Thought they were librarians? Far as I know they don’t exactly enjoy the outdoors.”

“They’re *historians*. Big difference,” she says with faked seriousness.

Catra snickers at her, “If you say so.”

“I do.” She shoves at Catra’s shoulder, loving that Catra goes along with it. (She may be stronger, but if Catra really didn’t want to move she wouldn’t.) “You know, I think they’d like you.”

Catra rolls her eyes and scoffs, “You’re biased.”

She definitely is. “Maybe. But you’re clever, you’d pick up the things they talk about a lot quicker than I do.” She’s also right.

“You’re smart too, dummy.” She gives Catra an incredulous look; ‘smart’ and ‘dummy’ don’t exactly go hand in hand. “Yeah I know. I stand by it. You may be an idiot Adora, but you’re not stupid.” Catra half mumbles it, but the meaning isn’t lost.

She chews at the inside of her cheek before saying, “Wow. Can’t believe you like me.”

Catra glares, ears down, but fighting a smile. “Shut up. I don’t like you.”

It’s so easy. “Uh huh. I’m just the only one allowed in here because...what, you can’t stand me?”

Catra’s ears flick back to their normal position and her eyebrow quirks up. “Exactly.”

She hums, nodding, before tackling Catra to the ground. Why? She’s not sure. Maybe because it feels strangely safe to do, an easy way to be close to her without the danger of intimacy. Catra yelps before dissolving into laughter. Adora has to reign in the smile she knows wants to appear on her face - she needs to pretend that sound isn’t the best thing she’s ever heard.

She ends up with her hands pinning Catra’s shoulders to the cushions under her. But she didn’t capture her wrists so she gets a shove in the face in return. She’s laughing behind the hand pressed over her mouth. She doesn’t mean to bite down, but her back hits stone when Catra throws her balance off and it happens.

Catra takes her hand away, face all scrunched up. “Ew, gross.”

She shoves at Catra’s chest, grinning. “Says you.”

Catra licks at her own fangs subconsciously, “Guess we’re lucky I’m not in your position then.”

Adora’s suddenly very aware of what her position actually is. There’s a knee holding down one of her thighs that takes her attention first (any increase in pressure might actually land her with a bruise.) It’s not the only thing making her heart pound. It’s also the wrists Catra quickly has pinned to the floor at her sides and the particular rush that comes from a fight, one she relies on more than she cares to admit. And though this version isn’t life-threatening, not bringing forward her single-minded focus she’s gotten used to (wherein She-Ra would start to crackle to the surface), it brings almost the same effect.

There’s something almost like She-Ra bubbling in her veins, something brighter than herself. But it isn’t her. It can’t be. It still feels different. It must just be Catra and the way she makes her

feel - it makes sense, she's gone so unbearably long without the easy joy that she gets from their playful struggles. The distorted version of the feeling she'd received in the portal world not doing the thrill justice, because in that reality she'd never grown to miss it in the first place.

Since she can't gesture with her hands, she knocks her head forward, "Are you trying to give me a bruise?"

Catra actually winces at that, *before* she looks down, *before* she's seen whether or not there's any damage, which she finds strange. "Sorry."

Catra never used to apologise before, no matter how bad the damage was. It sets her on edge a little (which is ridiculous because Catra apologising is a *good* thing.) "It's okay, just let up a little."

Catra does, removing that pin entirely. It's an opening she takes, if only because she doesn't like the shadow that's come down on Catra's face, using her now-free legs to lightly kick her over. She follows, remembering to grab Catra's wrists this time, holding them next to her head.

"Sneaky." Catra's *almost* impressed.

'Good enough.'

"Learned from the best."

The shadow disappears entirely, replaced with satisfaction. There's even the whisper of a purr in the air and fuck, if she'd known complimenting Catra like that would get *this* reaction… Needless to say she's got to do this more. She feels drunk.

But she should've known better than to think for even a second that Catra would just lay there and purr for her (not *for* her but…) The ghostly rumble all but dies as a tooth-filled grin takes over Catra's mouth. (Which apparently Adora has been looking at...again.)

“Didn’t learn enough evidently.”

She doesn’t have time to respond before she gets a knee in the stomach and the instinctual way her body curls in allows for Catra to tackle her to the floor again. Except this time when Catra captures her wrists in her claws, she holds them above her head, and immobilizes her legs with her thighs.

She’s surrounded by the heat given off by Catra’s body and she can’t breathe, can’t think through the warmth and the closeness. She can’t even stop the way she relaxes into the feeling - the exact opposite of what she should be doing. And what’s worse? She doesn’t even *think* of putting up a fight. She can’t blame the way her head tilts back, baring her throat slightly, on anything subconscious. That’s all her; a signal she knows Catra won’t misread or ignore. And she doesn’t, her claws slide in at Adora’s obvious surrender. She doesn’t let go through, or even move at all. It takes Adora a moment to figure out why; feigning surrender to gain the upper hand is a Catra signature move, of course she would think that’s what she’s doing.

But she’s not, she really is just that weak for Catra’s touch, finally soft after more than two years of it being a weapon. Catra’s eyes bore into her, trying to figure out the game where there is none. Both of them are breathing raggedly, more than they should, but given the month off from fighting (and Catra’s whole recovery) it’s understandable. It’s also the fact that Catra is *pinning her to the floor*, but Catra doesn’t have to know that.

She swallows and it might as well be a mistake given the way Catra’s eyes track her throat like the predator she is. (A fact she really ought to remember more.) Catra’s tail lashes behind her and she finally releases her wrists, hands landing either side of Adora’s face. But she doesn’t move, still stunned from heat and touch and *Catra* in her senses.

She (once again) comes to the shattering realisation that the last time they ever did anything even close to this, without adrenaline and *‘danger’* blinding her thoughts, they were on the same side.

Which means that she wasn't aware of her own feelings… Which really explains why this is affecting her so differently. (Beyond the *'it's been so long'*.)

She didn't want to run her fingers along the curve of Catra's hip back then. Well she did, but she didn't *know* that. And if she did, she didn't know *why*. She has got to get ahold of this *soon*, if not *now*. If Catra's going to get as close as this on anything even close to a regular basis she *has* to. Because right now she feels like someone's pushed her head first into boiling water.

Then Catra leaves, hands lifting off the floor as she sits back on Adora's thighs. It feels like someone's pulled a blanket off her body first thing in the morning. But there's also relief; this is a feeling she was at least once used to. Air comes easier when Catra's face isn't inches from her own.

Catra's got her arms crossed over her chest and she's wearing the biggest grin when she says, "Wow. You're out of practice aren't you?"

Dealing with Catra's touch? Yes, she is *very* out of practice. Wrestling? Also a little out of practice. Not like there's much use for it anymore. She shifts up onto her elbows, ignoring how the stone gnaws at the muscle.

"No one else here will train with me. I'm too rough or something."

"Figures Princesses can't handle a punch."

"It's more the tackling to the ground."

Catra shrugs and the intense atmosphere they've manufactured dissolves, much to Adora's relief.

"You could train with me. I know I'm a good actor but I'm so fucking bored in here."

There's hesitancy in her words - like Adora could ever reject an offer like that. Still, she looks at the walls, how undeniably close

they are.

“Not much space in here for it. You’re at a bit of a disadvantage.”

“Aren’t I always?”

“Gods you’re so dramatic... But I’ll ask about making the spell bigger okay?”

“Sounds good.” Catra’s tail waves behind her.

Said tail that suddenly goes stick straight at the sound of the door opening. Adora can’t help a breathy laugh as she collapses back to the floor. She turns her head to be able to look at the door, but it’s not exactly needed since the voice is so familiar.

“Hi Catra - oh.” Bow takes a moment to clock their situation, and while she may be slightly oblivious, she’s not so much so as to not understand the confusion (and apprehension) present on her friend’s face. “Sorry Adora, Glimmer told me you were still asleep. Or maybe she was just hoping. I didn’t think you’d be here, basically, so I came to - yeah.”

“No I - I woke up early.”

“I should’ve figured.”

She’s blushing. She has to be. And Catra *has* to have noticed because when she glances at her out the corner of her eye she’s got a small grin again, just so entirely wicked.

It melts a little when Catra looks back to Bow, still hovering in the (closed) doorway. “It’s fine Bow.”

He doesn’t seem to believe her, looking between them again in a way Adora really does not like. It reads like a study. “I can leave if you want.”

“Adora doesn’t mind, do you?”

She can’t help how she imagines Catra purring with the words, and it’s the biggest mistake of her life. (She wants to bury her face in her hands but that’ll just draw more attention to the red in her cheeks so…)

“Nope. It’s fine. Can you get off me?” It comes out too sharp due to her own - discomfort? Embarrassment? Both?

Catra rolls her eyes and somehow she knows if they were alone she’d shrug and say *‘make me’* and they’d be right back to wrestling on the floor. But they’re not, so Catra dismounts her hips with the supernatural grace that’s always mesmerised her. It leaves her slightly immobilized for all of three seconds.

"You going to stand there, Arrow Boy, or are you going to join us?"

His entire face lights up. "I can come in?"

"I'm offering, aren't I?"

Catra's still acting like...well *Catra* around other people. (An observation that should not have her feeling so happy.)

Bow almost skips as he comes over (which Catra seems to be holding herself back from saying anything about), and the three of them settle onto the now-scattered cushions all over the floor. It occurs to her that outside of her carrying Catra’s dying body, she’s never been in the same room as both Catra and Bow while they were all on the same side. It’s nice - wonderful, actually - but it also means she has no idea how to act at all.

It doesn't help that apparently this is the first time Bow's been invited through the barrier. (Which means he didn't cut her hair, which means Catra did it herself, which means that whatever ugly feeling the thought brought is satiated. A definite good thing; she doesn't have to push it down if it's been resolved.)

Luckily Bow makes the first step into the non-existent conversation, “What were you doing?”

It’s a fair question from...well from anyone who didn’t grow up in the Fright Zone. (She’s had to learn that the hard way.)

“Wrestling, obviously,” Catra answers.

“And that’s...normal for you two?”

“Yup.”

He has his momentary revelation as *something* seems to click. Adora’s not sure if she wants to know what.

“Huh. You know that story makes a lot more sense now.”

Both her and Catra respond with; “Which story?” Though Catra asks it with intrigue, while she has mild dread on her tongue.

There’s a confusion-filled smile before he turns to Catra on the other side of her. “Well I don’t know much, but after like the first few months here Adora tried to tackle Glimmer. Makes sense now.”

“Wait, she told you?” The sudden tension in her body can clearly be seen given the way Catra snickers.

Bow shrugs, “She tells me everything, you know that.”

She lets her head loll back against the chair; she *does* know that. They *have* just gotten back to that place again, so whatever happens right now will probably get regurgitated back to Glimmer sooner rather than later. Given the position Bow found them in, she’s not looking forward to being around Glimmer for the next few days. At least Bow won't say anything directly. Glimmer - Glimmer might.

Catra brushes her tail against her arm (there's only static in Adora's head for a second) and she sounds way too pleased with herself when she says, “Gonna share the whole story, Adora? I think we deserve it.”

She opens her mouth to say no but Catra just gives her this *look* that tells her she'll get it out of her one way or another.

She sighs, "I tried to tackle Glimmer because...because that's just what you do with best friends..."

At least Catra will understand that much. She worries for a moment that Catra will get angry at her for referring to Glimmer as her best friend (Catra didn't even handle her having other *friends* well in the Horde) but she doesn't see anything out of the ordinary.

Catra's actually grinning a little. "Apparently not here."

She throws her arms up. "Well I didn't know that! So I tried tackling her and she teleported...and I was so disoriented by it I fell on my face. Okay, happy?"

Catra laughs, not the way she does when they're alone, but close to it. This is more restrained, and while she's disappointed at the lack of her squeaky giggle, she's unfairly glad she's still the only person who's heard it.

"Of course you fucking did, you dork."

"If you ever get teleported you will *understand*, okay?"

"Oh I'm not letting Glitter's magic anywhere near me. Princesses are one thing, magic is another."

Bow cuts in, "Never know, you ever think you'd be living in Brightmoon?"

"...No. I can honestly say I never *once* thought that."

Bow hums, spinning on the cushion he's sitting on to lie with his head at Adora's feet. Easier to see Catra she supposes. It's so remarkably relaxed.

“Bet there’s lots of things that can happen now that you never thought could.”

Catra scoffs, “That’s not exactly a hard bar to pass.” Bow looks uncomfortable for a second and it’s frankly ridiculous how much pride surges through her when Catra softens further, sighing when she says, “Go on then. Give me some examples.”

Her and Bow meet in a glance, she thinks it reads; *‘I like her.’*

She doesn’t respond. Not out loud anyway.

‘Yeah. I like her too.’

It sounds lovestruck even in her head

Chapter End Notes

> Jealous!Adora makes an appearance because I said so. Girl had Catra to herself her whole life with literally no competition for her affection; therefore, she experiences jealousy and has no idea what the hell it is.
>
> (And since this came out hornier than I intended here's a sidebar: they're both switches and that kinda came through here which really wasn't my fault. I feel like when they make out it's either really soft and loving or its essentially a fight with kissing and there's no in-between. Also people seem to think when it comes to praise kinks it's one or the other. Absolute fools. *Both* of them have praise kinks. Catra wants compliments and Adora wants to be told she's good. It's not rocket science.)
>
> Also just threw some plot in there and this time it was actually on purpose.

Walls: Part II

Chapter Summary

Adora makes good on what she said.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

She's been in this tiny little circle for over a month and a half now. And yet somehow, it manages to feel too short. Adora makes good on what she said and the day comes where Glimmer, Bow, Adora and the former King of Brightmoon come to her prison. It's the most people she's been around at once since before she'd killed Hordak.

Throughout her childhood people had gawked at her; the only one of her species in the Horde as far as she was aware. People got bored of her soon enough, but she still remembers the way they gaped before getting ahold of themselves.

She has never felt more like an exhibit than she does right now.

It has her holding one of her arms, a move unconscious but obvious enough in her discomfort that Adora's shoulders fall and she's rushing to her side. The arm that comes around her back brings her heart rate down from it's spike. As much as she wishes not to, it feels like 'us versus them'. As much as she wishes it not to, it feels like old times.

'That's not a bad thing.' Her selfish head tells her.

Furniture has been coming in through the week. A table and chairs, a mirror, and a bed. It's more than she ever had in the Fright Zone. She's grateful for all of it, even more so the gifts

Adora brings her. (Not that she tells Glimmer that.) It's not much, just some books Adora thought she might like.

(*"You can read?"*
"Yes Catra, I can read.")

But somehow she still manages to wonder if they were able in their youth, whether or not Adora would have done this for her then; brought her gifts if they were given the chance. In some ways she had, and in some ways Adora had. Rocks and little pieces of rubble.

Before all of this though, before she'd known this was even to happen, Adora had come with a box. Something called a 'chess set' and set it down on the floor outside her spell since she didn't have the table yet.

She'd asked, *"What's the point?"*

The whole of the day Adora never lost this soft little smile. It was unfair really, for her to look that pretty, and for Catra to not be able to feel that smile against her lips. But such has always been her life, so unfortunately, she is used to this. Doesn't stop her wanting it with every inch of her being whenever Adora touches her, however innocently.

Adora had shrugged, *"You said you were bored."*

"The point of the game, Adora."

"Oh, strategy. Winning."

That had certainly got her attention. *"Teach it to me?"*

Adora had shook her head, still smiling. *"I'm saving it for a special occasion."* She had waited for Adora to elaborate. *"Glimmer agreed. You get this whole room in a week's time. We're just waiting for King Micah to return from his visit to Salineas."*

"And then I get this whole room to myself?"

"Uh huh."

"Well, tell Glimmer I said thanks."

"How about you tell her yourself, tomorrow? Said she was going to come see you."

And Glimmer had, five days ago. And she's here again now, looking at her father: the not-dead King. He's not at all what Catra might expect a King to be, but Beast Island doesn't sound like somewhere where regality would remain given the *decade* he's spent there. (She ignores the sharp guilt in her mouth; Entrapta.)

Glimmer is holding a vial full of blue light that might as well be star shine. The Queen asks, "You ready?"

She keeps her voice steady, "I guess."

"Can I come in?" Bow asks.

She nods, trying to tamp down the low, anxious wave of her tail. She wonders why he still asks, but it's not like she wants him to *stop*. It's nice. He comes next to her on her other side.

Glimmer and the King set to work spilling the liquid around the edges of the room, its glow getting even brighter as Micah instructs his daughter on the proper way to move her hands. It's so wholly odd to see. She looks to Adora and finds the same feeling there; they're outsiders to this. Family, mentorship, whatever else. She leans into her further. Adora lets her.

The sorcerers work around every wall, moving a potted plant out the way as they go. They even go into the attached bathroom. She watches their every move (mostly because she has no idea what else to do) until it *seems* done. But it must not be because the King is standing on the other side of the not-glass looking at her.

"Hello...uh, Catra is it?" He looks at his daughter for reassurance. Glimmer nods enthusiastically, even Bow gives the King a wary

thumbs up. The oddness just keeps growing. “Can I come in?”

She’s surprised he’s asking (and that he seems to be copying Bow for how to act.) Then again, maybe he doesn’t know what she’s done. There’s more pressing issues to deal with, more crucial things for him to know than her endless series of atrocities. Which makes this a new kind of worrying. First impressions aren’t something she’s ever succeeded with, not something she’s ever tried to get right before. It was the Horde; she didn’t care.

Does this count as a part of her ‘trying’? Probably. She glances at Adora’s face anyway, but there’s no indication of what she should do there.

“Of course...your majesty,” even she flinches a little when she says it. Everyone save the King turns to her sharply. “Yeah it sounded wrong to me too.”

Glimmer snickers a little and Bows smiling though, so aside from her own mild mortification, everything seems to be fine. She can feel Adora smiling at her too, but that one she fights not to look back to.

It really doesn’t take all too long after that. She moves (with Adora still around her) out of the way when needed, careful to not step on the glowing solution. The last of the liquid joins the lines of the old spell to the new, and the King makes a circle of cyan in the air out of nothing. The walls she’s been staring at for so long fall like a curtain to the ground, sinking into the spell lines without a trace before that same rolling blue transparency rises from the ground at the edges of the room. It crawls quickly up the walls before disappearing into the ceiling.

Adora lets her go. She wishes she hadn’t, but she can’t bring herself to move back into her arms. She can’t really bring herself to move much at all. She reasons that it’s magic; after everything, her whole childhood, she’s allowed to feel uncomfortable around it.

She’s watching Glimmer when the Queen tenses, eyes flicking into hers suddenly. She looks different - less blue. She hasn't seen Glimmer without the barrier since, well, since she’d asked her to kill her. It’s not exactly a pleasant thing to realise, and it’s clear she’s not the only one to.

Evidenced enough in how Glimmer sounds a little strained when she says, “Is it weird to say that we’ll let you get settled in?”

She *is* succeeding in not gritting her teeth. “Little bit, Sparkles.”

“Well, we’ll leave you alone then.”

Glimmer tugs on her father's arm, the King turns, looking away from the wall - seeing if the spell worked, she supposes. “It was nice to meet you, Catra.”

She does not think anyone, in her entire life, has *ever* said that to her. It’s really the shock of it that keeps her from laughing. “Nice to meet you too…”

Adora is beaming far too wide at her side.
‘Such a dork.’

(Idly she wonders how long it took Adora to break out of the salute they’d drilled into them as kids, seeing as she doesn’t feel inclined to do so now.)

The sorcerer looks about as sure as she feels comfortable, which really, is not very. “Call me Micah. I never liked the title anyway.”

She feels her ear flick. “Okay. Micah.”

“See you tomorrow?” Bow asks on the way out.

She nods and waves at the three persons leaving, not trusting her voice to be anything other than a bite. She is actually absolutely fine with Bow coming to see her tomorrow, she just does not particularly want him here right now. She doesn’t want anyone but Adora near her right now. Her skin feels itchy with it.

Glimmer, it seems, feels the same way - the not wanting to be near her right now at least. If it were just the two of them, Glimmer would be long gone in a shower of glitter by now. Somehow she knows it's going to be a while before Glimmer comes and sees her again. Alone anyways.

Adora whispers close to her ear once they leave, "You can move, you know."

It makes her jump, which she hates for a lot of reasons, but that smug smile she can *feel* without having to look is the main one. "Shut up, I know that."

"You do?"

It's so fucking stupid that Adora's shitty little attempt at mocking makes her feel so much better. She can feel her toes now (a feeling she hadn't realised she'd lost till then), she can walk past that dreaded line and go over and sit on the - *her* - bed. It's nicer than any bed she's ever seen, but honestly that's not saying much. The blankets are thicker, there's more of them, there's no holes in it, and there's no scents belonging to anyone else clinging to them. The bedframe is still metal but it's slightly mobile - not built into a wall or the floor. And of course, it's pastel just like everything else.

Adora follows her, gesturing at the furniture. "We figured you'd prefer this to a normal Brightmoon bed."

This isn't normal? She should've expected that. She dreads to think, "What are the normal beds like?"

Adora hums. "You ever seen a pastry?"

"...No."

Adora's eyebrow quirks. "You ever seen a cloud?"

She snorts quietly, "Yes, moron, I've seen a fucking cloud."

“Well then you get the idea!”

It’s really cute when Adora starts using her arms when she talks, *especially* when she clearly has no idea she’s doing it. But if she draws attention to it, she’s just going to stop so...

“Take it this is your fault then?” She pats the mattress (and the softest fabric she’s ever felt that’s covering it.)

Adora crosses her arms, fighting a smile. She might even be pouting a little as she comes and sits beside her. “Wouldn’t phrase it like that.”

Okay so she did then. Sometimes she still struggles to trust that Adora even still cares. Despite her coming to see her every day. Despite how readily she accepts her touch. But things like knowing she thinks about her outside these walls well, it helps.

“Oh sorry, would her royal highness like a thank you letter? I’ll go get my wax seal.”

She should really expect the headlock Adora takes her into - it’s been happening a more and more lately. (For pettier and pettier reasons.) She’s missed it. Even the knuckles grinding into her skull as she struggles.

“That would be so thoughtful of you - really nice - and kind - and generous.”

She can’t stop laughing. Even her protests get corrupted with them. Adora too, is trying to muffle her snickering. She scrambles at Adora’s arms around her neck, but without her claws out Adora doesn’t stop. This is what she gets for trying to be better apparently.

“You are worse than the Princesses!”

Adora’s arms let up enough for her to escape and she tries (and fails) to flatten her hair back down at least a little.

Adora looks far too pleased with herself. "'Course I am, I'm an ex-Princess aren't I?"

She flicks Adora's forehead, snickering at her annoyed little exclamation. "Kind of forgot you got a tiara."

Adora doesn't seem to take the words as sound - which she's right to do. She didn't forget. How could she? She doesn't acknowledge it. There's a difference.

Adora looks away, muttering, "You know what...I - I don't know if I miss it."

She suspects Adora was half-hoping she wouldn't hear. But she's an idiot if she ever thought she wouldn't, given that she's right next to her.

She has no idea how to react. Not the words themselves, and definitely not the shame she can pick out of them. She wants to comfort her, she wants to hide. She wants there to have never been She-Ra in the first place but that's never been an option. If someone had asked her even a few months ago, she would've said without a doubt, that Adora loved being She-Ra; being worshipped by the entire planet. But she's learning, ever so slowly, that that was not - has not - ever been the case. Adora doesn't feel like she deserves the praise, or the thanks, for anything she's done. She thinks her best is the bare minimum. If Catra had been anything other than bitter about it, she would've seen that growing up. It's just another regret. As with most things in her life, she finds the roots of things are bathed in shadows and red lightning.

She sighs, tail curling close to her body on the bed. "Guess we haven't really talked about *her* yet…"

Adora's sudden hand on her thigh makes her whole body freeze with shock. Adora's never done *that*. Not anytime that she can remember anyway. The contact leaves practically as soon as it

comes; Adora seeming to realise her own action. She can’t bring herself to look to see how Adora feels about her slip up.

Adora stands swiftly, crossing the room. “And we won’t, not right now. Believe I promised to teach you a game?”

She's not looking at her and suddenly she needs Adora's eyes like she needs air to breathe. She doesn't get them though.

As grateful as she is for not having that conversation right now, she is *concerned*; isn’t she meant to be the one who doesn’t want to talk about things? If anything could make her want to talk about She-Ra, figures it would be Adora *not* wanting to. If only because she wants to know why - there is no reason she can understand that Adora would give up an open opportunity *from her* to talk about a serious matter to teach her a game.

But she’s having trouble thinking, the ghost of a handprint branded onto her thigh and burning reason from her head. (It’s ridiculous, she’s aware.) But she’s still concerned for Adora, regardless of how easily she can render her useless. It filters through when she says, “That you did...Princess.”

“Ex-Princess.” It sounds like Adora’s smiling through gritted teeth. It’s a sound Catra’s familiar with.

'Adora, please, just look at me.'

“Sure. Whatever you say.”

Chapter End Notes

Honestly I was expecting to write the whole of this without Catra calling her Princess. Then this happened. I'm just weak for it ok sue me.

And oh look at that maybe it's some plot.

Micah and Adora get along. So would Castaspella and Catra. If you want me to elaborate on this I will but it won't be in

this fic. (Probably.)

Space

Chapter Summary

It's Catra's turn to try and break some walls.

Chapter Notes

School and this chapter kicked my ass this week I'm sorry.

(Also let it be known I love Adora *in spite of* her hair poof.)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

It didn't take all that long for her to be comfortable with the extra space. She had lain in the bed long enough that it started smelling like her, after that it was back to the same thing she'd done every other day. (With some added reading and trying to remember which of the intricate little stone pieces could move where.)

When Adora arrives today, she's...weird. Hovering in the doorway and looking uncomfortable - worried. Not enough that it permeates the air, but enough that her anxiety is contagious. She gets closer on instinct, watching how Adora reacts carefully, the blonde watching her in turn. Only a few feet between them and some tension slips from Adora's shoulders.

She resists the urge to reach out for Adora's hand, instead settling for taking the trays from her. "What is it?"

Adora can't meet her eyes. "I know you like your space. And I don't want to make you feel like you *have* to be near me."

"Adora…" she admonishes, but it trails off.

There's really no way for her to say, *"You're so fucking stupid, I always want you near me dumbass,"* without raising a lot of

questions she cannot answer.

She sighs, getting a grip on one of Adora's wrists and dragging her over to the table. (They can actually eat at a table now, it's a rather novel thing.) She lets go and sits, setting the trays out while Adora hesitantly takes the opposite seat. She's relaxing a little more every second but it's not enough. It leaves her thinking of what to say, the both of them eating as she does so.

She drums her claws on the wood, swallowing down the bacon in her mouth. "If I want space I'll ask, okay?"

Apparently that's all Adora needed because the tension drains away entirely. "Promise?"

"Promise."

Adora sighs, leaning back in her chair. "Okay, okay that's good. Yeah, that's -"

She can't help snickering lightly as she takes another bite. "Good?"

"Yeah."

She points her fork at her. "You're an idiot. You know that?"

Adora rolls her eyes. "I ought to, given how often you remind me."

"Just keeping your ego in check."

Adora rests her elbow on the table, hides her smile behind a loose fist. It fades though, as much as Catra doesn't want it to. Adora's hand falls back to the table, her fingers beginning to worry a path along the edge of it.

"Catra I'm - I'm going away again. Salineas. Four days."

'Why do you sound so nervous?'

She's disappointed, of course she is. But she's getting used to it; that and holding onto the hope that Adora's coming back. That she's not leaving her. That she's not going to be without her again. She handled almost three years, she can *handle* less than a week.

"When?"

"Three days from now."

'Why won't you look at me?'

She pauses, staring Adora down until her eyes flick to hers. It's a win, a small pitiful one, but a win nonetheless. Maybe acting like nothing is wrong would be the better way to go about getting answers, but it's a little too late for that. She leans back, arms crossing and tail flicking.

"Who's going with you?"

Some of the wood varnish is under Adora's fingernails now. "Bow...and Glimmer."

'There it is.'

"...I'll be alone."

There's pity and apologies in Adora's eyes now. She doesn't know whether to be insulted or touched that Adora's finally starting to understand.

"Yeah. Is there - is there *anyone* else you want to come see you?"

She has an answer, an answer so clear it makes her dizzy. Scorpia... And subsequently every heartbroken, disappointed face she's ever caused her to wear.

"I - I'll think about it."

Adora informs her they've dismissed the guards outside her room since it's clear the spell won't break. It's a boring topic of conversation (even if it eases her to know a little), and she tires of it quickly when Adora keeps explaining exactly why Glimmer chose to do it. (Glimmer is wary of being around her without a barrier but she wants to show her good faith is essentially what it boils down to.)

"You know there *is* something else we can do."

"Oh yeah and what's that?" Adora says as she collects their trays onto one.

"Well, I seem to recall that there was a reason why I suddenly have all this room."

Adora raises her eyebrow. "You want to fight?"

"Train. But sure."

The speed at which Adora leaves her chair has her laughing. It's like someone just flipped a switch, energy suddenly flowering through her. It's nice to see that again.

"Wait, do you *want* me to go get staffs from the gym?"

It's cute that she's asking, seeing as Adora's clearly already assumed that's what they'd be doing anyway. And while Catra hadn't actually thought of that, the distance staffs provide will help. Hand-to-hand is an excellent excuse to be a little more touchy than they have been (not that either of them have exactly been sparing in contact), but she really should be taking any opportunity to limit her suffering. She already wants to kiss her every second they're together, and it's not like contact helps that in any regard.

She's both excited and dreading it. She has missed just simply *moving*, missed sparring with Adora even more. But the scent of Adora's sweat is not something she's ever forgotten and given how much she has *not* been ignoring her feelings this could get

overwhelming very quickly. Then there's the whole matter of Adora's muscles which...really she has not fully considered the consequences of this agreement. If Adora pins her like last time, gods if she *purrs* again like she did last time...

But with the way Adora's looking at her, so shamelessly *beaming* at her because of this. She really is helpless but to agree. She gives a one shoulder shrug, trying not to let how much she loves this absolutely ridiculous woman show. "If you want."

Adora practically jumps as she half-sprints from the room.

She spends the wait warming up unused muscles, her daily stretches not doing all that much to keep them strong. She's still thrilling at even the prospect of doing this again. Almost obnoxiously so. (Not as much as Adora, but she *gets it*.) She tries to crush it down a little before remembering that she doesn't have to; they're alone.

She's not looking at the door when it opens. Her ears flick back towards the noise, she hears something pass through the air and she catches it with muscle memory alone. It has her smirking, just a little.

"Good to know some things never change."

She spins, finding Adora just in her white shirt and still smiling like she doesn't know how to do anything else. (She wants to get rid of it, but the only two options for that she can see is to be mean or to kiss her, both of which she is *not* going to do.)

"Oh things have definitely changed."

Adora stretches her arms out and Catra has to pointedly look absolutely anywhere else. Mostly at her own claws that she flexes. They haven't got started yet; she doesn't have anything to blame her flush or dry throat on.

"Enlighten me."

She gets closer on instinct, ignoring the warning signs her rational mind starts yelling. “No wardens...no superior officers - *no Shadow Weaver* - I don’t have to play by the rules any more.”

Adora scoffs lightly, “As if you ever played by the rules.”

She can’t help her own obnoxious grin. “Fair. But did I ever use my claws when we trained?”

She loves how Adora’s eyes drop to her hands when she registers the familiar sound of those claws making themselves known. Adora’s shoulders drop as she thinks, that is until Adora’s smiling again slowly. “...You didn’t, did you?”

She’s unsure as to why Adora’s got an unfamiliar shine in her eyes. She can’t help pushing at it, just because it’s fun. (Just because she wants to look at it forever.) “Or my teeth.”

That shine gets brighter and Catra has no idea what *exactly* she’s done to elicit it, but she will spend the rest of her life trying to figure it out if she needs to.

Adora readies her staff. “Don’t hold back on me.”

“Wasn’t planning on it Princess.”

She would say Adora is nervous by the way she swallows but it’s offset by the undying smile on her face. It’s a power rush to say the least, on both accounts.

It’s a well known dance. One easy to fall into; their push and pull and lashing like the sea. She feels younger, carefree in a way she hasn’t known since she was a preteen. She’s smiling, but she’s sure there’s not much else to it other than teeth.

“So this whole ‘Princess’ thing, how long are you gonna keep it up?”

She gets closer. They are *training* after all, and she's always been allowed to touch her when they're like this. "Does it bother you?"

Adora's ready to parry her again - it's not like she was trying to hit her anyway - when she knocks her staff. Another warm up move if anything until she hooks the ends of the staffs together to try and twist it out of Adora's grasp. All it does is pull her off center. She spins behind her, taking the opportunity to drag her tail against Adora's side before backing off again.

Even with the few feet between them she can see the flush in Adora's cheeks, can blame it on her actions rather than adrenaline if she really wants to. And she does. Because apparently she wants to torture herself today.

"No - no it's...fine. I'm just surprised it's not bothering *you*."

She keeps moving, because it's how she's always fought, because it means Adora can't sink her feet into the ground. Her claws clink against the staff as she adjusts her own grip. "Oh it does. But messing with you is worth it."

Adora's not making any more moves towards her, whole body showing hesitance Catra doesn't want, so she figures she's going to have to do it herself. It's not even a remotely calculated move, just a leap forward to try and goad Adora into trying to hit her properly. It works though, Adora swiping at her sides with the end of the staff. She dodges it easily, pushing her own staff like a bar across Adora's chest but it's blocked.

It's faster than she was expecting. She is absolutely *not* impressed. Adora's got that fucking smirk on her face - that cocky one she never really let anyone else see because it was *unbefitting* of a future Horde officer. Which just made Catra love it more, even if it made her so fucking angry sometimes.

"And you call me predictable."

'There she is.'

She knows she's been relaxing around Adora, that they're always getting closer to what they were before. But Adora's been holding back on her too, it's nice to see her just *be* finally.

If Adora's even slightly wary of her claws so close to her throat she's not showing it. She should be - she has *permission* to use them finally. She's still pushing against Adora when she leaves light scratches along one of her legs with her toe-claws, only hard enough to cut the fabric and maybe leave some white lines. Adora stumbles, clearly unprepared for it, and Catra uses it to sweep her legs out from under her.

"Only because you are."

Adora huffs a strand of her hair out of her face once she gets the air back in her lungs, most of it having left once she hit the stone floor. They hadn't used mats in the Horde, but that doesn't mean if they have the option now that Catra is going to say no.

She gives Adora time to raise her staff as a block before she's pushing down again. They've definitely been here before. Adora's got added strength - added muscle - on her side, but Catra's got gravity and dirty tricks. She's also got one of Adora's thighs trapped beneath her bladed toes. She curls them just slightly, and uses Adora's distraction to get another couple of inches on her.

"While I have you here, is there anything you want to tell me?"

She's not sure where it comes from exactly; it's not a distraction technique. She just knows she's been thinking about Adora's odd, *deflecting*, behaviour since yesterday.

Adora's eyes snap up, and if she weren't already panting from the effort she might be from the panic Catra's question seems to start up. It's not what she was going for and she does feel a little guilty, but there is something she is trying to do here. (She cannot be distracted from how the blood, high in Adora's cheeks, makes her eyes bluer right now.)

"What, no? Of course not."

Her arm shakes a little when she says it and Catra takes that to mean she's not entirely wrong in her assumptions - Adora would brag for what felt like hours whenever she set a new plank record. (It was, at most, maybe a passing comment, she was just insecure *and* impressed, it didn't make for a good mix.) And while she's not making it *easy* for her, it's not hard compared to what both of them are used to. But this knowledge makes her confident enough to push a little more, whittle her way under Adora's skin since she's apparently so very good at it. When she gets close enough she can hear Adora's heart beat thundering.

"Maybe talk about something you've been avoiding?"

Adora straightens up her arms with enough force to send her sprawling to the side. Which is her fault, she should've seen that coming. Adora returns to their position, the hair falling from the band dripping like golden vines now they're reversed.

"Catra I don't know what you're -"

She manages to keep her snort to a flick of her ears. "Yes you do - tiara ringing a bell?"

Adora sets her jaw, face carefully blank. She doesn't say anything. Catra's arms twinge from the continuous force she's putting into holding Adora's body weight above her. Figures Adora's not holding back *now*. It takes a couple moments for her to decide what she's going to do, but then she shifts her grip, both hands at the right end of her staff. Adora clearly doesn't know what she's intending to do, but that's a good thing. It means she's not prepared for it when she collapses her arms in, catching Adora before flipping her onto her back.

She throws her own staff to the side so she doesn't end up with it accidentally pressed up against Adora's throat. But she keeps her claws out, digging carefully into the skin and fabric at the base of Adora's neck as she keeps herself upright.

Adora's staff ends up lying across her chest, she's not even holding it anymore, or making any moves to fix that. No, her hands are holding Catra's shoulders from the fall. She can smell her here, the only reason she's able to think through it being that Adora hasn't begun sweating like she thought she would. Makes sense she supposes, actual fighting added onto training made both of them fitter in the long run.

She focuses on trying to talk rather than the fact that she is once again straddling Adora on the floor of her room. (And that Adora isn't trying anything to push her off. Again.) She pulls her claws in, Adora's hands softening on her as well in response. It doesn't seem gentle enough for what she's trying to do - she's still essentially holding her down. It's stupid - *so* fucking stupid of her - but she reaches a hand up, brushes Adora's hair out of her face before returning the hand to its place.

Adora's whole body freezes, including her breathing, before relaxing slowly into it. She doesn't look *upset*, the only reason she's not stopping and pretending this never happened, just confused. She wonders what reason Adora will come up with for her doing this, but she really has no idea. And she doesn't care right now. She will. But not yet.

"I know I have absolutely no right to demand for you to talk to me but...please? I want - I want you to be able to talk to me okay?"

Adora's still as surprised from the juxtaposition of her actions and words as she was a few minutes ago. It takes a couple of moments for her to catch up with what she's asking. She still looks confused. "I do - I do want to talk to you."

'Then act like it.'

She's just glad she manages to hold her tongue for once in her life. But she doesn't bother to hide how she doesn't believe the words Adora is giving her.

Adora's looking at her shoulder when she says, "...You win this round. Can you let me up?"

Not even Adora willingly giving up a fight is going to get her to drop this. Which really is a testament to her own stubbornness if anything.

"Are you not even going to admit that something is bothering you?" The tips of her claws catch in Adora's shirt again. She doesn't care.

Adora stays silent. For a full minute. (She counts.) But whatever it is she's doing must be working, because Adora turns her head sharply so she's glaring uncertainly at the far wall, whole body deflating when she says, "Fine! Something's bothering me! Happy?"

Not entirely. But its a fucking start.

She's not sure how much more she could get out of her if she kept Adora here, but that option dies as soon as a purr bubbles out of her throat at Adora's admission. It cuts out as soon as she realises she's doing it, less than a second really, but with Adora *underneath* her, she heard. And Adora's head snaps back to her at it.

She can only assume Adora's thinking *'it makes you* that *happy?'* Or something similar. She half scrambles off her, collecting her staff from the floor and finding a starting place on the other side of the room. Her tail won't stop flicking. Adora meanwhile forces herself into a sitting position, slowly making her way to standing, pole back in her hands. Steel eyes study her for a second, making Catra solidify her own version of Adora's thoughts.

"I'm not *avoiding* talking about her. I'm just *not* talking about her."

It's bullshit. But it's something. She knows if Adora weren't holding something she'd be rubbing at the back of her neck. "Thought we said no more lies." It's got more bite than she meant.

Technically neither of them had said it aloud, but they might as well have. It's clear she's not the only one to read it like that with the way Adora curls in on herself. She mumbles, "I don't want to talk about it."

'Yeah no shit.'

"You know that just makes me want to talk about it more, right?" She manages to keep it soft, if a little teasing, this time.

Adora sighs, but she doesn't sound upset. "...Of course it does."

"Tell me. Please."

She has never said please so much in her fucking life. She thinks it's about as close to begging as she's ever come to. She knows Adora knows that. She hates that it would be so easy to pry her open; all it would take is one *'Please, for me?'* and Adora's selfless obligation would dictate that she has to. But she wants Adora to come to her (at least somewhat) willingly.

Adora's clearly deliberating in her head as she circles the floor. Really all she's doing is walking, staff loose in her hands. Catra keeps the distance, mirroring her. If she needs to keep her moving, that's fine.

"I don't want you to worry." Adora winces, whether it's from the words, or the sound of her staff scraping along the floor, she's not sure.

"Guess what genius, I'm already worried."

Adora looks confused for a moment; like she couldn't believe *Catra* worries about her too. She's almost insulted. "Catra I'm…I don't want you to. I don't want *anyone* to."

She forces herself not to growl, it won't help anything. "Adora…"

There's so much *shame* on her face. It's fraying Catra's nerves more with every second. She hadn't realised it was necessarily

nerves she is feeling but she's sure of it now.

"Your friends are always going to worry about you when you don't fucking tell them what's wrong, idiot." It was *meant* to be half-teasing. It comes out more sad than anything else.

"Guess I didn't think about it like that… Everyone else lets things like this go."

"I'm not like everyone else here, so you can trust that I won't… Not anymore." She mumbles the last bit to the wind that's gently carding through the room. Adora hears it; she must do with the way her posture falls slightly.

Catra drops her staff to the floor, walking over slowly enough that Adora could move away if she wants space. (Not that it's something Adora's ever asked for before, but a lot of things have changed, she sees no harm in offering.) But Adora stays rooted to her spot, that sadness never really leaving. She doesn't even flinch when Catra's hands, carefully clawless, hold onto her arms. She can't stop the twitch of her ears when the metal clangs to the floor.

She takes a steadying breath. "Do you not want to tell *me*, or this a no-one-knows situation?"

As much as she wouldn't like it, she could deal with the first option. Adora has other people to help her now. And it's not like she *wants* to talk about feelings, she just wants Adora to feel better.

"...The second one."

She takes a moment to figure out where the fuck to go from here. There's really only one thing she can think of. "Chair or bed?"

"Huh?" Adora's confusion is fair, it's quite a leap in conversation topic.

"Fine, I'll pick."

Adora’s basically standing in front of the armchair anyway. She pushes her backwards until the back of her legs hits the cushions, then climbs on after, settling into the opposite side and holding her arms out. She wants Adora to come *willingly*.

Adora doesn’t hesitate *too* much before she's realising what this is and crawls over and into her arms, swinging her legs over. She keeps her chin resting on Adora’s head (on top of her stupid hair poof) rather than burying her nose in her hair. She still needs to actually pay attention if Adora speaks.
But Adora doesn’t. For such a long time it makes her tail start twitching. Which Adora notices because *of course* she does. Adora bundles deeper into her neck and she has to stomp down on the purr that’s sitting eagerly on her lungs.

“I’ll - I’ll talk, okay? Just give me a minute to try and...yeah.”

She hums an affirmation. Words have never come easily to either of them. And when it comes to the truth, right now at least, she is more than happy to wait.

“I just feel like people are disappointed.”

She can’t stop the way her hand tenses on Adora’s shoulder. Adora had shifted before she spoke - a silent sign that she was ready. It stops her reacting any more than she already has.

“Because She-Ra’s gone?”

Adora's been holding her breath against her neck, but at that she feels her inhale weave through her fur. Then a miniature nod. She didn’t think Adora could curl in anymore. “Yeah... The only reason I’m here - that I was even allowed in the Rebellion - is because of her. Now I - I don’t know.”

If there was ever a time for her to not move, it would be now. She forces her tail not to snap. She wants to growl against the outright absurdity of the idea; that the Rebellion wouldn’t want her

otherwise. The best soldier Catra's ever known, and Adora doesn't think a side - that was close to losing a war - would want her. Thinks they wouldn't want her *now*, even after she saved *every last one of them*.

"That's bullshit. Even without She-Ra, you would've joined the Rebellion as soon as you found out what the Horde was doing. You're too good not to. And they would've been just as fucking grateful of you because you - you're amazing."

"You really think so?" She thinks Adora's trying for teasing but it comes out confused.

"I will not be repeating that outside of this moment okay? But yeah… And Glimmer doesn't let you stay here because you're a Princess -" Adora pokes her stomach weakly. "- Were a Princess. You're one of her best friends and you live here, idiot."

Adora still sighs deeply. "Everything would be so much easier if I hadn't destroyed the sword… She-Ra is gone and it's all my fault." Adora's hands fist in the front of her clothes, she can feel the rigidness in Adora's jaw against her skin. "Fuck, Catra, I'm useless without her, okay? Is that what you want to hear?" The sudden volume shift has her jolting.

"What? No! No I don't - I - she's gone because you did the right fucking thing! How the fuck can you be useless when you saved *everybody*?"

"I'm not saving anybody *now* am I?" And just as Adora's voice breaks, Catra clutches her as tight as she can.

"You don't have to, the war is over, no one expects you to do that anymore."

"But they do - they all do. Everybody expects me to know what to do all the time, but I don't. I knew how to plan battles, I *learnt* how to be She-Ra. Everyone loved her, looked up to her - to me - for answers. They still do and I just...I just don't have them

anymore. They all want me to be *her* again but they know I can't and they...it's the way they look at me."

"How do you think they look at you?"

"Like I'm not useful to them anymore."

"That's bullshit -"

"- Catra."

"No, no, you're going to fucking listen to me, okay? You told me I'm worth something when I thought that was as far from the truth as you could get, but I'm trying to believe it because you said it, so I'm going to do the same for you. You have so many people that care about you. You don't need to be useful to people for them to care about you. And if they think you do, they're not worth it and I'll kick their ass."

There's a pitiful little chuckle. "What, from in here?"

"Well you'll have to bring them here, but yeah... I know I can't stop you feeling like this but - but I want to help. You're not a fucking burden, Adora. You've *never*, not fucking *once*, been a burden. To me or anyone else."

Adora pries her hands from her shirt, and they shake as they slide round her waist. "...I don't - I don't really believe you. But I'll try."

It takes a minute's deliberation before she allows a whispering purr out of her throat. It's barely even a sound, a light, continuous trembling in her chest. It's been so long since she's let it loose without the immediate panic needed to choke it down. But the obvious hitch in Adora's breath is worth it; the way she traces patterns on her spine to keep it going is worth it.

"That's all I'm asking."

“Suppose I was bound to have my turn at this, wasn’t I?”

“It’s only fair.”

Adora

The next day starts the same. She gets up with the moons, pacing the length of her room, stretching occasionally, till it’s time for her to leave.

Catra acts no different than she did yesterday, which is a bigger relief than she was expecting. She doesn’t - didn’t - judge her for what she said. What she admitted. What she did. She is still reeling from the feeling of Catra’s arms around her, of her face in her hair, of her purr bouncing around her chest alongside her heartbeat.

She blames that for why Catra wins three out of the five rounds when they manage to get a *proper* training session in. She can’t bring herself to care that much, not when Catra’s grinning almost constantly and her ears keep pricking up every time she gets her on the floor like she wasn’t expecting it to work. She’s just adding to her scattering of bruises, but it doesn’t matter. They’ll heal soon enough.

She knows they’re both aching afterwards from how long it’s been since either of them have done anything like it. Especially against each other - even Brightmoon guards won’t throw her around as rough as Catra used to. And still does evidently. There was a reason her and Catra were top of their classes.

“We’re going to train again when you get back right?” Catra asks as she’s stretching out her arms.

Which Adora does not look at. She is looking at Catra’s *face* because she is *speaking* and that’s what she is *meant* to do.

“Yeah, of course.” She can’t imagine going back to the world where she doesn’t get to do this.

Catra's tail waves slowly with her satisfaction at her answer. "Now go shower, you reek."

If she weren't almost at the opposite side of the room, she would shove her shoulder. "Says you."

She lays the staffs in her hand against the wall and collects the trays from the table before heading to the door. Catra's ear flicks when she looks back at her but she doesn't think anything of it.

That is until she puts a hand on the door handle and Catra calls, "Adora?"

"Yeah?"

It's clear Catra wasn't expecting herself to speak either. Her ears are back and Adora doesn't know whether to push the issue or ignore it.

"It's nothing. Forget I said anything. I'll see you tomorrow?" Even Catra winces at just how forced it sounds.

She half-throws the trays in her hands to the floor, going over to Catra with increasingly wary steps. Catra doesn't flinch again, whole body almost eerily still. But she still lets her hold onto the tops of her arms, a movement familiar enough to be safe. (Not that many instances wherein she used this move ever went *well* before. She'll just have to hope it's different this time. And besides, Catra did it for her yesterday.)

"Catra?" she tries.

She's expecting it when Catra tries to turn away from her, but her grip won't let her. Catra won't look at her and she's got her jaw set. So she tries something new.

"Tell me. Please?"

It's what got *her* to open up yesterday, figures she might as well try to employ it right now. Doesn't mean she's *ready* for when it

actually (starts) to work.

“Can you…?”

“Can I what? Catra, whatever you ask, I’m not going to be angry, okay?”

“It’s selfish... I’m not meant to be that anymore am I?”

Her heart fucking melts. Catra looks so worried about this. She really shouldn’t be. Sure, she’s not *meant* to be selfish. But selfish and bad don’t necessarily mean the same thing with Catra, at least not anymore.

She loosens her grip - enough that Catra could escape if she wanted - before sliding her hands carefully up to hold onto Catra’s shoulders. She lowers head to try and get her to meet her eyes. “I won’t tell anyone if you don’t.”

It gets a weak laugh at least. “You’re such an idiot… I just - can you come back later?”

“Why?”
It comes out before she can stop and she knows she’s fucked up. Catra’s ears flatten against her head fully and her head all but molds itself to her chest.
“- No, no, I mean I’d lov- I’d like to. I really would. You don’t need a reason, okay? I was just surprised. I’ll come back with dinner.”

She squeezes Catra’s shoulders under her hands to try and ease her further. It must work a little considering the way one of Catra’s hand comes up to hold onto one of hers when she looks back.

“You sure?” Her ears are slowly coming back to their regular position.

“*Yes*. I’ll come back and I’ll stay as long as you want me.”

Catra squeezes her hand, but there’s a melancholy in Catra’s eyes she doesn’t understand.

Chapter End Notes

Literally Catra doing anything with her muscles (which she definitely has) or claws or teeth (now they're on the same side) Adora is just absolutely weak for. We all saw Shot In The Dark.
Adora: What do those claws do? Destory? Amazing. Marry me.

This got way more emotional than I intended holy shit. They were just meant to fight and then Adora was going to come back later and then boom, She-Ra. It's gonna get gay next chapter :)
(Not that this wasn't gay but...)

Where Do You Want Me? (How Do You Want Me?)

Chapter Summary

They always were better in the dark.

Chapter Notes

If you've read Don't Go. Well.
This is very tender if I do say so myself.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

"I'll stay as long as you want me."

'I always want you. That's the problem.'

She half expects Adora not to come back. She wonders if she'll ever trust in her staying the way she once did - them against the world forever. Childish wishes, she knows, for a childish sentiment. But she believed it, she believed *so hard* in everything Adora said. Or at the very least she wanted to.

The trust - that faith - shattered. They're rebuilding. But it's not *fixed*. So all that's left for her to do is pace around her room (despite the ache in her muscles) until nightfall.

It wasn't all that often that Adora worried about things, but when she did, well...she can end up looking as Catra does now. (Except Adora doesn't have a tail she can't keep still, or senses that kick into overdrive with her stress.) It would be her job to ease her with reason or playful taunts, but that's never really run true in reverse, mostly because she's never worried about something this way.

How can she handle the pressure of battle, of lying to the faces of those who look for any excuse to extinguish her, and not something as simple as waiting for Adora to make good on a promise? Unfortunately she knows herself well enough now to realise it's because Adora *didn't* promise anything. She's relying entirely on that broken faith. Gods Adora makes her a wreck.

Her whole body locks up whenever she hears footsteps outside her door, and she has to crush down her hope before the wave grows too much. It's a painful thing to drown in - she doesn't have to have experienced it to know that.

She holds onto her own arms tightly when she hears footsteps for the fourth time. Only these halt without fading. The first of the evening moons have risen. But it still takes Adora actually opening the door and stepping inside for her to fully believe that she's *here*.

"Hey."

She can't stop the way her whole body sinks with relief. She resists hugging Adora within an inch of her life, resists her hugging her at all, staying on the opposite side of the room.

"Hey Adora."

She curses herself for the softness of it.

"Can I turn on a light?"

She nods, not comfortable trusting her voice not to betray her right now. She braces herself, but it's not needed. The light isn't as bright as she expects it to be, it takes her all of a few seconds to clock the waiting look Adora gives her, hand still on the switch; clearly this was intentional. She makes a mental note to figure out how to do that later while rolling her eyes.

She sits at the table, tail snapping when Adora doesn't move at first, "Sit your ass down, I'm hungry."

Adora takes the opposite seat with a fond huff.

She tries to not stare while they eat. It doesn't work. Adora looks different like this, ridded of the warmth of daylight; silver in her hair, only grey in her eyes. Simultaneously harsher and softer, drawing her in, dangerously so.

"Something wrong?"

She shakes her head. An answer and a method of ridding her hopeless thoughts. One that Adora doesn't take - or maybe she just doesn't care - getting up and pulling her chair round so they're adjacent. Her face so annoyingly *open* while she tries to gauge Catra's reaction. It means a lot that Adora's trying so hard to make her comfortable, even if it is stupid.

She rests her head in her left hand, starts eating again as if it'll distract from how her tail brushes unwittingly against Adora's leg. She knows it would fully curl around her ankle if Adora were close enough. But that touch is enough to have her blonde idiot beaming anyway.

'She's not yours, she's never yours.' She wonders how many times in her life she'll have to remind herself of that.

Once again they fall into silence during the meal. That's fine by her. What's not so fine is the little looks Adora keeps shooting her. She's keeping her gaze firmly on the food in front of her for a *reason*. She can't let herself look because she'll just end up staring at the bruise-blue shadows catching on the side of her face. Adora just has to make everything that much more difficult for her.

"Now what?" Adora questions when they're done.

She hums, thinking it through somewhat in her head before getting up. First things first, she turns all the lights back off. (Even if the dimmer lights didn't hurt her head, they're not preferable for what she plans to do.) Next she drags her bed over in front of the window, followed by the armchair as a strange headboard. She's not really sure why.

When she looks back Adora's got this amused little smile, and finishes her drink before coming over.

"Princesses first," she says with a mocking bow and a knock of her tail against Adora's hand. It gets a little laugh from her at least. Adora gets as far as sitting before, "Wait, stop, jacket and shoes off on my bed."

Adora huffs but complies. She ought not to relax so much from simply seeing Adora without her jacket, but it's always been something akin to special for her. She knows it makes Adora feel a little exposed, but she'll do it for her and that...well it means a lot. (Adora knows all this of course, it's why she does it in the first place.)

"So what *are* we doing?"

"Stargazing."

Her younger self would make excuses for this; something along the lines of, *'you brought back the stars dummy, who else would I ask about them?'* And while she may be too proud to admit out loud she just wants to look at the sky with her best friend, she has not even considered trying to fool herself.

Adora looks confused for a moment before standing. She takes a light hold of her hand to lead her towards the window, luckily letting go before the barrier.

"Then wouldn't it be better out here?" Adora says to the night air, clearly not realising she hasn't followed her out.

“Adora…” she swears she was going to call her stupid. She swears she was, but if she thought Adora was stunning in the artificial light of her room. It’s nothing compared to Adora in the moonlight, looking back at her with her eyes shining brighter than any of the stars outside. She wants to see her with her hair down, she knows it would catch in the breeze like a halo. It’s better this way though, a small saving grace; she doubts she would breathe otherwise, and her feelings are already bordering choking as is.

“I can’t,” she manages to breathe out.

She hates how clearly she can see Adora’s shoulders sink. “Right, right, sorry.”

She climbs into the armchair, leaving enough space for Adora beside her. Which Adora fits herself into easily when she passes back through the barrier with an almost completely suppressed shudder. Catra tells herself she doesn’t notice; that she is watching the sky intensely the whole time. She does not trust herself not to say something she’ll regret right now.

She hopes Adora doesn’t notice how her fur bristles slightly when they both settle - the ghost of space between them promising to drive her crazy.

‘It’s better this way, it’s better this way, it’s…’

“I hope you can see them one day, without the barrier.”

She goes to say ‘me too’ before she becomes concerned as to whether or not that is a lie. Getting rid of the barrier she has no qualms with. It’s what must come with that; leaving, the world outside, everyone else she’s ever hurt. Things she should do, things she’s been using the excuse of that very barrier to avoid. (Things like Scorpia, Entrapta, the water Princess and her destroyed Kingdom, the late Queen, the list is endless.)

So she doesn’t say anything. She doesn’t have to worry about her fur anymore, the dampening on her mood returning it to normal. She feels her tail curl in empty space.

“Sorry I - I know you don’t think you’re getting out of here.”

“Adora -”

Adora misreads her tone, “Yeah I know, I’ll shut up.”

“That’s not - tell me about the stars.”

“Oh...ok. Well -“

There’s not many stories, not that she was expecting volumes. There’s people she doesn’t know when Adora talks, *“Razz once told me Mara was from the stars.”* People she’ll never meet but is starting to get to know anyway. She doesn’t even know how to feel about Adora’s She-Ra (she catches herself before she starts thinking of it as *her* She-Ra because that is ridiculous. It's also her second slip up of the day.) She can’t afford to feel conflicted about one from a thousand years ago.

Adora looks wistful, if a little hurt, as she talks about her - Mara - and the things she did. Catra can’t bring herself to ask her to stop. Not when Adora gets closer, wholly unaware she’s even doing it. It shouldn’t make her heart ache nearly as much as it does. This tension she’s sitting in that’s making her heart race, it’s made out of her own feelings; it’s not real. Adora wouldn’t hesitate to touch her as she does right now because it wouldn’t mean anything more to her.

“The stars had names once…”

She can’t dwell on almosts. She shifts from the armchair onto the mattress to be able to see more of the sky, new clusters of white speckles appearing on the horizon. Adora follows anyway, feet getting tangled in the blankets.

“You know that just means we can make up our own, right?” she half-teases when Adora’s beside her again.

She regrets saying it. Adora shouldn’t be able to smile like that; easy with her eyes closed like there’s nothing else in the world to think about. Adora shouldn't be able to hum and have her enraptured like a child hearing a new story. And she certainly shouldn't be able to look at her like nothing bad has ever happened between them. But she does, for a moment at least, before turning back to the sky, raising her arm and pointing. Adora leans into her and she freezes, she knows it's just so she'll be able to follow where she's looking but really stars are the last thing she's thinking about with Adora and her warmth blanketing her side.

“Alright, that cluster there - what would you call that?”

She waits for Adora to move away because she really cannot think about stars when Adora's chin is practically on her shoulder. She allows herself a single look as Adora lowers her arm, glad of having enough self control to not be caught staring at her smile. The sky is almost dull in comparison.

This isn't a memory - she knows that - but it feels like it. Them side-by-side and looking at the sky. It’s not exactly like when they’d make patterns out of smoke-stained clouds on rooftops, always shifting and changing and fading. Stars stay. This she could write down and come back to again and again.

“*Entrapta*.”

Adora hums again, considering this time, and her hand twitches in the space between them. Which just makes her *annoyingly* aware of it.

“Why?”

She suddenly regrets saying anything. Because it’s not like she has any good reason to not elaborate. “Looks like a cupcake…”

Adora doesn’t laugh though. “Can I tell her that? You know she’ll be honoured.”

She sighs, “Yeah okay. So, Princess, what would you call that - and don’t say ‘circle’ or I’ll hit you.”

Adora shoves her gently on the shoulder anyway, and she manages to catch a glimpse of her light blush, almost angry at the dark for taking the colour from her.

“I wouldn’t!”

“Yes you would.”

“...Okay maybe. But I won’t, this time.”

She goes to scoff but Adora’s hand comes down to rest on hers and it dies in her chest. Adora bridged that gap like it was nothing. Because it *doesn’t mean anything* to her. It’s not a new realisation, but it still stings, enough that her claws catch in a blanket.

“I don’t know, what about *Ring*?”

That and the feeling of Adora squeezing her fingers brings her sharply back to the present. She manages to hide her self-inflicted hurt when she says, “Gods you’re a nerd.”

“Better than circle though.”

“Well I suppose there is that one - and I mean one - redeeming thing.”

Adora shrugs, “Good enough for me.”

By the time the next moon has risen to its peak Adora still hasn’t let go of her hand. She almost wants to cry with how comfortable and easy and *nice* it is. She doesn't know whether or not they could’ve had this in the Horde but she hopes to the gods that they couldn't. It’s painful to consider any other option, to consider she could've been having this so much sooner. She wants to bring her hand up and kiss each of her knuckles in turn. It’s a strange thing

for her to want but she can’t dwell on the idea, let alone the why of it.

“We should write these down.”

“Hm?”

“The names, the patterns.”

“Just what I was thinking.” She thought it earlier, so not a complete lie.

“Sure it was.”

“Shut up.”

She knows her ear flicks given Adora’s soft snort. It’s really quite an awful retaliation when she rests her head on Adora’s shoulder just to get her to be quiet. She forgot. She actually *forgot* this isn’t the Before. They haven’t *done* this yet. She silently damns the night. It is its fault after all.

She grits her teeth waiting for a reaction, tail whipping across the bed. But Adora takes her by surprise; instead of rejecting or even just letting it be, she returns it, leaning on her too. It takes everything she has to swallow down the purr in her chest, it feels like it’s sitting on her heart.

She’s grateful Adora says nothing. She doesn’t doubt that she would run as far as she could at the first opportunity. It’s not that she doesn't love this, it’s that she loves it too much. She *can’t* get used to this. But she also *can’t* pull away. Because she’s *still* lovesick and foolish and will take from Adora all that she can get.

Adora doesn’t talk, so she doesn’t either. The only sound is that which curls through the air outside and in through her window, the beating of their own hearts, and steady breathing. By now she’d have closed the curtain and changed into the sleep clothes

Bow had gotten her, but she really can't bear to lose one second of the contact Adora is offering right now.

Of course it has to end, she knows that. She can feel it approaching as soon as Adora raises her head. She gets jostled when Adora sighs but she stubbornly refuses to move until Adora definitivily calls an end to this.

She can't tell if she fabricates how miserable Adora sounds when she mutters, "I should probably go…"

'Or you could stay for once.'

She pulls away, quick but softly. She knows her ears are almost flat to her head purely from her own thought, but she doesn't care.

As horrible as her memories of the portal and her corrupted body are, and as much as she was trying to *hurt*, she can't help but think back to it right now.

"It's always the same with you Adora. 'Oh I have *to do this. Oh, we* have *to do that.'"*

She regrets everything about it. But she can't tell herself it was a lie. It just turns out she's not the only one that applies to. (She's been around Glimmer and Bow enough to know that.) At least Adora's not a hypocrite.

She *should* go but she doesn't *have* to. And it doesn't seem like Adora *wants* to.

She turns her head sharply, finding Adora shocked still and tense under the intensity of her glare. It's an unhidden challenge.

"Do you *want* to go?"

Adora

There's too much in her glowing eyes for this to be what it appears on the surface. She may not always know when Catra's playing games, but this isn't a game. This is...something else.

It's Catra clutching her hand desperately in a fake world, *"Stay with me, okay?"*

It's Catra full of building rage as reality starts crumbling around them, *"Why can't you just stay?"*

This is bigger than this moment and she can only be grateful that she realises it.

"No."

'I never do.'

She was wrong to think the intensity would melt away, that she might finally give Catra some peace in this matter, that she might actually believe her. Catra leans closer, close enough that she can feel her breath on her face, still daring, still challenging.

"Then don't."

It reads: *'Prove it.'*

It would be so easy, she realises, to eradicate the space between them. Easier than anything. There's a burn in her blood that demands to be satisfied with Catra's touch, not dissimilar to the magic she's lost. But she just can't, not when she wants so desperately to do something monumentally reckless and *selfish* above all else. Something that, unfortunately, would prove all too strongly how much she means it.

It takes swallowing and staring at where Catra still allows her to hold her hand for her to say, "I'll stay."

"I never wanted to leave you." Why couldn't Catra just believe her? Why can she still not?

The intensity finally softens, Catra moving back enough so that she can finally *breathe* again. There's another moment of silence before the quietest purr she's ever heard spills into the air. Her neck hurts with how quickly she snaps her head back up. Catra looks like she's trying not to laugh at her with the thin line she's made of her mouth.

She knows if Catra wanted to she'd be able to push it down - but this means she *doesn't* want to. Catra's *happy* and evidently comfortable enough to let that show. She feels drunk.

She blames her false inebriation for why she reaches out. It's as stupid and reckless as she had feared, entirely too soft when she rests her hand on the side of Catra's neck. The purr she'd been dying to feel stutters out with Catra's shock. She takes her hand back like she's been burned.

"Sorry, I just - I wanted to feel it…I missed it."

The last part may have been a little too much, but it's out there now. Catra still looks shocked but its nature changes. Her ears soften from their alert position.

"Alright."

She doesn't move, practically scared to, as Catra lies down, tugging her hand once before letting go. Catra's looking at her like the way she does when she's expecting her to figure something out. At least this time it's easy. She eases herself down onto the bed slowly, unable to escape the way Catra's eyes shine in the dark.

The side of Catra's mouth twitches up when she finally settles. "Take your hair out." She knows her face is an obvious question. "You get my purr if you take your hair down."

She doesn't know *why*, but it's such a small thing she doesn't care *at all*. Not when she'll be able to drink in the physical proof of Catra's contentment. The snap of the band on her wrist is a crack in the silence.

“Happy?”

Catra smirks before grabbing her hand and laying it on her pulse. The immediate vibration that starts under her palm takes her breath away. She knows her mouth is hanging half open but she can’t help it.

Catra’s just as soft as she always was (she's not at all surprised that she remembers the exact feeling), softer if anything now that she’s eating properly. It just makes it harder to keep her hand still. She traces fingertips through thin fur, the arcs getting bigger when Catra doesn’t protest. She always was good at pushing the boundary with her. It’s only when the whole of her hand starts making a repeating journey along her neck that Catra fully opens her eyes again.

“Are you...petting me?”

“Um, I guess? Is that...okay?”

Catra nods hesitantly, “Right now, yes.”

It’s nice to have that, finally a concrete rule when it comes to how she can act around her. Finally a line. She’s never expected to be able to *pet* Catra whenever she wants, fuck, she’s never even considered it, but even the *possibility* of sometimes is short-circuiting her brain.

Her hand hasn’t started moving again since Catra spoke, the reason she realises this is because Catra nudges her jaw up. Catra’s not going to ask her outright, she knows that much. But she will tell her if she wants her to stop. And while she could just so easily remain like this with her forever, with Catra rumbling her comfort against her skin, she clearly wants her to move.

So she does, beginning the same route through her fur with a little more fragility. She smiles as Catra sinks into the bed, curling her claws into the fabric. She wonders if Catra could fall asleep like this. She wants that to be true - in a shockingly powerful way for such an innocent thing.

'I'm staying. I get to fall asleep with her again tonight.'

It makes her so happy she could cry.

She risks going higher, knowing full well how easily Catra can bite her from here (which she will certainly do if she goes too far, Catra can't have changed *that* much.) Catra just stares, eyes half-lidded, at a spot on the bed and so painfully not at her. But she *doesn't stop her*; not when her fingers run through the thicket of fur on her jaw the way she's never dared to do before, not when her hair ends up under her hand. Catra is completely still, the only movement being the inconsistent rise and fall of her chest as she breathes and purrs.

"You sure this is okay?" Because she has to ask.

Catra stares at a different part of the bed when she nods, lip between her teeth. It clicks then that Catra's ashamed of this; of *liking* this. She's not going to say anything else, it'll just make Catra feel raw, she might even run from it. She can only hope that Catra will ease eventually but really there's only a half-chance of that happening.

She stokes through her hair properly, in absolute awe of being able to. She really does like her hair like this, the way it sticks up and curls round her face, wild in a different way than her mane was. She likes how it feels under her hands, how it'll fall in front of Catra's eyes when it gets longer, how she'll scoff when she suggests she tie it back. She drags over it again, but when her fingers press against the base of Catra's ear, she shivers.

She stills her hand, "You cold?"

Catra blinks a few times before she mumbles, "A little."

She pulls her hand back to reach down for the covers at their feet. There's enough for one each so there's no reason for her to curl up with Catra under the same sheets. She knows she has no right to be disappointed.

She doesn't return her hand because Catra doesn't offer. 'Right now' might've already ended. There's nothing in Catra's eyes - which are finally looking at her again - that gives an answer either way.

Silence stretches for a while before it's broken by a heavy inhale. "Tell me about Etheria."

"You live here too y'know."

But she supposes a lot has changed since Catra's last seen it. Post-war Etheria can be unrecognisable at times.

"Idiot. I mean...all the places I went to I was trying to destroy. I want to know what they were like before, or after, I guess."

"Um okay, you ever heard of Mystacor?"

Catra

"No. Or if I have I don't remember."

"I know you haven't been there but figured it's as good as any place to start before the…yeah."

Catra kicks her lightly under the covers, which she knows just 'means go' on, but it's just so like they used to so it throws her for a second.

"It looks like here actually, white and purple, really bright absolutely everywhere. It's the home of pretty much all sorcerers, I don't really know what they do there, but when I went with Glimmer and Bow it was meant to relax me or whatever -"

"- Did they figure out you can't relax to save your life?"

"Yeah, pretty quickly. I kind of got it. Not the way they wanted me to. But…" The way Adora's eyes lock onto the ceiling says more than she does right now.

"Why do I feel like there's a horrible memory for you there then?"

Adora scoffs, which she takes to mean she is *correct*. "Well, Micah is from there, Castaspella too, and, um...Shadow Weaver."

"Oh. Good start then." She keeps it lighter than she's feeling.

It doesn't stop Adora from tensing. "Yeah I didn't think that through… She um, she followed me there. Tried to get me to come back early on."

She feels her tail arc across the mattress behind her. "I didn't know that. Well I knew she was trying to get you back..."

'Because so was I.'

"I was so terrified she'd do something like that again, come find me, steal my memories - which I didn't even know she could *do*!" Adora deflates a little, but she's got a small smile and she's looking right at her again, so she figures it must be alright in some respects. "Guess I should thank you."

"For what?"

'Are you forgetting that I walked away from you? Bound and scared and alone with her?'

It was petty vengeance for all the times it had happened to her, sure. Fuelled by anger and a need for Adora to *understand*, like most things back then. It's not a fucking excuse. Adora has nothing to be thankful for.

"You broke her connection to the Black Garnet. That was a *good thing* you did."

'For selfish reasons. Just like everything fucking else.'

"Sure." She keeps it devoid of emotion.

At least Adora reads her right this time. “Okay, okay I’ll - next place. Plumeria’s nice - Perfuma’s Kingdom. No castle, just trees and flowers and huts and tents. The people are...a lot. Pacifists, optimists. You’d probably hate them.”

She doesn’t bother to fight her tiny smile. “Probably.”

“Kind of feel like I should be at the bottom of the bed,” she yawns.

She doesn’t know what the time is, too tired to even guess from the moon’s positions in the sky. But she trained herself early on in her life not to fall asleep next to Adora, always awake enough to make it to where she was meant to be. A habit she hasn’t found time or reason to break apparently.

Adora scrubs her hand across her face, clearly fighting the sleep they’re both feeling. “It’s your bed.”

“You saying you would’ve curled up at my feet if it’d been the other way round?”

Adora sighs, closing her eyes, “Catra, is it okay if I sleep here?”

‘Despite my better judgement, I don’t want you anywhere else.’

“Yeah dummy, I think I’ll survive. Now sleep.”

Chapter End Notes

I don't want to get into whether or not Shadow Weaver has mind-wiped Adora before because thinking about it makes me sad.
I did add in an allusion to Adora's future interest in cartography, as well as the fact that no one should let this girl name things. I mean Swift Winds was named 'Horsey' for 3 episodes so.

They held hands, Catra got pets, Catra had a lesbian shutdown, they got to cuddle kind of, they stayed up all night talking, they almost kissed. All with a coat of sad yearning. I said it would be gay. (Also while Adora's staring at their hands Catra's looking at her lips.)

It's Different With You

Chapter Notes

> First part I was listening to Watch You Sleep (yes second thing I've written listening to it, shut up I'm a lesbian.)
> Second part I'm saying has "Yeah Adora, concentrate" vibes.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Her sleep is dreamless. The kind of sleep she's not familiar with. And she's torn from it by a very sudden knock on the door. She's lurching her body up, half-yelling and throwing her arms forward before she's even awake.

There's something - someone - holding her wrists when she actually gets a grip on reality. Of all things for her to wake up to, Catra's face - Catra's eyes - might very well be the last thing for her to expect. But it is what's happening. She can process the firm but soft way she's touching her later. Right now all that lives in her head is Catra's freckles and her fang hooked over her lip. For one exceedingly strange second she thinks she's back in the Fright Zone, or that this is a dream. Then she remembers yesterday.

There's a wave of love in her chest she can't stop.

Catra lets her go once she's sure she's not going to accidently hit her anymore, which is...fair, considering the first seventeen years of their lives. "Good to know you still do that."

Catra's grinning when she says it, and it is a welcome relief from the usual blatant concern she gets from Bow and Glimmer. (She still doesn't think it's unreasonable of her to have weapons in her bed but she has gotten rid of them now the war has ended. And that's only because her excuse is invalid now.)

She knows she fails to look annoyed when she shoves her and mutters, "Shut up. Do you know who that is?"

"No," Catra's tail whips when she stands, the only evidence of her discomfort.

She's not sure why she feels it necessary to pull in closer to the armchair - she is not *hiding*, she is just mostly out of sight of the door. She reasons that it's because she's not wearing her jacket and that her hair is a wreck, and all those years of having to be awake and presentable for morning inspections is kicking in because of Catra. She is *not* embarrassed about essentially being caught in Catra's bed. That's ridiculous.

The door opens but it's not anyone she knows, just a faceless guard holding something. "Your breakfast."

'Is it really that late already?'

Catra takes it. "Thank you." And closes the door again.

She's floored. She shouldn't be...but she is. *Catra* saying a genuine, no-sign-of-sarcasm, *'thank you'* to a Brightmoon guard. Or anyone for that matter really. She must've done it before, Adora just apparently has never witnessed it.

She knows she stares once the door closes, once Catra's walking back over with the smallest of smiles balanced on her lips. It's absolutely *stupid* how in love she feels right now. She woke up with Catra again; she feels kind of invincible. And she *kind of* wants to tackle Catra back to the bed and never let her leave, drown in her eyes and her smiles and her laughs and softness. And she *kind of* hates herself for even thinking it.

Catra lays the tray on the bedding before climbing back on herself and tossing an apple in her direction. "Eat."

She turns it over in her hands before putting it down. "I can eat whenever I want, I'm not going to take your food."

It’s not meant to be anything more than words. A denial of an offer. So she’s really not sure what she’s done to illicit the snap in Catra’s voice, “Fine.” Catra tears at what meat is on her plate, not looking at her.

“...Wait, are you mad at me?”

Catra’s ear flicks as she swallows and then scoffs, “I’m not mad.”

“You’re not *happy*.”

She very nearly backs off when Catra growls, but she knows her well enough to recognise that it is a grumpy growl rather than a vicious one. She doesn’t have to wait all that long before;

“You’ve never been the one to not have food.”

‘Oh.’

She tries to think back to how many times she's found Catra in a corner of the Fright Zone after being banned from receiving food for whatever reason. She realises for the first time that she lost count before they reached double digits. It was just a fact of life at the time, one she never really thought about beyond the act itself.

It makes sense that Catra feels it imbalanced. She’s completely right in that regard. She *likes* providing for Catra, always has. She knows, in theory, that the sentiment runs just as true the other way; Catra’s just not had the opportunities to do so. And she still doesn’t, not from in here.

“*Oh.*”

“Dork.”

She takes the apple back, watching as Catra’s ears perk up when she takes a bite.

It doesn’t seem to matter how long she stays, she can’t get to grips with spending a morning with Catra. Yes, she does it every day she possibly can, but it doesn’t *feel* like this. This is...she doesn’t even know. She might be tempted to say timeless; this feels like a dream in which only the two of them reside. She can pretend she never woke up this morning if she wants.

Everything she ought to do is sitting on the sidelines like smoke on the horizon. She can ignore it. She *does* ignore it. The peace she feels just existing with Catra again acts as a shield.

When she’s done, Catra moves the tray off the bed, lies down on it instead, arms behind her head. Adora watches the breath in her chest move in and out slowly like the tide, sometimes audible, sometimes not. Just...easy.

That’s what this is; easy. Catra lying beside her, eyes closed, freckles dotted across her nose. She can’t take her eyes off her. She’s glad Catra can’t see her, she must look as lovestruck as she feels, there’s too much inside her for it not to show.

There’s a lot of things she wants to do, none of which she can. (None of which she would even allow into her head a couple months ago.) She wants to hold her hand, she wants to kiss the corner of her mouth where it curls in the suggestion of a smile, she wants to - she wants to lie down with her again. That she could do. But she shouldn’t. Not feeling the way she does. Not wanting the way she does. It would feel like a lie.

So she doesn’t move, not for a long time. Not until Catra brings one of her legs in and opens her eyes. “You okay?”

She’s just relieved she wasn’t still looking at her, gaze having trailed out the window. “Yeah, yeah I’m fine. I just...guess I don’t know what to do.”

“What do you want to do?”

‘Nothing you would want me to.’

“Um…”

She bites at her lip before shutting off all reasonable thinking and just *acting*. She turns and lies down, careful to keep contact to a minimum, and rests her head on Catra’s stomach. Her back to the mattress, her feet just touching the floor on the opposite side of the bed.

She keeps her eyes fixed to the ceiling when she asks, all too quietly, “Is this okay?”

“Yeah Princess, it’s okay.”

She can’t stop the way she sighs and sinks into the mattress (and body) under her. There’s the briefest tremble of a purr under her head, snuffed out so quickly she could easily be convinced she imagined it. Which Catra would undoubtedly try to do should she say anything. She stays quiet out of what feels like necessity, trying not to smile too wide.

“What do you have to do today?” Catra asks after a while of comfortable silence.

She turns her head to the side and sees Catra watching her, not a sharp edge in sight. “Read over some itineraries then pack. Slow day.”

She loves the way she can feel Catra’s inaudible snort when blue-yellow eyes return to their fake sky. “Not like it’s gonna take you all that long, just two copies of the same fucking outfit.”

She shoves weakly at Catra’s hip, saying, “Hey,” but there’s no heat in it at all. She is technically correct. Still, she can’t help but take the opportunity to tease her, “Sounds like you just wanna spend more time with me.”

“Oh you wish.”

She has to leave eventually, she always does. Time spins like thread until another knock on the door sounds through the room. In between meaningless conversations she figures she must've fallen asleep, there's no other explanation for how foggy her eyes feel.

Catra doesn't rush to the door, lets her sit up on her own before standing. She takes her lunch from the guard with another small thank you.

Adora runs her hands through her hair, wincing at all the knots she finds. "I should go."

"I know."

She throws her hair up as best she can, but there's really no way to salvage it until she gets back to her own room and finds a hairbrush. She feels around under the bed for her jacket and boots as Catra sits again and starts eating. (It reminds her how little she's actually eaten today and moves 'find food' to the top of her priorities list.)

Just as her belt clicks into place Catra says, "You told me to think about people I want to see."

She doesn't let herself get too excited, lest Catra retreat. She starts pulling on her boots without even looking at her. "You figure it out?"

"Scorpia. Can you...ask her, or whatever?"

She turns at the obvious hesitance to see Catra's ears and eyes down. She quickly finishes with her shoes, stands and comes round to Catra's side. Catra turns her body towards her but keeps her gaze downcast. Gods she wants to hold her so badly.

"Yeah I can do that. I know she wants to."

That gets Catra to look up. She realises that she actually has an excuse right now to do as she wants; she's leaving after all. She

holds her hands out, any doubts she had about this evaporating when Catra takes them. Then she's wrapping her arms around Catra's shoulders, resisting how badly she wants to crush her into her body. Catra's hands rest carefully on her back but there's not even a hint of tension in her body.

She keeps it short - she feels like she has to. But it doesn't stop her from doing something stupid. When she goes to take her arms back she lets the blunt edges of her nails drag along the underside of Catra's jaw in what she hopes to appear as an accident. (And it kind of is but…)

Catra coughs once in response, but she can hear the rumble underneath it. (Only because she was desperately listening for it.) She knows better than to address it out loud. She has always suspected Catra liked that sort of thing, last night just confirmed it. She knows she's risking a lot by doing this but...but nothing. She's just being - well she's being selfish. She makes sure the sudden churn in her stomach doesn't show.

"I'll see you tomorrow."

They're meant to leave as soon as they've had lunch to be able to arrive in Salineas around nightfall. Only problem is she's had lunch, alone, and Bow and Glimmer are nowhere to be found. The kitchen staff say they left with their food a while ago. Neither in their rooms nor the dining room, not even the garden where they sometimes have impromptu picnics.

Standing in bright daylight, she comes to a conclusion. Not a particularly smart one, not even a wholly reasonable one. She's still riding the high of spending the night with Catra a day later - she can't really imagine ever getting off of it. She has a horrible feeling four days away from Catra will do it though. So what she manages to come up with is about as biased as it could be, made of pure wanting.

She finds herself outside of Catra's door for the second time that day embarrassingly quickly. She's just looking for an excuse to see her again before they go. She knows that. It took only one little whisper of knowing that Bow said he wanted to see Catra again before they leave, and then barely a footnote of *'if Bow is there he'll probably know where Glimmer is'* for her to end up back here.

She's not proud of herself right now. At least she remembers to knock. The door opens and the last thing she expects is for Glimmer to be the one behind it.

She all but startles, "Glimmer?"

"Yeah?"

Before she can say anything else though, she hears a snort muffled by distance so clearly Catra and then a call from the other side of the room, "Adora get your ass in here."

Glimmer teleports to the table, sitting back down in front of her food, leaving Adora standing in the doorway still in a mild state of shock. It eases now she has a full view of the room, seeing Bow in the other chair. (If she'd seen Glimmer eating lunch with Catra *alone* she might've just passed out.)

She closes the door with a click, feeling exposed despite the fact the only one really looking at her is Catra. She's sitting on her bed where it now resides next to the table. (Why she didn't bring over the chair, she's not sure but Catra is just like that, so…)

Catra leans back on her hands when she gets closer and her tail curls in greeting. It doesn't really match the wicked way she's grinning, entirely smug, and the way she drawls, "*Hey Adora*. Back so soon?"

She forces herself not to react (it is *difficult*.) She gets closer and satiates her sudden need to just touch her by ruffling her hair, "Shut it you, I was just looking for these two."

She grins herself when Catra hisses and swipes at her hand, intentionally slow enough not to hit. Catra recovers quickly enough, "And why did you think they'd be here?"

She was hoping Catra would let that go. She ought to have known better than that. "Uh, I - I thought Bow might be here and he'd know where Glimmer was. Doesn't matter, I was right wasn't I?"

"I think it matters Princess."

She's about to tackle her when Bow and Glimmer both interrupt, with varying degrees of confusion, "'*Princess*'?"

"Long story."

Which really is just Catra speak for *'I don't want to tell you.'* Or at least it is now. Catra at thirteen would've already given them a fresh set of scratches each. Knowing that shouldn't make her smile.

It takes five seconds of silence before Catra sighs a definitely overdramatised sigh and pats the space on the bed next to her with her tail. "You just gonna stand there looking like a moron?"

She rolls her eyes, but she is grateful for it. She resolves, as she takes the offered seat, to not touch Catra unless she initiates it - she just has a feeling it will be a little too obvious otherwise. It's not really anyone's fault that she touches Catra differently from anyone else, it's just a fact. She's rougher and softer in a way it took her a long time to realise.

Catra doesn't reach out, which is fine. She turns to the people at the table and they carry on with whatever they were talking about. She's content to just listen.

Catra talks occasionally, and she pays attention (her mind doesn't really give her any other option.) Or at least she does until Catra brings her elbow up to rest on her shoulder. She has to put all her energy into *not* wrapping an arm around Catra's waist and keeping her looks to a few seconds each. She thinks she's doing a

good job of not being obvious - or at least not obvious enough to warrant comment from anyone.

"...Isn't that right Adora?"

She's concentrating on it so much in fact, she's completely taken off guard. Catra turns her head towards her and she's unfairly caught in the shine in her eyes.

"Huh?"

And Catra - like the asshole she is - laughs. (Glimmer laughs too but she's a little distracted.) She can't be mad, not really, not when she sounds like that. But there are appearances to keep up. She pushes Catra off her with more force than she meant. A yelp turns quickly into a snicker, matching ones coming from her other two friends. It's nice.

Catra turns onto her back, brushing hair out of her face with a huff and a hidden smile only she knows isn't a scowl, "Bitch."

"Asshole. I'm just trying to figure out how long we can stay here before we have to go."

She's not but who really needs to know that?

"We've got plenty of time," Glimmer says, not even bothering to hide her amusement.

She feels the flick of Catra's tail under her nose, drawing her attention back (always back) to her. "Good."

She can't stop smiling - she knows both Glimmer and Bow notice. It's the first time all these people she loves so dearly are all in the same room, happy and talking. She thinks she's allowed to be as close to euphoric as she's ever come.

And if her hand manages to end up behind Catra’s back, and if her tail moves over the surface of it, only the two of them need to know about that.

Chapter End Notes

Fully on board with the 'Adora can't truly relax unless she's with Catra' thing. It's different when you can use a woman's stomach as a pillow.
Adora: Catra might hate me for doing this.
Catra: *has literallly accepted every fucking thing she tries*
(Also Catra really wanted to run her hands through Adora's hair when she was lying on her.)

{This didn’t really fit the vibe but I couldn’t stop thinking about it so you can pretend it’s like an Adora imaged scenario or whatever}
“Back so soon? You miss me?”

Catra stands on her bed. It’s strange seeing her from this angle but she’s not complaining about it. She’s definitely not complaining when Catra drapes her arms loosely around her shoulders.

She blames the unexpected intimacy (*in front of people*) for the way she stutters out an unconvincing, “What, no!”

“I think you’re lying.” Just because she is doesn’t mean she’s ready for Catra to call her out on it, no matter how obvious.
“I think you were looking for any excuse to come and see me.”

She honestly can’t tell if Catra’s joking or not but it’s too close to the truth (it *is* the truth) for her to laugh this off in any way that’ll save her. Instead she blushes like the idiot she is.

Scorpia

Chapter Notes

> Well. It's here. And I really fucking struggled I've not really written Scorpia before.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

She doesn’t expect the next few days to be easy or fun. They’re not. She has her chess set that she plays against herself, her few books that she tries her best to pace as she rereads them. She exercises as much as she can since Adora left the staffs for that purpose, and spends more time than she ever has in the shower (which is still not *much* but…)

It’s just worse than it should be because she’s waiting. She doesn’t even know if Scorpia said yes to coming. She would more than understand her saying no, but she would just like a fucking answer of *some* kind to stop her wanting to crawl up the walls. (Which she considers doing in far too much seriousness.) But the only person who can give her that answer is gone so really she has *nothing else to do*.

Two days go by like this. She more than deserves to stew in her regrets - she knows that without a shadow of a doubt. If penance were easy, she wouldn’t think she was doing it right.

She hears footsteps, not unusual - people pass by her room occasionally. She doesn’t know the layout of the castle, but from what she’s gathered, there’s not much this way. She is technically in a guest room, which is still infinitely funny to her in a twisted way.

She does not startle when the new steps outside her door halt. She stops her pacing, that is all, her ears straining for anything else. There's a click and unfamiliar scuffling on the other side of the door as someone tries to open it. She's grateful for Brightmoon not having automatic doors right now.

The door finally opens, and if she weren't terrified, she knows she would smile. She never did learn to knock.

"Hi Wildcat."

"Scorpia," it comes out as a broken sigh. She shouldn't be feeling this sting in her eyes already - from her just being here - but she's come to realise this is just what happens when people come back. As rare as it is, she knows that. "I didn't think you'd come."

Scorpia steps fully into the room, closing the door behind her a lot more easily than she opened it. Scorpia looks healthier than she's ever seen her; which considering the Horde is not a hard bar to pass as she's come to learn time again. She looks softer, a feat with all her sharp edges Catra's always thought out of place. But that's about where the differences end; she still appears to hold herself the same, trying to make herself as small as possible despite her towering frame.

"People tried to talk me out of it."

"I don't blame them." It is the better thing for her to do after all.

"Perfuma and Entrapta said I should, though so..."

From what little she knows, Perfuma makes sense. Entrapta though - that she's surprised about. She can't even remember if anyone here knows why Hordak died, or if they all think her a murderer. She can't imagine anyone but Adora correcting Entrapta's thinking - if she even knows that *she* is the reason why he's gone at all.

She resists the way her tail wants to curl around her leg. "How is she?"

"Entrapta? She's good, upset about Hordak, but she's dealing with it like...well like *Entrapta*. She's quieter, thrown herself into her science now portals are working, we have Alliance meetings in her lab sometimes, everyone takes turns being her lab partner."

Even when she's not trying to hurt she still does. Or maybe this is just the scars she's left behind, with the only medicine being time. She doesn't know how to feel about that. She's spent so long thinking the best thing she can do is let everyone move on without her, she's never thought that she would be the reason for someone being held back. Didn't really think she was important enough to.

She crosses her arms over her front. "How many of them actually know what she's on about?"

"Um…"

It's a slow, small smile that starts on her face, but it is undeniably real. "I'll take that as none of them."

"Bow does. I can pick up enough when my powers aren't shutting off electronics from 'power overload' - I think that's what she calls it. She gets really excited about it though. Um, Adora can keep up with enough of it too, Glimmer doesn't have the patience. Perfuma will sit in there too sometimes if I'm there. Entrapta likes her plants."

She can't look at her when she asks, "How is that girlfriend of yours?" She's a coward.

She can see enough out of the corner of her eye to know Scorpia's blushing. At least she's right then.

"You know about that?"

She's missed being around hybrids - the click as Scorpia's tail moves is reassuring in the strangest way.

"Bow heavily eluded to it."

Scorpia shifts, obviously trying not to smile too much. “It’s - it’s good with her. I don’t really know what I’m doing but there are these really nice Princesses - Netossa and Spinnerella - they’re helping us. Well me mostly, Perfuma’s been with other people before...”

It doesn’t *hurt* exactly, to talk about this. But it’s still got her fighting off the way her fur wants to bristle; it’s guilt and it’s discomfort and it’s all the ways Catra failed her.

“Do you..want to sit down?” She can’t really offer much else.

“Oh, uh, sure. Where…?”

She gestures with her head for her to take the armchair, still next to the table. The silence isn’t comfortable - not even bearable - the way she’s managed to get it to be with Bow and Adora (even Glimmer on rare occasion.) It doesn’t get better, not as Scorpia actually sits, not as she walks round the table. And it is as soon as she takes her own seat that she realises she really ought to have even attempted to plan what she should say. She was too busy trying not to hope too much that she didn’t even fucking think of what to do if she *did* come. She *hates* not having a plan.

She manages to both wish Adora were here to reassure her, and be glad she’s not here to see how she will inevitably mess this up. She knows deep down she’ll be proud of her for simply trying but...that really doesn’t feel like enough right now. And besides, she’s not fucking doing this for Adora. She's doing this for the woman across from her that she's treated like shit pretty much from the moment she met her.

She needs to be honest. Brutally honest. That’s really the only way she knows how to handle Scorpia and her disarmingly earnest *everything*. But she’ll be kinder. No pushing her away. (Not that she has a reason to do that now.) No bringing her down to give herself control. Which, knowing her, will be easier said than done.

“I don’t know where to start with this…”

“We don’t - we don’t have to do this *right* now, if you don’t want -”

“- No, no we do. It’s long overdue anyway. It’s the reason you’re here.” She curls a leg up on the chair, hugging it with one arm, staring at where she picks at the table’s woodwork with the other.

“It’s not the only reason.”

‘It should be.’

She still wonders how Scorpia survived the Fright Zone being as good as she is. How she didn’t get corrupted by it. She used to wonder the same about Adora, but she knows her better now - knows Adora bears the marks in other ways. Scorpia must as well. Maybe one day she’ll know her well enough to figure it out.

She drums her claws on the table, screwing up her face before releasing it and turning to the woman waiting across from her. “Fuck it. I’m sorry. I am so, *so* fucking sorry for absolutely everything.”

“Really?”

Her eyes burn. Of course Scorpia thinks that low of her - why would she think anything else?

She takes a deep breath, swallowing around everything stuck in her throat before the words burst out; “Gods yes! Fuck, my first couple weeks here I felt so guilty I couldn’t even think about you - or Entrapta - without feeling sick.” She feels that nausea now too, alongside the dizzying pace of her heart. “You didn’t deserve the way I treated you. Not at all. I know that - I *knew* that back then too, fuck I knew everything I was doing was wrong I just…”

“You were hurting. I know you didn’t mean it.”

That bitter laugh is back, she'd almost forgotten it lived in her. "Of all excuses I've ever tried to make for myself that one is the worst. So don't make it for me."

Scorpia curls in on herself before she has a chance to stop it. "Sorry…"

"*Don't apologise!* Gods, I am trying to tell you you didn't do anything wrong."

That might've been the wrong thing to say. If anything Scorpia just curls further. She looks like a kicked puppy.

"I - I'm," she cuts herself off with a sigh, drags her hands roughly through her hair. "Y'know I thought I'd already done the hardest apology."

'Still wrong.' She's so fucking stupid.

She knows she has to keep speaking, she can practically see the reflexive 'sorry' sitting on Scorpia's chest.

"Adora she - she hurt me, and I hurt her, but she's always *known* me. She clung onto the person she grew up with. You only knew me at my worst. And you still cared so…" She doesn't know why she tries to explain it.

"I don't want to make this any harder than it needs to be for you. I know the past month has been a lot for everyone - I know this has been a lot for *you*."

Her tail hits her leg and her claws drum another tune into the wood. "That's one way of putting it I suppose."

Her life *has* been feeling all or nothing ever since she's been in this room. That's not really anyone's fault at least. She's cut off, but she's meant to be. This is a *punishment* for fucks sake.

Scorpia uncurls, apparently realising she had done it at all. The guilt is gone from her face, thankfully. Catra lets her think in

silence, but it doesn't take all that long.

"I do forgive you. I know I don't have to, but I was never very good at being mad at you. And I don't want to be."

Scorpia's fondness, so similar to before, makes her tongue feel bitter when she next manages to speak;

"It's not about being mad at me," though she really doesn't understand how she isn't, but Scorpia always was better than her, "It's about...I don't know. You *should* be angry. I really don't think you could ever hate someone, but if you could; it should be me. I don't even know how you can stand to be in the same room as me! I don't - I don't deserve your forgiveness."

'I don't deserve anyone's.'

Her head is heavy on her shoulders as she looks cowardly at the floor. Scorpia starts something but she holds a hand up to cut her off. "Adora's managed to convince me that I can earn it. So please just, let me earn it. Gods it's the least I can do after everything that happened and - and *didn't* happen between us."

She thinks this must be the first time she's even acknowledged the painful truth out loud. She was so wrapped up in own heartache that she gave just as good as she got. And just as with everything else, she's so much *worse*. Adora didn't know. She did. She saw a devoted woman and didn't even have the fucking decency to tell her no; she let her cling and hope instead of severing it like she should've. Fuck, she even used it sometimes.

"It's not your fault you didn't feel the same."

"No. But I was - I was so fucking disgusting about it. I'm selfish. I know that, I always have been. But I've never been as selfish as I was with you."

"You weren't. You weren't *nice*, but you weren't selfish."

Wrong. So immensely, painfully wrong.

It’s so incredibly hard not to cry. She doesn’t know why she won’t let herself. It’s not like Scorpia will judge, she’ll probably comfort her; maybe that’s why. At least with Adora she feels her tears are earned, she may be ashamed of them but the way Adora doesn’t take her shit, often pushing back just as hard. It makes it bearable.

Scorpia well, she should’ve been prepared for her softness again. She should’ve had a better defense in place, should’ve had one at all. She feels raw and exposed like this, but not *seen*. Not the way Adora makes her feel.

She hates this reaching only for Scorpia to side step her. There’s frustration, becoming sharper and sharper as her eyes sting. She knows what’s coming before it happens. Unfortunately she knows herself well enough now. It’s vulnerability turned frustration turned rage. So tragically familiar.

She may recognise it, but it is a far cry from stopping it. It breaks out. That part that makes her hurt herself hand in hand with the part that hurts others.

“I wasn’t fucking selfish? You’re telling me I didn’t break your heart? Didn’t make you cry? Question your worth? Make you feel like you never had any in the first place? Because *I know* I fucking did okay? Don't bullshit me and don't fucking *lie* to me!”

She doesn’t realise she’s standing till the words are out. Her claws are blades at her sides, having gouged new marks into the table she didn’t hear over her own bitter shouting. There’s tears sitting on her waterline she furiously scrubs at as she falls back into her chair. She traces the trenches in the wood, surprised that otherwise the furniture is still intact.

She can’t bring herself to look at Scorpia, but she knows she’s not moving. Probably shocked - maybe even scared - still. She lets her body take over since it will probably show her remorse better than anything else; ears about as low as they can go, tail winding around her own leg.

“I *knew*, okay. I cared, I did, just…you’re right, it hurt. Everything hurt so much all the time and I took it out on you because I knew you’d let me. Pretty shitty explanation I know, but it's the only one I have.”

It’s not the first time she’s known herself to be a monster, she doubts it’s the last. She doesn’t know how young she was the first time she heard it, doesn’t even know if it was Shadow Weaver, though of course she assumes so. Just a talk, dark figure berating her as she, a young scared child, hissed and growled at her superior.

"I didn't mean to lie to you. Well not this time, I did, before I left, about the recordings. They were in Emily and I didn't want her destroyed."

It doesn't even mean anything to her now. The lie doesn't mean anything - it was in defense of another. She'd be hypocrite on top of everything else if she got angry at a lie meant to protect.

"I don't blame you for leaving. I never know when to quit. Or I just don't, even when I know I should." She sighs again, turning her eyes towards the ceiling as she always does, "I should've stayed with you in the Crimson Waste."

Scorpia tries to deny her, "You wouldn't have been happy there with me."

"I would've been *happier* than I ended up being. I should've at least tried."

"You never did tell me what changed..."

That one she at least has a better answer for, "Shadow Weaver. Picked Adora over me, again. It just...I couldn't take it anymore."

That's really as simple as she can make it. It hurts to say out loud, a half-snarl in her own ears, even as she thinks herself a petty, destructive idiot.

"A lot of the things you did..."

She can practically taste the hesitation and it makes her tail lash as she forces her eyes back down. "What about them?"

She's never really seen Scorpia *steel* herself for anything, it's strange to watch. There's a flicker of lightning between the spikes on her shoulders that she thinks she's imagining until she *remembers*. There's suddenly fear bubbling inside her as well, an unwilling reaction to a childhood of memories she's trying to force down.

She doesn't have to try all that long because as soon as she hears the next words everything just kind of...stops.

"Adora. You did them because of her, right? I didn't...make that up as a reason for...all of it, did I?"

And just like that there's tears again that she *has* to breathe through, there's no other option. "No. No you didn't."

“Some of the things you said to me and did to me, it - it was because I’m not her, wasn’t it?”

'She just wants answers, she deserves *answers. Just for once in your life admit it.'*

It’s that of all things that makes tears finally spill over, just the one, but it’s more than she wants. She makes sure it doesn’t have time to stain her fur darker. “Yeah it’s, fuck, it’s because you weren’t her.”

It’s as heartbreaking to admit out loud as she always thought it would be. Her voice is as cracked as she always thought it would be.

“Thank you, for telling me... I didn’t think you’d ever admit it.”

She finally manages to look at her again, there’s *almost* a smile, made purely of relief she herself doesn’t feel. She won’t let herself

label it as proud, because it can't be. She hasn't earned that.

"Yeah I didn't either."

"It's nice, having a reason and it not just being about me."

"Still shit though."

"It's...it sucks, yeah."

She is surprised about the little snort that gets out of her, Scorpia never one for swearing. It's the little hesitance where she clearly thought about it that got her.

"Does Adora know?" And when she doesn't answer, "Do you think she feels the same?"

"Of course not."

Adora's not ashamed to love like she is. She doesn't hide fondness and caring behind sarcasm and rough touches. If Adora felt the same way she'd have figured it out a long time ago.

"I don't really know where we go from here…"

"Well I don't have many things to do in here so literally any stories from outside will be exciting for me."

"Oh, um okay, well this one time Entrapta…"

"Everything alright in there?"

She doesn't recognise the voice, she tries to keep her startle at the sudden, rather loud, sound to a minimum. (And probably fails considering the way her tail is behaving.)

"Everything's great!" Scorpia calls back, no signs of being caught off-guard at all.

“I think that’s your cue to go.”

“Yeah it is, I told her to come get me when it was time for our evening meditation.”

She seems, understandably, sheepish to admit that, but not embarrassed. It has to be Perfuma based on that though. Catra honestly doesn’t know what ‘meditation’ is, and if anyone’s ever said anything about it, she doesn’t remember. Sounds Princess-y though.

Scorpia lets her get the door, following close behind. She turns the handle and crosses her arms as she lets it swing further open.

“Hello Catra.”

She knows she’s fought this Princess, she knows what she can do. But she can’t recall it right now as she smiles at her, small and polite and delicate. (‘*Right, flowers, figures.*’) She has a horrible feeling it’ll come back to her later though.

She nods as non-condescendingly as she can, “Princess Perfuma.”

The Princess turns to Scorpia just slightly, smile growing when she looks at her. It’s bittersweet for Catra in so many ways.

“How’d it go?”

She glances at Scorpia out the corner of her eye as she shrugs. She is not the one to answer this.

“I already said it was great. We actually talked. Like a lot.”

The distinct, pure glee in the words makes her feel is a type of relief she can count on one hand the amount of times she’s experienced it.

“Well that’s good!”

There’s so much positivity in three fucking words that it actually puts her on edge. Adora did warn her. And she may be getting better, but after Scorpia, the less of this aggressive optimism the better.

She steps out of the way, “Scorpia, I guess I’ll, uh, see you some other time…”

“Yeah, I’d like that. I’m - I’m proud of you.”

She doesn’t really know how else to respond but with, “Thanks.”

Neither of the other two women seem to mind though. Scorpia crosses the barrier when something occurs to her.

“Hey, wait.” She already regrets saying anything when Scorpia looks back, obviously confused. This just means she actually has to *say* it out loud.

'Do it for her.'

She grits her teeth and forces out, “I don’t really like people touching me…*but*, I know that you do so…”

She kind of hates herself for the awkward way she half-raises her hands. Then she’s wrapped up in Scorpia’s arms before she can blink. It’s just as crushing as she remembers.

“Oh, there it is, okay.”

It *might* be more bearable when she actually has some warning beforehand. Apparently she’s not ready to voice that though. Scorpia sets her down gentler than she's ever done (maybe made easier by the fact she's not desperately squirming out of the hold.)

“Bye, Wildcat.”

There’s a genuine smile, small and careful, on her face. It doesn’t fade once the door closes.

Chapter End Notes

Adora's not even this chapter but by god is Catra gonna fucking talk about her.

My take on Scorpia is that the Horde made her unable to say no - which is why her leaving is such a big moment for her. She says yes to everything to keep herself safe, forgives too easily to keep the few friends she does have.
Spinetossa be out here helping *all* the wlw. And I don't know I just wanted to throw in that Perfuma's had one or two past relationships since I headcannon her older. (Plus with Plumeria's community-centered culture I thought it would make sense.) Also, of course, she's a trans woman.

Home: Part I

Chapter Summary

A deal is made.

Chapter Notes

Oh look at that more Don't Go references.

Context that applies to all my canon-verse stories: Catra and Adora only ever slept in the same bed alongside each other a few times when they were kids before they got caught. Every other time since then was when Catra had a really bad day (Adora never one to allow herself comfort when she was hurting.)

Content Warning: mentions of blood, implied child abuse

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

She calls Scorpia before they leave Salineas, she knows her and Catra talked. And she knows it went well...in the end. But she also knows there's been a tide of anxiety she herself has been feeling regarding it for the last few days.

She wants Catra to get her friend(s) back, but she also wants to be there to help her through it. Even if Catra would probably shoo her out when the time actually came. At this point all she wants is to hear that Catra's okay from her own mouth.

She *thought* she managed to say it in passing yesterday, but Bow's look had been so *knowing* that it put her on edge for the rest of the day, even after his suggestion: *"Maybe you should give her her own trackerpad?"*

She has been berating herself since; it's so simple.

They didn’t teleport to Mermista's kingdom but they do teleport back, since the returning team is smaller. (Not that Glimmer *can’t* teleport all of them, it was just that she couldn’t teleport all of them *and* all the supplies.)

The clock in the dining hall reads far later than she thought by the time the three of them have eaten. Even still, she has to battle her longing, and reason to herself that she shouldn't go see Catra. Logic wins out easily - Catra’s probably asleep already, and she has no reason good enough beyond *‘I missed you,’* to wake her up.

If she tried, she could convince herself, *‘I was worried,’* is a good enough reason. And it wouldn’t even be a lie. But she holds herself back from doing so (it really would be uncomfortably easy to do.) She resigns herself to her bedroom without any protest as Gimmer and Bow walk her there. (She is *not* dead on her feet, she is just not as stable as she ought to be.)

At least this time she manages to stay awake long enough to brush her teeth, change, and even remember to take out her hair. Her curtains remain open though when she emerges from her bathroom, and her lights would remain on if she'd turned them on in the first place.

She focuses on the flow of water she can hear - a stand in for the incessant hum of the Fright Zone she learnt early on. It eases her into a calm quickly enough, pure exhaustion actually putting her under.

It’s golden in her dream. Warm with a moonrise. She’s high up, far above everything else, and all she knows is Catra next to her. She won’t remember the words they speak when she wakes up, they don't even make sense as she dreams them. It’s just nice; peaceful.

It's the Fright Zone, it has to be; she's never been high up like this with Catra anywhere else. She can't. Catra's still trapped here. And just because she knows why doesn't mean she likes it. They've been trapped their whole lives in one way or another, Catra shouldn't have to endure that anymore.

She tells her that. Dream her anyway.

"Adora I do deserve that. You know what I've done."

"I know, I know," she says back, *"You hurt me."*

There's a distant slow drip of liquid getting louder, she looks at Catra's hands where they lay limp in her lap. She doesn't know whether the drips are from her tears as they trickle down her face, or the blood that covers her hands like gloves as droplets hit the ground far below. Catra looks at her, most of her faded from the light. What's left is a child, tangled mane, shining wide eyes and everything.

"Adora I'm scared."

"Don't be scared. We're safe up here, remember?"

"Liar."

The light fades, the crumbling grains in the sky breaking as shadows cracked with red crawl towards them too fast. The world crumbles in a blaze of crimson. She doesn't know if the screams she hears are Catra's or hers.

She still reaches blindly for her as she's thrust back into a nicer reality, and as always, she finds empty space. Her throat stings with her broken breathing, she coughs when breathing exercises don't soothe it. The open curtains mean she can see into her room as she sits idly trying to get a fucking grip. She is *tired* of this fourth night in a row. It's not her longest streak of nightmares, but she has been having multiple a night. It's more exhausting than staying awake. (An option she has explored, but Bow and Glimmer got too worried.)

At least she doesn’t shake when she stands. She turns the bathroom light as low as she can and drinks, not able to meet her own eyes in the mirror. Her face will be little more than shadow anyway. She doubts she’ll be able to rid herself of them tonight.

The night-time wind in her room makes her shiver even as her heart continues it’s rapid-fire beat. She pulls the robe she took back from Mystacor out of her chest of drawers since it’s kind of meant to be slept in anyway, and bundles herself in it. It helps. It's soft.

'Soft like her.'

It's not like her.

The scrape of the drawer as it closes is jarring in its echoes. Something makes her stare a burning hole into the top of the dresser, but she doesn’t know what. Probably the same thing that’s preventing her from letting go of the handles, that's making her think like this. It might very well be loneliness, or even just longing. It doesn’t really matter, she just wants Catra here. As always. That night together ruined her - she should’ve been stronger, should’ve been able to foresee what it would do to her.

She doesn’t have Catra here, but she has something. She hasn’t thought about it all that much, burying it along with most things to do with Catra when she’s not with her, but she hasn’t forgotten that it’s there. The creak of the bottom drawer as she pulls it open makes her wince; as if someone could hear it, as if anyone knows what she is doing. No one does. No one ever will.

Maybe, *maybe* she can be this weak, alone in her room late at night. It wouldn’t be the first time.

She pulls Catra’s mask out from its hiding place. She tries to think what Catra would say if she knew. She thinks she’d be surprised more than anything, but she wouldn’t be angry; would probably just call her a sentimental idiot and forget about it. That’s reassuring in a strange way.

And thinking about her like this just makes her ache more. She can't go back to her bed like this. It'll just feel empty. She feels empty just standing here, holding the only thing of Catra's she has outside of her cell.

She holds it to her forehead, pretends, oh so pathetically, that she can feel Catra like this. As much as she tries she can't forget; it's far from the first nightmare she's had even this week about a young, scared Catra she couldn't protect. And every night it left her begging to just see her to ease the guilt.

'Catra's alive, she's fighting, she's forgiving you.'

'Catra's here, she's a few minutes away.'

'She's not going to be upset with you for having a nightmare.'

'She's not going to be angry with you for worrying about her.'

'You don't have to stay. You can just check and leave.'

She's not sure how long she stands there unmoving like that, but enough for her feet to go half-numb from the cold stone floor. There's light indents from the mask on her palms as she sets it down. She wasn't wrong when she thought before that she could convince herself to go to Catra if she drenched the intention with lies; that it's about going to see if *Catra* is okay. It's rather easy after all that to replace the mask to its hiding place, throw her hair up and pull on her boots.

There's no guards in the hallways which she's glad of, despite how all her years of training and sentry duty mean she doesn't like it. It makes it easier to convince herself of non-selfish intentions, keeps a dream-like quality to what she's seeing. Catra's never been all that far from her, prison being one of the castle's spare rooms, but the three minute walk always feels longer than that.

She's been told she's impulsive by many people. It's things like rushing into battle without a plan and doing *this* that makes her agree. Four consecutive nights of bad sleep and genuine worry is

fuelling her right now, which is probably why she hesitates so minimally before opening the door to Catra's room .

She's a fool for thinking that if she's quiet enough Catra won't ever know - she's never been quiet enough before. Catra's silhouette jerks with a loud hiss in the limited light, all she can see of her is the shadow of her hair and the contrasting glow of her eyes.

"Adora?"

It's so soft the way she says it, shocked but her voice is too heavy with sleep to be any semblance of sharp. With the dream still fresh in her head, she can't help but think it sounds like when they were kids. It hurts in a way she's not prepared for.

"Yeah, it's - it's me."

"Hey, it's okay. It's just me."

Covers shift as Catra gets up, the comforting silence of her steps on the floor as she comes closer to the light. Adora watches her pupils thin, the low, calm wave of her tail as it shows her confusion. In direct contrast to that, Adora's own fists are tight at her sides, she can't help it.

Catra's figure gets painted in colour when she gets close enough. It's not what she expects. She expects to see black and maroon not light gray. Catra's in leggings and a tank top, with her hair all sleep-mussed looking *soft* in every meaning of the word. She should decidedly not be rendered half-useless by seeing Catra in sleep clothes of all things - it is night, Catra was sleeping, of course she is. She *can't help it.*

"Adora what -"

"- Can I stay here tonight?" she blurts out before she loses her nerve. So much for pretending she was going to leave.

Catra, to her credit, doesn't even flinch. She just looks her up and down - understandable considering what she's wearing and the time. And yet Catra manages to both soften and solidify in the next second.

"What happened?"

She wouldn't need a reason in the Before, they would just do it. She misses that right now. But Catra is justified in wanting an answer so she has to give her one. She doesn't consider lying, Catra would just get angry at her for that. But she doesn't want to admit this weakness, not even to her.

She can handle it the other way round. She's *used to* this the other way round; Catra crawling into her bed after a nightmare. (If she wasn't at the end of her bed already.) She *owes* Catra this, in some respect. She is working on making this fair after all, in small, hopefully discreet ways.

"Just...nightmares, about you. I keep having them and I just - I guess I wanted to make sure you were okay. But you are so I can - I can leave if you want."

She's already on her toes and ready to run if necessary. Catra can tell (it's not as if she's hiding her nervous energy at all) and reaches forward for her hand. It relaxes instantly in her reassuring grip, uncurling to hold on.

"You can stay."

It feels like she finally settles back into her own skin. The ghost of trembling leaving completely as Catra tugs her deeper into the room. She closes the door behind her when she follows easily.

It's darker than last time with the curtains drawn, almost pitch black once the door closes. She stumbles a little, having no clear picture of the room since the furniture changes place so often. Which of course Catra sees if her little snicker means anything. She's silently grateful for Catra with her near-perfect night vision still holding onto her, leading her through the blackness.

Catra pulls her down after a couple steps onto what must be the bed from the feeling of it. “I can take the chair, it's fine.”

Catra walks around to the other side and she turns, trying to follow the shine of her eyes. She feels the dip as Catra sits on the opposite side, almost jumps as Catra’s tail brushes across her hand where it sits atop the bedding.

“Adora don’t be an idiot. The bed’s huge.”

The returned softness of it stuns her silent. She feels the remaining tension trickle out of her body. She is...at ease. She wouldn’t think she’d be; with Catra close and gentle. She blames the night, as she always seems to do. It is Catra's fault she feels like this, but it's something she could never *blame* her for.

She takes her shoes off, robe too, glad Catra doesn’t say anything. Catra’s already lying down when she gets under the blankets herself. There’s a careful and purposeful space between them she knows she can’t do anything about. Even if she feels that every worry that’s been living in her head the past few days could vanish by just feeling her. Catra’s got to bridge it - it’s the rule she made for herself.

She attempts to sleep again when she sees Catra’s eyes close. She’s not tossing and turning like the nights previous, she’s comfortable and not *scared* to fall asleep here. But she can’t. She remains stubbornly awake. Even Catra and her softness and her warmth that she wants to drown herself in not being able to drag her under - or maybe that’s why. She is *aware* of how close Catra is in a way she wasn’t the other night. Catra asked for her to be there, she didn’t this time.

‘If Catra didn’t want me here, she would’ve turned me away.’

She would’ve been sure of that a couple of years ago, but not anymore. This Catra is more selfless than that. She would’ve never thought a side effect of that would be her questioning Catra’s sincerity, but here she is, in her bed with forced breaths

almost convinced Catra's only letting her be here because she knows better than anyone how awful her nightmares can get.

All that tension is back in her shoulders as she lies there, hands curled into fists again. She screws her eyes closed as if it's a barrier to her own worries.

"Nightmares still bothering you?"

She doesn't let herself jump at the unexpected sound, forces her face to smooth out now that she knows Catra is watching her again.

"A little…" because really, what else is she going to say?

Catra hums a recognition and it makes her feel safe enough to open her eyes again. She can't see anything but Catra's eyes in the dark, pupils as wide as she's ever seen them. It's strange, but known; they've done this before, lifetimes ago.

She watches as Catra seems to trace her face before she says suddenly, "Come here?"

She doesn't know what shocks her more; the words themselves or that Catra's asking.

"It's just us. There's no one here," Catra sounds...nervous, but like she's smiling. She doesn't really understand.

She doesn't even know why she's questioning this. Catra wants her closer; she wouldn't be offering that if she didn't want her here at all. And she wants *to be closer* to Catra, she always does - gods, it's why she's here in the first place. So she moves, shuffles towards her till she can feel the radiating heat of Catra's skin next to hers.

"We're not going to get told off for doing this anymore," Catra whispers like it's a secret.

They're close enough that she can feel her breath on her face, meaning it takes her a moment for what Catra actually said to process, then, “You’re right.”

She gets why Catra sounds like she’s smiling, because she is too. She experiences momentary euphoria in knowing that Catra wanted to be like this at night, just as she did. That it was merely the punishment that prevented the both of them from having this every night in the Before. If she could purr, she knows she would.

But apparently Catra’s going to go further with this, “You’re nightmares are about not keeping me safe?”

The smile promptly dies.

'Failing you.'

“Yeah…” she mumbles, unsure whether she wants Catra to remember that.

Or maybe she does given the way Catra’s tail curls around her ankle. She forces down the stutter of her own breath because with Catra so close, there isn’t a chance she won’t notice.

“Okay then…” Catra shifts downwards slightly on the bed while she remains absolutely still. Whatever Catra’s going to do she won’t be prepared for, which just means she doesn’t stop the small gasp that makes its way out of her throat when Catra tucks her head in against her chest.

“You want to do this?”

And just like that she feels more vulnerable than she has in a long time. It was too obvious, too nervous, too longing.

Catra mumbles into her chest, either ignoring or unaware of how pathetically weak her words were, “Wouldn’t do this if I didn’t, dummy.”

She nearly chokes. “Oh.”

She expects Catra to laugh but there's no sound, not until; "Put your arm around me."

She doesn't hesitate this time, curling Catra in tighter against her. The pounding of her heart spikes before it slows, driven higher by Catra so close, eased by the warmth she was craving burning in her arms. And just as Catra starts relaxing into the sheets, the tension in her body melting away, Adora runs her fingers in gentle arcs across her shoulder blades. She thinks she's getting better at telling when Catra's trying to stop something, or maybe it's the fact she can feel the beginning of a purr in her own chest before Catra gets ahold of it.

"Think you can protect me like this?"

Gods she loves the feeling of Catra speaking into her skin. Gods she loves *Catra* for just doing this; for somehow knowing she needs this.

"Yes."

That seems to be all Catra needs before the last of her walls come down, quiet thunder rumbling through the both of them, loud and calming in a way Adora's never known anything else to be.

"I missed you, Catra."

She doesn't mean to say it anywhere other than the inside of her head. But it's okay, she can blame it on a mix of her nightmare, the four days they've spent apart, even her own tiredness if needed. But it's also not needed at all;

"I missed you too."

She has to strain to hear it over her purring but it's undeniably what she said. There's a burning in her chest she's come to recognise, one caused by the love she feels; one she shoves as far down as she can lest it take ahold of her. She doesn't let herself fall asleep till it fades to peaceful embers.

In the morning she wakes before the guard comes. She blinks her eyes open to Catra still tucked under her chin, the fur on her back under her hand. Catra's thrown an arm over her, curled her legs up more but other than that, there's no difference from how they fell asleep.

She expects to feel an outrageous amount of joy, and she does, but she also doesn't; it's calmer than that. This is just...what they were always meant to have. It doesn't exactly feel new. It doesn't exactly feel old either. It just is. They just are.

Catra purrs as soon as she stirs, low and steady and it almost lulls her back to unconsciousness. They don't stay in the embrace after that, her excuse to run from her own feelings being that she doesn't want to be caught walking back to her room in her sleep clothes - too many questions. Catra agrees to her reasoning without questioning, but she still assures her she'll come back with breakfast.

"Thanks for last night, I, uh - it helped. A lot," she admits carefully after swallowing the last of her breakfast.

"You have another nightmare? Come to me. Just knock first."

It's what she wants. In every way she can think, she wants that. It's what she's wanted since the night she brought her here. But she can't say it. Even if Catra's offering, it's selfish; there's no way to return the favour. It'll feel like taking advantage of her, though she doesn't understand why.

"You don't have to do that."

She probably looks more obvious in how she feels than she sounds given the way Catra kicks her gently under the table. "I want to. I don't miss much about the Fright Zone but...the barracks, sleeping with other people around, I miss that."

'I've missed sleeping near you.'

“Didn’t you get a Force Captain’s room?”

Catra takes the deflection though, “Yeah. Not that I slept much. And when I did it was awful so...guess that hasn’t changed much.”

It’s something about the way she says it that makes her remember what Bow said. Or maybe it’s her less rational self beginning to spin fickle reasons - excuses - for her to let herself spend nights with Catra again.

“Catra I’m going to get you something.” It comes out too sharp if the twitch of one of Catra’s ears means what she thinks it does.

“Okay?” Not upset, just curious, maybe a little amused.

“Yeah, I’ll - I’ll be back in a minute.”

She’s at the door again within fifteen minutes, holding a new issue trackerpad. It was easier to get than she thought actually, what with so many of them being made to talk to relief teams across the planet.

Catra’s dressed now though, curled up in her armchair with a book Adora’s pretty sure she’s read twice already. (She makes the mental note to get her more books.) It’s a sight she’s slowly getting accustomed to; Catra in some vein of domestic. It probably only seems that way because of how they grew up but there’s not much she can do about that.

Catra folds the corner of the page and sets it down, coming over and taking the trackerpad out of her hands. “I have no idea how to work this.”

“Gives you something to do, doesn’t it?”

Catra’s hand migrates to her hip, “So you don’t know either then.”

“I know what I need to know,” Catra rolls her eyes, “Messages and calls mostly. Which is why I’m giving it to you. I thought

about it in Salineas, but this way you can ask me - or anyone - to come here. Or not I guess. I just figured you'd want more control over what happens to you here."

That gets her to soften at least. "Thanks Adora."

"Really, after so long, it's the least I can do. Now I've got to go but message me when you figure it out."

She hugs Catra without thinking, but it's received and returned without delay. This is their usual goodbye now, which all things considered, shouldn't make her as happy as it does.

She doesn't mean to spend so much of the day waiting for Catra to message her, but it's just where her mind goes when it's not consumed by building plans for coastal towns. She's just unfortunate enough to have Bow with her when that happens.

All it reads is *: Figured it out :* but it has her smiling anyway.

"You give it to her?"

"Yeah."

It is not even the first knowing look he's given her today.

Not a week has gone by and she has spent two more nights in Catra's bed already. She doesn't know what to make of it.

They don't usually fall asleep facing each other, for which she's grateful for. It's easier to relax when glowing eyes - able to see in the dark what she can't - aren't on her. It's easier to convince herself that what they're doing is allowed. But it's also harder to endure in pathetic, lovesick ways. Harder to stop herself from intertwining their hands when Catra held her from behind the second time; harder to stop herself from pressing kisses into Catra's hair the third.

And she feels guilty. She wanted to make this fair, it's what lets her do this. But it's not fair to Catra for her to have done this twice already. A late night - early morning - message saying she can't sleep and Catra responds with *: I'm awake :* almost instantly. Welcomes her into her bed with gentle questions and clawless hands. Catra hasn't asked once.

She had tried to reason to herself at first that maybe she has more frequent nightmares than Catra does. Except that is a blatant and known lie. The last time she went she *knows* Catra had a nightmare too - the bristling of her fur that didn't settle until she touched her told her as much. She reached out. Catra didn't. It stung.

She *understands* Catra's reservations. Of course she does, she's living them too. It's *Catra*, she gets it. But it makes her feel weak, and despite everything Bow and Glimmer, even Perfuma have said, she can't stand it.

Something wakes her up. Not a nightmare, not someone else, just a small sound and a flare of white light from behind her eyelids. It makes her groan as it tears her from sleep, she considers ignoring it, but she doesn't. The light's too harsh for it to be daylight, so it's origin has to be the only piece of tech she has in her room.

She sits up, eyes adjusting to the darkness without the artificial light that woke her. She lights the lamp at the side of her bed and finds her trackerpad on the covers next to her. She doesn't *remember* falling asleep with it there, but if the last thing she did was say goodnight to Catra then it makes sense.

: Had a nightmare :

She doesn't move for a couple seconds, taking a moment to realise what that means, before typing out an immediate reply *: On my way :*

She’s already pulling on her shoes before it’s finished sending. Apparently she was successful in convincing Catra that it is *okay* to ask her for this, that she *wants* her to, that last night. There’s selfish relief before the cold wave of reality hits; Catra’s had a nightmare, she is *scared*, enough so that she is asking for her to come.

She doesn’t *run* exactly, but only because she knows the sound of her boots will be too loud - Catra’s senses are even more sensitive when she’s stressed. It’s easier to open the door than any other time, she finds. She uses the momentary light to see where the bed is, locating it in the furthest place from the door as it could be. She can’t see where she’s going at all, walking in a straight line but ending up with a handful of curtains. She pulls it aside just enough to see Catra still on her bed, curled up and not looking at her.

“Catra?” she whispers, trusting that Catra will hear it. She does given the way her ears flick back to meet her.

Catra’s curled as close to the wall as she can be and it’s then that she realises this is about as close to a dark corner as she can get here. The bed is shaking when she sits down, she tucks the trackerpad she finds under the bed. Catra hisses quietly at the proximity but does nothing else - she doesn’t have to. Adora knows better than to touch her when she’s like this.

“Hey, it’s just me, remember? It’s just me,” she whispers as low and steady as she can. It gets glowing eyes to look at her. Catra’s arms stay around herself but the shaking subsides a little. “You’re okay. You’re safe. There's no one else here but us.”

Catra closes her eyes to breathe, her tail unwinds from it’s vice grip on her ankle. There’s less fear when she opens them again, like Catra’s managed to convince herself of something. Catra loosens her hold with one hand, leaving it up-turned in the space between, and she doesn’t hesitate in the slightest to take it. She doesn’t mind the strength in the grip, cherishes it in fact.

“She’s not here.”

Her heart fractures with knowing exactly who she means - for there’s really only one person it could be. Adora may have more figures lurking in her dreams now, but none of them as powerful as Shadow Weaver, none of them are born from years of endless expectations she couldn’t meet. And no one knows more pain from her hand than Catra.

“She’s not here, she can’t hurt you anymore.”

There might be punctures in her hand at this point, but she doesn’t care.

“She’s still out there. She could.”

She can tell it hurts for her to admit it, but that just means she loves her more for it. “I won’t let that happen, no one here will.”

Catra’s knees finally come down, and she takes her hand back. She’s expecting for Catra to lie down, tug on her hand for her to follow and for them to go to sleep and not talk about this again. She’s not expecting Catra’s arms around her waist dragging her as close as possible, for her to bury her head in the crook of her neck. She lets her, would never deny her what she knows brings her comfort. She feels Catra’s claws through the fabric of her shirt, feels her bared teeth against her neck and under different circumstances she might be feeling very differently about this. But right now all it shows is Catra’s distress that she yearns to eradicate.

She strokes her hands down Catra’s arms repeatedly, traces her stripes, elated when it makes Catra stop baring her teeth (which leaves Catra’s lips against her neck instead but that is the last of her worries right now.) She draws Catra’s legs over her lap, feels a sigh wash over her skin when Catra realises what she’s doing, then allows her hands to find a new place on Catra’s shoulder blades.

She traces scars absentmindedly in the moonlight, finding them by memory and touch. She clutches Catra tighter whenever claws snag; anything to make her feel better. She would let Catra carve fresh scars into every inch of her body if it meant she found solace in her arms.

It never lasts, she knows that. She still has to remind herself that she will have this, Catra in her arms, again every time.

Catra pulls back, taking her hands (and claws) with her. Adora's hands slip along the fur of her shoulders as an excuse to prolong the contact. Not that it's necessary with how they'll most likely end up, but now that Catra's letting her she just...can't let go. She *needs* her under her hands. She can't see much in the shadow of moonlight, uses it as a shield for her actions when she runs thumbs under Catra's eyes to see if she was crying. She wasn't. And yet she lets herself leave a hand there, cradling the side of her face.

She doesn't even truly realise that she's done it till she gets caught up in Catra's shocked eyes again. She's about to apologise for it, feels like she's crossed a line, already pulling her hand back when Catra follows. She leans *into* it.

Adora's scared to speak, fully aware of how fragile this is right now. Catra's still here, allowing herself to be comforted. But she wants to run. She can read the shame in her body at giving in, but she's *not moving away*. If she had less control of her tongue - less understanding, less fear - she'd tell her she's proud of her.

"You came," Catra mumbles into the skin of her hand, unable to look at her.

That fracturing feeling in her chest sings a reprise. It doesn't seem to matter how many times she comes back, Catra's always going to doubt her in some respect. She doesn't know how to fix it. She should know how to fix it by now. She can only hope that hearing it *enough* might finally convince her one day.

"Of course I did. I -" *I love you.* It's the first time she almost slips up with it. She resists the tears stinging her eyes, laughs pitifully instead, "Promised, didn't I?"

She was hoping for at least a sad attempt of a smile on Catra's part. It's not what she gets. She doesn't know what it is about what she said that causes Catra to shove at her shoulders hard enough she falls to the bed. She bites her own tongue when Catra crawls towards her, stopping when she's on all fours above her, just staring for a moment. (There is a lot about tonight she's going to be obsessing over when she's alone again.) But it is only for a moment before a miniature horror spreads over her face and Catra drops to her chest, curling there, every muscle tense.

"I'm sorry."

She doesn't understand why Catra sounds scared, and she knows better than to ask. "It's okay, everything is okay Catra. You're safe. No one's going to hurt you here."

She doesn't know if that's what Catra wanted to hear but she hopes so. Catra turns her head, and she worries her suppressed laugh at the ticklish feeling of Catra's ear on bare skin will upset her. It doesn't, Catra relaxes minimally into her instead. Everything is okay - *she* ought to believe it at least.

She brings her arms up and around her, unused to but content with the feeling of Catra on her chest. She strokes through Catra's hair as gentle as she can, relieved in every sense of the word when Catra starts a drowsy stuttering purr under her hands.

She can worry about her near-slip later, right now, this is all she needs. To hold Catra, to be held in return. To be needed by her again, to feel her purr rattling in her bones turn slowly to quiet snores. It's something she's wanted for a long time, realising it only when she finally had Catra *happily* curled in her arms asleep for the first time since they were kids.

She has been so good at pushing down this want, so good at ignoring it when daylight sits on the horizon. But it is oh so hard to do when she has it; when she actually *has* Catra like this. And if she falls more in love every time she drifts off with Catra's creaking purr vibrating in her skin, then...that's just what happens.

Chapter End Notes

Holy shit this came out gayer than I intended, the girls really took this away from me I'll be honest. That whole last section wasn't even in this to begin with (otherwise this would've gone up sooner) and then suddenly it's all 'first almost love confession' and 'Catra almost kisses her and then panics because she thinks Adora knew what she was thinking'.

Glimmer and Bow don't actually know about their sleeping arrangements because Adora gets up so early anyway. Also if they ask she'll just say she was with Catra which isn't a *lie* but...

Next chapter will be out tomorrow or the day after because it's a short one ;)

(Also Catra folds book pages because she's chaotic :P)

We Don't Get An Epilogue Yet

Chapter Summary

Beginning of the end.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Catra's used to being woken up by other things now, guards or Adora mostly, but more often than not she wakes to silence. It doesn't bring her paranoia anymore, but she still misses a constant something in the background. There's a gentle flow of water far below her window, muffled by the spell, that she can only hear by sitting next to the barrier. It gets louder after rain, and she enjoys it more than she'll ever admit.

She's lived her whole life by routine, it's only natural for her to adapt one to her new, less stressful existence. She'll change out of the sleep clothes Bow gave her, go to the bathroom, then open the curtains. Usually she'll do stretches or practice chess moves till Adora comes (if she's not here already.)

Today she gets stopped at the curtains, a faint sound of something outside meaning she forces her eyes to adjust to the light quicker than is comfortable. There's few times she's ever not trusted her own eyes. Right now is one of those times. She has to be imagining the daggers in the sky on the horizon.

But she blinks and stares and they stay, accumulate in number as they descend from space. There's a dread she'd almost forgotten dripping heavy in her gut as white spires lower slowly to the planet's surface.

Adora

She doesn't know what she feels when she draws back her curtains to see a corrupted sky. There's shock, definitely - confusion even, as it takes her wasted seconds remembering just exactly what - exactly *who* - this is. There's anger at herself while she dresses, a disguise; a shield, for her fear and guilt. She got too comfortable. How could she have let herself get *used* to a life without war? She's lived her whole life in a one, she should know better than to think this supposed end was infallible. They knew Hordak was trying to find his way back to Horde Prime, they should've prepared for this. Why didn't she even *consider* that this might happen? She's meant to be *smarter* than this!

She doesn't know where her feet are taking her at first, the panic bubbling inside disrupting her thoughts like the sound of gunshots. Only the first of the day's moons has risen, there is no sound that she can hear to even indicate that something is wrong. She has no reason to be unsettled by the pure absence of people she passes in the halls. She is nonetheless.

Without windows she can pretend she imagined it - that she'll find Glimmer and she'll tell her it's an illusion, show her the clear, star-filled sky she's gotten used to.

She's not collected in how she bangs on Glimmer's door. She doesn't care.

She hears noises that don't land properly in her ears from within the room, and then the shimmer of Glimmer's magic on the other side of the door. She waits only until Glimmer's face is in view before;

"Glimmer it's Prime!"

There's alarm fighting it's way through Glimmer's sleep-haze, "What?"

A sound stemming from deeper in the room causes the two of them to turn, she can't even bring herself to be surprised that

Bow is at the window, still in his sleep clothes, pulling the curtains aside. There's already too much in her head, too much blood pumping in her chest for this to matter.

"Adora's right, he's here."

Why couldn't she have been wrong? Why couldn't this have been a trick of her own anxious mind? A self-made punishment for relaxing into the peaceable aftermath of a war she was never meant to survive. Her mind is already conjuring false casualties, wondering how many of them will come to pass. She hasn't missed war. And this is, without a shadow of a doubt, a war.

A war she'll have to win. Without She-Ra.

She grits her teeth and breathes, straightens her back the way she was taught at four years old. She can feel herself slip back into the role of a soldier as easily as one might pick up a pen.

'Shadow Weaver would be so proud.' It's more cold bitter mocking than lie.

"Glimmer, what are your orders?"

Gone is the woman in front of her soft from sleep, happy with her best friend - the man she loves. She can see the change, the tension creeping into the way Glimmer holds herself. Leadership like a heavy cloak being put on her shoulders; she knows the feeling.

She can see a change in Bow too, hands twitching as he turns from the sky, eyes shifting like he's looking for his arrows.

"Bow, contact the Alliance. Get everyone here as soon as possible. Station every guard we have, send some to protect the lower towns. Adora, we're going to see Entrapta."

Chapter End Notes

I did always say Prime was going to show up.

So, I have been scattering information in past chapters as set ups for what I need to get through the rest of this story, *however* if there's anything I've missed, I am not against going back and editing it in. This will not be following season 5 exactly (they won't be going to space for starters) and some of it, I'm guessing, won't be all that plausible but that is because this focuses so much on Catra and Adora and their relationship rather than anything else.

Sidenote: if you want to think Glow is together already past this point go for it.
My Tumblr because I don't think I've put a link to it in this fic

Saving Face

Chapter Summary

> *"I don't want to leave. What don't you understand about that?"*
> *"Don't you get it? I am* never *going to go with you!"*

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

It's been a couple hours at most and the warships seem to have stopped accumulating. She's not ruling out that there might be more on the way - there's probably even more that she can't see hanging in the void beyond the atmosphere. She can see two spires from her window, certain there's more all over the planet like nodes for a network. (She has Entrapta to thank for that thought.) As soon as they land, there's movement she's just able to pick up - small machines spilling into the sky like a swarm.

She doesn't know what else to do but stand and stare, hands holding onto her arms the way she always does. It's not like she can do anything from her prison, it is not even as if she is safe in here since it seems anyone else can come through. There's anxiety weaving its way through her veins that means that standing here is all she'll do. Anything else would feel like cowardice. And if there's anything she hopes to have gotten better at, it's not running away.

There's footsteps in the hallway she doesn't truly hear until the door clicks open, mesmerised by the enemy outside.

She turns and there's Adora coming towards her, and then there's Adora right in front of her, hair frayed and forearm pressed to her

throat. Enough to pin, not enough to cut off air. Small mercies, she supposes. Adora would probably end up with a set of scratches on her sides otherwise (followed by immediate regret.)

"Horde Prime is here, he's brought his whole galactic army. They're planting spires into the ground and surrounding the planet. What do you know?"

She can feel the shake in her arm, reads it as fury, and shoves Adora off her. Her prolonged and growing anxiety prevents her from realising that that might not help, as well as stopping her fully noticing the stumble in Adora's step from her shaking legs.

"Nothing! All *I* know is what I can see out my fucking window. Hordak didn't tell me anything. Ask Entrapta."

Her tail is lashing where it's not trapped between her body and the wall. Adora doesn't pin her again. She pulls her lip back down over her teeth, lets her ears go back as an apology for shouting.

Adora swallows. "We already did."

It's then that she finally notices the tremors in the frame in front of her, still not able to pick apart from her own stress what that means. "Then why are you here?"

"I, um…" Adora mumbles as she turns her gaze to burn a hole in the floor.

"You think I had something to do with this? I mean I did but not *this*... You still don't trust me do you?"

She doesn't know how far she believes that as she says it. She might even just be lashing out; aiming to hurt so she's not the only one, she just doesn't know. Whatever her reasons, Adora crumbles before her, what she mistook for rage morphing to blatant *fear*. Gods she can *smell* it now that her senses are catching up to her. Adora is *scared* and she was stupid to think otherwise.

This isn’t about them. She's made that mistake before.

But Adora doesn’t know her thoughts, rushes forwards to reassure her. A hand comes up to hold the side of her face and it reads like pleading without Adora speaking. If Catra *were* going to say anything, it would’ve dissolved on her tongue - Adora doesn’t *do* things like this when there’s daylight. She fights leaning into it and *wins*.

“What? No, no, of course I do. Catra I promise I do just… If you don’t know anything then I - I don’t know. I just…” Adora sighs shakily, hand dropping away from her face. Catra can see her wince as she does so. “We’re in over our heads. Anything will be useful.”

“I can’t help you with that. He’s powerful, he’s got an army spanning galaxies, that’s all I know.”

Adora being this...she dares to say intimate, with her right now means it comes out sharper than she meant. Adora’s head falls into her hands with another sigh, fingers tugging at her scalp, and her claws flex with the need to ease her.

“Hey, come on,” she’s slow with touching her, brings her claws in as she guides Adora into the armchair a few steps away from her. She strokes down one of her arms how Adora normally does for her and crouches in front of her knees.

“Hey, I’m sorry okay? If I knew anything I’d tell you, you know that right?” And when Adora doesn’t move, “Stop tugging.” She pulls gently at Adora’s wrists to stop her pulling her own hair out.

She’s thankful Adora’s not crying when she finds blue eyes again, she wouldn’t know what to do then, this she might be able to handle. She doesn’t let go of her, just holds her hands instead of wrists in a way she never could in the Horde.

“I don’t know what I’m doing Catra. I don’t even know where to start without She-Ra.”

She wonders if Adora's told anyone else about this in the weeks since they first discussed it. Knowing her, she won't have, which...she doesn't know what to do with. Happy to help, scared of saying something wrong. Surely Bow, even Glimmer, will help better than she can. They've been doing this feelings crap their whole lives.

'But they don't know Adora like you do.'

Pride and possession aren't needed now, but when are they ever? She's always felt too much, and it's never done her any favours, but at least she knows how to deal with it. She can focus on one thing if she really tries hard enough instead of letting the storm take her. And there has never been anything easier for her to focus on than Adora.

"Being She-Ra wouldn't tell you what to do right now."

Adora stares down at their hands. "No, but she would fucking help."

Unfortunately she knows from experience that that is true. The Rebellion would've been crushed without She-Ra. If not from the force of the Horde, then by their own hopelessness. And she likes to think if she would've joined Adora from the start the Horde would've never stood a chance - not against the two of them.

Which is the *only* reason she says; "What if I…helped?"

Adora snaps to her eyes, in pure unbridled shock. Hands that were limp in her hold hold onto her as if she's going to disappear otherwise. "What?"

There's really no going back on this for her now. She sighs, pulling her hands from Adora's crushing grip carefully. She feels her tail twitch with how avidly Adora watches her as she sits next to her. There's hope in Adora's eyes she knows has every right to be there, it still puts her on edge.

She turns to snark, because she is still *her* even after everything, "I *was* always better at strategy than you, and it sounds like you guys could really use all the help you can get."

Adora's body finally moves at that, no longer a statue in the position Catra had left her in. Adora's hands twitch in her lap like she wants to wring them and her leg twitches like it's about to start bouncing. The stench of her fear has dissipated but it's painfully easy to translate Adora's anxiety.

"Why?"

Adora's eyes are just so wide and so fucking blue and she is, has always been, so weak for them when they're full of hope like this.

"Because I'm tired of war, Adora."

She doesn't blame Adora for how clearly she cannot wrap her head around her words. There's a whole process going on in her head that Catra pretends she's not watching. Adora straightens from her slouch, back like a soldier, and chews at her lip before finally turning back to her.

"You're gonna help the Rebellion fight the Horde?"

She can in no way read Adora's tone, but she takes it as disbelief which is...fair.

"Don't say it like *that*." Should Adora say anything, she would absolutely deny calling the sound of her voice anything even *close* to a whine.

But really, she wouldn't care all that much. Not when Adora looks this happy. She has actually never seen her this happy. She can't feel the sting of the realisation over her own joy; *she* has made Adora this happy now. Maybe she can do something without entirely fucking it up.

She's kidding herself if she thinks she can see Adora's eyes glowing before she tackles her in a hug.

Adora

"I don't want to leave. What don't you understand about that?"

"Don't you get it? I am never *going to go with you!"*

She's in shock, she must be. If she were any more emotionally drained she'd probably start crying, as it is, she hasn't dropped that low yet. She just lets herself smile obnoxiously wide into Catra's shoulder. Catra doesn't hug her back, but that might be because she's got her arms pinned to her sides.

She lets go when she feels able to (probably taking a little too long but she *has* managed to remove herself from Catra's person now), and finds Catra looking at her softly. There's still definitely discomfort, she's not smiling and there's a light bristling to her fur, but there's no harsh lines or blades.

"It's more...I'll help other people who live on this planet stop it from being destroyed by someone *not* from this planet."

"Right, right, sorry," it's slightly teasing on purpose, just because it makes Catra relax a little.

She's unsure what it would take for her to just kiss Catra right here and now, she's sure there is something that would do it. But she's still pushing down this burning inside - the one she's labelled love - and that's exactly what fuels it, so she manages to just sit and smile.

"I want you to help, don't doubt that, I am…" so very in love with you, "Ecstatic, obviously… But I do need to talk to the others about it. We also need to figure out what Prime is going to do first."

Not asking before doing something has caused a lot of problems. Between her, Bow and Glimmer mostly but it started even with Angella, and she is not about to make that mistake again unless absolutely necessary.

Catra's claws catch in a cushion. "I'll watch then, make a log or something on everything outside, I just need a pen and some paper."

"Yeah okay, that's a good idea, I'll bring it later. I would lo-like to stay, but..."

She manages not to wince too much at her stumble, it's not like a near confession, but it *feels* like it. Saying 'love' anywhere with Catra near just sends her into a mild panic, no matter the context.

"You need to go, I know. Keep me updated?"

Catra's ears perk up with the question and she has to stop herself smiling stupidly at it. "Of course."

She doesn't hug Catra despite the way her whole body seems to be straining for it. She has more things to worry about than how cold she feels leaving Catra like this.

Glimmer manages to catch up with her in a hallway a little under an hour later. Bow's not with her but that doesn't matter all that much right now, he's probably coordinating messages with Entrapta by now.

"What did she say?"

Right, the reason Glimmer sought her out. "She doesn't know anything, Entrapta was the only person Hordak trusted enough to talk about him with. But she, uh, she said she'd help us."

Glimmer halts in her tracks, "You're joking."

She curses herself for her own smile but she just can't get rid of it. "I'm not. I'm going to take her a pen and some paper for her to make a log of everything she can see, then...I don't know, I'll train? Whatever you need me to do. Before I go, can you ask the other Princesses when they get here if they're okay with her

leaving her...room? I'm not going to say anything to her until they agree."

"Guess she's not much use sitting in there" Glimmer sighs, "She's really the last of our worries now but I have to ask, do you think there's *any* chance she'll side with him?"

There is not even a thought of hesitation. "No. And I'll vouch for her in any way they want." There's not much she *wouldn't* do for Catra at this point.

"I trust you Adora. And you don't need to convince me to accept any help she's offering, even if I don't fully trust her. We're going to need everyone we can get," Glimmer starts walking with her again, "As many sorcerers as Mystacor can afford to spare are coming here, they're bringing some powerful artifacts. Mostly to protect them, but they'll help at least."

She asks too hopefully, "Is there anything you need me to do?"

"Not that I can think of. Just take Catra her things and then...guess all we can do is wait for people."

She was afraid she'd say that. Training it is then. If Catra says yes she'll do it with her but...maybe that's not such a good idea. Catra's hands and claws on her skin, her joy when she wins, the way she huffs when she loses; there's no room for how it makes her feel in a war. She could barely let herself feel it when she foolishly thought this was over.

She doesn't need to be able to fight Catra this time. She's *with* them this time.

'With you this time.'

Her mind is still as traitorous as always, it seems. She has a feeling the peace period will have made it worse if anything. She cannot afford to be distracted by Catra.

'Didn't stop you before.'

Distracted by an enemy, distracted by an ally, there's not much in it, either way it is not *good*. Especially when she doesn't have She-Ra anymore. And that's really it, isn't it? What's making her dread like this; it's just her and her own weaknesses. There's no powerful beloved warrior waiting under her skin anymore. It's just her. And she, as it turns out, was never very good at saving anyone by herself. She's seen and felt enough of Catra's scars to know that.

It doesn't matter what Catra said, peace allowed for her to alleviate her guilt a little but war *needs* She-Ra. The Rebellion needs her. And she's useless.

The hand Glimmer puts on her shoulder makes her flinch. "I know you want to help, but you just can't, not until we know more and not without… This is going to be hard on everyone, okay?"

"I know."

Gods does she know.

She doesn't train with Catra. Every good thing she would feel would just be soured by the threat hovering outside the window. She goes to the castle gym and beats punching bags till the protective bandages covering her knuckles wear thin and daylight fades.

She checks in with Glimmer and Bow before she goes to bed. Glimmer informs her that she had dinner with Catra and given the circumstances it shouldn't warm her the way it does. They invite her to stay. (*"Adora, don't pretend like you're going to sleep well."*) Still, she declines, tells them they should be together before the everyday falls apart, and that her training's left her exhausted. Both excuses rather than lies.

She's not expecting their awkward shuffling, blushing and general fluster. More so than usual if she accidentally mentions something that might refer to their feelings for one another.

She takes a risk, “Did something happen?”

Glimmer takes Bow’s hand in the doorway, “I told him. He said it back.”

That is the absolute last thing she is expecting right now. “Oh shit. I mean I’m - I’m happy but why now?”

“It happened two days ago before...all this,” Glimmer half-heartedly waves her free hand as she says it.

That is...bad timing more than anything. “Guys I’m sorry. I know how much you’ve both wanted this.”

Bow startles under his fading blush, turns to his...girlfriend, maybe? “Wait you told her too?”

Both her and Glimmer laugh a little, too tired for anything more. “Yeah, I did.”

“I’ll leave you guys to work this out then.”

They give her a hug anyway;
“Thanks Adora.”
“Goodnight.”
“Night, guys.”

She sighs looking at the time on her trackerpad. It’s late, too late to justify this without a nightmare maybe. But she’s been facing the looming cloud of her own weaknesses all day; everything she isn’t without She-Ra. And unfortunately there’s few things that can draw that pain away like Catra, conflicting as that truth feels.

: Can I come see you? :

: I already assumed you wouldn’t even try to sleep :

: Is that a yes? :

: Yes moron :

She is doing this to be better; the more energy she has, the more she can do. She's ready with the excuse in her throat when she opens the door. But Catra doesn’t ask why, despite how clearly awake she is, she doesn’t even move in the bed, letting Adora figure out her position on her own. She doesn’t hold Catra tonight with no nightmare to facilitate it. There are *limits* to this strange thing they have, not fully repaired. It's fine though, Catra just being near helps, more than she will ever admit.

Even this distance hurts in it's own way - the same and so different to the Before. But this is a war. And she can’t be selfish; can’t afford distractions.

Chapter End Notes

> So. I added Glow in there completely out of the blue. I wanted at least one pair to have gotten their shit together.
>
> Also if Adora had kissed her in this I definitely would've put the line: "If I'd have known you'd kiss me when I joined the Rebellion, I would've done it a lot sooner." And you know I would've made it angsty as fuck.
>
> Me: remembers Adora feels She-Ra when she feels love
> Me: oh shit I gotta do something here

Tied Up: Part I

Chapter Summary

Catra gets out.

Chapter Notes

Know that Adora and Entrapta have had some hours of light bonding through near-death experiences in her lab at this point.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The Princesses arrive the following day, the sorcerers too. The Rebellion did not have to wait too long for aid and *she* does not have to stew long in her inaction.

There's two artifacts brought from Mystacor that can work to boost the sorcerer's natural power, and with a Runestone so close, most magic is supercharged anyway. A magenta barrier, incredibly similar to Catra's prison except it works to keep people *out*, bubbles to cover the whole of Brightmoon. It is just as well so many sorcerers came; it takes at least three to maintain the gigantic spell at any one time. And it does not help when they are having to make holes in it to let refugees and allies inside.

But it is just as well; everyone is sure the reported highly advanced white bots sent out from the spire bases are on their way to attack. They can't really think what else they could be even for. Catra's been trying to see them and estimate numbers, but the Whispering Woods has been providing an unfortunate cover even from her wicked sight over the past two days.

Their first official meeting in the time of the new war is about Catra. It almost feels like old times. No one seems to be exactly *comfortable* at the idea of having to deal with Catra in general,

Mermista especially, which is fair. But they do reluctantly agree to let her out to help. It's dire, and they know that. They *understand* that.

They also understand that Catra is practically the best strategist to ever come out of the Horde. She is impulsive at times - Adora knows that better than anyone - but Catra also knows better than to give into that in a war. Something much of the Rebellion, including herself, are not so good at ignoring. Catra is an advantage they can't afford to forget about.
And she hates thinking of her like this. But if it's what she has to do to get Catra free and let her actually help then it's what she'll do.

The first talk doesn't exactly go well, but it is during this short period of time that she realises how little she actually mentioned her relationship with Catra to those in the Rebellion. Frosta didn't even know they were *friends* before she joined the Rebellion. Just thinking her *'obsession'* as Mermista so kindly put it, was just because Catra was leading the other side of the war.

"You were obsessed with her after the Battle of Brightmoon Adora."

"I wasn't obsessed." But the face of literally everyone there was enough for her to be quiet after that.

Scorpia had just said , *"I think Catra should be allowed to help if she wants to,"* and left somewhat abruptly after that.

That was this morning's talk, and now with Perfuma and Entrapta (who they have finally managed to coax out of her Brightmoon lab) here an actual verdict can be reached.

"Entrapta, how do you feel about it?"

Adora's spent more time with Entrapta in the past two months than she thought she would, and her lab has become a not-

exactly-safe refuge should she need it. She actually really enjoys the busy work around the lab, and just being an ear for Entrapta to fill with things she can barely grasp. There's always noise there, even if it's just a nostalgic hum of machinery. It's enough; she hates silence.

"I've been comparing success and risk rates of both sides strategies during the war. Having Catra make plans with you would vastly increase chances of success *and* reduce risk rates."

Perfuma sits beside her, Scorpia on Entrapta's other side, "Entrapta, I think what Adora is asking is whether you are comfortable seeing her again after what she did."

"Oh." Entrapta keeps her eyes on the table before pulling her mask down. They've all since learned that that just means she feels vulnerable or wants some time to think through something.

Glimmer hesitates, trying to make sure she's reading it right, "Do you want some time to think about it?"

"Yes...thank you."

Adora would breathe a sigh of relief if she were alone; interactions, especially group interactions, are still very hit or miss with Entrapta.

With no one speaking for a moment, Frosta takes the floor, ice spilling out of her hand and spiking along the edge of the war table when she slams her fist down. (It makes her fight to suppress a flinch.) "Well, I don't trust Catra."

No one is surprised at how strongly Frosta can hold a grudge. (Gods knows how long it took Frosta to forgive *her* for Princess Prom and she just unintentionally insulted her a couple times.)

"Duh."

Mermista and Frosta were never close as far as she's aware, but they've been agreeing on all things Catra given the Battle for

Salineas and Frosta's unforgiving nature. And Adora gets it, she does. And she *knows* she's biased, but it is only the two of them who are against it so clearly this is a good idea. It is not just her affection for Catra making her request this.

"I know that, and I don't expect you to, but I *do*. And you trust me, right?"

The ice recedes a little, "Well, yeah but…"

She pushes just a little more, "As bad as the Heart was, if it weren't for it, we would have lost the war to the ambush and Hordak's weapon. Without revealing Double Trouble we wouldn't have even *known* about the ambush. *We would have lost*. You can't deny we need her."

"Well I *could*, but…" Mermista gives one of her signature sighs, "Yeah, I guess having her on our side would help."

Frosta remains unrelenting until Glimmer suggests that she be personally in charge of guarding Catra when she is in the meetings. And oh will Catra hate that. Adora can already *hear* her scoffing already at the thought of being guarded by a child (of course Frosta is a teenager now but Catra won't care about the distinction.)
She manages to make it so it is just when Catra is actually around other Princesses that Frosta's service will be invoked. She figures then at least Catra will have the walk to and from the war room without a Princess she doesn't know (and who doesn't like her) breathing down her neck.

With their most violently-inclined opposition out of the way, Adora turns back to the last go ahead they need, "Entrapta?"

"I am okay...with seeing her again." It sounds genuine, even if Entrapta doesn't raise her mask for her to check in properly.

"Okay, and thank you."

She doesn’t know if she should be thanking her, but it’s what she does. There’s more she should say, but she doesn’t know what exactly. She watches as Scorpia offers her a pincer and purple hair curls around it.

“So we all agree, Catra can leave her cell?” Glimmer brings her concentration back from trying to think of what she might say easily enough, but she decides she will talk to Entrapta after this. She feels like she owes her that.

“On some conditions.”

Everything beyond this feels like it doesn’t even matter all that much; *Catra is getting out* for one reason or another.

“Entrapta, can I talk to you?”

The Princess is still seated on Emily, tinkering with her trackerpad the way she has been doing since she initially agreed to Catra being let out. Scorpia seems to be trying to make sense of it as the rest of the Alliance trickle out.

But Entrapta removes her mask when she hears her and nods, and she looks as normal as she ever does, no obvious emotional distress. That’s reassuring at least, though it’s not as if Entrapta reacts the way Adora’s come to expect from people most of the time anyway.

She’s had time to think about what she wants to say, trying to make it as to the point as she can - the way she’s found Entrapta responds to best. “I want you to know that Catra didn’t kill Hordak, it was an accident where some cables broke and a pipe near the forge fell. He was underneath. Catra doesn’t care if other people think she did it, but I thought knowing might make it easier for you to see her.”

Entrapta turns her gaze back to the table, but she doesn’t pull her mask down, which she takes as a good sign.

She's grateful of Scorpia chipping in when the silence stretches, "You can still feel uncomfortable or even upset around her - that's something Perfuma kept telling me before I went to go see Catra. And if it gets too much, I want you to know you can tell any of us and we'll take her back to her room."

"Logically she should stay and I should leave, considering what we are trying to accomplish."

"Maybe, but Catra's not a Princess. You should be here. And we need you as well, you've done more to help us than she has." She may not know Entrapta all that well, but she knows that much.

She also knows both of these Princesses stayed with or *went to* the Horde because they felt they fit there better. And they are *all* getting better at including them because of it. That feeling of rejection, Adora's starting to understand; just another consequence of giving up She-Ra.

"Really?"

"Yeah - think of all the bots you've reprogrammed. No one else could do that!" Scorpia's right. Even with Bow, they really had no technological match for Entrapta's First One's tech-powered bots.

"Catra didn't kill Hordak?"

If she were anyone else she would put a hand on her shoulder. "No. And she's sorry about hurting you, sending you to Beast Island and everything."

"...She named stars after me."

She didn't think Entrapta would remember that. "Yeah, she did."

Something shifts, any weight held in Entrapta's shoulders vanishes. She looks up at Adora with what seems to be an earnest half-smile. "I've thought of more upgrades for my bots, I was actually...working on them in the meeting."

She is trying to understand Entrapta, but she doubts she ever really will. She doesn't know if this is Entrapta being okay with everything and moving on, or if she's deflecting because she's upset. She could ask, but it doesn't feel like it's her place.

Instead, she offers the only thing she really knows Entrapta might want; "Entrapta do you want some help in your lab right now?"

"Right now?" Entrapta's already rising up on her hair.

"No She-Ra, meeting's done for the day, I can't really help with protecting Brightmoon…"

She's essentially pleading Entrapta to give her a purpose right now, as miserable as that sounds. But she seems overjoyed to be giving it to her as she tugs her out of the room by her wrist, Emily beeping as she follows.

Yesterday was the second time Adora has failed to bring Catra breakfast since they began this ritual. (Aside from when she's not in the castle at all.) She does not intend to make it again unless necessary. Catra's going to have even less visitors now - not that she had many to begin with.

But that might not be as much of an issue as she's been thinking, not since Catra's getting to leave her room for the first time today. And she has yet to tell her.

Catra's surprised to see her, though she tries to hide it, it's obvious by her tail and ears. "I didn't think we were still doing this," Catra tells her when they've sat at her table.

"Yesterday we had a meeting, otherwise I would've come. You...don't want me to not come, right?"

"...You know the answer to that." Catra scowls at the table and she can't stop the smug smile that takes over her face, not for the way it makes Catra scoff and roll her eyes to hide her embarrassment. "Shut up."

"You *like me*." She's expecting a kick under the table that she doesn't get.

"I *don't*. You'd think if I said it enough it would get through to you. Your stupid hair poof sound proof too?"

She does kick Catra (lightly) for that one. "That's low."

Catra points a claw at her, "That's fair is what it is."

It's nice, to still be needling her like this even with everything going on. She's not really sure why she'd thought it would leave but...it hasn't, and that's all that matters.

"I didn't tell you I was trying to do this before because I didn't want to get your hopes up, but...you're getting out. Next meeting, I got the Alliance to agree to let you come. You said you wanted to help," she adds on the last bit as an excuse for...what? She succeeded in getting Catra out of her fucking prison, she doesn't understand why she's trying to give *reasons* for that.

"I know I did. And I'll...help. When is it?"

"In a couple hours. I didn't want to tell you until I knew for sure," she says carefully.

Catra nods but her eyes are fixed to the table edge, face completely blank. Her arms come up to hold herself slowly, probably not even fully aware she's doing it. It's when her ears start going down that Adora says, "Hey, stop. It's going to be fine."

The blank look vanishes from her eyes at least, "Adora I haven't left this room in two months. I think I'm allowed to be a little...freaked."

Well that's about as close to an admission of being nervous as she's going to get right now. She stands, trying not to make the chair scrape on the floor too loudly, she fails and Catra flinches.

She *picks up* the chair to move it next to her and Catra doesn't move away from her when she puts a hand on her shoulder.

"I didn't mean it like that, you can feel however you want, but it is going to be *okay*. I'm staying with you until Glimmer comes to take the barrier down."

Catra's hands fall from her arms into her lap, and she still won't look at her. "Is it going back up again?"

She chews her lip, "Yes...they don't want you free yet. I'm sorry."

Catra takes a moment to breathe, and really that's the first time she's ever seen her do anything like it. It's strange. She still expects anger at every turn and it feels...cold without it in a way. But not bad, just...she doesn't know what to do here.

"Getting out at all is more than I thought they'd ever..."

Catra trails off. She'd almost forgotten about that; that Catra thought the best way for her to - repent? Keep people safe? She's not really sure - was to stay hidden away in here.

'Maybe you should've thought of that before you went ahead with making big decisions about her life without her.'
'You're doing it again. Assuming what she wants.'

She tastes something bitter in her mouth, feels the trickle of guilt in her stomach. She wants to apologise. But she doesn't. Her tongue gets tied in it. She settles for staring at her hand on Catra's shoulder, and feeling the thin fur between her fingers.

"There are some conditions, but I'll tell you nearer the time, okay? It's nothing bad, you won't like them but…I just don't want you thinking about it until you have to."

"Sit with me while I go through the log?" It sounds hollow.

"Of course."

Catra distracts her from all she's feeling wonderfully well all things considered. The log is boring - or it would be if it weren't Catra explaining it. Snide comments about their powerful enemy and all.

It is later than Adora is expecting when Glimmer knocks on the door, and they both go to the door to greet her.

"Hey Sparkles."

"Hi Catra, Adora tell you what's going on?" Glimmer rolls her eyes at the name but her voice tells Adora she's actually some sort of glad to see her. That's a good start to this at least.

"Yeah, but she hasn't told me these 'conditions' I gotta meet. Though I think I can probably figure it out."

Glimmer's holding one of the conditions in her hands: cuffs (and the liquid needed for removing the barrier in the other.) Specifically ones that cover the whole hand. Glimmer holds them up and has the decency to look sorry about it. Catra doesn't look too agitated, though maybe she's just hiding that. She resists taking Catra's wrist in her hand to ease something she's not even sure is there.

"And a bodyguard in the form of an icy teenager for when you're around Princesses."

That makes Catra's tail twitch, and gets her arms to cross. "Oh great."

"It's the claws they're most worried about, and don't act like that's unfounded." Glimmer points a finger, Catra rolls her eyes. And Adora just watches this, still unused to the two of them getting along, before she takes the cuffs from Glimmer and sets them on the table. "Okay, my dad told me how to *disrupt* the spell rather than completely dismissing it, so it should be really quick to put back up again."

Catra just shrugs and stands aside to let Glimmer into the room. The Queen trails a few lines of purple solution around the center of the spell - a box around the heart of it - and the blue flickers. It's not swirling the way it normally does, suddenly static. The colour fades to white.

"Is it...done?"

"Yeah, should be, um, how about you try go onto the balcony?"

Catra is (rightfully) suspicious of it as she gets to the window. She presses a claw to the barrier and it breaks like a film, her whole hand passes through, then the rest of her follows, leaving the wall intact behind her.

Adora has not seen Catra in full, unbroken daylight in something like seven months. Not since Elberon. And it is a stupid thing to have missed, but daylight makes the edges of her figure glow orange like flame. Her shorter hair holds the light better, and she hates herself for thinking it.

She watches from afar as Catra carefully puts her hands on the white stone ledge like it might burn her. There's something that makes her realise Catra could escape right now; just jump off the balcony and be done with her. But she won't. And not just because of the war beyond Brightmoon. (Catra would be able to survive it out there, she's sure. She thrived in the Crimson Waste after all.)
She meant what she said: she trusts Catra.

She feels frozen in this moment, utterly, completely unaware of anything else but Catra against Brightmoon sky - it doesn't matter that it is pink instead of blue. She doesn't know why she wants to cry. It - Catra is - she's *here*. She's in Brightmoon. She has been for the past two months but it just feels *real* now.

"You okay?"

Glimmer is next to her, worried about her. Catra is not the only thing in the world. Still, she sees her ear flick in the short

distance.

“Yeah, yeah, I’m fine. How long?”

“Uh, about fifteen minutes now… Should I leave you two to it?”

“Yeah I,” she still got her eyes on Catra, sees no signs of her disagreeing, “I think that would be best.”

Glimmer nods beside her, “I need to go get some things from the library, I’ll see you *both* there.”

“See you in a minute, Glitter,” Catra calls back from the balcony without turning. There’s a tension in the words that could have so many origins.

Glimmer teleports away, leaving just her signature sparkles, without another word.

Before she can go to the balcony, Catra turns, coming back to her. Catra’s not crying but she’s not exactly *okay* either. There’s fragility in her movements.

“I get why I’m emotional, but why are you?”

She just shrugs, trying to keep her breathing as flat as possible. “You’re here.”

She thinks Catra understands with the soft way she’s looking at her, eyes shining from held-back tears. Catra coughs and looks at the cuffs still sitting on the table. “You gonna tie me up or what, Princess? Think it’s fair that you get me back after all this time.”

It’s a distraction, one they both need. And she takes it easily, jarred by the name and the words themselves. It’s an excuse to cross to the other side of the room and collect the metal.

She waits for Catra to offer her hands before starting to tie her into them. “I am sorry about this. It’s just the terms Glimmer got people to agree to.”

The cuffs are heavy, about an inch thick of pure metal all the way round. Is it excessive? Yes. Would it actually keep people safe from Catra if she wanted them hurt? No. But the Princesses don't know that.

"It's fine, not the first time. Or even the second actually."

Explains why she wasn't all that distressed about it, she supposes. "Can you tell me?"

Catra flicks her eyes up from her hands, "...Sure. Well one you already know, Bow and Glimmer kidnapping me -"

"- Wait, they kidnapped you?" She almost drops the cuffs entirely.

Catra just snickers, "They didn't tell you?"

"No, when was this?" She buckles one of the fastens, watching Catra's face for when to stop.

"Not long after the Battle of Brightmoon, maybe three months?"

"Yeah I - I wasn't around then much, training with Light Hope."

"Who?"

"She-Ra hologram. She's gone now though."

Her tone must be short enough that Catra doesn't press, or maybe she just wants to keep this light right now. "Hm, remind me to tell you about the kidnapping though later. It's funny. They were awful at it. Couldn't handle me."

She can't help smiling at Catra's own smug grin, "Didn't hold back did you?" The metal encases one of Catra's hands completely.

"I did actually. No bodily harm. Okay, I did bite Bow when he tried to gag me."

She laughs probably a little too loudly. She doesn't really know why. "His mistake."

She switches hands after the final buckle is fully tightened, and ignores the little foolish thing in her head telling her she won't be able to take Catra's hand if she needs it. It is *foolish* because when has Catra ever needed that? She probably won't even want her to touch her when she feels so vulnerable.

She swallows around something, "What's the second?"

"Hordak. After he found out I lied to him about Shadow Weaver escaping. And after he tried to suffocate me with whatever machine he was building back then. I'll thank Entrapta properly for saving me one day. Remind me?"

She stops her in her movements completely. She looks up, half horrified, and expects to find at least discomfort on Catra's face. There's nothing, resignation if anything.

The sadness that eventually crawls into Catra's eyes is for her, she knows that, not anything to do with the memory. "What, you think everything was all power trips and evil scheming?"

She is slower to bring the metal around her hand after that, this seeming suddenly so much worse.

"I at least hoped you were *safe*." It comes out small and quiet.

Catra *shrugs*, "Nah, higher up just meant punishments from new people."

She is not all that far from distraught. She feels so *stupid*. When was the Fright Zone ever *safe*, especially for Catra? She'll figure out a way to blame herself for this soon enough, she has no doubts about that. "Catra…"

"Adora we do not have the time, and I do not have the *energy* to do this right now," Catra snaps, evidently done with her empathy. She probably reads it as pity. (And some of it *is*...)

"Right, more important things than you telling me your death sentences." She works on the final fastening, tugging maybe a

little too harshly with her own upset.

“I know you’re being sarcastic but that’s actually true.”

The last fasten clicks into place and she watches the muscles in Catra’s arm flex as she gets used to it. There’s really not much give in the chain between as they find out when she tests them.

“You know I could get out of these if I tried? Cut through them with my feet which *haven’t* been bound at all. Your Princess friends did not think this through.”

“Well I know that, but they don’t.” Her fingers twitch now she doesn’t have anything to do with them.

Catra gets closer, knocks their shoulders together like she’s not tied up at all. She looks at her with a raised eyebrow, Catra just tilts her head in return. “So I have you to thank for not being completely incapacitated?”

“I guess so. You should be thanking me.” She doesn’t mean it, Catra knows that, which is reassuring.

“My hero. Now just take me to this stupid meeting, moron.”

It just lacks the amount of teasing that would comfort her. If someone asked her to explain what exactly shows Catra’s fear she wouldn’t be able to explain; it’s just written into her, despite how well she hides it.

“Hey,” she knocks their shoulders together again, a little softer, not knowing if Catra will respond well to anything else right now, “I’m going to be with you the whole time.”

The fear ebbs slightly; Catra’s tail stop its low subtle flick, instead eerily still. Adora’s half sure if they weren’t about to leave, it would curl around Catra’s leg. And yet Catra nods, motions for her to go forward.

She knows Catra won’t appreciate her drawing attention so she does as silently told. The door is light as she opens and stands by it. She’ll wait however long Catra needs to go through this door. The message gets across without either of them speaking. And Catra gives a sigh and then an attempt at a smile.

Catra may not have her mask anymore, it is still safely hidden away in Adora’s room, but it turns out she doesn’t need it. Her wary false smile vanishes, a picture of disinterest in its place. She doesn’t know how to feel about it’s return. In some way it helps. It just means she knows Catra can do this, they both can. There is reassurance in Catra’s constructed confidence. She finds ease caused only by familiarity in the way Catra breezes out of the door like it means absolutely nothing to her.

Chapter End Notes

> Ok so I tried my fucking best at an Adora-Entrapta interaction but it was fucking hard. (Also maybe I'm projecting onto Adora because I love Entrapta and I want people to understand her.)
> Also just Scorpia running away from the meeting because it's so obvious Adora loves Catra back and she doesn't want to say anything like 'she was obsessed with you too, y'know.'

Tied Up: Part II

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Adora doesn't lead her through the hallways, trusting her not to run by walking ahead. And given her track record, she's more touched by it than she ought to be. She's trying to make a map in her head as they walk but she's a little preoccupied with the near-blindingly pristine cream walls. The smell she's long used to, but the *light* is as awful as it was those first few days in her cell.

She knows Brightmoon has guards, so the obvious lack of them must be due to the war waging outside. It is not what she's focusing on, actually she's not focusing on much more than her careful facade. It has been...a while since she's employed it. She'll blame Adora and Bow for that later.

Brightmoon is bigger than she thought, some of the castle having been built both into and around the mountain. But soon enough she hears a collection of voices, too far away to distinguish, but loud enough she knows the open door at the end of the hallway is their destination.

And even if she couldn't deduce it from that, the way Adora takes her wrist in her hand would let her know. It both comforts and distresses. But she knows exactly why Adora's done it.

She hears Entrapta first before anything else, the familiar sound as cutting as it's always been. All she's doing is explaining an upgrade, presumably for a bot of some kind, but it is enough. She freezes suddenly, enough so that Adora jolts with it. Her tail is snapping behind her and she cannot bring herself to try and stop it. There is definitely more her body is doing but it doesn't matter.

“I didn’t think she’d be here. Adora you didn’t say she’d be here!” she hisses. The screech of her claws against the inner metal is muffled but she knows Adora can hear it.

She glares at Adora for the four seconds it takes her to figure out who she’s talking about. The ice Princess appears in the doorway up ahead but she can’t take her eyes off Adora’s face; both so she can get answers and so she can continue to see the only familiar thing here.

“Frosta give us a moment,” Adora doesn’t look away either as she says it, just pulling her further away from the door by her wrist. “Why didn’t you think she’d be here? She’s a Princess in the Princess Alliance! You -“ Adora drags her other hand across her face, “I should have said, I didn’t think and I’m sorry. But she's staying. You said you want to make things better, well this… dealing with Entrapta and Mermista and everyone else is how you make a *proper* start. Not staying locked away from everyone. If you decide you don’t want to help us you can go right back in that cell.”

She doesn’t growl, with only Adora to hear her it’d be petty rather threatening. And she’s not - she’s not angry with Adora. She’s just...lashing out because she’s hearing something she doesn’t like, exactly as she used to. She imagines that’ll happen a lot today; old wounds means old patterns.

The supposed bodyguard stands glaring at them from down the hall but Blue-Hair can’t hear them. Which is maybe the only thing stopping Catra from doing something destructive. Like leaving scars in the walls as both an outlet and a warning. Doing things like that was always meant to drive people away, but it won’t drive *Adora* away, it never did and it won’t now.

It’ll come again, the anger. It is her protection after all, it’s how she made it as far as she did. But she can’t use it like she used to and she knows that. She *won’t use it*. Not with Entrapta, not Scorpia, not Adora. Not even Glimmer or Bow. Those that hate

her though? They'll get anger and everything that comes with it, she is not *that* good.

Maybe later, when she's back in her room, away from all the *new* pummelling her senses, she'll be grateful for the handcuffs. It might very well stop her doing something stupid.

That being said, if she weren't in chains right now she'd be able to grip Adora's wrist and have her know what it means. But she can't, so tragically she has to use ground-out words, "Stop me? If I start getting too…"

Adora's whole face softens the way it usually only does when they're alone. Annoyingly it makes her breathe easier. As does the gentle hand on her shoulder. "How?"

She nods her head towards Adora's hand, "This is good."

Adora gives a miniscule smile that she seems to know she shouldn't have, "Try not to piss everyone off."

She smirks, because that outcome is practically inevitable, and keeps her eyes on Adora as she walks backwards, out from under her hands. She has all that false confidence thrumming in her muscles when she says, "Why not? What are they gonna do? Lock me up?"

Adora is exasperated with her but there's a smile she's fighting down underneath it, an almost glow in her eyes that makes her feel electric to have caused it.

She stops when the ice Princess - who she doesn't actually know the name of - is beside her, glaring up at her with condensed fury. "What's up Snowball?"

"Wouldn't you like to know Horde Scum."

Oh it's so easy.

Snowball is dragging her along by the chain between her hands then, and she growls unwittingly. There is a silence that falls as she enters what she guesses is the Rebellion's war room, and she despises it. She manages to keep her head up though. She will not cower before these people, not when she has been in so many *far worse* situations. This is uncomfortable - *awkward* - at best.

They are technically on the same side now, as much as she hates it. So if she doesn't fuck this up completely, she'll come out of this unscathed. Or at least in the physical sense, she realises when a block of purple appears in her peripherals.

She counts seven people not including Adora, Snowball and herself. It is a too long ingrained survival instinct; people, exits, architecture, shadows. It won't help the gnawing anxiety she's burying, but she'll at least feel safer knowing how to escape.

And then there's the warmth of Adora at her side once she catches up to her, and it feels just a little better. Especially because Adora has to half-jog to keep up with Snowball's pace and it makes her snicker.

"Sit." Snowball is taking this so seriously she almost laughs. But she doesn't actually want to get punched in the face right now so she holds her tongue and she takes the seat she's forced into.

Whatever the reasoning is for the position - seated between the Queen and ex-She-Ra, carefully away from anyone else - she has to admit it would be how she'd do it if she were worried for everyone's general safety. She really needs to stop unintentionally underestimating Glimmer. She'd think getting trapped in a burning bunker would've taught her that better.

There is all of one foot in between hers and Adora's chair and she wants it *gone*. Mostly for the fact that Snowball stands between them, glowering with her arms crossed and hands encased in ice. Adora leans on the armrest closest to her and she does the same,

both to be closer to her and to smell how much Snowball doesn't like it. If she were a hybrid, she'd be hissing.

"Just so you know, Frosta's always this intense."

"No, I'm not." And just like that she sounds as young as she is, all the threat gone.

Glimmer snorts at the head of the table, "Yes you are. Everybody ready to start?"

Everyone nods. Catra watches the way Adora subconsciously shifts into her perfect soldier position, back sickeningly straight. It causes a pang of sadness she doesn't really understand. She forces herself into a more upright position, and purposefully skips her eyes over Entrapta and Scorpia directly opposite her as she looks to the Queen.

Glimmer takes a steadying breath before, "So, Horde Prime is here. He is here for a reason and as of right now our priority is figuring out why and what we're going to do about it."

Well, she kind of thought that was obvious considering the fucking army that happens to be scouring the planet surface, but really what does she know?

"Doesn't he just want another planet to occupy?" Bow says from Glimmer's other side, ever the optimist.

Occupation is a light word for whatever it is Horde Prime plans to do to the planet. She only needed the warships in the sky to figure that much, the spires just confirmed it. *Take over* seems more appropriate. *Crush into submission* if he truly is a worse version of Hordak and is worried about rebellions *like this one*.

"We might very well be the only planet left in the Universe not under his control, so most likely. Which also means we can't rely on any interplanetary aid."

All the ugly feelings she has right now, the ones making her barely even acknowledge Entrapta across from her, don't seem to apply to the Princess. Either that or Entrapta has just gotten a lot better at hiding her emotions. Catra hasn't even looked at her yet, but the sound of her voice makes her want to wince. She won't let herself.

Glimmer takes a moment to process that train of thought, "Well I don't think any of us were counting on *interplanetary aid*, so that doesn't change anything."

Catra can only imagine Entrapta's disappointment. She can't think of anything that Entrapta wouldn't do to be able to study an alien species.

Just because she's not looking at Entrapta doesn't mean she's ignoring Scorpia next to her. (Though maybe she's also unintentionally been doing that as well.) Scorpia waves while a pirate a few seats down from her says something loudly. She makes her chains jangle in response with a shrug and a small quirk of her lips. Scorpia is happy with it though. As is Perfuma beside her, surprisingly if the matching wave means anything.

Catra wonders if Perfuma, or even Scorpia, has made it mandatory that they sit next to the other in meetings. She wonders it only because it's a nice thought, and considers it for herself and Adora. (Although with her, she doubts anyone else would feel comfortable enough to be that close to her.)

Either way, the embodiment of flower power is seated on Scorpia's right hand side. "Could he be after the Heart? I know we stopped it but...he won't know that."

Super weapon at the center of the planet capable of destroying they don't know how much? Remarkably sensible thing to assume. Good to know Scorpia picked a smart one.

"Adora, can the Heart even work without She-Ra?"

“I - I don’t think so. The sword was the channel, it shut down without it so…”

She risks a glance at Adora at that, finds her face carefully calm though the tension in her jaw suggests otherwise. She wants to reach out to her; these people apparently still don’t know what talking about She-Ra does to her. But she doesn’t do anything, for selfish reasons of course. She just can’t be *soft* like that in front of these people.

Gimmer states, “I say we assume it’s purely a takeover until confirmed otherwise.”

It is silent after that until Scorpia speaks up, “Alright so...what do we do?” And yes, Catra is shocked by it, but Scorpia feeling confident enough to speak out here is a *good* thing. She’s quietly proud of her.

“Well,” Bow starts, “We know Prime’s clones have a,” he looks at Entrapta. And subsequently so does she. And it stings. Bad. Liquid guilt in her stomach.

“A hivemind.” Entrapta doesn’t even look up from whatever’s in her lap to say it.

“Prime sees everything they do, knows everything they do and we’re guessing he controls them all from his ship.”

The disturbing information would distract her, if it weren’t for Entrapta choosing to at moment to look at her. It’s a brief thing, blank and unperturbed. Catra quickly fixes her eye to the circular table, registering that the beeps she's been hearing intermittently are coming from a trackerpad held by purple hair.

“It’s fascinating as a concept. I’ve already tried accessing the system through wireless transmission with the drones but the algorithm’s too protected.”

Of course she has. It’s comforting.

“So do we try and...break the connections between the clones and Prime?” Perfuma looks to Entrapta to see if she’s got it right, but Entrapta’s still got her eyes on the screen.

“If Horde Prime has been around as long as Hordak led me to believe, then he’ll be completely disorientated, if not incapacitated by a sudden cut off from the network.”

“We can keep trying, but we can’t rely on it. We can’t afford to give Prime any information. If anyone goes beyond the barriers, they need to avoid all bots and clones at all costs.”

Catra thought that was obvious but Glimmer says it anyway. What civilian is going to leave? These danger-prone, self-sacrificing idiots are the only ones who’ll even think to go outside.

“I could, theoretically, access the network by getting close enough to a spire since the energy output is so great. Or maybe even through a clone!”

No one says anything. Which is ridiculous. Has no one else been watching like she has? Of course it is *Entrapta* and she won’t care about the dangers, but the others fucking should.

“With the amount of bots and drones you’d be lucky to avoid being killed on sight, let alone make it out alive.” Maimed is really the best possible outcome.

It’s then that she realises she’s just spoken to Entrapta for the first time since she condemned her unconscious body to a supposed execution. And she’s telling her not to get herself killed. The irony.

“I could teleport her in?”

It occurs to her then that the majority of people at this table have magic; and powerful magic at that. She’s never had that particular brand of power on her side before and she's got...mixed feelings about it considering the witch that ruined her. But she’ll get over it. Magic is just another tool. It’s an *advantage*, one she would be

a fool to dismiss. And besides, they brought her here to plan. She should probably get on that.

But before that she needs to convince them to not do *this* reckless plan, and something she never had to do before; explain why not. She never had a council in the Horde, and it's not like she would've listened if she had. She went against every superior she ever had and was worse to those below her. But that's not important right now; she just has to be better than that. This isn't about her.

She leans back in her chair, calculating all the ways that Glimmer's idea can go wrong. She'd drum her claws on the table if she had use of her hands.

"Just appearing out of nowhere only works if *you* know what's there. And you don't. You could take a bigger team for defense, but that would draw too much attention from the bots on the outside."

Bow nods, probably relieved that his best friend isn't going into *that* particularly dangerous situation. "What if we tried disabling the spires entirely? Close them off to stop more bots coming."

"Only if you can do it remotely, or from a safe enough distance, I guess."

There's a silence after that which she can only hope is because they are thinking and not waiting for her to do something. She can feel Adora watching her and any other time she'd welcome it (feel empowered by it.) As of right now it makes her fur bristle.

"I think that's a line of thinking for when we have more information. So if we ignore the spires for now, is there any way to attack Prime directly?"

And here's where her and Glimmer differ apparently.

"Now that's a fucking terrible idea. We'll just have his whole army breaking down the only protection we have."

Glimmer reluctantly accepts that she's right and sits down.

"Are you actually going to give us anything useful? Or are you just going to shut down every idea we have?" the Princess whose Kingdom she destroyed, people she saw murdered, the one person she might have pushed even further from her mind than Entrapta, says.

She whips her head to the sound and finds deep-seated, genuine *hurt* in the eyes of someone she doesn't even know. She thought she knew all the ways to feel self-loathing but this is new. This is knowing she had an impact in the most horrendous way possible. There's no escaping this, and there's no previous trust to fall back on here.

Turns out she's been on a hairpin trigger this whole time. It's not exactly surprising.

She feels that familiar anger, the one she just *knew* would show up. It's fuelled by guilt and the need to defend, like a spark in her chest; destructive and begging to be let out. She's glaring with bared teeth, claws cutting into metal and a growl sitting in her throat.

"Mermista, my dear, I don't think that's the best idea right now," she hears whispered down the table. At least she has a name now.

And then there's Adora's hand on her shoulder, dousing the feeling, dragging her back up from red. Exactly like she asked her to.

"Other than the hivemind and not being able to access his system, how much do we actually know?"

It's nice to see that Adora hasn't forgotten the years she spent (trying to) talk down precarious situations her growls, hissing, claws and comments caused. It's still so fucking strange to find similarities between their old lives and this one.

She closes her eyes, forces herself not to visibly melt into the comfort Adora's voice and touch brings. She almost forgets about Frosta's presence hanging over her shoulder - she felt the ice near her head, but it retreated too quickly for it to bother her all that much.

"Oh practically nothing. Extensive army, tech more advanced than I've ever seen, controls most of the Universe beyond Etheria." Entrapta probably shouldn't look that excited about that but...it's Entrapta. (It is a lot easier to look at her now that she has a measure of observable hatred to compare her to.)

"Brilliant. We're doomed."

Her jaw twitches at Mermista's voice, but it's fine, she's not talking to her.

"Don't fret my love. We faced uh -" The flamboyant pirate looks at her, gritting his teeth as he seems to try and find a way not to say her name, she kind of wants to dare him to. "- Well we've faced dire circumstances before."

Gods if someone had said that to her even a few months ago she'd take it as a glowing complement of her achievements. It's an...unexpected piece of proof that she's improving, however slowly.

"As flattering as that is, Horde Prime is not me. If he's anything like Hordak he won't want his hands dirty. He'll stay hidden safely away in his ship and send out - there's reports of clones?" Bow nods, "We'll be swamped with clones and bots and whatever else he's got as soon as he realises we're the ones trying to stop him."

Entrapta darkens a little at the name but there's not anything she can do about that right now.

"Catra's right - that felt weird to say."

"Even weirder to hear, Arrow Boy."

He smiles a little at the name she hasn't used in a while. "Prime has more firepower than we've ever seen. Until we know how to hurt him - is it even worth trying?"

"What do you mean?" She doesn't jump at the sudden unexpected voice over her shoulder no matter how much she wants to.

He addresses everyone in his response, "Is it worth the people we might lose fighting against an enemy with no apparent weaknesses?"

And this is when she realises just who she's working with. It's jarring. And she'll have to adjust to it. But it makes so many things that much more obvious.

"No." Everyone turns to her sharply and she successfully fights down a hiss. "The only people you're willing to risk - because for some reason you don't have an army - are yourselves and the Rebellion needs you here defending not getting killed trying to get information. Brute force can't solve this - it won't even make a dent in *his* army. You don't attack."

"We can't do nothing." Catra's kind of grateful for having a reason to be able to look at Adora, to be able to see the little frown lines she's got on her forehead. Always insisting that something has to be done, Catra can hardly believe she used to get angry at it.

"I didn't say that either."

"So what *are* you saying?"

Any response she might give Mermista will end with snarling, so she doesn't even bother, "Entrapta have you sent your bots out to do recon?"

If the bots don't have cameras or at least microphones installed, she'll be beyond shocked.

"No, they're still helping with the war relief. But…" there's a brief minute of tapping then, "Half of them are now."

She nods at her, gets a neutral expression back. The guilt is still there, but given that Entrapta is talking to her, not glaring like *some*, it is a lot easier than she thought it would be to do this. Scorpia is grinning ear to ear for obvious reasons. She doesn't even want to tell her to stop which is another nice little bit of progress she'll cling onto.

"The other half should defend the people who aren't here. They've still got their weapons right?" Adora asks.

"Not all of them." She trusts Entrapta is already sorting out the algorithm for which bots are to stay. "I have a surplus of bots I have yet to upgrade, should I do that?"

Bow thinks for a moment, "Can you get them up and running so they can protect the barrier?"

Entrapta just grins in response. Nice to see that losing Hordak (and surviving Beast Island) hasn't changed her all that much.

"Should we even be encouraging people to come here? The more of us that congregate, the more clones and bots that'll come to attack us."

Since protecting people is not exactly her strong suit, she decides to take a backseat on this one. Glimmer will figure out how to protect her people.

"We should collect accounts from refugees about what they've seen," Perfuma suggests.

She lets her attention wander after that, since she'll go right back to captivity and won't be able to help. She doubts any civilian would even want to talk to her anyway.

"Frosta, you said that your castle is holding refugees as well?"

“Yes, I’ll -”

It is easier to breathe without Frosta directly over her shoulder, even if she has just moved to the opposite side of her to review numbers or something.

She turns away from the head of the table as soon as she hears Adora shift in her seat. She finds Adora half slumped into the laughably princess-y design, far from the soldiers posture she’s been holding this whole time. She drags her tail over Adora’s leg in a silent question, grateful for Frosta not being between them so she can do it safely.

Adora looks over at her as her tail retreats, tired and...disappointed, she thinks. “She-Ra. They need her.”

She should’ve figured as much. “I know. But they need you alive more than anything.” Adora hums nonchalantly, looking down at where she touched her. There’s a subtle twist in Adora’s lip and it has worry swirling in her gut. She swallows before saying, “Adora, I need you to promise me something.”

Adora’s eyes flick between hers as she tries to figure out what, but remains stubbornly silent.

“I need you to promise that you’ll be smart about this.”

Adora picks at her nails and gives a single laugh, “You calling me dumb?”

“No. I’m calling you impulsive.”

Adora just scoffs in response. Even though she *knows* she’s right. Adora’s still that same self-sacrificing soldier she’s always been. She’s never had reason to change, so why would she?

And Catra hasn’t had to consider the idea of losing her completely in a long time; not since she *lost* her to the Rebellion, not since the portal. And it is a horrible collection of thoughts, feelings and memories to return to. It doesn’t flood through her, more like the

faucet of her mind's been loosened. It's going to build and break. But not just yet. She just hopes she'll be alone for when it does.

"Catra I need to help in whatever way I can. You know that."

She knows what that *means*. Whatever way - *any way* - is the same thing. Adora is reckless and determined and persistent to a fault, and she loves her for it dearly, truly she does (didn't always, torn between hating and admiring for a multitude of reasons.) But it was always her downfall as well as an asset. She's exploited it enough to know that.
It makes her predictable.

"No. Promise me. No running into this head first."

'You're not going to survive it this time.'

She can't say that out loud. There's no possibility that Adora will take it the way she means it. She'll read it as Catra seeing her as weak, like she can't handle herself without She-Ra, the way everyone else has made her feel. She won't figure out that she just wants her *alive*. Which means...which means she'll have to say it. Out loud. In front of all these people lest the chance slip from her fingers.

"We - *I* need you alive," it comes out just as desperate as she feared and the vulnerability makes her skin itch.

Adora looks up at her then, at the near pleading, eyes full of conflicting emotions. She doesn't have time to decipher it before;

"Well that's rich coming from you."

Those walls she *stupidly* let drop for one fucking moment slam home again. There's a snarl ripped from her chest before she has the chance to stop it. It is a threat, and a poorly thought through one at that. But it doesn't matter. Mermista doesn't know *shit* about her and Adora.

There’s ice against her neck, burning on her pulse. She could bite down on it, shatter it beneath her teeth if she tried. But she doesn’t, if only because she realises how ultimately foolish it would be.

It’s probably meant to silence her, it does anything but. She can't roar, but gods does she wish she could sometimes.

“Frosta, please, she can’t help it.”

Well she *can* but it is hard and she doesn’t *want* to. Let them be fucking scared. She came so fucking close to destroying them all, they fucking should be.

But she deserves the reminders for all she’s done. All the scorn and hatred for the bruises she’s left on the planet. But...she also has the walking proof of her many betrayals sitting across from her, and unsettlingly fine with her presence. She doesn’t *need* the reminder for what she did, and nearly did, to Adora because it lives within her constantly, despite her forgiveness. And she especially doesn’t need it from a stranger.

All she wants to do right now is be done with this. And if she thinks selfishly enough, to be wrapped up in Adora’s arms in her bed. This is not a nightmare though, this does not justify the warmth of Adora around her. The most she has now is Adora’s hand on her shoulder, her eyes bringing her to where she’s supposed to be.

The ice recedes. Adora pulls her chair closer, eliminates the distance when Frosta tries to stand between them again. And all that anger fades to white noise. Adora is here. Adora forgives her. Adora cares. Adora knows she never wanted her dead, it was a lie she told herself spun out of pain. Adora isn’t scared of her, she is next to her, comforting her despite it all.

“She never wanted me dead, Mermista.”

She almost cries with that confirmation. She ducks her head and breathes, and it stops her from burying her face in Adora’s neck.

She'll settle for Adora's hand sliding down her arm to hold her wrist.

"She just… the Crystal Castle…"

Adora's hand relaxes its grip as *something* occurs to her. Catra has been to the Crystal Castle, left Adora for dead there, so she understands why she's thinking of it. She just doesn't know why Adora looks like she's figuring something out.

"What about it?" Glimmer asks, a reflection of Catra's own thought so exactly that it confuses her for a second that it's not coming out of her own mouth.

"It's got data crystals thousands of years old - the First Ones fought Prime, maybe they left some information about him."

That is actually...a smart connection to make. One that no one else would. And she's proud of her. (And she's glad she's proud of her.) Entrapta squeals across the table at the prospect of more tech, though she should've expected that.

But going to the Crystal Castle means leaving Brightmoon, which means she's going to be facing drones and bots and clones and everything else *without She-Ra*. And sure, Adora can take care of herself but...not like this. Not when she's ready to charge in without a plan at a moment's notice like she so clearly is. Because she didn't promise. She *didn't*.

And those memories start dripping a little louder, a little bit faster.

"I'll go tomorrow."

Of fucking course. Why does she - why does she even bother? There's a flare in Adora's eyes and it is hopeless to fight it. It's that damn determination; that need to help in whatever way she can. Headstrong moron.

She can feel her ears flattening to her head. She looks to Bow and Glimmer, surely they'll agree it is too dangerous for her to go

alone. They have to. They're not fucking stupid. Luckily she finds what she's looking for in Bow's eyes, he nods to her in a silent understanding.

"I'm going with you."

She almost sighs out loud out of relief. Instead, she remains as blank as she's able to project, "Glimmer, should go too."

She really ought to not say anything else, it'll just come out bitter, but she has to give reasons for wanting three of the Rebellion's most important members to leave at the same time.

"Going through the woods is a fucking death sentence right now, teleport them there and they can message you for when to teleport them back."

Adora's fingers brush against the pulse in her wrist and her ear flicks in response because *somehow* she momentarily forgot Adora's hand was on her. She's getting caught up in her own head and she really cannot afford to do that right now.

"Plus Prime doesn't get led to a First One's ruin," Adora says with a little smile that says she's going to get her way. Catra's never really seen it used when not in regards to her. (And it's annoying because she kind of loves that smile.)

Glimmer relents, nodding before summarising;
"Fine. So Entrapta, work on the bots, Scorpia go with her. Catra continue your log, Adora, Bow prepare for tomorrow. I'll take a shift protecting the border. The rest of you decide who's going to interview refugees and who'll defend with me - long range attacks only."

Glimmer walks with her and Adora back to her room, puts the barrier back up and leaves. Catra notices her not-so-subtly psyching herself up for what may or not be a fight before she teleports away with a wave.

“Wasn’t so bad was it?”

There's less tension in Adora’s shoulders than there was earlier, which is at least a small relief. It’s nice knowing she’s not the only one to have found that mildly harrowing.

“Hope by that you mean it could’ve gone a lot worse.”

Adora smiles as she takes her hands, beginning to unbuckle the many fastens. It takes a while, but without conversation she luxuriates in the gentility with which Adora treats her. A warrior’s hands turned soft is always a fascinating thing to see.

She flexes her claws when the cuffs finally do come off, feeling the itch underneath them that wants her to rip something, “Haven't got anything I can tear into, have you?”

“No.” She pouts to get Adora to roll her eyes at her. “You’ll live… Hey I’m - I’m proud of you. For today. I know you hated it.”

She takes a step back, feeling her throat close up, “Yeah, yeah whatever.”

The smile shrinks, “I don’t know how early I’m going tomorrow, but I’ll try and come if I can.”

The reminder that Adora is leaving tomorrow twists her face into something she doesn’t want anyone to see. The memories haven’t stopped flicking through her head - every time she thought she’d never see Adora again, and every injury she’s ever acquired. At least she’s almost alone.

“What’s wrong?”

Or she will be if Adora leaves right now like she *should*. She breathes about three times before she finds an answer, “You didn’t promise me.”

“What?”

“That you’re not going to get yourself killed trying to - to prove yourself -“

“- That’s *not* what I’m trying to do.”

And this is why she didn’t - gods this is exactly what she thought would happen. Why is she so bad at this? They’re supposed to actually be able to talk about things now. “That wasn’t what I meant - I - you’ll do anything for this - you’ll *be* anything for a cause. Don’t even pretend otherwise, you were made that way.”

And it is a horrible thing to say. But she says it anyway because then *maybe* Adora will actually listen to her. Only problem is she has no idea if it’ll work. She sighs at the upset on Adora’s face.

“Just...promise me you won’t go head first into danger unless you have to.”

That about as concise and honest as she can get it, but it doesn’t feel like enough. She feels like she’s asking so little but she also knows Adora won’t see it that way.

“Catra if someone's in danger and I can help? I’m going to do whatever I can.”

“I know, *I know that*, it’s what you *do* but I just…”

And it’s selfish. It’s so fucking selfish of her. And hypocritical in many ways. She wants Adora alive; she wants her to deny everything she’s ever been taught and raised to believe so she’ll come home safe *for her*. To be able to be here with her. Damn the world. She just wants her safe.

Those memories that have been dripping through her conscious are finally finding their breaking point. Does she even want to be alone right now? She can’t tell.

'I can't deal with the hole you'll leave in me if I lose you. I've felt it before. I can't do it again.'

If she were braver she'd say it. Maybe Adora deserves to hear it. Or maybe it's better to keep these selfish words to herself. It'll save Adora the guilt and the obligation to do as she asks. But the *obligation* might keep her alive. So it's selfless as well? She wants Adora alive, that's a *good thing*, so what does the reason matter?

There's so many turnovers in her thoughts she's almost dizzy. She steadies herself on the only thing in reach, which just so happens to be Adora herself. Adora who's holding onto her upper arms in an instant, eyes worried like she matters right now.

She doesn't, this is about Adora. And so she clings onto her, not caring about how desperate and fragile she must look. "Just be careful."

"I will be. I promise I'll come back."

And that's just it, isn't it? The leaving. The staying. Them together, them apart. Adora in danger, Adora safe. She wants to believe her. But parts of her *just don't*.

Air is coming into her lungs too quickly, burning on the way down. She's not crying but Adora's eyes are swimming in her vision. She knows what this is, and it's not as bad as it's been before. This is fine. She can handle this. It's shallow water, not drowning.

"Catra?"

The heat, the firmness of Adora herself - here, *not gone* - is grounding. Of course it is. She takes her lack of shaking to be a good thing. She's already coming out of it before it's even properly begun. Adora doesn't know that though, she crushes her into her chest. It's probably a good thing she hasn't been pulled completely under a wave of panic otherwise she wouldn't be able to breathe here. But she can, she gulps down breaths that taste like Adora's worry; like her need to calm her down.

She clutches onto her, not caring about anything else beyond the embrace. She soaks herself in it; warmth and home and Adora's little whispers of, "You're okay, you're safe, I'm here, I'm not leaving you."
There's tears because of it, ones she'll be ashamed of later. She already despises herself for being this fucking weak, however, there's nothing she can do about it but try to surface.

It comes easier than ever for obvious reasons. She's never had anyone here to help her through it, she's never even let anyone *know*. Except, of course, Adora. Because she's always the exception to every rule she's ever made for herself.

She chokes out a thank you into Adora's shoulder, she wants her to know that she's grateful for her being here, holding her like this. Because she *needs* this. Tragically and pathetically, she needs this. She needed it in that meeting and she needs it now.

"Do you want me to stay tonight?"

'Always.'

If she could, she'd purr her agreement into Adora's clothes. But as it is, all she can muster is a weak little nod. One Adora doesn't question.

Adora leaves once she's calmed down. She has a mission to prepare for. But she comes back before nightfall. Adora doesn't take her into her arms immediately when they settle down after dinner. She falls asleep next to her. And in some ways Catra likes that she can't sleep; it means she gets to watch her like this. Peaceful. Safe. Soft. *Here*.

She watches the stars when all her attempts at sleep remain futile. Or at least she does until Adora stirs beside her of her own accord. She only half-wakes if the unintelligible mumbles are anything to go by. It doesn't seem to be a nightmare.

Adora reaches out for her in her waking sleep and Catra feels every tension inside her drain away. Barely, she holds herself back from stroking through her hair. She shuffles closer and Adora’s arm wraps sloppily around her waist, she grunts into her hip and it’s unbearably cute. But she gets the message.

She lies down on her side, feels solid muscle and giving flesh curl against her back, feels Adora's even breathing in her hair. It doesn’t seem to matter how happy being with her like this makes her, how calm and content, it still takes hours for her to fall asleep.

Chapter End Notes

Happy birthday to Adora!

If I put Netossa in this, her and Catra would win this immediately and I've still got an ever-growing number of chapters to write, so yeah a lot of characters aren't in this

Also fun fact: if a cat can purr it can't roar. It's the defining difference between a 'big cat' and a small cat. So Catra is kitty <3

Me: I need to write this long and difficult chapter
Also me: write them kissing

Entrapta

Chapter Notes

IT WAS ENTRAPTA'S BIRTHDAY ON THE 24TH!!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Yesterday was...a lot. Not that she expected much else. Catra getting out, the tension between *everyone*, the near fights and Catra letting her calm her down. Though the fact that the last thing worked so well is still astounding, she thinks once she's woken up with Catra in her arms. (She doesn't *remember* falling asleep like this but she must just be remembering it wrong.)

She should probably get up. Or at least check the time. They're not exactly leaving late, but she doesn't want anyone to come looking for her and see Catra like this. (She tells herself it's not because she's oddly protective of seeing Catra vulnerable but that is a damn lie.) And just like every time she's found herself in this position, she wants to trail kisses along the side of Catra's face and brush through her hair; just make her purr in general. And just the same as always, she refrains. Because she's not allowed to want that.

Every time she's tried to sneak away from Catra after waking up curled around her, Catra's caught her, so there's no point in trying. She turns over, heart melting a little at the way Catra shivers with the cold where her skin's now exposed, and reaches her hand blindly for the trackerpad that is usually under the bed. She finds it and checks the time; early enough. She can waste half an hour here before there's any risk of being late.

She never curls back into Catra once she's moved away, *because* she wants it so badly. Also because Catra is usually also awake by this point. Today's not different; Catra's not moved yet, but her soft snores are breaking off quickly and her tail's starting to

animate. Catra wakes fully with a groan as she rolls onto her front, burying her face in one of the pillows. It makes Adora snort just loud enough to get a one-eyed glare.

There is the barest whisper of a purr muffled by bedding and she kind of wants to drag Catra into her side so she can feel it. Catra didn't purr at all last night and in some irrational way it made her feel like she failed to make her feel better. In some ways, she supposes that was true. But she has the confidence in herself that it wasn't *just* her fault she was feeling that way.

The sound cuts out all too soon. Catra narrows her eye before pushing herself up to sit. She probably doesn't mean for her tail to arc across the bed and hit her side but who knows.

"You're still here?"

"Got about half an hour, more if I push it."

Catra nods before her face sours like she's remembering something. She probably is. And gods does Adora hope it's not going to be a repeat of yesterday. She never wants Catra to cry, but especially not because of her. That being said she will not hesitate to postpone the mission should Catra need her to be here.

"I'm sorry, about how I acted yesterday, that was…" Catra trails off with a look on her face that says she's disgusted with herself. And she can't allow that to stand without at least trying to reassure her.

"Yesterday was a lot, for both of us. I - I needed this," she waves a hand at the bed, "Just as much as you did."

It's completely true. She needed to be sure Catra was going to be okay after everything. She obviously *was not* but at least she was here able to hold her. However, Catra doesn't look like she believes her. She doesn't outright call her a liar though, so that's good.

With the bed up against the wall, Catra has to climb over her to be able to get up. Her tail drags along her arm as she stands. Adora pretends she's not watching Catra's every move as she draws the curtains. She doesn't even know why she bothers anymore - pretending that is.

Catra grabs her log and makes a few notes, looking far too grim for early morning. And yet it's still soft; Catra in morning light with her sleep clothes and wild hair. The light's not fully broken yet so her eyes are shining more than they usually do.

And she's beautiful. And she can't tell her that.

"Want me to go get breakfast?"

Catra nods, eyes still out the window, probably counting. Adora sighs as she gets her clothes from the top of the dresser where she left them last night, before retreating to the bathroom to change. She takes her sleep clothes back to her room with her and finds her own trackerpad (just in case) before collecting breakfast from the kitchens and returning.

Catra's dressed too when she returns, staring out the window again but in one of the dining chairs now. She settles into the other, waiting for Catra to turn and take her plate but she never does. Now she's worried. Even the sound of the trays on the table didn't make her move. In fact, no part of her is.

And she's not thinking clearly when she stands and walks in front Catra's line of sight. It breaks her out of her haze at least. Catra asks a silent 'why' and she honestly can't answer for a minute.

"Don't scare me like that."

She doesn't understand it either. It's not even worth trying to figure it out right now, or even today. There's too many other things rattling around in her head for that to become another. Catra swallows and turns, taking a tray and waiting for her to return to her seat.

“Any, um, reason for that?” she tries, ignoring her own weird behaviour.

“Remember what you’re going to do today?” It’s carefully emotionless.

“...Yes.” Obviously. Catra starts her meal without looking at her. “Is that your way of saying you’re worried about me?”

Catra shrugs but her tail flicks high enough that she can see it over the edge of the table. She doesn’t *want* Catra worrying about her. She knows how awful it is to worry about things out of your control but she is also still going to go. She needs a distraction for her, preferably one that’ll last until she gets back.

“What if I get Entrapta to come see you while I’m gone? Both of you seemed alright yesterday.” Catra just carries on eating, giving nothing away. “I know you might not want to and I’m not saying you have to but I just...there might not be a lot of time for it in the future.”

Catra’s ears droop as she realises she is right. “Can’t afford to wait, huh?”

“Yeah…”

“Alright. I’ll talk to her *if* she wants to see me.”

“She will. Want Scorpia too?”

“Ask her that.”

Catra’s got a right to be as...snappy as she is. Technically yesterday counts as a set back as well as progression. She gets it, and she’s determined not to say anything that’ll make this mood worse. Doesn’t mean it’s not annoying.

“I just think if you have to worry, then worry about something you can actually *do* something about.”

Catra *seems* to soften a little, "No I - I get that. I want to see her when we're not surrounded by your Princess friends who hate me. It's not...going to stop me worrying though." She half spits 'worrying' the way cadets used to say 'weakling'.

So she ignores that part, for Catra's benefit. She would say 'they don't hate you' but that's probably a lie at least in regards to Mermista. Maybe even Frosta.

"Better than being here alone with your thoughts."

"True."

She grabs one of the staffs that sits against the wall by the door. It's the only weapon she's trained with at all since the sword, and the one she knows best. She turns back to Catra, finding her looking smaller than she has in a while. She quickly wraps her in a one armed hug, unfairly elated when Catra's hands land warily on her hips.

Catra moves away from her before she lets go. She knows it's just Catra...protecting herself, or whatever it is. But it's like the old her in a way that makes her feel guilty. Her feeling like this is her fault after all.

"See you in a couple hours."

"Yeah…"

Seems the best way to convince Catra of that is to just...come back.

Catra

Adora was right to suggest Entrapta coming. Though she is no way going to admit that. It is probably one of the few distractions

available that might actually work. Not that she's exactly going to *stop* thinking about Adora. That's a lost cause.

She gets a message from Scorpia asking if they can come see her now about an hour or two after Adora leaves. She's not proud of how long she waits to send a message back.

No one knocks, though that's to be expected from these two. They walk in, Scorpia first and a mass of hair second. She's just glad it doesn't hurt seeing them.

"Hey Entrapta, Scorpia."

"Hi Catra." It's sweet that Scorpia's smiling so damn wide. She probably wants this to work as much as she does. More, considering it's *Scorpia*.

Entrapta waves silently, face entirely blank. Right, and this is Entrapta. It has been...a while since she's had to use her language. That being science and facts; the best, and possibly only, way of keeping her attention. Logical rather than emotional, which means it's a far cry from any other interaction she's had since the Horde. Emotions confuse Entrapta to a degree and it used to be annoying that someone was so inapprehensive in the face of her threats. Now, that might actually work in both their favours.

"Why don't we do what we did when I came?" Scorpia suggests.

Better than standing silently in the middle of the room. "Entrapta do you want to sit down?"

The Princess nods but doesn't move, so Catra takes a seat at the table first. Scorpia guides Entrapta gently forwards, and the Princess opts to take the chair opposite her while Scorpia takes the armchair.

She's glad Scorpia's being relatively quiet for this, as glad as she is that she came at all. It means more than she'll let show. But this is about an apology before everything else. The catch up she knows Scorpia is yearning for can happen if this doesn't immediately fail. She doesn't really have any concrete idea of how this'll go, she doesn't even know how upset Entrapta is with her.

And she's stalling, essentially. Which is kind of shitty of her when she asked them to come but...this is still so fucking hard. Or at least it will be if she ever fucking says anything. She just has to say sorry and go from there. That's all. This is *Entrapta* she's not going to be confused if there's nothing preceding it.

She hates that she has to steel herself for this but… "I'm sorry. For everything. And I know that's a lot to apologise for but -"

"- Did you kill Hordak?"

She should've seen that coming. Entrapta has a unique way of being direct. She's missed it. She's even missed her ramblings that leave her head spinning as she tries (and ultimately fails) to keep up. But once she gets past that, she realises Entrapta doesn't sound upset. More some desolate form of curiosity.

"In a way, yes. Do you want me to tell you what happened?"

Entrapta nods, sitting forward. She'll want to know everything. Even Adora doesn't really know the whole story - and she's not meant to be thinking about Adora right now. That is the last thing she needs; worrying about whatever stupid danger she's gotten herself into now.

Catra looks at Scorpia, searching for anything that'll tell her if this is a supremely bad idea. Scorpia just has an encouraging, though wary, smile. She hears a click and some static, and Entrapta's hair is now holding her recording device. And wow she hates that but this is her apology so she's not going to say anything.

And she tells her. Hordak finding out she lied, him trying to kill her with the blaster, her up in the rafters, destroying the weapon, and

the ceiling coming down on him afterwards. It's not graceful or smooth in the way she tells it. Often taking back words to get it as true as she can remember it. But she's not crying either.

Entrapta turns the device off, thankfully not playing any of it back. She doesn't want to lie and say she feels bad about what happened. But she does say she's sorry for the pain it's still causing Entrapta now; that is true. One apology won't bring back her friend. She's not so unempathetic to not realise how hard this must be for her.

"I know you're sorry - your ears have been sloped down this whole time... I miss Hordak. People tell me that's okay and normal. They expect me to be angry at you but I'm not because it's not your fault." Entrapta debates to herself silently for a few minutes before, "I forgive you for sending me to Beast Island."

Well that's already far more than she thought she'd forgive her for. Entrapta not forgiving her for indirectly causing the death of her best friend - she'd be surprised if it went any other way. But based on what she knows about Entrapta's experience on Beast Island, her too-easy forgiveness to that kind of tracks.

"Oh, um, Adora told me you had a good time there," she tries.

And just like that she lights up. It is a jarring mood switch. "I did! The entire island is malfunctioning First Ones Tech. It had so much information about the planet. I was going to go back, maybe even set up a specialised lab there but then Horde Prime showed up." Entrapta is smiling just thinking about it.

And she smiles as much as she's able to in return, "Bet you didn't want to leave." Entrapta doesn't pick up on just how strained all her words are, but that's a good thing.

Entrapta shouldn't have even been there in the first place. Although it did mean Glimmer got her father back, she remembers that. Micah and Entrapta are probably the only ones her horrible actions ever benefitted. (Because it certainly didn't help her.)

“I didn’t but Adora said I could mess around with an intact First Ones spaceship if I came back. She’s called Darla and she’s amazing!” Entrapta could be describing a human if she didn’t know better, with how wistful she sounds.

She's unsure as to exactly why Entrapta talking about Adora so casually stuns her for a second. Enough that she rapidly blinks a few times to bring herself back to hear Scorpia say, “She spends most of her time outside the lab with her.”

She turns to Scorpia, “The one we found in the Crimson Waste?” There can’t be that many spaceships lying around on the planet, surely.

Entrapta nods happily. “I wanted to try and get her space ready again, since we’re back in the wider Universe I could actually visit other planets.”

She can’t help but look at the warships speckled across the sky, “Don’t really think that’s a good idea right now.”

Entrapta’s hair deflates a little, “No. But after this! The Universe will need to adjust to an existence without Prime.”

Well it’s nice to see someone believe that they’re going to win. Because honestly she doesn’t. Not that she’s going to tell fucking anyone that. Maybe she’d feel differently about that if Prime had any fucking weaknesses she could exploit. Right now everything is about defense and that’s never really been her strong suit.

“Yeah. When this is all over. You can probably do whatever you want. Working on anything interesting during the peace period?” She’s actually genuinely interested, but she’s not sure if that comes across.

“Most of my efforts were going towards automating menial processes needed by the people, as well as redistributing and repurposing old Horde tech...” It sounds like something she’s carefully practiced, or at least not a whole truth.

“Okay. And what were you working on that you didn’t tell any of the good guys about?”

Entrapta looks like she’s just passed a test or something, which considering her, it wouldn’t be out of character for her to have made one. Her theory isn’t exactly disproved by Entrapta typing something into a modified trackerpad. Scorpia is beaming at the two of them anyway. And when Catra leans back in her chair, she finds her smile is now natural.

“I was working on portal technology again now that we’re out of Despondos.” There’s that manic grin.

Catra tries her damn best not to let her face drop, lets it fade slowly instead. Portals remain a persisting motif in her nightmares. Angry red swirling storms paired with whoever her subconscious wants to torture her with that particular night. She doesn’t want to ever see one again if she can help it, let alone go through one willingly. Even if they do work.

“Oo I was helping with that!”

But it’s important to Entrapta. And nothing horrific is going to happen if she gets her to talk about it. Letting Entrapta talk about her work and listening is the best thing she knows to offer her. It was what ‘bonded’ them or whatever in the first place. Obviously the other Princesses have been more accommodating in that sense now, but she can still do it too.

“They’re working now?” It sounds way too forced.

“No, not yet.”

Catra knows exactly how much she means that ‘yet’ part. “Be careful. Both of you.” It comes out before she can think better of it.

She ignores Scorpia’s little ‘aw’ as much as she can, hissing only quietly, enough that they both know it's for show. Entrapta is

smiling still as she types something into her trackerpad (at least it looks like a trackerpad.)

"Can I ask about that?" she asks, figuring it's about her work. She's wrong.

"Oh, yes of course. Back before you sent me away," Entrapta completely ignores how she flinches at that, "I was trying to understand interpersonal relationships more and I collected all the data I had on how people interacted with me. It was an algorithm for determining whether or not someone was my friend. Do you want to see?"

It's not even nice to be right. "No, I'm okay. That would compromise the data anyway wouldn't it?"

"Yes I suppose it would. I've been trying to implement a sub-module that takes into account past experiences as a foundation for renewing a relationship."

She feels her tail curl around her ankle. "Sorry." It's maybe the first reflexive apology she's ever given.

"It's not just you, Wildcat. She also had to program it for the whole 'leaving her in the Fright Zone' thing since it affected the results for everyone in the Alliance."

It doesn't do *all* that much to comfort her, but it's something. "Okay... How far did you get with the portals? Without the sword and everything?"

"They haven't worked so far. I don't have the materials here to make the infrastructure and hardware. And most of my stuff is still in the Fright Zone. But when I do get them working? Oh it's going to be revolutionary!" When not if, it's enough to get her to smile again, though much smaller. "In theory, we'll be able to cross galaxies in a few minutes, oh think of the civilizations I could see."

"I'm happy for you. Studying all of that has gotta be your…" she waves her hand, "Dream I guess."

"It is, it is!" Entrapta claps like she does when she's excited (if she's not jumping around on her hair.)

There's more typing and it sets her on edge. Her tail must start snapping or something, because Scorpia tells her, "She's just making notes of what you're doing, she's not actually inputting it."

She mutters, "Guess that's better."

"Other people got uncomfortable when I inputted directly into the system while they were with me."

And then, just because she can't help but think about her, "How's Adora doing?"

Adora's doing better than most, it turns out. Coming to see Entrapta at least twice a week. And Catra loves her for it. Conversation goes off the rails after that. Really whatever Entrapta wants to talk about her and Scorpia listen. It's more than maybe she ever did in the Horde. And it has a low burn of regret firing in her gut.

(She's glad Scorpia never brings up the *Adora thing* with Entrapta here. She'd ask too many questions and really, Catra's unsure she'd be able to get through that without driving the two of them away.)

There's a sudden beeping after a while that has her tail stick straight behind her. Turns out Entrapta set aside exactly an hour for this. Fit with a timer and everything.

"Sorry Wildcat, Entrapta's got a schedule these days, I forgot about it."

"It's fine. That schedule include sleep?" She has *never* seen this mad woman sleep. Not once. In the Horde she figured if Entrapta had any powers besides her hair and brain it must be that.

Entrapta just laughs though. “I’ve still got the upgrades to install in the bots. *Some of them* aren’t responding to the new code all that well,” she says it how superior officers used to scold her before she hit double digits.

Entrapta rises up on her hair, ready to leave with a wave but she stops her, “You know, you ever want someone to rant to about morally ambiguous experiments, you can come here.”

“Okay!”

She catches Scorpia making one of Bow’s ‘big eye’ faces at them both. “Don’t say it.”

“Super Pal Trio is back!”

She sees the hug coming, doesn’t fight it. She’s getting better with this. She pats the princer wrapped tight around both her and Entrapta, “Okay, okay you’ve made your point.”

Considering she doesn’t have to fight to be able to breathe, she’ll assume Scorpia’s getting better at controlling her strength. Or just has just very recently realised breathing is important.

As soon as they’re both put down, Entrapta says, “Bye Catra!”

Unsurprisingly, she rushes off down the hallway as soon as she gets the door open, her hair waving for her as she gets stuck back into her work. Catra swears it's like she’s got a magnetic pull towards her lab.

“You better go after her before something goes wrong.”

“Yeah, oh boy are those bots being a problem right now. She thinks it might have something to do with the Moonstone or the barrier.”

She shrugs, “She’ll figure it out.”

“I don’t doubt that.” She walks Scorpia to the wide open door, not expecting the Princess to turn around again. “That seemed to be easier for you. Apologising.”

She huffs, “Been getting a lot of practice.”

“I’m just proud of you.”

Apparently it doesn’t matter who says it, or how many times, hearing that never fails to make her emotional. Probably (definitely) because she never heard it before coming here.

She wraps her arms around herself, “Thanks.”

Scorpia puts her pincer on her shoulder, “And Adora will be fine.”

Scorpia runs off after Entrapta before she has a chance to react.

Chapter End Notes

> That bit where Adora's like 'don't scare me' is because of the finding her on the throne completely immobile, like Catra's always moving so when she's still and silent it freaks Adora out. I didn't really want to explain it in-text so...
>
> And you know how Entrapta had that graph set where she was like Catra's my friend the data says so, yeah she's adding onto that. I’m weak for super pal trio sue me. Also found out that a common neurodivergent thing is experiencing no relationship decay which honestly explains the canon reconciliation as well as this a little.
>
> Adora POV for the Crystal castle next week (it was going to be this chapter but I switched them round which is one of three reasons why this is late)

Almost

Chapter Summary

Adora and Bow go to the Crystal Castle

Adora

Entrapta agrees, Scorpia agrees and the Best Friend Squad is ready to go. She'd almost say today is going perfectly if it weren't for the state of the lab when she'd gotten there. Needless to say that some of those upgrades are undergoing a rocky birth-phase.

Adora's got a staff in hand and a bag tied to her belt, but that's it. She still can't bring herself to use a sword after everything. Bow's got the trackerpad they need to contact Glimmer and his own bag for tech attached to the inside of his quiver - newly replenished with an assortment of arrows he was working on during the peace period. Not necessarily secret projects, but she doesn't have any idea what most of them do (one of them probably shoots fireworks for all she knows.)

Entrapta already had code for tracking First Ones tech ready to download onto the pad. Which she now thinks may have contributed to at least some of her encounters with Catra during the war. But Entrapta's fine tuned it a little, only picking up signals past a certain power threshold so the Crystal Castle itself won't register. So all they have to do is follow the signals around until they get an intact enough data crystal.

Adora looks away when Bow and Glimmer say their quick little goodbye, feeling like she's intruding when he kisses her forehead. There's a little envy as well and she *hates* it, crushes it down so far she'll fool herself into thinking she never felt its fleeting presence in the first place. Glimmer doesn't even have to take Bow's hand, she's already holding it when she reaches out towards her.

There’s worry in her eyes clear as anything, and she knows Glimmer would be coming with them if she wasn’t needed here. She squeezes Glimmer’s hand in reassurance. This should be a relatively quick and safe mission compared to their other ones.

They appear outside the Crystal Castle instead of inside it. Which would be fine if she knew whether it’ll still open for her. She tries the password and it works. Makes her feel a little better; less useless. Even if she's never necessarily needed She-Ra for the password to work.
Glimmer kisses Bow on the cheek before she teleports away with her telltale shimmer.

Adora honestly didn’t think she’d ever be back here. But it doesn’t hurt. Doesn’t ache all that much. This place was never a home. There’s horrid memories here, most of them eased now that she has Catra worried and waiting for her in Brightmoon. All those simulations sting less than they once did. Really it is just Light Hope’s lies and shattering the sword that can hurt her here now. Unless the castle decides to replay some more memories which...

“Bow I should, um, I should warn you that this place can project memories, or...mine at least,” she says as they stare down into the softly glowing cavern.

He gets his trackerpad out from his quiver, “Oh, um, do you want me to look away if that happens?”

He's trying so hard to mask his confusion. It gets her to laugh, “No, it’s okay I just wanted you to be prepared. But they might not be…fun.”

His brow softens further, “The Horde?”

“Yeah.” They both enter the structure, the hatch closing behind them and swallowing the natural light. “I told you Catra followed me in once, right?”

“You did. Is that what happened? You guys relieved some memories and it all went sour?”

“More or less.” She has even more regrets about that day now that she understands Catra better. She doesn’t know what she’ll do if she sees Shadow Weaver hurting Catra - even a fake Catra - again.

She’s expecting danger as they reach the entrance hall. She’s not She-Ra anymore, this place has an uncomfortably high chance of seeing her as a threat. But the place doesn’t immediately light up red, so she can at least get the next breath into her lungs.

“Don’t touch anything unless we’re taking it, I don’t know if it’s going to recognise me anymore.” It’s remarkably bitter in her own mouth.

She turns to find Bow already looking at some First One's writing carved into a rock; a crystal pyramid rising from the floor. Technically it is a data crystal and they could definitely use it, but she remembers what happened last time someone tampered with these particular crystals.

Bow backs away from the writing quickly, “You’re not doing great with not having her are you?”

He phrases it as a question, but it sounds like something that’s been sitting on his chest for a while. She can’t really blame him; he needs She-Ra just as much as anyone else on the planet.

“No.”

“We can get through this without her, you know. No one is upset with you for destroying the sword when you needed to.”

He’s the second person to say that to her. And she still doesn’t believe it. She’s just glad he realises now is not exactly the time to talk about it. He points to the pyramid he was just examining, “Is this one?”

"Yes but the whole place might shut down if we force it out, I," she manages to snort despite it all, "I shot a beam at Catra with the sword by accident when she tried to take one and the whole place went on lockdown. She was so pissed at me."

They start walking towards one of the many doorways. The castle remains unusually silent, the soft glow of the writing on the hallway walls beckoning rather than angry.

"That's one of the more understandable things for her to get angry at you about."

"Yeah." It's stupid that she's smiling in this situation. "We should go deeper if we can, try and find something we don't have to pry out." Or a bigger stash, whatever comes first.

"Why, do you think some high-powered tech will just be lying around on the floor?" Bow makes a geographical marker on the pad so they'll be able to find their way back.

She shrugs, more relaxed now that the doorway hasn't come crashing down on them both, "I've seen a lot weirder in here."

The castle is still as much of a maze as it's always been. She doesn't even know *why* it's so big. There's nothing here. Well, not anymore. Maybe Light Hope had purposes for all these halls. Or maybe these big empty halls used to be specialised training rooms. Holograms had to be somewhere, she supposes. Bow suggests maybe they had been places for allies of She-Ra to stay once. It's interesting to think about at least.

They open a door that leads to pitch black and she steers them away immediately.

There are monsters here. Electric rather than magical, but dormant. She is terrified of waking them up. She's sure they can handle the spiders together, but the creatures that are in these walls, half concealed and blank-faced, she's not willing to find out

about. They actually need to get the tech out of here once they find it.

After maybe an hour of aimless walking, it doesn't take them much longer to figure out that the most powerful signal - the one that keeps growing the further they go, must be the Heart. Purely because she thinks nothing else would have the power to cause Bow's trackerpad to malfunction the way it is. If it were simply a matter of the miles of walls, the signals would stop entirely. They probably shouldn't have come down so far. That being said, they still haven't found anything.

Eventually the pressure starts getting to them both, or maybe it's the castle's way of telling them to turn back. Either way, they turn around and lock onto a different energy signature.

She's not sure what finally triggers a simulation. But she wouldn't be surprised if it's because she was thinking about Catra to fill the silence. They just turn the next right and it's a green Fright Zone hallway, little glitches in the textures stopping her from panicking.

Bow puts a welcome hand on her arm, "Is this one of the memories?"

"Yeah." Another her runs through them, maybe nine years old, and clutching something to her chest. "Also I might disappear."

"What -"

She clamps a hand over his mouth in case 'she' says something. 'Adora' stops, looking around for what has to be Catra. She lets Bow go, the two of them following her memory round a corner. Adora doesn't really remember this, but if what she's holding is a ration bar then it would make sense. This happened far too many times for her to remember every one.

'Adora' looks up at a vent that's hanging half open in the ceiling before calling, *"Catra you in there? I brought dinner."*

She waits a few moments before the glow of Catra's eyes appear in the ink of the shadow. She grins and waves the bar in her direction. A clawed hand wraps around the ledge of the opening before Catra's body swings down effortlessly. Her claws clink on the metal as she lands in front of her.

"What flavour is it?"

"Brown." Catra makes a face and she laughs, Catra knows it's the brown kind today, it always is on Wednesdays. *"Better than going hungry."*

"Not by much."

She shoves her, lighter than she would anyone else. *"Shut up, do you want to share or not?"*

Catra grabs her by the wrist - the one not holding the food - claws only digging in slightly, and pulls her into the furthest corner. She splits it, giving Catra the bigger half like always. Her best friend curls into her side before she takes it. It is winter after all. Even if the machines heat up the floor below them, Catra's always been the best heat source she's ever known.

When she takes the first bite the simulation vanishes. She's back in her normal body, with Bow standing frozen a few feet away. She gets to her feet, walking on. "Come on, we need to keep moving."

She knows he wants to say something but is looking for an opening in case this isn't something she wants to talk about. She gives that opening, "That might be the nicest memory this place has ever shown me."

If she does somehow trigger them herself, then that makes sense. The castle is still linked to her mind, so it...projects a memory to mirror that. Last time what started as good memories got poisoned by some bad feeling every time. Looking back, that was probably Catra's doing. And it makes her miss her; long for her as she is now. She starts walking faster. The sooner they find what

they're looking for, the sooner she can stop Catra worrying (and the sooner she gets to curl up with her like in the memory.)

But Bow doesn't live in her head, has none of her guilty thoughts, "Catra was so cute!"

She grins so wide it hurts because Catra would kill him for that. Or at least she'd say she would. (She knows Catra likes him.) Catra probably wouldn't even talk to her for a while for agreeing, but Catra's not here so, "I know right! She had to *grow into* her hair."

Bow near squeals and she *gets it*. "I know Catra's protective of your memories, but you have to tell me more stories when we get back."

Her brain kind of short-circuits on the 'protective'. She didn't think Catra's jealousy extended to *memories* but… "Yeah - yeah I'll ask her, I guess, about what I can tell you."

They walk a while longer before Bow starts looking around like he's expecting another to appear, "Do you know why it showed you *that* memory?"

"No, not really. That wasn't - I don't even remember that. Catra got food bans a lot, courtesy of Shadow Weaver, so I'd always give her half of whatever I could get my hands on... When I could find her."

"Well that….actually explains a lot."

Luckily there's no more holograms after that. It's been another hour or two when they come to another crossroads (not that this is exactly their first, this is just the one they're choosing to actually stop and consider their options.)

Bow points, "The one with the most light?"

It's as good a bet as any.

And it is a *very* good bet. The light, naturally, has a source. One which just so happens to be a wall full of data crystals back lit by what must've once been a screen. A whole wall. Entrapta would cry. (Which she shouldn't think about, because then she'll just think about Catra and she can't afford to be distracted when this place might very well collapse at any moment.)

"What do you say we take as many as we can and run for it?" Bow says brightly.

She shrinks her staff down and clips it onto her belt before removing the bag. "Just what I was thinking."

Nothing starts screeching as they pull as many crystals as will fit in the bag off the walls. She doesn't want to leave anything here in case they can't find a way back but Bow manages to talk her into leaving once they can't carry any more. He makes another electronic marker just to appease her.

They cross the room's threshold and the lights turn bloody. A sensor in the wall or something. **"Unauthorized presence detected."** Sadly the crystals weren't responsible for powering the lockdown systems.

She sighs, tightening the bag at her hip, "Without Light Hope I was hoping this wouldn't happen."

"You've gotten out of these before, right? Without Glimmer?"

"Uh, yeah."

They start running. Naturally. She still doesn't know how to turn this damn thing off. And she probably should, considering how many times it's put people in danger.

They make it back to the crossroads in under two minutes. They stop only to check the trackerpad (it's picking up signals again) for how to get back to the entrance, before rushing down what they assume is the right tunnel. The red light shuts off into pitch black behind them section by section. Three long hallways pass by

before they see any spiders. It's a left or right decision at first, before eyes light up to their left and the machines start screeching.

"Shit."
She knows Bow would say the same if he ever swore.

Bow shoots a net and slime arrow down the hallway to slow them down. She's unsure as to how well it works considering they don't have the time to look back. The shriek of metal as the bugs rush after them is as awful as it always is.

She knows they can't outrun them, so as soon as there's a hallway too small for their large frames, she grabs Bow by the arm and drags him down it. For all she knows this is a maintenance tunnel. She's never figured out how the spiders track people, but it's obviously not smell because they carry on past their turning without stopping.

They're still running, but slow enough now that it's almost a rest. "Well, good news," she says through rough breaths, "Means we're close to the entrance. There's worse monsters lower down."

"Did you see that green one with all the tentacles way back?

If she weren't running she'd be laughing, it's a weird, but familiar feeling. "Gods I'm glad that thing didn't wake up."

"Do you hear the beeping?" She nods. "It'll get faster the closer we get to the marker."

This is why Bow is the tech guy, because she'd never think of that.

Another main hallway is still red up ahead, the only light that's in the tunnel now. Bow pulls her left when they reach the hall. The only sound in the castle is the distant crumbling of the walls. She can't hear more spiders but she has a horrible feeling that won't be the last of them.

The castle seems slower in a way, because the doors on the sides of the tunnels only close after they pass. She's actually considering thanking the castle for being so fucking old, it makes it a lot easier to get out of alive. Either that or losing Light Hope messed with the protocol.

The beeping does get quicker. Bow calls Glimmer as they run, only stopping another moment to get it out of his quiver again, telling her to be waiting for them in the entrance. Unsurprisingly she's a bit panicked by it, but they'll apologise when they get out.

There's more spiders in the distance, because *of course* there is. She knows Bow can hear their hissing too. He risks a look back and they must be closer than they sound because he runs just that little bit faster. The lights are still shutting off one by one behind them, but the red in the walls isn't enough to stop her recognising a mark etched into the stone. It's one she made herself after a particularly infuriating day's training.

"I know where we are, just two more rights and we're back at the start."

The entrance court comes into view exactly as she said it would. The crystal pillars are shuddering, some of the ceiling smashing to the ground. The door hasn't slammed shut yet. But it will. Soon. Because there's no way they're getting out of this that easily.

The spiders are catching them up. The lights are still shutting down, following them by plunging their previous steps into blackness. And the door that's going to come down any second is getting closer.

Her and Bow are evenly matched for speed. It's something she found out relatively early on in their friendship. But her Horde training means she's got just that much more stamina. And she uses it to run just that little bit faster, ready to hold that damn door up.

There’s too much adrenaline soaking her thought for her to realise that she can’t *do* that anymore. She is essentially *fragile* - horribly weak - like this. And she doesn’t care. She forces herself to stop in the doorway, Bow a few steps behind. She’s not moving till he’s through.

In some way it’s nice to be right when the stone comes crashing down on her.

She catches it on her hands first before it falls to her shoulders. She's not strong enough to hold it, only to slow it’s descent. The ancient material crumbles a little in her hand, chips of it rolling down her arms.

Bow slides under it, reaching out for her, trying to pull her through, but the force pressing down on her from above won’t let her move. She *can’t move*.

She’s still got to get Bow out. He needs to get back to Glimmer. She - she’s got to get back to *Catra*. She has to *move*.

Last time she was able to do this. She could lift this door, weakened with age, despite how it’s designed to not let even She-Ra through. She can’t do that now - or at least she shouldn’t be able to. She shouts her throat raw as the door presses down across her shoulders harder, feels the burn in her muscles spread to every part of her body. It’s a burn she knows, a tidal wave of something she doesn’t have the mind to figure out right now.

She is glowing. Gold, gold, gold, then iridescent white as she shoves the stone up over her head.

She feels Bow’s hands on her arms, dragging her forward and she’s glad. There’s a static in her mind right now, making her limbs heavy despite how strong they felt a moment ago. Strong like mountains and iron and...and She-Ra.

“Adora?”

She looks up at Bow, rights herself so she's actually standing before looking back at the shape she's left in the door. It was her - the towering humanoid carving says as much. As does the fact that the obnoxious red light has returned to blue, all lockdown procedures suddenly halted. The spiders on the other side of the door are immobile now, eyes dark. She imagines once they're gone they'll scuttle back off to wherever they came from.

"Adora, Bow are you okay?" Glimmer teleports from the other side of the room, she must have been waiting in the entry hall.

He gives her a quick kiss on her cheek, "I'm fine." The insistent beeping gets turned off.

She can't take her eyes off the silhouette in the doorway. "Yeah I - that was her right? I'm not imagining that?"

Glimmer grabs her arm and shakes her a bit with her excitement, "No, no that was her!"

She's smiling, but she wants to cry with relief. She throws her arms around her friends, both of them hugging her as hard as they can. And when she pulls back, they don't let her go, all holding onto one another.

"Do you know what - how that happened?" Glimmer asks. Some of her magic is spilling out of her pores, sparkles moving through her hair as she grins.

Her hands grip them both tightly, "No I just - she just - she was *there* and now I - I feel the same way I have since I broke the sword."

It feels warmer though, under her skin. Maybe that's just the residual magic. Magic that she still *has* apparently.

Bow's still half-breathless from running when he says, "Well, now we know she's in there, we can get her back."

She nods. And keeps nodding because she can *get She-Ra back*. She just has to figure it out. And she will. By the gods she will. She-Ra is...is how they win. It's what she was made for, wasn't it? Winning the First One's wars. She's a weapon.
A weapon Prime doesn't know about.

There is hope burning in her chest. Familiar and alive.

There is strength and power still inside her. Purpose simmering under the cage of her skin. And all she has to do is...let it out. Bring it out. *Drag it out*.

Because this means she is *needed*. Finally, she is needed again. Useful again. Wanted again. She is *enough* again. She-Ra is here. And she's never going to lose her. Never again. She can't. Not now. Not when people will be looking to her, relying on her again.

She has to be enough for them.

But it is also so much easier to let them down like this. There is no *I can't* keeping her from failing anymore. There is *I can* and there is *I must*, the same as it's always been.

And there is fear.

Home: Part II

Adora

"Hey, can we not tell the Alliance about She-Ra returning yet? I - I want to be able to - I want to know that I *can* bring her out if she's needed."

Glimmer keeps her hand on her shoulder while she says, "Yeah, of course. Whatever you need to do." And then teleports away, leaving her and Bow standing in the throne room's entrance.

"Entrapta, you're gonna love this," Bow says as he dumps his collection of crystals onto one of the tables in the lab.

The look on Entrapta's face is priceless. There are tears. They spill over when Adora places down her bag as well. She picks one up with her hair, turning it over. Adora has no idea what she's doing, checking for faults maybe? All Adora knows is that it says *Protocol 27*.

Bow asks, "Will you be able to read them?"

"Hm? Oh yes, I've been rebuilding the infrastructure needed to translate it. I had a specialised setup in the Fright Zone but it's simple enough to replicate a beta version." Entrapta points to a half-welded hip-high pedestal with a little insert for a crystal in front of a screen. Honestly with all the pipes in the room, it kind of feels like a more-purple version of the Fright Zone. (Which makes her think of the memory she saw, which makes her think of Catra but she is *not* going to see her yet. She has to check on Entrapta first.)

"Need any help?" Bow offers.

"I have help, Scorpia's just gone to get lunch. I think Perfuma said she was going to make us all mini fruit platters." Entrapta starts

up a recording of the Princess to confirm it. (Adora always forgets that she does that.)

Bow knocks her with his elbow, "Lunch is a good idea."

Right, it's been at least three hours since she last ate. Surprisingly, she's not actually that hungry. She blames adrenaline and magic. (And worry, but she won't admit that.)

"Bow is there anything else I need to do today?"

"Not officially but," he gestures above his head, making a face that is in no way subtle, but Entrapta's not looking, "Maybe do something about that."

"Right. Yeah. I'll get on that." She has no idea how to even *start* but...

He puts a hand on her arm before he goes to the door, "You coming with me?"

"I'll catch up, I'm - I'm gonna go see Catra first." She shouldn't feel embarrassed about that - she thinks it's embarrassment - but after the memory she just *needs* to be around Catra. (And there is guilt because of it that she is desperately trying to ignore.)

"You gonna tell her?"

She laughs, "Can you imagine what she'd do if I didn't?"

"She'd forgive you."

"Yeah, *eventually*."

"*Eventually*," he agrees, "See you later then, you too Entrapta."

"Bye Bow."

Adora wanders back over to the table, rolling one of the crystals over in her hands. “How did talking with Catra go?”

“Good! Scorpia said it went really well and I trust her. Catra invited me back.” Entrapta compares the size of the crystal to the indentation.

She smiles, “Yeah, you okay?”

“Definitely.” And then Entrapta’s grin gets hidden behind her welding mask and an armful of crystals.

She takes her staff off her belt as she walks so she remembers to leave it in Catra’s room. Also so she can fiddle with it as she awkwardly stands on the other side of Catra’s door. It’s been a while since she’s hesitated like this. She’s not missed this lack of confidence when it comes to Catra.

But she manages to knock on the door and pushes forward while she has the nerve before there’s any reply. Catra was obviously sitting at the table with her log, but she’s standing now, smiling with relief as she walks towards her.

She throws the staff to the ground, not giving it a second thought once she pulls Catra into her arms. It shouldn’t make her as happy as it does when Catra holds her back just as tightly; which is to say near-crushing. Catra starts purring into her shoulder while she grins into hers.

“Saw a memory. Missed you,” she mumbles as explanation.

Catra’s purrs give way to let her say, “You okay?”

“Yeah it was a nice one.” Catra purrs louder.

She eventually has to move away. And she consolidates the loss by getting to see Catra’s face. There’s a speckling of grey around her ears where her tufts are starting to grow back in which she’s

never noticed before. Catra's also making a strange face, she's now realising.

“Still worried about me?”

Catra seems to shake away a thought before she takes a step back. Adora knows Catra is just checking her for injuries but it still makes her heart beat faster to be under her eyes like this. It’s somehow simultaneously lazy and intense. She hopes to the gods she’s not blushing.

She coughs out, “No injuries.”

Catra drags her eyes back up to her face, “Good.” And then punches her in the arm.

“What, you trying to give me some?”

Catra’s ear flicks as she scowls, “That’s for worrying me.”

“Well you didn’t need to. *We* just brought back a whole library's worth of First Ones tech for the Rebellion.”

There is a *flicker* of surprise on Catra’s face, one she suspects no one else would be able to catch. Because it dissolves before it’s even fully formed, Catra crossing her arms and rolling her eyes, “Yeah, yeah congrats Princess. If you’re expecting a song it’s not gonna happen.”

She snorts, “What because you can see Mermista singing in my honour?”

“The pirate definitely.”

“Sea Hawk sings no matter what happens, says it’s part of his charm.”

Catra quirks her eyebrow in a way that has always looked unfairly good on her, “He has charm?”

She rolls her eyes before she goes to ‘tackle’ Catra but really she’s just wrapping her arms around her waist roughly while Catra pushes at her face pretending she hates it. A Horde-safe hug. “What no purr this time?”

“Not when you’re being this much of a cocky little shit. Take it, it went well then?” Catra fights her way out of her arms, hands on her hips like she’s never been more in control.

“Yes. But admit it, you’re glad I’m home.”

Catra smirks, not looking her in the eye, “Don’t push your luck.”

Gods she just wants to touch her. Even after hugging her *multiple times*, the want is not satisfied. It’s not *usually* this bad. She can’t even bring herself to try and figure it out because really, what good is understanding *why* going to do? It doesn’t fix anything.

She needs to stop making excuses for herself about things like this. Even justifying the overly familiar ways she touches Catra doesn’t make them okay - doesn’t remove the selfish intent behind them. But she’ll stop making excuses later, when she’s left this room and the way her body strains to be near Catra behind.

She pulls Catra along by the wrist, same as memory-Catra did, to the armchair. Safe enough for now. Catra doesn’t even fight her on this, goes easily with her into the chair, sitting far closer than is necessary.

Excuses will end later. Now *isn’t* later. She winds her hand with Catra’s.

And Catra’s shocked by it, that much she can tell without looking at her face. Catra’s fingers flex away from the hold so her claws won’t pierce her skin. But she doesn’t pull away. Catra leans back into the chair, looking anywhere but at her. And it’s almost worse than not touching her at all. But she’s not giving up the hold on her, not now that Catra’s holding back, however weakly. And all of this is so stupid because they’ve done this before. They must have. This doesn’t feel new.

“So, anything interesting happen out there?” Catra half-coughs out.

“Uh, yeah...something - something happened out there. Something you’re not going to like.” She holds Catra’s hand tighter, like Catra won’t run away if she does. And Catra stays so she’ll convince herself it works.

“...What?”

“She-Ra she, um, I felt her. She’s still in here somewhere.”

She feels Catra stiffen, there’s a loud snap of her tail against the fabric, and clawtips pricking at her skin. It contrasts greatly with how blankly Catra says, “Well that’s good. It’s what you wanted.”

“It was - is.”

Catra’s eyes flick over her face. “So why do you sound as uncomfortable as I feel?”

She stares at their hands, focuses on the fact that Catra’s here with her like this, “I don’t - I don’t want her to ruin things between us again.”

She wishes there could be a world where Catra was allowed to be more important to her than She-Ra. Where she could forget all about her so she could keep Catra as happy as they were before Prime. Because Catra’s not happy. Not with the way she swallows silently and looks to the floor, her tail curling around her own arm.

“She won’t be around a lot. I don’t even know how I did it. The door was going to trap us both and she was just...there waiting for me when I needed her.”

She doesn't tell Catra that she might not have survived if She-Ra *wasn't* there. She doesn't want to scare her for no reason. Not when she kept her promise and came back. Even if she *wasn't* careful like she said she'd be. She also thinks about telling Catra that She-Ra came forth when she thought about her and Bow and

Glimmer. But she doesn't. Because she doesn't want Catra pulling away from her. Not when she's leaning into her. She didn't realise Catra was - is - leaning into her. Catra is pressing her forehead to her shoulder and she freezes.

"I can smell her magic on you." Catra pulls away quickly, clearly trying not to wrinkle her nose. "That's what that was."

It makes her stomach sink; Catra's always found comfort in the way she smells. She wants to apologise. She thinks Catra's the only person she's ever felt she's had to *apologise* to for being She-Ra.

She slowly pulls their joined hands into her lap, just so she can hold Catra's with two. Because she *needs* Catra to not pull away from her for this. She hates how her voice shakes, "Do you hate it?"

"What?"

"Me. For being her."

Catra looks stricken by that, ears flat to her head. Catra's mouth opens a couple of times before she's able to say anything, "Adora I don't - I don't know. I spent the whole war trying not to think of her as you. At first I tried to convince myself that she was this *thing* that *made* you leave. But that fell apart pretty quickly."

She tries to think after that but it's more difficult than it should be, "The Sea Gate?"

"Yeah. She spoke like you, she smelt like you under it all and she…" Catra tucks her head into her chest, "Bleeds the same as you do."

The almost-gone scars on her back ache. She can't stand to see her look this guilty. She tries for teasing, since it's really the only way she knows how to fix this, "Well I'd like to think you have to put a little more effort into it."

“You do see how that’s not a good thing?” Catra snaps as she pulls her hand away.

She doesn’t know what to do with herself now. “Yeah, I know but…” She decides to sink back into the chair. “This is - this is how we win.”

Catra looks to the ceiling, her breathy laugh is sad, “‘We’. *I’m* going to win because of She-Ra. You do get the irony in that, right?”

She stares down at her empty hands, “I do…”

Catra sighs, her ears finally returning to their normal position, and leans back so they’re shoulder to shoulder. She bites out, “I’m sorry,” before her face softens, “You were probably excited about it before me.”

“Yeah, I guess there was...excitement.”

Catra turns in towards her, looking like she's ready to pick her apart no matter how much she hides. “You spent all this time wanting her to come back - feeling guilty for not having her - and now you’re…upset?”

“No, no, I am excited about having her back. But then there’s you, and everyone else and every *thing* else that comes with her and - and I don’t know.”

“...So, what are you gonna do now?”

“Try and get her back properly I guess.” Catra makes a questioning face. It’s cute but she can’t say that. “I couldn’t keep a hold on her before. And I don’t want to tell the Alliance unless I know for sure that I can transform when I need to.”

“But you told me?”

“Of course I did.”

And apparently that fixes *something* because Catra smiles, subtle and small. And she curls into her, rests her head on Adora's shoulder, clearly still smelling the magic, but ignoring it. And everything just seems...easier.

"You'll get her back. And you'll save the world, same as you always do."

"Don't know about 'always', but thanks. You promise me we're going to be okay?"

Catra pulls back only enough to pull the arm she was leaning on around her shoulders, "I promise." Catra fits into her side and Adora melts into the contact. *This* is what she needed. Right now it feels like *all* she needs.

"*Now* you get a purr."

Sides

Chapter Summary

If she weren't officially a Rebellion soldier before...

Chapter Notes

Warning for trauma response and violence just in case.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Three days. She has spent three days trying to get She-Ra to - to even *be there*. She can feel her now, can recall times she felt her before. There's something waiting at the edges of her fingertips when she tries, and her eyes glow otherworldly blue on occasion. But she can't *hold* it. It's like light; always slipping through her fingers. It doesn't work.

"Hey Adora, did I - did I do something?"

She *was* just about to leave for another day of trying (and when that doesn't work, training till her arms are numb.) But she is not going to leave now. She knows that tone, it's one that makes Catra's ears pull back. She turns and finds she is, unfortunately, correct. Catra's got her arms crossed and hip cocked but her ears give her away. (And the words but…)

"What, no, you - you're - we're okay. You promised, remember?"

"I did. But you didn't. You're...you don't seem okay." Catra's chewing the inside of her lip, she's sure.

She steps closer, but does nothing more. She's been good the last few days, fewer excuses. Nothing she shouldn't do. "It's just *her*,

it’s not you.”

“Prove it.”

She does her best not to gape at that. (She fails.) “How - how do I do that?”

Catra holds a hand out, something hard in her eyes that’s practically daring her to say no. Not that she would. Not when Catra’s offering. As soon as she’s close enough, she takes it, and Catra pulls her in. She *doesn’t* stumble, really, she doesn’t. But Catra acts like she has, half catching her in her arms.
She could so *easily* just rest their foreheads together. She wants to, gods does she. Catra starts rubbing her arm the way she usually does for her and she can’t help smiling.

“You’re exhausted.” And when she doesn’t respond, too shocked for it really. “Have you been sleeping?”

Catra squeezes the hand on her arm when she doesn’t respond quick enough. (Not that that exactly makes her want to answer.) She just got distracted by the most of Catra she’s felt in three days.

“Yes.” Catra doesn’t look like she believes her. “I am sleeping. But the last few days...six hours isn’t enough apparently.”

Catra takes a miniscule step back and crosses her arms over her chest, eyes to the floor and tail curling the way it does when she’s uncomfortable. “You know that all you have to do is ask, right?”

Ask for what, though? It takes her too long for her to figure out that it’s about sleeping in Catra’s bed. Oh. That. That she hasn’t done since...right. She plays absently with her own fingers, wishing - selfishly wishing - Catra were still holding her hand. “I know I just - you can’t like having me take up your space all that much.”

“You’re such an idiot.” Catra sounds angry, but the fake kind - the kind that's covering up something else.

She snaps her head up, “Huh?”

“Yeah I - I fall asleep with you like - like *that* because I don’t like you taking up my space.” Catra swallows when she’s done, tail snapping behind her. And Adora may be...oblivious but even she can see that Catra is - was - scared to say that. And she loves her for saying it anyway.

“Oh.”

Catra scoffs, turning away and grabbing her log from the top of her drawers, “Moron.”

She doesn’t know if it’s coincidence or not that Catra has a nightmare that night. But Catra wants her in her bed. She doesn’t have to make excuses for this - not to Catra and not to herself. Catra scowls into the dark though, even after she’s laid down again. Adora can see it in the moonlight, what with the open curtains.

“What can I do?”

Catra’s eyes shine blue and gold when she opens them again, “I didn’t - I’m fine.”

“You’re not.” Technically she’s taking a risk by saying that. But they’re - they’re so much better at this now so...

Catra’s ear flicks. And she sighs, heavy and...sad. “Can you…?”

She waits for her to say it, but Catra never does. Instead she growls quietly to herself and drags one of Adora’s hands up to her head. It’s easy enough for her to figure where to go from here. She lets her hands mess with the grey around Catra’s ears, a little coarser than the rest of her hair. Feels like she’s getting drunk on the strength of Catra’s pulse under her palm.

And it’s here that she gives up on excuses, at least for tonight. Catra purring under her hand until she falls asleep - she doesn’t want to make any. She just wants to love her, *without* the guilt. Same as always she supposes.

Catra

“Rejoice, Etheria, for Prime has come to you. Do not fear, for each of you shall join me in my glorious image. Your world will be made anew.”

That was the first, and only message Prime transmitted through his spires weeks ago. She honestly hasn’t thought about it all that much beyond ‘world made anew’. But she supposes that’s what happens when a galactic tyrant comes to take over your planet. But there’s been another:

“You all may run from my hand, but you need not do so. For Prime is merciful, I shall welcome you into my empire with open arms in good time. Your leaders - your Princesses *- will not save you. And rest assured, I shall darken your false beacon soon enough. And all will be bathed in my pure light. Prime sees all. Prime knows all. They will not escape my judgement.”*

She can’t stop thinking about it. Not since every day she wakes up and counts the clones at the barrier, and every day without fail the number has increased. His voice plays on repeat in her head like one of Entrapta's broken recordings.

She keeps an even closer watch on Prime’s forces than before, but it’s not necessary. They’ve never fired their weapons, even as Rebellion soldiers ‘fought’ them off the last time refugees tried to make it through. That was two weeks ago. She doesn’t know what they’ll do now.

But before long there is a wall of clones, of Hordak-like things standing shoulder to shoulder. All blank green eyes and white robes. There’s no bots to be seen on the front lines, which Prime

must have a reason for, but she can’t bring herself to try and understand a madman.
And they don’t speak, the clones. Not unless approached. In which case everyone has received a slew of Prime-loving nonsense. (Or at least that’s what Adora said.)

The next meeting of the Alliance is...strained from the beginning. As expected. She’d like to say she acts better this time. But she’ll chalk that up to it not being about her in the slightest. She’s ignored essentially, and she does not care one bit. It’s nice to just be out of that room again.
(She lets her tail curl around Adora’s wrist from the beginning this time. That’s probably helping too. Even with Scorpia giving her unsubtle looks.)

“Entrapta, anything on Prime?”

“So far the only data I’ve found relating to him is a component list for his ships. Materials from other worlds with properties I never even thought were able to occur naturally...” she’s getting starry-eyed when Perfuma cuts her off with a hand on her arm.

No weaknesses, not even a home planet. But she has only deciphered a third of the crystals. And it’s not their only information source. There’s also the hundreds of people inside the castle that have had first hand experience with Prime’s bots - and the world after the Heart. There’s reports of chasms, new ones like worldly scars torn by the Heart's power before it was stopped. Some people have fallen in, the depth meaning they’re lost to the black entirely.
And that’s not even the worst news.

“Prime’s doing something to the people. From what we’ve gathered, he’s implanting chips into the backs of people's necks,” Perfuma says, looking deeply uncomfortable.

“We think they’re getting hooked into the hivemind if rumors about green eyes are true. We need to check the status of everyone in the castle. And people shouldn’t be allowed into Brightmoon until we do.”

Glimmer nods, agreeing with Bow. “This is our top priority. Try to be quick and efficient, but subtle. If Prime catches on and someone’s inside… Well, we don’t want that happening.”

The rest of the bots are up and running the next day. They’ve been coming out in groups but Entrapta messages her saying that those are the last of them now, updated and ready. It forms another wall essentially. Seeing Horde bots defending Brightmoon against the Galactic Horde - it's surreal at least.

As far as they’re aware, no one inside has been chipped. Catra figures that it explains why so few people have been adding to the castle’s numbers. They’re not making it before getting caught. She manages not to think about what’s become of the Fright Zone all that much, but she honestly wonders whether the wreckage of a place is even still standing.

Aside from out-of-date ship statistics, models and materials (they’re not really sure if they’re out-of-date but it’s safe to assume) Entrapta hasn’t found anything. Well anything related to Prime, all the First Ones knowledge she’s collecting is proving a difficult distraction for her to overcome. Catra wishes she could go to her lab and help with at least something. She’s going stir crazy with the log and endless watching. It’s the first thing the Alliance has denied her actually.

But Entrapta comes to her room the day after (she’s pretty sure it's to watch the bots but it’s nice anyway.) There’s not much either of them can do remotely, so as soon as the hour’s up Entrapta’s gone with a wave.

The day following that, she gets another visitor after lunch; the Queen herself. And Glimmer is exhausted. Not mentally - she's still the snarky Queen she's come to grow *a little* fond of - but physically she's weary. Magical drain with keeping the barrier as strong as they need it, the Moonstone, and by extension her, powering a lot more of it than before as sorcerers rest. If it weren't for the Mystacor artifacts the barrier would've crumbled long ago.

"So, you and Arrow Boy? You figure out your shit yet?" she asks as she jots down the amount of moving white *things* she's seen in the woods today. Whatever they are, they aren't good. Just more weapons.

Glimmer, honest to gods, flushes. There are sparkles in her pores as she thinks about her boyfriend and Catra doesn't bother to hide her eyeroll. "We did actually. Adora didn't tell you?"

"She did. I just wanted to hear it from you. Say it's catharsis after watching you two dance around each other."

Glimmer makes a face she's not seen before. Opening her mouth to say something before getting a hold of herself. "...Shit timing on my part."

"There was probably a reason you waited till the war was supposedly over. Can't imagine it's all that fun for you two." She will deny with her last breath that this is sympathy she's feeling.

"Well, at least I don't have to worry about this ending badly without ever telling him how I feel."

And she does not like the hard way Glimmer is glaring at her when she says it. But she's been *accused* before, of many things. If she can't deflect away from *whatever* Glimmer might be implying, she'll be disappointed with herself.

"You Princesses and your feelings. Gods you really are all as bad as each other, I thought at least *you* had a little more control over yourself."

And Glimmer does, when the emotion isn't anger or fear or any range of terrible feeling. (Annoyingly like her in that way.) Either way, she falls for it: "I am nowhere near as bad as Perfuma or even Scorpia and *she* was your best friend."

Younger her would've said she didn't exactly have any choice in that matter. "Yeah, yeah fuck off Sparkles."

"Fuck you too Horde Scum."

Her relationship with Glimmer is not exactly any less *weird*.

And still the clone numbers grow.

Everyone in the castle is restless - and there are a lot of people in the castle. All waiting for when this strange holding pattern breaks. And she is too. With how impulse-prone the Alliance is, she's surprised they've listened to her for this long.

Were she back in the Horde, she'd keep this waiting game going - gather as much strength as possible before striking back. Stalling with purpose. That's what *Prime's doing*. They're on the other end of this and at a worse disadvantage than they were originally. No information on *how* to attack, not that they in any way *should*. Most likely all it would mean is that they waste arsenal (and lives if it came down to it.)

She starts modelling moves with her chess board. Noting down possible courses of action in the back of her log. Attacking would cause retaliation which they can't guarantee they'll survive. Defending is what they're doing and it's making things worse for them. And round and round she goes.

Another meeting. The plan starts out simple: lead the clones away from the barrier.

Luring without outright attacking. *Not* that anyone's going outside the barrier without a plethora of weapons. Which is a risk to do in and of itself but it's the only way anyone is comfortable leaving the bubble. She may be relying a little too much on Prime not seeing them as a threat.

Despite that meeting going better than the first, it's still a relief once Frosta isn't hanging over her shoulder - once it's Adora's arm draped there instead. If she didn't have handcuffs on (and if Brightmoon had any walls that weren't white) she'd even say it's just like walking around the Fright Zone together. Though this touch lacks the roughness they had to use to keep superiors from giving them dirty looks.

"Do you even have enough people to do this?"

Adora hums and she can feel it against her arm, "Well we'll see, won't we?"

She fights not to falter in her step, not sure how successful she is. "Adora it is a *wall* of clones. They've surrounded the entire kingdom. There are more in the woods that I can't see."

She doesn't mean to bear her teeth, not really. Adora looks above her eyes, her ears must be back. "You really that worried?"

She growls, sharply turning her head away because *yes*, she is. She doesn't get how Adora *isn't*. Adora rubs - she's hesitant to say 'pets' - her arm lightly until they're back at her room. Some of the tension flows away once they're behind a door again, more of it goes once the cuffs come off.

She rubs at her wrists and paces the room. She expects Adora to go rushing off trying to get She-Ra again or train or whatever else she does when she's not with her. But she stays, looking unsettlingly concerned for her.

"Stop looking at me like that."

Adora crosses her arms, “You’re not exactly making me feel like I can leave you alone.”

It gets her to stop pacing at least, “What do you think I’m going to do?”

And just as quickly, those arms drop again. “Catra it’s not that. You’re not okay - and really I don’t think anyone is…” Adora ducks her head, “Do you want me to stay a while?”

‘Always.’

But that’s not the answer Adora needs, it’s not the one she wants. But she’s not going to lie either. She runs a hand through her hair before saying, “Is there - is there anything I can do? I’m going crazy in here watching *them* every second of the day.”

“Catra I don’t know -“

“Adora. I want to help. I said that. I meant it. If you’re going to go out there and *fight* if it comes down to it I want to be there.” Adora’s got that face, the rare one where Catra’s genuinely shocked her. She feels like she could tap her and Adora’d just fall over. It’d be funny if she weren’t starting to get concerned herself. “Adora?”

Adora half-shakes herself out of it, “You’d - you’d risk your life for the Rebellion?” There’s a wary, disbelieving *something* tugging at her lips as she says it. A smile and grimace; hope and horror.

Well she wouldn’t exactly put it like that but… “I want to help.” It’s about as close to a confirmation as she’ll give.

Adora throws her arms around her and considering what happened after she said she was just ‘joining’ the Rebellion, she really should’ve expected this. Adora hasn’t pinned her arms to her sides this time so she can hug her back just as tightly. She really will never get enough of the feeling.

“Thank you. You - I don’t know if you understand how much that means to me. But this doesn’t mean I want you to die for the Rebellion. You understand that right?”

Adora manages to sound worried about it. Which would be funnier if she couldn’t, tragically, say the exact same thing to her. “I know. You’re just happy we’re on the same side again.”

“The way it’s meant to be.”

She scoffs even though she agrees, because it is a dumb line (and it’s making her heart pound against her chest so hard Adora might feel it.)

Adora slowly moves back, but her arms stay around her. She’s not complaining about it, she’s just pleasantly surprised. So she keeps her arms around Adora too. Even as Adora rests their foreheads together and that surprise turns to just plain shock.

The world doesn’t shatter. She feels like it should. And then she feels annoyed at herself for being so dramatic. They have been this close before. Usually at night, always without their faces actually touching. She closes her eyes like Adora’s doing, trying not to breathe too unevenly because Adora will feel it.

She chokes out, “You sap.” And Adora laughs. And her insides feel light molten gold. “If this is what I’m gonna end up like for being around Princesses I might reconsider.”

“Don’t you dare.” Her eyes open a fraction and find glowing blue. She doesn’t say anything.

They’re going to let her out. No barrier. No chains. To go *possibly* fight for the Rebellion. It’s a wildly sobering thing to be told once she comes to terms with it. It’s also, however buried under unfortunate circumstances, a recognition of her abilities. And she manages to at least get some enjoyment out of how Adora portrays the general reluctant consensus.

She's not going to try anything but they don't know that. And she'd consider them fools if they were completely confident in her loyalties. *She's* not even confident in her loyalties, only that she will fight to protect the people she cares about.

"I still have to keep an eye on you," Adora tells her, smile small, as they wait for Glimmer with the potion that'll free her. Adora's twirling a staff in her hand, the one Catra refused is shrunk and clipped onto her belt. She didn't ask why Adora wasn't taking a sword, she didn't really need to.

But still, Catra grins far too wide at that. "You think I won't be doing the same? If you get hurt doing something stupid I'm going to see it and forever give you a hard time about it."

"Of course you are."

She sticks her tongue out at her and Adora does the same. It is ridiculous considering what they're about to do, but maybe that's exactly why they're doing it.

She hates - absolutely despises saying, even inside her own head - but Brightmoon is...nice, when there's no Horde tanks firing on it. Yes, all she can see now is the grand entrance hall, the Moonstone and the shallow lake because Glimmer teleported them there to avoid citizens seeing her. Which was probably a safe move, even if it looks like it exhausted Glimmer to do.

She leans against the castle's outer wall when Adora puts her arm around Glimmer's shoulders. Just glad she's not feeling jealousy as well as everything else as they wait. Sorcerers gather at the border, completely ignored by Prime's army on the other side. They're there to let them back in, and she wonders just how much maintaining the magic is costing them. Even from here she can see the exhaustion, so similar to Glimmer's, radiating off them.

The bots stand in a line, most painted white with a purple moon insignia. She cannot for the life of her articulate what she's feeling but she knows she wants to laugh. The bots won't be helping them today, though. There's really no way to keep everyone safe if they're on the *other* side of them. And Catra is grateful - she really doesn't want to end up shot today.

Bow comes and stands beside her when he joins them a few minutes later. Aside from Scorpia and Perfuma, he's really the only one who comes close to her. She keeps her claws sheathed as a sign of trust she knows none of them will pick up on.

There's not really a plan in place beyond 'lure them away', even as they start the short walk to the barrier. Adora falls into a soldier's step next to her and it aches just a little through the familiarity. The clones are as blank as she'd been told even as they reach the border, the only movement is that of hundreds of green eyes settling on the group.

No one moves for a while, just two sides of a war with a transparent wall between them. Or it is until Adora does something *incredibly* stupid: walking through said barrier. Adora's on the other side before she can pull her back and she shudders from the cold of the magic as she follows her through without a second thought. No one else does but she can't think about that.

And all remains still, even as all those eyes focus on the two of them. Her fur bristles and she subtly bares her teeth at them out of instinct. She wants to snarl but they are trying to *avoid* a fight. She can see Adora's hands twitching, so at least she's not alone in her feelings.

The rest of the Alliance comes through, a literal rainbow of people in a line. It's weird to feel a part of something but she can't dwell on it. Glimmer is on Adora's other side, there's no sparkles flurrying from her fists yet, but with the set look on her face, she'll probably be seeing them soon.

“Will you speak with us now?”
There’s an uncomfortable silence as the wall turns to survey the Queen. Catra kind of wants to poke one of them in their weird eyes but that is a beyond stupid idea.
“...Why are you here?”

“We do not question the glorious will of the almighty Horde Prime.” Catra didn’t realise they spoke in unison. Which makes her stomach roll and her tail lash. *“All will bend to Horde Prime in time. It is destiny.”*

She wants to spit in their face that she’s never believed in destiny. But it would be wasted. She looks at Adora and she thinks if she could growl as she can, she would.

“We do not submit to Horde Prime,” Glimmer says carefully.

Something changes. Catra’s not sure what. The clone in front of Glimmer looks different in the eyes but she can’t see it from this angle. All she knows is that the next words aren’t said with a chorus. They don’t need to be.

“You will.”

It is at least a comfort to know Horde Prime didn’t know Glimmer could teleport. Ten clones swarm on her but she’s up in a tree the next second, a few of them coming with her and falling off the thin branch. Bow rushes through to catch her as she falls, and the rest of the Princesses are pushing past the clones afterwards. It breaks up the line, gets the clones to turn away from the Kingdom and towards them.

Catra thinks maybe this plan can still work. The clones are following them into the woods and they haven’t raised their weapons yet for whatever reason. If they have a hivemind then do they have to wait for Prime to give the order? She has no idea, but she is grateful for not having to dodge blasts yet. They all crouch in the undergrowth - some better camouflaged than others - and watch their eerily still opponents.

But figures there's a reason for that. Her ears twitch back, hearing inhuman footsteps behind them. She spins and tackles something white into a tree, and rips out the circuitry in its neck when she realises what it is.

"Bots in the woods!" she shouts, hoping everyone hears.

Now the clones are aiming. Not all of them have weapons at least. She doesn't care to know why. Everyone runs deeper into the growth and hides behind a separate tree to escape the initial wave. A way down from her, she can see Perfuma weaving branches into a shield but it's not going to help everyone. There's ice too, water, wind, sparkles and...nets. Really, there's everything.
But there's just so many of *them*.

They should've brought something to talk to Entrapta with, enough magic forming a shield and they'd all be safe from their own bots. Another blast goes by her head and she peers round the trunk after. Bow shoots an arrow and she watches the clone fall to the ground, green fluid leaking out the wound. It smells like pure chemical. Not blood.

One of the clones is holding something, grey and sparking green in its hands. And she decides then that she will get whatever it is. They're not coming back from this empty-handed.

Adora stabs through a bot with one of her staffs, energy fizzing out of the limp form. She has a plan she *can* do by herself, but having Adora there will help. She calls her over and pulls Adora in close to avoid a blast going through her arm. She can hear Adora's pounding pulse over the cannon fire.

"Now would be a good time for She-Ra, y'know."

"Yeah. It would." Adora gives her a face that clearly reads that she *can't* for whatever and resists the very-not-needed-right-now urge to comfort her. She settles for squeezing the hands she has on Adora's forearms.

"I'm going to try and get something, you need to be ready to catch it if I throw it." Adora nods as she lets her go. "You're about to see how I fight when I'm not holding back," she taunts, just to see the frown in Adora's brow smooth out a little.

"Oh really?"

She laughs at that, leaping up onto the closest branch that can hold her weight. She relocates the clone with the device and shouts, "Bow! Cover me."

He gives her a thumbs up, strings another arrow into place and Adora runs to his side. Even when fighting an intergalactic army, it's nice to know a universal flaw in soldiers is that they never look *up*.

Adora

It is, dare she say, *nice* to see Catra fighting people other than her. And she won't be ashamed to tell Catra that later. What she will be ashamed of, and what will subsequently never pass her lips, is that she's rendered practically useless because Catra is...hot. She's fucking gorgeous in battle. She always has been. But like a lot of things she's been releasing recently, it's different now that Catra's on her side.

And she really can't be this distracted right now, not when there's a bot firing behind her. She won't be *as* mesmerised by Catra if she's not looking at her. Also she doesn't want to get shot...that too. She pulls Bow out of the way, takes down two more bots to cover him as he covers Catra.

"She's amazing when she's, y'know, not trying to kill us."

She spins around, seeing four clones lying prone on the ground, only one with arrows in it. "Yeah…" A battlefield is really not the place for her wistful sigh but it's already happened so…

"Adora, are you feeling She-Ra at all?"

“No, I couldn’t get her to work, you know that -”

“- Because your eyes are glowing.”

That might be so but she still can’t get a grip on it, and that’s the whole fucking issue. She can’t distinguish *any* of her feelings right now, let alone stop fighting long enough to try and find She-Ra amongst the adrenaline.

Catra leaps full-body at a clones head, knocking it to the ground and snapping its arm behind its back. Adora dodges a blast and rams her pike through another bot’s chest that was coming towards the two of them from Adora’s right.

“Adora!”

She turns back to Catra in time to see her throw something. She has no idea what it is, but she tucks it into her pocket anyway. Catra will have had a reason. At least after that, Catra gets out of the direct firing line, falling back deeper into the trees.

And if Catra was good at taking down clones - which must have some form of organic matter in their makeup - it is nothing compared to how quickly she can tear apart bots. Any hesitation has disappeared completely. (Not that there was exactly much to begin with.)

Adora shrinks her staff down and charges at a bot that’s about to fire at Bow’s back, making it grow again when she’s got it against a tree and cutting off the power. She doesn’t hear Catra running towards her, but then there’s easy-to-recognise hands pushing her shoulders and head down. If it weren’t for the way Catra says for her to duck in her ear, she’d probably forget that they’re on the same side again and throw her to the ground.
As it is, the words counteract the instinct, and she obeys without questions. A green blaze flies over their heads. She keeps low to the ground and sweeps a bot's legs out with her staff before impaling it through the chest, Catra running off to her left.

She watches as Bow shoots an electric arrow and short circuits a clone's cannon. He shouts, “Everyone get back into the trees!”

Glimmer teleports to his side, leaning on him heavily and momentarily checking for injuries while he tells her something. A plan most likely. Adora’s lost sight of everyone but the two of them, the blue undergrowth providing excellent coverage. Glimmer runs instead of teleports away (and Adora figures she must be near-entirely drained for her to do that) but not long after she hears someone shout Scorpia’s name over the chaos. Next thing she knows Bow is running towards her and tackling her to the ground.

The sound of lightning, all too known, crackles like a scream in her ears. She screws her eyes shut, hates with every fibre of her being that it makes her shake. It’s involuntary that she calls out for Catra.

Bow scrambles off her once Scorpia’s magic recedes, thankfully not saying anything, and she springs to her feet. Both of them draw their weapons before realising what just happened: Scorpia overloaded their circuits, even the clone’s weapons aren’t glowing anymore.

“Everyone get inside!” Glimmer shouts.

The sorcerers on the other side start casting and sure enough the spell parts like a curtain. Spinnerella and Netossa usher Frosta through first. She pushes Bow gently on the shoulder and he runs forward through the break and into Glimmer’s arms.

“Catra!”

She just hopes seeing - hearing - the Black Garnet’s magic hasn’t sent her panicking. She doesn’t really get an answer to that as Catra comes out from behind a tree, holding a cracked circuit board. Adora holds a hand out as Catra runs to her, and Catra takes it when she’s close enough, pulling her along when she doesn’t slow. They’re not the last through, Mermista using her

magic to wash the clones deep into the woods before coming back inside the barrier, the spell sealing afterwards.

She checks Catra over, only her slit-thin pupils and fluffed up fur giving away her distress. Both of which she can blame on the fight, but she knows better. Catra tears her hand away when she seems to realise she's still holding it.

It's not totally silent as they walk back up to the castle's entrance. Though most of the noise is Perfuma telling Scorpia how proud and impressed of her she is. It's sweet. And it makes her look at Catra a little too long. She wants to be walking hand in hand with her like Spinerella and Netossa are doing but that's not an option, sadly.

"Any injuries?" she asks when Catra catches her staring.

"No. You?"
She shakes her head. The worst she has is some minor burns from close calls, and the worst she can see on Catra is a small chunk of hair missing. Unnoticeable if she hadn't spent hours looking at her.
"Do you still have the thing I gave you?"

Glimmer stops her trudging walk ahead of her, watching as she pulls out the metal...something, wary of it's spikes. She doesn't exactly want Prime's acid green energy anywhere near any of them.

"Is that a chip?" Frosta asks.

"It's what they were trying to put on you Sparkles."

"Makes sense," Netossa says, "Take out the opposition's leader and take her for your team."

Unsurprisingly a blanket of discomfort settles on all of them.

The group starts walking again, but before Adora can even try to figure out how to tell Glimmer that she cannot leave Brightmoon under any circumstances now, Catra walks past her, circuit board still in her hands. She watches Catra hesitate to put her hand on Scorpia's arm, sees the way she screws her face up and does it anyway. Catra was clearly anticipating at least a shock but everything seems to be fine as Catra tugs on Scorpia's arm.
She quietly asks for her and Perfuma to give the tech to Entrapta. Scorpia gives her a mock salute and she catches Catra's hidden smile.

They get all the way back to the Moonstone bridge when Frosta says, "I think Prime's doing something."

They all turn to see two warships hovering above the Kingdom outskirts. There's a green flash and the wasted clones disappear from the forest edge. Somehow she knows those gaps in the barricade will not last all that long.

Chapter End Notes

Slaps chapter this can fit so much foreshadowing in it :)

Save Me...

Chapter Summary

Prime requests an audience with the Queen

Chapter Notes

CW: unrealistic injury detail, violence

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

Horde Prime requests an audience with the Queen of Brightmoon as soon as the clone wall returns to full strength.

And they should absolutely, in no way, be entertaining this idea. So naturally there's a meeting about it. Because the Queen thinks they should go *talk* to him. Catra doesn't think she can convince them otherwise this time - they're done waiting. (And deep down she is too.)
Ultimately they're going to end up out there, with him and his army. She knows the Princesses well enough to figure that out. And somehow making Prime wait seems like an even worse option.

She's in cuffs again. Seated at the circular table between She-Ra and the Queen just like the last time. Adora had seemed to have been led to believe that she'd never be put in chains again. And her stupid little frown made her want to kiss her.
(*"I'll talk to them about it. I don't like them treating you like a prisoner."*
"Adora, I am still a prisoner. Technically."
"I know but...I at least thought something would change.")

She doesn't know exactly what she does that makes Adora put a hand on her arm. Probably just made a very obvious face of disagreement because they really *should not* go and talk to Prime.

But whatever she did, Adora doesn’t remove her hand afterwards. And she can't help wondering if Adora would've taken her hand if she could. It takes a considerable amount of effort for her to think about anything else, which is unfortunate considering that she really needs to fucking focus on this damn meeting. She assumes the prolonged touch is unconscious, but given how stiff Adora becomes when she looks at her, she really has no idea.

They don’t even put her back in her room when it ends. (Adora very quickly removes her hand as soon as people start moving which doesn’t help her figure it out *at all*.) At least the Alliance also realises time may, just perhaps, be of the essence. Adora undoes her cuffs with steady hands in front of everyone, undoing them far quicker than any time before. She doesn’t really know what that means either.

She goes with Adora back to her room to get her staff. Entirely because she cannot be alone with Frosta with her claws out. Not because she’d do anything, but because Frosta will definitely think that and she has a…*habit* of proving people right when they think she’s a threat. Today goes to shit and she’s going to get hit a lot, why make that number any higher?
There’s also the added benefit of seeing more of the castle. She thinks she *could* get back to the war room by herself now. That is if Adora’s taken them the same way each time.

She doesn’t enter the room with her, waiting in the shiny hallway she’s not actually looked at all that much. Adora’s practically blank once they’re turning back. She hopes it’s just nerves about a possible fight and not something else.

“This is a terrible idea,” Adora all but whispers.

She makes a small noise of agreement for the lacking of any other response. She can tell it’s not the only thing Adora wants to say but the rest of the walk remains silent. In fact, it’s silent between the two of them till they’re at the castle’s entrance hall. She sees

a little more of Brightmoon this time, walking with the group through soft stone walkways instead of being teleported there. The light still makes her eyes sting a little, but it is nothing compared to the first few days she spent in her cell.

There are people in the grand chamber when they arrive, gathered to watch the clones outside, and her body fights between curling in on itself and standing proud with fake confidence. It ends up some awkward mix of the two. Not that people actually pay all that much attention to her beyond an initial scowl.

One of the people asks Glimmer something but she's not listening. She's watching Adora, same as always. (She could probably stand to be a little more subtle about it but it's not like Adora's ever noticed so...) Adora's got the look she used to get before training assessments, where she tries to plan for everything but just doesn't know enough. Her hands are clenching and releasing over and over again at her sides.

"Hey," she gets Adora to stop with a hand on her arm. She hesitates under blue-grey eyes before pulling Adora over to the furthest wall from everyone, "It's going to be alright."

Adora starts shaking her head, "You don't -"

It's not particularly careful the way she reaches up and holds Adora's face in one hand. But it's to stop her talking - hopefully stop her thinking - more than anything and it works flawlessly. She's not going to tell her they'll be fine because she doesn't *know* if they will be. But acknowledging that won't help anyone. (Especially not her secretly-very-anxious best friend.)

Adora closes her eyes and leans into the hold for just a moment before moving away. And she hates how even that much *softness* with other people around makes her feel ill. It would've been fine in the dark, alone - sometimes she can let herself have it, only because Adora hasn't once rejected it. She tells herself no one saw, even if everything whispers to her that that is a lie.

She catches Glimmer telling the people to disperse, that it's dangerous to be this near the entrance. She's not exactly wrong if the barrier fails. She takes it to mean they'll be going now, and Catra knocks her head back towards the Queen and she keeps her eyes glued to the floor as they walk back over.

The enemy wall has moved back between the time of the...request, and that of them exiting the castle it seems, leaving a single clone ahead of the rest. If that's Prime then she's extremely confused. It looks exactly the same as every other one of them. Though she does quickly find a difference: the eyes. That's what she couldn't see last time.

Adora doesn't rush through the barrier again, thank gods. She keeps a clawed hand on her wrist anyway. Adora doesn't say anything, doesn't even move.

Catra prepares to hear the haunting unison again but it doesn't come, just a single voice, like Hordak's but not. Pretentious even in the way he says;
"Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon."

"Horde Prime."

"The occupants of this planet have told me *many* things about you. It is an honour to finally meet with you."

"Wish I could say the same."
Catra tries not to wince at that. It's something she would say, which means Glimmer should definitely not have said it. His face stays emotionless though, barely even blinking.
"...Is this your real body?"

It doesn't matter how far forward the question was sitting on her own tongue, there is no way Catra would've asked him. She's not saying anything to them. Maybe Glimmer's got even more bravery than she originally thought. Or more stupidity. A whole lifetime of

friendship with Adora means she knows exactly how similar the two are.

But Prime doesn't react. Again. "Oh no, my original body grew useless eons ago."

He doesn't elaborate further, probably for effect. Annoyingly it works, she had foolishly forgotten just how truly *ancient* this entity is. Her ears twitch towards shuffling from their side, and it's clear she's not the only one.

Glimmer pushes her shoulders back as Bow gets closer to her. "I asked your clones what you wanted before. Are you going to answer?"

He makes a face like he's thinking it over and it's just unsettling more than anything - looks false. "I have come to...ask something of you."

She thinks he's trying to smile but it's like a ghostly version of Hordak; he just can't do it. It also sounds like he has the utmost confidence that they will obey - which means they'll be made to. (She thinks about the witch for a flicker of a moment, sees enough of her in Prime to be seething as well as scared.)

"And will you destroy the planet if we don't comply?"

He laughs. Cold and restrained. Amused by them the way one is when they know so much more than you. It's a laugh she remembers from childhood, but this is far from mocking older cadets. She never thought she'd miss them.

"I have no intention of laying waste to your planet. Not yet. I simply wish to *inquire* about the Heart of Etheria."

Glimmer blurts, "You can't have the Heart," before she can stop herself. Everyone tenses as the clones take a step forward.

"Oh Little Queen, it is not a matter of whether I can - it is simply a matter of when. No harm has to come to your people if you do as

I ask.”

Bow puts a hand on Glimmer’s shoulder, “We can’t help you.” Bow remains rigid as glowing eyes look him over and Catra’s proud of him.

“Oh but you can. You just refuse. A foolish game. My empire will not be halted by you and your kind.”

He snaps his fingers and every weapon he has on the ground points at them. Catra forgets about the barrier and tightens her hold on Adora, unconsciously preparing to pull her out the way and take the fire for her. If she were thinking clearly, she’d realise that it is far more likely to happen the other way round.

“You can’t hurt us. You need all the Princesses *alive* to activate the Heart.”

Catra didn’t know that. Clearly Prime didn’t either. (She doesn’t actually know if it’s true but if it isn't, it is a brilliant lie by Sparkles.) She lets go of Adora’s wrist, but only because her claws were close to breaking skin. The woman she loves is protected - even if Prime doesn’t know she’s a Princess. They can tell him and he won’t be able to kill her. Glimmer, Scorpia and Entrapta are all protected too so long as Prime believes it to be true.

“Even She-Ra?”

She doesn’t know if the panic that makes her feel is warranted. If he knows, Adora’s safe. But, she supposes, that also makes her a target the same as Glimmer.

She regrets not placing herself in a position where she can see Glimmer’s face. But she trusts that Prime can read the way her shoulders drop. She doesn’t risk looking at Adora, he might not know *who* She-Ra is - he might not even know that she has a civilian form. But she can sense the way Adora stiffens even further out the corner of her eye.

More of that thin smile, “Oh yes, I know about her. And the people who made her. Who is her bearer?”
Green-white eyes fall on Adora near-instantly and it takes everything in her not to hiss or something far worse. She *wants* to fucking blind him. Her claws make their usual *shink* as they snap out. She can’t tear into his face from this distance but she swears to the gods if she gets the chance…
“It’s you. I’ve seen your face before, thousands of years ago when I fought your ancestors. A pathetic attempt on their part, but oh did they try. If you should continue to refuse me I’ll crush your worthless rebellion…just as I crushed theirs.”

“I’m here aren’t I? You didn’t destroy them all.” There’s a hardness in her voice, in her face, that Catra doesn’t recognise.

“No matter. Wherever they are, they are weak and powerless compared to my vast army.”

He waits for them. Waits for what, none of them are sure. They’re not moving and neither is he. Considering the last few weeks, she expects him to have more patience. He sighs, disappointed in a way that feels out of place with the severity of the situation. Though that’s it, she supposes; this isn’t *severe* for him in any way. *He* has every fucking advantage. She remains steady in her opinion that this was a *bad* idea.

“Very well. Perhaps I’ll have to make you more...amenable to my demands.”

The clones all raise their weapons.

The majority of them manage not to cower under the sudden heavy fire. The spell absorbs all the hits, the entire unceasing rain of them. But she should’ve known better than to think the barrier would be indestructible. Fissures start appearing in the transparent deep pink like it’s glass.

Their bots start firing from the inside. Needless to say no one thought that was going to happen. Catra does not know where

Entrapta is - if she's even watching - but she will hug her after this. The gaps they'd made in the army a day or so ago are nothing compared to this. Clones are gunned down too fast for her to count.

And still the clone inhabiting Prime stands there. Like he couldn't care less. Like this is meaningless. And she *hates* him.

A sorcerer falls. And she can't even tell whether Prime knew that would happen. She snarls at him. Just because she can. Because he deserves so much worse. Another sorcerer from the small group of them that are out here runs to fix the fragmenting pink. And just as there's only five clones left, including Prime, bots start coming out of the woods.

It takes another sorcerer crumbling to the ground for Glimmer and herself to realise they won't win this by standing their ground. Just because the Princesses have a shield doesn't mean anyone else - here or inside the castle - does.

"Stop! Stop, we'll talk to you. *Away from here*."

The firing ceases on both sides. He doesn't even have to move. So that snap was for show then. She wants to spit at him.

"It's admirable that you continue to try to protect your people."

"I was taught to believe it's the sign of a good leader." Prime laughs again. "Walk. We'll follow."

He and his army turn, calmly, steadily marching into the woods like they're not a threat at all. And there's anger in her blood that demands she prove him wrong. It's been a while since she's felt it.

Ahead, Bow whispers, "Are you sure about this?" to Glimmer.

"No. But if it saves the people."

He never turns back, none of them do. And she still feels like they're being watched.

The army is scattered amongst the trees. Some of the bots even avoid areas, though she can't fathom why. She has a horrible feeling that even if they get rid of this set more will come, it's only a couple of miles between them and the closest spire. And getting closer.

The Galactic Horde comes to a halt, one of the chasms caused by the Heart preventing them from advancing in a unit further. There are trees half fallen in, blue vines having had time to grow down into the abyss. Deep blue tree roots line the cliffs edge, gnarled and upturned and clinging to crumbled blue-grey stone.

Altogether, the army, predominantly bots now, turns back to them. Glimmer's hands light up with magic. Catra bares her claws further, everyone else taking it as a sign to arm themselves.

"I am not one to be fooled Little Queen."

"We know that. That's why there's no trick."

Catra knows realistically there's no way they will all come way from this unscathed - if they even come away from it at all. And she does nothing. She obeys silent orders the way she never did in the Horde. Maybe she's just gained perspective. (Or maybe it's because she actually cares about these people. Some of them.)

Glimmer raises her hand, a sparkling orb buzzing in it. She sends it flying for the enemy. Catra leaps into a tree just as everyone sends a mass wave of magic forwards.

She runs faster than anyone else - faster than the bots on all fours- and crashes down on the clone inhabiting Prime. She slices through its throat before she can second guess herself, knowing that's not the end of him. She's not that stupid. Or that optimistic.

A shot goes flying by her head, she only manages to miss it because of her hearing. She turns back to the clone who fired it,

the glowing halo sliding into its eyes, a cruel smile twisting its previously blank features. “Did you think it would be so easy?”

“Not at all. I was just checking.”

The smile vanishes, the glow with it as Perfuma’s vines wrap around the body and send it to the ground.

It is simultaneously easier and harder to fight Prime’s army when they’re scattered like this, firing from anywhere as the bots weave through the trees. With magic being able to attack in multiple directions at once, she sticks with the nearest Princess. They take out what they can and she watches their backs, whoever it is she’s with at the moment. She doesn’t tell them she’s doing that, but she doesn’t really need to.

She stays away from Scorpia. She’s no use if she gets swept up in memories. Or if she can’t breathe. She is free to fight and nothing more.

She keeps an eye on Bow since he seems distracted. She takes a moment hidden among leaves to follow his sight. Unsurprisingly he’s watching Glimmer - as exhausted as she was last time. Catra leaps to the tree closest to the Queen and jumps down on a bot’s back when its cannon aims and misses just a little too close to Bow. There's already another machine raising it's arm at them.

Snowball - *Frosta* - is punching the bots with fists made of ice nearby, so she shouts, "Frosta! Wall for the Queen?” across the field.

Frosta gives her a nod, running and sending a thick wall of ice out her hands in front of them. A shot gets caught in it, heat fizzing out with the cold. Catra jumps over it and onto the bot, disabling it quickly. She launches herself at the other one coming towards them, only distantly hearing:

“Glimmer are you okay?”
“I’m fine Frosta, let’s just win this.”

She looks for her next target, finding it in the clone that's a little too close to Adora. She calls out to her, Adora twisting to look at her for a moment before she gets distracted by said enemy. Why Adora's not running it through or knocking it to the ground, she doesn't know.

A sheet of ice sweeps across the forest floor, she can hear the bots not-feet slipping on it but she's not watching. "Bow cover Frosta!"

Clambering into the cover of leaves, she gets as close to Adora as she can. Adora who is practically frozen in place, fist white around her pike. The clone - Prime - is saying something about She-Ra. She doesn't hear it. Not since his hand makes a connection to Adora's cheek. All false gentleness just like Shadow Weaver. She's jumping down and pulling the arm away so fast she hears a crack. She's sinking claws into its chest the next second.

The disgust on Adora's face from the touch hasn't exactly gone, but it has at least eased now that the body is crumbled on the ground.

"Are you *trying* to get yourself maimed?" Her claws reek of Prime's alien chemicals so much that there's tears burning in her eyes.

"Are *you*?" Adora blurts out in response, looking confused with herself as to why she said it. "He can't hurt me without losing the Heart for good."

"He can't kill you. There's a difference."

Adora opens her mouth to retort, but Catra pivots away with a scoff before she can, running for the nearest bot and leaping at it. She hears the clang of Adora fighting behind her, finding comfort in it that she probably shouldn't.

Far from them, Perfuma and Scorpia are taking on a frankly absurd amount of bots together using their magic. Scorpia's never exactly been a fighter in the way Catra knows best, but this...might make her think otherwise. She looks back, checking

that Glimmer is still alright. She is, Bow is defending her from behind the ice wall while she catches her breath, a bot is fizzing with her sparkles far away. Catra hears the swish of water far from her on the other side, so figures the water Princess must be alright too.

Checking on other people in battle is a first, she realises kind of miserably. It is, technically, a distraction. She's never been in battle with people she actually cares about being in danger like this. Well, not when said people she cares about aren't the ones she's fighting against. She blames that for the fact an enemy manages to catch her.

There's a harsh impact on her face, solid not gunfire. The taste of metal explodes in her mouth as she stumbles, her lip throbbing. She lashes out, but her claws find nothing as she's pinned to the ground on her front. It gets pulled off her and she rolls quickly into a crouch.
The weaponless clone is sprawled on the floor, pinned there by Adora as she punches its face in, the not-metal crumpling under her strength.

She should, decidedly, not be as in love with the sight as she is. Adora's got green chemical clinging to her hand and She-Ra's blue in her eyes when Catra pulls her off by the shoulders. Not because she wants Adora to stop, but because there's already more bots and their cannons firing shots at them. She shields Adora's body with hers as Bow shoots another two clones down.

She scrambles off her and pulls her back to standing. Adora's hair is a wreck and the glow is gone from her eyes, replaced by some sort of dark rage, when she looks at Catra after crushing something under her boot. "It was trying to chip you."

Maybe it's suitable that the fur on the back of her neck stands on end. "Thanks."

It’s mindless after that, all bots now. Circuitry dies in her hands, and even the shock of electricity isn’t as bad as the eye-watering stench of green chemical that’s thankfully gone from her hands. She also stays with Adora after that, too focused on not getting hurt to wonder why they separated at all; who else knows how she fights?

Adora’s eyes light up a couple times, but never for long, there’s even the occasional beam from her skin and hair, however flickering. It’s strange but considering they’re fighting robots from space...well she has higher priorities. Like how separated the Rebellion is on the battlefield. She can see Glimmer, Bow and Mermista (and of course Adora) but the others are all through a series of trees, much farther from the chasm than they are.

She dodges another blast as it whizzes by her head, heading for the water Princess where she stands all too close to the cliff edge. Tackling the bot to the ground, and shutting it down quickly, she springs back up. Mermista isn’t anywhere in her sights initially. But she does hear her calling for help.

She looks around for the pirate - she doesn’t think she’s ever seen him anywhere other than Mermista’s side - but he’s not here. She doesn’t even know if he came with them. It takes her exactly two seconds to realise Mermista’s gone over the edge.

“Bow, Mermista’s over the cliff!”

“I’ve got her!” he calls back, pointing over her head before he’s running to the ridge.

Catra spins, kicking a bot hard enough that it goes flying into a tree. The impact must have broken something necessary because it powers down. There isn’t another target for her to hit after that and she’s immediately searching for Adora. She finds her, thankfully, a way from the chasm with Glimmer at her side *talking* with a clone - with *Prime* again.

She almost springs to their side and slices the clone herself, but instead she thinks, and backs herself into a tree. She keeps a watch for enemies in the area, listening carefully to what Prime's saying. Tension is readily coiled into her muscles in case she needs to run to either them or Mermista and Bow.

Adora

She was holding Glimmer up before Prime over took the last clone. The emotion dragged forth by the white rings in its eyes and the reanimation of its face mixes easily with her own adrenaline, making her want to run from him. Or at least punch his face in. But just like last time she's annoyingly frozen.

Glimmer stands beside her, upright and faking it. Adora watches Bow over Prime's shoulder running to the ravine edge. There's water droplets hanging in the air that she's only just registered. It's quiet enough here, far enough from the bigger fight, that she can hear Mermista's voice echo. She puts it together after that, realising that there's not enough water around for Mermista to save herself.

"Give me She-Ra and this all stops." Prime yanks her focus back with that horrid voice of his.

"You'll never have her," she sounds so much more confident than she feels. She doesn't know if he can *take* She-Ra from her, but she's willing to bet that he will *try*.

"Or the Heart." Glimmer's fists are still sparkling so at least she has some strength left.

Prime just looks at them with some mockery of tired, "I cannot hurt you, Little Queen or you *She-Ra*," he spits the name so venomously she wants to recoil, "That will not change until you outgrow your usefulness to me. But I can hurt those you love."

The cannon - the one they didn't break for some fucking reason - is fired before they can stop it.

Bow’s got a hold on both of Mermista’s arms, having just managed to pull her up to standing. He’s not looking for the blast that's going to hit him. Why would he? They should’ve taken this clone down by now.

Glimmer shouts, “Bow!” as loud as she can.

Glimmer can teleport. She should be able to get there in time to save him. But she’s tired and drained. And Catra gets there first. Bow doesn’t get hit, not once Catra’s shoved him out the way. But he is falling, Mermista too, feet slipping on crumbling ground. And Catra. Because Bow may not have been hit, but she was.

She yells, “Catra!” exactly the same.

Glimmer shimmers into view at the edge, footing stumbling slightly.

“Perhaps you will rethink your decision now -” There’s a pike through the clone’s stomach before he can say anything else. And she’s running.

Glimmer’s there at the edge waiting for her. No, not waiting, just in shock as she stares down at the three falling people. She doesn’t have shock halting her right now. There isn’t logic. There is the sight of Catra falling and the inescapable need to save her.

There is absolutely nothing in her stopping her from jumping after her.

She doesn’t catch Catra.

From what they’d been told this should be an endless fall. Of course it’s not. No, she’s hit the ground legs first, and she’s been lying here who-knows-how-long trying to regain consciousness. She’s in a shallow pool of water, ice cold, that probably helped in reviving her. She tries to stand and fails, pain flaring in near-every part of her body as the bone gives way under her.

She looks around uselessly. It is as black as the world behind her eyelids. There's moonlight high above, sure, but it doesn't reach this far down.

"Catra?" Her voice manages to break on the single word. Reasonably, she knows there isn't a reality where she gets an answer. She does it anyway, gives scratchy cries of Catra's name over and over again as she crawls through the water and the dark.

There's...green. Glowing eyes when she looks up. She would've seen them if she could stand. But they stare down at her, the whole group of them, huddled and most likely surrounding something; surrounding Catra.

And she drags herself towards them, pain so intense it would've blinded her anyway. She doesn't even hear the water as she moves, only feels the cold of it. When she finally, *finally* reaches Catra, she's panting hard through gritted teeth. She wasn't crying before. She is now.

She pulls Catra into her arms, fingers catching on the cauterized shot through her stomach. All Catra does is whimper. Because she *can't* do anything else. But it means she's alive, and it's the only reason she doesn't scream.

The water laps at her legs as she raises Catra properly into her lap and cries into her shoulder. It doesn't matter that Prime can see her like this. Being *weak* right now doesn't matter. The dull echo of Catra's heartbeat feels like the only thing keeping her sane. She winds a hand into her wet hair and clings on as tight as she dares.

There's already so much tension trapped in her body where she tries to stop herself shaking that she doesn't even jump when Prime speaks;
"You see She-Ra, I had no choice. Not since you forced my hand. Down here, I had hoped to get the Heart through...civil methods. But you denied me my right. And so, this is the consequence you shall face."

He needs to *stop talking*. She opens her eyes, sees the glow of them reflected in the pitch black of the water. She breathes in the distorted smell of Catra's fur. Feels that blaze Catra makes her feel, disfigured by the desperation and fear and rage roaring in her whole body.

She needs to get out of here. She needs to win this fight. She needs to keep everyone safe. She needs to save the world. There is so much she *needs* to do. There always is.

But she doesn't care. For once it doesn't matter. The world is second to how she feels right now; second to Catra. Catra who is dying in her arms, who is making her glow - ignite - from the inside out. She grabs ahold of the feeling, letting it flow instead of shoving it down.

Everything is burning magic - burning power - as she stands on broken legs. She can feel the bone strengthening, every gash and bruise she's gotten in this fight and fall fading or knitting itself back together as bright blue like a flare surrounds her. She can barely register it as she looks down at Catra. Her arm feels stronger than she's ever known it, and yet she still cradles Catra to her.

The words come easily as she raises her other hand to the sky. So familiar and now, she realises, unneeded. The blade that fabricates in her grip is not of this world, not of any one world at all. She stares into acid green eyes, Prime's eyes, as the magic washes into her muscles in a tidal wave.
There is something so *satisfying* about looking down on him and the false body he's inhabiting.

The soft way she moves Catra onto her shoulder feels out of place with how harshly she slices through the circle of clones in one arc. A translucent rainbow follows in the golden blade's wake. She jumps, fast and high enough that she doesn't hear the splash when the clones hit the water. Her hands - *She-Ra's hands* - make grips in the rock. The stone that shatters falls soundlessly to the bottom.

The slightest amount of light is reaching them after the jump but she doesn’t need it. She-Ra’s gold-white aura is more than enough for her to see the cracks in the stone, the roots weaving in and out the sides of the ravine. She scrambles up the wall, the journey taking too long considering the limited use of her other arm. But soon enough there’s a ledge she can push off with her feet. The rock rumbles with the force. She grabs a hold of a tangle of vines where it drips above the abyss. The half-rooted trees lie on top of one another overhead, the only reason she suspects that it doesn’t fall down on them.

She’d have made it to the top by herself. She knows she would have. But it is still a relief when Glimmer appears next to them, teleporting them the next second. She’s on her knees when they appear back at the surface, Catra breathing shakily, quietly, weakly, but *breathing*. Glimmer collapses beside her and she doesn’t know what to do.

Bow lifts Glimmer, carrying her to the nearest tree and setting her down. She’s caught in a war with herself over whether or not to look at Catra in daylight. The amount of wounds she must be branded with right now might very well make her sick. She resolves to look only at her face. There’s no bruising save for the swelling of her lip but that wasn’t from the fall. There’s no blood in her wet hair, so at least some other part of her took the brunt of the fall. She doesn’t let herself analyse any further - it'll crush her too much.

Bow comes back over and gently tugs on her hands. It is surprisingly difficult to let go. She channels as much magic into Catra as she can before he takes her. It’s not nearly enough.

“Go. I’ve got them.” Catra’s body is completely limp in his arms and she feels more tears spill. “Go win this for us.”

She takes only a second to breathe. They don't have time; Catra doesn’t have time.
The sword appears in her hand again, an extension of her now

rather than anything else, hers to dismiss and call. If she were Adora, she'd tremble as she stands. But she doesn't.

She doesn't bother wiping the water from her face, she doesn't care. Everything is already in perfect clarity, She-Ra's focus like tunnel vision as she crosses back through the trees. The world around her, the blue of the forest, is illuminated white with She-Ra's light. Really it's no wonder why everyone, including all the bots, turn to stare.

She hopes Prime can see through his bots too. She wants him to watch her destroy all of them.

What's left of the army starts converging on her, leaving her friends alone to come for her. It's a relief, strangely. Her sword morphs easily into a shield - easier than she ever remembers the transformation to be. It actually feels like she has control over this, she can *trust* this. Like now that she's *got* She-Ra, the magic's actually listening to her.

Instead of getting pushed back by the cannon shots, she feels invigorated by them. Like she's absorbing the energy. Maybe she is.

She runs at the bots, ramming the flat of her shield into them with a yell that makes the air crackle. It sends them flying much further than anticipated. She swings her sword at the rest, the movement creating static iridescent magic that hangs in the air until she sends it forward like a second blade. Somehow she both expected and could never have guessed that that would happen. She-Ra is more than her, ancient, timeless; she knows what she can do. But she is also Adora, who could barely grasp the power she had with the sword holding her back.

Her friends are huddled close to trees to avoid fire, she just shouts, "Get back to Brightmoon, I'll handle this!" And hopes enough people hear.

The glow fades once the last of them lies on the forest floor. She doesn't shrink down back into her body; she can't. She's all too aware again, genuine unbridled panic breaking through She-Ra's battle calm. With She-Ra's height, she can see the cliff edge - Catra's not there. There's no one around her, and she hopes to the gods that means everyone listened to her. She runs towards the castle spires she can see over the treetops.

The Rebellion is there waiting for her. There's a divide on the other side of the barrier. Injured people in groups all looking at the same thing. And she can guess what. The spell seals closed behind her and the first thing that hits her ears is soft crying. As soon as she realises it's more than just Scorpia she knows it's bad.

She has been scared far more times in her life than she'll ever admit. But this is different. And not. This is that damn throne room all over again. Worse, somehow, because it's not just the two of them. It's not Catra *wanting* to die, it's Catra suffering for doing a good thing. All these people looking at the dying body of the woman she loves, expecting She-Ra to save her when she doesn't even know if she can. She didn't have that last time. Last time they were the ones expecting her to come home with the news of Catra's demise by her hand.
It won't just be her grieving if she fails this time.

And she's crying. Even She-Ra shakes as she would, the sword flickering out of existence.

People step aside for her and she can't even look at them. If she could run she would. But she can't. Bow's sitting on the ground, Catra against his chest. Glimmer is at his side hugging him and the body in his arms as she shines, the Moonstone high above them beaming with the connection. She-Ra has never felt heavier than now, seeing just how ashen Bow's face is as he looks at her.

She can hear the thunder of the lights in the Horde throne room as they flicked on, as she found Catra looking as weak and lifeless as she does now. She doesn't want the memory - she's never wanted it.

She joins them on the ground, and Bow gives Catra up to her. Catra feels gentler, more breakable than glass; injured and unmoving. And - and not breathing. The unsteady pulse that held her sanity is gone too.

She clutches Catra to her chest just like before, buries her face in her shoulder as she fails to bite back a scream. Her strength doesn't matter, it's not like she can bruise Catra anymore than she already is. It feels like she hasn't stopped crying since finding Catra in the water.

'I can fix this. I can fix this,' is all she thinks as Glimmer's magic shimmers around them.

Chapter End Notes

****Glimmer's Interlude****

...Hold Me, Never Leave Me

Chapter Notes

> This directly follows the last chapter so I would recommend reading the end again.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

The four of them appear in the entrance hall. There are other people around. Realistically there must be. She can hear Glimmer telling people to leave but she can't see anything but Catra; the blurred, dying version of her produced by tears.

Catra's face is still bloody from her split lip, the water at the bottom of the pit not enough to wash it away. Her trembling fingers do nothing either, too soft with the way she practically traces Catra's lips. And yet her hand still manages to be stained red.

And she just holds her, Catra's face in her hand - able to feel so much more of her when she's She-Ra. In a horrible way it's not so unlike how they'd been earlier. Catra hadn't told them they'd be fine then, and her breaking heart is whispering that Catra somehow knew this would happen.

She holds her head, gazes brokenly at her with too much reverence, she knows that. But what does it matter now? Catra's not even breathing to know that she's looking at her like she's everything she's never let herself want. Because she is, still, after all this time.

She's so glad Catra's eyes are closed. She can pretend she's asleep, peaceful and dreamless the way she's only seen a few times; the way she always wants Catra to sleep.

But the thing about falling asleep with Catra is that one of them always wakes up. A nightmare or not, she can always feel Catra's warmth where she touches her.
Catra might not wake up from this. Catra's colder than she's ever been.

There is a fear she's horribly, terribly known before. One that worries and cries and whimpers what if this is it for them. It's never been this consuming. This is soaking her thoughts rather than poisoning the edges. There's no fight here to distract her from it.

There is instead pure desperation brought by the death of Catra's pulse, undoubtedly new. It's never *been like this*. It's never been this hopeless.

And the world feels a million miles away.

It is just them, the way they'd always said it would be, in a situation neither of them in their wildest dreams could ever have predicted. And she's proud of Catra underneath it all. She saved Bow, fought for the good guys, how could she not be?

But she's also heartbroken and angry because *how could she*? Catra's not the one meant to die for this war. It's *her*, it's always meant to be Adora - *She-Ra* - who takes the fall. She-Ra can survive. And this is the second time she's had to watch, helpless as Catra all but destroys herself.
It makes her a hypocrite. She doesn't care. Not when her tears are running down, getting caught in fur and Catra doesn't even flinch.

"Catra please, please you can't - I can't lose you again. Don't *do this* to me again. I can't do this without you, I said it before and I meant it - I still mean it, I'll *always mean it*. Catra I -" and she still can't say it.

Catra can't hear her. If she ever tells her she deserves to *hear her* say it. To know that she's been a coward this whole time, selfishly

loving her this whole time when she's never once been allowed to. Catra deserves to hear her apologies afterwards.

Nothing changes in the light of her admission this time.

She didn't think it would. She's just...desperate. And lost. And it feels like she's already grieving for her whole life that she's spent thinking about this woman. For all the somethings and what ifs she'll never get to have with her if she doesn't *fix this*.

It's easy in the end - to doom herself. It is easy to kiss Catra. To feel her like this, to breathe into her while magic pours through the both of them.
And she hates the fact she ever wanted it in the first place.

She's never let herself entertain the idea of actually kissing Catra in any serious light; a want to kill and bury every time it revives itself. In much the same way she never even thought it a possibility to be She-Ra again. And yet here she is. She-Ra again and kissing Catra.

It is a press of lips and nothing more; a goodbye if this doesn't work. Catra can hate her for this, she'll welcome it. Because it'll mean she's alive to hate her.

Gold surrounds them in a column like the electric blue earlier. She doesn't see it, sinking into the heat of the magic in her blood, into the renewing warmth of Catra. Most magic is cold - not this. She-Ra's never been cold, not for her.

She never breaks the kiss, never holds tighter for fear of breaking. The strength drains from her body quicker than the light fades. For a few stained moments she is Adora kissing Catra; she's not above her leaning down or bringing Catra up. It's just them, it's Catra in her lap the way that's familiar, it's her feeling *right* in her arms, *right* everywhere they're pressed together.

The light disappears. She should pull away, she's already given everything she can. She should. She can't keep doing this forever. Eventually Bow or Glimmer or anyone will have to pull her away

and - and Catra gasps against her lips, her whole body jerking with it. She'd crumble into Adora's chest if she weren't holding her. Instantly, Adora's shaking again, a truly pitiful cry falling into the silence as she snaps her eyes open. Then she's frantically scrambling to hold Catra's face with her other hand too.

She's still *crying*. She's not even ashamed of it. She is looking at Catra *alive* - she has to be alive, corpses don't gasp for air - and all that fear is still there, feeling like it's trapped. Her fingers are stiff against Catra's skin where she's fighting with herself to stop them gripping. Damn desperation.

Catra coughs, still not opening her eyes, body curling in on itself slightly. She wants to pull Catra against her chest but she just can't; she can't move. She tries and fails - it doesn't matter because Catra's blinking her eyes open.

Her trembling hand manages to push Catra's hair out of her face, she catches it against her cheek. She thinks Catra will hate her for doing this in front of people but...well Catra's going to hate her for so many things already. She can still feel that pressure like a ghost against her lips.

But as soon as her hand lands back on Catra's cheek, she's sinking into her, seemingly completely unaware of anyone else around them. She feels the same way, but she has none of the excuse. And it doesn't matter, it really, really doesn't.

Catra's looking at her as soft as she does at night, she's whispering, "Hey Adora."

And she whimpers pathetically in response. She doesn't care. Maybe she hadn't felt fear like that before, but then she's never felt relief and *joy* like this either. She lets loose a sound of pure delight before she's screwing her eyes shut and kissing Catra on the forehead roughly, then the cheek and finally settling into her shoulder as she hugs her. Maybe she'll regret that later too, right now she doesn't care.

Catra doesn’t fight it, not for a moment. She was limp in her arms before, this is different, this is just gentility. Catra seems to start purring once she stops moving, turning into her neck just like she’s doing and hugging her back. She can hear Catra’s heartbeat here, strong and loud. She wants to mould a hand to her neck but Catra won’t want her to, so she presses her forehead there instead.

The rhythm drums into her skin and she feels like she could fall asleep here easily; held by Catra, feeling her purr and heartbeat in her chest. She’d forgotten just how much healing exhausts her.

But Catra stops purring and pulls back far too soon (though really she's sure she could spend forever holding her, being held *by* her, and it wouldn’t be enough.) “You still crying?” Catra teases, but she knows it’s a genuine question.

She doesn’t want to be out here. She wants to stay hidden in the safety of Catra’s pulse, away from the eyes of her best friends she knows are still there. She wants this closeness before Catra pushes her away again. But she is, pathetically, still crying. And it makes her angry.

“You told me not to sacrifice myself! You said you were going to be okay!” She shoves at Catra’s chest with too much strength and Catra slides off her to the floor looking mildly affronted. “I’m sorry, I’m…” she screws her eyes shut, hands curling into the fabric on her legs as she tries to *stop crying*.

‘How many times am I almost going to lose you?’ That’s what she meant. It’s not a question she wants answered unless the response is ‘never again.’

Catra’s warmth moving against her side makes her sigh through the watery hiccups. It’s back, the ice of the water gone with magic. And even in those few minutes, she missed it. She wants to melt back into it again but she won’t. For now. She's weak and the slightest sign that Catra needs her in any way? She'll be wrapped around her again.

“Adora, I am okay. Look at me.”

She goes to retort because how could Catra *possibly* be okay? But then Catra’s tail is curling in her lap and she’s wiping the tears from her face, soft clawless fingertips dragging under her eyes. She doesn’t know whether it makes her heart feel full or empty. She keeps her eyes closed as she shakes her head because she can’t - she just can’t. If there’s *anything* left on Catra she’ll just cry more and neither of them handle tears well. She wants to stop for her, she really does but...

“You saved me. Adora you - you *fixed* me.”

There’s a pitiful noise in the back of her throat but she is smiling brokenly after that. From relief more than anything, except maybe love. She turns her head, finally managing to be brave enough to see Catra again and finding this *knowing* look; she knows what she said.
She wants to thank her. For what, she’s not sure. For living? For allowing her this? For not pushing her away? For knowing what to say? For knowing her at all?

She never figures it out, the two of them are wrapped up in pincers before she can, and a relieved, ecstatic “Catra!” rings in both their ears. Catra’s ears flatten to her head with the sudden loud noise but she is smiling from what little of her face Adora can see since they’re both pressed in tight to Scorpia’s chest.
There’s another...something wrapped around them after a couple seconds. Purple hair only stays for a second before Entrpata’s coming in front of them and sitting on the ground.

Catra taps at Scorpia’s arm where she can reach, “Scorpia? Ease up a little?”

“Right, right, you just died and -”

“No, it’s not that, I just said I’d do something,” Catra holds her arm out for Entrapta and the Princess looks a little confused by it, “You get under it.”

Entrapta worms her way cautiously under Catra's arm. Adora's sure Scorpia would be near tears if she hadn't just been crying anyway.
"You did good with the bots today," Catra tells her.

Entrapta grins ear to ear, "They took down the clones beautifully."

"They did."

"How's the wound?" Most people don't look excited saying that - though she is clearly trying to hide it.

She can tell Entrapta's holding herself back from poking at where a hole should be. Adora pulls slowly out of Scorpia's hold, getting her first look at Catra's disappeared damage. Because it has disappeared. Vanished, even the clothes sewn back together and the stain of blood on her face like it was never there.

And even though she's talking to Entrapta, Catra looks to her to say, "All fixed."

She wants to kiss her. Again. Because she has. She's kissed Catra and she's acting like everything is fine - like it didn't happen at all. But honestly...that's a very *Catra* thing to do. Preservation of a sort. Or maybe she's not said anything because she was crying, or because there are people around? It doesn't matter, it won't matter until they're alone again.
For now she'll sit here, close enough to touch but holding back. And she'll think about the time she'd thought that maybe kissing Catra would sedate the urge because it was entirely wrong.

"Can we get in on this?" Bow asks, because of course he does. Glimmer doesn't, just throwing her arms around Catra's shoulders from behind in a move she's lucky doesn't get her injured. Catra heard her coming, what with her not teleporting, so all she does is fake a grumble.

Bow and Glimmer settle in between her and Entrapta, kind of linking up the scruffy circle. Bow holds out a hand which Catra

hesitantly takes, not understanding the meaning of it. “Thank you, for saving my life.”

Her ears pin back in surprise, “Don’t thank me.”

“Too bad, Wildcat. People here thank you when you do nice things.”

Catra snatches her hands back, shoulders squaring as if it’ll hide how flustered she is. “I don’t do nice things, shut up.”

Catra’s tail is flicking behind her and she’s nearly blushing. Adora thinks about all the times Catra’s calmed her after a nightmare. She’d say that was a *nice* thing to do. And when Catra looks at her, scoffing and flushing more, she has a feeling Catra knows what she’s thinking.

“Actually you do, I have records,” Entrapta says happily.

Adora smiles at that, watching Catra’s exaggerated eye roll with a heavy sigh. Bow puts a hand on her arm that she doesn't mean to startle at, “You okay?”

“What? Oh, yeah I’m fine. Just tired, She-Ra, healing and all.”

“Then let’s get you back to your room, Princess.”

Before she can respond to that (because literally the whole Alliance is here), Glimmer says, “I’ll teleport you -”

“- No, Glim, I think we might need to start rationing teleports again.”

Glimmer’s got her angry sparkles back at least. Not that she’s actually angry with Bow. So they’re more *frustrated* sparkles.

“It’s fine Shimmer, I can *walk*.”

Catra

She does, actually, walk away from the hall by herself, sort of. Adora is trailing so close behind her she can feel her worry like a clinging blanket. It's sweet, she gets it, but it's also just weird. The same way a lot of today has been.

She'd died. Just...completely died. Less than an hour ago and yet the memory of the pain is already that; a memory. The only evidence she has is Adora's behaviour and the aching in every part of her body. Adora's behaviour… Adora *kissed her*, twice. Forehead and cheek in quick succession. And she...she doesn't know what to think. It was clearly done out of relief. And it made her feel more loved than she has in a long time, maybe ever. But does Adora even know that?

Pain shoots up her spine when she looks back, trying to figure out which way to go, and then she's stumbling. Adora doesn't even have to get closer to put her arms around her. Or pick her up. That *loved* is so obnoxiously loud, and she lets herself think it, just so long as she knows it's not love in the way that she feels.

If they weren't alone she'd protest. But strangely, they are. She wonders where the *many* refugees are for a moment before deciding she doesn't care. Annoyingly it feels *so* much better here. She wonders if Adora's still healing her, if that's why she's doing it.

"This okay?" Adora asks, even though they're already like this and already moving again.

"Yeah, yeah this is fine. Sure you're not too tired?"

Adora just glares at her, so she's not really sure what the answer is. She figures if the journey's too long she'll just get down. Adora can't stop her from doing that.

She-Ra's residual magic is burning in her nose, and it is the only reason she doesn't curl into Adora's chest. (Like the last time Adora held her like this.) It's...different than she remembers it. It's more like Adora, more bearable in that sense. She'll blame the lack of her sword for that. But it's still near overwhelming.

She expects Adora to start talking but she never does. And she can't think of anything to say so...she just watches where they're going. After a couple minutes she asks Adora whether they can go right at the upcoming fork - there's people down the left hall. Adora nods, shifting her grip on her back a little before carrying on.

Adora doesn't put her down once her door comes into view, not even after entering and closing said door. She really does want to protest, or say *anything*, she's just caught in stunned silence. Adora sets her down on her bed, never once losing contact completely. And really, Adora needs to be careful, because she has no idea how much that's making her feel. It feels kind of dangerous to indulge this much in daylight but *Adora* is the one doing it so...

Adora climbs on the bed next to her, looking unsure what to do with her hands now that they've separated. Catra turns so they're sitting face to face, both of them with their legs crossed. Except that doesn't really help because now she doesn't know what to do either.

Adora chews at her lip before, "Is everything - everything's all healed right?"

"Um, yeah, I mean I can still kind of feel it? Is that normal?"

Adora rises up on her knees, shifting closer, and she's helpless but to stare up at her. Helpless but to wait and see what she'll do. "Yeah, yeah that's fine. You're okay… Right?"

"Yes. I'm-"

But then there's Adora's hand on her face, fingers under her chin and thumb brushing over her bottom lip. She manages not to gasp but she knows her tail's gone stick straight. Not that Adora notices with the intense way she's looking at her lips. It's because of the cut that should be there but isn't. She knows that - well her head does. Her heart, not so much.

She wants more than this. She shouldn't. She can't.

"Adora stop…"

'Stop touching me like you love me.'

She grips onto Adora's wrist, pulls it away from her face - from her lips - slowly. It doesn't matter that she keeps a hold on her, Adora looks...scared as she sits back. "I'm sorry, I'm so sorry. I shouldn't have -"

"Adora, it's - it's okay. It doesn't hurt, it's just uncomfortable," she lies. Gods she hates lying to her.

"What? Oh - oh, yeah She-Ra...it's probably still going to ache for a while." Adora tries to hide her grimace but fails.

"Hey did - are you alright? I don't remember anything between hitting the ground and then...y'know, *you* crying in front of me..." she can't help trailing off at the end.

She never wants to make Adora cry, well, not anymore. But knowing that she was crying *for her*? It's conflicting. It means Adora cares. And she knows that, she does, but there have been seeds of doubts about that her whole life, planted by that witch. For once, they're entirely silent.

"I'm sorry -"

"- Adora…" Blue eyes are glistening again, she doesn't know how to stop it. Just because it means she cares doesn't mean she wants it. She has her proof for today - for the next however long. Now all she wants is Adora happy again. Or as close as they can get into it given everything.

"No, really, I'm so sorry. I should have known better, I -"
She's paralysed as Adora tucks her head into her own chest, breathing far too loud. She has no idea what Adora's talking about. She knows Adora blames herself for everything, but this

seems...extreme, even for her.
“I’ll go.”

At least she’s able to move when Adora starts to leave, grip she still has on her wrist tightening. “Don’t be sorry, and don’t leave. Please.”

After everything today, after Adora held her, kissed her cheek and forehead, it doesn’t feel like she’s cutting into herself by saying it. She *knows* Adora doesn’t want to leave. She doesn't know why she feels like she has to. But no matter, it’s still hard to breathe until she sees hope.

“You want me to stay?” Adora’s voice shouldn’t be allowed to break like that.

She can say this. She can *say it*. “Yes, dummy. You really think I want to be alone right now?”

Adora sits back down, turning her hand over without breaking Catra’s grip to be able to run her fingers over her pulse. Annoyingly it makes her breathless.

“You forgive me?”

She snaps her gaze up from where Adora’s touching her too softly. “Forgive you for saving me?”

“No for…”

Maybe it’s because her mind is still waking back up, but everything Adora’s saying is confusing her, “What?”

“For - I - to bring you back I -”

There’s no sound when the tears well back up in her eyes. They just fall, Adora looking at her like she’s still lifeless. She lets go of Adora’s wrist and it manages to make her look even more distraught. They’re both doing stupid things today, for different reasons, sure, but still *stupid*. Today is just *different*. Today means

she can do this; pull Adora into her lap by her waist, fold her into her chest.

And she's scared to do it, sure. Feels like someone will punish them for it. But she doesn't care, can easily force it from her head as Adora clings to her and sobs, "I know - I know it's not the first time you've almost died but it was worse, it was so much worse Catra. You were - you were *dead*. No pulse, no breathing, just blood and bruise and -"

She wraps her arms around Adora's back, feels her relax marginally because of it. "It's okay, I'm okay, *we're* okay."

The smell of She-Ra hasn't really faded. It's still cloying around her, but that crackling magic isn't so present in her hair. She turns her cheek into her, breathes through her mouth so she can stay here, and the body in her arms relaxes further. Adora takes deep breaths that she can feel even through her clothes before one of her arms unwinds from around her neck. There's no tremors in Adora's hand as she pulls Catra's arm back and curls a hand around her wrist.

"I just - I need to know you're alive right now."

She grits her teeth against how much that hurts her to hear. She starts purring, forcing it for the first time in her life. It's difficult but she does it. Focuses on how it feels to be with Adora like this instead of why.

"This help?" Adora nods into her shoulder, breaths coming easier. "I'm going to move, okay?"

"Do you want me to…?"

"No, you're alright." Catra feels weak, that aching in her limbs spiking as she moves back with Adora still wrapped around her. The solid stone of the wall as she leans against it won't help the pain in any way but it's taking the strain off.

“Wait, let me,” Adora loosens the grip she has on Catra’s shoulders and waist, looking increasingly embarrassed about it, her blush creeping under her shirt collar. (She looks unfairly gorgeous. Damn blue eyes.) But she moves, not out of her lap (thankfully), just into a position they are more familiar with. Though she’s never had Adora sit with her like this - actually in the well of her crossed legs - it’s close enough to *their* hold that it’s easy to breathe.

Adora leans her ear to just below the dip between her clavicles, re-taking her wrist in her hand. Any other time she’d assume it’s for her purr but after today - after Adora’s been gripping onto her pulse points - she thinks it’s safe to assume it’s for another reason too.

Adora mutters quietly, “Forgot how tired healing makes me…”

She sinks further into the wall and winds her other arm around Adora’s shoulders. “Well, we don’t have to do anything, so I guess that’s not a problem.”

“Catra there’s always something to do.”

“Not for us, not today. Pretty much got the best excuse for fucking off that you can get.” Adora grumbles an agreement that she can’t help snickering at.

And then it’s calm. It’s quiet. And it feels like a dream. As everything after the fall does. Maybe that’s why she’s being brave; it feels like there’s no consequences. And until she wakes up tomorrow, or until Adora pulls away, it’ll stay that way. But it doesn’t seem like Adora has any plans on moving.

“You gonna fall asleep on me, Princess?”

Adora stiffens ever so slightly, “That okay?”

“Yeah, you need it.”

It feels...intimate to take Adora's hair down. It's unfair really the amount of emotion she feels. Gods, at least she has excuses. Adora makes a little confused noise where she's too tired, or maybe just doesn't care, to say anything. Catra rolls the band onto her wrist and starts running her fingers through golden hair. Adora's done this for her only twice but...it feels right to repay her. She hopes Adora's smiling but she can't tell. It feels nothing like her own mane, tangles falling apart under her claws easily.

It doesn't take all that long for Adora to fall asleep. And even though she said it, she's still not expecting it. If she didn't think it would wake her, she'd crush Adora to her chest. There's love alight in her veins in knowing that Adora, *Adora* feels safe enough with her to fall asleep in broad daylight.

It takes Catra a while to feel like this won't shatter if she moves, the whole time she's holding herself back from burying her face in soft hair. She wonders, if there were other hybrids here that could pick out scents like she does, would she give into the instinct to mark Adora as hers? It doesn't matter; Adora will smell like her after this anyway.

Eventually, she does move. As much as she loves this, wants this, *adores* this, she - they - can't still be like this when Adora wakes. She's already indulged too much. She can't give an answer if Adora asks why.

She knows Adora's fallen asleep in her clothes many times in her life, they both have. But it feels wrong now that they're *here*. So, with a sigh, she unclips Adora's belt and gently tugs off her jacket, purring all the while and hoping that it's enough to keep Adora asleep. With the way they've ended up, it's remarkably easy to lift Adora slightly and lay her on the bed. And after pulling off her boots, she lies down next to her, the purposeful distance between them makes her ache as much as the injuries.

The sleep she herself finds is light and would be restless if she felt she could actually move without breaking...whatever this is. So

she gives up. And tells herself it is fine for today if she just watches the woman she loves sleep.

Catra knows nothing about magic beyond how much it can hurt. But she's seen how tired Glimmer's been for a while now, so she supposes (hopes) that Adora's okay. She's been asleep hours now. And it's peaceful, thankfully. The most she moves is to turn onto her side towards her. (Which makes Catra panic for all of ten seconds since she has really just been lying awake beside her the whole time, before realising Adora's still asleep.)

And all the while she keeps up a gentle purr, sometimes inaudible but still there. She's just happy, selfishly happy. She has never purred this much in her life. And of all the things that have happened today, she thinks Adora would be glad to know that. Even if it hurt, just a little.

After the fourth moonset there's a gentle knock on her door. She climbs carefully off the bed, crushing down the urge to ignore the door and just stay with Adora for the rest of time. But she gets to the door, opens it to find Glimmer and Bow. They both move like they're going to hug her and she can't stop the way she quickly gets out of reach. Neither looks upset about it, thankfully.

"How are-" Bow starts.

She puts a finger to her lips and opens the door wider. And learns that Bow doesn't only use his 'big eyes' for her. She gets it - Adora is a special type of beautiful when she's peacefully asleep. Except neither of them can see her face from here, just her soldier's body completely tension-less the way Adora never is.

The archer takes the rest of the food from Glimmer and sets it down on the table as the Queen draws a rune into the spell line at the door. The wall goes back up and Catra tries not to let show that she didn't even realise that it wasn't there in the first place.

She takes a seat at the table and expects Bow or Glimmer to drag the armchair over, but Glimmer takes her seat in Bow's lap. She doesn't care, thinks they're dumb, but doesn't care. She still rolls her eyes at them.

She doesn't realise how thirsty she is until she tastes water again. She drinks two full glasses but can barely manage a couple of slices of meat before she feels sick. She hates the pity and concern they look at her with but it's not exactly like it's undeserving.

Her ears twitch back when Adora moves, and her heart melts when she hears a drowsy whispered, "Catra?"

She fights the desire to run to the bedside, "Over here, Princess."

Adora turns over, nearly falling off the bed and still blinking her eyes open. "Hi guys, what are you doing here?"

"We came to see how you were, obviously."

"Why didn't you wake me up?"

She just gives Adora a look that speaks of all the rough nights they've had together; sleep is a damn blessing at this point. And good sleep even more so. Adora sighs and spots her boots on the floor when she swings her legs over the bedside. She pulls them on, foregoing the jacket (and really Catra shouldn't smile at that but it means Adora *stays* looking as soft and sleep-ridden as she has been.)

"You know healing really takes it out of you."

Adora stumbles a little as she trudges over, rubbing the sleep from her eyes, and it kind of proves Bow's point. It's cute. And she wants to kiss her. So Catra covers it up with snark. "Ironically I think you need to keep your strength up."

Adora weakly shoves her shoulder when she's close enough before running a hand through her loose hair. "Do you know

where my hairband-" She pulls it off her wrist and holds it up, silently mourning the sight as Adora ties her hair back up, albeit messily.

Adora brings over the chair Glimmer ignored. Leaving an obvious space beside her that she wants to fill. She mouths, *'You okay?'* and Adora reaches a hand out. She climbs onto the seat next to her, smiling not purring when she feels the now-familiar sensation of a palm on her pulse. And she was right earlier, Adora does smell like her.

Glimmer and Bow are looking at them strangely but despite that, she doesn't feel the need to run. This...this is okay. With these people, it's okay. She's sure Bow would absolutely melt if she told him that. Glimmer might just say she's going soft, probably mock her a little.

"...So," Glimmer starts, "Did you guys talk about what happened?"

"Uh...no, actually. I still don't know what happened after I hit the ground."

Adora looks apprehensive at that, but she'll tell her. It's how she is. "Oh… uh, yeah, right I - well… I jumped after you -"

"- Because you're an idiot," she says just because she doesn't like how uncomfortable Adora looks. And it works. Adora lightly smacks the back of her head and Adora's lucky there are people here because otherwise she'd be shoved to the floor.

"Shut up I saved your life. Anyway...I woke up in some water in pitch black. I - a lot of things were broken."
She would interrupt again, demand Adora tell her where she hurts. She *knows* how she's feeling. There'll be time for that later, right now she'll let Adora talk. She needs it. She can tell with the blank way she's looking at her.
"There were - there were clones down there. It's the only reason I found you, they were all standing around you. I - I got to you and…" she can see Adora wanting to cry but she's probably too

dehydrated. Adora's hand grips her tighter and she curls her tail around her ankle. "Let's just say you were still breathing then. Prime said some things about getting the Heart, how that was the consequence for disobeying him, I don't really remember because, well, She-Ra. The magic just...took over."

"And then you got back to us?" Adora turns to Glimmer and nods. "She took down the entire rest of the bots by herself. It was incredible!"

"Incredibly stupid."

Adora doesn't even flinch. "You know as well as anyone how much She-Ra can do. Less than half a robot army is nothing."

She rolls her eyes, at least Adora's feeling better. She wouldn't be this cocksure if she weren't. "Alright hotshot, shut up and drink some fucking water."

It's long past nightfall when Glimmer and Bow stand, walking to the door to leave before Glimmer thinks better of it. She comes back and slings a gentle arm around Adora's shoulders, "Do you want to stay with us tonight?"

Adora had eventually let go of her, but she sees the twitch of her fingers and hopes she is right in assuming she wants the hold back. She almost purrs.

"No, I'd - I'll be alright on my own. Maybe tomorrow?"

"Sure thing," Bow says from the doorway.

Well she's certainly not going to be purring after that. She does not want Adora on her own. Not after the way she's been with her. Adora's not *touchy*, well not like she's been today, and as much as she craves everything Adora will give her, it makes her worry.
She wants to hold her again. Of course, *of course* she does. She's

hopelessly in love. But having this for miserable reasons can be just as painful as holding back for selfish ones.

Bow and Glimmer leave. And she thinks Adora's going to as well when she gets up. She watches Adora's back silently, forcing her body still and lips not to move. Adora sighs and spins around, looking guilty of all things. "When you...asked me to stay, did you mean…?"

At least some of that worry drains away, "You know you always can." Gods she hopes Adora can't see the flush she *knows* is there. She wonders how many times she'll have to tell Adora the same fucking thing before she believes her.

"Catra I've been with you every second since...y'know... If you want to be alone I'd understand."

She climbs out the chair, standing further than she's been from Adora since, like she said, since her fucking death. "Adora if I *don't* have a nightmare tonight it'll be a fucking miracle. I want you here. And besides, I know you're not alright-"

"Yeah no shit." It *still* makes her smile when Adora swears. Because she knows it's *for* her, she'd feel bad about it if it wasn't.

"Are you...feeling better?"

"Yeah. Sleep helped. Thanks for that."

She crosses her arms over her chest. "Not that different, really."

"No I - I guess it's not."

Once the silence hits the minute mark without either of them moving or speaking, she decides, "I'm going to shower."

Adora looks thankful for a way out, "That's, yeah I'll go do that too. Won't be long, okay?"

“Who knows, maybe I’ll be quicker than you for once.” She doubts it. Fur is literally the worst for that but shorter hair has considerably reduced the effort she has to put into it.

Adora laughs, “Yeah good luck with that.”

She shoves Adora’s arm to keep her smiling, “There’s so many fucking towels here that getting dry isn’t actually that bad.”

“Yeah, yeah, alright.”

Adora’s faster than her. Obviously. But she also has a feeling Adora was quicker than she’d normally be because her hair’s still obviously damp when Catra comes out the bathroom and finds Adora sitting on the bed with one of her books. Good to know they’re still competitive over stupid shit.

She turns the lights off, hears Adora huff in fake annoyance and makes her way through the moonlit darkness to close the curtains. Adora’s lying down, blind in the dark by the time she gets under the covers. She’s taken her hair out without prompting and she can’t help smiling.

“I get why you like it,” Adora whispers.

“What?”

Adora reaches for her in the dark, missing completely. She takes her hand but Adora brings it back, places her claws on top of her hair and, oh, that. Adora lets her go and Catra allows her hand to run one length of her hair before she curls back into herself. She brushes her tail along her leg instead. It feels safer.

Adora sighs, closing her eyes and sinking into the bedding. “Thank you, for saving Bow. I don’t think I ever said that.”

“You would’ve saved him if I hadn’t.”

“I guess, but you still did what you did.”

She hums, essentially dismissing the words, and turning onto her back. She tires to just let the tiredness she knows she’s feeling wash over her. It takes a few minutes in silence, lulled by another person's breathing, but it works. That wired but drowsy feeling she’s had gives way to familiar weariness.

“Sorry for being...clingy today. I know you’re still not great with people touching you and I - I feel like I ignored that,” Adora mumbles.

Catra opens her eyes but doesn’t turn, “I didn’t mind. You know you’re the only one I’m - you’re the exception ‘Dora.”

“Still?”

Gods does she have to sound so delighted by it? She’s probably grinning like a moron as well. She won’t look and check.
“Shouldn’t have said anything, should I? Don’t need to inflate your ego any more.”

“Hey! Let me have this.”

‘You have no idea how much I’d let you have if I didn’t think you’d break my heart all over again.’
It’s too late for thoughts like that.

“You’re gonna be real smug about that in the morning aren’t you.”

Out the corner of her eye, Adora’s definitely smiling, “Maybe.”

She’s closer to sleep the next time Adora talks, but not near enough that she’s angry about it. “Hey, Catra?”

“Hmm?”

“Can - can I do one last thing?”

She wants to ask why she sounds scared - no, not scared. Upset? She opens her eyes and looks at her, says, “Yes,” anyway. Adora’s hand crawls across the bed, trying to find her body in the dark. “Can you tell me?”

“I just want to make sure it’s gone.”

There’s a prick in her heart that means she’s laying Adora’s palm over the not-wound instantly. She doesn't think Adora’s ever touched her here and that’s probably why it makes her breath hitch. Adora swallows in the dark, fingertips spreading out over her skin and fur before she snatches her hand back. Adora murmurs a thanks into the arm she’s resting her head on.

She feels like she crossed a line. She doesn't know what line but...she doesn’t want to fall asleep with that being the last thing to happen between them. “You never did tell me what you broke in the fall.”

Adora grimaces just a little, “Sure you want to know?”

“That bad?”

Adora nods, “Both my legs. Maybe a crack in my hip, maybe even a couple of ribs. I don’t know. Everything just hurt. Doesn’t matter now does it?”

“Matters to me. If you’re allowed to blame yourself for what happened to me I’m allowed to do the same.”

“Yeah, but you shouldn’t.”

“And neither should you.”

Adora sighs, not looking at her and hiding in her arm. “Night Catra.”

She can worry if she said something wrong in the morning. “Night ‘Dora.”

Chapter End Notes

In case this wasn't clear: Catra doesn't remember the kiss and Adora thinks she's just not talking about it because a) Catra doesn't feel the same b) Catra's scared of losing her if she rejects her
I'm sorry? But it was either this or nothing I have a *plot* in place.

Also a random note from draft 1: [Catra gets out of her lap and Adora’s like babe no please]

Knowing (What You Don't)

Chapter Summary

Adora thinks it's time the barrier comes down

Chapter Notes

There is literally one mention of blood but warnings in case.

Catra

Catra does have a nightmare, like she said she would. She jolts up in the night, claws scrambling at her abdomen until she's sure the hole is gone. It hadn't been Prime who gave her the wound in her dream, but that doesn't really matter. She still feels it, the phantom of it.

Adora is awake beside her in an instant, arms curling gentle and firm and real around her waist when she nods that it's okay for her to. She kind of wants Adora's hands on the not-wound again but...it's just late and she's not thinking clearly through fading adrenaline.

She doesn't do anything but pause momentarily when Adora offers her embrace to sleep in. She curls into her side, head on Adora's stomach. Adora doesn't touch her, she guesses because she doesn't ask. Luckily she falls back to sleep before she can ask for hands in her hair.

Adora

It is so hard to leave Catra in the morning. But she does it. She gets dressed, gets their breakfast and eats it with her all before saying goodbye. She sees the way Catra's face subtly drops when she realises she's going to be alone and trapped in that room again. And she vows to herself then and there that she'll try and get her out.

Really the only reason it's taken this long is because the Alliance wasn't sure of Catra's allegiance. Now they can't question it. Not after what happened to her - not after knowing who she was saving.

Glimmer finds her almost immediately after she leaves. (The route to the training grounds *is* pretty much a sure bet for finding her if she's not already there.) "Where were you?"

Instead of answering, "Why? What's happened?"

"Alliance meeting in half an hour. Also Swift Wind arrived this morning."

She can't remember the last time she heard good news. "He did? Well that's good." He'll make She-Ra stronger, hopefully. Or at least make transforming easier. "Is Catra coming to this one?"

"No. Bow said he knows what the healing process is like and he knows Catra. She won't admit that she's exhausted."

Well that's true. She wonders if Glimmer hadn't caught her wandering around if she'd be excused as well. Probably not, considering people will be wanting to ask about She-Ra. She sighs, dread bubbling in her stomach at having to talk about what happened yesterday. There was a reason she wasn't telling them. She needs to get this fucking magic working *quickly*.

Swift Wind damn near tackles her when she reaches the gardens but she hugs him back anyway.

"Adora! She-Ra's back?"

"Uh, yeah she's - she's back."
She steps away from him, is barely able to read how tired he is through their bond but that's more than she ever usually feels. She doesn't know if it's stronger because of the proximity or because of the transformation yesterday, but she hasn't felt it like

this in a long time.
"Sort of. Is that why you're here?"

"You were in distress so I came to help." Distress might be an understatement but she doesn't know how well overwhelming grief translates. "And well, I figured I can do more for the war effort as She-Ra's steed than out there."

"What have you been doing out there, and *how* are you okay?" His white coat is flawless and if it isn't magic keeping it that way then...he's just been flying through a war zone that shouldn't be possible.

He doesn't know is the short answer. Swift Wind hasn't had any trouble aside from the tiny drones and they go down instantly with one blast of magic. She's not surprised that he's been ferrying refugees to safety - he brought in two with him when he landed this morning.

She warns him that She-Ra's been...difficult to get ahold of. She tries to transform right there in the courtyard, hoping that having him here might help. And it does a little. She can feel *something* and she's sure if she tries hard enough that she'll be able to drag it to the surface. But she doesn't have time. And he's too tired to bolster her strength as he usually does.

She says they'll get to training when they're both rested. He doesn't ask her why she's so tired and she doesn't want to explain. Swift Wind knows Catra's here, she told him the first time he came to visit during the short-lived peace time. But he still doesn't know, well, anything about them. And it'll stay that way as long as she has a say.

It's clear he can't pick out her feelings for Catra through the bond - he would've *definitely* said something otherwise. A saving grace.

She muses how Catra would feel about - how she would *act* around - Swift Wind if she were to ever meet him while she walks to the war room. Catra probably *will* meet him sooner or later. And

she'll probably despise him. At least at first. She truly doesn't know. And whether Swift Wind will like Catra? That's even funnier to try and imagine.

The atmosphere is much graver than she was expecting when she gets there. It's utterly silent. At least she's not the last one. Entrapta enters not long after, walking on her feet instead of hair. (That probably shouldn't alert her that something is wrong but it does.) She waits for someone to say something, but no one does. Maybe there's someone still missing? She looks across the table and realises she can't see someone.

"Where's Frosta?"

There's a lengthy silence then; "She got chipped," Bow tells her for lack of anyone else doing it. Clearly they all thought she knew.

"What? When?"

"Yesterday. When you were fighting," Entrapta states, utterly blank. It's far from how she was those first few weeks after learning of Hordak's passing but it's still clearly readable as a type of loss.

"Glimmer why didn't you tell me?"

"I didn't find out till this morning. After you and Catra left we all went to rest, Frosta never showed up to dinner and we assumed she was just still in bed. But that...was wrong. We should've checked to make sure everyone got back."

And there's guilt making her veins feel cold, because of course there is. Everyone that they lose is her fault, and she has a feeling everyone knows that. Before it was guilt because if something happened it was her fault She-Ra wasn't there. Now it's because she *is* and she still couldn't keep everyone safe.

'I wasn't anywhere near Frosta. I couldn't have seen what happened.'

'And that's the problem isn't it. You should've been there for her. And now Prime has a Princess. He has knowledge he wouldn't get elsewhere.'

"Is there anything we should be worried about Prime knowing?" Perfuma asks, mirroring her own worries.

"Does that mean he knows how the Heart works?" Scorpia has a point.

"Only a little bit better than he did before." And so does Mermista. But it's not enough to make her feel better.

Any knowledge is worse than none. And the Princesses are the only ones who know - well, who know that the Heart was what dragged them through the portal in the first place. At least this means Prime knows they weren't lying that he needs the Princesses alive.

Sea Hawk says, "I think we should be limiting excursions from the magic bubble from now on."

And she would agree except, "Well, She-Ra is back. She can - *I* can - probably handle it out there."

"Well that's good at least, right?" Perfuma says, clearly trying to bring the mood up a little. Not that it works.

"She's not - I don't know how reliable she is. She's...it's not like it used to be. I'll keep working at it. I know what she feels like now I'll figure it out."

No one asks her how long she's been lying to them. No one asks how long she's known. It only reduces her anxiety a little, annoyingly. (They could still ask. This doesn't mean that they won't.)

"I have an idea," Entrapta announces loudly.
She's all but bouncing on her hair which really means this idea might end in flames. ('*There's an 85% chance it's what other*

people would call dangerous,' Entrapta told her once.) Glimmer gives her the go ahead.
"If I could get a bot brought back in intact enough condition I could try and get a read of Prime's network through it. I could in theory deactivate the chips. *Or* I could hack the bot and get it close enough to a spire that I could access it that way!"

Scorpia puts a pincer on her arm to bring her down from where she's nearly at full height up on her hair above them. She does that when she gets excited.

"Better than doing nothing," Sea Hawk says with as much enthusiasm as it seems even he can muster.

It's quiet for a while, though not entirely. Glimmer and Bow talk with Entrapta about what she plans on doing. The rest of the table talks amongst themselves. And Adora sits silently, trying to gather the nerve to bring up what she told herself she'd do earlier.

Glimmer, at least, gives her that chance eventually. "Anyone have anything else they want to say?"

"Catra gets released. Permanently." She surprises herself saying it (blurting it out more accurately) but she can't bring herself to regret it. She's done it now, she'll see it through.

Everyone, unsurprisingly, turns to her sharply. The other conversations stop and fuck does she hate being under the spotlight like this. (Especially for this specific reason.)

"She's still a threat to us."

She doesn't like the way Mermista's staring her down. Figures that her assumption that no one could make an argument against the release was wrong. One good thing doesn't erase the bad, she knows that.

She forces herself to sit up taller. "She *died* for Bow yesterday, I think we know where her loyalties lie."

“They lie with you, not the Alliance.”

She never thought about it that way… But no. *No.* Mermista’s wrong, “She didn’t save Bow for me!”

She didn’t mean to stand but Mermista mirrors her, keeping their eyes level. “Didn't she?”

Right now she just - she can’t stand how *dismissive* of this she’s being. Catra's been imprisoned for months, she's done everything they've asked of her, she's *offered* to help, she's been *pilant* to their conditions. And it's *Catra*, she doesn't do pliant. Half of her understands that they just don't know Catra like she does, the other half of her doesn't care. She can hear her own heart pounding in her chest.

“*No*. I know she’s selfish - gods do I - but she’s a good person. I know that’s hard to believe after everything, but she is. You can hate her for Salineas, I’m not asking you to forgive her. I am asking you to trust that she cares about Bow, she cares about Glimmer, Scorpia, Entrapta. She would have done what she did for any of them.”

“And what about the rest of the Rebellion? What about them? Do you really think they’re safe from her?”

Maybe this is just stinging that much harsher because Frosta’s not here. It’s high emotions all around, she knows that. But despite knowing that, she doesn’t stop herself giving in and all but yelling;

“Yes! I am telling you that Catra is on our side! She could be long gone by now - and she’d survive out there, I know that, she knows that. She has been showing all of you that she trusts you and you don’t even realise! If she wanted to hurt any of you do you even understand how many chances she’s had to do just that?”

“Gods Adora we get it, you’re in love with her!”

She doesn’t mean to recoil.

There’s regret on Mermista’s face instantly but she can’t look at her anymore.

“I didn’t - I’m sorry I didn’t it know it was… I thought you two were...”

She swallows, hangs her head and grips onto the table’s edge hard enough that the crystal shatters. Gritting her teeth and letting the shards fall from her hands, she slowly replaces her hands flat on the top. There’s a dim reflection of blue light in the surface, the barest pulse of gold in her skin. She can feel eyes on her like a second clinging, suffocating skin. The hardness in her shoulders doesn’t soften like she wants it to when she looks back up.

“*Catra gets out*.”

Mermista’s sat back down. She looks guilty, though she’s trying to hide it. Sea Hawk’s hand is on her shoulder. “Adora you just...you don’t think clearly when it comes to her.”

Maybe she doesn’t. But then neither does Catra. It makes them even. And maybe now they’re on the same side it’s a glaring disadvantage but...she’s already gone this far.

“The barrier comes down. As your She-Ra I’m not asking. What are your conditions?”

She knows even Glimmer is surprised by her essentially pulling rank. She’s never even thought to do it but...it’s Catra. And Mermista, annoyingly, is right - she’s not thinking clearly. But she’s *right* about this. Catra deserves to be free.

“She’s guarded every hour of the day. And doesn’t leave her room without someone.”

“Alright. Anyone else?” It’s painfully silent. “Glimmer?”

Glimmer nods, but she can’t read how she actually feels about it. She lifts her hands from the table, seeing the barest amount of

blood there. When she turns her hands over, they're healed.

"You figure out the details. I'll go let the guards know."

She tells the guards their updated schedules and retreats to her room. She should go see Swift Wind but she won't, she hopes he's asleep so he won't have to feel how many emotions are rattling around in her head. She hadn't considered before that he'd been feeling everything alongside her and she's...kind of terrified of him figuring out what the usual cause is.

But apparently it doesn't matter. Because everyone knows. Even Catra knows, she must do what with kissing her and...everything else they did yesterday. Her breaths come easier as she runs through everything that happened yesterday *after* the kiss, and how Catra hadn't once pushed her away.

'Catra doesn't hate me. She just doesn't feel the same way.' And honestly that's more than she ever thought she'd get.

She wants to go to Catra and just sink into blank thoughts brought by her warmth. She thinks Catra would let her. But she'd have to tell her why and she can't do that, even if she does know. She'll go later, when she stops feeling like a hairpin trigger. After she trains like she's supposed to.

Just a couple more minutes she tells herself as she sits on her bed staring at, but not seeing, the floor. She hears Glimmer call her name outside her door. They don't wait for her to respond before her and Bow creep into her room. Probably a smart move, not waiting for an answer. She'd just lie more. Say she's fine over and over again.
Gods she lies to them so much, even just by proxy. She should've learnt her lesson better with Catra.

Thankfully they close the door behind them. And by the time they've sat down on either side of her she's ready to apologise for not doing anything, throat thick with everything she's *still* feeling.

Bow asks, “You okay?” and it makes her breaths come that much harder.

Might as well try to reassure them. “Yeah, yeah I’m fine. Why wouldn’t I be…”

“You’re not fine.” Glimmer doesn’t have to *say it*. It makes it harder to pretend that way.

“Doesn’t matter. I’m sorry for...y’know, all that. I shouldn’t have said what I did. And I shouldn’t be wasting time like this.”

“You were upset, you can have a breather.”

She doesn’t even know what to say to that. She’s had her breather. Now she needs to *do* something. Fucking anything that’ll mean she’s useful. She’s been selfish for the day - and the only reason she could do that was because it was *for* Catra.

They think Catra’s clouding her judgement and *fuck* this is why she never even told them they were *friends*. She’s made it obvious now. (Damn desperation.) She needs to prove them wrong; that she can be what they need her to be. She needs to fucking *be* She-Ra.

“We’ve got half an hour before lunch, want us to stay with you?” Bow tries.

“I know you’ve got things to do. *I’ve* got things to do.”

“Half an hour, that’s all Adora,” Glimmer says like it’ll persuade her that they can waste that long on her.

“No, really, you shouldn’t -”

“- Do I need to make it a royal decree?” She’s got her ‘Angella’ look.

“...No.” Only because she really can’t let anyone else down today.

“Well then.” Glimmer and Bow pull her rigid body back by the shoulders until she hits the mattress. Bow tugs her in against his side and Glimmer hugs her from behind. She relaxes without permission, too many (not enough) nights spent with Catra like this mean it’s natural now.
Nights neither of them know about because she hasn’t told them - hasn’t even told them how dreadfully she’s been sleeping for...well for her whole life. There's so much she hasn't told them.

Glimmer squeezes her tighter, “Want to talk about it?”

“No.”

“You know you can, right?”

“I know... I - I’m sorry for not telling you sooner.” Her voice breaks and she wants to hide.

“Can I ask why you didn’t? You don’t have to answer,” Glimmer says quickly into her shoulder blades.

She doesn’t have to answer, but she should. They should know how long she’s been hiding this from them. She stares at the wall, inhaling shakily, “Being in...*feeling* like that about the enemy, I just - I couldn’t -”

“- It’s been going on that long?”
Something drops in her stomach. She nods anyway.
“How long, Adora?” There’s a hardness in Glimmer’s voice that she knows is upset and she turns deeper into Bow’s arm. She feels like she’s let them down.

“My whole life. She’s always - I’ve never not…”

They both hug her tighter and she is so close to crying. Maybe they'd stop asking her about it if she did.

Bow asks quietly, “Were you together, before you left?”

She shakes her head, desperately trying not to think about what she would've done if they were. (Maybe nothing would've been different and that...that hurts *so much*.) "I didn't *know* not till I came here…"

She half waits for them to ask her if they're together now. If they'd questioned yesterday it might be understandable, but after today - after her *obvious* reaction - she doesn't really think she could stand it.

"I don't - can we not talk about this?"

She's sure they exchange a look over her head but she's not coming out from her hiding spot to find out.

They try to reassure her, "Whatever you want."
It doesn't work all that well.

She goes to see Catra after lunch. (She didn't speak a word during it and ate far from everyone else.) She's too drained to crush down the worry that's been building every moment she's away from her. *Worry* she's allowed to feel though so...

She should go train. She needs to go try and get She-Ra back. But instead she's fucking here; outside Catra's door and ignoring her lovesickness, pretending it's never been there in the first place.

Catra's on her bed when she opens the door. And she tries to play off how startled she is at being woken up like this and it's...it's really cute. She quickly dismisses the thought. Adora knew she'd be tired but she didn't think Catra would actually sleep during the day. Catra's ears flick back and slope softly when she realises it's her.
(And doesn't that make her feel so much better.)

"Hey Adora."

Catra

Adora walks in without knocking, and once she gets over being awakened so suddenly, realises that Adora's looking almost as tired and downtrodden as she did yesterday. It's the way strands are falling out her ponytail, it always gives her away.

"What's wrong?"

Adora looks up from the floor and there's just things about her that say that she might cry. It's not even that her eyes are red, it's in the roughness of her breathing, the way her eyes don't focus on anything too long, the way her shoulders curl in. She gets up after Adora stands there silent with her mouth open like she's trying to find what to say. She offers a hand and Adora takes it somewhat reluctantly.

"What do you need?"

"Nothing, I'm fine."

"You're not fine," she half snaps before she thinks better of it. That just makes Adora look worse and she takes her other hand in apology. "I - just talk."

She half expects Adora to move her palm to her pulse but she doesn't. "I'm going to meet Swift Wind for She-Ra training so I can't stay long."

"So…?" It comes out soft this time and the lines of tension in Adora's arms ease.

"Had an Alliance meeting. Thought you should know what happened." She tries not to panic as Adora hesitates, "Frosta got chipped. Entrapta's going to try and hack into Prime's network if we manage to get a bot and..." And Adora must remember something because she swallows trying to hide her increasingly ragged breathing.

She starts, "Adora -"

"- Can I hug you?"

She is genuinely shocked at the abrupt request (and that Adora's asking), but doesn't delay a second in wrapping her arms around Adora's waist. Adora doesn't cling like she did yesterday, this hold feels a lot less...scared.

"Is this about the meeting or...or is it yesterday..."

"No it's - today's just been a lot." Adora takes a deep breath, "I got them to agree to remove the spell, there'll be guards stationed, and you can't leave without an escort but…"

She pulls away slightly to look at Adora when she says, "Thank you." She needs to know how much she means it. "I know you've got to go but how about we go through the log? Just for a little while."

Adora nods, shoulders relaxing in a way that lets Catra know she's done something good. They sit at the table and she lets Adora just scan through the pages of records.

It's now that she thinks. Frosta's been taken by Prime - of course Adora's blaming herself for that. Then there's She-Ra and everything else that happened yesterday and well, she gets why Adora's needing the reassurance. She's heading for a burn out most probably. *If* she's not already there.

And there's only one way she's ever really known how to deal with them. "You know, if we were still in the Fright Zone, I'd take you somewhere high up -"

"- Our spot?" Adora's smiling with what looks like hope over the top of the worn leather book.

She nods, "Our spot."

Adora puts the book down and lays her hand on the open pages (and Catra really wants to take it again.) "We can do that tomorrow if we find time. I'll give you a proper tour of Brightmoon and we - we can find a new spot if you want. Somewhere above and away from…"

“Everything else.” She purrs even though Adora can’t really hear it. “I’d like that.”

Brightmoon Things

Chapter Summary

> Catra gets a tour of Brightmoon. Adora trains. Glimmer says thank you.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

Glimmer comes to her room before breakfast (before Adora) and it's weird. Micah's there too, standing outside the door and waving to her, which she returns. Glimmer holds a glass vial of neon yellow, and apparently they need 'so much' because of the duration and size of the spell. She could not care less, but she hums like she does. She just wants this over with. Not being encased in magic sounds fucking great.
But for all that, there's not much more to the spell dissolving than a bright light (that does *not* make her yelp quietly and cause Glimmer to snicker at her) and quiet fizzling.

"That's it?"

"Yep. You're a semi-free woman now."

Maybe she's still expecting magic to hurt.

She can hear the people outside her door properly now and she only hopes the walls and door are more soundproof when it's closed. (Otherwise she might actually *ask* if there's a soundproofing spell and she really does not want to do that.)

Micah leaves with another wave, which she returns, again. If this is all her relationship with him is going to be she's not hating it. She turns to the window, trying to get used to the pink light caused by the dome as opposed to the blue she's had for months.

She expects to hear Glimmer's footsteps retreating or the shimmer of her teleport. She is *not* expecting arms around her or *lips* on her cheek.

She's in mild shock for a moment before she's suppressing a growl in her throat. She's not actually angry, she doesn't think, it's just...unexpected. She has lived *a life* but not once has that ever happened to her. And it's come from *Glimmer* of all people. (She wonders if she's doing it because Adora did yesterday? Is that a Brightmoon thing she's unaware of?) Glimmer lets her go, smiling unsettlingly wide and practically hopping.

"Uh what was that?"

That energy dims a bit. "It was a kiss on the cheek?" she says it like she's worried she doesn't know.

"No, I know *that*. I - why?"

Glimmer puts a hand on her arm and really this is the most they've ever touched. "It's a way of saying thank you between close friends here. And it's for saving Bow. Because I didn't thank you for doing it sooner."

'A thank you, huh?' Then what the fuck was Adora thanking her for yesterday? For living?

She covers up her...whatever it is she's feeling, (mostly confusion) by muttering, "Yeah well, I wouldn't do it again that fucking hurt."

Glimmer's smile is too fucking sure, "You fucking would."

"Whatever you need to tell yourself, Sparkles."

Glimmer gives her another hug and teleports away too quickly for her to complain.

She does think about leaving before realising she fucking can't. There are guards for a reason. She could jump out the

window...and lose whatever tentative trust she's gained. She also considers talking to them before being mildly horrified with herself for thinking it. What has she become? Genuinely considering small talk with strangers for something to do.

She reads one of the books she's already read after updating the log *but* now she can sit on the balcony that's been taunting her for months. Not that she's doing it long before Adora's walking in with breakfast. It does take Adora a couple seconds to realise that she is indeed outside because the barrier is down finally.

"Sorry I would've been here if I thought they'd be doing it earlier. I'm surprised Glimmer's even awake at this hour. She *hates* mornings."

She rolls her eyes and tugs on Adora's ankle with her tail when she's close enough, encouraging her to sit down with her on her pile of cushions. Getting to eat outside, with an actual breeze blowing through her short hair, is pretty novel. Adora looks happier today too, tired, but better. Gods she hopes today is going to be a good day.

She's free, basically, it should be. Adora said rooftops and she has *missed* those. Really she knows the thing that might ruin her mood is other people. Which she...is going to have to be around if she leaves these walls. She will *deal* with people. She'll be polite, or at least fake it and keep her traitorous limbs under control long enough to get back here. Then she can hiss and growl all she wants.

"So, anywhere you want to take me?" she asks when they're done.

And doesn't that just make Adora beam. She reaches out a hand to pull her to standing. "I got a few ideas, yeah."

She tries her damn best to keep her fluster to a minimum when Adora drags her past the two guards still holding her hand.

Adora takes her to the kitchens. And she thinks she'd be more impressed by the size of it if she'd ever seen a proper kitchen before. The Horde just had a metal room with a counter for unboxing ration bars and she'd only ever seen it at night three times. That apparently wasn't an actual kitchen.
This is pristine cream tiled walls, it's bright, and there's a ton of people. Almost too many. And more than a few look at her with fear or disdain. One woman tries to subtly hide her child behind her legs and that - that *hurts*. She keeps her ears pinned to her head the rest of the time they're there.

They leave. After they steal a couple...somethings. Catra doesn't know what they are and technically they can just take them but still, it's been a while since she's done anything like this with *anyone*. And doing it with Adora rolling her eyes at her just makes it so, so worth it. She can almost forget that there are a number of Salineans who hold their breath when they see her.

Next is the castle library (or one of them? There might be more, she's not sure.) Again, she's never actually been in a library. And it's nice; quiet and the books smell good. And there's a distinct lack of people. There's a fire already glowing in the round fireplace with a young blue-skinned girl curled up in an armchair beside it.

Adora tells her you actually *have* to be quiet here and she silently promises to herself that she will be coming back here. She walks through rows of pale wood bookshelves, mindlessly tracing the spines with claws retracted. She keeps a hand on Adora's wrist the whole time, jokingly whispering that she doesn't want either of them getting lost. But she doesn't seem to need the excuse, Adora is perfectly content to let herself be pulled along after her.

She gets distracted by a couple things, books older than others, ones with well worn paper. She takes one down, flicks through and imagines sitting curled up in front of the fireplace. Unlike the girl earlier, she pictures Adora curled around her, head on her shoulder.
She puts the book back after that and walks away quickly.

After half an hour Adora says quietly in her ear, “Wanna find a rooftop?”

And if she couldn’t feel Adora’s breath on her face she’d respond verbally. As it is, she just nods and lets Adora lead her back through identical paths and out crystalline double doors.

Adora does not know how to get to Brightmoon's roofs. Which really just leads them on a tour of Brightmoon’s balconies. Eventually they find one that’s close enough to an outcrop in the mountain that they can pull themselves onto the tiny lip and climb up the roof that way. Adora complains about the curves not giving her any hand holds like metal pipes used to, so she carves some into the stone, assuming no one else will ever find them. (Though imagining Glimmer yelling at her for scratching up her castle does have her snickering to herself.)

It’s a shorter climb than it was to their old spot but a lot of it is just them walking over rooftops together trying to find a better lookout point. This climb at least is easier for Adora past the initial curve. They don’t dangle their feet over hundred foot drops or lean against railings here, just sitting on cream stone with their legs splayed out in front. Catra’s sure this view is normally beautiful, and it still is, but the pink dome, the warships in the sky and the spires do ruin it. As do the clones surrounding the Kingdom like ring rot below.

She looks at Adora - studies her more accurately - cataloging all the ways she looks different than in her memories. She’s got a sharper jawline now, all the baby fat her body was clinging onto is gone. Adora looks more tired, really it’s a depressing comparison to make, but it’s true. She knows she looks the same; she may be getting accustomed to Brightmoon niceties but she’s still essentially ragged. She’ll never look like the people here.

She didn’t see Brightmoon during peacetime but when this is all over - *if* they win - she might. And somehow she...she just feels

like they'll remain out of place here. Out of place together at least. Dark colours and scars don't exactly fit here, even though the people have been on the other side of the same battles.

The Rebellion don't think the way she does, she's realised. All their battles haven't been personal, never one-on-one. Their spur of the moment ideas, impulsive natures, are fine for large scale fights. They have the power and numbers to be able to do it. But that doesn't work when you're on your own. You have to be smarter, not stronger.

"Do you really think we can win?" She doesn't really know what prompts her to actually ask. She's not lashing out because of the bitter thoughts prowling around her head. She's just...contemplating. And she wants to know what Adora thinks too.

Adora smiles at her weakly before it drops and she turns back to the polluted sky. "I have to."

She breathes through the anger the words cause like a reflex. There is the quietest growl in her throat and it makes Adora look...guilty. Always guilty. "You don't. Not with me anyway."

'You've never had to pretend with me.' Even thought she always did. Still does.

Adora sighs, brings her knees into her chest and rests her chin on them. "Catra I - I don't know… But if I don't believe who will?" Annoyingly that's a good point. Burdens of being a leader. She brushes her tail up Adora's arm, smiling sadly when Adora twines it around one of her hands.
"...They're worrying about me, Catra."

That shouldn't make her heart feel like it's breaking and spilling over at the same time. She knows what that means. She knows how much Adora's despising the situation she's in now. The one thing she doesn't want is the thing she has. She wasn't there at

the meeting yesterday, she kind of wishes she was, just so she would know what they said about She-Ra.

She doesn't want Adora to be the hero. Never has, and she's not been subtle in that. She even got sick of Adora being *her* hero. She shouldn't have; should've been grateful. She should've realised the shadow-made world sitting on her best friend's shoulders.
She puts a hand there like she can take the weight. She wishes she could. (There's a lot of things she wishes she could do.)

"They're allowed to worry about you."
She'd curse the way her voice is too tender if it didn't make Adora's whole body soften. But she doesn't look at her, and - and she needs Adora to listen to her right now. She needs to hear this because no one else is going to tell her. She gets a finger under Adora's chin, slowly tilts it towards her until blue eyes, half-violet under the magic, meet hers again.
"*I'm* allowed to worry about you."

Adora flits her eyes away again and drops her tail, and she pretends it doesn't hurt. She can't help feeling like she's gone too far. "Why do I feel like this isn't going to be the last time you try to convince me of that?"

She lets her hand drop from Adora's jaw before she does something stupid, knocking their foreheads together gently instead. It's strange how this feels safer. "Because you keep not learning it, idiot."

Adora sighs and turns away, legs landing flat in front of her again. "Catra, it's always been like this."

"I know, but just don't...don't be like that with me. I can't - I can't watch you hurt yourself like that."

It doesn't feel like chewing glass to admit that but she still doesn't like it. She'll do this for her, Adora deserves to know she cares about her. Which...Adora seems surprised at. The sentiment or

the fact she's actually voicing it, she doesn't know. Adora's face half-crumbles, and she deliberates with herself before shuffling closer and resting her head on Catra's shoulder.

"I can't promise that, Catra."

"Can you at least - can you *try*?"

It doesn't sound the way she wants it to. And she knows that after everything she shouldn't be asking Adora for anything. But she's still selfish, and if her being selfish can somehow help instead of ruin them…
Adora nods shyly against her shoulder. She wants to pull Adora into her, maybe lie down with her and stare at the stars beyond the warships.

"I should get to training. Swift Wind might come looking for us. Well...me."

She knows Adora has to go. But she can stall. She's not ashamed to admit she likes it up here with her, wants to spend more time with her. "What is the deal with that?"

"With what?"

"A magic rainbow horse? I don't get it."

Adora huffs, "It's a magic bond *thing*, I don't know why he got transformed. I don't know why he's in tune with my emotions or whatever. And other She-Ra's had *steeds* as well it's not just me."

She is ignoring the emotions thing because she does *not* want to know. "Oh a magical, soul-bonded *steed*. My bad, how majestic." Adora shoves her hard enough to jolt her whole body. "Hey, you want me to fall off the roof?"

"Oh please, you know you'd survive… Hey, there is still one place you haven't seen."

“Only one?” Adora kicks her this time so at least she’s switching it up.

“No, but I didn’t show you my room.”

It’s adorable how nervous she sounds, cute that Adora wants her to like her room. And oh gods Adora’s room. She’s not sure why that makes anxiety spike in her chest but it does. “Do you...want to show me your room?”

“Yeah?”

“Don’t sound too sure about that.”

“Well I am,” and as if to prove it Adora stands, and just like earlier, she holds a hand out to pull her up too. She takes it, secretly hoping Adora won’t let her go even though she *knows* she will. “*Then* I’ll train. Come on.”

Adora’s room is about as impersonal as their barracks were. It’s kind of sad. Sure, there’s her clothes in her wardrobe (literally just copies of the same outfit as she had joked months ago), her things (mostly hairbands) on the dresser. But it still looks like everywhere else in Brightmoon, even if nowhere else smells this much like Adora.

There’s a waterfall on the balcony which...she doesn’t even want to ask why. The reason is probably just ‘Brightmoon things’. It’s darker than her room thanks to more furniture and the strange curtain around the bed. She likes it.

Adora is watching her so intensely it makes her tail fluff up. (She kind of never wants it to stop. She kind of wants it to be for a different reason.)

Adora

She hasn’t been able to take her eyes off Catra just *existing* in her room. It is surreal, seeing what she’s imagined so many times. It’s

simultaneously out of place and entirely perfect.

Catra turns slowly and she tries not to let her eyes linger, “Your bathroom the same as mine?”

“Pretty much,” she manages to say steadily.

Catra still looks at it, probably confused by the bathtub since she doesn’t have one. And hasn’t ever been in one. But Catra’s proud and doesn’t question it at all like she did after she defected. She comes back and sits on the bed, tail waving calmly in a show that she’s comfortable. She looks more comfortable than Adora feels actually (though it may just be an act), Catra's not the one awkwardly standing in the middle of the room staring at her.

It makes her feel so much better - that Catra’s happy in her room - and yet she still asks, “What do you think?”

“Why do you want my opinion?”

She can’t very well tell Catra that she wants her to be here with her every night, that she kind of wants to share the room like they used to. Except it’s just *theirs* and they can stay up as late as they want every night, giggling and doing stupid shit so…

“I don’t know. I don’t want you to hate it here.”

“I don’t hate it.” Catra looks at the bed she’s sitting on, her claws prick in the bedding and her whole body stiffens. “You know...”

“What?” She probably shouldn’t be this excited to hear the answer.

Maybe she should have kept it more hidden because Catra thinks better of whatever she was going to say and doesn’t look at her as she exits the room and jumps up on the balcony railing. It doesn’t really seem like Catra’s asking for space, so she’s helpless but to follow. She stays in the doorway, though, far too happy to just look at Catra and not the spires in the distance.

Catra turns after a minute, grinning with so much easy confidence that Adora doubts whether it's fake. It is, she knows it is, but it's probably not meant to make her forget the question she didn't get an answer to. She's just lucky she's not staring at her dumbstruck (she almost is but decidedly not yet) when Catra jumps down.

Catra crosses her arms and cocks her hip in that infuriatingly attractive way she does. Why does she always have to look so good with the sky as a backdrop? She wants to kiss her or maybe just look at her forever. She's lost count of how many times today she's had to remind herself that Catra is pointedly pretending the kiss did not happen and that she should *do the same damn thing*.

"It doesn't always have to be *my* bed, 'Dora."

It takes her a moment to catch up. And not just because of the nickname she's only ever heard in the dark. They sleep next to each other all the time, Catra saying she wants to continue that but in her room should not make her heart leap. "Oh."

Realistically they'll probably still end up in Catra's bed, what with the whole 'escort' thing. But the sentiment is so sweet she wants - well, she knows what she wants. And she panics, blurting, "I should - I should go do She-Ra things with Swift Wind."

Catra snickers at her a little (which is fair), "Can I join you?"

She has been borderline-to-actually excited all day; getting to show Catra Brightmoon, the rooftop, her room. It is stronger than all that right now. Even the idea of (potentially) training with Catra again has her bouncing on her toes and dragging Catra down hallways. She'd be embarrassed about it if Catra's laugh weren't chiming in her ears.

She is being heavily judged by her own damn soul-bonded horse and it is *weird*. He was ready to go when she got to the training grounds, had cleared it of dummies for her. And there was just pure confusion when he saw Catra.

"Uh, Adora? Do you know the Horde Commander is behind you?"

"Haven't been with the Horde in months, Feathers."

"She wanted to come. And I want her here. She might help."

She had begged with her eyes for him to not ask questions and he complied, thankfully. Subtlety is and never will be Swift Wind's specialty but she wishes it was. She had dragged Catra over to the side of the field, knowing she was just inviting more questions later. But now they're here and Catra is also looking at her in that wicked way that makes her a little nervous amongst...other things.

"Why do I have the feeling he has no idea about me?"

"It never came up! I guess I just kind of assume he knows what I do. I mean I am so glad he's not in my head but it would make this so much easier. He's not exactly been your biggest fan since y'know *war*."

"He can't hate me more than Mermista."

Well she supposes that's true. "I would say try not to provoke him since he has hooves and you have bare feet but -"

"- But I'm probably gonna." And she's still grinning with fangs and she really has to go back to the middle of the open field *right now*.

"It's not working like it used to." Really she's only been at this for a couple of minutes but having Catra and Swift Wind here just watching is making her antsy.

"Well duh. How many days have you been trying exactly like this?"

"A couple…" At least the way Catra's looking at her now makes her annoyed and not flustered.

Swift Wind knocks her shoulder with his head, “Adora, hold my horn.”

She does, for lacking of ideas more than anything else, ignoring Catra’s unhidden snickering. (“You look dumb.” “Shut up.” “Are you sure you want her here?”) There is light at her fingertips, gold flirting over her limbs but not sinking in and transforming. She opens her eyes just enough to see Catra watching them with concern. Catra must catch her because she tries to smile for her and...and there’s something.

“I think,” she opens her eyes to look at Catra properly, “I think I’ve got her.” She wants Catra to hold her hand, she thinks it might help, weirdly. But she doesn’t. She searches through the things in her head and body, finds the burning from two days ago.

And it’s not exactly unique - the feeling that is. It feels like...she doesn’t even know. Almost like how Catra makes her feel those times when it near overwhelms her. It’s a feeling she usually pushes down. Which...makes a lot of sense actually.
But she can’t think about that right now. Can't let herself spiral as she undoubtedly will. She latches on. She feels a buzz in her hand from Swift Wind and the white intensity rushing through her limbs.

She’s taller than Swift Wind now, (and she’s always taller than Catra.) She steps away from him, rolling her shoulders. It’s strange to be back in this body without a fight nearby, without being scared. The sword isn’t in her hand and until she calls it - at least that part is easier now when she’s already transformed.

“Well, you did it.”

She snaps her eyes to Catra at the strain in her words. She’s expecting her ears to be down (they are) because of She-Ra. She knows Catra doesn’t like her but...this isn’t that. She doesn’t know what this is, actually. Well, she does, but not in regards to *Catra*.

The wide eyes, the blush she's - she doesn't think she's ever seen *this* on Catra. No - *no* they're best friends she must've seen this before. It's because it's never been directed at her that it's alien. Catra's never - unless this isn't what she thinks it is. Unless this is Catra reacting to She-Ra again after so long without her. Unless she's making this up, unless it's because of what happened two days ago. Unless, unless, unless...

She feels utterly lost. She doesn't know what to do when Catra tears her eyes away, tail flicking wildly. She doesn't even know what it means because she can't fucking trust herself not to *make* it mean more than it does.

"Uh, yeah. I did. Now I've just got to figure how to do it on command."

Catra nods slowly, eyes not on her face. It's now that she actually looks down at herself, apparently not having realised that she's got a new outfit. It's not like it was exactly forefront in her mind last time. It feels better. Not exactly surprising since the magic feels more...right without the sword. No tiara that she always silently thought was as stupid as Catra said that time she mocked her for it. She *is* kind of surprised Catra's not teasing her about the ponytail though. (Maybe she will later.)

She kind of wants to ask if Catra likes She-Ra now - really something she could never have imagined asking Catra *ever*. She needs to stop thinking about Catra's eyes on her. At least the electricity she's feeling is dimmed by her insecurity.

"Did I help?"

There are few times she's felt more grateful for Swift Wind. "Yeah Swifty, you helped."

That snaps Catra out of it a little - an eyebrow raising at the 'Swifty' she's sure. But she keeps her question devoid of mocking, "Do you know what brought her back? The first time, I mean."

She shrugs, "You needed me. I just did it. I don't know how."

There is softness for a fraction of a second before Catra covers it up like always, “I don’t exactly want to have to die every time you need She-Ra.”

That makes something sting. “Not helping.”

Swift Wind asks, “What about this time?”

“I don’t know. It was just a feeling. I think I just need to be able to recognise her. And...be able to do it in battle.” Gold floats away from her as she shifts back into her body, none of the flaring dramatics of last time.

Catra’s tail snaps behind her once. “Maybe we should just fight again.”

“I can’t tell if you’re joking or not.”

“I’m serious. Well, call it ‘training’ if you wanna be all *you* about it.”

“What do you mean *‘all me’* about it?”

Catra scoffs, which really just means she doesn’t have an actual answer, “Shut up, Princess. Just fight me.”

And she is about to do just that (well, tackle Catra to the ground just to hear her laugh), when Swift Wind’s wings flap and draw her attention. “I want to help.”

She turns and holds his face in her hands, having to look up at him now, “You help just by being here. I know you’re still tired.” He huffs, glaring at Catra. “I can handle her. She won’t hurt me.”

Catra all but purrs, “You sure about that?”

“*Yes*.” She turns back to her horse, wholly prepared for any number of reactions when she says, “We’re friends. It’s okay.”

He’s suspicious and confused, rightfully so. But he takes her at her word, trotting to the side of the field and settling down in the grass.

Catra pounces before she’s ready, swinging around her shoulders until she’s basically just clinging to her back. She suddenly remembers being twelve and carrying Catra around Fright Zone hallways on her back like this for no reason. “That was *slow*, Adora. I mean really.”
Catra had spoken with the same playful jeer back then too.

She knocks a shoulder back to throw Catra off, and reaches the other arm back to drag her to the floor. “And you were being nice.”

“Just being *fair*,” she says, smirk in her words despite the fact she’s lying on the ground after Adora put her there.

It’s at times like these when she wishes she never kissed Catra in the first place, more so than other times. It is infuriating and mildly heartbreaking that she *knows* what it’s like now. As painful the memory is - maybe because of it - she can remember with startling accuracy how soft Catra’s lips actually are.
If she did it again it wouldn’t happen the way the same way, she knows. Catra would lash out or just reject her outright if she were to be understanding about it. But Catra’s not exactly the most *understanding* person. (And she loves her anyway.) It makes her heart hurt enough for her to make herself stop thinking about it.

“When have you ever been *fair*?” It comes out teasingly enough. Catra just grins wider.

(‘*The way you’re looking at me right now is* far *from fair.*’)

Catra curls forward quick as a whip, taking her legs out and sending her sprawling before she can get an arm under herself. Catra crawls over her and she flips them before Catra’s able to look down at her directly with her unbelievably pretty eyes. Except now she’s looking *up* at her directly and it’s not really any better

since she's still got a light stain of red under her fur. Catra's also got grass in her hair and really all she wants to do is run her hands through it.
All she *wants to and should do* is stop thinking about her best friend this way.

She springs back up to standing awkwardly. Catra following but not attacking again. A reset.

"You have to actually try to be She-Ra."

"I know that." She completely forgot that's what she's meant to be doing.

Catra snaps her claws out halfway and she probably shouldn't be excited about that. "Maybe you need some incentive."

Gods she hopes Swift Wind can't feel the way she thrills since there's not exactly She-Ra to blame it on. It has been far too long since they've done this. (A few weeks but still.)

She's ready the next time, throwing a punch that she knows Catra will dodge easily. Claws brush along her side without even enough tension to slice the fabric. For all her talk, Catra's still being *nice*. And annoyingly enough she feels a pulse in her chest. Maybe it's She-Ra, maybe it's just her own damn feelings. She runs at Catra anyway.

And Catra dodges. And she's as mesmerising as always. Spinning away from non-landing hits with a smirk no matter how close she was to getting caught. After three dodges and two blocks, Catra jumps at her. She sees it coming, as she's probably meant to, and grabs Catra's waist, catching her and tackling her to the ground again. Catra lets out a hiss from the force and she quickly takes her hands back in case there's a rock or something underneath her.

It's a ruse, or maybe just convenient, because Catra's clawing at her shoulders and flipping her over. She kind of wishes she did hit a rock or something, anything to distract from Catra's hands on

her shoulders. The edges of claws on each of her thumbs press against the tendons in her neck and between that and Catra's warmth sinking into her skin she can't breathe. Catra's not even got her hands trapped and yet she's immobilised by her weight on her thighs and blades on her throat. She can't think, let alone focus enough for She-Ra.

"It's not working, all I can think about is you."

She is going to regret saying that later. Or maybe she won't because Catra purrs, all smug glee, and she's glad she can't feel it as well as hear it. She is already feeling far too many things she shouldn't. She is already *wanting* too many things she shouldn't. (She can't even think about the dull confusion Swift Wind is sending through the bond.)

But isn't that what she thought before? And isn't that - shouldn't she be able to find She-Ra in here anyway? She takes a deep breath to try and just *think*, but that makes the blunter edges of claws scrape gently against the column of her throat and all hope of that dies.

The purr stutters out, "Adora?"

She reaches up to grab Catra's wrists and lift them off her, using the leverage to switch them over. She traps Catra's hands between hers and the ground and moves so she's not between her legs because she really - she just can't be there. Not that straddling Catra is really any better for rational thought but...

Catra's not exactly looking at her like she's worried, she's not pushing back like she has been either. Somehow she knows she's working through something in her head. And of all things that shouldn't make her feel soft, but rarely is Catra patient when she doesn't have to be.

There's that feeling again, she thinks. She doesn't give Catra any warning before she's pulling on it, the light following. She hopes she's getting better at this. She sits up before the light fades, not

wanting to accidentally crush Catra. Still, Catra scrambles out from under her immediately. She still doesn't know about earlier, but this is definitely distress.

“Sorry, I just felt her and latched on.”

“No, it’s fine, that was the whole point. I just wasn’t expecting it to work.”

Catra swallows and she succeeds in not watching the movement in her throat. She doesn’t succeed so well in ignoring the way Catra rolls her neck and stretches her arms, that relaxed alertness washing back over her as she stands. It's not that often that she has to look up at Catra, though when they were on opposite sides it seemed like she'd do everything in her power to make it so. She much prefers it this way. The Catra looking down at her now is devoid of rage, just smirking as She-Ra sits back on her knees.

She's smug with being taller, even if it's not by all that much, all fang points and shining eyes when Catra all but purrs, “Ready to go again?”

She almost chokes.

She manages to transform twice more before it exhausts her too much. If she weren’t already flushed from exertion, she knows she would be from Catra jokingly telling her, *“Good work, soldier.”* She doesn’t even know why.

They walk Swift Wind back to his not-a-stable (she knows he insists it’s not but she’s not sure what else it could possibly be. Unless other stables don’t have a bed? She’s never actually seen one.) Then go find an incredibly late lunch together; Catra’s first meal in the communal dining room. She’s surprised Catra wants to stay until she realises it’s not actually all that different from the Fright Zone. They find a far corner and huddle together. They couldn’t do that in the Fright Zone, what with the seats bolted to the tables.

She’s prepared to defend Catra from anyone who so much as approaches them. (Sadly, also not that different.) But she can’t stop the dirty looks or comments. Catra doesn’t seem to mind too much, the only thing giving her away is the sway of her tail, just a little too restless for her to actually be comfortable. She puts a hand on Catra’s knee to ease her, thinking it’s subtle enough for being around people. Catra doesn’t agree, her body jolting with the contact before she brushes it off.

“I’m fine. Just a lot of people today. And...She-Ra.”

“Do you want to be alone?”

Catra nods, ears down, “I think so.”

“You’ve got the trackerpad if you want that to change.”

Catra has a nightmare. And it is one of the most heartbreaking and terrifying things she’s ever experienced having a guard knock on her door in the middle of the night telling her that ‘the prisoner’ just woke up screaming her name. She grabs a robe and her trackerpad, not even bothering with shoes before she’s near running to Catra’s room. (The other guard doesn’t look even remotely surprised to see her, even with the helmet.)

She should probably knock, she doesn’t. At least she can understand through her panic that bursting into Catra’s room after a nightmare is a bad idea. She opens the door slowly, keeping the light that enters minimal before she swiftly closes it again. It is already enough to have a hiss crackling through the silence.

“It’s just me, you’re alright.”

“Adora?” It’s a little broken - scared - but not in the way it is when Catra’s been crying.

“Yeah Cat, it’s just me. You gonna help me out? I can’t see anything.”

It’s quiet, only pierced by rough breathing for a few seconds before there’s fabric shuffling and then a hand around her wrist. She stumbles sitting down on the bed and shuffles her trackerpad under the frame in case anyone needs to contact her.

Just as she’s slipping the robe off her shoulders and crawling under the covers, Catra asks, “How did you know?”

She settles next to her, blankets across both their laps. She doesn’t look at Catra when she answers; Catra’s not going to like it. “Guard um, came to my room, told me they heard you...shout my name. Said you sounded really scared…”

As expected, Catra growls at that, “Remind me to ask Sparkles if she can soundproof this room.”

Catra’s tail arcs across the bed behind her, almost knocking the pillow off when she doesn’t respond. All she can see is Catra’s blue eye, and the fact that it’s glaring at the bedsheets. She knows Catra’s uncomfortable? Angry? About it happening, but she still has to know.

“Does that...happen often?”

Catra bites out, “No. She-Ra she um...do you remember what you did when I infected you with the virus at the Northern Reach?”

She does not. And doesn’t that just make her stomach sink. Glimmer and Bow, even Sea Hawk never told her what happened when she was infected. Apparently because they didn’t see most of it. They certainly never mentioned anything about She-Ra.

“No, just red and then blurs and then walking back to the boat. Was it bad?”

She thinks Catra nods before remembering she can’t see anything but her eyes in the dark. “Think that was the first time I realised if you wanted me dead I would be.” Adora’s torn between knowing how she hurt her and never wanting to hear it. It must show on her face, because Catra’s tail curls over her legs. “You didn’t hurt

me too bad, just...scared me. It wasn't you. And that was my fault."

She reaches a hand out then remembers Catra's reaction earlier. Even though they're alone and it's been a couple of hours, she shrinks back. Though Catra doesn't let her get far, taking her hand with claws initially before they're retracted.

Despite that, she still asks, "Do you want me to leave? I'd understand -"

"- No."

Catra grabs her shoulder and pushes her down, curling into her immediately. She can't help laughing quietly in relief at Catra burying into her neck, especially when she hisses about it while throwing an arm over her. So much for no one knowing they spend nights together. At least they don't know about *this*.

She gives in because Catra has, hands resting on the bare skin of her back. She runs her fingers between Catra's shoulder blades and makes a quiet questioning noise. Catra hums, pressing her nose to her skin for a second in confirmation. She lies there just petting Catra's back until she completely relaxes on top of her. But she doesn't stop, not until the reasons why she wants to do this poke at her conscious.

"You called me something earlier," Catra mumbles when she stops, "'Cat' was it? Really?"

She feels her face heat up, she knows it's a dumb name but she kind of likes it. "Shut up, like 'Dora' is any more imaginative."

Catra snuffles into her neck (it's ridiculously cute and she wants to kiss her ears like she's never done before) and starts purring inaudibly. "Does anyone else call you that?"

She trails too-soft fingers over the dull ridges of Catra's spine. "No, just you."

“Then you can’t say shit... You know if anyone else called me that they should invest in avoiding me for *a while*.”

She hums a smug noise instead of laughing like she would another time. “I don’t believe you, *Wildcat*.”

And even though Catra’s draped over her, clearly happy, she presses claws into her side. She quietly exclaims, “Hey!” to cover up the way her breath hitches. She might take the growled, “Careful ‘Dora,” seriously if Catra weren’t still purring. (And if she hadn’t used the name.)

She squeezes Catra tighter before relaxing into the sheets enough to sleep. And she is ready to do so, minutes passing in a rumbling silence. The purr cuts out though, not stuttering like it does when Catra falls asleep. She thinks about moving to see if anything's wrong but Catra shifts first. The breath on her neck leaves, the next second it appears on her cheek, lips following. And she just about shuts down.
She’s suddenly never been more awake.

Catra doesn’t pull back and she silently wishes to see the glow of her eyes more than anything, even if she can’t read anything off them in the dark. Unfairly soft lips brush against her cheek when Catra whispers, “Glimmer said it’s a way of saying thank you here.”

She holds Catra tighter in case she thinks she's reacting to this badly. She's not - she's fucking elated - but also half-paralyzed. Catra curls her head back down and she manages to have *thought* again. The kiss makes some sense at least with the context. It also means Glimmer kissed Catra which she never could’ve seen coming in a million years. But also Catra just kissed her so she can’t really comprehend a lot right now.

She stutters out, “Uh, yeah I guess it can be. If you - yeah, people do that here. What - what are you thanking me for?”

“A lot of things… Being here. Putting up with me. Getting me out. Whatever you want.”
She knows Catra can hear the way her heart's pounding, she half wonders what she’s thinking. If she even thinks it’s strange at all. She breathes, just breathes for a while until;
“You never kissed me,” Catra says it like a tease. Like they *haven’t*. It does nothing to ease her heart rate. It's confirmation, essentially. It's nice to *know* that they're (still) pretending two days ago didn't happen the way it did.

So she'll pretend. “It’s not really something I do. Why, you wanna be the exception?” She tries the tone out for herself, glad when Catra just huffs a laugh into her clavicle.

“If you want.”

She stares at the ceiling speechless as Catra falls asleep in her arms.

Chapter End Notes

> The room is actually pretty sound proof, the guard can only hear loud noises.
>
> My Tumblr because I keep forgetting to put it in
> (Mental health's being a little bitch right now so updates might take longer sorry.)

Moving (In)

Chapter Summary

Catra doesn't exactly have a *great* day...

Chapter Notes

Listened to Show Me Love by t.A.T.u. a lot while writing this. Don't know if it affected it but the vibe is great, especially for the last bit :)
I learnt how to work spotify to be able to make a playlist for this so anyway here

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

It's been two days since she put a little too much of herself out on the line with Adora. She knows she's been off ever since. She just hopes Adora doesn't understand why. 'Because I said you can kiss me and you haven't' is a truly pitiful reason for her to be as standoffish as she's been. (She is *not* sulking.)

There have been so many fucking reasons why she never *said* anything about how she feels. And this is one of them. She knows Adora doesn't feel the same, but this is practically a rejection. And it's so much worse because that miserable little truth is thrown in her face every time she so much as looks at Adora now. It doesn't help that it's making Adora hesitant to touch her *even though* every time she does she leans into it near-immediately. *Even though* they shared a bed - her bed, still only her bed - last night.

She had let Adora cling to her shirt so tightly she thought it was going to rip. Adora's shaking wasn't exactly helped by her having to pass the guards to get to her room, apparently she had managed to keep it together until the door closed. Which...did not help Catra's own feelings in any way; she's still one of only three people who have ever seen Adora like that.

She knows she’s the only person Adora ever admits to that she’s still scared of Shadow Weaver. Because she is too. And horribly enough, they don’t *just* hate her. Because that would be too easy. Adora apologises for not saving her, and she tells her it shouldn't have been her job in the first place. Because she’s learnt by now that saying she did the best she could makes everything worse.

Adora still doesn’t ask for comfort once her body and mind calm down, and she'd be a hypocrite if she were angry about that. Adora had just turned away and laid down. And she had stayed awake sitting beside her, watched as tension slipped back into Adora’s shoulders before giving in and curling around her. Really the only thing that allows her to do it is the relieved sigh Adora tries to stifle, forgetting that she’ll hear it no matter what with her senses.

She doesn’t know if Adora’s other friends have ever done this for her. But she thinks - she hopes - she’s the only one who ever wakes up holding her.

Adora still eats breakfast with her after she goes back to her room to get her clothes in the morning. Part of her wants to offer for Adora to keep some in her room but she’s...she doesn’t want Adora saying no again. To anything. She feels breakable and she hates it.

“Perfuma’s called an Alliance meeting.”

“She want me there?”

“Didn’t say, but come with me anyway?” Adora holds a hand out across the table and she feels pathetic waiting a few seconds to stop herself clinging when she takes it.

She does not miss Frosta’s glare over her shoulder. She doesn’t miss her at all. She didn’t know her. But she was still just a kid caught up in a war, and she’s not so heartless as to not understand the loss. She can feel the absence of her presence like

a dark cloud - can see it on everyone else's faces when they look at her.

The meeting is reflecting on castle numbers. It's been months for the people sleeping on bedrolls and Perfuma's come to the conclusion that as many rooms as they can muster should be given to the largest refugee families. "At first we're just going to pair everyone we can up. We'll condense more if we have to."

And she knows Adora said it was Perfuma's meeting, but she's still surprised when she actually addresses the room, especially that clearly. The most she's heard from Perfuma before this is unsure suggestions followed by a bright smile if others agree with her. She knows this woman leads a whole Kingdom and has for years but… Maybe she's still just associating politeness and kindness with weakness.

"Micah and Castaspella are staying in my mum's room, Bow and I will stay in mine." As seriously as Glimmer says it, Catra has a feeling she's not too unhappy with sharing a room with her boyfriend for the foreseeable future. (She's going to make fun of the two of them for it as soon as the opportunity arises.)

Scorpia says, "I'll stay with Entrapta in that room off her lab, it'll be fun."

That is not the word she would use.
"It'll be days without sleep," she points out. She has not seen Entrapta take a fucking rest *ever*, let alone seen her set time aside for actual sleep.

"Scorpia has assured me my sleep schedule will not interfere too badly with hers."

She looks to Scorpia incredulously because she doesn't know how that can be true. (Apparently she *does* sleep?) Scorpia offers, "Perfuma made me some earmuffs," like that will actually do anything. At least she has optimism.

Rooming arrangements for people she doesn't know are made, or just confirmed. She doesn't care to listen, too distracted by Adora tapping her fingers on the chair's arms. She glances at Adora out the corner of her eye, and she's unsure whether she's surprised that Adora's doing the same. She moves her tail so it's hanging on Adora's side, and waves it up in question. Adora takes a light hold of it and nods once, subtle enough that no one else sees it. She does the same.

"Catra can stay with me."

The entire room goes quiet. She's not expecting people to be *surprised* given Adora is literally the only person she's comfortable with. And they grew up sharing a damn room. (And a fucking bed.)

"You're sure?" Glimmer asks loudly enough that both her and Adora are laughing. She doesn't even realise it's the first time she's laughed in front of most of these people.

"We grew up sleeping in the same bunk bed, I think we can manage it in her big-ass room. I have had *years* practise dealing with her sleep-fighting."

There's a few chuckles at that, most of them probably due to Adora's indignant huff. And she can't say shit because it is *true*. Catra's been woken up by Adora kicking the frame so hard it made the whole bed shake.

"And I can deal with the fact that the room's going to be covered in claw marks."

Adora tugs gently on her tail and she snatches it out of her grip, frowning and whipping round to her jackass of a best friend. "Those marks were *intentional*."

"Were they?" That smug *knowing* tone used anywhere else and Adora would be on the floor with her arm pinned to her shoulder blades. Which Adora knows. "I remember a certain incident involving our bunk's bottom left pole."

Her fur is standing on end with her anger (it is *not* embarrassment.) So *maybe* she accidently cut straight through it and it had to be replaced before the metal plate holding the top bed snapped in half.

"We were eight! You know I can control my claws now asshole." She grabs Adora's arm to yank her closer so she can put her the other around Adora's shoulders, putting enough pressure into it for it to be headlock if she weren't sitting down. And the most annoying part is she knows Adora is *letting* her do this. She is *snickering* in the hold.

"So the fact they're digging into me right now is *intentional*?"

She growls, "Entirely." Adora is still *grinning*.

"Okay...is that everyone paired up?" Perfuma at least sounds amused by them. Which is strange, since she's still used to receiving scorn in response to their 'antics' as Force Captains used to call it.

At least when Adora moves back into her chair, she grants her the dignity of tapping out instead of just breaking the hold like she normally would. She retracts her claws but doesn't let go of Adora's wrist under the table. Adora has done the same nearly every meeting previous, she doesn't see why she shouldn't (except for the obvious reasons.)

When Mermista speaks, Catra doesn't bother to look at her, turning her eyes to the murals on the walls she's never really paid attention to. "Perfuma, you can stay with me if you want."

"Oh, well thank you." From her voice, she thinks Perfuma didn't seem to realise that she hadn't been included in the pairings. "Will Sea Hawk be there?"

"If I don't kick him out."

The affonted noise the man in question makes means she's trying not to snort. It comes out quiet enough that it's drowned out by

everyone else doing the same thing.

Adora stays behind to talk to Bow and Glimmer or something. Which means she stays too. She does get up though, getting closer to the pastel murals now that she's realised she knows at least five of the people depicted.

"Hey Catra," Glimmer calls. She turns, Adora knocking her head when she does in a 'come here'. "You sure you're comfortable with sharing a room? I mean we'll get you a bed roll but-"

Neither of them laugh as loudly this time, but they still *do*. Adora trying to muffle her snickering behind her hand, just at the absurdity of it.

"Are you serious?"

Both Glimmer and Bow just look confused now, "Uh…"

"We'll," Adora coughs, looking something like embarrassed, "We'll be fine."

"You guys have slept together?" It is the phrasing that makes Glimmer's snort as undignified as it is. And Catra wouldn't go as far as to say Bow sounds distraught but it's funnier if she says he does.

"Not like that, Arrow."

It's so easy to make him blush. And she focuses on that and Glimmer still laughing instead of Adora going utterly *red* beside her. She doesn't want to address the reason why in any way because she will be *wrong*.

"Literally. As in you sleep in the same bed?"

"Duh."

“Oh, um, okay? I - alright. Fine. You’d think that would come up - wait, have you done that here?”

And just like that the amusement she’s been getting out of this dies. Adora didn’t tell them.

She’s not *angry*. She doesn’t think. But she’s not feeling *nothing*. She doesn’t really want anyone knowing how they fall asleep together sometimes. Even if it makes her happy that Adora is at least hers in that way. But now she’s kind of wishing Adora told *someone* because a sickly little feeling is crawling up through her torso.

“The guards didn’t tell you?” Adora near winces saying it and that makes her tail lash.

“No. No they didn’t.”

Adora gives her a pleading look and it’s a bitchy move, but she ignores it, crossing her arms and cocking her hip. (Her tail won’t keep *still*.) Adora looks at the floor, which she’d understand - there are three people staring her down - if she weren’t feeling whatever it is she’s feeling.

“Yeah - yeah we - I stay in Catra’s room sometimes. Sleepovers…”

She can feel Glimmer’s eyes on her but she won’t give her the satisfaction. “So I guess I should stop worrying about whether or not you’re going to rip each other’s throats out.”

“Wouldn’t rule it out Sparkles. Bow, walk with me?”

She won’t know if he followed because he wanted to or if it was just because she’s not allowed to be outside her room without a fucking babysitter. She walked away before he could give an actual answer.

He only tries to open her up twice. And he doesn’t get anything out of her. Is it fair to him? No. But she doesn’t feel all that bad

either. She’s selfish and looking for a damn distraction. She gets it when he tells her he needs to hand out supplies and the feeling of dread is enough to immediately rid her mind of it.

He delivers her to the castle’s basement. It’s mostly storage (and it reeks of smoke and dust) but they’ve converted part of it into a lab for Entrapta. It looks like the Fright Zone - no, that’s wrong, it looks like Entrapta’s castle in Dryl. She spends the rest of the day there with Perfuma, Scorpia and Entrapta in her lab. She would ask why Perfuma stays so long since she would've thought the Princess would have to be sorting out rooms and moving in families or whatever, but she knows she's not allowed to be alone with just Entrapta and Scorpia. Part of the deal.

Being around Entrapta, the explosions that follow her, and Scorpia running around after small robots means she doesn’t think about Adora. It feels like the best times she had with them in the Fright Zone, if it weren't for Princess Flower Power sitting beside her on a makeshift desk making eyes at her girlfriend. But it's good, and she's as distracted as she wished until Perfuma and Scorpia are bringing her to the main dining hall. She almost sighs disappointedly at herself when she spots Adora immediately. At least she gets the satisfaction of seeing Adora do a double-take when she sees her.

Adora stops talking to her unimportant Rebellion friends to look at - to watch *her*. She feels important to her again. And she wants to take her by her stupid jacket and kiss her in front of everyone. Well. She felt better for a second.

Adora stands when she’s close enough, and she’s so absorbed in her that she doesn’t realise Perfuma and Scorpia leaving her side. Or Adora’s friends that glare at her. They don’t matter when Adora’s reaching for her arm in front of everyone. Her thumb brushes all too softly against the skin of her wrist, but that's not enough for Catra to not see the creases in her forehead.

She tries, “Hey Adora.”

Not even that melts Adora's concern. "Catra I'm sorry -"

She holds a hand up, "- Don't. I'm fine. I don't want to talk about it. Especially not *here*."

This might be the easiest Adora has backed down in a long time. She just nods, tugging her arm, "Come on, we'll get you some food."

After dinner it takes a single trip to get her few clothes, books and chess set to Adora's room. The guards follow, though they look unsure about whether they should. Adora waves them away, *technically* she is still under watch and she will be for who-knows-how-long. They'll probably have to come back if she wants to be alone anywhere though.

Her outfits next to Adora's in her wardrobe makes her feel...she can't really describe it. But it feels good, like that annoyingly possessive part of her has found a balm. It means her clothes will smell like Adora's. She realises she's going to leave a scent mark in Adora's room, that she's not going to need the excuse of nightmares to share the bed with her best friend, and she almost starts purring.
Almost.

Being alone with Adora and now actually being in her room means the feeling she's been dutifully ignoring is back. It takes glancing at Adora sitting on her bed for the feeling to begin swiftly reigniting. It's an ugly feeling - like most of the ones she has. She doesn't want it. It's making her stomach feel wrong like she's sick.

She realises as she shuts the wardrobe door too loudly that it's insecurity. Or some mutation of it. It's remarkably simple for all the lengths she's gone to to avoid it. It's doubting that hasn't been curbed, so it's just getting worse. And the worst fucking part is that now she knows what it is, she also knows how to fix it. Which requires perhaps her least favourite thing to do.

It requires the very thing Adora offered and she denied. She kind of wants to groan and bang her head into the stupid pastel wardrobe. Instead she just grits her teeth and asks a simplified version of what's been eating away at her whenever she gets a moment to think.

"Are you embarrassed by...us, where we come from?"

She hears Adora startle on the other side of the room at her breaking the silence, "What? No. Catra why would you ask that?"

Just like before her tail snaps, her ears go down too this time and she despises how easy she is to read. She wants to snap or hide or claw something. She stares at the painted wood in front of her, tempted to scrape the white off it to see what's sure to be the medium blue of the Whispering Woods underneath.

It distracts enough for her to ask her next question void of a snarl. "How come Bow and Glimmer didn't know about…?"

"I -" Adora sighs, "They didn't ask and I didn't tell them."

She wants to call bullshit but Adora's tugging on her fingers, showing her nerves. So she's not mean, but she's not kind either, still keeping a distance even as she gets a little closer. "You - we do…*this* because we're allowed to now. We're not going to get punished, so why haven't you told them?"

Adora looks up at her through her lashes, "I - I didn't think you'd want me to."

Well she didn't but that's not the point. "Are you ashamed of me then?"

"*No*, I'm not fucking ashamed of you Catra. It's just…" She walks slowly as Adora speaks, but eventually she does get to the bedside, she does sit down. Adora shuffles closer and her warmth melts into her shoulder, easing her worries almost as much as the words. "It's a weakness, not sleeping. If anything I'm ashamed of me."

Her body rights itself as relief works through her. That - that is an answer she can accept. That is an answer she knows to be true. “Ah.”

“Yeah… And - and I still remember how scared I was when Shadow Weaver found us like that. Even if I don’t remember what she said anymore. I guess I’m - I still expect something like that to happen if people find out. Even when I *know* I shouldn't feel like that. And I don’t want them talking. Anymore than they already do.”

Adora’s chewing her lip by the end of her little speech and she puts a hand on her shoulder. “People were gonna find out eventually. Brightmoon has a fuck ton of gossip. I was surprised the guards kept their mouths shut. I mean I shouted your name in my sleep that’s...” kind of mortifying actually. Not as bad as the one time she did it back in the barracks but still.

Her ears go back down and Adora looks guilty, whether it’s because of that or the words doesn’t really matter. “I know. I mean they already assume I - we...”

“What?” If there’s people she needs to threaten to make Adora feel better she *will*, no hesitation.

Everything runs cold when Adora shifts away, it gets worse as Adora’s arms wrap around herself. Catra’s frozen, arm hanging in the air before she drops it to her side and just stares at Adora. If she looked guilty before it is nothing compared to this; her whole face is contorted with it.

“I am sorry, for kissing you.”
There are few times in her life when she’s genuinely thought her heart had stopped. Now is one of those times. She’s used to hearing her own heartbeat, it feeds back her own panic when it pumps rapid-fire. But when she's most scared is in times like right now, when there’s only static and blank thought. There's not usually Adora’s voice trying to break through it.

“I shouldn’t have done it, I know that, and I - I’m never going to stop being sorry for it -”

“What the *fuck* are you talking about?” Her tongue feels heavy in her mouth; the only reason the demand isn’t shouted.

She barely hears Adora’s whispered, “What?” over the sudden returning roar of her blood in her ears.

Maybe it’s a good thing Adora moved away because she springs to standing with her claws out. *Now* she’s shouting, “No I’m asking you what! When the fuck did you *kiss* me?”

Guilt gives way to shock, maybe even fear. “You really don’t remember?”

“Evidently not!”

Adora gets to her feet too, waving her arms like she does when she’s too concerned with what she’s saying to realise she’s doing it. “I thought you were just pretending it didn’t happen! I’ve been doing the same - fuck, Catra -”
Adora rakes her hands through her hair before she sighs and sinks back down to the bed. Adora just holds her head while Catra stands there, claws sliding part ways back in. She’s holding back a true growl but she manages it. It won’t help and she’s already shouted.
“...I don’t know if that makes this better or worse honestly.”

“Gods Adora I - just tell me when.” Her growl does slip into her words though.

“When I healed you…” When Adora looks up, it’s like she’s bracing before taking a hit. “You remember that CPR training we did when we were fourteen?”
She’s sure the *‘get to the fucking point’* gets through in her expression alone.
“Yeah well you weren’t breathing so…”

Her responding short bitter laugh shuts Adora up efficiently. She starts pacing, the reality of what Adora's telling her trying to worm its way through all the barriers preventing her from understanding. She's got enough now that she can accept what's happened. Adora having kissed her - she could never just *accept* that. But Adora doing CPR on her (with magic) and calling it that, that she can grasp. Adora thought the Horde was *good* for eighteen years - clearly she sees things a little differently than most people.

Her next pained laugh is quieter but it still stops Adora's breathing. Catra got what she wanted and not only does she not remember it, it wasn't even for the reasons she wants it to be. Not because Adora loves her, she doesn't even *want* her that way. It didn't *mean* anything to her.

And she can't even be that angry, rationally, because it was to save her fucking life. But she's not rational. She never has been. And she is angry and *hurt*. She wants to tear something that makes a horrible noise under her claws, but there's no metal anywhere even close to here. None that she can destroy anyway. And the trees outside are beyond the wall of clones so… She just paces, angry and growling and muttering, "You did it to heal me… Alright. Fine fucking - fine."

"I'm sorry." Adora sounds weak and even that doesn't soothe her.

"Didn't mean anything, it's fine."

"You keep saying that…"

She hisses, "Well what do you *want* me to say Adora?"

"I want you to sit down and breathe. I want to know what you're thinking." *That's* never going to happen. Adora's made sure of that.

"If I sit down I'll rip your bedding." Maybe Adora's room will end up with claw marks. Gods does she want to.

“I don’t care. Catra you’re scaring me.”

Fuck. Just...*fuck*. Because that actually works in permeating her cloud of self-loathing and rage. She snarls at the wall, fists her hands and drags her knuckles down her face instead of her blades and just tries to breathe. Just like *Adora wants*. Because she gets everything and she always has.
That’s not fair to her. She’ll be grateful of not spitting her thoughts out later.

Her sigh is low in her throat when she turns. There’s water sitting in Adora’s eyes ready to fall and it’s enough for her to come back over and sit as far away from her on the bed as she can. She kind of wants Adora to say something. And she kind of wants her to never speak again.

The silence stretches for minutes. She doesn’t know what to do. Neither of them do, obviously. She can’t leave. She doesn’t really want to leave. She - she just wants. The one person she can never have. She’s been calling Adora her best friend in her head all day, all week. And it’s not a lie. But she just wants more where she shouldn’t, same as always.

And she wants to move on from this before it breaks her. She’s already going to be pushing this from her head for the rest of her damn life, she doesn’t need to soak in her own misery and Adora’s discomfort.

“Was it at least good for you?” she tries to joke.

Adora jerks her head round. She hasn’t been crying at least - she didn’t scare her too badly. “Well...uh, one, you were dead in my arms and I was crying. Two, I...wouldn’t know.”

Well the first part she understands. That whole day was horrible for her - evidenced enough by the aftermath alone. It doesn’t matter if Adora doesn’t *love* her, she was still dead and Adora still *cares* about her. (*‘She always did, she always did.’* It’s painfully hard to believe that right now.)

The second...she - she *kind of* had Adora's first kiss. She thinks. Maybe. That's - she doesn't -

"Wait, you and Sparkles never…?"

Adora all but cringes, "No, Bow remember?"

And before she gets to ahead of herself, "And in the Horde there was never -"

"- No. Weaver would've had my head."

That crushes any good feeling that could've come from this. Because she's right. Shadow Weaver didn't care about her enough to make threats, but if she caught Catra kissing or doing more with anyone, the witch probably would've been thrilled at getting to ruin it. But her golden girl? Adora is right to have been scared. Though *Adora* most likely would've been fine, the girl she hypothetically would've been with...Catra doesn't think she'd have been able to *walk* away from the Black Garnet chamber.

"Catra I'm so sorry -"

"- Shut up! Gods never thought I'd get sick of you apologising."

Adora curls back into herself, hands fisted in the bedding. Catra flops back against the mattress. She knows she's got to be the one to break this next silence but she *really* doesn't want to. The claws on her feet scrape quietly against the floor. Adora is still immobile next to her. And it makes her give up. Adora doesn't deserve to feel bad about it. It's not Adora's fault; that she loves her, that kissing her is really all she wants, that saving her meant making her hurt like this.

She grits her teeth, which might send mixed signals but she can't help it. "I'm not...angry with you. I mean I was but - but it was just to heal me, right?" She looks over when Adora nods rapidly, eyes wide. Another time and she might make fun of her for it. "You thought I was pretending it didn't happen?" Another nod,

less energized. “Then we pretend it didn’t,” she sounds like she has more resolve than she does.

"Okay, okay whatever you want.”

She stares at the ceiling. “Bow and Glimmer know?”

“They saw it.”

That anger is back but it's not for Adora or even herself this time. Bow and Glimmer got to witness what she’s dreamed of for years while she doesn’t even get to fucking *remember* it. “Of course they did.”

Adora shrinks again, curling into her knees. The sight gets through to her again, makes her get over herself. She lays a hand flat on the bed in offering, and Adora’s eyes shine when she sees it. Adora takes it carefully, like her damn hand might shatter, but she doesn't look at her. And neither does Catra.

“Nothing’s changed. You’re still my best friend.”

‘And you still don’t love me the way I want you too.’

Adora swallows, “You promise you forgive me?”

So *that’s* what that meant. “I promise.”

She’s not going to cry. She won’t let herself. She can’t cry - Adora still doesn’t know that she’s hopelessly in love with her, she doesn’t think - and that would just give it away completely. Even Adora for all her oblivion would figure it out. She just needs to be away, but she also needs to know Adora won’t leave her for how terribly she reacted to all this.

She takes her hand away and stands, ignoring how Adora holds her breath. “Are you going?”

She knows Adora doesn’t just mean exiting the room. She could point out that she *can’t* by Brightmoon law but… “No. Just not

ready to sleep. I'll be on the balcony if you need me."

"I am sorry, Catra."

"I know."

Chapter End Notes

The angst is back <3 If you thought Catra knowing was going to get rid of the miscommunication you were wrong, sorry. BUT Catra did deal with her horrible day pretty well so I'm proud of her.

Also, yeah spotify playlist for YSSMIAC

(Random Entrapta headcanon: she's really light sensitive which is why her castle and her lab don't have any windows)

The Things You'll Do

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Catra sleeps on the balcony, whether she meant to or not. And Adora somehow feels worse now than she did when she kissed Catra in the first place. She'll ask for a bedroll for her today, she doesn't blame Catra for not wanting to be close to her like that after everything.

Apparently Catra didn't figure out her feelings. So at least there's that. But she was still, essentially, rejected. And it hurts. Worse than it should because she hurt Catra too and it's...it's just a mess.

She doesn't know how to even begin to fix it either. And Catra gets angry when she tries to fix things and - she'll let Catra decide. Catra can lead them. It's what she was doing before, when she thought she knew. She'll just...be She-Ra. She won't think about this. And she'll be the friend Catra wants her to be. Catra will come back to her, eventually.

Catra doesn't really speak to her the next day beyond short sentences and clearly forced smiles. Like she's trying to be okay with knowing that when she had Catra in her arms for what she thought was the last time she *kissed* her of all things. No, not kissed. She was just resuscitating her. That's the lie she's got to believe. And she's miserable. She misses her, as pathetic as that is. But it's not what she's meant to be focusing on, Catra never is, there's always *something* else.

Being She-Ra is difficult. It's never been easy, but it's so much harder now. It's all her; there's no sword stopping the magic. It's just her own damn mind. But she transforms, as many times as she can since Catra's not here to stop her. Whenever she thinks

about her and the anger that rolled off her when she found out, She-Ra's form flickers, strength draining until she can get a hold on it again.

It's terrifying; that Catra has so much power over her. But at least she's not the only thing that makes her phase. Just worrying too much does too. (Which makes her worry and doubt herself more, unfortunately.) But she keeps going, letting the magic flood in and out of her veins until it feels like a tide she can actually control. It's long past dark when she stops, shaking too much to continue.

She gets food from the kitchens, taking it back to her room and finding guards outside her door. Catra is there waiting, reading a book and sitting on top of her wardrobe. She can't help smiling at it. And she eats, Catra asks how her day was and she doesn't tell her anything more than that she got She-Ra to work properly. That's the only thing Catra asks her. She wants to reach out but...she's scared to step foot on a burnt bridge lest it crumble completely.

Catra jumps down a time later and unfurls the bedroll someone must have brought her, curling up on it on the floor space beside her bed. She doesn't see Catra's face until the next morning.

The next day is almost worse, she sees Catra even less. She's gone before she even wakes up.

She remembers to eat, fully intending to drown another day in training, but she gets distracted. She's not so caught up in herself as to not realise the tension in the castle. She can't very well ignore the people she's meant to save.
They are *restless*, all of them.

The added rooms helped, but not by much. They want to fight. And so does she. Prime hasn't said anything, quietly taking over more and more of the planet everyday. If there's any town or village left free, she'll be astounded. No one knows how to help from inside the spell, and it's too risky leaving. The inaction is

getting to her too if she's honest. They don’t want to be idle and useless anymore and she *gets it*.

She should have just trained. She should not have done what she did. Spending hours finding who wants to fight, asking their families whether they agree that this is a good idea. Keeping it from Bow, Glimmer, the rest of the Alliance. She shouldn’t have let Sea Hawk or Juliet overhear, should never have let them agree to come if they kept it quiet. Gods she even set up a meeting that evening to discuss the layout.

She is just digging herself deeper into this pit with little to no regard for the consequences and she doesn’t care. She’s already done it. She’s not thinking clearly; she’s hurt and reeling and desperate for something to do. *'Desperate not to let anyone else down,'* her head tells her when her guard is low enough.

She tries to reason with herself that the people would’ve gone out there anyway. She’s She-Ra; she can keep them safe. And because it’s not a lie she believes it. She manages to arm all thirty fighters without alerting Glimmer in the early morning. Or maybe she does know. Adora won’t care until the aftermath, or if Glimmer tries to stop them.

Her heart is beating unhealthily fast listening for the shimmer of her magic as she and her battalion creep down through the town. They escape out the dome by sneaking around the belt of ground lining the mountain, making their way as quick as they can to the southernmost side of the barrier. She pushes down her worry enough that she can get She-Ra to the surface. And she keeps the feeling there; buried and silent.

They’re only supposed to be out here for two hours maximum, she reminds herself as they pass through the spell. She tells that to the sorcerer that has accompanied them. She told it to the battalion yesterday. She’ll keep everyone safe. There's guilt she tells herself she shouldn't feel. She is helping the people, weakening Prime and she can get tech for Entrapta. There are just as many things that can go *right* today as they can go wrong.

And maybe today won't mean anything to Prime, the damage they do won't make an impact on his army. But it'll make her feel better too, at least she hopes so. If nothing else it is a *distraction*.

Catra

She doesn't know where Adora is. She left in the early morning leaving Catra on the balcony, told her she'd be back in a couple hours. It's been five now. She shouldn't be *this* worried, and not after just how little they've seen each other recently. And she knows it's her own fault for running away and taking refuge in Entrapta's lab but she just...she needs time to be okay with what happened.

But she is worried. And she tries to be reasonable about it. She messages Bow about where Adora is, but he has no answer. Neither does Glimmer, Scorpia, Entrapta. She even asks Perfuma.

She knows there are guards outside, she can hear them talking when she's close enough to the door. So she gives up pride for one fucking minute, opens it and asks, "Did Adora say where she was going?"

Maybe they're shocked under the helmets, she wouldn't know. "No. Should we be worried?"

"I don't know...maybe." She's been waiting hours, she's not waiting any longer, not even the short time it would take for someone to get here. "Follow me."

Adora's been quiet, almost resigned since their…*talk*. But she's also been quick to respond whenever she does acknowledge her, always showing her shock at recognition with her big annoyingly pretty eyes. Last night more than the first. But the one thing she's found that makes Adora turn away is when she manages to ask how her day went - silly small talk that has Adora all but shutting down. So she feels at least justified in her conclusion that Adora is

hiding something. Something she is doing, or now possibly something she has done.

The guards follow, their staffs scraping along the ground quietly enough that the only one who flinches at the horrid sound is her. At least said sound gets lost to clamouring voices as she draws closer to the crowds. She doesn't know where she is but at least she's found *someone.*

Bow calls her name from across the room. If she were a better person she'd feel bad about making him wade through refugees to get to her but there is no fucking way she is walking into that. "Have you found her?"

"...Sort of. Swift Wind said he felt her in distress and left a while ago. Turns out a group left Brightmoon to go fight, She-Ra was leading them. Everyone is back save for Sea Hawk, Adora and Juliet."

Well she only knows two of those people, and only cares about one. She hisses, "Moron," to herself. "I'm going out to find her -"

"- By yourself?"

She knows her tail is fluffed up behind her, but with the crowd she didn't hear or smell Mermista so close. She'd flatten her fur down if it didn't draw attention to it being on end in the first place. She settles for just snapping it out of view behind her.

"I'm not a Princess, you can afford to lose me." She believes what she's saying. But really she's just thinking about what she can say that'll get her to Adora quicker. She will drag her back by her damn ponytail if needed.

"No. Adora can't lose you again. You think she's going to be anything other than destroyed if you get chipped going out there by yourself to save her? "

Of all people, she wouldn't have ever guessed that it would be Glimmer who would say that. Bow would, with his bleeding heart.

But not Glimmer, and it's - it means so much more coming from her. It's not - Glimmer means that. She's forgotten in her own turmoil that Adora *cares*, she cares a lot. It's why she kissed her (*did CPR*) in the first fucking place. But it is still beyond jarring hearing other people acknowledge it.

And she needs to say something before she gets caught up in her thoughts that *aren't* about saving Adora right the fuck now. "What will it matter if she's already taken? You guys rushed into the Fright Zone with barely a plan to save her, I'm doing this."

"I'm not trying to stop you! I'm saying I'm going with you."

Oh. Well...fine. She'll take - yeah that'll work.

"No, Glim you can't do that. We already know Prime wants you." Bow takes Glimmer's arm, too gentle for how distressed he is.

"And we have a higher chance of saving them all if I teleport them out of there."

She suggests, "What if she waits at the barrier?"

Glimmer nods, pleading expression working so expertly that it barely takes a second for him to relent. Either that or he knows she'll go out there anyway.

Mermista draws their attention away, "The group went out the southern side hours ago, are you sure you'll be able to find them?"

"Yes." If there is one thing she knows for fucking certain it is Adora's scent. And besides, it's not as if She-Ra is exactly subtle.

She should've thought this through better. Not going after Adora, but using Glimmer's magic. Because she didn't realise what she had said yes to until her vision is suddenly filled with pastel light and her stomach is in her toes. She comes out of it, dropping to

her knees, now on grass. Maybe they're round the southern side, she wouldn't fucking know with how nauseous she is right now.

"Warning next time, Glitter," she coughs out.

"Sorry," and either Glimmer doesn't mean it or she's too distracted to be paying attention to her. Which...fine, they've got other things to worry about.

She doesn't hear anything as she stands, rolling still present in her chest but she's not trembling anymore. And she worries for a moment that it'll be hard to find Adora (and the other people that should be with her.) It's not; She-Ra is lighting up the woods like a moonrise.

"Stay. Here."
Glimmer grumbles, crosses her arms, but she doesn't make any further move past the spell line.

It is a graveyard of Prime's bots as she weaves through the branches of blue trees alone. She can hear Swift Wind before she can see him. There aren't any more active bots or clones around that she can see but still She-Ra stays battle ready and waiting up ahead. And maybe it's a bad idea to sneak up on She-Ra when she's this fucking tense but she doesn't realise that until her sword is swinging at her. She dodges it, years of practise not failing her now.

"Catra? You're not meant to be out here!"

"Neither are you dumbass! Your *team* got back hours ago. Have you been out here the whole time?"

"...Maybe." That explains the dark stains written under her eyes even with the glow of power. She's not even sure how that's possible but Adora is pouring fatigue from every damn inch of magic skin.

"I've been trying to convince her to go back, I've got this!"

She-Ra is panting just standing there, looking ready to collapse and ignoring her horse apparently as he zaps a golden beam into the distance.

Catra jumps back down to the forest floor, ear twitching in the direction of movement. More bots most likely. "You're coming with me *right now*."

She-Ra rubs at her face, shaking her head and clearly picking up on the sound closing in. Her eyes don't even focus on anything. "No - no I need to…"

"What do you need to do?" She makes sure it's soft since she can't touch her. Well, she could, but she still doesn't *want* to. She-Ra still makes *danger* sing in her head, even as it wars with other things.

"Help - help me get a bot for Entrapta?"

"Adora there are more than enough on the way back, come with me."

She-Ra debates it, looking past her to the carnage she's caused, then Swift Wind who nods at her, before finally focusing her gaze back on her. "Everyone's back safe?"

No. But Adora won't come back with her if she knows that. She feels justified in lying, "Yes, now come on, Glimmer's at the barrier."

She-Ra's glow fades, her hair stops flowing as she gives in and turns away from the newest line of bots with a final swing of her sword. Catra doesn't see the point of it until the iridescence left behind cuts the enemy clean in half. She didn't know She-Ra could even do that.

She remembers that Adora isn't the only person still out here, and looks to Swift Wind, though he doesn't see her. She is getting Adora back *now* but he looks like he's staying.

“Go. I’ll catch up,” she orders, knowing that Adora is far more likely to do as she says if she doesn’t appear to give her a choice. She is still a soldier.

She runs over to Swift Wind, speaking quietly enough that Adora won’t overhear and turn around. “Sea Hawk and someone called Juliet are still out here, bring them back when you find them.”

He doesn’t offer any resistance to the order, even though she expects it. “I’ll keep the bots off you till you’re back inside.”

She nods, turns and starts running.
Maybe Adora was running too in the beginning, or maybe she didn’t want to leave her behind. Whatever happened, She-Ra is walking now. Still fast given her height but otherwise trudging. As she catches up, Catra sees her form flicker several times.

She’s never seen She-Ra do that either. And as much as Catra wants to say something, she doesn’t. She-Ra stumbles, exhaustion evidently catching up to her. It’s strange to see her so...mortal. There’s burns up her arms she hasn’t healed yet, scratches on her armour, tangles in her hair.

She-Ra sways slightly as she slows further, blinking like she can’t make everything out. There’s a flash of light and the burns are gone. But that only makes it worse - Adora falling back into her body for a second and causing She-Ra to drop to her knees.

Catra’s quick to rush to her side, taking a hold of an arm to keep her upright, ignoring her instincts entirely. She’ll have the crackle of her magic clinging to her fur for the next few hours but now isn’t the time to worry about it. “Adora, Adora are you -”

“- I’m fine.”

So goes to argue but she can’t, not with her looking this bone-weary. “You can transform back," she tucks a strand of loose hair back behind her mask (the mask that looks like hers), "It’s alright. You’re done.”

Adora's face contorts with her conflict. But the fight drains out of Adora as the gold does. And as clearly as Adora wants to collapse, she doesn't. She gets back to her feet, not shrugging off Catra's hold but also trying her best not to lean into it. And she deals with it, pulling Adora gently forward by one arm until the barrier is only fifty or so steps away.

They grab the most intact bot they can find, dragging it behind them until they reach the barrier. Glimmer is waiting for them like she said, and Catra's surprised she kept her word. A rune is plastered to the wall, ready to activate. The spell parts and she makes Glimmer check their necks, just to make sure.

She drops the bot in time to catch Adora as her legs give out again. Adora doesn't fight it this time, leaning on her shoulder as she holds her round the waist.

"Why the fuck have you got a bot with you?" Catra was more expecting a 'what's wrong with her' but she supposes that's pretty obvious.

Adora mumbles, "Entrapta…" barely coherently but the Queen understands if her eyeroll is anything to go by.

She's still unprepared for the feeling of Glimmer's magic (she doubts she'll really ever be *prepared* for it.) She wants to crawl out of her body when they land back at the castle's entrance. She drops to her hands and knees again, not retching but the instinct to do so is definitely there. Adora's hand is on her shoulder, having dropped to the ground with her.

"Bow can you take this to Entrapta?" Then there's footsteps and the dim screech of metal that she assumes means he's taking the bot away.

"Sea Hawk?" someone who must be Mermista asks.

"He's still not back? I'll go back out and look for him."

“He’s - Swift Wind is looking for him and the other person,” she manages to say. She waits for Adora to call her out for lying but it never comes.

Once the dizziness fades, she moves from hands and knees to sit properly on the floor. It’s a good thing that Adora doesn’t bother trying to stand, because Catra would be dragging her back down to the floor anyway. Adora can barely keep her eyes open, even as she takes her face in her hands and demands, “What were you *thinking*?!”

She doesn’t give a shit that Mermista is here. She is angry and she is worried and scared because really the only time she’s ever seen She-Ra like - like *that*: damaged, was during the Battle of Brightmoon. There’s a dark shadow of guilt and hurt before it disappears and Adora falls into her arms.

And just like that the anger is gone. She manages to get her hands under Adora’s arms and drag her up to standing. She keeps Adora close to her with one hand on the back of her neck and the other around her waist, since Adora’s arms are apparently too limp to hold her back.

Adora whispers, “I’m sorry,” and it’s so small she has to stop herself from crushing Adora into her.

“Are you hurt?”

Adora shakes her head, barely awake, “She-Ra always heals.”

“Adora.”

“Just sore.” The mumble into her shoulder makes her sigh but at least she admitted *something*.

She needs to get her back to her room. Because while she feels honoured to see Adora *needing* anything, she doubts the civilians will feel the same way seeing their beacon only half-conscious in the arms of their ex-enemy.

“Come on, Princess, let’s get you to your room. Can you walk by yourself?” she asks even though she knows she can’t.

“I’ll be fine.” The slur kind of negates what’s been said.

She’s about to just carry Adora to her room, exhausted protests be damned before -
“You need help?” Mermista’s scent gets stronger as she gets closer, somehow still smelling like the ocean despite having been land bound for months.

“Don’t you need to be here for your pirate?”

Mermista crosses her arms over her chest, “Do you even know how to get to Adora’s room?”

“Do *you*?”

“I know how to get to Glimmer’s.” Okay so she doesn’t. But if Mermista gets them to the sleeping quarters she can find her way from there.

“Fine. Get her other side.”

That fact that Adora doesn’t even seem to realise they’re talking about her, or that Mermista gets an arm around her waist too, scares her. She’s not even acknowledging the most civil interaction she’s had with Mermista thus far.

She puts a hand on her chest and Adora’s eyes force themselves to open. “You still with me?”

Adora hums, “Tired.”

“Yeah, that’s what happens when you use magic and fight for five fucking hours,” she says as they start walking.

“It wasn’t - it was meant to only be two.”

“Why didn’t you tell anyone?” She knows why she didn’t tell her, what with everything. But she should’ve told someone in the castle - someone not also going with them.

Mermista tells her, “We could’ve helped.”

“Glimmer said no one’s allowed to leave. Thought everyone would try to stop me...”

And she sounds so ashamed it makes Catra ache through the anger that’s back and simmering quietly. She wants to hug her, and she would if Mermista weren’t here too. She settles for rubbing her back and taking more of her weight.

“Can’t believe you were breaking rules and didn’t tell me.”

Adora somehow tucks her head even further into her own chest, guilt rolling off so thickly she can smell it. “Didn’t think you wanted to speak to me…”

She’d apologise on the spot if they were alone. Gods the sooner they get to Adora’s room, the better. But Adora...looks afraid and she knows she can at least ease her.

“Promise I did.” She whispers it in Adora’s ear, wanting nothing more than to be alone with her. Adora looks at her finally then, blue eyes framed by the bruises of exhaustion on her face. Adora relaxes after that, and she will say exactly nothing about how much heavier Adora suddenly gets.

They go up a set of stairs she recognises, she even knows the smell. “I know where to go from here… Thanks.”

Mermista isn’t hesitant in letting her carry the whole of Adora’s weight, clearly still worried about her pirate. Still, she doesn’t run off immediately, taking the time to say, “Take care of her.”

Thankfully she leaves without expecting a response.

And fucking *still* Adora tries once again to walk on her own. Her ankles buckle on the third step and Catra gives up, just lifting Adora into her arms as was her plan earlier. The training she's been doing has rebuilt her muscles, thankfully.

She expects at least a small protest. She gets none.

"I didn't think you could, uh, could lift me."

And even looking as much of a mess as Adora does, she's still so fucking cute. She is genuinely flushed and doesn't that just stroke her ego. She's seen Adora look like this before, she knows her best friend has a thing for strong women (who doesn't) but she's never looked like this because of *her*.

"You've gotta stop underestimating me, Princess. Or don't. Makes that face you're pulling funnier."

"I'm -" Adora hides in her neck and she smiles devoid of smirk now that Adora can't see. She really has just missed feeling her. "I'm not making a face."

She lets it go, Adora is tired, she needs sleep not ribbing. Even if she's missed that too. (Even if she kind of wants to keep Adora in her arms for the rest of her damn life just to be the cause of her blush.)

Adora is practically a dead weight by the time she gets her to her room. And maybe she sets her down too gently on the bed, but she hopes she's too out of it to really notice. Adora falls back onto the mattress looking like she intends to fall asleep fully dressed.

She sighs, putting a knee on the bed to take Adora's boots off at least. Adora drowsily hums a questioning noise with no accompanying words. She climbs further up the bed, pulling Adora's hairband out and ignoring the way her lips quirk up as she figures out what she's doing.

"I've made it a personal mission to never let you fall asleep with your hair up again. Or with your boots on, I mean really, Adora."

“You’ll fail.”

Probably. “Jacket off. Or I’ll do it for you.” It’s maybe a weird thing to threaten but Adora might not even remember this when she wakes up.

Adora turns her head into the pillow, and she’s only able to make out the, “Want you to do it,” due to her hearing. She should not flush as deeply as she does but *technically* Adora is asking her to undress her so she thinks she’s allowed. Really her only saving grace is that Adora keeps her eyes closed as she does it.

Adora is already asleep by the time she gets her under the blanket. And it’s so sweet she *almost* kisses Adora on the forehead. She refrains by getting up and pulling a poofy little stool over to the bedside.

She kind of hates herself for sitting at Adora’s bedside like she’s dying. But...she just feels like she can’t move. It’s not like she’s never watched Adora sleep before and it’s not like Adora seems to care, because she has definitely caught her before. It’s ridiculous how little excuses she needs nowadays to play her lovesick game with herself.
In some ways denying was good, if only because it stopped her doing stupid things like this.

She’s still quick enough moving that when Adora wakes she doesn’t see her blatantly concerned gazing. It’s only been two hours but Adora already looks so much better, that unnatural dullness in her skin and eyes having vanished.

“How do you feel?”

Adora rubs the sleep from her eyes, turning more onto her side to look at her. “Not great.”

“Guess I can’t kiss you and make it better like you can,” it sounds far lighter than she feels saying it.

It is the first time she's mentioned *it* and it - it stings. She thinks it maybe always will. But she needs Adora to think she's okay with it - that it didn't mean anything to her either. And jokes are really the best way she knows how to do that.

Adora does smile, a little, but it's pained. She had watched as the damage done to She-Ra had faded, but maybe she missed something.

"That's actually a thing here, kissing injuries to make them better. It's usually done with kids but Glimmer and Bow still do it." Adora looks a little wistful as she says it. For what, she's not sure. A nicer childhood most likely.

But as surprised as she is that that is a thing here, she is in no way shocked that Bow and Glimmer do it. She - maybe she's jealous. A little. "Gods imagine what Shadow Weaver would've done if we did that."

Adora bundles into the blankets further and she doesn't blame her. "I don't want to."

"...Where does it hurt?" She's going to do something stupid now. Because stupid things make Adora smile when she does them. And she can't stand how sallow her face gets when she mentions Shadow Weaver.

"No where specific."

She huffs, "You're not making this easy for me, y'know."

"What?"

She snaps her fingers, "Right hand." Adora slowly comes out from under the blanket, eyes never leaving as she reaches out. She's being ridiculously obvious as she brings their hands to her lips, probably too careful with how she kisses the back of her hand. And really the way Adora's breath hitches makes her as nervous as it does happy. "Feel better?"

Adora nods, looking even more shocked than she had when she picked her up. Adora may not be smiling at her silly attempt at making her feel better, but it did, apparently, work. Kissing her, in any capacity, made her feel better. And she is...is just far too happy.

Adora tugs on their hands and Catra knows she's got a similarly shocked expression when Adora asks, "Lie down with me?"

She hopes her swallow is silent enough that Adora doesn't notice it as she climbs on top of the covers next to her. Adora shuffles into her side, still under the blankets, tucking her head into her shoulder. She doesn't let herself purr, even if it is the first time she's even wanted to since their *conversation*.
She's actually in Adora's bed with her, like they said they'd be. She is trying not to show her enjoyment of such a simple thing too much.

"I'm sorry." It's muffled in her fur, but she hears it clearly enough.

"You said that already."

"I didn't mean to scare you like that."

A younger her would reverently deny being scared. Now though...
"Why did you - no, that's a stupid question."

She sighs, wrapping an arm around Adora, bringing her closer in. And she can admit to herself that it's for more reasons than Adora just seeming like she needs it. And she doesn't feel bad. Not when Adora shuffles enough to put an arm around her too.

"I'm sorry."

She doesn't want to tell her to stop apologising, not right now. She doesn't want Adora feeling any worse. And she doesn't want another fight. (If what happened could really be called a fight.)

"Just don't do it again."

Adora stays pointedly silent. And she takes it.
'No false promises at least.'
There aren't any lies made to placate her. A hopeful part of her says that's improvement.

She doesn't know what it is about the position or the silence that lets her feel comfortable enough to drag her claws through Adora's hair. But she does, almost absentmindedly. Adora melts into the touch as much as she drinks in the easy affection.

She has realised multiple times today that even just the two day distance has made her miserable. Now more so than ever. She has missed Adora and she wonders how she even survived the past three years. And she thinks about burying it, denying it. But she doesn't. Maybe it's just because it's easier with her here, with Adora curling into her as much as she is. Her feelings aren't reciprocated, but she has this closeness. This *almost* that lets her be weak enough to say:

"I missed you."

Adora tenses, hand gripping onto her shirt. But she doesn't actually move. The only reason Catra doesn't run. Her hand feels like lead as it falls away from her hair.

"Catra you said we were going to be okay. You said nothing would change but you've barely looked at me. *This* is the first time you've ever been in my bed, and it wasn't meant to be."

There's something about the way Adora says it that makes her heart beat faster. "You want me here?"
And it's a coward's answer, sure. But she can't admit why she's been turning away and she doesn't want to outright lie and drive Adora further away.

"Of course I do. Do you...not want to anymore?"

That twists something in her chest; Adora afraid of being rejected by her. She wants to crush Adora into her chest again, and maybe she would if the blanket weren't preventing it.

"No, no I do. I...I've been doing a pretty terrible job of pretending it never happened, haven't I?"
Adora stays quiet again, only pressing her face deeper into the crook of her neck in answer. She reaches down and smooths out Adora's hand on her stomach, removing the fabric held tight in her fingers to wind theirs together.
"I'm sorry Dora. I'll - I'll be here. I'll stay."

It's far harder to say than it should be. But Adora's said it to her enough times by now, she ought to return the favour. And it works, Adora doesn't try to hide her sharp inhale and squeezes their joined hands before saying weakly, "It's like mid-afternoon."

"Tonight, dummy... And right now. I'm not letting you out of this room, you get dinner in bed today."

Adora laughs into her neck before disentangling them enough that she can sit up slightly. It's nice to see her eyes again, even if she feels colder now that Adora's warmth has left her side.

"You *promise* we're good?"

"*Yes*, Adora, we're good."

"Okay...okay. Then I can do this."
Adora kissing her on the cheek is the last thing she really ever expected to come next. But it's - it's happened now. And it takes her a good minute to remember that she said Adora could do that. And as much as she sulked about it not happening, she is grateful to herself for saying it.
"Thank you for dragging me back here."

She might actually, genuinely be speechless. She is not gaping, thankfully, just staring. Her purr bursts out of her chest as soon as there's a line of worry forming on Adora's brow. She needs her to know that she *can*.

"Yeah, uh, you're welcome." She manages to stutter out awkwardly, hoping Adora doesn't read it as discomfort. But she does, the doubting in her actions colouring her eyes. She tugs on

their still entwined hands for Adora to lie back down with her and the look disintegrates.

But Adora clambers out from under the blanket and she's frozen in response. She watches Adora move, remaking the bed sloppily with Catra still on it, before retaking her place. She cuddles back into her chest without hesitation and that just makes the purring louder, though she'll deny it. (But Adora only moved so that they could touch and be closer together so she feels that it's a reasonable reaction.) And Catra wraps her arms around her again, even tighter than before as if that will in any way soothe the fullness in her heart.

Adora can't trill like she can but she does about the nearest equivalent as she presses her ear to the source of the sound. Maybe she's still a little out of it - Adora was very...affectionate the day after she healed her, and that was brought on by exhaustion too. (*'Or maybe she's just missed you as much as you did her.'*)

"...And you say I'm cute."

There is the barest blush that ignites on Adora's cheek, almost but not quite hidden by her hair, and she wonders if Adora's ever been called cute before. She can't remember saying it, but that doesn't mean that others haven't.

"You *are* cute. And Bow agrees so I win." Definitely still a little out of it.

She ruffles Adora's hair just because she can. "Can't believe you like me."

"That's my line, shush."

"You shush, you're the one that needs to sleep."

Adora pushes weakly at her side, really doing absolutely nothing to make her purr quieten. "I don't *need* to sleep. I'm fine."

“Uh huh, sure. If you can turn into She-Ra right now I’ll hug Swift Wind.”

“As if you would.”

Dodging the challenge means she’s right and Adora knows that. She curls her head up to purr into Adora’s hair, “Just sleep, idiot.”

She flops back to the bed, and it takes two minutes at most for Adora to be asleep on her chest.

Chapter End Notes

> So they got a lot further emotionally than I thought they would. Literally the only thing stopping them now is plot.
> We Are On The Home Stretch Now People
> We've literally just got Failsafe and Heart left to do and they will be similar to canon. Chapter count may also change.

Reunions

Chapter Notes

> Haha remember a million years ago when I mentioned that Bow's dads went to some first ones ruins?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

They're running out of time to do something. And everyone knows that.

Sea Hawk and Juliet never came back. And it's her fault. *Again*. She needs to stop being so fucking reckless. Catra was right - what was she even *thinking*? Going out there and losing the Rebellion more people. As if they actually have people to spare. As if they ever did.

The only reason she's not spiralling (more than she is) is Entrapta. She did something good there, at least. Swift Wind brought another bot back with him so as to not be empty-handed, so she's got the two of them sitting half-autopsied in her lab being studied for Prime's network. But even that is slow-going progress without access to a spire.

Then there's Catra, telling her it's not her fault whenever she so much as starts thinking about it, somehow she just knows. Catra's been...amazing. She's been everything she needs and the only one who doesn't look at her with worry or expectations. Catra falls asleep next to her, tail always wrapped around some part of her even if nothing else is. And it helps with the nightmares, she's sure without Catra she'd have multiple each night, but she's only had one in the past three.

Catra's been holding her hand a lot more too (apparently how much she likes it is obvious) and she loves ~~her for~~ it. Even around their friends, well, it was one time but they all *saw*. And Catra had

laughed at her expression so brightly she'd stopped thinking. Glimmer teased her *a lot* about it later.

But it's nice, it's really, *really* nice. Because she can reach out too. Yesterday Catra went with her to the dining hall, and she hopes the Kingdom's citizens are getting at least used to Catra being here even if they don't like her. But something happened that made Catra's ears flatten to her head, something Adora didn't pick up. And somehow, she had the confidence to put a hand on Catra's hip and pull her into her side. The momentary sudden intense panic as she had realised what she had done was worth Catra's soft, shocked expression. And the inaudible purr Catra gave as she leaned into it.

Things are changing on the outside too, those that can attack from inside the dome do. But Prime isn't replenishing the infantry he loses. Not quickly anyway, it's like they're an afterthought. And no one really knows what it means, but it's not surprising people think Prime's gearing up for his final move.

None of the Rebellion members that have been chipped are put on the front line, so at least some hope is maintained. If Prime wanted to crush them for good, he's sure to send Frosta. None of them feel as though he'll have an issue with sending a mind-controlled child to fight her friends. But he's never sent a single chipped Rebel to them, it's not mercy, so it must be for something else.
Netossa figures he was using them to lull remaining civilians into a false sense of security to make it easier to chip them. No one has any better ideas.

It's early morning on the fourth day after Prime got Juliet and Sea Hawk when Glimmer teleports suddenly into her room. So early in fact, that she and Catra aren't even awake yet, still half tangled together in their blankets. The sound alerts her body before her mind, automatically reaching for the knife under her bed. Whether

Catra wakes from her moving or the sound, her fur is completely on end as she bolts up, hissing.

"Sorry I thought you'd be awake - You still have that?" Probably about the knife but she can't really make that connection right now.

"Fucking *fuck* Sparkles don't do that!"

She puts a hand on Catra's shoulder, putting the knife back under her bed frame and ignoring the look Glimmer's giving them. Catra unwinds her tail from around her leg and Adora pets down her arm to flatten the bristling. Catra grumbles and gets out of bed, going to get her clothes from the wardrobe.

Adora asks, "How are you awake before us?"

"It's not a choice. There's - we - the Alliance needs to have a meeting… Some people made it into Brightmoon."

Catra rubs at her face, probably at the fur that's been matted down with sleep, "Chipped?"

Glimmer shifts, hands shimmering in a way that is clearly not *good*. "No, surprisingly. But you might not like who it is..."

Catra turns, spots the magic as well, "Just spit it out, Glitter."

"Bow's dads…"

"And?"

"Shadow Weaver." Her heart has never sunk so fast in her life. "I wouldn't have let her into the castle but she says she's got information we need."

Catra scoffs, almost snarling, shutting the wardrobe door too harshly. "She always does."

“She’s told George and Lance and they agree.” At least it’s clear Glimmer is apologetic about it.

Catra crosses in between them, face utterly devoid of reaction but her tail is too still, giving her away. Adora wants to do something, but she also gets it. She feels that cold grip on her veins too. If Catra were to come back to bed, she’s not sure she’d be able to let her leave.

She sighs, resisting the urge to punch something with the nervous energy that’s building, “When’s the meeting?”

“As soon as possible, I need to go wake everyone else up -“

Catra turns with her hand on the door handle, “- Can I suggest you *knock* first?”

Glimmer throws a finger up, which Catra returns and it is still so weird seeing them get along. And she is sure that this is them getting along. But with Catra gone, Glimmer turns back on her with this *look*. “There’s sharing a bed Adora, and then there’s -“

“- No. No, I’m not doing this right now.”

“Okay it’s bad timing, but it’s cute!”

“Catra can hear us. And you know she’ll sharpen her claws if you say that about her again.”

“Alright, alright, I’m leaving. But I stand by what I said.”

Catra’s there waiting on her bed when she comes out of the shower twenty minutes later. The trepidation on Catra’s face she doesn’t even try to hide, she feels herself. She doesn’t want to leave this room, maybe ever. Not that that’s an entirely new feeling since Catra’s been staying with her; she often finds herself wanting to drag Catra back under the covers for at least another

few minutes before the distance of daytime. This room feels like the only safe space for them to just *be them* anymore.

“If we don’t leave now...”

Catra sighs, getting up from the bed and holding a hand out for her to take. She does, relaxing ever so minimally. In all the times where the atmosphere was stifled with the knowledge they were walking into Shadow Weaver’s clutches, Catra never held her hand. Not for the feeling of it nor the reassurance. It’s a reminder that they aren’t under her control anymore, Weaver doesn’t even have her magic, she can’t hurt them like that again.

“I don’t want to do this, Dora,” Catra whispers, bringing her closer.

She rests their foreheads together, breath draining out of her. “You think I do? I never want you in the same room as her again.” Her mind is running a mile a minute, flashing memories she doesn't want.

“And I don’t want her messing with your head.”

She wants to say that she won’t but…she knows how much Catra hates lies. She’d gotten better at spotting the traps while Shadow Weaver was in Brightmoon, but she went eighteen fucking years *not* figuring it out so she doesn’t exactly trust herself. Not when it can hurt Catra again too.

But they're both still here, “We can do this, okay. We’ll get through this, we always do.”

Catra nods, claws pricking through her clothes, and she likes the feeling of it; of Catra showing her that she needs her. “She won’t try anything in front of everyone else will she?”

She opens her eyes, finding Catra’s face screwed up. She knows she’ll have hated saying it, and rubs circles into her forearms. “No, no they won’t let it happen. None of them. I - Catra should I have told them? About at least *some* of the things she’s done?”

Catra snaps her eyes open and she's caught up in the storm there. "No. I'm glad you didn't."

Gods she wants to kiss her, as close as they are, it would be beyond easy. Her nerves, her fear would disappear with it, she's sure. Sometimes she feels like one honest kiss from Catra would...well she's not really sure what she'd do. She wouldn't be able to *think*, that she knows.

She moves back, still holding Catra but just...making this safer. "Micah and Castaspella, they were her students too. They know what she's like. You can trust them."

"They were? Right, Mystacor… Adora - can we just… I don't know."

Catra's already frustrated, or maybe resigned. This is going to be a bad day no matter what but, "Lets just hope it's good news and…*go*."

Catra nods looking at the ground, and Adora can't stop her chest feeling the way it does when Catra still doesn't let go. And she gives in to herself, just a little. She drops one arm and brings it to the back of a Catra's neck, drawing her in to kiss her forehead. She is allowed to do this, she tells herself, trying desperately to believe it if only to keep her heart from pounding out of her chest.

She doesn't expect the half-chirrup Catra gives, and clearly neither is she if how wide her eyes are means anything. She can't help laughing as Catra removes her other hand muttering, "Your fault, dumbass," under her breath as she walks towards the door.

They're going to be the last ones there, she's sure. And she despises that she's preparing herself to be berated for being late before she's even seen Shadow Weaver; already practising what she's going to say when she blames Catra for her misstep. She wonders if Catra can hear her heart the way she can, drumming

in her ears. She should calm down for her, she's probably making her feel worse.

She tries Perfuma's breathing techniques, not even caring that she's having to resort to them in front of another person. The door to the war room is open up ahead, so at least neither of them have to actually open it. She really doesn't think she could.

She should ask how Catra's feeling. This has to be worse for her, she's just better at hiding it evidently. But they're too close now. They don't have time and she can see the walls Catra's putting up like they're corporeal. If she knew how to prepare herself, she would. But she honestly doesn't. The best she can do is ignore and silence the voice telling her she's going to let Weaver worm her way back into her head.
She's terrified to be a weapon for her to wield again. She won't be. She's better than that.

She looks at the floor for as long as she can as they cross the room's threshold. She can sense Catra stiffening beside her, like she's bracing for something, all the hypnotizing natural fluidity in her movements frozen. And still white eyes set in red are there waiting for her when she forces her head up. Her shoulders go back before she can stop it.

It doesn't matter that the Alliance is in the room too, or Bow's wonderful dads. With Catra at her side and Weaver in front of her, she feels like a child. She doesn't even have her shadows anymore but the room still feels just dark and dangerous with her there as always.

"Adora," she greets, a terrible caricature of caring. Not for the first time she wonders whether Shadow Weaver would look as menacing without her mask. The witch makes a show of directing her blank glare onto Catra close beside her.
"Catra. I see you survived."

Catra's face is grave but she remains silent and still. She wonders if Catra's fighting the instinct to cringe away from the misleadingly

even tone like she is. She thinks about taking Catra's hand, like she's gotten used to in the past few days. Her fingers sting just thinking about it in front of *her*.

They're not the last ones here, as she originally thought, Bow runs in, Micah and Castaspella following. He hugs his dads and they hold him back. They don't pull away, each keeping hands on his shoulders as Bow asks, quite rightfully, "How have you not been captured?"

She glances at Catra out of habit, she wonders if she's ever actually seen a parent interact with their child. She thinks no, given her near-unreadable expression. But it's melancholy, she's sure of it, maybe longing.

Micah and Casta, she thinks, respond similarly to her and Catra. The instant recognition and subsequent dread at seeing their old mentor. It's small, but it's there.

"The Whispering Woods is still posing a challenge to Prime. We don't know why but we're not complaining," Lance says, stepping reluctantly away from his son as he says it to better address the whole room.

George steps away too, and Bow takes his seat next to Glimmer. "I have a theory that it has been purposefully confusing Prime's clones. The woods are filled with old wild magic, after all. Though the bots have better chances of making it through. They're more resilient. But a, uh, flying horse named Swift Wind has been helping us through."

"Yes he's She-Ra's horse, he can be very helpful," Perfuma responds brightly, apparently unaware of the volume of tension in the room.

George turns to her, "Well then thank you."

She's not really expecting to be addressed and stumbles out, "Oh, oh no I didn't tell him - I would've if I'd known - but he, uh, does what he wants."

She kind of despairs at how uncomfortable she sounds. Catra's got a small smile on her face as she puts a hand on her shoulder. It reads 'calm down' clearly enough, but there's no malice in it. She forgets why she's a mess for the moment.

"Enough."
She actually jumps away from Catra's touch, and she knows Catra would be hurt by it if she hadn't done it too. Her line of sight snaps to Shadow Weaver at her voice. She didn't *forget* she was here, it just faded into the background for a second before coming screaming back to the forefront.
"We are wasting precious time with this idle talk. We believe we've found a weapon we can use against Horde Prime. That is why we *risked our lives* trying to get here."

For all of a minute there was a bearable atmosphere - one where the impending doom was suppressed in the face of a familial reunion. And Shadow Weaver ruined it. She could not be less surprised. She walks around the table, desperate to put some distance between them.

George clears his throat, "We found that there was a rebellion in the times of the First One's, Mara - the one you told us about - there was some programming connected to her name -"

"- When you say 'friend of Mara' to the hologram it activates a recording!" Adora has always enjoyed Lance's enthusiasm, she hadn't known Scorpia the last time she met him, but they really are similar.

"She wasn't alone and her squadron left a message. I - Lance the…"

"Oh, oh yes," Lance hands over a small slip of parchment to his husband.

"'*There is a failsafe for the Heart of Etheria. It will allow you to destroy the Heart and end this for good. It's at the Arxia outpost,*

but we lost touch with them a week ago. If there's anyone left out there, you need to find it."

There's a hush in the room, not that she really notices. Her heart is in her throat for so many reasons. Failsafe; there is a *failsafe* for the Heart of Etheria. A way to shut it off, keep Prime from ever harnessing it, keep their planet and the Universe safe from it's unstable power for the rest of eternity. They can *do this*. It is a way to end the war she's grown up in *finally*. She can't quite believe it *but* they've been waiting so long for *anything*, she can't afford to question it.

It's also a message, a direct message from her people. Technically. She - she supposes she's never really thought of the First Ones as her family, her ancestors, but they are. And they're still out there...maybe. And maybe whoever left this message knew the people she's descended from. Not that that really matters.
What matters is that it's hopeful - First Ones like Mara, who were fighting to save the planet. They could be good, even when so many of them were set on destruction.

She asks hesitantly, "Is there any more?"

George meets her halfway across the room. The paper is incredibly small for all the emotion she's feeling.
...Mara bought us time, but it's too late for us. This is Rebel Squadron Grayskull. And for the last time, we're signing off.

She's been fighting in Mara's name the whole time - for her friends and the people she cared about. For the people who cared about the planet she loves, instead of the ones who ruined it and were content to let it destroy worlds. It's a relief she's not expecting to feel. Her eyes actually sting with it.

"Mara did it. She actually - this could work!"

Glimmer teleports to her side to hug her and she accepts it, smiling and breathing easier than she has all day. Bow joins too.

It’s the lightest she’s felt in a long time.

“We can still save everybody?” Scorpia asks, with the appropriate amount of disbelief.

Adora looks over at her, sees Perfuma kissing her as an answer. She also sees Catra watching them with a secretive smile.

Catra

Perfuma and Scorpia are cute, she’ll give them that. But they can’t keep her attention with Adora looking as bright as she does, embraced by her friends and happy. She’s enamoured with the sight. But the light is swallowed, any amount of joy corrupted, as always, by Shadow Weaver standing like an omen on the other side of the table.
She looks bored with them. Cold hearted bitch.

She doesn’t even try to school her tone into something Weaver will accept. Not that she ever really did that even when she was at her most powerful. “And where have you been this whole time?”

“Trying to stop the Heart of Etheria from falling into Prime’s hands, of course. Someone had to.” Always quick to answer, unless she was trying to prove a point.

She remembers vividly how it felt to crack her mask down the middle and steal her power from her. Even without being able to see the Garnet shard shatter, gods does she want to do it again.

“For selfless reasons I’m sure,” the other sorcerer - Castaspella - says with as much suspicion as she had.

And it seems to throw the witch for a moment, she actually thinks about what she is to say next instead of whipping the same suspicion back on them. Her respect for Glimmer’s aunt has suddenly appeared (it might honestly be the quickest she’s ever come to respect someone.)

"I do not *want* the planet destroyed. I found rumors of a failsafe that would set the magic contained in the Heart free. I came here because I thought you'd want to know."

It brings down the happier side of the room successfully. Glimmer exclaims, "You're still trying to use the Heart of Etheria? After *everything* that happened last time?"

Shadow Weaver just sighs, like they're too small to understand her clearly intelligent plans the way she's always done. Gods, Catra always hated it.
"With the Heart deactivated, your magic will be stronger - strong enough to defeat Prime and his armies, I'm sure."

"And what's to stop you from just taking the magic for yourself?" Micah asks this time, face downright stoic. It's refreshing not to do all the interrogation herself, it's also keeping her much calmer than she would be otherwise. (Not that she's exactly *calm* but her claws are only halfway out.)
She's got allies.

"We are running out of options. Don't think I don't know that you've spent months sitting idle in this spell. It's weakening by the day and you ought to know that. Or did I not teach you enough?"

Both Micah and Castaspella recoil slightly at that. Which is fair with the amount of acid the woman is able to put into every word she ever says. Catra knows Shadow Weaver takes out her every feeling (if she has feelings other than rage, Catra's never been sure) on everyone else, she's just not used to seeing it so clearly not aimed at her. She's not enjoying it. She just wants this over with.

Adora comes back over to her slowly, maybe with the silence she thinks something's going to happen. It wouldn't be the first time but Weaver doesn't have her lightning. ('*Scorpia does'* and wow she doesn't want that thought.) She's not even looking at her - until she spots Adora moving. So much for feeling any piece of

safety. Adora doesn't touch her as she gets to her side, a careful distance between them.

Shadow Weaver narrows her eyes at them and she braces for whatever she's going to do, Glimmer doesn't give her the chance; "The failsafe is at Arxia. So where or what is Arxia?"

White eyes leave and she wraps her tail around her leg to stop it winding around Adora's. "Mystacor. We have to go to Mystacor."

"And why do you think it's there?" Adora asks.

Micah responds, looking...confused, she thinks it's confused. "She's right, I remember something - the - there was…"

Castaspella animates considerably as she must realise what he means. "Oh, yes! Mystacor was built on the ruins of an ancient First One's citadel. There are tunnels and rooms running underneath sealed off for centuries that have been forgotten. No one knows what they -"

"- An artifact known as the Crystal of Arxia was hidden in them by a group of traitorous First Ones."

Castaspella manages to glare daggers at the back of Shadow Weaver's head. It's almost funny.

"So we go to Mystacor and get it. It's that simple?" Mermista is the first one to break the new layer of tension, bored tone probably helping.

"Not exactly. It won't be easy. The city is controlled by Horde Prime now, same as everywhere else. A small team is better given that it will be *stealth* we need."

"If you know where it is why come back here at all?" She's proud of how accusing Adora sounds because she is right - this is obviously a power grab or a manipulation or trap or all three. It's going to drive her insane until she knows which.

Weaver starts moving around the table like a fucking predator and Catra's tail lashes. She doesn't back away either, too proud to. "Adora I am trying to help. You have let Horde Prime take too much ground, we cannot afford half measures anymore."

Shadow Weaver reaches out for Adora and Catra is ready to rip her damn hand off before Adora shoves it aside without grey fingers ever touching her. Shadow Weaver has never been phased by her growling or snarling or anything really. She's always known the power she holds over her; with how much she wanted her approval, she didn't need to be scared of her. But now Catra realises that she will not hesitate to blind her to protect the people here, or worse if needed.

Shadow Weaver actually backs off in the face of Adora's rejection, and she's just glad she understands the witch well enough to know she wasn't expecting it. It's satisfying. And she kind of wants to kiss Adora for it (just a little.)

"I say there's no time to waste, we leave as soon as we can."

Weaver retreats further at the Queen's words, and Catra takes the opportunity to walk closer to Glimmer's side, hoping Adora will follow. She does.

"If we need stealth, we'll need nightfall," she says, carefully not acknowledging that she's listening to Shadow Weaver.

"We leave tonight then, after the second moonrise." Glimmer looks to her for her judgement and she nods. And it's good, for all of two seconds before it's ruined by that voice.

"We'll need Micah to give us an invisibility illusion. Since *someone* cut off my magic."

She grins unashamedly, not giving a shit if Weaver sees. Even Adora's told her it was a good thing that she did it, she *can't* feel any remorse for it. She can see Scorpia giving her this knowing, proud look.

“I’m coming - Bow, I’m going,” Glimmer says before his protests even begin.

He takes both her hands, “Then I’m going too.”

"And what about me?" Castaspella shortly, still glaring at Shadow Weaver in a way Catra understands.

"Try and keep the barrier up, it won't hold much longer." Neither Micah or Glimmer argue with her. “And since we'll be dealing with the First Ones, we'll need She-Ra.”
And Weaver may be right but now she wants to insist Adora not go just to spite her. But Adora nods, face not giving anything away. And if Adora’s going, so is she.

Scorpia raises her claw, “What, uh, should the rest of us do?”

Glimmer pulls away from Bow, “Keep the people calm, don’t alert them that we’re going unless you have to. A few of you stay at the barrier, keep Prime occupied. And help Entrapta with the network any way you can.”

She showers as soon as they’re back in Adora’s room, scrubbing too harshly at a scent that’s not even on her. She just feels like there’s shadows in her hair, on her skin. Maybe a shower wasn’t such a good idea with how it fucks with her hearing. She makes it quick.

She kind of expects Adora to go running off to train, but she doesn’t. She’s got her sword in her hand that vanishes as soon as she registers the door opening.

Catra bites at the inside of her lip, trying to find the nerve to say what’s been on her mind since they left the war room. She finds it in Adora’s eyes, the way they look at her like she’s searching for something.
“You don’t actually trust her do you?” It bites a little more than she meant it to.

Adora looks a little affronted, standing and coming towards her saying, "Of course not. Catra I know she'll try something, she'll do *something* to someone... Why, what made you think that?"

She's quick to reassure her, "Nothing you - you stood up to her." She steps away from the bathroom door, "I'm just...worried. I would give so much just to know what she's going to do."

"...Catra I - I don't know if I'll - if I'll realise what she's doing. I don't trust my instincts around her. But I trust *you*... Can you just stay with me? I don't want to ask you to be around her but…"

"I'll come. I was always going to. I won't leave you alone with her, okay?"

She gets close enough to touch her, waits for Adora to smile with relief and say, "Okay," before hugging her. And she doesn't let go - neither of them do - but Adora probably doesn't feel like she'll stop breathing if she does. Adora grips the back of her head, curls into her neck and turns out she doesn't need to let go; she can't *breathe*. Or maybe she can because a whispering purr breaks out her chest.
Adora starts stroking her hair even as her claws catch in her jacket, even as she holds her far tighter than she should.

"We'll stop all of this and we won't ever have to see her again." It's breathless and she hopes to the gods that Adora won't read into why.

Adora's arm around her back tightens, "I hate that she still scares me. I hate that I feel like I can't touch you in front of her without you getting hurt."

She almost laughs. Shadow Weaver has driven Adora into her arms; the last place she ever wanted her to be. She drags her cheek against Adora's hair, just slightly. Maybe it's making up for lost time, or maybe she's just possessive.

"I know, but she's powerless, Adora. Mind games and fear are the only things she has left."

She doesn’t really believe that. Shadow Weaver *has* to have some magic hidden away, she *has* to. There is no way she’d come back here with nothing to protect herself.

“Yeah but she’s *really* good at mind games and fear tactics,” Adora mumbles, both petulant and nervous.

“There’s - there’s one thing that we can trust with her and that is that she’ll do anything to survive. As long as we can figure out how she’s going to do that in time, everything’s going to be okay.” Again, not really sure how much she believes that but it’s what Adora needs to hear.

“You’re right.”
Adora brings her head up, moves her hand from the back of her head to hold her cheek. She purrs louder - as loud as she can for as much stress as she’s feeling. This is the second time today that Adora’s been this close to her and it is a wonderful distraction for literally everything. Adora even kissed her this morning, unprompted. She can’t believe she forgot about that.
“We can stop her, save everyone… Thank you.”

And Adora kisses her again, quickly on the cheek. She purrs embarrassingly loud but it makes Adora smile so... She leans into Adora’s hand and wonders if she ever figured out her scenting or if she just thinks this is a thing she does. “You don’t have to thank me, Princess.”

Adora pouts, and she laughs, completely forgetting the reason why Adora’s being this affectionate. She can’t kiss her the way she wants to, but this is good enough. And more than she ever thought she'd get.

She doesn’t have any doubts, surprisingly, as she pulls Adora back into their bed. There’s nothing telling her she can’t. She just curls up with her, ready to forget the world for a while. And Adora, she doesn’t say anything, content to do as she suggests. Happy to just be with her. She just stays.

Chapter End Notes

‘Fucking fuck Sparkles’ might be my favourite thing I’ve ever written.

Also there's a shitty sketch on my tumblr of Catra holding Adora's hand for the first time

Crystals & Shadows

Chapter Notes

> Warnings for past child abuse, murder mention, trauma response, emotional manipulation, anxiety attack (I don't really know how to describe it but it's very similar)
> You know, general Shadow Weaver things
>
> (Grammar note: the failsafe code isn't capitalised but the Failsafe crystal is just in case the inconsistency doesn't make sense)

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra

They don’t leave Adora’s room for anything besides lunch. But Adora gets restless enough that she gratefully agrees to light training on the balcony after a long time just lying with each other and desperately trying not to think. (*Somehow* they had managed to fill a few hours with occasional conversations that didn’t revolve around Weaver or Prime or the war at all.) They don’t want She-Ra tired but if they do nothing, Adora will be a ball of nerves before they even get to the hall where they are to meet. Catra’s certain the Brightmoon-born won’t get that and it doesn’t even matter. She knows what Adora needs, so no one else has to.

And maybe it helps her too that she’s just messing around with Adora like they’re kids. It is an *excellent* distraction. It always was. She feels blissfully ignorant of their impending situation as they lie side by side breathing together on cold stone, looking up at the sky. They make patterns out of clouds like they used to, though there are far fewer curling in the sky here than in the Fright Zone. She looks at Adora like she used to as well, like she's the only thing worth looking at. And just like back then, Adora doesn't see. And even if she does, she's got an excuse ready.

She drags her claws through her hair before they leave, forcing her mind to quiet, donning false confidence like she always used to. She's survived her whole life walking towards Shadow Weaver, pretending she wasn't scared so often she believed it. Anger; she needs anger. That's how she's always done this. It's easy to find, harder to pull to the front.
She'd never thought she'd be out of practise. She blames...she's not really sure who but someone. Maybe even just *Brightmoon*.

Adora doesn't say anything this time, just holds the door open looking worried but like she's trying to convince herself she's not. She sighs, putting a hand on Adora's arm but unable to say much of anything. Adora can see her trying though.

"We can do this, Catra."

She just nods weakly, adrenaline already leaking in her stomach.

"I didn't realise *you* were coming."

Those are the first words Weaver says to her upon realising she's in the room. That anger she was struggling to keep at the forefront earlier? The struggle is *gone* just like that. Her claws snap out, but she knows better than to growl, replacing the urge with an acidic smile and snark the way she always did.

"Don't have to sound so happy about it."

"Adora, are you really sure -"

"- Yes. She's coming."

Her bitter smile morphs to a far more comfortable, far more genuine, smirk; *'Adora's on my side, bitch.'*

Shadow Weaver turns away from them with a glare and she feels the fur on the back of her neck stand down. She can see Adora giving her a sorry expression out the corner of her eye and she

resolutely doesn't look at her. She always hated this kind of pity, only when she was younger she'd spit venom at even knowing it was there, not caring that it meant pushing away the one person who was offering her comfort.

"I'm fine. Stop looking at me like that."

Adora isn't convinced, mouth opening like she's going to retort which Catra absolutely doesn't want her to do right now. But she's interrupted by Bow and Glimmer sidling up to her close enough that she feels just a little trapped.

Bow whispers, "We're happy you're coming with us." At the same time Glimmer says, "She's a *bitch*."

It, annoyingly, gets her to smile. Which Glimmer seems incredibly smug about. Adora coughs trying to hide her laugh, face melting a little. Adora's now looking at them with the same fondness she's really only seen caused by her getting along with the self-proclaimed 'Best Friend Squad'. (It's a *dumb name*. And she will mock it. She will not be changing her opinion no matter how many puppy eyes Bow gives her.) She really did fall for a complete sap.

Micah coughs on the other side of the room, looking uncomfortable enough that it must mean he's been subject to Shadow Weaver's judgement for the past minute. "We need to stay connected once the illusion is active otherwise you'll lose sight of the others. The invisibility itself will last until the spell is dismissed."

"And under no circumstances *talk*." Weaver may not be directing it at her specifically but gods does it feel like it.

Glimmer walks forward, probably to get more space as she draws in the air with her fingers, cyan lines lighting up in their wake. Micah mimics her until both of them have the glow of a rune around both their hands.

Bow puts a hand on her shoulder that makes her tense, even though it's just to indicate that she's meant to move closer to the spell. It's at this point she realises how much magic she's going to have to experience and barely resists shuddering.

There seems to just be a single line unconnected in the runes as Glimmer says, "I'm ready. Dad?"

Micah nods, "We'll need to teleport as close to the central building as we can. This spell will take a lot of energy, so we need to get into the tunnels quickly. Everyone ready?"

The answer is fucking *no*. But she can't say that.

Glimmer stands opposite her father and the rest of them link it into a circle. She's got Adora and Glimmer on either side of her, Bow and Micah bearing the horror of having Weaver's hands on them. The invisibility is activated instantly after that, followed immediately by Glimmer's magic shooting its way through her body.

She fights to stay standing when Mystacor appears, but she does, with Adora holding her arm. She thinks Adora would ask if she were alright if it weren't for the strict no talking rule. (Part of her wants Adora to ask anyway, simply because it would mean she would be breaking a rule set by Weaver and she's always loved when she did that. As incredibly rare as it was.)

There's no time for her to get her bearings. Shadow Weaver is leading them, Bow now at the back of the train. Between the disorientation and the danger of the area, her senses are ratcheted to extremes, she hears so many things and she can't tell which are closest. She focuses on the heartbeats since there's enough of them all beating out of time to create a blanketing sound.

She jerks when the train stops and she finally manages to make out the archway they'll be entering through. There's a single

sorcerer that was most likely patrolling the grounds before hearing the distant shimmer of magic. She knows they can't see them. She knows that. She's not going to move. But she can't stop her skin crawling at the green eyes. She's never seen an Etherian with the same eyes as the clones and it's horrifying. There's a person still in there. They think. They don't even know if they can be saved.
The group creep across soft grass as soon as cursed eyes look away.

Mystacor looks remarkably similar to Brightmoon on the inside; same cream-purple walls and round hallways. They only pass one other person that they have to freeze for, thankfully. But she still makes them wait far longer than they perhaps should, there's just dozens faint sounds that *could* be footsteps and she doesn't want to take any chances.

There's only a few turns, all of them making their way quickly and silently. There was a chamber full of floating mirror shards, grand glassless windows, fluffy clouds hugging the towers in the near-distance. And then there's statues; towering and pristine save for one. If it is Shadow Weaver she shows no recognition of her vandalised likeness.
But they do stop at the end of the row, First Ones writing etched into the wall.

"We're going to drop the spell now," Micah whispers back at them.

Glimmer shudders slightly as the runes dissipate, leaning on Bow as he puts an arm around her. Micah isn't afforded the luxury of a break, arms raising in tandem with Weaver's. Just as the writing lights up, the low echo of a step rings in Catra's ears. Except it's growing louder this time.

The wall slides down loudly and she hisses, "Someone's here, go."

Even Weaver listens to her, all of them running into the dark tunnel. She can't even tell if she saw the green eyes simply because she was expecting to. The wall seals behind them and

Micah and Glimmer breathe heavily. Bow hooks his arm through Glimmer's as she forms a globe of light in her palm. (She kind of forgot no one else here can see in the dark.)

She has no idea if anyone saw them run in here, but she knows better than to be complacent in her judgement. She has to assume the worst.

"We have to move quickly now they've seen us." She remembers exactly *why* she thinks like that as she watches Weaver's back.

Glimmer's magic follows her like her own personal star, it's kind of mesmerising when it's not used in combat. Catra doesn't even notice the stories painted on the walls, old and crumbling but not faded.

Bow asks, "What is all this?"

"History," Micah says with something deep and almost calculating. He stops in front of a mural full of eyes and hands reaching for a star. "Our history apparently."

"The Spell of Obtainment was a mistake. One for which I have paid the price."

"Three people were killed because of that spell."

And gods does Catra hate herself, because her first thought is for herself, for the child she once was. She is in no way surprised that Weaver has killed people - she is more shocked that she isn't one of them.

"If you hadn't have broken the connection, it would have *worked*, the Horde would've been gone long ago."

The outrage she is feeling makes her feel better at least; this anger isn't selfish. She is angry that she isn't the only one the bitch talks down to, with no remorse for all the shit she's done. Like everything she's ever done has been necessary or - or that the pain she's caused is an *inconvenience to her*.

“I was a child! I shouldn’t have even known about that kind of magic.” Catra sees herself in Micah’s anger, the way Weaver remains cold to it, disappointed by it.

“You were the most talented sorcerer I had ever met. You could’ve handled it. I’m afraid that title has been passed to your daughter now.”

“Stay away from her.”

Glimmer steps between them, “Dad, can we please keep going, we don’t have a lot of time.”

It’s silent from then on.

The tunnel ends, entering into a larger rounded room. Adora walks forwards, and a rune in the floor illuminates red before fire is shooting up around her. And Catra doesn’t even have to think; she is jumping through flame and calling out for her. Adora didn’t move, so all she has to do is push her back through to the other side. And she does, with perhaps too much force but she cannot care about that.

They crash to the ground together and Adora’s arms come around her, hands on her shoulder blades, as she reassures, “I’m okay, I’m okay.”

She takes a deep breath, resting her forehead to Adora’s shoulder for just a moment. She didn’t feel the fire but maybe she was numbed by adrenaline. She forces a small smile when she raises her head again, heartbeat calming after the violent spike. And that mistake of a smile causes Adora to wear an infuriatingly attractive smug grin. It’s the rare one as well. (It’s the one that has doomed her to trouble a hundred times. And she never cared once.)

“Did you just jump into fire for me?”

She shoves her in the face just to break it. “What? No! Shut up!”

And Adora has the fucking nerve to laugh, even snort and she hates how much she loves it. She climbs off her, ears pinned back as she sits next to her. Adora is still laughing, looking ridiculously soft as she giggles, “You did.”

She just scowls, shoves her in the shoulder. She huffs as she offers Adora a hand to stand up again.

“It’s...an illusion?” Glimmer’s got her hand in the fire when Catra turns around, so she would hope so.

“Some of the fire is illusory, some is very real. Everyone be careful.”

‘Like you care.’

Adora

Everyone save for Weaver is up ahead of her, even Catra who had started at her side. She hadn’t meant to fall back, but she does feel like she needs to be alone now. Not that she’s really alone with the darkness over her shoulder, but Weaver can’t see her hands and that’s what matters.

She tries for She-Ra for the first time since her fools mission. It scared her; the phasing. She-Ra shouldn’t *do* that. She should have better control over her. She made the sword earlier but that was it, she wasn’t pulling magic into every inch of her skin, only her finger tips. But that doesn’t even work now. There’s the bars of light but nothing else.

She wipes the sweat from the fire off her forehead and tries again. And fails. Again. The magic is *there*, she *knows* it is. But it’s like there’s something pushing it down. She grunts softly as she gives up on keeping the tension in her hand. It’s still loud enough for Catra to catch it.

Catra stops and looks over her shoulder, ears back, “Adora?”

She jogs back to her side, forcing a blank expression while Catra silently asks if she's okay. She's not. Fear and doubt are creeping along her tendons. She should've done more training. She should've checked if She-Ra was even still there after she pushed her so far.

"I'm fine."

Obviously Catra doesn't believe her by the way her tail whips against her leg. She thinks Catra's going to retaliate but she's cut off before she even starts:

"- I see you two are close again."

Catra doesn't jump, so she must've known Weaver had gotten closer but Adora certainly hadn't. She doesn't give the witch a response, doesn't have a thought beyond *'get Catra away from her'* as she puts a hand on Catra's hip and pushes her forward quicker.

"Catra, do you really think that's wise?"
She's not sure which of them stops, or maybe they both do. Catra stares resolutely at the fire instead of answering. Adora doesn't even really know what Weaver means by that. If there even is a meaning other than bringing Catra down.
"Can you even get a hold on She-Ra?"

"Yes -"

"- Don't lie to me."

If she were as brave as Catra she'd say, *"Why shouldn't I?"* But she's not, and instead hangs her head as white eyes bear down on the back of her head. She drops her hand from Catra. Whatever Weaver might do will certainly be worse if they're touching when she snaps.

"You can say yes when you can *always* bring her forward."
Her tone is turning more venomous, whether or not she's aware of it. And Adora can't answer. It'll just make her more angry. Or

disappointed. Whichever will make her feel worse. She turns around, as she's been taught to.
"Tell me, does She-Ra stay until you dismiss her? Are you in *complete control*?" And when she still says nothing, "*Answer me*."

"No. But you - you don't know anything about She-Ra." She tries to meet Weaver's eyes as she announces it, but all she's met with is pity. It makes her feel stupid for even trying anything.

"But I know you. I know that Catra distracts you, she always has. Magic needs focus, and yours has always been weakened by your attachments. How long has it been since you last transformed?"

She hates how guilty she feels, how it's made its way to her stomach and twisting her up inside. Shadow Weaver is just confirming what she thought earlier - she should've done *something*. Anything at all. And horribly, she's right about Catra distracting her; she was too swept up in being happy with her. In getting to touch her, hold her, kiss her. (Even if it's not in the way she really wants.) That's not Catra's fault though, it's her own.

The longer she stays silent, the more she can feel Catra growing worried. She wants to reach out for her. She knows she can't. She holds her own hand instead, pushing a thumb into the palm as if it'll make light spill out. It doesn't, it just makes her shake, makes the magic retreat even further. "I -"

"Tell me."

It's like Weaver pulls the words out of throat, "Four days. And she was - she was phasing."

"Catra leave us. We need to talk," she orders without even looking at her.

Catra's fur fluffs up as she bares her teeth, "I'm not leaving you alone with her -"

"- Go." She grits her teeth and screws up her face, something nasty spiking in her chest as she says it. "If she can help me I…"

She must look desperate given how Catra deflates. And then Catra growls, loudly, but she does obey, walking away with her tail snapping and arms crossed. Her ears are twisted back to hear them. It makes her feel a little safer.

Weaver starts walking, expecting her to match the pace. "What happened the last time you transformed?"

"I - I don't know. I - it felt fleeting like I was - like I was losing her." She curses how her voice breaks, half expecting Weaver to comment snidely on it.

She remembers being caught crying by Weaver when she was eleven, she'd hit her head during training and ran away after showering when the cold water made the pain unbearable. *"A Force Captain cannot show any weakness, Adora. No leader can, that is the only way for people to respect them, it is the only way they will be obeyed. And that is what you are destined for, isn't it? Do not let this happen again or there will be consequences."*

"Magic needs precision, for you to be clear headed. It reflects emotion if your attachments are preventing that… Tell me, had something happened with Catra?"

She fights to keep walking. She despises that she's right. She wants to curl in on herself and break something and shout. But she just stays quiet. It's what she's so good at with Weaver, isn't it?
"Not in any way that would put you on Shadow Weaver's bad side." That's what Catra said. And she was right. At the time she thought she was reducing the punishment - and maybe she was. It didn't matter in the end.

Shadow Weaver sighs and stops, "Catra distracts you, confuses you. If you cannot get ahold of She-Ra we are all in danger. And really, haven't you hurt each other enough?"
It makes her eyes burn, anything she might say caught in her throat. She won't cry but her hands are shaking again. It doesn't stop as Weaver puts her cold hands on her shoulders. She should

shove her off, she should move at all but...she doesn't.
And all the accusing disappears, replaced by unsettling softness that she somehow knows she needs, "If you want to save her, focus on protecting her. I am not trying to be cruel, Adora."

It's a lie. Or not. But it's not true - Shadow Weaver is cruel. She *knows this*. "Just tell me what I need to do."

"It is simple, it is what I have tried to instill in you your whole life: do not let your emotions control you. Control *them*. You have strength, Adora, I've always known it. Now, more than ever, it is time for you to prove it."

"I'll - I'll try."

And Weaver snaps back to stone like she always does, it leaves her wincing. "Adora, we cannot afford *try* anymore. If we have any chance of stopping Horde Prime for good we need She-Ra. The world - the universe - needs She-Ra right now, not Adora."

She rips her body away from her, wanting to scratch her touch off. She manages to stand tall, feeling anything but confident as she says, "And I'll do it. No matter what I am *saving everyone*."

She wants to run to Catra up ahead but she can't. Not after that. Not with Weaver's eyes on her and this crushing weight on her lungs. She can't tell Catra about this. Unless she heard it all. Oh gods what if she heard it all? She probably did. Her tail is still, in fact her whole body is almost rigid as she walks. And on top of everything, there's dread for what this means.

She crushes it down. This - *everything* - is almost over. She can talk to Catra after. She can't think about Catra right now. She can't think about anything but finishing this.

They pass through the false fire again, and she's blinded for a moment as they're plunged into a much darker room. It's

beautiful once her eyes adjust, all things considered; the towering crystal obelisk is perfect despite its age, glowing softly blue.

"*That's* the Failsafe?" Glimmer asks incredulously.

"It's bigger than I thought it'd be. How are we gonna get that to the Heart?" Bow has a good point. The crystal is about as tall as the grand halls in Brightmoon's castle.

"The failsafe is a code. It's stored inside the crystal," Shadow Weaver says like that's obvious.

They all walk forward, she doesn't get to stop like the others, Weaver's hand on her back pushing her towards the platform. No one else follows them this close and she understands but she feels vulnerable, isolated.

She asks, "So, what do we -"

"It needs a password." Weaver takes her hand and lays her palm on the crystal's cold smooth surface before she steps away. "Given what activated the hologram, I think you already know what it is."

"We're friends of Mara."
The light flares inside, shooting up the structure as she jumps back. It splits in three, the symbols and words lighting up.

Glimmer behind her asks, "What does it say?"

"'*Someone needs to go inside and accept the failsafe.'* What does *that* mean?"

"It means the failsafe must be bonded to a willing soul and carried to the Heart of Etheria in their body in order to be deployed."

And something settles over her. Battle calm, perhaps. Clarity at least, even though she *doesn't* understand. It's going to be her, like always. That's what she knows.

"And we're sure that's safe?"

Shadow Weaver doesn’t even acknowledge Bow behind her, even though how worried he sounds makes Adora want to turn to him. It’s prodding at her resolve. “We can't turn back now. The fate of the world is right here in our grasp, we can’t lose it to Prime now.”

And she’s right. She hates it. Gods does she. She doesn’t want to agree with Shadow Weaver. But she’s fucking right - they can’t lose this now. This is the only advantage they’ve ever had. And she has to do this.
She looks up at the orb feeding the Failsafe overhead, it’s pure whiteness. She can’t think about what it might do to her. It doesn’t matter anyway.

She starts forward, foot barely making it over the threshold before; “Adora, don't go in there.” And Catra’s pulling her back by the wrist.

Weaver hisses, “Catra, this is not the time. Someone must take the failsafe.”

But Catra’s spent too long with that tone, only responding to it with anger. Catra’s face is set as she pulls her further from the Failsafe, and off the platform.
“So, you do it, then. I've been watching you, but I bet you knew that. You've been in here before, haven't you? You could've taken the failsafe yourself and gotten all the power you've ever wanted. But you didn't. Why?”

She’s proud of Catra for a lot of things right now. She could not articulate why, she just is. There is so much pulsing through her chest, so much she is ignoring and pushing down but still that gets through. But Catra shouldn’t bother; she’s going to do this, she can’t see any way it’s not going to be her. She can’t let anyone else take the risk. Catra’s still trying for her anyway.

And she loves her so much. And she needs to protect her. Protect all of them.
Which means she’ll do this.
Which means that Shadow Weaver is right.

Even if this is all a manipulation into Weaver getting power and magic and whatever else she wants...there isn't a way she *can't* go through with it. Catra just can't see that yet.

Catra

"You're being paranoid. This is not a grab for power, you selfish wretch, this is about saving the world. Adora understands that well enough." She manages not to flinch at the insult or Weaver waving her arms even as her body prepares to be hit.

She grips Adora's wrist tighter, growl coming through in her words, "Why does it have to be Adora? What is going to happen to her? What aren't you telling us?"

If she lets Adora go through with this she might never forgive herself. She owes it to Adora to not let her go through with this. She has been trying, trying her fucking best to get her to see she doesn't have to give everything for this war. And Weaver is here to poison her again. She shouldn't have left them alone.

Weaver glares at her but shrinks. She's sure it's just because there's others, but Weaver actually takes a step back under the scrutiny.

"Answer the question." She doesn't think she's ever seen Micah this cold.

Shadow Weaver brings her hands in front of herself, ease coming back into her body and Catra can't even comprehend how she can do that in front of them. "Whoever uses the failsafe must absorb the full magic of the Heart when it is destroyed. That much raw magical power would burn any mere mortal apart." Catra gets a sick feeling in her stomach as the witch looks at Adora, all inevitable expectation.
"None of us are strong enough -"

"But She-Ra is. That's why you..." Adora trails off sounding defeated.

“Yes. We all need her. This isn’t a choice. Only She-Ra can hope to survive the process. No one else can do it.”

Catra looks at Adora, Adora looks at the Failsafe - at the world she has to save. So tragically like the past three years she feels it tear through her body.

“And if I don't survive it?”

She wants to scream. How is Adora even considering this?

“Then the magic will be restored to Etheria through your sacrifice. You will give us the power to defeat Prime and save the Universe. Your friends, everyone that lives and breathes, will be free.”

Weaver has the fucking nerve to come closer, to actually put a hand on Adora’s shoulder and Catra can’t take it. She shoves Shadow Weaver away shouting, “You fucking witch!”

And it seems to be enough to reanimate everyone else:
“You planning on endangering - *sacrificing* - another child?”
“How can you even fucking suggest that? We’re not going to sacrifice fucking anyone!”
“There is no way we're risking Adora like that!”

Adora’s curling in on herself, she’s rigid - preparing for something. Preparing to take the failsafe. And she has to stop it. This is about Adora, not Shadow Weaver. Adora’s pulling away from her hold, but she won’t let her. She gets as close as she can without overwhelming her, holds Adora’s face in her hands.

“Adora just look at me,” and when she does, all wide fearful eyes, “Adora please. Don’t do this to me again. Don’t do this to *yourself*. We can find another way -”

“- We don’t have time for another way, Catra. I - I don’t have a choice. I'm sorry.” She can’t speak as Adora breaks away from her. “Stop it! I'll do it.”

Adora gets back to the platform before she feels like she can move. She knows she looks as desperate as she feels, clawing at Adora's hand to just *stop* her. "No! What's wrong with you? Shadow Weaver is sacrificing you. Why can't you see that?"

"Because it doesn't matter if she is. This is the only way -"

She's about to do something *drastic* when someone else comes through the fire on the other side of the room. Sorcerers with green eyes, four of them. And then Adora's shoving her out the way of a spell, hard enough that her hands find the stone at the bottom of the dais. The colour of the magic is so dark it blends with the unlit room, and Adora gets hit. Dragged down to the floor by black tentacles; black magic.

She cries out Adora's name on instinct, not even realising she does it. It's not exactly the first time she's seen Adora trapped in dark magic, but it's the first time there's no anger keeping how sick it makes her feel at bay.

But Adora breaks free of it, remarkably easily actually. A weak spell then. If these are meant to be the good guys then that makes sense, they're simply not used to this type of power. That's an advantage. One she never had when faced with Weaver.

She leaps at the closest sorcerer, letting Bow's net arrow take them down first before she's tackling them to the ground. She can't sink her claws into these people, and it's when she's thinking about how to incapacitate them without lasting injury that the magician under her lights up blue. It pushes her off them with invisible force, makes her fur fluff up the way all magic does.

She looks around and sees Shadow Weaver get hit by a light spell. And there's two voices in her head, one bitter saying she should've had a taste of her own power, the other that actually cares if she's injured. She hates both of them.

A red orb goes flying past her shoulder, it eats away at the wall where it hits. She jumps out the way of the next one easily, and

keeps dodging as she tries to figure how to knock them out without getting hit or getting them hurt too badly. There's already one enemy slumped against the wall, purple shimmer around his head.

She calls out to Glimmer, and when the sorcerer turns around expecting an attack, Catra jumps on their back and binds their hands. Glimmer teleports closer to put them to sleep with her magic but she's hit with another bout of dark energy when she materialises.

She hears Adora shout out Glimmer's name, Bow too. She manages to run to her without getting hit, she gets an arm under Glimmer to help her up and the Queen shoots sparkles at the sorcerer she had pinned before. Bow fires an arrow at the next magician that was aiming for them, but they still manage to send the shot for them before getting tangled up. Catra pushes Glimmer off her, watching as the sorcerer breaks the net by freezing it. Bow's just lucky only his arm got sliced by the flying shards.

He shouts over the battle, "We have to get out of here!" like that's not fucking obvious.

"The failsafe! We can't!"

Maybe she can't afford to look at Adora, but she does it anyway. She gets roped in void for it, but even the way her skin screeches with the memory of pain far worse than she's feeling, she's watching Adora get closer to that thing. Adora is resigning herself to this, she's really going to do it.

Adora might die here.

And she struggles against the magic holding her down, manages to scream, "Adora! Gods *please* it doesn't always have to be *you*!"

Adora doesn't listen.

“Adora!” she yells her name again, and it might be pleading or something else. Everything inside her is telling her it matters that she keep calling out for her but it *doesn’t*. Adora’s bathed in the light, it’s feeding into her and drawing on her skin and clothes as she cries out. And Catra watches the woman she loves in pain. And she’s helpless. More helpless than she’s ever felt.

She can’t even tell that she’s crying until the image of Adora being drawn off the ground by the Failsafe is blurry. She’s not the only one shouting; Bow and Glimmer are too, bound in magic like she is. Maybe Micah is still casting, maybe he’s not trapped, she wouldn’t know.
She’s panicked and her heart’s breaking and she can’t *breathe*. And she knows the spell is weak, she might even be able to break out of it, but in her distress she doesn’t even think to try.

And Adora shouts her stupid little catchphrase. And Catra’s relieved and she’s angry and she’s still got water running down her face and something feels fragile and weak in her chest. She’s blinded by light she knows is She-Ra. She’d know it anywhere, she doesn’t need the screech of chipped sorcerers.

The spell lets her go but she can’t stand, everything is heavy and her heart is beating loud but weak in her ears. It’s swallowing up everything else. She manages to sit up at least. She still wants to retch from the magic that she’s going to feel in her skin for days.

She hears She-Ra before she really grasps that she’s in front of her. “I've got it. I've got the failsafe. Let's get out of here.”

A symbol - a heart of all things - burns on She-Ra’s chest and it’s all she can look at, the beating glow of it. That’s going to save them. And she doesn’t care. She cares about what Adora just did. The risk she just took.

'I almost lost her.'
‘Adora doesn’t care.’
‘Adora cares too much.’

Maybe they're not all true, but she doesn't know that. Adora still sacrificed everything again. For everyone else. Because Shadow Weaver told her to. And nothing has really changed. And she was a fool for believing it had.

She-Ra offers her hand and she can barely meet her eyes for a second before she takes off running back through the fire.

Chapter End Notes

I wanna know if y'all think Catra's gonna leave next chapter or not.

Let Me Hear You Say

Chapter Notes

Added a new song to the playlist for this

Catra

She is angry. And hurt. And scared. And frustrated and - and there has never been a time in her life where she has felt more than this.

She can't look at She-Ra without her eyes burning, without wanting to cry or scream or tear anything that will shriek under her claws. Not even the time she had alone back at the entrance of the tunnel numbed anything. She wants to run. She used to do that in the Fright Zone; the dark corners hiding her even if they were never safe. There's nowhere familiar like that anymore. Not here, not in Brightmoon.

The teleport back makes her retch. It's weak and she can feel Weaver's eyes looking at her with veiled disgust, she shoves Adora's worried hands off her. She intends to rush back through the barrier, fighting off any clones that try to stop them before curling up on Adora's floor for the night. Maybe even her balcony. Or her bathroom, at least that's closed off.

But her caution, her adrenaline, isn't needed; there's no clones. There's nothing. And it makes her feel worse, causes the acid in her stomach to rise back into her throat. The castle and barrier are intact. It's just silent. *Something* must have happened, even if it's not obvious what. Or maybe something is *going* to happen.

"Everyone inside."

She-Ra's voice makes her angry enough that a pressure builds behind her eyes.

Glimmer opens the spell and they all file in. There's still warships in the sky, more than there should be, all cruising slowly like storm clouds. And somehow this is worse just because it's new. Being watched she's used to, not knowing what's coming next...well she's never liked it.

"Prime's flagship…" Glimmer says with fearful awe.

The group all turn, see the monstrosity hanging in the sky on the other side of the woods. It's static, thankfully. Prime has to be moving in for the kill. There's no way he'd risk exposure like this. They're out of time.

'At least we have the failsafe now.' She cringes at her own thought.
It makes her feel sick; that she can't even be hopeful, that she can't see this as a good thing at all. All she sees is a weapon buried in Adora's chest. One that Adora accepted without a fight. A lamb waiting for the dagger to be pulled out.

She starts walking again before anyone else, arms crossed over her chest as if it'll protect her. She's already hurt. It doesn't matter. She gets stopped by Glimmer's aunt rushing across the bridge to meet them. She would push past but;

"The barrier won't hold much longer. A few days at most."

"I've got the failsafe, I can leave tomorrow."

She feels like her lungs have just been crushed. Tomorrow. Tomorrow means she only has tonight. She hears her heartbeats like a countdown in her ears. A countdown to what, she's not sure. Until they win? Until Adora sacrifices herself for the planet? Until she loses the love of her life for good?

Because she can't entertain the idea that Adora will survive this. Assume the worst. Be prepared for anything. Except she can't possibly be prepared. How the fuck does she even begin to - to imagine this? To start planning for a world without Adora, a - a *life*

without her? She's already tried that. And she became the worst version of herself.

She’s selfish. So atrociously selfish and evil for thinking that if Adora dies she wants the world to be swallowed up with her as punishment; *this what you made her do.* Adora would hate her for even thinking it. The world is who she’s doing this for, the *only* thing Adora wants is for the world to be safe.

‘She doesn’t want you. She’s never wanted you. She wouldn’t do this if she did.’
She’s not even asking Adora to love her. She’s asking her to love herself.
‘Except you’re not asking, are you?’

“I’ll leave first thing in the morning.” There’s no room for anyone to question her.

She can’t do this. She can’t even look at her.

Adora doesn’t care what happens to her. Catra doesn’t *understand*. How can she love her this much, care about her *this fucking much*, while Adora sees herself as something with no more worth than a cog in a machine?

No one says anything. They just get ushered inside. She thinks someone says something about getting food. She hasn’t eaten for hours and she doesn’t feel it past the dread. She just follows, silent and obedient for no other reason than that she’s trapped inside her own head. It’s only once they’re in the kitchens (she knows they walked, she’s just not sure why, but she is relieved) that she realises Weaver isn’t with them. Micah’s gone too.

Something puts her on high alert again. She’s tired and miserable and silently despairing and just confused and hurt and she doesn’t want to feel anything. There’s other people here; refugees glaring hatefully at her. If they talk to her she’ll snap, she knows she will. She’ll shout and growl and lash out the way she’s always been

good at. People used to run from her. She thinks she wants them to.

She doesn't. Not really. She just wants to stop existing in this moment.

She looks at Glimmer and Bow, not desolate, but nowhere near happy either. They're pretending to be okay, ignoring the worry. But it is *just* worry. (And maybe that's horrible and inaccurate and ignorant of her to think but she doesn't care.) They're not heartbroken like she is.

There's no one here who understands how she feels, not really. Sometimes she feels like she's the only person in the world who can feel this way about another person; so completely and utterly consumed by love that it could drive her insane if she let it. (She practically did.) It seems like other people know how she feels about Adora but no one's ever outright accused her of it. Save for Scorpia, and she deserved that. And she can't - she can't talk to her. She can't do that to her after everything.
And really, she doubts she'd even be able to tell her anything given the state she's in.

She's isolated and alone in this. And there's no one she even wants to try and reach out for. Everyone else *wants* Adora to do this. They don't want her dead, but they want the war over. They want to be safe and free and Catra can hardly fault them for that. But she can't think beyond now and what this *thing* stored inside Adora might do to her. Love makes people weak - it makes her weak, it always has. Shadow Weaver knew that.

Shadow Weaver... Catra can understand her through the hatred, she expects this of her. The dooming of Adora to a demise she planned - it's control and it's manipulation and it's expecting Adora to obey her. (*'And she did. Barely even questioned it.'*) But the Princesses are meant to be the good guys. They're meant to stop this, talk Adora out of it, find another way. *Anything* but this.

How is *she* the only one thinking like this? It's selfish, gods she knows it's selfish. But it's *good* but it's *not* and -

She hears her own name whispered with malice from the end of the room and it makes something crack.

She wants to leave.

She doesn't want to be here anymore. Not in this castle with these people who she looks at and feels unearned betrayal. Not in this place that stinks of Weaver's magic, even if she is just imagining it. Not when half of her feels like the villain again. She feels so *alone*; might as well make it official. She *might as well* have control over it.

But she can't. She can't leave Adora.
She's never been the one to leave. That's not her role. She's the one who stays. For worse. Always, it seems, for the worst.

"Come on, let's get some sleep."

It doesn't even matter who says it. She follows the three of them aimlessly and forces herself not to cringe away or hiss or snap at Adora when she turns back to her. Adora doesn't say anything and she's honestly not sure if that's worse.

It all turns in her head, over and over. She's not nauseous anymore but with everything screaming in her chest it doesn't even matter. She's a coward. She's never been before but this has made her one. Too scared to leave. And too scared to stay.

Adora promised she'd stay.

That's what does it.

Because suddenly she can pass this off on anything other than heartbroken cowardice. She's running *for* Adora. She can't go through with another broken promise. The one they made long ago is so much more than broken; it's ash lost to the wind. They had each other this time and everything still happened. But she

can *keep* this one if she makes it so. Adora can't leave if she does it first.

And the storm doesn't pass. But she doesn't exactly feel it either. Numbed with grim resolve. She keeps moving when Bow and Glimmer stop, not hearing footsteps cease.

Glimmer grabs onto Adora's arm and pulls her back, saying, "Oh no, you're staying with us before you do something else stupid. And besides...it's been too long."

Catra can't even bring herself to fake a smile. She's going to carry on walking to Adora's room and curl up on top of her sheets alone until she can bring herself to leave. "I'll...see you tomorrow." Gods she hopes none of them can tell how close she is to crying.

"Where do you think you're going?" She stops but doesn't turn, not even when Bow puts a hand on her shoulder. "Best Friend Squad includes you too, come on."

"I'm…"
She thinks about refusing, but she's not angry at Bow, well, not enough to deny him. Not when she's - when she might never see him again. Oh gods she hasn't thought this through. She doesn't know if she can look at any of them ever again if Adora dies. She'll - she'll try. She'll come back one day, maybe. If only to see Scorpia and Entrapta again.
"Alright. But I'm going to get a few things first."

Adora looks confused but she can't explain anything to her. She just walks away. Tells herself it's practice.

She knows Adora has a small rucksack in her closet. Because they share it now, they share this room, just the two of them - and she can't think about that. Now or ever again. She can explain away most of what she has to put in it if necessary. And really there's not much, it's not like she can take her books or chess set with

her. And she doesn't want to, not if this is going to end how she thinks it will. She won't be able to handle the reminder.

She gets a water canister, spare outfit and a blanket that smells like *them*, claws catching on every item as she folds them as tightly as she's able to. And that's really it. It's nothing.
'Adora didn't even pack a bag when she left you.'

She grabs both hers and Adora's toothbrushes just to sell the lie. Gods she hates herself.

She's going through drawers as a precaution when she finds it; her old mask buried under Adora's clothes. The sight of it alone makes her cold. And conflicted. And touched and hurt all over again. Because Adora fucking cares, she kept this thing, as worthless as it is.
She means something to Adora, she knows she always has after everything that's happened between them. She just doesn't mean *enough*.

She grabs the bag and near runs to Glimmer's room.

Adora breathes a sigh of relief as she enters and it makes her feel indescribably worse. She sits down with them silently, mostly just looking up at Glimmer's bed high above them and wondering how unbearably soft it might be. She's never actually been in Glimmer (and Bow's) room. Inside her head she laughs at herself; she's in the Queen of the Rebellion's room by invitation.

The other three people in the room try their best to pretend like nothing's happened. They talk and they laugh reservedly and eat and Adora looks at her when she'd normally comment on something. When they're done, Catra suggests they put the rest of their food in the bag she brought. She gives Adora her toothbrush, goes into Glimmer's bathroom after her.

Adora doesn't say anything about her seemingly forgetting to bring their night clothes. Glimmer gives them each a heap of

blankets and cushions to sleep on before teleporting Bow and herself up to their bed. Catra wonders if the floating platforms were put in before or after they got together as she sits down on the ground. Adora keeps a distance between them as she crafts her makeshift bed. Glimmer probably expected them to sleep on the window seat. It doesn't matter.

She sees Adora still in the corner of her vision, then take off her jacket and boots, pull her hair down. And she watches when Adora looks at her for approval. Like this was a peace offering. "Cat, I know you're angry with me. But please, please just…"

She bites on the inside of her cheek to stop herself from making any miserable sound, breathes through her nose for a minute. "...Goodnight, Adora."

She doesn't sleep. Doesn't cry either beyond a single silent tear that she can't stop. She's going to leave. She will. As soon as Adora falls asleep behind her. At least that's how she thinks for a few hours.

Her resolve starts crumbling. It's like it was back at the start; wanting to leave and stay so badly. If she started crying, Adora would comfort her, hold her, stop her leaving. She could crawl into her arms right now. She doesn't hate herself for wanting it like she used to. In some ways she wishes she still did, it would mean without a doubt that she wouldn't do it.

She can make that self loathing come back. She can force bad feelings easily. And she does, let's her mind spit every black thought it can.

'You hurt her just by staying.'
'She doesn't love you the way you want her too for a reason.'
'You're a distraction.'
'You're holding her back.'
'Who loves the thorn in their side?'
'Adora wants to save everyone. It isn't your choice to make.'

'You don't know what's best for the world.'
'You don't even know what's best for yourself.'
'Adora can't do this if you're here.'
'If she fails it'll be your fault.'

By the time Adora's breathing does ease into something like sleep she's in so deep that moving doesn't break her. She's disconnected. The bag sits by the door, she doesn't go to it immediately. She doesn't know whether it's better or worse that she can look at Adora now.

There's no peace in Adora's face. Still resigned, still tired, still sad. And she can't leave her without a goodbye, can't sneak out like Adora did all those years ago. She slinks over to her, silently like her training taught her to. Adora is completely still, almost too still, not that she can really realise that right now.

She sighs, giving in. She's leaving, she can have this for the moments she has left. This is going to be permanent. She strokes the back of her hand down the side of Adora's face as softly as she can, freezes when Adora's breath hitches. That dread is back, dark and heavy.

Adora doesn't open her eyes when she whispers as quietly as she can, "What's wrong?"

'What isn't?'

Her voice is thick in her throat as she whispers, "I didn't mean to wake you. Go back to sleep."

Adora turns her face into her hand and it makes her heart ache. "Wasn't sleeping. Not until you did."

She mumbles, "Selfless moron," barely loud enough for Adora to hear. She debates her next mistake for far less time than she ought to. She wouldn't do it if Adora hadn't done *that*. But she did, and she lets herself kiss Adora's forehead lightly, as if it'll convey how sorry she is.

And she manages to pull away from the person that means everything to her afterwards. Manages to pick up the bag and open the door before Adora sits up, “Where are you going?”

“Just for a walk.” Not technically a lie. Not the truth either. She’s trying to protect her, protect both of them, that’s all that matters.

“...Want me to come with you?”

“No, it’s alright. I’ll be fine.” She leaves the room with Adora’s eyes on her the whole time. She says, “Goodbye Adora,” to a closed door.

The minutes blend as she wanders through identical hallways. She doesn’t have the presence of mind to figure out where to go from memory. She’ll find the entrance eventually. The guards don’t pay any more attention to her than a long look, like they’ll do something if she does. But the people, not so much. They talk, and without the protection of their beloved She-Ra, it’s not sugar coated. It makes it easier.
She doesn’t want to be here.

She ends up where she was heading for, walks freely through the towering arch, gets bathed in the light of the Moonstone. And hears footsteps. Someone was waiting, the sound just starts, it doesn’t fade in.
Adora’s not quiet enough in her following, doesn't keep enough distance. She doesn't know whether it's on purpose or not. She decides it doesn't matter, just plays this sadistic little game of keeping up the ruse for far longer than she should. Adora didn’t believe her flimsy lies. She’s learning.

She gets all the way to the barrier line, making sure she’s far from any sorcerer before she addresses the woman behind her. “Adora I know you’re there.”

Footsteps stop. “What are you doing?”

She sighs, looking dejectedly at blue ground, the tree line is just on the other side of the pink wall. She can run to it in seconds. "Think you can figure that out."

"No - no you need to say it." Adora...Adora doesn't *get* to have her voice break like that. Like she's terrified, like her heart's breaking too. She can sound like any emotion but that one.

"I… I'm leaving Adora." It takes the air out of her saying it.

And Adora is silent. She never thought she'd say those words either. She never thought she'd leave in the first place. But she has to, for both of them. She's a distraction and a corruption to Etheria's hero. She makes Adora worse. And neither of them - the Universe - can afford that anymore.
She runs.

"What? No - *no*, Catra!" sounds in the near distance, distorted by the magic before it clears.

Adora is following her. She can't *do that*… But she *wants* her to. She stops, sheltered in trees. There should be danger here, but Prime has left it. There's nothing, the woods are empty. A warning maybe, a manipulation, a tactical maneuver. It's a cruel reminder; that they don't know what they're doing. That She-Ra and the failsafe are all they have left.

Adora stops behind her, breathing hard and heartbeat pounding in the eerily silent forest. She should keep on running but she can't make her feet move; something - *Adora* - is stopping her. Her own damn feelings are stopping her.

"I'm *trying* to -" she cuts herself off with something like a growl and a sigh, "I'm...a distraction. I am. The witch is fucking right. I...confuse you. She-Ra she's...Weaver knows magic, I don't. And I hate listening to her but I can't be the one holding you back. So Adora don't - don't make this harder."

It's all true. Even if she's withholding the actual reason.

“If it’s so hard don’t *leave*. Stay with me.”

She hasn’t looked at her this whole time. She wants to give into the pleading so badly. She wants Adora wanting her. She focuses on the anger, the hurt instead. “Oh you can *not* say that to me.”

She starts walking and hears a quiet curse behind her. She pretends Adora is desperate for her. She can live in her delusion so long as she can hear Adora’s footfalls running to catch her up. Adora rounds her, hands gripping her arms to make her stop. And she does. And she looks at Adora’s frightened face for the first time. Because she’s weak...and deep down she wants Adora to convince her to stay.

And she might. With how Adora’s looking at her, with how tightly she’s holding onto her. “Why? Why are you doing this? We were *good* before she came back -”

She considers running. If she ran as fast as she could Adora wouldn’t be able to follow. But she looks at the brand pulsing on Adora’s chest, the literal manifestation of her heart; her love for the world. And she can’t just leave her without an explanation. Even if she wants to. Even if she wants Adora to feel even a fraction of her years worth of hurt.

She stares off into the woods, “If I don’t leave now then you will. You said - you said you wouldn’t leave me again ‘Dora but...that’s exactly what you’re doing. You keep your promise this way.”

Adora looks near *horrified*, “That’s not what I’m - Catra I -“

And she snaps, “- Tell me, what do you think the Heart’s going to do to you?”

Adora pauses. “I don’t know.”

“Did you even stop to think what the Failsafe might have done to you?”

“I couldn’t. You heard what Shadow Weaver said. It has to be She-Ra.”
She scoffs, all venom. Backs out of Adora’s hold on her, fighting the shiver from the wind.
“I have to do this Catra. I’m the only one who can.”

She snarls. It doesn’t matter if it’s true. She doesn’t care if it is. She shoves Adora in the chest hard, hands passing through that fucking parasitic thing living on her. “Why? Why does it always have to be you? Why can’t you just think about yourself for one fucking second?”

“I can’t! You know I can’t! I’m doing this. Catra I couldn’t live with myself if anyone else…I’m not sitting by and watching any one else get hurt because I didn't do anything.”

“You’re right. You won’t watch anyone else get hurt. You know why? You’ll be dead.” She was gesturing wildly with claws before, but her arms drop heavy as lead to her sides. She felt her stomach protest her saying it, almost couldn’t get it out through the sickness she feels.

Adora’s righteous pleading breaks. She ought not be angry that Adora dares to have the shine of tears in her eyes. But she is.

“Why are you doing this to me?” It’s a broken, watery whisper at best.

And it destroys her. She’s ricocheting back and forth between wanting to cut Adora down and feeling horrified with herself for wanting it at all. She’s lashing out again. And then turning it inward. She’s trying to push Adora away but clinging to any string to pull her back in.

‘You don’t want to do this.’ She can’t let herself listen.

She sniffs, rubbing at her eyes. “I’m sorry, I - *Adora* - fuck, it already feels like I’m missing you, okay?” Adora doesn’t look any better, in fact that makes the first tear fall. “Adora my whole life has revolved around you in one way or another. And I don’t know

what - I don’t know how to live if you’re gone. I can’t *watch you* leave me when you know exactly what you’re doing this time.”

Adora doesn’t even hesitate to - to fucking rush forward and *hold her*. And she fights to not lean into the hands on her face. And succeeds. And it feels like she’s picking stitches.

“You think I don’t feel the same? Catra I can’t watch you walk away again knowing this might be the last time I ever see you.”

She tears the hands away from her face, eyes burning with tears as she spits, “Then don’t watch.” She gets all of three steps.

“This isn’t you - it’s her, Catra, she’s in your head again. You wouldn’t -“

And she has to turn around, “She’s in yours too. You did everything she told you, do you even realise that?” Adora just glances at the ground, at the trees, anything but her. “You stood up to her before. I know you can do it so *why didn’t you*?”

“I - It’s not about *me* Catra. It’s about Etheria and the entire fucking Universe that I can save if I - if *She-Ra* does this!”

“If *She-Ra* does this you might not survive! Does that mean anything to you?”

Adora sighs, body showing all her resignation and exhaustion. “It can’t.”

She's heard that so many times in the past few minutes. She hates those two words. But she gets closer, claws at Adora’s arms because she needs to understand her right now. “Adora what the fuck do you mean ‘it can’t’?”

“It can’t matter Catra. I always knew I’d die to end this war. I was prepared for you to kill me that day. This isn’t any different.”

She hears static. Lets Adora go in shock.
“How can you think that little of yourself?” Adora had said it to

her months ago, she feels it like a siren in her head, she wants to scream it back at her.

Instead she chokes out, "Adora do you *want* to do this? Do you want to die for this?"

Adora wipes her face with her sleeve, "It doesn't matter what I *want*. It never does, never has. I - I have to do this."

All the anger she tries to muster falls flat, she just sounds broken, "And *I don't have to watch*. Goodbye Adora."

"Bye Adora. I really am going to miss you." She could say it. It would make this a cleaner break - at least at first. Adora wouldn't follow her. But...she's selfish and horrible and poison. She wants her to follow her, wants to try and believe Adora cares about something other than the world for a second.
She doesn't run as fast as she can. As fast as she *should.*

"Please, gods Catra, please don't *leave*."

She lets Adora tackle her to the forest ground, prolonging the inevitable like it seems she's always done. The bag gets ripped off her back and she doesn't care. When the world stops spinning, Adora is on top of her, holding both her wrists. The only way she's getting out of this is if Adora lets her go or if she makes her bleed.

And Adora's crying, properly now. Her face is blotchy with red and moonlight that's breaking through the tree canopy, entirely captivating. "What can I do? Just tell me what I can do to make you stay!"

She cries her own tears looking at the blue gleam of the failsafe. Adora lets her hands go but she doesn't move. She feels pathetic, lying on the ground crying. And when Adora gathers her up in her arms, she clings onto her. She tries to think and even though she is drowning in her unearned grief, the answer comes to her all too quickly.

She gasps against Adora's shoulder, forcing the words out, “Come with me. Come with me and stay alive.”
It feels too vulnerable. Like she's giving away too much. It's some sick mirror of Thaymore, that right now she's asking Adora to run away with her

She can’t hope. She *doesn’t* hope when Adora holds her head, brings their foreheads together. She knows better than that. The water is drying in her fur and she can’t even bring herself to get rid of it.

“Catra it’s me or the whole Universe. It’s *everyone else*.”
Adora sniffs miserably, and Catra’s shocked silent as Adora reaches up and pushes her hair back from her face with trembling fingers. All the breath rushes out of her.
“What kind of person would I be if I chose myself?”

“...A person like me.”

When she opens her eyes, she can’t read Adora’s face at all. Maybe reminding her how awful and selfish she is will make Adora give up on her, maybe Adora will push her away.
Adora won’t. She never has. But she might let her leave.

Adora stands up slowly, face blank apart from the shimmer of tears clinging to her skin. Catra gets up after her, and looks out at the woods. It’s lonely and quiet and tense with waiting. It’s like Etheria knows something’s going to happen to it, that it’s going to get caught in the crossfire.

This time when she walks Adora doesn’t follow. She just speaks. And maybe Adora knows what kind of power she has over her, maybe she doesn’t, maybe she’s learning right now.
“You keep asking me if I want to die. Do *you want to leave me*?”

She halts, laughs bitterly at the sky. This is it. It has to be it. She can’t keep spilling all the excuses she’s fabricated. She’s running out of them. She just needs to leave. Or she needs to be honest.

Glimmer whispers in her head, *"Well, at least I don't have to worry about this ending badly without ever telling him how I feel."*

She doesn't - she doesn't have to say everything. She doesn't think she *could*. But...she could say something. Enough for her to not regret it. Adrenaline clouds her mind as she *genuinely* considers it. Just...just enough. Enough is all she needs.

'Adora deserves to die knowing she's loved.'

It makes her exhale brokenly. She doesn't know whether that's selflessness speaking, or whether she's trying to dig her own grave or - or she's just trying to hurt herself more. But it works. Enough is all she needs. More than she's given before.

"No. I don't want to leave you. Adora I...I want to be with you all the time. I want to be *around you* all the time. It feels like - like I have spent every second of my life thinking about you. Waiting for the moments when you look at me. I am selfish. And mean and jealous and I was never meant to amount to anything. I stayed in that place knowing it was destroying me and everything else just to prove someone wrong."
Her heart is beating out of her chest, entire body bracing for what Adora's going to say when she's done. She feels stripped down and bare and raw and she wants to run more than ever.
"I don't leave. But I will, for you, like I should've done the first fucking time."

It's quiet for a long, unbearably, terrifyingly long time. She just stands there all but panting with how rough and fast her breath is coming. Maybe Adora is realising just how much she's hidden, how misleading everything she's ever said is. Maybe she's figuring out the *why* for every word and touch that crossed the line of friendship.

Her mind is shouting all the horrible thoughts from before. And she's crying again, fear overwhelming now. And it doesn't even fucking matter. Adora doesn't *get it*, just asks in something akin to a whimper, "So this is it?"

Her hands are shaking and she can't even crush them into fists without slicing them open. She nods, still turned away from her, still alone with these feelings.

Some weary sound falls through her teeth at the sudden feeling of Adora's hand on her skin. Adora turns her around gently and she can't for the life of her look at her face. Not after that. She wonders if Adora can hear the scream of her heartbeat like she can.

"I'm going to miss you. I'm - I'm going to be thinking about you no matter what. If - if I don't come back from this, you - I promise you're the last thing I'm going to think about." Adora rests their foreheads together and sighs tiredly, "*Gods* it feels like I'm always thinking about you… Please don't hate me for this."

She forces herself to look up, about to ask 'for what?' just to make this worse. To drive herself away.

But Adora's looking down, below her eyes. Adora's not going to leave first. Adora's got tears streaked down her face and she's shining from the glow of the failsafe. Adora's heartbeat is as fast as hers.

'Make her leave.'
'Make yourself leave.'
'This is the last time you'll ever get to.'

They're standing so close that Adora's chest brushes hers as they breathe. The failsafe is passing through her chest too and she doesn't even feel it. She doesn't think about it. She thinks about something she's been keeping at bay her whole life. It would be so *easy*. It would make Adora let her go. And maybe she'll hate herself for the rest of her life. It might mean that the last she ever sees of Adora is pity in her eyes, face hard with rejection. She'll live with it. She'll -

"Don't hate me either."

And in the end, she doesn't know who closes the gap.

She knows Adora is kissing her back. That she's got her hands either side of Adora's face from bringing her down. She also knows that Adora is pushing into her with as much desperation as she is, or at least it feels that way.

And it's a free fall beyond that. Every time she's thought about this is howling in the back of her mind and she *won't listen*. Adora's hands are on her hips, cautious but firm. If she weren't so scared, heartbroken, desperate and so many other things, she might find it grounding. It's anything but.

This isn't sweet like it should be. Her claws have got to be digging into the skin on the back of Adora's neck through her hair, and Adora's holding on to her so hard she'll have bruises. It almost makes her cry, that if she loses Adora she'll have this left; her fingerprints under her fur for a few days.
And she can't even let herself have this, can she? She has to ruin it for herself just like everything else.

She crushes thoughts under the messy slide of their lips. She can't afford to be careful, not that Adora seems to mind when her lip gets caught under her fang. Having Adora whimper against her mouth snaps something inside her. She doesn't even know why they're doing this. If there even is a why. She doesn't need anymore reasons than Adora is letting her have this.

Everything feels dangerous to do. She doesn't know if she's allowed to growl when Adora parts for air, or wind her claws into her hair the way she's always dreamed of. But she does, and anything could be the thing that makes Adora stop. Realise who she's kissing, that Catra's kissing her like she's been waiting for this her whole life because she has been. The last thing she ever wants is for Adora to pull away from her, but it would shatter her right now.

She has to leave when they stop. She still has to leave, this doesn't - this *can't* change anything. Adora is still going to… She just can't think about the after of this, all she needs is the taste of Adora on her tongue. She never even let herself imagine what

Adora might taste like and now she doesn’t have to. She never has to *imagine* anything about this ever again.

She’ll never *have* this again but fucking gods, she has it right now.

And she lets the desperate longing take over.

Adora goes willingly as she reaches down and pushes her backwards by her hips. She doesn’t question anything, just keeps kissing her until her back hits a tree. She ought to have better control over her claws, but she doesn’t. She doesn’t have the mind to be careful with them as they sink through fabric and into skin. And Adora does nothing but grip onto her arms, pull her closer as she licks too demandingly back into her mouth.

She can’t breathe but it’s not important in the face of this. Adora is letting her run her hands up and down her sides, touching as much as she can without fear of going too far. Without her jacket, she can actually feel the lines of her. She covers up an embarrassing sound by sucking on Adora’s tongue.

Adora moans, then shudders under her hands as the vibration makes her claws tear fabric. She forces her hands to still. She can’t - she can’t let her hands touch Adora’s bare skin. She’s not strong enough. Even if it would be so easy to press her fingertips into newly exposed flesh.

One of them has to stop. They can’t do *more* than this, it would kill her once the moment passes. But gods, all Adora would have to do is ask. She hates how sure of that she is.

It’s over, it has to be. *This is it*.

Adora doesn’t move as she stops, doesn't pull her back in as she buries into her shoulder, begging herself not to cry even as the light of the failsafe makes her eyes burn. Not that it matters; how ragged and wet her breathing is will let Adora know. Adora sounds remarkably similar to herself, panting into her ear as she puts an arm around her shoulders.

“Adora…”

“This -“ Adora starts, miserably, “This doesn’t change anything does it?”

She wishes it did. Gods, she wishes more than anything. “It… You’re… I can’t watch. I’m sorry.”

Adora holds her tighter, “I know. It’s - it’s okay, Catra, I…I understand. I won’t try and stop you again.”

“You’re going to let me go?”

Adora doesn’t answer. But she does drop her arm as she moves away. She can’t seem to take her hands off Adora’s waist as she stares at blue bark. Adora softens at the reluctance.

“Just…” Adora leans forwards, brings their foreheads back together because she wants to make the hardest thing she’s ever done *worse*. “In case this is the last time I ever see you.”

And Adora kisses her with finality, but so softly it makes her shiver. She forces her claws not to dig in too deep, even though everything inside her is yelling that she just stay, keep kissing Adora until she changes her mind and agrees to come with her.

She thinks, *‘Why do you only kiss me when you think it’s goodbye?’* It’s the only thing that’s going to stop her. Because this isn’t the first time for Adora, at least not with the way she said it before. The question is going to be playing on repeat in her head for the rest of her fucking life. And she’ll never get a *fucking answer*.

She pulls out of the embrace, all of Adora’s upset from before has calmed. She looks tired, subdued, scared and a whole manner of other things. Catra's too swept up in the hurricane of her own head to figure out what any of this might mean. Everything is so much colder, less alive than Adora. The world could never hold her the way she does.

'This is the rest of your life.' She doesn't listen to it.

She runs this time. Completely, as fast as she can. And Adora doesn't try to follow, even though she couldn't. Adora is letting her go. Adora didn't tell her...she didn't tell her what she *had* to do. And she won't let herself think about how much that means until she's ran herself into the ground, as far from Brightmoon and Adora and her own heart as she can possibly get.

Poison

Chapter Notes

This fic has a happy ending tag for a reason, I know some of you were worried about that

Adora

She watches Catra leave, run away from her, face a painting of hurt. It would feel like Thaymore all over again. *Would*. Except she can still taste Catra on her lips, feel the ghost of her heat along every inch of her body. Her back is still pressed up against the wood from Catra putting her there.
She doesn't move for a long time.

Don't hate me for this. That's what she said, trying to work up the nerve. It's what *Catra* said right before she did it for her. She's never been able to hate Catra, but hate her for *that*, for the thing she's been wishing for since realising what she was feeling...

She was right before, about thinking that actually getting to *kiss* Catra would just stop all thought. It doesn't feel like thought has started up again, actually. Maybe she wouldn't have let Catra go if she could just *think*. The only thing she knew to do in the moment was hold on. Take as much as Catra would give her.

She stares at the bag Catra didn't take with her. There's heartbreak sitting on her lungs ready to push down, but it stays away for now. She doesn't want to move, feels like something will shatter if she does. *This doesn't change anything*, she'd said that too, just put the truth out there because she couldn't bear to hope. It's why Catra left; because she's still got to do this, save the universe. It's always been the thing in between them, really. The world.

And that can't change. Not for everything Catra might let her have, might willingly give her, if she did. And in knowing that, she

doesn’t even let herself begin to think what that might be. She’s never been able to think about what could be, what she could have. She’s not about to start now. It will hurt just so much more given...everything that just happened.

It feels so, so wrong to just sling the bag over her shoulder. But she does it.

It’s cold as she walks back. She wraps arms around herself as she finds a sorcerer to let her back in. She - she needs a new shirt. Either she’s blushing the colour of roses or the cold is making the heat in her face feel worse. She feels exposed without her jacket, with her hair down. She almost hadn’t put shoes on before following Catra, she’s glad she did.

As the sorcerer checks her neck for a chip she blushes deeper remembering Catra’s claws against the skin there, she wonders if there’s marks. She doesn’t know what she wants the answer to be.

She walks in a haze back to her own room, desperately trying not to think of it as *theirs*. All the crushing misery is waiting for her there, she knows. She’ll go back to Glimmer’s room. She can’t be alone right now.

She feels the tears building in her chest as she pushes past the door. She drops the bag to the floor. Her room is neat, but different. Catra left some things askew. There’s one less blanket on the bed, the bathroom door is wide open. She’s sure if she opened the wardrobe it’d be as empty as it’s been the past three years.
She could fix most of it, Catra didn’t end up taking her things with her. But she doesn’t think she could actually do that.

It’s a testament to her night that she doesn’t feel scared about seeing that the one drawer only pushed half way back in is the one holding Catra’s mask. The headpiece is sitting on top of her clothes: Catra saw it. Catra knows...something.
She doesn’t make a sound as a tear clinks on the metal. And then

the thoughts start swirling. Is that why Catra did it? Because she figured it out, because she knew she wanted it? A parting gift.

"You won't watch anyone else get hurt. You know why? You'll be dead." Catra thinks she's going to die. It would make terrible sense for her to do this for her.

But Catra...she wouldn't. She wouldn't. Catra wouldn't do anything she didn't want to - she never has done, not unless she was forced. And Catra said she was selfish. Kissing her would've been anything but that. She would have given as much as she wanted to and nothing more. There is *so much* that she did that couldn't have just been for her. Which means that...which means that Catra wanted to.

And the mask clatters against the wood of the drawer as she drops it. She takes a shirt instead, swiftly swapping them over, folding the ruined one next to the metal. It feels right, as much as it hurts.

She catches her expression in the mirror from across the room, her winding thoughts evident in the twisting of her features. Her hair is a wreck, grass and fragments of bark caught up in it from tackling Catra to the ground, from holding her as she cried in her arms...and from Catra pushing her up against a tree. It feels wrong to brush away the evidence - the proof. But she has to.

She pushes her hair aside, but there's no mark on her neck that she can see. She grits her teeth as she lifts her shirt up and finds nothing. Maybe it's She-Ra, maybe there was nothing there in the first place. She almost turns away from the mirror, but there's one last place. There are red pricks of wound scattered on her hip bones and her whole body feels like it's melting with relief.

It was real. Catra kissed her. Catra kissed her because…she wanted to.

And she looked scared. Upset and angry; a mix she's seen in Catra so many times but this *wasn't like those times*. This was

terrifyingly new.
Catra could have left without saying anything at all, could've ran like she did at the end, could have fought her. She *didn't* though. Her heart whispers that Catra was - is - as heartbroken as she feels right now. And she doesn't dismiss it.

It's the way Catra said she was already missing her. So reluctant to admit anything but also open the way Catra never is. Catra *cried*. Adora knows she didn't want to, neither of them ever do. But she *did*. And that means so much.

"I want to be with you all the time. I want to be around you *all the time. It feels like - like I have spent every second of my life thinking about you. Waiting for the moments when you look at me."*
And she's trying not to cry again because fuck, if that doesn't sound like her own mind. As if she doesn't feel the same way.

It's the way Catra begged her to go with her. How she let her keep her there for even that small time. It's Catra pinning her to a tree to stop her leaving, to feel more of her, whatever the reason, she still did it. And it's more than the simple *fact* that Catra kissed her, it was the way she did it. How it felt like Catra was tearing into her, as desperate to be close to her as she has always felt. It's these marks she has on her now.

"You broke my fucking heart."
Catra told her that from the safety of her arms. Told her as she crushed her into her chest, she remembers how Catra froze once she said it.

"Adora?"
Her heart's been beating like gunfire ever since her room. Even Bow's voice isn't enough to really break her out of her renewed haze.
"Where's Catra?"

Glimmer hooks her arm through hers, maybe she looks as unsteady as she feels. She's not breathing properly, barely breathing at all really. And she gets guided onto Glimmer's window seat with the Queen and Bow on either side. Sitting down does help. She ought to thank them really.

She doesn't, she just says, "Catra...she left. She couldn't watch me do - said that she couldn't watch if this ends badly... And I let her go."

It takes a while for even Bow to ask, "Are you okay?"

She doesn't even think to lie, "No. But I will be. I'll go in the morning like I said. We can do goodbyes then."

Glimmer sounds slightly scandalised, "Adora, did you think we weren't going with you?"
She did, actually. She knows in any other situation Glimmer would most likely angrily scoff.
"We're going with you to the Heart. We're not going to do any goodbyes because we won't have to."

She doesn't believe they won't have to, but she'll try.
"Okay...Thank you." They hug her when her voice breaks and she doesn't fight it. "Something - something happened."

Bow rubs her back, "Is that why you look…?"

"- Miserable," Glimmer states.

"No, no that's not it. Well, you do, but you look...happier, as weird as that is. But you - you can't be *happy* Catra left."

She would laugh if she felt she were able to. She's beyond miserable, heartbroken and practically grieving underneath everything. She *misses her*. And it's also the most sure she's ever felt when it comes to her feelings for Catra.

"No, I'm - I'm never going to see her again. And it feels like I can't breathe. But I…I think Catra loves me."

Catra

She doesn't manage to run as far as she wants; she can't run off the edge of Etheria. The adrenaline is long gone. And the tears that are blurring her vision are catching up with her. She has to stop when her harsh breaths turn to sobs. It's dangerous to collapse against a tree, the forest isn't safe. Nowhere is. But she *can't breathe*.

"In case this is the last time I ever see you."

Fuck. Just...what the fuck does that even mean? Why - how could Adora even say that to her? How could she *kiss her* like that. Catra buries her face in her hands, just trying to fucking *breathe*.

"I'm going to miss you. I'm - I'm going to be thinking about you no matter what. If - if I don't come back from this, you - I promise you're the last thing I'm going to think about. Gods *it feels like I'm always thinking about you… Please don't hate me for this."*

She sits on the ground, swallowing back fucking everything. Gods there's so much. She loves Adora so much. And she's so mad at her, for everything. And she wants her here with her right now. And - and she...she did all of that. They both said *all of that*. Adora let her do it, she held onto her. *She kissed her goodbye*, softer than she's ever let herself imagine.

She said those things and they just...sound so much like herself. And maybe… There is hope. Genuine hope that she's not alone in this feeling. Maybe for the first time ever.

"You broke my fucking heart."
"You broke mine too."

She doesn't know whether she's crying or laughing. It's just those words in her head now, and Adora crying into her neck as she held her. It's the way Adora was with her the day she should have died, like she couldn't bear to let go. It's how Adora crawls into her bed with her, it's -

There’s a light in the distance, piercing and sickly green. The adrenaline comes flooding, and she’s on her feet. It’s not a laser pointed at her, thankfully. But it’s not fucking good.

The switch in thought track is disorientating and violent but she recovers quickly, leaping into the low tree branches. There’s a sound, talking, growing louder as she runs along branches. It has to be Prime, his tone is hard to recreate.

She’s not too close when there’s a large enough break in the tree line, and past the tall rocks, she sees it; the white of Prime’s architecture. Except it’s different to the spires. And it’s lighting up, and she thinks, plunging into the planet. The glow is back and glaring. And spreading.

The Heart. He’s going for - she has to get back now. Adora won’t be able to save everyone if the Heart’s already taken, the failsafe might not even work. Fuck her resolve. She can’t watch. But this can’t be for nothing either. She...maybe this is just stupid hope. Maybe she’s still doing this for selfish reasons.
But she’s only been running for an hour or so. She can make it back.

Maybe she shouldn’t have left. But she can warn Adora before it’s too late, and...and she can try and save her if she’s *with her*. Adora can’t fight Prime like this on her own and gods does she know Adora’s going to try. She doesn’t know how long they have, but she is going to fucking try, more than she’s ever tried for anything.

Adora

They don’t seem surprised at her revelation. They - they agree with her. And she’s glad she’s sitting down.

Glimmer starts, “Ever since she came here we thought maybe - I mean, what made you realise?”

Ever since - they’ve suspected it that long! She’d be angry if she didn’t completely understand why they stayed silent. She wouldn’t

have believed them even if they did say anything. Would probably have shut them down because it hurt too much to consider the possibility.

"It - she didn't want to leave. I know she didn't. She said some things, she sounded so... She *cried*, and um...she kissed me."

Both of them exclaim, "What!"

And she knows she's blushing scarlet again. Embarrassment is a welcome change in feeling. "I mean *I* was going to but she kind of...beat me to it. She… I'm not wrong, right? I'm not going crazy because -" because she might die and this is all she wants.

"Yes. Fuck, yeah Adora she loves you." She's not prepared for how relieved Glimmer seems to be saying that. It almost makes her cry again.

"And this is probably a horrible time to realise that." Bow is right. Tragically.

And just like that the moment breaks. It's a horrendous come down from a very brief high. "It's - I don't know if it's worse now. I mean I'm, I think I'm glad to know. But...she's gone. And I might…"

Somehow Bow just knows what she's going to say, "You're not going to die, Adora. We're not going to let it happen."

It's not up to them, though. She doesn't say that.

Glimmer squeezes her arm, "We're going to go in the morning. Get to the Heart *together*. You're going to save the world, we defeat Prime. And you can go find Catra. And *please*, tell her how you feel."

She manages to smile. *That's* what she wants; to have it all. For everything to go right in every way for once. To have a chance. She believes that they do. But she can't let herself *hope*.

“I will. I - I want to. I want us all to be happy together, here and alive.” She feels both deflated and uplifted admitting it.

“And we’ll get that. Okay, we’ll have that.”

She doesn’t give him a response because she doesn’t know how to. Not to that. There is a better possibility of having it now than ever, but there’s also this pulsing, buzzing thing on her chest literally glaring at her. Telling her *do not fucking hope for this Adora*.

It’s too late for them to keep talking really. She can barely see clearly.
In the end she gets at most two hours of sleep. There’s an explosion outside, followed by a horrific shattering. After Bow and Glimmer startle awake too, they all rush to the window but there’s nothing on this side of the castle, just clones and - there’s no barrier. Prime’s here. And they have to go *now*.

Catra

It takes longer than it should for her to get back. This is the hardest she’s pushed her endurance since Hordak. But she stays ahead of the virus rushing its way through the hidden mechanical infrastructure of the planet.

She finds Brightmoon far easier than she’s expecting with the shifting landscape. But maybe the poison has halted the magic. Whatever it is, it doesn’t matter. The mountains and spires come into view with the breaks in the canopy.

It looks wrong. She doesn’t get why until she’s at the tree line, sees the small plumes of smoke, runs to the base of the bridge unimpeded. The barrier is gone, the sorcerers; the whole Kingdom is silent. There’s no bodies though, no bots or clones. It’s the only reason she’s able to keep walking.

She makes it to the entrance. The barest trace of Adora is in the air, she calls out for her, but the answer makes her entire body freeze.
“She’s not here.”

She should’ve smelt Shadow Weaver on the wind. She’ll blame the smoke for that. There’s no one here she has to be civil for, and she’s strung too high on fear to care how she’s growling, “Then where the fuck is she? Where’s anyone for that matter?”

This is really the last thing she needs right now, for *her* to be here. She’d be lying if getting away from Shadow Weaver hasn’t also been on her list of reasons to leave, but it *doesn’t matter now*. She’s here. She’s trying to do the fucking right thing.
But fear turns to anger. And she can’t stand the fucking sight of her. The simple fact that she needs to know what happened is the *only* reason she listens.

“Prime came, destroyed the barrier. The Alliance led the people into the caves, Adora went to the Heart of Etheria to free the magic and become the hero she was always meant to be. No thanks to you. And if you are still so wretched, so selfish as to try and stop her -”

“Shut the fuck up!” She's so angry she can’t even savour how shocked Weaver is that she’s yanking her down to her level. “This isn't fucking about you! It never has been. Prime is doing something to the planet and the *only* reason I’m not punching you is because you’re not fucking worth it. You don’t matter. Adora does. So just fucking take me to her I know you can.”

She doesn’t care that she’s all but begging in the presence of the witch, even if she is spitting it like venom. If there was ever a time to break in front of her it is now.

“You assume too much of me, Catr -”

“- You’ve been able to track us our whole fucking lives. So do something good with it for once and let me save her!”

The fact that Weaver even has to think about it makes her snarl in her throat. But she unhooks her claws from her robe. She levels Weaver with a glare as she pulls a vial of blue powder out of her pocket. Of fucking course. She'd probably be making good on her punching threat if it weren't going to help her. Help Adora.

"Take my hand."

That's the last thing she *wants* to do. But the woods are lighting up acidic green on the horizon, Prime's ship is looming in the sky. And they're out of time and options.

Shadow Weaver's always cold, now is no exception. Her magic always bites like ice, but at least she does it quickly, doesn't waste any precious time making her suffer. She has a violent realisation that she misses Glimmer's magic as she stares down white eyes.

Adora

Glimmer manages to teleport them into the Crystal Castle's entrance directly. With the amount of lockdowns this ancient place has had to endure, she's surprised so much of it is still intact. There's still rubble from the last one, and it takes her a moment to realise it's probably because Light Hope isn't here anymore.

The entrance hologram appears and she forces herself to turn into She-Ra. In some ways it's easier than it's been recently, though she doesn't understand why; she's not focused at all. And that's what Weaver said she had to be. But she's accepted by the program once it finds the failsafe. *'Friends of Mara'* makes her smile sadly as the hallway opens up for the first time in a thousand years.

They walk in silence, the three of them hand in hand. *'You're doing this for them.'* It helps. She can smile at them knowing that. Even if she looks back towards the entrance, wishing there was just one more person here.

Glimmer's the first to break the silence, "Are you scared?"

She's been scared since the moment Catra closed Glimmer's door. "No. I just really hope this works."

"I meant it earlier, we'll be okay. And when we *all* get back...it'll be peace again. And Etheria will have more magic than it's had in a thousand years. It'll be a new world," Bow says, trying to be reassuring.

A new world. She hasn't thought about it like that. Maybe she should, *if* she survives it, she'll have to brave it to go find Catra again. It could take months but Catra *wants* to be found, so she'll find her. She won't stop until she does...

She hears Catra. Hears her *laughing* like they did as kids. She's going insane. But she doesn't care. Not if there's even a chance Catra came back. And she's running towards the sound of her voice that she would know fucking anywhere. Even if it shouldn't sound like that.

She rounds a corner and jolts to a stop. It's her. It - it's genuinely - and she's smiling so softly and -
"Hey Adora."

There's relief coursing through her like cleansing water. She all but breathes her name, "Catra…"

But a call from Bow and Glimmer behind and Catra vanishes, transforms. She's not here. This - that wasn't real. She's reminded why she hates this place. But that's not exactly what she's thinking about as she watches a teenage Catra walk towards her. Adora does miss the wildness of her hair, how she'd rebel at everything and everyone. Sometimes it infuriated her, sometimes she was in awe of it. She really has always loved her. She remembers training with this Catra, the way she'd thrilled at every touch Catra gave her. She remembers long nights whispering under too-thin blankets, trying not to laugh too loud.

There's Catra as she was their last years in the Horde, with her damn mask and her cocky smirk that left her hot and cold. It's

rough-housing with her in locker rooms and fighting off other cadets together. It's them promising to keep climbing up and up until it was just them - they way Adora always wanted them to be. It's the Catra she fought against, but the memory of the day she started wearing the outfit is nearly as clear as the Battle of Brightmoon. She can smile at her, even while awfully aware of the scars on her back.

It flashes again, and no, *there's* the Catra she fought against. All black and red and anger. The Catra she couldn't forgive with just a couple of words. And she feels tears well because she *still loved her*. She wanted to protect her just the same when that was the last thing she should've wanted. And Bow and Glimmer know that now. (*'And they don't hate you for it.'*)

For the briefest moment it's Catra as she was the days after the throne room, all burns and skeletal figure and hopelessness. Devoid of rage, devoid of everything but mistrust and regret.

It must be the last one when it shows Catra as she is now. The version of Catra she thinks loves her back. With her choppy hair, her mask-less face, her open eyes and trying smile. She doesn't realise that she is Adora again until Catra reaches up for her with ease.

These are all memories. And so is this. Catra pulling her down to kiss her is a *memory*. And it's horrible because she *knows* how this feels. The sensation is still buzzing in her skin. It's only been hours. And it's not Catra, but it feels like it. And she just wants to hope for this one brief moment. Sink into the memory. Kiss her again because she *wants to*, wants *her* with everything she has.

It shatters when she tries to hold Catra's face. Because she didn't do that, even though she wanted to. Fuck, she should've. She was just too shocked and hurt to do anything but kiss her back. She's left standing on a precise, fingers to her own lips as she stares at a void.

"Adora, the Heart isn't that… Are you okay?"

No. No, right now she can remember very few moments when she's felt this crushed. She swallows, trying to get her breathing and heartbeat under control. "We need to hurry."

He asks, "Memories?"

She-Ra phases and something cold grips her chest. "We can't let it distract us."

There's no 'we', it's just her and her weaknesses. Her love that's never done her any good. Loving Catra never hurt her any less, it never protected her like she thought it did, loving her friends won't protect them now.

Bow puts a hand on her arm and it - she needs it. She needs to figure out what to do. And then she's Adora again, for the smallest moment. That's the first time in a while that She-Ra's fallen away without her dismissal. And it terrifies her. It terrifies Bow and Glimmer too if the look they share means anything.

"I'm fine. Let's just go."

They don't argue.

She doesn't register when she starts striding ahead of them, too caught up in her own head. She's here focusing on She-Ra's power and she's back there in that forest with Catra saying...everything. She's tumbling back into her body and pulling herself back up again and it's exhausting and confusing and she just hurts.

The crystal walls disintegrate, and she gasps quietly upon seeing the sword as it was; wrapped up in vines, buried in dirt and glowing like a beacon. Appropriate, she thinks, that this is what she's seeing. The beginning at the end. It's telling her something. There's got to be a *why* for this.

They’re calling out her name far behind her, she can hear how scared they are. She keeps making them worry. But she’s fine, she can do this. They shouldn’t suffer for her. No one should.

Alone. She’s meant to do this alone. She found the sword alone, she destroyed it alone. She ended up in that portal alone in the end. She-Ra is needed by everyone else, even *Adora* needs She-Ra. But her friends won’t let her do this. And they’ll pay the price for it - all of them. Only Catra knew she couldn’t stop her. So she has to leave them to do this for them. And they’ll forgive her whether or not she survives.

Bow shouts, “Adora! Are you okay?”

The two of them come through the fake trees. Glimmer begins, “What’s this -”

“It’s my memories, the castle...I’m doing this.” She knows the bitterness in her voice is obvious, they just don’t know why it’s there yet.

Bow returns, voice back to almost-calm, “Adora, we just have to do this one step at a time. Do you know when this memory is going to end?”

“It might not if I don't…”

Glimmer asks wearily, “Don’t what?” Adora starts walking towards the thing that almost doomed her before. “Adora, don’t what?”

“I can’t change what has to happen. I have to stop Prime, I have to use the failsafe, I have to save everyone. There’s no more time. I’m confused and I’m distracted and I’m *scared*. And I can’t be any of those things if this is going to work. I can’t be worrying about you guys, the world, Catra...it’s - it’s too much. Shadow Weaver was right about my magic.”
She can’t stop the flickering, she feels sick with the feeling, the way her body is tearing and sewing at itself over and over. It doesn’t hurt, but she’s crying anyway, staring down the sword, knowing she’s letting her best friends down at the last moment.

“I - I feel like I’m losing She-Ra, I’ve felt it for a while and I didn’t tell you earlier. And I’m sorry, I don’t want this to be the end of us. But I have to do the rest by myself.”

Bow yells, “You don’t! Adora, we're here with you. We’re staying.” At the same time Glimmer demands, “What do you mean the end!”

She chokes on her tears a little, looking at them and smiling. Without the barrier of thorns that’s grown they’d be with her, stopping her. “I love you guys so much. I’m so sorry. You’re the best friends anyone could ask for. I’ll miss you.”

They both cry out her name as she takes hold of the sword’s grip, it feels wrong now that she knows what the alternative feels like. She doesn’t know what’s going to happen, but she knows this is what she’s meant to do.

Monsters

Chapter Notes

Content Warning: minor character death :)
(No detail)

Catra

She knows she's wincing as the spell finishes.

She doesn't know where she is and it takes too long for her senses and instinctual panic to calm down and catch up with the new world around her. The first thing that registers is Adora's faint scent, so at least the witch didn't fail outright. The next is Glimmer's gasp and Bow saying her name with disbelief.

She doesn't waste time, snatching her whole body away from Shadow Weaver, out of the spell written in black on the floor.
"Where's Adora?"

Glimmer looks more distraught than she can ever remember seeing her, "She - she *left us*."

"She's convinced herself she has to do this alone and the castle obeys her so -"

'You shouldn't have left.'

"- Of course that's - of fucking course she's gone! I don't - how long? Can I still find her?"
The structure starts trembling all around them followed by a high pitched not-screech that she recognises from the woods. Bow and Glimmer look at her worriedly.
"Horde Prime is hacking into the planet. Clearly he knows what the failsafe is going to do and he's moving fast."

"Is Brightmoon alright?"

“Yes. It’s fine.” How Weaver can sound bored even in this situation is almost as impressive as it is infuriating.

“Catra?”

(Does it make her feel a little better that Glimmer doesn’t trust Shadow Weaver’s word anymore? Yes.)

“No one seemed hurt but...it might not be that way for long. You go back, keep everyone safe. I’ll find Adora. I’ll save her.”

Glimmer looks to Bow and he nods. She doesn’t protest, doesn’t fight as Glimmer wraps her up in a hug. Any other time...she thinks she’d purr. They - both of them deserve to hear it. As it is, she just hugs her back.

“Bring her back to us.”

“I’ll do my best, Sparkles.”

“You better, Horde scum.”

Bow joins them, and she’s surprised she doesn’t feel in any way trapped. She’s...safe with them. Maybe it’s an appropriate thing to realise since they’re about to leave her alone with the witch. It breaks, and she looks at him when it does.

“There’s so much I should thank you for…”

He puts a hand on her shoulder, “You can do that when you get back. Just...when you find her *tell her*, please. She needs to hear it from you.”

She’s shocked, and it shows, but she manages to nod before - “Enough of this, we don’t have time.”

She hisses at her, and though Weaver glares she doesn’t grab her or something worse. This isn't about her. “Keep our home safe, alright?”

Bow and Glimmer both look touched at that, and yes, it might be one of the sappiest things she's ever said. But she means it. Brightmoon is, essentially, home now even if she was going to leave it. It's where her friends are. It's where Adora will be if they get through this.

She steps away, walking backwards to watch them teleport. They wave before the magic sweeps them away. As soon as they disappear she starts running in the direction of the virus, figuring it has to be going towards the Heart. It's petty but she likes that she can tell Weaver is struggling to keep up with her. She also knows there isn't a world in which Weaver admits that.

If she let herself, she'd melt with relief at the strengthening of Adora's scent in the air. It's followed by something acidic, pure chemical and a splitting roar. Which obviously means they're close. Of course Adora got herself in trouble first chance she could.

She'd be angry if she weren't terrified.

It might be the easiest it's ever been to shut Weaver out. They catch up with the virus, the walls still blue in the cavernous hall they find, though the towering mass of tentacles has green eyes. And there's Adora on the ground bleeding - no, not bleeding, it's green. Prime. He got her, poisoned her like the planet and this creature.

Catra runs at the monster, leaping at its head. It's glass eyes shatter under her claws easily. It howls, and she jumps off it's skull, forcing it back into a wall as she drops into an unsteady crouch on the ground. It's not dead, but it doesn't move for the moment either aside from the wave of its tentacles.

She takes the reprieve to turn back to Adora, still on the ground and sweating, looking at her much the same way she did when she left her. There's the fear, the shock, the hope, all of it. "*Catra*?" Adora tries to move forwards by herself and winces.

“Hey Adora.” It sounds like love and she knows that. She doesn’t care. She wants to keep looking at Adora for the rest of forever but the monster is moving again.

“You - are you really here?”

“Yeah, Dora -“
A tentacle crashes down onto the crystal next to her and she has to jump to avoid it. She swipes at the limb, wincing when the creature shrieks. When she turns back, Weaver’s got her hands on Adora’s arms, trying to get her standing again.
“I came back.”

Adora seems like she’s fighting to stay upright even with Shadow Weaver’s hold. Catra wants to be holding her instead, getting her to the Heart, being with her when she does this. But she can’t. Weaver isn’t powerful enough to take this thing down anymore. And even if Adora succeeds (she has to at least try and believe that she will), she’ll have to come back this way. So this thing has to die. And she’ll stay to make sure that happens, even if it kills her.
Adora will understand that if she’s the only one of them to live. And if they both go then...well, they’ll be together at least.

“Shadow Weaver’s going to take you to the Heart, okay?”

“No, Catra! No you’re coming with me!” It looks like it exhausts Adora to shout it. Adora’s reaching a hand out for her desperately, wasting strength trying to get to her. Fuck, they should get a goodbye. One that doesn’t end with her running away from her feelings.

She dodges tentacles to slash at the creature’s stomach. It doesn’t bleed; it’s machinery. It shrieks again, curling in on itself like it can fix what she just ruined. Maybe it can, it’s given her a window anyway. If this is the last chance she gets...well it’s not even the first time tonight she’s had that thought.

She runs over to them, takes Adora’s hand and watches how her pale face lights up. There's cracks of green breaking through her skin and it makes her feel sick. Adora's smile still manages to soothe something in her chest and burn another. She’s sure that even without the monster here, she’d be feeling the same amount of painful adrenaline kissing Adora’s forehead in front of Shadow Weaver. At least it doesn’t look like Weaver’s hurting her, Catra glares at the witch just to be sure.

“I'll catch up, ok? Get to the Heart.” She’d hold Adora’s face to tell her that if the monster was not looking directly at them again.

She shoves the other two away as a tentacle comes down between them. This is the only time she’s ever felt any kind of relief at seeing Weaver drag Adora away from her. Adora doesn’t stop calling out for her, shouting her name. And she ignores it. Somehow.

She doesn’t know how to kill this thing. But she’ll figure it out. Shutting down a machine can’t be all that hard if she prys it open enough. She digs her claws into the thick almost-metal hide of the creature’s back as deep as she can. It can’t get her here. She crawls up it hoping desperately it doesn’t have another limb that’s going to come out of nowhere. There’s no sickening squelch of organic matter when her hands get past the epidermis on the back of its neck. There’s wires and lights blinking and machinery pistoning, and a horrible falling feeling in her own stomach as it starts rolling.

She’s quick enough that she can jump off its body before it crushes her. She’s panting in a crouch when she gets her bearings again. And she runs, keeping close to the walls as she tries to find the best point to spring at its stomach again. She doesn’t get to do that.

She screams when the creature grabs at her ankle, poisoned spikes sizzling her skin and fur. Her vision goes black for a second with the force of the impact on her chin as she crashes to the ground. She tastes blood in her mouth from her teeth breaking

the skin of her tongue. Still, she manages to find a hold in the crystal floor that stops the creature pulling her any closer even as it tries.

The walls change colour. With the pain she doesn't realise it immediately. Not until something starts speaking,
"You will fail." She snaps her eyes open, finds what has to be Prime standing over her. She doesn't let her claws give an inch.
"You've been there for every foil your petty Rebellion has tried but you won't stop me. Your...Adora, her name is? You're close, it's obvious. I imagine it'll hurt when she dies. She won't save you. She won't save anyone on this pathetic planet."

She will. She wants to tell him that. And even if she doesn't...well Adora was worth it. She always has been. She's been worth every damn moment. Every fucking scar.

The creature tightens its hold and she shouts as the barbs pierce deeper and the burn almost blinds her. There's a screech as her claws loose hold.

"So brave, risking yourself for your Adora. I have never understood your kind's attachment...it always causes more problems than it solves. But it will make no difference. The Heart is almost mine, and when it is, your Adora will die."

She'd think a supposedly all powerful being would be above gloating. But he's not. And that makes him mortal in her eyes. She's about to spit, laugh, snarl, do *something* but she's hauled into the air. A chunk of crystal comes with her, but throwing it as hard as she can at the creature's eye does nothing except break glass. She spits the blood in her mouth at it.
She can't truly recall the last time she slept, she's tired under the adrenaline. Something aches as she curls herself up trying to tear at the thing holding her up. But there'd be no point in that, not when she's hanging over its mouth.

It doesn't matter what happens next; Adora's going to the Heart. She's going to save the world and Prime is going to be *wrong*. A

future together with Adora is an old hope, one she hasn't believed she would have since the day Adora found that sword. But staring down at teeth and a churning mechanical throat she wishes she was wrong to give up on it.

"I'm going to be thinking about you no matter what."

She tries not to cry but it doesn't work. There's too much fear and pain and hopelessness. Strangely, she thinks she's grateful to die in battle, to die trying to save the life of the woman she loves. It's a more selfless way to go than she ever could have imagined for herself.

It's not quick how the monster is lowering her into its mouth, and she shuts her eyes waiting for it to snap her in half or just swallow her whole. But it doesn't. And suddenly she's falling, yelling, landing on her back hard enough to knock the air out of her.

She looks at the hologram, sees who it's watching before it vanishes. She ought to move but she just stares as Shadow Weaver shoots one black beam after another, more powerful than she's ever seen her. Magic. She has magic again which means she got to the Heart. She can't see Adora from where she is but she has to hope that she's alive.

Shadow Weaver came back for her. After leaving over and over again she's actually here saving her. She doesn't believe it. There's another reason. One that's selfish, one she'll figure out eventually but right now all she can do is *watch*.

"Take Adora and run!"

Adora's here. Adora's alive.
Shadow Weaver's here. Shadow Weaver's alive.
And neither of them *should be here*.

She's startled by the flames that burst when spells hit the creature. The scent of Weaver's magic is stinging her sinuses. A black band of shadow wraps around the monster as it roars. Catra

manages to get to her feet, the shock keeping the worst of the pain away as she puts weight on her ankle again.

She can see very clearly what's happening but nothing is making sense. "What are you...?"

"I told you to run! Now, run!"

She cries out as a wave of shadow throws her back. Her entire body locks up from the feeling, preparing for worse but it doesn't come. Her breaths are coming in painfully quickly as she pushes herself back up. A barrier like black glass forms at the tunnel's entrance, so eerily similar to her prison walls. It doesn't feel real anymore, what's happening. She's watching Shadow Weaver fight through a screen.

There's so many emotions and memories and things she wants to say and whisper and scream in equal measure and all she does is bang her fists on the barrier. She hates this woman. She despises her very being but she's shouting for her. She doesn't want her dead. She hates that she doesn't.

"Shadow Weaver, no! What are you *doing*?" She's angry and she's scared and it all shows and she *doesn't care*.

"Please, Catra."
It makes her freeze. She's never heard those words from Weaver once in her life where it's not been a manipulation. She knows, deep down, this can't be any different.
"You need to make sure Adora reaches the Heart. The magic must be set free."

The black binding around the monster breaks, it shrieks again, limbs flying towards the sorcerer as she holds a shield in place. Catra can see her shaking.

"Stop it! It's going to kill you!" She shouldn't want to stop that happening. She shouldn't care at all.

“It's too late for me. But you, this is only the beginning for you. I am so proud of you, Catra.”

She wants those words. She wants to believe them but she just *doesn’t*. She *knows* Shadow Weaver doesn’t care. She never has, she never *will*. It’s not even an apology. And she starts crying. She wants her to run, she wants to scratch her and demand she tell the truth for once. She wants to *believe her*.

And all it comes out as is her shouting, “No! No! You don’t get to do this!” over and over.

She jumps when Adora touches her, hand catching hers as she goes to slam it on the spell again. She doesn’t fight her. In fact she feels most of the fight drain out of her. She turns as much as she’s able to without her eyes leaving Weaver, clinging onto Adora while they watch. Adora’s crying too, holds onto her too.

Weaver takes off her mask as the spell starts failing. It clatters as it hits the ground but she doesn’t hear it. It’s been thirteen years since the two of them caught that glimpse of her real face. It’s still as curse-damaged as it was, but Weaver wasn’t smiling back then.

“You're welcome.”

And that’s the last they’ll *ever* see of that face. She knows it without a doubt as everything behind the sheer wall goes up in orange flame. It burns her eyes to watch but both of them are frozen. Adora breathes shakily in her ears, her whole body trembling and Catra feels her trying to fall to the ground. She holds onto her tighter, turning away from the shattered mask on the floor.

She doesn’t want to cry for this woman. She fucking hates her, dying won’t fix that. But it still hurts. She won’t mourn the witch, but she’ll grieve for what should’ve been her mother. She knew she’d never change, this has just sealed that. She buries her teeth in Adora's jacket, trying not to tear it with her claws.

Adora cries into her shoulder too. Not for long, they don't have the time and they know that. Catra releases her teeth, breathing easier than she has since since she left. As soon as Adora feels steady enough in her arms again, she moves back. Adora just looks tired when Catra raises her head for her.

She doesn't want to say it, but, "We have to go."

Adora nods in her hands but she doesn't move except to hold onto her wrists, "Wait, please I just…need to look at you." Adora's smile is pained but genuine, and she's beautiful even as she sniffles, "You came back."

"I shouldn't have left in the first place. I was just scared, I didn't mean to hurt you again." But she did, she always does.

"I missed you," Adora whispers.

"I missed you too."

Adora turns slowly, slinging an arm around her shoulder. She watches Adora wince as she does it, and looks at the poison glowing green on Adora's split side. She decides then and there to repay Adora for at least one thing. Her chest feels full when Adora actually squeaks as she picks her up.

"What are you doing?"

Of all things for her to be thinking right now, how cute Adora is probably shouldn't be one of them. (She can blame the poison and the pain.) She starts walking as Adora scrambles at her shoulders to pull herself up properly.

"Returning a favour."

Adora's face softens even if the rest of her doesn't, muscles tense with poison most probably, since she feels her leg stiffening.

"Sure your ankle is gonna be alright?"

She has no idea, actually. The shock is wearing off and it *burns*. But she's getting Adora to the Heart no matter what. "Don't underestimate me, Princess."

"I've done a lot of things Catra, that has never been one of them."

"Then trust me, I can do this."

Adora

She'd curl into Catra's neck if she could stand to not look at her. It feels like the only thing keeping her together. It feels ridiculously good being in her arms again. And Catra's being so gentle around her wound, she is steady and determined even though she must be hurting too.

Catra keeps glancing at her, probably because she's staring. It doesn't feel *safe* to kiss Catra on the cheek, but she doesn't feel like she needs to hold her breath and brace to do it. Catra *almost* jerks to a stop but she's too stubborn for it. They don't really need excuses for it anymore, she doesn't think, but she gives one anyway.

"Thank you, for...for everything you've done for me."

Catra's ears go back. "Don't say that. You don't need to."

She lets her fingers play with the messy ends of Catra's hair, she's not scared to do it. Not when Catra's *here* with her. Not after everything that's already happened today. "I want to."

"Say it to me tomorrow, okay? You can say anything you want to me *tomorrow*." Catra doesn't look at her as her voice breaks.

Tomorrow means they survive. Tomorrow means they get to be together. And all she wants to do is kiss her.

"Can't wait."

Catra's laugh, the way she tries to smile, is as heartbreaking as it is beautiful.

The ball of light that is the Heart is getting closer and Adora feels her heart rate pick up. She doesn't want this to end. She holds on tighter, tries to breathe as much of Catra in as she can. She might've started crying again, she wouldn't know. It's just…there's so much that's happened, that's happening, that's going to happen.

"Catra I -"
'I love you.'

She should say it, she knows she should. This is probably the last time she'll ever be able to say it. But she can't do that to her; if Catra survives this and she doesn't, that's just more pain for her to bear.

"I care about you more than I've ever cared about anyone. I know you didn't believe me before when I said I never stopped feeling...like that, but do you believe me now?"

She needs Catra to believe her. She can't say those three words but she can say this. She's already said so much today. And gods does she hope Catra's figured it out.

Catra's ears go soft, "Yes, but Adora I need you to stop talking like this is goodbye."

"It's not…"
It is. It really, horribly is.

Catra's got tears in her eyes again and it makes her bite her tongue. "Adora, please, just let me believe that we're going to be fine."

She whispers, "Okay," as Catra squeezes her tighter. "Okay, we'll - we'll eat breakfast with Bow and Glimmer tomorrow. We can...go up to the roofs again or something. I'll take Swifty for a fly in the afternoon. You could join us."

“I’ll stay on the ground, thanks.” At least the tear-shine dissipates a little.

“I’ll bring something back for you. A flower from Plumeria or something.”

“You wanna bring me flowers, Princess?” She might even go so far as to say Catra looks touched. It makes her smile.

“Yes,” she says it simply. There’s no point denying anymore. She doesn’t want to.

And then all that brief hopeful happiness dies. Catra freezes in front of the light, all her fur standing up on end. This is it. There’s nowhere else for them to go. And they shouldn’t. She should be here. She *needs* to be here.

“You should put me down.” She can’t really afford to sound reluctant now but she does.

Catra sets her down gently. And the absence of her touch makes her ache as bad as the poison, makes her clasp Catra’s hand. She doesn’t care about the claws, she feels better for them. She looks into Catra’s eyes, finds the strength she needs in them as she reaches her other hand up.

The walls flicker and disappear when she touches the glow, the hallway transforming into a far grander entrance to the Heart chamber. And it’s there. A mass of machinery beating a pulse and shining like a star. It’s still blue-white-rainbow, not yet corrupted. It’s wild and flashing and it’s beautiful.

She stares at the platform ahead, it’s calling her forward. It’s not welcoming, not reassuring. Just lonely and cold and expecting. Her side throbs, the poison is working through her quickly and she knows her forehead is drenched with sweat. There is so much she's feeling and She-Ra isn't one of them.

She crushes Catra’s hand in her grip.

Hearts

Chapter Summary

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Chapter Notes

TW: some suicidal thoughts

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora

Catra needs to go. She needs to leave. She needs to live.

She can't be here when it happens, she'll burn up too. And Adora won't let that happen to her; she doesn't deserve any more pain, doesn't deserve to suffer on her behalf ever again. Catra left because she couldn't watch. But she came back because...she'll ask her tomorrow. That theoretical tomorrow that she is clinging onto with the last of her hope.

She'll tell Catra to leave. When she can find it in herself to let go of her hand. After she asks her just one more thing, "Catra I - did you figure it out? Me, us, I mean." She's just hurting herself. But she wants to know.

She looks at Catra, Catra looks at their hands. "I - I was hoping. I've been hoping since...tell me tomorrow, Adora, promise me."

She's nodding but she can't do it, can't say anything. Catra's ears fold to her skull as she rests her forehead on her shoulder and takes Adora's hand in both of hers. She looks small, afraid. And Adora will never know what it's like to not want to protect her.

"Catra, I wish we had more time together. I wish we could… We deserve more time. But there isn't any. And Cat, thank you for

coming back. I was ready to scour the ends of Etheria trying to find you if I survived."

"I would've let you, I wouldn't have run, I -" she can barely hear her with how close to crying Catra is, how loudly the Heart is beating, "I would've come back as soon as I knew you were alive."

In some ways she wishes for that. If she'd found Catra then, it would mean they were both safe. She would have run into Catra's arms, could've kissed her thinking it wouldn't be the last time. She could've told her everything without fear of the world ending around them.

It's too late for that now. They're here. The magic is sparking along the walls, crackling in the air. And she can't find She-Ra, not amongst the dread and longing and pain. She stares at the Heart, at the blackness hanging off the side of the platform.

She puts a hand on the back of Catra's neck and kisses her hair. "I know. I know. But you need to do it again. You need to go, save yourself. I need you to live for me."

Claws dig into her hand and Catra snaps her head up, "What? No I'm staying -"

"- *Catra please*. You need to leave." The tears she's been holding back fall over the edge as she pleads.

Catra moves quickly, or maybe it just feels like that. But she's clawing at her arms the next moment, face scared and determined. And she can't imagine what it's like to not be in love with her.

"What part of *I'm staying with you* do you not understand? I shouldn't have left at all. If you die, I die."

"I don't want you to die!"

"And I don't want you to be alone! I want to be with you!"
Her whole frame is trembling as she reaches up to hold Catra's face. Catra wants to be with her, and she can believe it any way she wants to. Catra holds her too, wipes her tears away with clawless fingers.
"You and me, together at the end of the world, right?"

She whimpers, terribly pathetically. The only thing that makes it okay is that Catra is crying too now. She brings her as close as she can, resting their foreheads together and nodding.

They were such *stupid* kids, saying things like that as if they ever had control over their lives, their futures. They made that promise from within the walls of the Fright Zone, surrounded by the glow of the incinerators with fresh bruises. The worst they knew was Shadow Weaver's magic, they couldn't have imagined this. But it's true; it's the end of the world and they're together. Because Catra came back. Because she's here for her. And she wants her to leave but…Catra makes her selfish. And she's right: she doesn't want to be alone. She wants that vow kept.

She glances at the Heart, not moving anything but her eyes. She-Ra. She needs She-Ra. They can be together, everything and everyone will be fine if she just has *her*. She tries. And the magic creeps forward, slowed by poison and duller than she ever remembers it being, but *there*. At least at first.

Maybe she pulls too hard, maybe it's her own damn fault. But that wispy light trying to take hold explodes behind a blockade, same as earlier. The brightness flashes out suddenly, her whole body cold with it's sudden absence and burning hot from roaring pain. Her legs give out and she shouts, falling safely into Catra's arms.

Catra

She manages to catch Adora before she hits the ground, sinking with her to the floor, so thankful to not be paralysed by her own panic. Adora's shaking, her face screwed up in pain as the green in her skin pulses brighter, crawls further.

“Adora?” Adora doesn’t make a sound, whole body locking up. “You’re okay, you’re okay, just breathe.”

It’s through gritted teeth, but Adora does it, air rattling in and out. The red around blue eyes when Adora opens them again is drastic compared to the sickly white-green the rest of her face is. The light changes, she only notices because it’s reflecting on Adora’s skin; Prime’s here. The virus is working its way down the walls. They’re out of time.

“I can’t heal.” It’s quiet, the words fighting their way out through rough breaths. “It hurts, Catra, I can’t - I can’t get her.”

“You can do this, just stay with me.” She pulls Adora closer as she whispers it.

This won’t be as bad as it looks - as bad as it feels - if she just holds her. Adora doesn't fight her even though moving her legs into her lap makes her bite her lip so hard it almost bleeds. She tells herself Adora is leaning into her this much only because she wants to be close, not because she can’t hold herself up anymore. It's *their* hold, and it calms her even if Adora’s pulse is weakening by the second. She doesn’t curl Adora’s head into her neck, she needs to keep looking at her. It’s really the only thing keeping her even slightly sane.

Adora reaches up for her and Catra starts crying again when she can’t even do that, her hand falling before it ever touches. She grabs her hand, holds it far too tightly. The failsafe flickers out of Adora’s chest, glowing green now just like everything else. Adora gasps out her name brokenly when another wave of pain appears to hit.

She holds her closer, gentler. “I’m right here. I’m not going anywhere.”

“Catra, I can’t - She-Ra she’s - I’m sorry.”

“Hey, hey it’s alright. You have nothing to apologise for.” She hopes Adora can hear her with how soft her voice is.

The way Adora tries to smile says she does. Nothing is *fine*, but it's at least bearable for a second. Then Adora's hold on her hand weakens. It's when Adora starts going *limp* in her arms, the Heart chamber electrified around them as the virus takes hold that she starts shouting. Any control she had over her fear vanishes when Adora's eyes start closing.

"Adora, stay awake! *Look at me*."

"Catra, I'm sorry. I can't do it." Adora can scarcely say it, more tears rolling down her cheeks.

"Yes, yes you can, stay with me. You are the strongest person I know, you can do this, just *stay awake*."

Adora doesn't listen.

And she crushes her into her chest, she doesn't care about being gentle anymore. Not when Adora's head lolls back, all the tension, all the shaking, falling away. Catra's too tired to hold her up, lies her carefully on the ground and shuts her eyes against the failsafe and its dimming green light as she presses an ear to Adora's heart.

If she could *think* at all she'd know that the only thing stopping her ending herself is the fact Adora's heart is still beating. It's weak, drowned out by the magic all around them but it's *there*. She can't hear Adora breathing, but she must be.

"I've got you, Dora. I'm not letting go. I'm never letting you go again. *Please*, I - please just *wake up*!"

The only thing she's ever begged for is for Adora to live, and she's doing it again. Just…crying and pleading into a dying woman's chest. Electricity snaps overhead and she doesn't even flinch.

And she gives up. It doesn't matter what happens afterwards. It doesn't matter if there's no tomorrow for them. She needs to say it, even if it is just a watery whisper lost to the scream of the world burning down.

"Adora, I love you. I always have. You need to hear me say that. You need to *know* that I love you."
Adora doesn't need to do anything else; doesn't need to save the world for her. She just needs to be with her when it all ends.
"So please just wake up so you can hear it."

If Adora's pulse gets stronger she can't tell. She wants it *over*. Wants the Heart to swallow them up so she doesn't have to live one second longer. She doesn't understand why it hasn't.

Something moves. Something that's not her and not the Heart's magic flashing across her skin. Everything sounds like magic in this cavern but she *knows* that sound. There's white behind her.

If she was in a state of fear and grief and despair before, it shifts to shock the second she turns to see there's a shield over her. It fizzes gold as it fades away. She doesn't know what that means. But gods does it make her hope.

She'd cry more at the hand on her face but all she can do is look wide-eyed as Adora turns her head back. Adora's looking at her. Her eyes are open. And she's awake and she's sitting up and she's winding a shaky arm around her back. *Adora didn't leave her*.

She'd be scared of what Adora might say if everything today hadn't happened. But it has. And she's still here. She's *awake* and she's holding her like she's precious and looks just about as shocked as she is.

"You - I didn't make that up?"

"No. No, I love you." She holds Adora's hand to her face, trying not to whimper at her still-weak pulse. It feels like the only thing she'll ever be able to say again. And she'd be alright with that.
"I've always loved you, idiot."

Adora's eyes start glowing, in fact the whole of her does. *She did that.* She knows she did. The green cracks in her skin retreat, gold dusts her cheeks. Catra doesn't remember her ever looking this happy.

“I love you too. I should’ve - I wanted to tell you.”

And she *gets it*, why Adora’s looking at her like that. She doesn’t remember ever *being* this happy. She knows Adora’s looked at her like this before. Even as kids. She remembers it too vividly for her to have made it up and - and she didn’t fabricate *anything*. Nothing was ever because she wanted it to be. Adora *loves her*. And it’s real.

And it might still be the end of the world, or it might not. She-Ra seems to be trying to burst out of Adora’s skin, but if she doesn’t…

“Shh, it’s okay. We’ve said it. You know now, that’s all that matters.”

The Heart howling above them, filling the air with lightning doesn’t matter. Nothing but how Adora’s gazing at her, how she’s reaching up with her other hand too. When she kisses Adora, there’s no fear in doing it. There’s no horrible thoughts clawing down her joy. She doesn’t second guess whether she's allowed to do anything, just wraps Adora back up in her arms while the roar of too many heartbeats flows into one.

It’s hard to keep it soft with how much energy is coursing through her but she manages. This isn’t desperate like before. It’s loving like she didn’t let it be last time. All she feels is *love*. She’s never felt like this - this *bright*.

She’d say those words again if she could bear to break this. It’s hard to breathe but it’s also the easiest it’s ever been. Adora loves her, Adora wants her the way she always did. The only thing she can do is feel; Adora…then She-Ra. The familiar body grows in her arms, Catra tastes her magic, feels it’s warmth the way she never has before. It still feels right, even when the hands holding her become ones she doesn’t know. She’s safe.

And she’s purring like thunder under gentle lips when she’s not gasping for air. She knows She-Ra can feel it against her palms,

she hopes that's what making her smile against her lips and just… Adora smiling against her. Fuck, she's imagined it so many times, all guilty shameful fantasies spun in the untouchable gold of wishing. It's still gold - it's all she sees behind her eyelids - but it's solid under her hands too.

Adora keeps them close, as close as possible, even when the kiss itself ends. Catra's head is tilted back now, she has She-Ra half in her lap and she laughs happily at…well, everything.

The magic sparks where they touch as She-Ra giggles with her, breathlessly, "Feels like that should've been our first kiss."

"Maybe. But I'm going to remember all of them." They're hers - theirs. She wants them, all of them.

"Me too."

It's quiet outside their heavy breathing. She looks up and the Heart is just…metal, or crystal or whatever it is. There's no light except for the dim shine in the walls and She-Ra. All she sees is Adora in her smile, in her eyes, even when she's as blindingly radiant as this.

They're alive, and Adora did it. The failsafe is gone and the Heart is dormant… And Horde Prime is still out there, the last power for She-Ra to obliterate. Which means she has to leave this timeless moment. She just has to tell herself she'll have this again. She'll have Adora again; in their room, in their bed. They can be *together*.
They are alive. And they get tomorrow.

She flexes her claws into She-Ra's back, "You need to go...save the world."

She doesn't want her to, she wants *Adora* back in her lap and kissing her. But she'll get that. She just needs to not be selfish. She needs to let Adora do this.

She-Ra strokes her thumbs along the fur on her cheeks and she lets herself melt into it, purr reigniting. “Think we just did that.”

“Prime’s still up there, with our friends.”

Adora looks at her knowingly, *smugly*, “You said ‘our’.”

She scoffs because her…everything, may be the saviour of the world but she is also a sappy dork. “Yeah, I did. So come on.”

She-Ra stands first, all but lifting Catra to her feet. She-Ra keeps her hands on her arms as she looks for a way out, seemingly finding it in the tears in the walls. They’ll lead into the chasms and back to the surface, though the climb will take a while. She’ll never know what happened when she fell to the bottom of one but she knows Adora was hurt and it was Prime’s fault. The peace she's feeling doesn't leave all together but the harshness of incubating rage makes it's way onto her tongue.

“You find him and you *destroy him* okay?”

She-Ra snaps her head back down to meet her eyes. “You’re gonna be with me when I do.”

It’s not a question, but she nods anyway. She doesn’t know what exactly stops her panicking when She-Ra picks her up, but she’s grateful. It may just be that her healing magic is still sitting in her skin like an inoculation. She doesn’t really care, the safety is fading but it’s still here for now.

She only sighs contentedly when Adora kisses her. She wasn’t expecting it, her mind is whirling with everything, but she’s floating. Everything is good here, and it’ll stay that way until she breathes fresh air again. She wants the kiss held, which given that it’s She-Ra she’s kissing is…surprising. She doesn’t want it to end, but it does, Adora keeps it quick and firm.

The *‘you just kissed She-Ra’* is sobering. She’d laugh again if a familiar intensity hadn’t settled in Adora’s brow, that single minded focus that always promised a defeat. Whenever she’d

seen it before, she'd denied just how good Adora (and She-Ra) looked wearing it, how hot it made her skin feel. Now though… well if there weren't something *incredibly pressing* hanging over them, she'd be kissing her senseless. The fact that she *could* makes her tail lash.

One day Adora will understand what she does to her when she captures and holds her eyes with a gravity so strong she can't move. From the moment Adora returned her words, her heart has not for a second calmed. She can feel She-Ra's pulse just as fast all around her, beating into her head and making her dizzy.

She can't breathe through the *love* she feels when Adora declares; "If he wanted to survive he shouldn't have hurt you."

Chapter End Notes

It's been a *long* fucking time coming.

The End...

Chapter Summary

She-Ra takes down Prime.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

She is trying to focus on climbing up the ravine walls and not how warm (and cute) Catra is wrapped around her back. It is a lot easier to climb this when she's got proper use of both arms…and when she's not blinded by grief. She does, however, remember being just as angry last time. She meant it; Prime shouldn't have hurt Catra. Shouldn't have hurt any of her friends. Now he's going to die. She won't *let* him live past today.

The rifts she throws into the rocks as she makes hand-holds splinter and grow under her strength. Catra clings onto her tighter whenever the stone makes a too-loud crack. There's no trees hanging over the fissure high above that she can jump for, so she just has to climb. She hopes they're not on some unknown time frame.

Catra hops off her when they land firmly on solid ground again. She-Ra can feel the magic in the air still, she wonders if that will still be the case when she transforms back.

"Have any idea where we are?"

"No."

It's difficult to navigate the woods at the best of times but it's…a completely new place. There's flowers sparkling gold, the woods somehow more and less blue with everything new growing in the moonlight. In the distance she can hear something, it's magic and

it's new and it's waking for the first time in centuries, she just knows that. Catra's more in awe than she's ever seen her, and she takes a moment to just look at her; the way her ears are twitching trying to catch everything as she spins around. But she can't think about Catra, or how different the world is now, they need to save it first.

Swift Wind. She needs him. He can get them wherever they need to go. She can always feel him like a live wire buzzing in the background, quiet enough for her to only notice it when it's needed. But it's still easier to grab ahold as She-Ra. She feels him, sends 'need you' through the channel as strongly as she can.

"What are you…?"

"Swift Wind."

Catra looks up into the trees before she leaps. Adora tries her best to stay calm when she loses sight of her completely, listening intently for the rustle of leaves.
Catra hits the ground again the same time Swift Wind does.

"Prime's at Brightmoon, the ground was lighting up with fire but it all just stopped, was that you?"

She-Ra climbs onto his back, rubbing the fur on his neck. "Yeah, we activated the failsafe. Take us to…his flagship. Then Brightmoon."

She thinks Catra and Swift Wind are glaring at each other but she can only see one of them. "I have to, don't I?" She just gives Catra a look. And Catra just sighs, "Fine."

Catra takes her hand and swings in front of her. They both hold onto Swift Wind's mane as he takes off. Catra unsuccessfully hides her muffled distressed cries on the way up, she'll deny the sounds if either of them mention it, but there's no way Catra can deny the claws digging into Swift Wind's neck.

It takes them flying as high as the cloud bank for him to say, “Try not to pull my mane out!” over the top of the wind rush.

Catra’s ears are pinned to her head and her eyes are squeezed closed, “This is why I said I would *stay on the ground*.”

She sighs, maybe Catra will be able to tolerate Swift Wind (and flying) in the future. Until then, she can wrap an arm around Catra’s body to hold her. Catra seems grateful for it, not relaxing, but her tail loosens it’s choke hold on her leg. She can handle Catra’s claws better than Swift Wind can, especially like this.

It’s still dark, an hour or so before the first moonrise. They’re below the clouds, which means she can see the changed grounds clearly. Etheria’s always been beautiful - and it still is - but there’s shock in how suddenly it’s changed. The fireflies of gold from before are floating above the midnight blue canopy, everything seems to be near glowing. The colours are just more alive, *everything* is more alive. Maybe that’ll change as the magic flows, maybe this is the new normal.

“It looks so different,” she whispers, almost to herself. Catra’s ear flicks back to hear her and she holds her closer. She thinks Catra would like the view if she had her eyes open.

“Whatever you did is planet-wide as far as I can tell,” Swift Wind yells back.

“Enjoy the calm while you can, Princess, we’re still heading into a war zone.”

“Used to it.”

Maybe she was relying too heavily on Prime having no spires below his flagship. She didn’t know whether she would have to fight anything until they were above it. Which they are now. But luckily there seems to just be rolling green cliffs.

“Land down there.”

She doesn’t like them all being out in the open like this, but they seem safe enough. She can *keep* them safe even if something does appear. Catra sways with the landing, face ashen. She doesn’t want to make her fly again, but they’ll have to, she’s not leaving her behind. Catra climbs off as she does, legs shaking subtly enough that Adora can tell she’s trying to hide it.

The grass is plush and vibrant under her boots and she can’t even savour the strange feeling. She just strides forwards, signalling for Swift Wind and Catra to stay back. She doesn’t know if whatever it is she’s going to do will have a radius. She-Ra knows what she has to do, even if she, Adora, does not. So she lets the spirit take full control. She doesn’t remember a time when she’s ever *let* it happen before. It always scared her, feeling so out of control. But she isn’t anymore: She-Ra is hers.

She stares at the harsh edges of her hands where they soften with blinding light. The gravity shifts, her hair flowing upwards and the air around her bending. She finds herself smiling at the feeling as her sword materialises. Control.

Her feet sink into the ground, the planet building their connection as the power wells. Her legs go numb with the amount of magic flowing through them, the feeling spreading, telling her what to do. Her arm raises, bringing the sword up like there’s a string connecting her to the ship high above. She doesn’t yell as she does it. She is a conduit as the power bursts out and upwards through her blade, eating the air in a growing blaze. Somehow it reaches the ship, she knew it would. She knew she could *make* it. This is her power. Etheria wants her to use it.

Whether the magic consumes, surrounds or forces its way through Prime’s ship doesn’t matter. It is *working*. The iridescence is blinding, she can’t see anything through it, through the power flowing in her bones, in her skin.

She-Ra is healing, light and love. She understands that now. Her power's never manifested in a physical form before but perhaps it was meant to. Her arm drops when the magic has run its course. The gold in her vision fades, leaving her staring up at where the acid hue of the ship's light is gone. His machines are hanging dead in the air and she...made the ship into a tree. She can hear Catra's little disbelieving laugh behind her.

The ground lets her go, apparently satisfied. She knows she's not done, but she thinks she can just stand here and get her breath back first. She's already given two bouts of magic, even the planet knows she's tired (somehow she can feel that.) Just one more, then she'll rest.

Catra's hand on her arm is welcome, and she grips onto it carefully. Catra kisses her hand and it finally gets her to look away from the sky, from the thing she made of the enemy. She wants to kiss her. And she *will* when this is all over. When she is only Adora again. They deserve to have a kiss that doesn't have impending doom suffocating them. She settles for kissing Catra's forehead, laughing to herself about having to bend down to do even that, smiling painfully wide when Catra trills quietly.

Catra's blushing once She-Ra is standing upright again. She tries to cover it by coughing, but even she knows it's not going to work *at all*. "Are we done? No, never mind that's a stupid question. Do I have to get back on the horse?"

"Do I have to let her ride on me again?"

She takes Catra's hand and starts walking back over to her steed, ignoring Catra's heavy sigh. "Yes. I don't know what that did, but I know the planet wanted me to do it. Prime should've lost some, hopefully a lot, of his power but he's still hurting our friends."

Neither of them complain this time as they rise in altitude once again.

Clearly whatever she did worked at least in some ways. There are clones wandering aimlessly in the woods below, Catra tells her. She says they're talking to Prime like he's gone missing or far away. The hivemind, she must have done *something* to it when she fucked up the ship.

They see Brightmoon before they hear anything from it. There's smoke plumes but they're small, there's shouting but it doesn't sound horribly dire. The civilians are still in the mountain caves, it seems. It's just the Princesses and their friends on the battlefield below the Moonstone. (It's remarkably like the Battle of Brightmoon, but she doesn't want to think about that seeing as she has Catra *in her arms as She-Ra* right now.)

There aren't that many clones, and they're disorganised. Most of them are unmoving, some have their weapons raised and firing slowly, but out of sync like they're wary - like they don't know where anything is. The bots aren't moving either, though if their connection is broken, she supposes they don't have consciousness to dictate that they should still be attacking. All the friends they've lost are there, some still fighting, most standing idle without orders. Apparently Prime was saving them for this fight. She thanks the gods that Frosta's connection seems to be failing. Netossa has rushed forward, encasing her and Frosta in one of her nets.

"There's Prime!" Catra calls, pointing to a hill where a clone stands motionless. But she's right, it's not like the rest of them. There's an expression on its face for one; anger as it stares down at the dwindling battle, knowing it's losing.

Horde Prime watches them, he aims his cannon at them but Swift Wind shoots it with a beam. Prime cries out from the pain as the weapon falls from around his body's arm. There's a small chorus from the clones on the ground, all calling out for their Lord. Some of them...seem to be weeping but that is the least of her concern.

Her and Catra are jumping to the ground before Swift Wind even lands, and he flies off into the fray shooting beams of blue-white

light. Prime doesn't move, doesn't run, doesn't even attack. He's too proud for it. Never one to fight his own battles (Hordak had to have learnt it from somewhere.) Fuck does she hate him. It feels insulting after everything he has put them and everyone else through that he should just *stand there*.

Maybe Catra's thinking the same as her, maybe she's just snarling with pure threat. They're both rushing towards him, but Catra's always been quicker than her, and she still is.

"You cannot even hope to defeat -"

Catra just punches him in the face. And all things considered, she should have seen that coming. She-Ra just needs to get a hold on him to be able to eviscerate him from the body he's piloting. She knows to do that, just as she did with the ship. She hears the crack when Catra forces the clone's arms behind its back. Prime is still in the body, but he surely won't be for long.

He laughs in Catra's hold, the glow of his eyes already slipping away but she won't let him. She-Ra's hands are beaming gold when she grabs his false face. The magic freezes him, forcing him back into this body. Prime struggles and Catra forces him onto his knees, most likely gouging into his skin with her claws if the grit of her teeth is anything to go by.

She can tell Prime is in pain. He should be. He deserves so much worse than what she's going to do to him. But the Universe needs him gone, nothing else. She kneels in front of him, glaring and hoping this will hurt.

He spits, "Though all is reduced to rubble, Prime shall rise again. So it has been, and so it always shall be."

"No. You're done. And it's time for you to fucking go."

She pushes her magic forward. There's just darkness inside, it's not green, it's not white, it's pure black. A creature too old and too powerful that should've died long ago. She doesn't know what Catra sees or feels as she forces the gold-white of light and

healing and everything else into the cavity occupied by the Universe's best parasite. She-Ra forces it out, her magic too bright, too big, too overwhelming to let that thing live any longer.

The light destroys it. The love she feels; for the world, for her friends, for Catra, it all burns through the congealed cloud. And when she opens her eyes it's just…gone. Prime is gone. There's a body he made left in its wake, the blank green eyes of a clone staring at her in shock. Catra let's them go and She-Ra does the same.

Everything is entirely still for an infinite moment. Then the air comes rushing back and there's just a clone lying prone on the ground. They're not dead, she made sure of that. They're just free. She doesn't truly know how the hivemind works, but she knows she just cut off the head of a body spanning galaxies.

The two of them look down at the battlefield. Frosta is wrapped in a group hug, Micah has his hand on Juliet's shoulder and Sea Hawk and Mermista are kissing. Clones are huddling together, bots are collapsing on the ground (not just from Swift Wind going around and kicking them.) The power flows out of her the next moment, and she's just Adora.

Catra whispers, "Their eyes, they're - you did it."

"Yeah… Yeah, he's gone. I - oh my gods we did it."

Catra grabs her arm and she swings round to look at her. There is pure shock on Catra's face but there is happiness too. "He's - he's fucking gone! Adora!"

Catra throws her arms around her first, but she's the one sweeping Catra up and spinning them. They are both laughing obnoxiously loudly but they've fucking earned it.

"Catra we really did it!" She knows she's shouting, but for once Catra doesn't seem to care about the volume.

She has barely set Catra back on her feet before she's kissing her. She's surprised at her own lack of hesitation but only for a moment because Catra is *crushing* them together. Her nose is squished up against Catra's cheek and she loves it. Loves her. Loves that they're alive. All of Catra's joy and relief and elation that she is pouring into the kiss; it's like she can feel it as her own.

And then it gets ruined, because they can't just have one normal kiss *apparently*. The clone far too close to them starts wailing. Catra growls at the slowly brightening sky as they break apart.

"I promise, one day we will have a normal kiss."

"I will hold you to that," Catra says about as seriously as she's ever heard her. But there's still that undeniable happiness and slight breathlessness that makes her heart jump.

Catra holds her hand as they walk over to the clone (she's not expecting it at all but she will *gladly* take it.) They've sat up now and look more confused than Adora's ever seen anyone look.

"Where is Horde Prime? He should - he's gone! What -"

She crouches down in front of them, hoping they're not going to attack her for getting rid of Prime. They very well might, she thinks Catra's growling means she's also figured that out. "Hey, it's going to be okay. You're free now."

"I don't want to be free. I want to be with Lord Prime."

That's a horrible thing to hear. She has no fucking clue how to get this clone to stop crying. And she absolutely will not touch them, not after what she just forced out of them.

"Why don't you go down to your...brothers? Maybe if you stay together it won't be so bad?"

Catra is trying so hard not to sound angry about having to deal with this, and it's sweet in a weird way because she's not doing it

very well. But the clone does listen to her, managing to stand and looking down to find their brothers. They go quickly down the mountain side. Neither of them bother to watch which group the clone is heading to.

“Okay, okay that was -”

“- Fucking weird,” Catra summarises incredibly accurately.

“Yeah… But we won. And we can deal with *all of that* later. Right?" With how tired she is, she would not put it past herself to have forgotten to do something.

Catra tugs on the hand she's still holding, "*Yes*, Dora."

She breathes a sigh of relief at being right, "Thank the gods... Come here.”

She is determined to do this right. Catra purrs as soon as her hand cups her face, seeming shocked with herself at the sudden sound, and she thinks she’s earned the right to be smug about it. This is *Catra*. But she can be smug later, right now, she just wants to kiss the woman she loves as softly as she can. She keeps it quick to limit the chances for interruption.

“I love you.” She wants to say so much more, but it can wait. She's waited this fucking long, a few more hours, days, weeks, she can handle. Catra already knows the most important part.

Catra’s ears show her surprise and she can’t resist leaning forward to kiss the base of one. Because she *can*, because it gets Catra to stutter out a, “I - I love you too.”

Catra really only has to turn her head a fraction for them to kiss again. The clear absence of claws as Catra holds her back makes her melt. Which wouldn’t be an issue if they were alone, even if it is still embarrassing. But they aren’t alone. Glimmer and Bow’s cheering registers to Catra first, but she’s not that far behind. At least she’s not the only one of them to be obviously flustered about being caught.

Glimmer and Bow tackle them in a hug and normally she'd be able to keep everyone upright but she is beyond drained. They all fall into the grass together, and she's thankful Prime didn't pick a cliff edge to oversee his defeat. It seems the relief-fuelled laughter is starting to hit Bow and Glimmer now as they lie on the grass looking up at Horde Prime's ships. She curls into Catra's side as they wait out their mildly hysterical fit. (Catra wraps an arm around her shoulder immediately and she smiles into her fur.)

"How are you guys feeling?" Bow asks, nudging Glimmer so they both roll into the impromptu hug pile she started. Catra, to her credit, says nothing as Glimmer settles in at her other side with Bow at her back. It's nice, she can admit that. Catra definitely will not.

"Like I want to sleep for a week."

Healing alone is enough to knock her out for a few hours from the power drain. She is very sure she could sleep for an entire day right now. She'd be setting her own record.
Catra hums her agreement, not purring but she is holding onto her tightly.

"We can do that," Glimmer says cheerily from Catra's stomach.

If anyone else sees them all like this, Catra is going to bolt and brush it all off. Adora prays to the gods that will not happen. She is very content here (with her face in Catra's collarbone.) All her friends are here, and *surprisingly* - fucking astoundingly - they are all safe.
At least she hopes so.

"Everyone's alright down there, nothing I need to heal?"

Catra growls into her hair, "No. You're done for the day. There are medics for a reason, they can handle everything."

She feels like she relents a bit too easily but, "Someone should still go tell the people it's safe."

Glimmer grins tiredly, “Someone that is not one of us. We’ve done enough. We’re just going to stay here. And you two are going to tell us everything that happened.”

“Glim, they might not want to.”

She is far too tired, too raw, to tell it the way they’ll want it. But she doesn’t know about Catra - Catra might not even want them to know at all. So she asks with just her name, “Catra?”

“They can know. And before you guys ask or start crying or whatever, yes I did what you told me to do -”

Bow cheers dramatically towards the sky, loud enough for Catra’s ears to fold down. He apologises after.

“About fucking time,” Glimmer says, but she’s sparkling so her joy is evident.

She doesn’t actually know what Catra’s on about, so, “What -”

“- They told me to tell you how I felt. I did that.”

She moves slowly to prop herself on her elbow so she can look at her...whatever they are now. She wants them to be girlfriends, but they can figure it out later. “You did. And it saved the world.”

“It -” Catra will deny that she is blushing but she is. And she’s beautiful and Adora loves her and Catra *knows* that now. “You really think it was *that*?”

“I *know* it was that. I’d given up, and you…” she doesn't like how her voice breaks at the end.

She’s already cried so much today. She wants to again, but there’s just nothing left but exhaustion. Catra looks much like how she feels; the sadness and all the rest of it present even if they both have so many reasons to be happy. Catra moves the hand that was around her shoulders to her face. And she sinks into it as much as she can, not even caring that they aren’t alone - Catra’s

allowing it either way.
She just wants to fall asleep with her now. Everything else can happen after.

Bow starts carefully, "Do you guys want to be alone? We'd get it -"

"- No, it's fine. We can talk about that part later," Catra answers for them.

She settles back down, falls into the relief just closing her eyes brings her. "We should probably tell them the parts before the end of the world. It was very dramatic."

"Everything always is with you."

"Have you met yourself? I could give a million examples right now." She tries her damn best to keep the yawn out of her words. And fails.

"You'd be asleep before you even reached five."

"Not true. I could kick your ass right now."

"Uh huh, sure." She shoves Catra in the shoulder as best she can from her position, feeling her purr silently start up in her chest. (*Now* she's smug.)

"You purr?" Glimmer questions. Adora supposes it would be weird if your pillow just started rumbling.

Catra mutters, "No of course not," and keeps the sound going.

Bow asks, "Can I?"

Adora's not looking but she can feel when Bow puts a hand on Catra's side, most likely with his arm around Glimmer too. He 'aw's just as expected.

"I know exactly what face you're making Arrows, don't think I don't."

Adora laughs, not even opening her eyes to check - she knows Catra's right.

She lets Catra tell the story when she's ready to. Her purring stops, but she doesn't tense, which means she's not really thinking as she says the frankly quite despairing words. She's detached from it, tone even as she gives their friends the basics of what happened. And Adora thinks she's listening - she would tell anyone that she is, in fact, listening. But she falls asleep before the story even reaches the Heart.

Catra

She knew Adora was going to be *tired* but she still goes completely silent once she realises that she has just fallen asleep on top of her out in the open. The story hurt to tell; it's still fresh and raw and she almost didn't get the words out. But she manages it without the detail. Without telling them how weak Adora's pulse was in the end, how devastated she felt watching Weaver burn up in front of her.

"She asleep?" Glimmer asks quietly from her resting place on her stomach.

And when Adora doesn't answer, Bow mouths, "Wow."

She is absolutely not saying anything above a whisper now. "Well she did a fuck ton of magic - did you see what she did to Prime's ship?"

"No, what - Oh shit." Glimmer sits up suddenly and she has to fight down her hiss when it threatens to jostle Adora.

Bow sits up with her, face equally confused, "She turned it into a tree?"

She fucking did. "Was definitely *not* expecting it. You should've seen her though…"

She strokes gently through Adora's hair (she'll take it out of the band later), not realising how pathetically in love she sounds until she feels two pairs of eyes on her. She resists the growing urge to run, forcing herself to keep looking at Adora *peacefully asleep in her arms*. If Adora can be asleep like this then it is safe.

"You love her so much."

Glimmer doesn't say it like an accusation, thankfully. It's just… fact. Part of her shies away from it, how there's no option of denial. The other, better, part glows. These are her friends, they won't hurt her if she admits it out loud. (Even if she doesn't truly believe that yet.)

"I… Yeah, I do. Or whatever."

"*Or whatever*... Feels good to say it though finally, doesn't it?"

Glimmer is *pushing it*. Whether she knows that or not, Catra doesn't care. "Don't be smug. Not very queenly of you."

"Like I give a shit about that."

"Shush, you'll wake her."

Glimmer seems to take it for what it actually is, sighing (she would dare to say fondly, but it is) and turning back to the view. She looks back to Adora in her arms once Glimmer is cuddled up with Bow. The quiet flow of water, for once, is perfect.

She wraps her other arm around Adora as well, not thinking about it. Adora hums in her sleep as she shifts to accommodate the new position. And now everything inside her is screaming that she can't do this during the day, exposed as they are. But she fights it. Because Adora wants to be in her arms; because she wants to curl around the person who means the most to her.

And she purrs into her hair, the action and scent effectively calming everything. Not enough to sleep, but she wants to stay awake. When does she ever get to just soak in the peace of a

moment? Fucking never. Though…that might change. She had chances of it before Prime. But she didn't have Adora then, not like this.

"Bet there's lots of things that can happen now that you never thought could."

She gets why Bow said that, looked like that, now. He...was right. He was fucking right. It won't be the same, things *can't* be the same after what Adora said (after what *she* said.) But she doesn't want them to be. There isn't a world where she wouldn't give everything to be with her the way she always dreamed. She somehow managed to convince herself once that that wasn't true, to make it hurt less. (It didn't.)
If Adora had said what she did today...she would've gone with her. It might have taken her days to get over her own pride, but she would have.

She can forget about that, all the mistakes she made for Adora, because of Adora, in spite of Adora. In this moment, none of it matters. Because they're here. And they're alive. And they're together. They're free of Shadow Weaver, of Adora's destiny, of everything that told them they couldn't be together. Because they *are*. She can kiss her when she wakes up, and hold her and she'll be able to tell her everything with time.

She loves Adora, she always has and she always will. And Adora...Adora says she feels the same damn way. And right fucking now, nothing else matters.

Chapter End Notes

I didn't mean to get emotional over this but I should've known myself better. Needless to say, I never expected to be working on this fic for something like 10 months. But...I'm glad I did it. Even if it's just because I can prove to myself that I can finish long projects.
We've just got the epilogue and the requested 'they go get Melog' oneshot after this!

...And After

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra

In the end Glimmer teleports the two of them into Adora's bed without warning. The Queen didn't fucking think that through because Adora bolts awake. Catra tries not to be angry, she really does but the emotion clearly shows because Glimmer is apologising and poofing out of the room the next second.

She watches as Adora rubs at her eyes, "How long was I asleep for?"

"An hour, maybe more. Feel better?"

Adora's ponytail is a wreck. It's cute. Still, she reaches up slowly to take it out (she did tell herself she would.) Adora doesn't even bat an eye at the gesture.

"Not really. But I should probably eat before I go back to sleep, I don't know when I'll wake up."

"Good idea. Hey you got..." She catches sight of the rucksack she stole lying open on the floor. It stings, seeing it again. She gets off the bed before she can second guess herself.

As she walks back, she throws the food left inside for Adora to catch. And then dumps the rest of its contents onto the floor, including the bag itself. Adora turns an apple over in her hands, smiling up at her, "That's a dramatic way of saying you're staying."

"*You* said I was dramatic." She puts a knee on the bed and crawls closer slowly until there's inches between them. Adora's looking at her lips and she has to tell herself she's not imagining it. She's *not*. "I'm just proving you right."

Adora bites her own lip clearly thinking about something, and for the first time in her fucking life she doesn't have to force herself not to look. "Can I kiss you?"

"Yes." Adora tosses the apple aside and reaches up for her. She manages to breathe out, "I want you to," before their lips meet.

Adora

Catra *wants* this. And it feels so much better to hear that out loud than it is to just think it uncertainly to herself. Distantly, she realises that this is their first kiss inside their room. (She's not really sure how long she's been thinking of it as *theirs*, but it doesn't really matter.)

Catra's purring under her hands, and even when she breaks the connection, she doesn't let go. Catra settles in her lap and the intimacy of it feels amazing. It feels like those first few weeks when she was allowed to touch Catra again; everything just feeling like *more* even though they've done it before.
Though, she supposes it *is* more. Catra never twined her arms around her before she came to Brightmoon, never rested their foreheads together, she never held Catra like this before the split. And Catra certainly never kissed her.

"Have I mentioned that you're really good at that?"

"At what, kissing?" Catra asks amusedly.

She knows she's blushing now but Catra sits back specifically to give her a look like she's trying not to laugh so… "Yeah," she concedes.

Catra moves a hand from her back to poke a claw at her forehead. "You haven't kissed anyone else, you fucking dork."
The thought of *'Catra's my first kiss,'* might be a little bit late, but it hits her just as hard. It hits her *visibly* if the way Catra's tail swishes means what she thinks it does.
"What're you smiling at?"

“You’re my first kiss.”
Catra’s face softens just as the slope of her ears does. And she can’t help it - she doesn't want to help it - she moves her hands up to Catra’s ears. Slowly so the feeling doesn’t come out of nowhere, she sets to scratching at the bases lightly just to watch her fight melting into her hands. Catra gives in almost suspiciously fast.
“And now I don’t need to kiss anyone else.”

Catra hisses weakly as her face *lights up* red. More than Adora thinks she’s ever seen it, and she doesn’t bother to hide her delighted laugh. Catra bats her hands away and she doesn’t care, too elated with the reaction.

Catra climbs off her lap muttering, “You - eat your fucking apple or whatever.”

“You know you’re cute when you blush?”

Catra huffs, blowing her hair out of her eyes. “Oh you’ve been holding onto that one haven’t you?”

She has. She’s allowed to grin obnoxiously about it. Catra tolerates it for exactly three seconds before doing that *thing* she does; the shift as she pushes her fluster down and forces the confidence back in. Catra leans over her again, she knows she’s reaching for the food scattered near her but that doesn’t exactly occur to her as Catra whispers in her ear.

“You’re not too bad at it yourself, Princess. Now eat.”

Catra makes her change into sleep clothes, unsurprisingly. She’d flopped back to the bed after eating, fully intent on falling back to sleep but Catra dragged her back up. She knows she should but it didn't used to matter. Still, she gets up and wanders over to the dresser to get clothes for both of them when she remembers.

“I know you saw your, um...your mask when you...” She feels cowardly for not looking at her.

“Can’t believe you kept it.” Catra’s voice is calm, nothing indicating that she doesn’t like what she did, which is good at least.

She shrugs, pulling fabric out, “I couldn’t get rid of it. I don’t know why.”

“You’re a sentimental idiot?”

How obviously *fond* Catra sounds lets her finally turn back. Her tail is waving languidly behind her as she smiles crookedly. It occurs to her that that is exactly what she thought Catra would say if she ever found out, it’s nice to be right.

“Something like that, yeah.”

Catra doesn’t hesitate to crawl into her arms as soon as they’re under the covers. Catra says nothing, just purring as she wraps around her. The sudden unprompted nature of the action still shocks her even if she was kind of expecting it, and Catra is tense in her arms until she squeezes her into her chest. She was always making excuses to touch Catra, to be as close to her as she could. They don’t *need* excuses now and Catra’s taking full advantage of it. She should be too.

‘You can touch her. She wants you to.’

She kisses Catra’s hair, just to prove to herself it’s okay. Catra’s ears pricking forwards are the only part of her that reacts so she does it again (and again), until Catra huffs a laugh. At that, she sets to tracing little paths on her back with her blunt nails. Catra likes this, she knows she does. She doesn’t need the confirmation of the subtle way she arches into the touch but it is fucking appreciated. She’s not exactly flying blind, but there are *possibilities* she can entertain now.

Catra is lying on top of her, between her legs and purring. Catra is in love with her. There are *possibilities*. Even if she weren't beyond exhausted, she wouldn't try for anything too new right now (just kissing is kind of making her short circuit.) But she can push a boundary without feeling like Catra might run from her or figure out her feelings.

"Can I pet you?"

The hesitance in her tone gives her away, and it's clear from the way Catra's tail flicks under the blankets as she raises her head to look at her that she picked up on it. But she says yes anyway and the blatant (though cautious) trust drives her forwards to kiss her softly.

She slides her hands under the bottom of Catra's shirt and just rests them on her back. Catra stills for a second before her purr skyrockets under her lips. It's easy after that to just stroke up and down Catra's spine as she unashamedly cuddles with her. And that's really the part that's getting to her: that Catra's not ashamed of it. Catra is dragging her cheek across her collarbones, *marking* her in that way she's always been secretive and standoffish about. And fuck does it make her feel loved.

She only stops when Catra's purring turns to gentle snoring on top of her. She knows she'll have a dead something when she wakes up if she does fall asleep like this. She does not fucking care. It is so damn easy to just drift off like this. And by the gods she just *wants* to.

"Can't believe we slept the whole day." She sits up next to Catra, and she can't help smiling at her. (Her hair's all over the place it is *cute*.)

Catra knocks her shoulder, "Think you mean *you* did."

Her smile turns into a grin as she leans into Catra's side and teases, "You stayed with me. It counts."

“Shut up. It wasn’t because I like you.”

“Oh really? Because there are some things that have happened recently that *really* suggest -”

It takes Catra actually kissing her for her to realise she was leaning in. She is in no way *used* to this, but she’s not scared to fall into it this time. She knows she *can*, knows it’s safe. She wraps her arms around Catra’s waist, loving how Catra’s rough morning purr starts up with it. Catra turns her body towards her and slides her hands tenderly up her arms and she’s just...not expecting it.
It’s at times like this when she wishes she could purr, she wants Catra to *feel* how much she loves this.

Catra bites her lip gently as she pulls away and by the tone of her voice, it’s from her own exasperation. “I can’t believe you kissed me and we managed to not figure anything out.”

Catra’s breathless and she just wants to crush her into her arms (not a new thought or want, but the intensity certainly is.) She gives in only slightly, putting a little more pressure into her fingertips, watching carefully for claws. “Hey, I thought you knew! *I* wasn’t the one who got angry.”

Catra’s claws do dig in but it’s just like they used to when they were messing around. Catra scoffs at her and she really needs to stop forgetting how strong Catra is because her heart can’t take the sudden reminders.

Catra pushes her shoulders and pins her to the bed, exclaiming, “You told me it was CPR, asshole!” She’s laughing until Catra’s climbing on top of her and leaning over her so that they’re nose to nose. “*You* didn’t do anything to make me think it was because you loved me.”

All she wants to do is kiss her again, but she has a *point* to make. “You were dead in my arms and the thing I think to do is kiss you? I - I thought I was being obvious.”

Catra considers it for a moment before flopping down onto her chest, “Can we both agree we were really stupid?”

“Yeah.” She kisses Catra’s ears just...because she wants to. Because it seems to be okay for her to do. There’s a muffled chirrup against her chest and heart feels like it’s fucking *bursting*.

Catra

They get their breakfast with Bow and Glimmer, just like Adora said they would. Adora doesn’t let go of her hand for a second, pushing their chairs together to make it possible and she has to pretend it means nothing to her.

She doesn’t think she’s at fault then if she maybe looks at Adora too much - more than she’s ever *let* herself do before. She’d go as far as to call it gazing if the word didn’t make her so uncomfortable. It’s instinctual to look away whenever Adora catches her, it’s going to take longer than a day for that to change. Her tail is betraying her though, brushing up against Adora’s leg whenever she does.
When Adora catches her the third time she kisses her on the cheek so quickly it’s like a challenge.

Bow stops her from figuring out how to retaliate. “You guys finally talk it all out then?”

“…Uh, yeah. Yeah we’re -”

“- We’re girlfriends now,” Adora says, just fucking beaming.

She hides her subsequent blush in her unused hand. Adora hasn’t *said* it yet and she absolutely was not prepared. It is a stupid thing to feel so strongly about but she does, deep down, know that she has kind of been waiting for Adora to say those words for the past twenty years of her life. (Though now she kind of wants to hear someone else call them that because she's sure she'd start purring on the spot.)

She knows without a doubt that Adora is watching her reaction. And she'd spend her next words denying how red her face is (and how obviously her body is giving her away), but she doesn't want Adora to think she *doesn't like it*. She knows how much her best friend overthinks. And she is still her best friend even if they are clearly more than that now. It's reassuring.

She turns and whispers, "We're girlfriends." Honestly being in awe of the fact that it is *true*. Adora's shoulder is a better hiding place than her hand anyway. She can feel Adora grinning into her hair and she kisses her quickly on her neck just to hear her muffled squeak.

The sound of Glimmer saying, completely deadpan, "Took you fucking long enough," thankfully drowns out Bow's cooing. (She expected nothing less, her fur still bristles.)

"You and Bow took just as long and *you* didn't grow up in the Fright Zone," Adora says half teasing, half smug.

Bow puts his hands up, "...That's fair."

Catra grumbles about having to tell the rest of the Alliance about their relationship (purely because she feels like she has to put up a protest first and she's glad Adora knows that.) But she is *happy* to tell them because apparently they gave Adora some shit about them being obvious before they even got together and she's got a fucking point to make now.

The point is that she kisses Adora in the Alliance's dining room when she can hear them coming down the hall and only breaks it when Mermista asks, "So you guys finally got around to it?"

"Us *getting around to it* saved all your asses, you should be saying thank you Seaweed."

They all look to Adora for confirmation of that and she purrs quietly with satisfaction at the red dusting her girlfriend's cheeks.

"No, no she's right. About the saving thing, not the thank you."

Frosta, Sea Hawk, Juliet, all their chipped friends were there at the battle. Without the source, the people came back into themselves; the chips still attached, hivemind still mostly operational, but able to think for themselves again. Frosta and Sea Hawk complain avidly about how loud it is in their heads, unable to distinguish anything anyone is saying.

Entrapta sets to getting the chips off with a little too much enthusiasm. But all in all that turns out to be a good thing since it takes her only a day to finalise the program. Catra is by Adora's side when the code gets sent through the network. She knows her girl still feels guilty about being the reason Sea Hawk and Juliet left the safety of the spell in the first place, even if neither of them hold even a shred of blame towards her.

The chips just...fall off. And according to Entrapta, that was (sort of) expected. "Every chip on the network should be dead."

Everyone breathes a sigh of relief. Except Entrapta who hurriedly collects the chips off the ground with her hair and puts them in a test tube. She gives them to Scorpia who looks like she'd rather not hold them.

Glimmer puts a hand on Entrapta's arm carefully, "*Every* one? As in across the entire Universe?"

"That's correct, yes. Frosta, can I look at your neck?"

Frosta lifts up her hair and Perfuma presses a cloth to the small pin pricks of blood, Mermista does the same for her boyfriend. Sea Hawk sits next to Frosta, a hand on her shoulder, and even Catra can see that there is going to be a bond over that experience. Ice Princess and an arsonist is going to be interesting.

Scorpia's with Entrapta as the Princess starts prodding at the machinery again, and Catra goes over to them. Most of the others start filing out of the room, and Entrapta pulls her mask down

before supplying a chip with a small electrical signal. Nothing happens and the Princess seems to be happy with that.

"Well shit, you really did it. Good job." She is beyond thankful it doesn't sound forced because she is actually genuine.

The mask gets flipped up and Entrapta's wearing her huge smile. "Thanks!"

Adora

It's not until nightfall when her thoughts let up. *The whole Universe* - that's what Entrapta said. Everyone is free but they haven't been for *thousands* of years. That's…people will need help. And Catra's going to roll her eyes at her (or worse) for wanting to help everyone in existence but she can't fucking change how she feels, how she works, overnight.
They might be the only ones who can help. She has an obligation. And she wants to. *After* they settle everything here. After everything that happened in the Heart, she can admit that she needs a break at least.

It takes until herself, Catra, Bow and Glimmer are all in the Queen's bedroom for her to actually be able to ask, "Should we go out there?"

"What do you mean?" Glimmer's looking at her like she's crazy, which is fair considering how completely out of the blue and poorly worded that was.

"Space, I mean. Etheria - the First Ones were harvesting magic, who's to say they didn't do it to others. We might be the only people left *with* magic."

Bow puts his glass down to level her with a look that is clearly asking if she's thought this though, "You want to go to space?"

She bites her lip nodding, waiting for Catra to say something because she can *feel* it coming.

“You want to go help everyone in the fucking Universe?” Catra sounds exactly as she thought she would, but at least that means she doesn’t seem angry. “Of course you fucking do, you idiot.” Catra’s smiling exasperatedly and climbing off Glimmer’s window seat when she manages to look at her.

“Obviously not now. Etheria first. But…”

She's not expecting Catra’s arm around her waist even though she sat down practically on top of her. “Wait until we tell Entrapta. She’s going to scream.”

“You want to?” She knows her shock’s probably making her look like a moron but that’s really not a priority right now.

Catra rolls her eyes but it’s followed by her kissing the corner of her mouth. “I already know you’re going to do it. And I’m with you, dummy, so I’m doing it too. And besides, who’s going to stop you doing stupid shit if I’m not there?”

There’s not much that could’ve prevented her from throwing her arms around her girlfriend in that moment, and none of them happened. It kind of feels like she squeezes Catra’s purr out of her and she can’t help giggling.

“Don’t make such a big deal out of it.” And then Catra’s pushing her back and levelling her with a look, “*But* you have to promise me you’ll look after yourself. No more self-sacrificing or I *will* make you sorry.”

“Okay, okay, I promise.”

“We’re going too," Glimmer declares sharply, "I mean I have to get Brightmoon in order first and -“

“- We’ll figure it all out. And then it’ll be Catra’s first proper Best Friend Squad adventure,” Bow says excitedly, putting an arm around Glimmer’s shoulders.

“Okay when you put it like that maybe I don’t want to go?”

"Bet I can make you change your mind."

"Oh yeah? And how -"

The fact that Catra immediately starts purring into the kiss is basically just admitting defeat. And she will be smug about it later.

People have always said Catra is a bad influence but she's never truly believed it. And she still doesn't. But she also is now aware that Catra can talk her into staying in bed all morning just by taking her top off and purring her name. Glimmer has been teasing her relentlessly about willingly missing breakfast for the first time ever.

The first rebuilding meeting happens in the midst of celebration party planning (and at noon because Glimmer will not *give it a rest*.) There's no significant damage anywhere really, mostly they just need to get rid of spires and bots. But people need aid and Salineas still hasn't fully recovered from the Horde. Catra grows dark at the reminder in the morning and she flutters kisses over her face to make her feel better. It works.

A couple minutes into said meeting, it's decided that She-Ra is going to Salineas in a week and the fact that everyone assumed Catra would be going with her anyway when she requested she go too made both of them feel weirdly exposed. It's nice to know that neither of them are used to this even five days later.
Still, she can get over the vulnerability if it means she can hold Catra's hand from the moment the meeting starts. Though that doesn't work entirely in her favour, she finds out:

"If we send a sorcerers party here then -"

She points with her right hand. Which wouldn't be an issue except she is holding Catra's hand with it and it is now too late not make it go unnoticed. The sound Catra makes when she's pulled forward is cute and so is the dark blush on her face. She doesn't

actually want to stop holding Catra's hand so she just settles quickly back in her seat. Catra doesn't pull away even if she's pointedly not looking at her, so neither does she.

"Aw Catra, are you embarrassed?"

"Can it, Glitter."

"You're acting as if you guys haven't been holding hands during every meeting you've ever attended."

Catra and Mermista's relationship is still not *great* but it's better than it was since the Heart. Catra's relationship with most people has gotten better since the Heart, saving the Universe improves a reputation drastically it turns out. She hopes to the gods that one day Catra will be remembered for that rather than everything else.

"I was in handcuffs. Doesn't count."

They've already spoken to Entrapta. She cried and laughed maniacally in equal measures, Adora even got her first proper Entrapta hug, hair and everything, when she found out it was her idea. They're going to space.

And they tell the others. It's shocking news, understandably, considering until a few months ago they didn't have anything beyond their own moons. But everyone has months if not a year or so to come to terms with it, including themselves. It is *exciting* even with the anxiety of the crushing void of space (she didn't even know it was *crushing* until Entrapta screeched it happily.)

They have time and they will be prepared. Eventually. Whenever she starts thinking too hard about it, Catra brings her back by reminding her with her own words: *Etheria first*.

Catra

The rebuilding is fucking slow. She hates the multiple teleports it takes for them to get to Salineas but it is better than going by boat. She has dealt with the Kingdom before and she'll do it again; she's here to help this time even if she is burdened by guilt.

It's all physical exertion since they're following Glimmer's plan and it kind of feels like being back in the Fright Zone's training halls. Being tired from helping people feels *good* though. And she knows that Adora is proud of her for facing the Salineans (and her own mistakes) because her girlfriend tells her every evening.

Adora's been amazing. Happy for them to use what little time they get to themselves to sleep if she says so, and she'll hold her even if she's not tired yet. She hasn't spent a night alone and if Adora has to get up early she'll wake her up too just to tell her where she's going. She didn't ask Adora to do that, she didn't realise she needed it, but she *does*.

They went on their first proper, honest to gods *date* before they left, Adora 'sneaking' a picnic onto their new roof spot. (She knows she got Sparkles to help.) She thought it only fair that on their first night in Salineas where they weren't exhausted that they should climb onto the palace roofs and stargaze. She didn't mean for them to fall asleep up there but getting to watch the moonrises was worth it.

It's those kinds of memories that make being here again bearable. She never had any good waiting for her anywhere when she led the battle that caused the destruction she now walks through daily. Now every time she hears terrible things or sees a torn up Horde insignia or anything else, she knows she can go find Adora, or be in her arms within a couple of hours. It makes it easier.

She didn't realise that Adora was hearing those same things. Not until they make it back to their temporary room and Adora immediately wraps around her from behind and sets to kissing her neck. She covers Adora's hands with hers, purring into the

affection for just a moment. It's not the first time Adora's done this but it feels off; it feels like an apology.

"What's wrong, baby?"

She can feel Adora's weak smile at the name as she kisses her shoulder. "Does it bother you, all the things people say? I know it's calmed down now that you saved the Universe but…"

She would roll her eyes at the reminder but now is not the time. "Adora, I've dealt with that kind of shit my whole life, you know that. And yeah, it sucks that this time they're right when they say that stuff now, but I can deal with it."

How much Adora does not like that is evident in how tightly she holds her. She lets Adora have her minute of thinking, she seems like she needs it.

"Guess I can't threaten the citizens like I used to threaten cadets."

"No you can't *She-Ra*."

Adora half growls against her skin and she shouldn't feel happy knowing she's adopted it from being around her her whole life. "Anyone, and I mean *anyone*, goes too far. You tell me. It won't happen again."

Adora's conviction makes her breathless and she doesn't bother hiding it. "Alright. You know that works the other way too, right?"

"I do. Is there…" Adora sighs, "Is there anything I can do when it happens?"

She taps on Adora's arm three times and the hold retreats quickly. She pulls her back, just turning so she can hug Adora properly. Adora sinks into her, one of her hands winding up in her hair.

"Just this, when we're alone again. Doesn't matter who doesn't forgive me, because somehow *you* do, so…"

It’s still difficult to say things like that and she knows she’s blushing under her fur. When Adora pulls away she knows it’s just because she wants to look at her but she still tucks her chin into her chest. The hands on her back move to her hips and Adora bends to capture her in a gentle kiss.

Adora’s looking at her in that lovestruck way she does when it ends. “You can be really sweet when you want to be, you know that Cat?”

She manages not to scoff, she is getting better at that, instead pulling Adora down to kiss her again.

Apparently there is a difference between a ball and a party. They have had parties of varying scale in the past few months in various Kingdoms due to peace celebrations, but this is a proper ball like Princess Prom was. Catra can’t really tell if she’s excited about it or not until she realises she can dance with Adora all night without excuses (and she can dip her and kiss her this time instead of telling her she’s kidnapped her friends.)

She got another suit made in Brightmoon’s deep purple-blue because it doesn’t matter how many times Glimmer offhandedly mentions how good she would look in a dress, she will not wear one. But she knows Adora is wearing one and that’s more than enough to have her trying to coax details out of her stubborn girlfriend. She gets a few but it’s not enough to prepare her for it on the day.

She stops dead in her tracks, jacket half on when Adora comes out of the bathroom. Neither of them say anything but Adora’s the first one to move, walking over to her in midnight blue and gold and pulling her jacket into place. She lets her, eager to be able to take everything in from up close.

In no world would she ever say Adora looks bad in blue because she *does not*. The dress may not be sleeveless like she was

secretly hoping for, but the sheer gold fabric is almost better. She's allowed to stare at what of her girlfriend's chest is visible because she knows Adora's doing the fucking same. The gold matches with her sandals and the fucking crown Adora's wearing. (She knows it's not exactly a crown but the last thing the Horde would've ever taught her would be the specific names for types of tiaras.)

Adora's been wearing her hair down a lot more - courtesy of her claws and complicated relationship with hairbands - and so has been compromising by tying just the front parts back. As well as allowing her to play with her hair whenever she fucking wants, Adora also just looks damn good with it and now is no exception.

She purrs watching Adora looking at her, she knows Adora wants her but the visible proof always leaves her blood thrumming. Adora snaps out of her haze when she puts her hands on her waist, and her grip finally leaving her jacket and moving to her belt.

"You know I've had dreams about kissing you in a suit?"

She did not but she has had dreams of kissing Adora in that dress she wore so she is not going to waste time telling her that (or teasing her with, "Just kissing?") She tips her head back and pulls Adora down by her neck, almost cutting her lip in the process but she's long since learnt Adora doesn't care about that.

She heavily considers just not going if Adora's going to kiss her like this, pull on her belt like she's starving for her. But they will be dragged down by Glimmer no matter what and it's just not worth her ire or comments. Adora pouts when Catra detaches her hands from her belt for her but she steps away without prompting.

Catra puts her hands on her hips, trying not to think how easy it would be to just fall into bed with the love of her life. "Satisfied?"

Adora smooths her dress down, smirking, "No. But I will be later."

"Getting ahead of yourself, don't you think?"

“Not at all.”

She’s not going to argue because Adora is right. And she’s going to be thinking about it all night. “You look stunning, Princess. Did I mention that?”

“Think you made your point clear enough, baby.” Adora drags her thumb over her bottom lip seemingly just to make her watch it and she growls and makes her tail flick in petty retaliation.

“What’s up with the tiara? You miss it?”

“Glimmer said it’s a circlet or a diadem or something -”

“- It’s a tiara.”

Adora sighs fondly before getting close again. “Seems like you like it though.”

“Yeah, whatever, it looks good on you.”

For some reason that makes Adora take it off and she crosses her arms, ready to roll her eyes but Adora puts the metal on *her* head instead. The weight is a strange sensation and it’s cold, pressing down awkwardly on her sensitive ears.

“You look gorgeous,” Adora says near reverently. She holds her jaw in her hands and just looks at her, and she lets her, taking that same time to notice that Adora’s got gold dust on her cheeks. “I’m going to have one made for you.”

“Do I get a choice in -”

“- No, I'm getting you one. But you don’t have to wear it,” Adora says just as softly, draping her arms over her shoulders.

“Alright, Princess.” She puts the tiara back on Adora’s head crookedly. “Looks better on you though.”

Adora rolls her eyes, walking over to their vanity and she follows her. Adora fixes the metal back to her head properly like the Princess she is. “Doubt that.”

She wraps her arms around Adora’s waist, whispering through her purr, “Just let me compliment my girl.”

Adora blushes in the mirror glass, “Your girl.”

“Come on, we’re going to be late.”

It was clear early on in their space planning that they had no fucking clue what they’d need. And Catra really should’ve seen Adora’s obsession coming. With Salineas mostly rebuilt and Prime’s planetary additions long destroyed she had turned to focusing all her energy into making endless contingency plans. It went on for weeks.

And the shift in Adora’s mindset left Catra reeling and unsure what to do. She tried to distract Adora too often, didn’t take her seriously and though the resulting fight wasn’t *bad* considering everything, it was the worst one they had had since getting together. But they talked, made promises and deals.

Adora told her she just needed to finish everything she felt she needed to do, that she wouldn’t be able to relax until the work was done. It wasn’t like rebuilding efforts or anything else; there was an end date and goal, she just had to get to the point where she felt like she could stop.

And in response, Catra’s mission became getting her girlfriend to sleep, eat and everything else and she took it *seriously*. She would help with planning as much as she could but it was a secondary priority. Adora promised that when Catra decided she should sleep she would, and she never broke it.

By the time Adora has all but burnt herself out, the task list, supply list and all manner of other things are nearly finalised and

Adora finally tells her one night that she's comfortable enough to let someone else take over the main efforts.

She breathes a genuine sigh of relief. "Good girl, you've done so well Dora, I'm proud of you." Adora's body goes limp with the praise and reassurance, and Catra strokes through her hair. "Think you can take a day off tomorrow?"

Adora nods into her chest. "I'm tired."

"I know, baby. I'll be right here when you wake up, okay? I've missed you."

Adora doesn't argue that they've technically been together every day, which speaks to her exhaustion more than even the drowsiness soaking her voice. "I'm all yours tomorrow. I'll pull the She-Ra card if anyone says I can't."

"Can't wait, Princess."

In the run up to their planetary departure, Catra finds herself staring at the stars more, coming slowly to terms with the fact she will be amongst them soon. The spaceship is completely operational according to Entrapta, the machine having been sent into space on autopilot and returning safely was her final test. (Not that that is going to stop the Princess tampering and tinkering but it at least assures them they won't die immediately.)

Her and Adora also face the fact that aside from rebuilding missions that last a week or two at most, they've never had to pack for anything - not with personal items. Now they manage to fill a full trunk each full of things *they* own, and it's mildly shocking even after living in Brightmoon properly for nearly a year.

She's looking towards the stars again a week or so before they're heading out, leaning on the cold marble of the balcony when she

hears the tell-tale sound of Adora opening their bedroom door.

“Hey Adora,” she says without turning. She’s never stopped with that one and she never will.

“Hey,” Adora greets softly as she makes her way out, and she’s flushed prettily from the drink she left her with. She thought Adora and the sparkle squad would be in the dining room longer but it’s sweet that Adora came to find her after she turned in early.

Adora comes beside her and lays a flat hand palm up on the edge. She twines their fingers together and Adora asks, “You ready, for all that up there?”

“Are *you* ready? You’re the one the Universe is waiting for.”

Adora scoffs, nudging her with her elbow. “They’re not *waiting* for me.”

“Aren’t they? You’re gonna save them, bring peace and magic and muscles and all that shit you do. They don’t know it yet, but they’re waiting.”

“Alright. Fine, whatever you say, love.”

Adora had to use *that* name because of course she did. She huffs for show because Adora knows that it makes her melt every single time, before pulling Adora into a kiss. When they part, Adora lets go of her hand to put an arm around her shoulder, it’s a nice contrast to the cold breeze.

“Think we should write a list of things we never thought could happen? Help us keep perspective.”

She laughs, “Gods no. The thing would never fucking end.”

“Well what’s at the top, theoretically?” Adora asks quietly in her ear.

“Aside from you loving me back?”

“Aside from that.”

“Living with Princesses, being friends with them.”

“Oh, really the galactic tyrant we took down is just what, fifth?”

“Something like that.”

Adora doesn’t stay up late on her own unless she has nightmares, she never has and Catra wonders if she ever will. But Adora always stays up late for her when she requests it, nearly always stays in bed with her in the mornings if she asks. Adora knows how much it means to her that she listens, that she puts things aside for her.

It’s past midnight and Adora’s still awake with her, lying under her and soaking in the afterglow, petting any part of her she can reach. She’s scattering kisses along the underside of Adora’s jaw as she purrs.

“What do you think we’re gonna find up there?”

It takes her a second to realise Adora’s talking about space. She shifts down to pillow her head on Adora’s chest because she cannot hold a conversation with the taste and smell of her sweat in her head, she’s learnt.

“Weird landscapes, destruction, enough technology for Entrapta to play with for the rest of her life. Aliens.”

Adora pets along the length of her tail. “Well duh I’m right here.”

Her purr dies down and she can see the way Adora’s eyebrows push together at it. “That…do you want to find where you’re from? I never asked you.”

“I don’t know. I…I don’t think I do? Not after what they did to Etheria and everywhere else but that was thousands of years ago... When I first found out I thought about whether I have a family that has been worried this whole time.”

It makes something twist inside her, something she’s always felt with the rare talk of their families. “And what about now? Do you think about it?”

“No. I - Everyone I love is here, you’re here. I don’t need my own blood. If nothing ever changes I will still be happy with everyone I have.” Adora’s hands move to her head, lifting it up so she can look at her properly. “And I’m not leaving, if you’re worried about that. Even if I find my family I’m not leaving you.”

And just like that her purr is back, quieter than it was but there. She gets up on her knees, resting all her weight on one hand, the other holding Adora’s face. “I wasn’t worried about that, I haven’t been for a while. I know you’re staying.”

Adora smiles and curls up to meet her in a kiss. “Good. I love you so much.”

“I love you too.” Adora laughs as she flops back down onto her chest and marks her collar bone. “We’re going to travel the Universe, love.” She knows she sounds ridiculously wistful but she does not care.

“You just realising that now?”

“No. I’m just remembering when we were younger and we said we’d travel the world together.”

Adora scratches her ears. “Got a bit of an upgrade, huh?”

“Yeah, I suppose we did. Going to fucking space...see this is why I said the list was a bad idea.”

Despite Entrapta's reassurances, take off is one of the most terrifying things she's ever done. Everyone save Entrapta, who is grinning maniacally, puts on a brave face but they're all bracing and holding hands when they break the atmosphere. Everyone around her cheers when they realise they lived, she doubles over from the relief.
Adora hugs her from the side when she stands upright again. Entrapta is all over the controls, her hair going wild with excitement.

"No going back now, Catra. You're stuck with us," Bow says without turning away from the glass.

"*Yeah Catra*," Glimmer teases, wrapped up in Bow's arms.

"Oh how will you survive?" Adora says in much the same way, except she finishes by kissing the base of her ear. Which flicks in her face, getting a mildly offended huff.

"I've been stuck with *you* since that cardboard box in the Fright Zone."

"Aw baby, you say that like it's a bad thing."

"It isn't?"

"Nope. You *love* me. You made that very clear last night."

The fact that Adora has gotten to the point where she's so sure of her feelings for her, is possibly her greatest achievement.

"You guys are gross," Glimmer says like she's forgotten what happened a few days ago.

"As if you two are any fucking better. Remember my newly acquired blackmail because I *will* be using it."

She caught them making out on Glimmer's throne and she will be using that knowledge as a shield to be able to make out with

Adora on one of the five captain's chairs that Entrapta has installed on the bridge.

Bow's face goes red just as Glimmer's cheeks sparkle with her fluster. "Fuck off, it wasn't even that bad!"

"Yeah but it looked like it was going somewhere and fast." Neither of them contradict her, which proves it.

Adora squeezes her side which basically means 'lay off' before letting her go. It's fair, they are all going to be trapped in this ship together for *a while*.

Adora asks, "Entrapta, are the coordinates for Rhidron in?"

They all collectively decided to let Entrapta run the ship, that doesn't mean they don't know the basics. (Well as basic as it can get for spaceship controls.) They had a final meeting yesterday detailing their pioneering trip plan, familiarizing themselves with the names and all available information.

"Yes. It's two days away without using the enhanced speed system."

"What's the danger of using that?" Glimmer is right to ask because:

"Oh, there's only about a nine percent chance that something ignites."

Catra expects nothing less. "Everybody strap in."

Adora takes the original chair in the center since it's connection to the ship is the strongest. Even with Entrapta's best efforts, *Darla* still responds best to She-Ra. Bow and Glimmer take the two seats in front and she takes the seat on Adora's right, sending her a reassuring smile and a wink.

Adora rolls her eyes with a matching smile, the plate under her hand lighting up blue. "Darla?"

"Welcome Administrator She-Ra."

"Confirm and activate course for Rhidron."

"Course activated."

"And Darla?"

"Welcome Administrator Catra."

"Make it quick."

Chapter End Notes

It's done! Still hasn't sunk in, I'll be honest. But this is probably the first big project I've finished ever so I've at least proved to myself that I *can*.
My tumblr
Also some quick little designs for Adora's dress and both their crowns (as well as bonus sketches)

Melog Epilogue:

Found in the Dark

I'll be returning to the 'We've Made It This Far' series as well as working on some AU one-shots before starting my next big project (details of which I'll post about because it might go under a pseudonym.)

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!